

WOMEN OF ASIA

**Globalization, Development,
and Gender Equity**

EDITED BY

**Mehrangiz Najafizadeh
and Linda L. Lindsey**



Women of Asia

With thirty-two original chapters reflecting cutting edge content throughout developed and developing Asia, *Women of Asia: Globalization, Development, and Gender Equity* is a comprehensive anthology that contributes significantly to understanding globalization's transformative process and the resulting detrimental and beneficial consequences for women in the four major geographic regions of East Asia, Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Eurasia/Central Asia. The anthology gives "voice" to women and provides innovative ways through which salient understudied issues pertaining to Asian women's situation are brought to the forefront.

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and Gender Equity

**Edited by Mehrangiz Najafizadeh and
Linda L. Lindsey**

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Preface and Acknowledgments

PREFACE

With globalization discourse as the centerpiece, the 32 original chapters in *Women of Asia: Globalization, Development, and Gender Equity* offer insights for understanding this transformative process in contexts that may serve to benefit women or to increase risks for women. This transformation has permeated social institutions throughout Asia and is associated with profound changes for women, whether they reside in Asia's developed or developing regions. Capitalizing on our professional and personal networks and available sources on gender issues in Asia, we located authors engaged in significant research and scholarship directly related to the anthology's thematic emphases. Their extensive research provided the foundation for their chapters included in this anthology. Although we are sociologists, our teaching and research increasingly incorporate rapidly advancing interdisciplinary scholarship and applied work related to the topics of the anthology. Contributing authors reside in countries throughout Asia and the West, and represent a wide range of disciplines including sociology, anthropology, gender studies, history, social policy, and cultural geography. By addressing topics from a variety of theoretical and methodological perspectives, they offer insights relevant for both conceptual and applied work. The anthology's interdisciplinary thrust and related perspectives provide new and dynamic insights useful to scholars, students, policy planners, and advocates and activists in a variety of disciplines.

Compiling original chapters addressing the situation of women in Asia, the most diverse

continent on the globe, is a formidable task. Given our objectives, we needed to ensure that the content reflects both the anthology's breadth (*Women of Asia*) and its depth (*Globalization, Development, and Gender Equity*). Reflecting its breadth, our introductory chapter highlights the gendered patterns in Asia that emerged from our comprehensive analysis of all chapters, and it is followed by two overview chapters suggesting how these or other themes play out across Asia. By organizing chapters according to region (East Asia, Southeast Asia, South Asia, Eurasia/Central Asia), and inviting authors with specializations on gender scholarship in developed and developing Asia, the breadth is additionally enhanced. The anthology profits highly from scholars addressing gender issues in regions such as Central Asia, and countries such as Lao PDR (People's Democratic Republic), Mongolia, Nepal, and Myanmar, which are underrepresented in the literature.

Reflecting the anthology's depth, authors selected topics based on their background, research, and knowledge of women's issues and situation in a given country. All authors had the latitude to determine how the topic pertains to one or more of the anthology's themes: globalization, development, and gender equity. Overall, the anthology contributes significantly to the discourse on critical issues surrounding women of Asia, giving "voice" to women and providing innovative ways for women to tell their stories on salient topics and issues.

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support and encouragement throughout this lengthy process and to Erik Zimmerman, Editorial Assistant, for his superb assistance in preparing the manuscript for production. We also thank all our contributors for sharing their expertise, insight, and attentive reflections as we dialogued on their chapters, all of which enriched the anthology.

Linda Lindsey also thanks Morris Levin (in memoriam), Nancy English, Ann Biele, and her BreadCo friends for their encouragement and thoughtfulness throughout the process, and Mehrangiz Najafizadeh thanks her colleagues and friends in Azerbaijan and Central Asia for

sharing their expertise, insights, and wisdom during the past two decades.

We also thank each other for providing mutual support as long-standing colleagues and friends. The editing of this anthology, with 32 original chapters written by scholars from around the globe, has been both an extremely rewarding experience as well as an extensive and challenging process requiring our attention to a myriad of facets and details. Our mutual support throughout this process has been of immense value in bringing this anthology to fruition. Finally, we extend our continuing gratitude to our families for their enduring support over the years.

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Part I

Introduction and Overviews of Women in Asia

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Chapter one

Globalization, Development, and Gender Equity

A Thematic Perspective on Women of Asia

Linda L. Lindsey and Mehrangiz Najafizadeh

INTRODUCTION

The massive entry of women into the paid labor force is one of the most consequential socioeconomic transformations in twentieth-century Asia. Although this labor trend has recently slowed in urban, developed Asia, the ongoing rural transformation in developing Asia largely continues unabated in the new millennium. As the catalyst for these transformations, globalization has profoundly impacted virtually every social institution throughout Asia, all of which are associated with significant changes in the lives of women and how gender roles unfold. Fueled by scholarly inquiry, activism, and policy-making agendas, research on globalization and development has exploded in various disciplines but sources linking this work to gender equity are often difficult to uncover. Discussed mainly in the context of development, gender issues tend to be marginalized from the larger globalization picture. The globalization discourse is the centerpiece of the original articles in *Women of Asia: Globalization, Development, and Gender Equity*. As highlighted throughout the anthology, this discourse demonstrates a mixture of benefits and liabilities ushered in with globalization that may challenge as well as reinforce patriarchy. In turn, various routes to gender equality may be more or less obstructed. Although patriarchy is

stubbornly persistent, we will see that women in Asia have mounted resourceful, creative modes that strategically seek to challenge and to weaken patriarchy's foundation.

The authors, from over 20 countries, represent a range of disciplines, with scholarship overlapping with women's activism, agency, and advocacy. Combined with innovative methodological techniques prompted by feminist insights, their work allows readers to better understand the connection between globalization and gender equity both with and without the entanglement of development. In this sense, development may be viewed as the intermediate step to determine how gender equity (or lack thereof) unfolds in various globalization scenarios. These scenarios are largely shaped by regional and national levels of economic integrity throughout Asia.

Developed and Developing Asia

Chapters throughout the anthology attest to the challenges faced by women in Asian nations more comfortably ensconced with globalization (richer, developed Asia) compared to nations in the continuing throes of globalization, especially those maneuvering rapid rural transformation (poorer, developing Asia). While the gap between developed and developing Asia remains wide,

virtually every nation examined in the anthology paints gendered trends that speak to enhanced well-being or increased peril associated with globalization. They speak to the global consensus that legal rights for women in Asia must be ensured and enforced. They speak to the powerful role of feminist-inspired activism in monitoring progress on gender equity. Like globalization, they also speak to the role of culture in unfurling gender liabilities in the name of tradition or drawing on this very tradition, as a source of women's agency.

GENDERED PATTERNS IN ASIA

Given its highly varied historical, cultural, demographic, and socioeconomic backdrop, Asia is perhaps the most diverse continent on the globe. Despite this diversity, and the intersectional risks to women emanating from region or nation, women of Asia represent remarkably similar patterns in carrying out their gendered lives. With globalization as the catalyst and overarching explanatory model to inspect gender equity, and with feminism as the catalyst to activism, these patterns allow readers to locate content according to how the patterns unfold, especially in the context of level of development. Although all chapters demonstrate some overlap, they are positioned according to the following patterns and help address the questions emerging from each.

- *De jure/de facto*: What are the successes and challenges to legal approaches for gender equity?
- Challenges of globalization: What are the benefits and liabilities of globalization for gender equity?
- Activism, advocacy, agency: What strategies and resources are leveraged by national and international networks in challenging patriarchy and navigating gender equity?

- Reconfiguring gendered lives and emergence of new womanhoods: How does globalization alter gender roles and relationships in women's lives?

***De jure/de facto*: By Law and by Fact**

Using language from civil rights history this pattern identifies the “*de jure*” (by law) and “*de facto*” (by fact) disconnect in ways formal mechanisms to address gender equity play out. This disconnect also targets unresolved issues and intersectional risks for women. The United Nations (UN) was one the first international organizations that spoke to this disconnect.

As early as 1946, with the establishment of the Commission on the Status of Women (CSW), a pivotal role in efforts forging international consensus on behalf of gender equity was carved out by the UN. With support from the growing international women's movement, the Commission's original focus on legal measures to protect the human rights of women amplified greatly, especially in relation to the global divide on women's role in economic development (UNCSW 2017). Another key indicator of UN efforts was the adoption in 1979 of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) during the UN Decade for Women (1976–1985). Described as an “international bill of rights for women,” CEDAW paved the way for UN Conferences on Women (1975, 1980, 1985, 1995) and the parallel non-governmental organization (NGO) forums in conjunction with each. The 1995 Fourth World Conference on Women, convened in Beijing under the banner “Action for Equality, Development and Peace,” brought together 50,000 women for the official conference and parallel NGO Forum. The seminal Beijing conference was arguably the most significant global women's event in history to spotlight the women's agenda. Its location in Beijing was also significant,

allowing for more women in Asia to attend than any of the previous conferences. In addition to the 189 nations ratifying the “Beijing Platform of Action” that targeted critical areas of concern related to gender equality, then First Lady Hillary Rodham Clinton addressed the NGO Forum in the now famous speech where she declared “women’s rights are human rights.”

Many authors incorporate UN documentary material in their chapters. The UN became the springboard for the legal achievements on behalf of women that subsequently translated into public policy in many Asian nations, particularly in advanced economies such as Japan, Korea, Singapore, and Hong Kong, and in rapidly developing urban China. Laudable goals and achievements, of course, should not be easily dismissed, but laws, policies, regulations, rights-based frameworks, official commissions, and assessments on gender equity must be viewed in light of the cultural will to enforce them, as well as how they translate to the everyday lives of women. After a rapid period of progress on attaining development goals and advancing a gender equity agenda, there are many indicators that progress has stalled and efforts at goal attainment are languishing. The UN has limited sanctioning power and it is difficult to hold governments accountable for failure to achieve the goals. Ratifying a document is seemingly easier than enforcing it.

The UN offers another layer regarding the *de jure/de facto* disconnect, what can be referred to as “*quasi de jure*” protection. The UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) offer a good example. SDGs are described by the UN as a “universal call to action to end poverty, protect the planet, and ensure that all people enjoy peace and prosperity” (UNDP n.d.). SDG #5 is the call for gender equality, including ending all forms of discrimination against women and girls. Eugenia McGill (Chapter 2) suggests that global consensus throughout Asia and the Pacific to achieve SDG targets is strong, and impressive strides have been made, particularly in the areas of education,

health, and employment. Progress is uneven, however, and rising inequality engendered by globalization remains a formidable barrier in closing continuing gender gaps. Despite UN efforts, female unemployment and a persistent regional wage gap in developing Asia persist. Similarly, Patrick Kilby (Chapter 3) suggests that, regardless of the recognition that gender mainstreaming is necessary for meaningful development practices, aid organizations sometimes operate in ways that marginalize the very women they are expected to serve. The aid community is also caught in globalization’s neoliberal framework that ignores the structural causes of discrimination.

On the other hand, capitalizing on CEDAW and appropriating a UN framework on human rights for *de jure* purposes, Muslim women activists and secular feminists in Indonesia adopted a framework on gender violence that resonated with Islamic law and institutions, and lobbied successfully for the passage of Law 23/2004, “Elimination of Violence in the Household” (Shahirah Mahmood, Chapter 11). Challenges remain to assure that the law will be vigorously enforced, but gaining consensus from a range of women’s groups, religious leaders, state actors, and NGOs was an enormous accomplishment in Indonesia’s highly patriarchal society.

In Japan, with CEDAW at the forefront, strategies were successful for the passage of the Equal Employment Opportunity Law (1985) and the Basic Law for Gender Equality (1999). Chikako Usui (Chapter 8) discusses ambitious “gender-friendly” policies for women in light of pressing demographic challenges, particularly in relation to an aging population and shrinking labor force. Japan’s *de jure* successes fall short in *de facto* practices, however, with actual changes inhibited by cultural, institutional, and structural obstacles related to traditional views of women and marriage and the family in Japan. Such obstacles prevent women at all skill levels from being retained in a labor force that is in urgent need of them.

Also in wealthier East Asia, Amy Barrow and Sealing Cheng (Chapter 6) examine the limits of the law in securing the social change necessary to advance gender equality in Hong Kong. Compared to developing economies throughout Asia, the establishment of Hong Kong's clear legal protections against discrimination on the grounds of sex, plus the establishment of both an Equal Opportunities Commission and a Women's Commission, is enviable. Like in Japan, however, despite this rights-based legal framework, stereotypes and social conservatism around gender roles in general, and variant sexual identities in particular, continue to inhibit legal approaches for gender equality.

In rapidly developing urban China, ideals of gender equality are spotlighted in government policy related to marriage and family and employment but, like in other parts of Asia, implementing these ideals has been stalled. Since its founding in 1949, the People's Republic of China (PRC) has been generally responsive to demands for securing women's rights and has enacted policies to reverse ancient customs that disempowered women in their marriages and their homes. Adapting Marxist principles, Mao's stance of "gender-erasure" invited women to the labor force and to the army (Lindsey 2015: 172–173). As a "state feminism" model, the All China Women's Federation (ACWF) serves as the organization speaking for women and overseeing women's organizations (Yingtao Li and Di Wang, Chapter 5). However, for the ACWF to advance a women's agenda directed to gender equity, it needs more cooperative ties to grassroots women's organizations. In this sense, the Marxist outlook related to partnership and equality should be strengthened to help counter increased essentialist messages directed at women that are reverberating throughout China. As Linda L. Lindsey (Chapter 4) argues, perhaps more than any other nation in Asia, because China's gender equity policies are the most powerful at the *de jure* level, its *de facto* disconnect may also be the largest.

Challenges of Globalization

It is important to note that early efforts by the United Nations and other international organizations on behalf of women were already in play before the full brunt of globalization's power became apparent throughout Asia. Whether in political, cultural, or religious contexts, and whether women's work activities are in the formal or informal sectors, globalization sets the stage for how virtually all gendered patterns unfold. Although globalization scenarios in developing Asia are strikingly similar, there are clear differences according to level of development in nation and region that help explain how globalization may be mitigated or magnified to serve gender equity.

Southeast Asia demonstrates globalization's influence in the rapid rural transformation associated with women's loss of economic activities associated with subsistence farming and traditional economic niches. Rural transformation in Thailand (Buapun Promphakping, Chapter 19) is linked to increased inequality structured by gender. Relative to many other Asian regions, women historically enjoyed greater economic security in Thailand by means of land being passed down through female bloodlines. With increased agri-business and changes in land ownership patterns, women's economic power declined. Economic diversity in livelihoods may be considered a globalization asset, but until it is played out across new economic niches, greater gender inequality will be fueled by loss of income which, in turn, intensifies women's poverty.

In Lao PDR (People's Democratic Republic), Nittana Southiseng and John Walsh (Chapter 18) show that women are increasingly entering "formalized" work that bridges the gap between family-oriented subsistence agriculture and market-based activities. Expanding their small businesses or microenterprises may offer better economic returns. However, they lack capital, knowledge of business techniques, and other

services that thwart these returns. Women's long established entrepreneurial niches in both the formal and semiformal sectors are not enough to overcome the gendered issues intruding from family and social relations in Laotian society. For globalization to be successful for women seeking other entrepreneurial options, strategies must account for these inter-institutional links.

Although the assumption that globalization is associated with increased availability of formal sector work offering greater economic returns for women, in parts of Malaysia Shanthi Tham-biah and Tan Beng Hui (Chapter 15) show, perhaps incongruously, that informal sector work has increased in conjunction with rapid globalization. Already poor women are often forced into even more casualized, highly competitive informal sector roles that further deter their economic well-being. Unless globalization is somehow "rebooted" to serve rather than impede their economic interests, similar to the situation in Lao PDR, benefits derived from these work roles cannot be sustained.

Compared to displaced rural women working in informal sectors, globalization may offer benefits to urban, professional women who have already maneuvered some of the early repercussions of globalization. Middle-class professional women in urban Vietnam may find themselves in the privileged position of choosing whether professional work or marriage offers a more rewarding alternative and a better economic future (Catherine Earl, Chapter 17). In this sense, globalization's channel related to increased education and expanded career options can well serve these middle-class women.

Globalization benefits are also mixed in South Asia. South Asia's economies are marginally poorer and more rural than in Southeast Asia, and its rural transformation proceeded later and at a (relatively) slower pace. South Asia is also marked by larger scale labor migration. The globalization path in Nepal (Mira Mishra, Chapter 22) demonstrates a typical pattern of household diversification with the transition from agriculture to wage

work, and the predicted increase in employment options. More unique in Nepal, however, is that remittance income from men's labor migration is massively augmented by work women are doing in other sectors.

Other research suggests that diversification of income in rural Nepal is aided by microfinance programs that target women and respond productively to issues when goals for women are compromised and problems are addressed as they arise (Adhikari and Shrestha 2013). Globalization benefits appear valuable for women in Nepal overall, especially when constructive microfinance programs are incorporated as part of the economic mix for household diversification (INAFI Nepal 2012; Magar 2017).

The microfinance route in Pakistan may play out differently than in Nepal. Globalization's incursion into programs originally designed to alleviate poverty risks and empower women may foreshadow program peril. As demonstrated by Veronica E. Medina and Priya Dua (Chapter 24), microfinance's strategy to grow developing nations' economies through women's entrepreneurship often operates in cultural environments that devalue women and their work. With attention to origins, institutionalization, and transformations of microfinance in Pakistan, and globalization's neoliberal power to alter its path, they found mixed and uneven progress for microfinance to enhance the lives of Pakistani women.

Economic benefits accruing to women in India's globalization are also mixed, worse for the poor, but better for the middle-class. The rapid increases in education for women channeled many into professional roles and into India's highly skilled technical workforce. The cost of these advances for women, however, may be linked to escalating sexual violence throughout India. Delhi serves as the conduit offering expanded employment options for women, for example, but is also referred to as the "rape capital" of India (Subhadra Mitra Channa, Chapter 23). Globalization ushered in massive, rapid social change that affected all sectors of Indian society

and served to deteriorate long-established cultural norms related to gender, class, and caste, and opened a disheartening channel linked to sexual violence. The benefits of education and employment opportunities for women may be overshadowed by these latent patterns.

China's globalization path offers perhaps the most paradoxical record of assessing the benefits and liabilities and globalization (Lindsey 2007). Through cost benefit analyses, Linda L. Lindsey (Chapter 4) demonstrates how the path to gender equity unfolds under neoliberal globalization (NLG) overall and how it unfolds in China. She suggests that heightened gender peril ushered in with NLG may be mitigated by China's "state capitalism" modification. A paradigm shift from hegemonic NLG to a range of state capitalism models may offer global economic policies that are especially beneficial not only to women in China, but to women throughout developing Asia.

Women's Global Dilemma: Balancing Work and Family

Cultural roots are profoundly entangled in the process of globalization, impacting gender equity throughout Asia. Usually with a foundation rooted in patriarchy, religion, and traditional family practices, culturally entrenched gender attitudes are not easily swayed when women enter the paid work force in large numbers. Cultural issues are perhaps the most intrusive when considering the "work-family balance" discourse routinely surfacing in urban areas in richer Asian regions and where public policy is supportive of employed women. The notion that there is even such a thing as a "choice" to balance work and family may be mysterious in much of developing Asia. As noted earlier, Japan is a prime example of the policy provisions that are designed to serve women maneuvering this balance. Chikako Usui (Chapter 8) shows that, with pessimistic demographic trends in mind (*Economist* 2014),

Japanese policies encourage women to combine work and family roles in ways that enhance their well-being as well as that of their families. On the other hand, she contends that carrying these out appears to be virtually impossible. As the persistent, "infamous" M-curve pattern displays, women in their 20s and 30s are likely to leave the labor force at marriage, with increased likelihood at childbirth, and return when (probably their one child) enters school or finishes high school. Policies about balance do not play out in choices couples make. The M-curve has softened recently (*Asian Review* 2017) maybe as much due to women delaying marriage and childbirth as to policy initiatives. With Japan's distinction of having the globe's longest living population, arguably an economic benefit of globalization in advanced economies, the M-curve may be sustained, too, because women are the expected providers of eldercare. These patterns coalesce to inhibit highly educated women, who desire enticing work-family options, from pursuing professional careers.

Whether caring for the young or for the old, women are the caregivers, and both Japan and South Korea are experiencing a rapidly aging population. Sirin Sung (Chapter 7) notes that eldercare in South Korea usually falls on daughters-in-law who may stay out of the workforce longer to care for elderly parents, and especially, for elderly parents-in-law. Often overlooked is that "work-family" balance includes this growing demand for eldercare. As a domain of women, eldercare is supported by Confucian-based ideology that (married) women accept this role. Korea is perhaps the most enduring Confucian-based society on the globe (Han 2014). As Sirin Sung explains, Confucian principles remain powerful, even as there is a slight altering of patriarchal ideals viewing men as employed heads of family and women in domestic roles. However, this eldercare trend cannot be sustained, and coupled with legal support, the legacy of Confucianism in Korea may decrease as Korean women enter the labor force in large numbers.

Singapore is also caught in the tsunami of a rapidly aging population. The old-age dependency ratio, currently at 4.9 working adult citizens per elderly person, is expected to shrink to 2.1 by 2030, driven largely by declining fertility and women dropping out of the workforce to provide care. In turn, these women lose income in their prime earning years and risk impoverishment when they reach old age (AWARE 2016; Chin and Phua 2016). Nursing home costs are high, although Singapore's generally robust subsidies to families with limited incomes, has made community eldercare in nursing homes more common (Wyman 2016). Eldercare is poorly paid, with migrant women from developing Asia overrepresented as the caregivers. Like Japan and South Korea, Singapore also confronts the economic disadvantages of an aging population and represents similar cultural beliefs surrounding women as "natural" caregivers that, in turn, undervalue caregiving work. Shirlena Huang and Brenda S. A. Yeoh (Chapter 13) examine how caregivers, local and foreign, working in Singapore nursing homes, validate their identity and worth despite the negative aspects associated with care work. Huang and Yeoh's research findings challenge "traditional and essentialized constructions" of such work as being "'naturally' feminine" and as "altruistically motivated."

In Asia's poorest nations, choices surrounding work and family, as well as employment and caregiving to the elderly or to children, are far different from choices women have in richer neighboring nations. The "topic" of work-family balance in countries such as Bangladesh is rarely addressed, but it is implicit in gendered paths women follow. Roslyn Fraser Schoen's (Chapter 21) case study of a family in rural Bangladesh suggests another side to the "work-family" balance. Spurred by globalization's invitation to different livelihoods, the eldest daughter in a son-less family with a migrant laborer father moves from the farm in order to obtain formal education. Girls may be encouraged

in their quest for education and in aiding the economic survival of a family with no sons, but her family may not tolerate "non-traditional" choices, for example, about relationships and dating. Young women must negotiate "patriarchal bargains" to accommodate their needs, spurred by globalization, to the needs of the family, spurred by cultural traditions.

Activism, Advocacy, Agency

In conjunction with the international women's movement, advocacy by NGOs inside and outside of Asia offer resources to mobilize activism in nations with various degrees of legal commitment to gender equity. Advocates at the local level may serve as initial conduits to help a community's grassroots leaders navigate difficult gendered political and cultural terrains. The goal of most NGO advocates is to enhance agency and the empowerment it should generate, eventually retreating to supportive roles when communities come to advocate for themselves. Throughout Asia, women and women's advocates maneuvering these gendered terrains confront three fundamental trends fueled by globalization: emerging, "untested" forms of governance and political economy; need for an expanded and educated workforce; and the explosion of information and communication technology (ICT). As we see throughout the anthology, there are benefits and pitfalls with all three.

Regarding the *first* governance trend and political economy, much of developing Asia has transitioned to a variety of political economy forms following the end of Soviet domination or Soviet influence. Some, such as Vietnam, remained communist and embraced a "socialist" model of capitalism, while others, such as Mongolia, navigated to democracy and embraced a more powerful neoliberal capitalist model, the latter coming at a high price to women. As Susan S. Witte, Toivgoo Aira, and Laura Cordisco Tsai

(Chapter 9) explain, the adoption of free-market approaches in Mongolia coincided with the loss of traditional sources of income, forcing a segment of already economically vulnerable women into sex work. To offset the devastating health and violence risks of sex work in this new economy, community leaders, women's advocates, and a range of Mongolian professionals collaborated to promote structural change to address needs of these marginalized women. Economic empowerment is enhanced through targeted programs congruent with the situation of women. Although not within a post-Soviet context, programs advocating for female victims of sex trafficking in the Philippines, as discussed by Laura Cordisco Tsai (Chapter 12), demonstrate this strikingly similar pattern. Struggling to exit sex work, women are not only stigmatized by their families and communities, they also remain economically vulnerable. Paths to successful community reintegration capitalize on advocates offering services and programs with a variety of options for women. Women-inspired projects with survivors aimed at economic empowerment that benefit their families can, in turn, lessen this stigma.

In Afghanistan, elation after the Soviet exit was short-lived. While transitioning to a democratic government, the Taliban reemerged as a powerful force for retraditionalism, often under the auspices of a return to "authentic" culture. Women remained its seemingly easy, visible targets to enforce this return. Initially at the forefront of international advocacy in Afghanistan, women's issues took a giant step backward in the post-2001 context as Afghan women were reduced to portraits symbolizing victimhood, helplessness, sorrow, and pain. Orzala Nemat (Chapter 25) argues, however, that these portraits are not only reductionist, but they overlook women's agency in everyday practices of governance in their local communities and at the national level. She focuses specifically on Afghan women's political participation, such as parliamentary elections, and also on factors that facilitate such

participation, as well as factors, such as enduring patriarchy and (neo)patrimonialism, that limit women's political roles.

In the post-Soviet economic transition, most nations of Eurasia and Central Asia are also dealing with new forms of governance after independence, while simultaneously adapting to massive repercussions of rapid neoliberal globalization. Women continue to confront patriarchy and inequalities that are difficult to eliminate. Rano Turaeva (Chapter 32) examines gender and change in Central Asia through focusing on the agency of women, a topic that is largely overlooked by gender studies of the region. Through case studies of women with diverse backgrounds from Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Kazakhstan, she explores the innovative character of women and their agency. With agency at the forefront, women's innovation and entrepreneurship offer strategies for productively transforming gender roles in the context of globalization.

It is important to recognize that while each of the five Central Asian countries, as well as Eurasian Azerbaijan, possess their own unique attributes, they also share significant cultural elements. These include Turkic linguistic ties, Islamic heritage, seventy years as part of the Soviet Union, independence, and periods of political and economic adjustments following independence. Mehrangiz Najafizadeh's (Chapter 26) research on Azerbaijan demonstrates a unique array of historical and contemporary elements that speak of a nation that is simultaneously secular and Muslim, both of which are relevant in shaping women's identity. In expanding her earlier work on the "place" of Azeri women, she examines the historical context and social construction of women's roles in the late 1800s and early 1900s, the subsequent seventy years of Sovietization, and the economic and sociopolitical transition following Azerbaijan independence in 1991. This foundation lays the groundwork to understand the opportunities and challenges that Azeri women face in areas such

as education and employment, and provide insights on other pressing issues including patriarchy, gender-based violence, and war and forced displacement. Although new opportunities for women coincide with new challenges, efforts to improve women's well-being and "place" in Azeri society are supported both by state agencies and by NGOs. As such, Azerbaijan represents a blend of agency and advocacy that can enhance the lives of women.

The *second trend*, activists encounter, and ultimately embrace, is globalization's need for an expanded workforce that fosters women's education and training. Focusing on women entrepreneurs in rural Kyrgyzstan, Deborah Dergousoff (Chapter 31) discusses the complexities associated with training programs developed by international NGOs with the goals of improving women's well-being and cultivating economic development in their communities. These programs must maneuver complexities surrounding development-related social relations in a capitalist market economy that may detract from these goals. As noted earlier (Patrick Kilby, Chapter 3), development programs in Asia are imbued with structures that may not be in the best interests of the women they are intended to serve. The aim of improving women's lives may play out differently depending on how various development agendas are appropriated. For women to be productive change agents for themselves and their communities, education and training need to be leveraged to serve their own needs.

In nations such as Myanmar, struggling with ethnic strife and a political culture still enmeshed with remnants of military rule, it is ironic that education, one of globalization's few taken-for-granted benefits, may offer cultural notions of gender that reinforce stereotypes and promote gender hierarchies. In responding to such liabilities, Elizabeth J. T. Maber and Pyo Let Han (Chapter 20) show how a women's organization in Myanmar initiated alternative community-based learning environments and programs to contest gender inequality, but also to provide

spaces for women to engage more openly in social and political activism.

The *third trend* related to activism is the explosion of information and communication technology (ICT) that has found a pathway to even the remotest parts of Asia, allowing women to come together in unprecedented ways. Women's organizations within a nation and activism spurred by international and civil society organizations can capitalize on available technological and media tools in advocating for a political agenda in service to women. With hastily convened press conferences, for example, the successful use of media tools to rapidly disseminate information on the ongoing status of a proposed law against gender violence in Indonesia, mobilized support from women's organizations and the broader public (Shahirah Mahmood (Chapter 11).

On the other hand, in Central Asia, Lucia Direnberger (Chapter 30) analyzes the difficulties faced by the women's movement in the policy-making arena in Tajikistan working on preventing violence against women, as some international organizations align with various powerful conservative actors. International organizations in support of particular agendas intentionally or unintentionally, may counter policies that benefit women by producing knowledge through their own definitions of gender, tradition, and culture and by disseminating this knowledge in their official published reports. With ease of access, these reports can be widely distributed—electronically or otherwise—and reinforce cultural beliefs and traditions serving the interests of state and religious leaders.

Other research pertaining to ICT shows that media messages can bolster views of women as submissive and compliant. Mobile phones are common in Tajikistan, and they can be used as a means to encourage women's acquiescence to particular notions of appropriate dress. Although the government contends that closer monitoring of Islam for Tajikistan's approximately 98 percent Muslim population is an effort to counter the rise of terrorism, activists and others argue it restricts

free speech and religious rights (Lemon 2016; Swerdlow 2016). Women's dress is a visible example of such restrictions as women routinely receive text messages reminding them to stick to "traditional and national clothes and culture" (Erickson 2017).

Another scenario has emerged in Kazakhstan, where a wave of retraditionalism in support of conservative interpretations of gender roles, particularly in the family, has heightened insecurity among some women. Diana T. Kudaibergenova (Chapter 28) discusses how a *kelin* (daughter-in-law) is particularly vulnerable to this trend. A *kelin* traditionally occupies the lowest position in a family and is expected to be obedient and dutiful, acceding to the authority of her husband's family. Kudaibergenova's research focuses on internet-based social media in Kazakhstan that have generated a popular "*kelin* discourse" that may reinforce, rather than challenge, these strongly patriarchal images. This discourse likely resonates with cultural beliefs emphasizing women's submissiveness and men's dominance. Yet, at the same time, young feminist bloggers have emerged in Kazakhstan, gained popularity, and raised gender awareness as they utilize social media to campaign against "Kazakh retraditionalism." While information and communication technology can be used to constrain women's agency by providing patriarchal messages about women's roles both in their homes and in the broader culture, it also can be leveraged to the advantage of women.

Re-Configuring Gendered Lives: Emergence of New Womanhood

In important ways all trends converge in this pattern. Virtually every chapter considers the strategies Asian women mount in refashioning their lives in the context of globalization. Chapters reviewed here clearly suggest these strategies. In Southeast Asia, even though legal rights may not have translated to desired gender equity

outcomes overall, some women in this region appear to have more latitude in determining how to structure and negotiate their globalized lives in the political arena, their workplaces, and their homes.

Through discourse analysis, Mikael Baaz and Mona Lilja (Chapter 16) explore choices in the performances of Cambodian female politicians maneuvering gender pitfalls as they carry out their responsibilities as elected officials. They are well aware that in Cambodia's fledgling democracy the notion of a female politician is an anomaly. Their performances show how power and resistance are entangled and how these performances shape their political futures. Overlaid with patriarchal Cambodian cultural values rooted in religion, they "play with" images in performances that seem to accommodate gendered images, but simultaneously to resist and challenge these very images. The continual reconfiguring of gendered scripts in their political lives can offer alternative visions of successful leadership for the next generation of Cambodian women with political aspirations.

Women politicians in Singapore are constrained by similar gender stereotypes as those in Cambodia, but with a distinctive twist. Netina Tan's (Chapter 14) analysis of social demographics of elected and appointed women highlights intersections related to both gender and ethnicity. Elected women are largely Chinese and do not reflect Singapore's celebrated multi-racial and multi-ethnic portrait. Although female Cabinet appointees may be more diverse ethnically, female politicians overall are overrepresented with "political portfolios" in line with gendered expectations, such as those relating to community development, cultural issues, and youth causes.

The intersectional challenges in Singapore took another twist with the recent appointment by the ruling party of the nation's first female president, who is Muslim and also Malay, representing Singapore's poorest ethnic minority (Ungku and Singh 2017). Women politicians

throughout Asia must continually refashion their political lives to “do politics differently” while traversing a host of intersectional risks.

In the intersect between workplace and family in urban Vietnam, Catherine Earl (Chapter 17) shows that professional women reconfigure “modern womanhood” in decisions related to security in the workplace compared to security in a marriage. This reconfiguring, however, suggests that a choice to retreat the workplace does not translate to a return to patriarchal tradition. Nittana Southiseng and John Walsh (Chapter 18) likewise suggest that Lao women transitioning to formalized work roles significantly reconfigure their familial and social relations for both economic survival and social success. It can be argued that these Southeast Asian women refashion gender roles in practical, beneficial ways that offer paths allowing them to evade patriarchal regimes in their communities, workplaces, and homes.

Religion is sometimes overlooked when considering notions of refashioning womanhood, especially since it can be associated with images of patriarchal oppression rather than women’s empowerment. In Southeast Asia, however, religion may be viewed as a constructive resource for women. Barbara Watson Andaya (Chapter 10) discusses women’s prominence in ritual roles in indigenous belief systems that may have waned with the acceleration of incoming world religions and philosophies, but that were not eliminated. Although wide economic and political gender gaps may indicate incursions to women’s agency, her analysis suggests that women retained some of their former agency related to religious roles. Bolstered by increased education, women’s position in Southeast Asia is relatively better than in neighboring regions, even as they maneuver the restraints of tenacious cultural stereotypes related to gender. However, although seemingly incongruous, women may counter stereotypes by drawing on the esteem associated with centuries-old religiously-based belief systems.

Paths to new womanhood through reconfiguration of gendered lives also play out across South Asia. In Nepal, Mira Mishra (Chapter 22) shows that the path moving women away from reliance on agricultural work to expanded wage work markedly changes gender roles in the community. Largely related to new sources of household income generated by women, gender roles become much more heterogeneous, offering alternative visions of womanhood that are less likely to be synchronized by tradition. Roslyn Fraser Schoen (Chapter 21) suggests a similar scenario in Bangladesh in her case study mentioned earlier. Whether by choice or circumstance, women seeking an educational route to well-being will simultaneously and, inevitably have their lives reconfigured. In the throes of economic transition, emerging womanhood continues to be fashioned and refashioned. It is yet unclear which are liberating for women and which are not.

Likewise, it is important to gain insights into women’s daily lives in order to understand how emerging womanhood comes into play in Central Asia. Sophie Roche (Chapter 29), for example, focuses on various methodologies utilized in gender-related research and argues that the particular method used to document women’s lives and positions in Tajikistan may inadvertently reinforce traditional and patriarchal notions of womanhood. She finds that women constitute themselves differently when alternative methodological sources, primarily qualitative in nature, are utilized for women to present themselves. Such sources of data can uncover productive paths in forging new womanhood. Svetlana Peshkova (Chapter 27) also suggests distinctive approaches used by female Muslim religious leaders (*otinlar*) in Uzbekistan in efforts to transform themselves and their communities into “better Muslims” and “better humans.” As such, these leaders prompt social change by using education, ceremonial leadership, didactic storytelling, and advice in order to provide alternative meaning and interpretation of daily lives; to

inculcate “differently structured desires”; to address social and economic factors that can negatively impact their communities; and to suggest alternatives to address pragmatic needs and resolve problematic situations.

CONCLUSION

Given Asia’s economic and cultural diversity, the patterns that emerged in this anthology represent notable overlap. Women navigate the treacherous slopes of globalization and patriarchy with creativity and imagination. Even in dismal circumstances, innovative strategies uncovered agency rather than victimhood. Paths to gender equity, however, continue to be shaped by the power of patriarchy and by other formidable cultural obstacles. As globalization impacts and reconfigures gendered lives in Asia, it remains unclear whether globalization’s benefits and opportunities will be overshadowed by its liabilities and perils for women of Asia.

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Chapter two

Gender Equality, Women's Empowerment, and the Sustainable Development Agenda in Asia

Eugenia McGill

INTRODUCTION

Most countries in Asia and the Pacific have made impressive strides in recent years in order to close gender gaps and expand opportunities for women and girls. However, in developing countries of the region, these gains have been particularly uneven, and much more work remains to overcome entrenched gender biases and inequities. In most of these countries, gender gaps persist in access to secondary and tertiary education, quality health care, employment and business opportunities, political participation, personal security, and access to justice. At the same time the region faces a number of challenges, including faltering growth rates, rising inequality, major demographic shifts, accelerating mobility and urbanization, and heightened risks from climate change and natural disasters. These regional trends are likely to affect women and men differently, and to further complicate governments' efforts to meet their commitments under the 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda, including those related to gender equality and women's empowerment.

This chapter discusses the interrelationship between gender equality and inclusive, sustainable development, reviews recent trends and remaining gaps related to gender equality and

women's empowerment in developing countries of Asia and the Pacific, and considers the gender dimensions of regional trends, including demographic shifts, migration and urbanization, and intensifying climate-related events and risks. Finally, the chapter considers possible pathways to greater gender equality in the region in light of the 2030 Agenda.¹

GENDER EQUALITY AND THE SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT AGENDA

For several decades, the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) together with the Beijing Platform for Action—the outcome document of the Fourth World Conference on Women held in Beijing in 1995—have provided comprehensive policy frameworks for action by Asian and Pacific governments, women's movements and other civil society actors and partner organizations, to close the remaining gender gaps and address entrenched gender biases and harmful practices. Virtually all countries in the region have ratified CEDAW and endorsed the Beijing Platform, and most report periodically to the CEDAW Committee and participate in intermittent reviews of

the Beijing Platform including most recently, the twenty-year review in 2015.

The United Nations (UN) Millennium Declaration, endorsed in September 2000, committed to address gender inequities in order to reduce poverty, hunger, and disease, and to promote more sustainable development. However, the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) that were subsequently developed to implement the Millennium Declaration, were widely criticized for their narrow approach to gender issues. In particular, the only target for the gender equality goal (MDG 3) was related to education, although the indicators for Goal 3 also covered employment and national decision-making. In addition, the gender-related health goal (MDG 5) was limited to maternal health, with the original target focused only on maternal mortality, although a second target, for universal access to reproductive health, was added in 2007. Despite these limitations, between 2000 and 2015 the gender-related MDGs were tracked and reported on by most developing countries in Asia and the Pacific. Encouragingly, several of these countries localized the MDGs, including Goals 3 and 5, to better reflect the more ambitious targets they had set in their national development plans (ADB [Asian Development Bank], UNDP [United Nations Development Programme] and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific [UNESCAP] (ADB et al. 2006; UNDP 2015). Thailand, for example, established national and provincial MDG-plus targets that exceeded the international targets (Government of Thailand 2009).

The 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda and related Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) endorsed in September 2015 represent a major leap forward from the MDGs. In contrast to the MDGs, the SDGs were developed through a highly participatory process, they have universal application, and they are much more comprehensive and challenging in scope and substance (Fukuda-Parr 2016). The SDGs' approach to gender, for example, include not only a stand-alone

goal (SDG 5), but the integration of gender considerations through most of the other 16 Goals and related targets and indicators. This reflects recognition that the Sustainable Development Agenda cannot be achieved without the equitable participation of women and girls.

SDG 5 itself is also much more comprehensive and ambitious than its MDG counterpart, MDG 3, including targets for (i) ending all forms of discrimination, violence, and harmful practices against women and girls; (ii) recognizing and valuing unpaid care and domestic work and promoting shared responsibility within households; (iii) ensuring women's participation and leadership at all levels of decision-making; and (iv) ensuring universal access to sexual and reproductive health and rights (United Nations Statistical Commission 2016).

Taken as a whole, the SDGs represent a welcome return to the broader and more ambitious gender equality and women's rights agenda of CEDAW and the Beijing Platform, enhanced to reflect recent research, advocacy, and action on topics such as unpaid care work, although they have been critiqued for not explicitly addressing forms of exclusion based on sexual orientation or gender identity or expression (Mills 2015). Nonetheless, the SDGs provide a broad platform to tackle remaining gender inequities and harmful practices in developing Asia in the years ahead.

RECENT TRENDS AND REMAINING GAPS

The overall performance of Asian and Pacific countries in promoting gender equality and women's empowerment has been mixed, as indicated by recent progress reports on the MDGs. This is reflected most clearly in the tracking analysis undertaken for the latest regional MDG progress report (UNESCAP et al. 2015), which found that most countries were "early achievers" or on track in narrowing gender gaps in educational enrollments (MDG 3, Target 3a). However,

most countries in the region have been making slow progress, and therefore were off track in reducing maternal mortality and providing universal access to reproductive health (MDG 5, Targets 5a and 5b). Subregional trends have also varied, with South Asia lagging in achieving gender parity in secondary and tertiary school enrollments, and the Pacific lagging in increasing skilled attendance at birth (the regional proportion actually fell between 1990 and 2015). When all of the indicators for MDG 3 are considered, the picture is even more mixed. National indicators also mask wide disparities between urban and rural areas, with the least progress found in remote rural and conflict-affected areas, and among disadvantaged ethnic minority groups and castes, internally displaced people, and migrants.

Capabilities in Education and Health

Improvements in education and health are widely understood in terms of expanding individual capabilities and opportunities. Numerous studies also document the interconnected spillover benefits of educating girls, which translate to later positive effects on the health and education of their children, especially girls (United Nations Millennium Project 2005a).

With few exceptions, countries in Asia and the Pacific have already achieved gender parity—or a reverse gender gap favoring girls—in enrollments at the primary and secondary levels, and a substantial number of countries have reached parity or reversed the gap at the tertiary level (UNESCAP et al. 2015). However, in countries that have recently closed the gender gap in enrollment, there remain large numbers of women who have never attended school and are functionally illiterate. Even in countries that were early achievers of gender parity at the national level, gender gaps persist in rural and remote areas such as the outer islands of Tonga

(Government of Tonga 2015), and within poor and marginalized communities, such as ethnic minority communities in Vietnam and undocumented households in Malaysia (ASEAN [Association of Southeast Asian Nations] Secretariat 2015). Enrollment ratios also do not reflect the level of girls' and boys' enrollments, nor their levels of attendance and completion, which are often much lower. In Pakistan, for example, only 60 percent of girls are enrolled at the primary level, and a smaller percentage of girls complete primary school, with only 29 percent of girls enrolling in secondary school (UNESCO [United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization] (UNESCO 2011)).

For countries that have rapidly increased girls' primary and secondary school enrollments, the further challenge is to improve the educational experience for girls and to address the factors that still lead large numbers of them to drop out, especially between the lower secondary and upper secondary levels. This will require greater attention to the recruitment of female teachers, the quality of teacher training and supervision (including training on gender-inclusive teaching styles), the revision of textbooks and teaching materials that perpetuate gender stereotypes, and the encouragement of girls to consider a wider range of future occupations. Social pressure for early marriage still prevails, especially in South Asia, and this calls for special efforts to persuade community leaders and parents of the benefits of continued education for adolescent girls. Education policies and regulations that prohibit married adolescents from attending secondary school must also be reexamined. The new SDG on education (SDG 4), which supports "inclusive and equitable quality education . . . for all," and includes several gender-related targets, provides a sound framework for addressing these remaining challenges.²

As noted, several countries in the region have achieved reverse gender gaps in enrollment at the tertiary level. Even in these countries, MDG

progress reports note strong patterns of gender tracking in the selection of courses at the tertiary level, with women concentrating in education and health courses and men predominating in science and engineering. The unfinished agenda for education, therefore, also involves proactive strategies to encourage more young women to pursue technical and professional training in male-dominated fields where there are higher economic returns. SDG 4 includes a specific target on “equal access for all women and men to affordable and quality technical, vocational and tertiary education” (SDG 4.3), which should enable tracking of countries’ progress on this agenda item in the years ahead.

Turning to health trends, the phenomenon of missing girls at birth, most likely due to prenatal selection, is a particularly serious problem in several countries in developing Asia. The countries where the sex ratios at birth are most seriously imbalanced, with 110 or more boys born for every 100 girls (compared to a normal ratio of 105), include the People’s Republic of China (PRC) (118), Azerbaijan (117), Armenia (115), Georgia (114), Vietnam (113), Albania (112), India (111), and Pakistan (110) (Bhatia 2016). This is already having profound social and economic impacts. By one estimate, over 1.4 million girls worldwide were missing at birth in 2008; 1.35 million of these were missing in Asia, with the vast majority missing in the PRC and India (World Bank 2011). Rooted in persistent norms of preference for sons, the rate of sex-selective abortions in these countries has accelerated by the spread of affordable ultrasound technology. Both the Indian and PRC governments have introduced various programs to criminalize the use of ultrasound for sex selection and to provide incentives for parents to have girls, but this has not yet had a major effect on sex ratios at birth. However, the positive experience of the Republic of Korea in raising the status of girls and reducing sex selection practices, provides hope that similar progress can be made in India, the PRC and other countries.

The problem of missing girls in infancy and early childhood is also significant in Asia and the Pacific, and is reflected in skewed girl-to-boy mortality ratios for children under age 5. Of an estimated 617,000 missing girls under age 5 in 2008, more than 400,000 were missing in Asia (World Bank 2011). Strong patterns of son preference and neglect of young girls are often cited to explain girls’ higher mortality rates in these countries. However, the *World Development Report 2012* suggests that developing countries’ higher female mortality rates in early childhood are more likely the result of the high incidence of infectious diseases related to lack of clean water, sanitation, and drainage. In support, the report notes that excess female mortality among infants and young children in Bangladesh, the PRC, and Vietnam has been declining as those countries have improved access to clean water and better sanitation.

Excess mortality and health-related disabilities among women of reproductive age also persist in Asia and the Pacific. An estimated 140,000 women in the region died in 2008 from complications associated with pregnancy and childbirth (UNESCAP et al. 2012). Moreover, for every maternal death, it is estimated that 30 to 50 additional women suffer debilitating complications from pregnancy or childbirth (United Nations Millennium Project 2005b). This translates to between 420,000 and 700,000 women suffering pregnancy or birth-related complications in Asia and the Pacific each year. Not surprisingly, high maternal mortality ratios are correlated with low rates of prenatal care and skilled health personnel at birth, limited use of contraceptives for birth spacing, and a high rate of adolescent births (which are generally riskier).

The Asia and Pacific region as a whole did not meet the two targets under MDG 5 by 2015—reducing the maternal mortality ratio by three quarters (from 1990 levels) and providing universal access to reproductive health care—although most countries have succeeded in reducing maternal deaths by 50 percent or more, while

increasing access to contraceptives, prenatal care, and skilled birth attendance. Nevertheless, UNESCAP et al. (2015) report that 16 countries in the region still have maternal mortality ratios of 100 per 100,000 live births or more, and 5 of these countries have ratios of 200 or more, with the highest ratio by far in Afghanistan (400).³ It is also concerning that the ratios in Indonesia and the Philippines have recently increased (ASEAN 2015).

Several MDG progress reports note wide variations between maternal mortality rates in urban areas and rates in rural areas, with extremely high mortality rates in remote provinces or areas, as well as challenges in reaching internal migrants and some ethnic and caste groups. Vietnam, for example, reports much higher maternal mortality rates (and other indicators of poor maternal health) in remote and mountainous areas and among ethnic minorities, compared with national averages (Government of Vietnam 2013). Vietnam and several other countries also report increases in adolescent pregnancy, linked to young people's limited access to contraceptives.

MDG progress reports for Asian and Pacific developing countries also note other trends affecting women's health, including continuing problems of malnutrition, anemia, and iodine deficiency in women, the increased incidence of non-communicable diseases such as diabetes, and strained health facilities and health staff. In contrast to the MDGs, the SDGs provide a broader framework to address these and other health-related issues facing women and adolescent girls in the coming years, but sustained investments in public health will be needed to make progress.⁴

Economic Activity

Economic independence—particularly through paid work outside the home or family farm—is an important dimension of women's empowerment and well-being, enabling them to make

choices for themselves and to participate more fully in household and community decision-making (Kabeer et al. 2013:77). However, achieving gender equality in the economic sphere will involve reducing a number of persistent gender gaps and biases in the region's developing economies. While the proportion of women in paid employment outside agriculture globally increased from 35 percent in 1990 to 41 percent in 2015 (United Nations 2015), the share of women in non-agricultural wage employment in Asia and the Pacific was estimated to be only 32 percent as of 2012 (UNESCAP et al. 2015). However, this average masks wide variation across the region. For example, based on recent MDG progress reports, only about 10 percent of women in Pakistan are in waged employment (Government of Pakistan 2013), in contrast to 42 percent of women in the Philippines (Government of the Philippines 2014).

In addition to participating at lower rates than men, women in the region tend to be concentrated in less remunerative sectors, such as agriculture, petty trade, and social and personal services, and in lower-paying and more vulnerable jobs within sectors, including home-based work. Many of these jobs correspond to traditional notions of “women's work” and have been labeled “5C jobs—caring, cashiering, cleaning, catering and clerical work” (UNESCAP 2016: 2–3). Women in the region are also overrepresented among contributing family workers and in other forms of informal employment. Gender wage gaps persist in both formal and informal sectors, and women generally experience higher unemployment rates than men, although there is considerable variation across countries. Across sectors, women in the region also experience high levels of sexual harassment at work (Jha and Saxena 2015). Only a small percentage of women own agricultural land across the region, and women continue to face discrimination in accessing bank loans, which inhibits the growth of women-owned businesses. At the same time, women in the region continue to shoulder the

main responsibility for unpaid care work within their households, devoting about three times as many hours as men on average (ADB 2015: 55). Only 20 percent of women in the region have pensions (compared with about 35 percent of men), and discriminatory retirement regulations in several countries require women in formal sector jobs to retire several years earlier than men, which further reduces their income-earning years and opportunities for promotion (ADB 2015: 22–23).

After decades of spectacular growth and increases in labor productivity, the Asian and Pacific economies began to cool in the wake of the global financial crisis of 2008–09, and further deceleration is projected (ADB 2016a). The global economic slowdown negatively affected both women and men in the region, particularly those working in export industries, construction, and tourism. Informal sector workers, including casual and part-time workers in export industries, were hit especially hard because they were the first to be laid off and lacked any form of social protection. Women's employment, especially in formal sector jobs, still has not recovered, and formal wage employment opportunities for women seem to be shrinking in some countries. In rural Asia, the economic crisis only deepened the hardship already experienced by households as a result of food and fuel price hikes in 2008, with women shouldering much of the hardship (ADB 2011).

In the context of moderating growth rates, unemployed and underemployed women in the region are increasingly seen as an “untapped resource” that could “give the region a considerable growth boost” (ADB 2015: ix). However, the shrinkage of formal sector wage employment and increasing employer reliance on temporary and part-time workers are problematic for the “decent work” agenda underlying SDG 8, and are particularly troubling for female workers, who are already overrepresented in the informal sector. This trend underscores the urgent need for more active and gender-equitable labor

market policies in the region, as well as the strengthening and expansion of social protection schemes to include informal sector and migrant workers.

Within the SDG framework there are a number of possible entry points for governments, private sector firms and associations and others, to improve economic opportunities for women in Asia and the Pacific, including: (1) increasing young women's enrollment in high-quality, market-oriented technical and vocational education and training (TVET) programs, and in science, technology, engineering, and/or math (STEM) studies; (2) maximizing opportunities for women's employment in the public sector, public employment schemes, and publicly funded construction projects; and for public procurement of goods and services from women-owned firms; (3) providing financial, technical, networking, and other support to small and medium-sized businesses (SMEs) owned by women; (4) eliminating discriminatory laws and practices related to employment, business, access to economic resources; ownership and transfer of assets, pensions and other social protection programs, and introducing or strengthening laws and employer policies against workplace harassment; (5) extending legal protections and support to domestic workers, agricultural workers, home-based workers and other informal sector workers; (6) promoting gender-equitable practices by private sector companies, for example, through adherence to the Women's Empowerment Principles;⁵ and (7) introducing or strengthening legally mandated maternal, paternal, and family leave, and introducing or expanding affordable child-care services for working families.

Political Participation and Public Decision-Making

Participation in public decision-making is another important indicator of women's empowerment, both individual and collective, as well as

being essential to social justice and meaningful democracy. Women's participation in elected bodies has also been linked to improvements in the implementation of government programs and reduced levels of corruption (United Nations Millennium Project 2005a). Although no numerical targets were set under either MDG 3 or SDG 5, virtually all Asian and Pacific governments committed in the Beijing Platform for Action's aim for gender balance in all government bodies, building on an initial target of 30 percent for women's participation, established by the UN Economic and Social Council.

A number of governments in Asia and the Pacific have taken steps to increase women's representation in all branches of national as well as local governments. However, very few regional countries have achieved the agreed 30 percent target at any level of government. With respect to women's participation in national parliaments, the world as a whole is clearly off target, at about 23 percent. But at the end of 2016, Asia (under 20 percent) and the Pacific (at about 15 percent) were even farther behind (Inter-Parliamentary Union 2018).⁶ If Australia and New Zealand are excluded, the representation of women in Pacific parliaments drops sharply to about 8 percent, which is the lowest regional average in the world. However, regional averages mask significant variations across countries. In the Pacific for example, the representation of women in national parliaments ranges from 38.5 percent in Timor-Leste (the eighteenth highest ranking in the world) to zero in Micronesia and Vanuatu. Timor-Leste is also the only developing country in Asia and the Pacific that now exceeds the initial global target of 30 percent women in national parliaments. Nepal (29.6 percent) and the Philippines (29.5 percent) have also effectively reached the target. Other regional countries that have met or exceeded 20 percent representation include Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, Kazakhstan, Lao PDR (People's Democratic Republic), Pakistan, the PRC, Singapore, Turkmenistan, and Vietnam. At the other end of

the spectrum, two Pacific countries, Micronesia and Vanuatu, have no female parliamentarians at all, and the Solomon Islands, Tonga, and Tuvalu have only one each.

The Asian countries with the highest rates of women's representation in national parliaments tend to be countries that have introduced gender quotas for party lists or reserve seats for women (including Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Kazakhstan, Nepal, and Pakistan) or one-party states (including Lao PDR, the PRC, and Vietnam). The success in Cambodia, the Philippines, and Timor-Leste, however, seems mainly due to the grassroots advocacy of women's organizations in partnership with national ministries of gender or women's affairs. Notably, three of the countries with the highest female representation in national parliaments—Afghanistan, Nepal, and Timor-Leste—are all conflict-affected or recent post-conflict countries.

Even in countries with relatively high levels of women's representation, female parliamentarians tend to be excluded from the most powerful committees and are channeled mainly into committees dealing with social sectors and women's and children's affairs. In developing Asia, on average less than 10 percent of government ministers are women, far lower than in other Asian regions, and other than the Middle East and North Africa (ADB 2015: 74, 77). Across the region, women are also underrepresented in the judiciary, senior civil service, and senior levels of private sector companies (UNESCAP 2015a: 72–73). However, in recent MDG progress reports, several countries note improvements in these areas. Malaysia, for example, reports that almost 33 percent of its top management positions in government are now held by women, and female representation on boards of public companies has increased to 16 percent in response to the government's target of at least 30 percent (Government of Malaysia 2015).

Women's representation in locally elected bodies also varies, but cross-country comparisons are more difficult because of the heterogeneity of

subnational governance systems in Asia and the Pacific. Based on available data, UNDP (2014) estimates that the average representation of women in subnational governments in the region is 21 percent, with the highest representation in the PRC's urban councils (over 49 percent) and in India's rural councils (over 38 percent). In terms of absolute numbers, UNDP calculates that over one million women have been elected recently to rural and urban councils in India, with over 730,000 women elected to rural and urban councils in the PRC.

UNDP also noted different trends across levels of local government, with slight increases in women's representation in rural councils since 2010, but decreases in district and provincial councils. Regional trends since 2010 have also varied, with increased representation of women across all combined local government levels in East Asia, but decreases in South Asia and the Pacific.

Much work remains to be done to support women's meaningful participation in public decision-making, and to strengthen the institutional frameworks supporting gender equality in Asia and the Pacific, in line with SDG 5. The positive experience of countries in the region in introducing gender equality legislation, various forms of electoral and party quotas, gender-responsive budgeting, and other affirmative measures should provide models for other countries to emulate and adapt. Regional and national civil society organizations and networks have played critical roles in advocating for, and supporting these reforms, in the past (UNDP 2014: 64–73). Their continuing engagement will be essential, not only to press for further institutional reforms, but also to help develop the capacities of female electoral candidates, and to improve the gender-responsiveness of elected officials and civil servants (both women and men).

Personal Security

Gender-based violence—including domestic violence, sexual assault and sexual harassment

outside the home, and trafficking of women and girls—is a major source of female death and disability and a major contributor to women's disempowerment in developing Asia and the Pacific. Increasing evidence from national prevalence studies, news reports of particularly egregious abuses, and advocacy by women's organizations and networks, are finally shifting public opinion in many countries to demand more effective government action.

As discussed earlier, persistent patterns of son preference combined with readily available technology for prenatal sex selection have led to skewed sex ratios in several Asian countries, with serious social, economic, and political repercussions. The incidence of child marriage in developing Asia is also extremely high, accounting for about half of all child brides in the developing world (UNFPA 2012). A recent study of ASEAN countries found widespread patterns of sexual harassment across key economic sectors, even where protective legislation exists (Jha and Saxena 2015: 143–144). While about one in three women globally experience physical or sexual violence in their lifetime, the prevalence rates for intimate partner violence in most parts of the region are above the global average, with the highest rate of 42 percent in South Asia, followed by 35 percent in the Pacific, and 28 percent in Southeast Asia (WHO 2013: 47). In a multi-country study conducted in Asia and the Pacific for the UN joint program, Partners for Prevention, almost one in two men surveyed reported that they had used physical or sexual violence against a female partner, and almost one quarter reported having raped a woman or girl (Fulu et al. 2013).

An increasing number of studies have also estimated the economic and other costs of gender-based violence in Asian and Pacific countries. The Government of Fiji (2010) estimated the cost of gender-based violence to be around F\$300 million annually, or about 7 percent of Fiji's gross domestic product (GDP). In Cambodia, 20 percent of women experiencing domestic violence report that they

have missed work and their children have missed school as a result; in Vietnam, women who have experienced domestic violence are estimated to earn 35 percent less income than women who have not been abused, and the total productivity and opportunity costs of gender-based violence have been estimated to equal over 3 percent of GDP (Government of Vietnam 2013; UN Women 2016). On the other hand, the costs of providing a minimum package of essential services to survivors of gender-based violence have been estimated to be 0.25 percent of GDP in Lao PDR and about 0.30 percent of GDP in Timor-Leste (UN Women 2016).

More than half of the countries in Asia and close to 40 percent of Pacific countries have enacted laws against domestic violence (UNESCAP et al. 2011), and MDG progress reports refer to several new or proposed laws on the issue. Other initiatives being undertaken in the region include the creation of multi-sectoral action plans; sensitization of government officials and staff in the local justice system and service providers; provision of integrated services to violence survivors; and awareness-raising campaigns that engage with men, young people, sports clubs, faith-based organizations, and others (UNESCAP 2015a: 45–48). These are encouraging developments, but much more needs to be done to change both men's and women's attitudes toward domestic abuse and other forms of gender-based violence, to effectively enforce the new laws on gender-based violence, and to provide appropriate support for survivors of violence or abuse. The new SDG 5 target on ending violence and harmful practices should also encourage greater accountability by Asian and Pacific governments on these issues.

GENDER DIMENSIONS OF REGIONAL TRENDS

Asian and Pacific countries face a number of regional challenges, including demographic shifts,

increasing migration and urbanization, and heightened climate-related risks and events. These trends are likely to complicate efforts to realize the Sustainable Development Agenda by 2030, including the gender equality targets in SDG 5 and other SDGs.

Demographic Shifts

The population in Asia and the Pacific increased by over one billion people in the last 25 years and is expected to grow by another 500 million by 2030 (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 2: 3). During the same period, countries in the region will be experiencing profound demographic shifts. Already, three major trends are under way: one set of countries is undergoing a “youth bulge” with at least 20 percent of their population between 15 and 24 years old; other countries are seeing their working-age population increase rapidly; and in another set of countries, the population is aging rapidly, with 14 percent or more at age 60 and older. Even greater shifts are expected by 2050, when half of the region's population will be over age 50 (UNDP 2016: 3, 9). As discussed earlier, the sex ratios at birth in a number of regional countries are also seriously imbalanced, which is already having profound social and economic impacts. Each of these demographic shifts will have profound implications for the development trajectories of countries in the region, including gender implications.

For developing countries with growing youth populations, including several in the Pacific, the challenge will be to convert their “demographic opportunity” into a “demographic dividend,” by increasing and improving the quality of basic health care, nutrition, and education for children and youth, and then ensuring a smooth transition from school to employment or other economic opportunities. Going forward, progress on SDG 2 (end hunger, achieve food security and improve nutrition), SDG 3 (ensure healthy lives) and SDG 4 (ensure inclusive and equitable quality

education) will be essential, and the targets for each of these goals require attention to the particular needs and constraints of women and girls.

For developing countries with large and expanding working-age populations, mainly in South and Southeast Asia, the challenge will be to expand economic opportunities for both women and men through creation of decent jobs and support for SMEs, while strengthening social safety nets and care support for working people and their families. As discussed earlier, this priority has a strong gender dimension, since female labor force participation in most countries in the region is below 60 percent and is falling for the region as a whole (ADB 2015: 39, 46). Some of the relevant policy responses include incentives to keep girls in school; gender-responsive technical and vocational education and training, and job-placement support in non-traditional sectors; employment and business law reform; and expansion of affordable child-care facilities and services for working parents. The Republic of Korea is viewed as particularly successful in managing its demographic transition, including through investments in education and marketable skills of both its young women and men (UNDP 2016: 38).

For developing countries with rapidly aging populations, including the PRC and some Southeast Asian countries, the opportunities and challenges include supporting an active and healthy aging process, while strengthening health and social protection systems, and improving the living and work environments to accommodate larger numbers of older persons. The gender dimensions of this demographic transition are stark. Although women in the region are less economically active than men and have less opportunity to accumulate savings, their life expectancy is longer, and therefore they have more years to support themselves with fewer accumulated assets. However, only about 20 percent of women in the region are covered by pension schemes, compared to 35 percent of women globally. Discriminatory retirement regulations in a number of countries

also require women to retire earlier than men, further diminishing their chances to accumulate savings (ADB 2015: 82–83). Due to entrenched social norms, women already shoulder most of the care responsibilities for other family members, and many older women in the region already care for grandchildren as well as ailing spouses. However, with limited savings and assets, older women are less likely to be able to afford their own health care and long-term care expenses, especially those living alone. At the same time, the expansion of health care and long-term care services for older populations can be expected to increase employment opportunities for working-age women. In line with the SDGs' strong emphasis on gender equality and inclusion, governments and their development partners will need to pay careful attention to the needs and constraints of older women, and to address the existing care burden on all women, in responding to this major demographic shift.

Migration and Urbanization

The Asia and Pacific region has become increasingly mobile and urban, with most migrants moving to urban centers, and these trends are expected to continue and even accelerate in the decades to come. Both migration and urbanization have strong gender dimensions.

In terms of migration, Asian and Pacific countries are major sending and destination countries for international and regional migrants. In 2013, about 95 million international migrants were from the region, and close to 60 million international migrants were located in the region, out of a total of almost 232 million migrants worldwide (APWGIM [Asia-Pacific RCM Thematic Working Group on International Migration] 2016: 9). Regional migration is highly gendered, with men frequently migrating for construction work or work at sea, and women migrating primarily for service work, including health services and domestic work.

Women are estimated to constitute about 49 percent of all international migrants in Asia and the Pacific, although the percentage varies significantly across countries, ranging in 2013 from about 13 percent of all migrants from Bangladesh to about 58 percent of migrants from Nepal (APWGIM 2016: 141). Women are also more likely to migrate through irregular channels, particularly where their home countries have imposed restrictions on female migration in an attempt to protect women from exploitation and abuse in destination countries. Ironically, these well-intended restrictions have increased the vulnerability of women by driving many of them to migrate without official documents, and often relying on unscrupulous agents. In some destination countries, women migrants are also subjected to pregnancy tests, which can be a basis for terminating their work contracts. Women also represent the vast majority of “marriage migrants” in the region, as single men in countries with serious gender imbalances increasingly use agencies to locate marriage partners in neighboring countries, with mixed consequences for the migrating women. Both men and women, and boys and girls, are also trafficked within the region for forced labor and sexual exploitation; the UN estimates that over three quarters of identified trafficking victims are women and girls (APWGIM 2016).

Although women migrants generally earn less income than men, they tend to remit a higher percentage of their earnings than men, and on a more regular basis (APWGIM 2016: 47). However, in the global financial crisis, women migrants had more difficulty sending remittances. Those who lost their jobs and had to return home had more difficulty than men in reintegrating and finding new jobs, and were more likely to move into more vulnerable types of work, indicating the greater vulnerability of women migrants to economic shocks. Women in migrant households also bore most of the burden of the crisis because of their primary responsibility for managing their household’s basic needs (ADB 2013).

Given the highly gendered migration patterns in the region, any initiatives to manage regional and bilateral migration flows in a safer and more orderly manner, and to improve working conditions, access to basic services, and remittance channels for migrants, will need to address the particular needs and vulnerabilities of women migrants. Initiatives to simplify and expand regular migration channels, to regulate recruiting agencies, to require contracts and minimum wages for migrant workers (including domestic workers), to provide health services and repatriation support to migrant workers, and to lower transaction fees for remittances will particularly benefit women migrants.

Like migration, the increasing concentration of populations in urban areas is a global phenomenon, but this trend is particularly pronounced in Asia and the Pacific. Close to half of the region’s population already live in urban centers, a dramatic increase from the 1950s when only a fifth of the population lived in urban spaces. By 2050 the proportion of urban dwellers is expected to climb to two-thirds of the regional population (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 11: 1–2).

Cities and towns generally provide wider economic and social opportunities for young women, compared to rural areas, which helps to explain why a large segment of rural-to-urban migrants, particularly in Southeast Asia and South Asia, are women (UNDP 2016: 161). However, women often face serious barriers to finding good jobs or other livelihood opportunities in urban areas, due to lower education and skill levels, discriminatory hiring practices of employers, and social norms that can restrict unaccompanied women’s travel and their ability to find safe housing and engage in market transactions. Urban women, therefore, are more likely to be employed in lower-skilled, lower-paying formal sector jobs, such as factory work, domestic work, and even lower-paying and more precarious informal sector work, such as market trading and home-based work (UNESCAP and UN-Habitat 2015: 13, 71–73). Discrimination against women in independently renting or

owning land, housing, or work spaces in urban areas also places them at a disadvantage, especially in the context of urban development projects that can involve re-zoning and involuntary resettlement (UNDP 2016: 163–164).

The lack of adequate and affordable education, health, water/sanitation, energy, and transport services in poor urban communities in the region disproportionately burdens poor women, especially given their traditional household responsibilities. Violence and safety concerns in urban areas also disproportionately affect women and girls, and are often linked to inadequate infrastructure. For example, the region's slow progress in improving urban sanitation services places poor women and girls at risk of harassment or violence in walking long distances to communal latrines, especially at night. Lack of reliable, affordable transport services and street lighting also jeopardizes the safety of women working night shifts in factories, call centers, health facilities, and other offices (UNESCAP and UN-Habitat 2015: 98–101).

The formidable challenges facing urban Asia and the Pacific in the coming decades call for more innovative, inclusive, and equitable approaches to urban governance. Female elected officials and women's organizations are already playing key roles in successful innovations in urban infrastructure development, improved service delivery, and engagement with communities across the region.⁷ In the years ahead, it will be extremely important to include mechanisms for the active participation of urban women and women's organizations—particularly those representing women from poor and marginalized communities, young and older women, and disabled women—as well as sexual minority communities in urban planning strategies and processes.

Climate Change and Natural Disasters

Asia is home to some of the largest emitters of greenhouse gases (GHGs)—chiefly the PRC, which

is responsible for almost half of all regional emissions and almost 24 percent of global emissions—while also being one of the regions most vulnerable to the effects of climate change. Industrialization, urbanization, and deforestation all contributed to a 70 percent regional increase in GHG emissions between 1990 and 2012, compared with a global increase of 41 percent over the same period (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 12: 7–8). Over two billion people in the region still depend on wood and other solid fuel sources to meet household needs for cooking and heating (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 7: 2). Meanwhile, some of the climate impacts already being felt across the region include scarcity in water supplies, rising sea levels and warming ocean temperatures, and more frequent and severe weather events (ADB 2016b: 1). Some countries in the region are already facing sharp fluctuations in water availability, which will severely hamper their ability to meet their SDG 6 commitment to provide access to safe and affordable drinking water for all (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 6: 1). Increasing water shortages will also affect the sustainability of agriculture, with negative impacts on smallholder farmers and regional food security.

Over the past 50 years, Asia has also experienced heavier rainfall, more violent storms and extensive flooding, and more severe heat waves and extended droughts. In the past decade alone, climate-related disasters in the region, including storms and floods, resulted in almost 300,000 deaths, injured or displaced close to 1.4 million people, and inflicted economic damage equivalent to almost \$370 billion (UNESCAP 2016, SDG 13: 1–2). Poor households, who often live in environmentally exposed areas, and have limited income and assets to draw on, have suffered disproportionately from severe storms and floods, and have taken much longer to recover (UNESCAP 2015b).

The gender implications of climate change and climate-related disasters are becoming increasingly clear. Given the gender divisions of labor in economic sectors, traditional gender

roles within households, and persistent gender gaps in education, access to resources and decision-making, women and men can be very differently affected by climate-related events, and are likely to have different needs, constraints, and priorities in responding to them. For example, water shortages and indoor air pollution from use of solid fuels for cooking and heating disproportionately affect women and girls, based on their household responsibilities (ADB 2016b: 4–5). More severe droughts and flooding in agricultural areas pose particular risks to smallholder farmers, but female farmers tend to have less access to extension services and other inputs to adopt more “climate-smart” practices. The erosion or destruction of coastal habitats can also endanger local fish stocks on which coastal communities depend for consumption and increase the burden on local women to find alternative food sources for their families (ADB and FAO 2013: 10–11).

Within poor communities, women can be particularly vulnerable to natural disasters because of their care responsibilities for children and elders, lack of awareness of disaster preparedness, and the location of storm shelters, lack of transportation, inability to swim, and other factors. For example, three-to-four times as many women died in the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami compared with men. National and local disaster relief efforts often disregard women’s reproductive health, privacy, and other needs; prioritize the restoration of men’s assets and livelihoods while ignoring women’s economic losses; and fail to protect women and girls from the increases in harassment and violence that often accompany disasters (Tanaka 2016). Recent research has also identified some of the longer-term, gender-related impacts of natural disasters. For example, one study of the health effects of typhoons in the Philippines found that infants born within a year after a typhoon had lower birth weights, indicating the negative impact of typhoons on the health and nutrition of pregnant women (Morrow 2014). Another study of the human development effects of typhoons in the Philippines found higher

mortality rates among infant girls born after a typhoon, especially those with older siblings, which the researchers attributed to the deterioration in economic conditions following the typhoon, households’ subsequent disinvestment in health care and nutritious food, and “competition” among siblings for scarce household resources (Hsiang and Anttila-Hughes 2013).

Given the different impacts of climate change and climate-related disasters on women and men in the region, any mitigation, adaptation, and resilience-building initiatives should be informed through gender analysis and wide consultations with affected stakeholders, including women and women’s groups, and also include appropriate strategies and activities to address the different needs of women and men. Some governments and their development partners in the region are already strengthening the gender-responsiveness of their disaster risk planning, such as the “Gender Equality Actions for Hazard-Prone and Disaster-Affected Areas” developed by the Philippines ODA-GAD (Official Development Assistance-Gender and Development) Network. In the past, mitigation activities have been considered more challenging to engender (compared with adaptation activities), based in part on the technical nature and scale of the projects. However, recent experiences in mainstreaming gender concerns in clean energy and other climate-related projects provide examples for future mitigation efforts in the region (ADB 2016b).

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Despite progress in closing gender gaps and expanding opportunities for women and girls in developing Asia and the Pacific, the region’s gender equality agenda is far from accomplished. As discussed earlier, secondary completion rates for girls are uneven across the region, and maternal mortality rates are still high in some countries. About half of all child brides in the developing world live in Asia, son preference is still driving

disturbingly high ratios of boys to girls in several countries, and prevalence rates for intimate partner violence in most parts of the region are above the global average. Despite decades of impressive growth, female labor force participation in developing Asia has dropped and the regional wage gap persists. Gender discrimination, restrictions on mobility, and heavy household responsibilities also continue to limit women's economic and social activities outside the home. At the same time, regional challenges, including major demographic transitions, increasing mobility and urbanization, and intensifying risks from climate change and climate-related disasters, demand policy responses that take into account the different impacts on women and men, and girls and boys, especially in poor and marginalized communities.

The SDGs, including SDG 5, provide a comprehensive framework for regional and national actions to address these regional challenges and further gender equality in Asia and the Pacific over the next 15 years and beyond. Given the diversity of countries across the region, at least some countries are likely to localize the SDGs and set even more ambitious "SDG plus" targets in some areas, as was done under the MDGs. On gender issues, this would be especially useful, to prioritize actions where the largest gender gaps and barriers exist in each country.

In particular, the SDG 5 targets on eliminating all forms of violence and harmful practices, should be useful for civil society organizations and networks, researchers, journalists, and others to document and publicize local practices such as sex-selective abortions, child marriage, bride kidnapping and trafficking, intimate partner violence, cyber bullying, workplace harassment, acid attacks, dowry deaths and gang rapes. These SDG 5 targets and indicators will also require governments in the region to collect data and report on the prevalence of gender-based violence and practices such as child marriage, as well as actions they are taking to address these violations, which should heighten their accountability on these issues.

The integration of gender considerations in most of the other 16 SDGs should also be useful in holding the region's governments accountable to reduce remaining gender gaps in access to quality education and health care, decent work and other economic opportunities, ownership of land and other assets, and leadership positions. The general requirement to disaggregate SDG monitoring data on the basis of sex and other social factors could also encourage more gender-aware policy-making and public investments to address regional challenges such as aging populations, rapid urbanization and intensifying climate events. However, meaningful progress toward a more gender-equitable Asia and Pacific will also require the strong advocacy and engagement of civil society coalitions, including women's organizations, political commitment of government officials and parliamentarians, support from the private sector and development partners, and adequate resources to implement and sustain needed changes.

NOTES

- 1 This chapter draws on material by the author in "Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment in Asia—The Unfinished Agenda," in *Ending Asian Deprivations: Compulsions for a Fair, Prosperous and Equitable Asia*, edited by Shiladitya Chatterjee, co-published in 2013 by Asian Development Bank, National University of Singapore and Routledge, as well as a background paper prepared by the author for Asian Development Bank in 2016.
- 2 For example, the SDG 4 targets include eliminating gender disparities at all levels, mainstreaming gender equality education, and ensuring that education facilities are gender-sensitive and non-violent.
- 3 Several countries report even higher maternal mortality rates in their own recent MDG progress reports, including Cambodia (206), Indonesia (228), Myanmar (240), Nepal (258), Pakistan (276) and the Philippines (221), which may be due to different sources and methodologies.
- 4 These issues include malnutrition (SDG 2); non-communicable diseases and mental health, pollution and hazardous chemicals, affordable medicines and vaccines, health financing, health

workforce development and retention (SDG 3); access to safe and affordable drinking water and improved sanitation (SDG 6); workplace safety (SDG 8); road safety and disaster risk management (SDG 11).

- 5 See UN Global Compact n.d. “Women’s Empowerment Principles.” Retrieved March 9, 2018 (www.weprinciples.org).
- 6 For purposes of comparison, the figures cited here are for lower or single houses of parliament, since not all countries have upper houses.
- 7 Some examples include the female elected councilors participating in urban governance in Bangladesh, and the NGO, Mahila Milan, that has been actively involved in urban sanitation projects in India.

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Chapter three

Gendering Aid and Development Policy

Official Understanding of Gender Issues in Foreign Aid Programs in Asia

Patrick Kilby

INTRODUCTION

While there has been some progress by international development agencies in the area of women and development, it is necessary to look at the formation of aid policy and practice more broadly in order to understand its importance to the women of Asia. Although there are some success stories in gender and development, particularly related to advancing girls' education and maternal and child health, the recognition of structural issues based on patriarchy and men's exercise of power that marginalizes women, is still very weak throughout Asia and with new challenges emerging. Most development policy on gender continues to focus on women's economic roles and is grounded on neoliberal social and economic frameworks. Policy tends to avoid the structural causes of discrimination and the marginalization of women, and how these causes intersect with patriarchy, religion, ethnicity, disability, sexual identity, and other compounding factors. Issues faced by transgender people, for example, are barely recognized, if at all, despite all too frequent attacks in places such as Korea, India, and Indonesia (Kim 2016; Nadkarni and Sinha 2016). The exception may be programs to combat gender-based violence, most notably in South Asia, but

few of these programs work on structural issues around male power and the use of violence as a means of controlling women (Wu 2011, 2012).

Across Asia the reemergence of conservative social values makes further progress on advancing women's equality very difficult. Despite an apparent global consensus around issues of gender and women's rights, substantial movement on addressing women's inequality has stalled, with the Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) having to backtrack on earlier global agreements on gender equality. What can be described as a "minimal response" is even reflected in the resolutions and official policy statements following each of the four United Nations Conferences on Women¹. With hegemonic masculinity as the root cause, Hearn (2015: 13) refers to the process through which men dominate global institutions and ignore, or even frustrate, the push for gender equality as the "domination of common sense." Long-standing taken-for-granted patriarchal norms are framed in a language that is dismissive of any alternative analyses. Kandiyoti (1988) suggests that well intentioned policy literally evaporates by the time it reaches implementation on the ground. Van Eerdewijk and Dubel (2012) explain this process as a "missing middle," arguing that many gender policies even if often developed by

high ranking women, fail to connect with a middle management that is often male. Agency policy is both dominated by men and middle management and has sets of priorities to meet goals under pre-existing patriarchal gender norms. Advancing women's rights takes a back seat.

Despite subsequent landmark policies, four United Nations Conferences on Women, and other landmark events over six decades, expanding any official understanding of gender and development has stalled due to what Hearn (2015) refers to as “transpatriarchies:”

A key aspect of transpatriarchies in practice is the impact of transnationalizations on managers and management in transnational organizations, and the formation and reproduction of [patriarchal] gender orders in organizations and societies.

(Hearn 2015: 41)

Given these structural impediments, the challenge remains as to how to advance gender equitable development policies in a rapidly changing “aid world” in the throes of a new form of corporatism, in which an authoritarian state and capitalism come together. I will argue that this is acute in Asia where authoritarian states are on the rise and conservative social values have reemerged to erode progress on women's equality, and gender equality more broadly.

WOMEN AND DEVELOPMENT IN ASIA

Gender has been an issue for the United Nations (UN) since its founding, with the Commission of the Status of Women (CSW) established in 1946 (Galey 1995; Jain 2005). In 1949, CSW head Lakshmi Menon, from India, was pushing UNESCO on the importance of girls' education in developing countries (Vaughan 2013). It is almost ironic that fifty years later Menon's wish was achieved, with girls' education being a central plank of the UN Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) in 2001.

In the 1950s and 1960s, the CSW shifted its focus to looking at women's economic and social development to mirror the major development trends at the time (Jain 2005). In the UN system the CSW was largely alone in advocating for women's rights. Other major agencies such as, the International Labor Organization (ILO) and the Food and Agricultural Organization (FAO) relegated women as second-class citizens, by suggesting what today would be an anachronistic gendered division of labor. Women were to be confined to domestic roles, with “home science,” for example, a favorite training program for women, supported by any number of sewing projects, which (sadly) still occur across Asia (Jain 2005; Quataert 2013). Except for pioneering aid efforts as early as 1963 by Sweden to support women in developing countries, women and development was virtually unknown in bilateral development programs (OECD-DAC 1975; Nanivazo and Scott 2012). In 1968 Sweden proposed to the UN a long-range plan for the advancement of women, moving away from separate projects to a better integration of women into development programs. But these progressive policy decisions were much harder to put into practice. In 1975 the Swedish delegation, reporting to the OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) and Development Assistance Committee (DAC), noted that:

... it should be recognized that just as development processes reflect the domination of men ... social research in these countries is also to a large extent characterized by men's values and interests.

(DAC Secretariat 1975: 21–22)

In addition, patriarchal religious and cultural norms persist to this day. For example, in East Asia the dominance of Confucian philosophy continues to stymie efforts to have women's rights fully respected, even after fifty years of ongoing effort (Li 2000; Pascall and Sung 2014). In 1979, the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women

(CEDAW), replaced the 1966 Declaration to End Discrimination against Women (DEDAW). The first draft of DEDAW tabled in 1963 (UNGA 1963) was led by a group of 22 developing countries, including those from all regions of Asia, and the Soviet bloc, with the clear statement that “discrimination impeded development” (Fraser 1995: 78). The absence of Western countries in the presentation of DEDAW draft resolution challenges the common notion that the leadership on women’s rights and development emerged from the West, or that the anti-discrimination drive in development represented an agenda of Western feminists (Shain 2013; Victoria and Grewal 2014).

Ester Boserup’s ground-breaking work, *Woman’s Role in Economic Development* (Boserup 1970), based on her own observations in India, brought women and development as an aid issue to a much wider audience (Turner and Fischer-Kowalski 2010; Quataert 2013). She challenged Western donors by calling for “women’s integration into the development process as equal partners with men” (Drolet 2010: 213). The Percy Amendment, passed in the U.S. Congress in 1973, led the way to the creation of the Women in Development (WID) office within USAID (Snyder 1995). But it was not until the 1990s, after an adverse audit by the U.S. Accounting Office, that USAID began to systematically comply with the Percy Amendment (Miazad 2002). Similarly, the OECD-DAC convened an expert group on women and development in 1975, but any impact for women in developing countries, even with straightforward issues such as women-headed households and their special needs, continued to be ignored (OECD-DAC 1975; Buvinić et al. 1978; Snyder 1995).

UNITED NATIONS CONFERENCES ON WOMEN, 1975–1995

International Women’s Year activities of 1975 and the associated UN Conference on Women in

Mexico City, brought the issue of women’s rights to a much broader global audience, setting in train a series of processes that led to gender and women’s rights as ostensibly a central plank in development. There had been two earlier attempts at global conferences before Mexico City at tackling women’s issues surrounding women’s rights. The first was part of the Treaty of Versailles negotiations in 1919 after the Great War and the second at the first session of the CSW in 1946, when this newly formed group’s work plan was agreed to (Allan et al. 1995). Governments rejected the idea that linked women’s rights to a development agenda. Mexico City, therefore, was a landmark event in the fight for women’s equality and gender justice.

The Mexico City conference (and the associated civil society Tribune made up of NGOs), was a momentous event, bringing together 8,000 delegates (mostly women) from all over the world. It “introduced activists to the potential of pursuing their interests through the UN, at a time when there were few international venues for women’s rights” (Bunch 2012: 214). The key outcome of Mexico City was the building of a network:

Women discovered their ‘brand.’ in every country women and girls were treated as an inferior minority. In over 200 formal and informal meetings, emerging leaders formed new friendships. Recognizing that power is taken, not given, they forged a network for change.

(Persinger 2012: 192)

The agreed to World Plan of Action focused on three broad objectives: integration and full participation of women in development; working toward equality for women; and the role of women in the promotion of peace.² The main criticism of the plan was the characterization of women as passive victims of “underdevelopment.” A woman was portrayed first and foremost as “mother, worker, and citizen,” rather than having a broad range of identities and voices (Zinsser 2002: 149). As a first step, however, the World Plan of Action also offered guidelines and targets

for governments and the international community to be met by 1980.

The achievements in Mexico City went well beyond Boserup's economic role of women, by also putting the structural discrimination that women faced in all societies onto the agenda (Moghadam 2000; Funk 2013). In addition, Mexico City brought out the differences in priorities of First and Third World women. For Third World women, and Asian women in particular, the key priorities were about underdevelopment and the role of race, class, and caste, as well as gender, in women's marginalization. For First World women, the primary concern was around gender equality (Jolly et al. 2004; Jain 2005).

Five years later the UN Conference on Women in Copenhagen (1985) was seen to be hopelessly divided over the issue of Israel and Zionism. It still managed, however, to make some advances on the issue of gender justice. The idea of "male power as a cause of women's low status" (Jaquette 1995: 55) was introduced. The word "sexism" appeared in the final report after it had been rejected at Mexico City, and gender-based violence (battered women) was raised for the first time (Allan et al. 1995; Kilby 2015). One unfortunate outcome of the assertive voice of Southern and Asian women at Copenhagen, was that U.S. women's groups lobbied the U.S. government to cut funding of UNIFEM and INSTRAW.³ These programs were two tangible outcomes of Mexico City supporting Third World women in general, and Asian women in particular (Jaquette 1995).

Despite the clear commitments at Mexico City and Copenhagen, there was little movement in foreign aid practices. For example, in 1980 USAID's WID activities made up only two percent of programing, and only one-tenth of that two percent went to women-specific projects. The view was that projects and activities that targeted women were "often considered expendable by mission personnel" (USAID 1982: 390). The World Bank (WB) felt they could give advice to governments on how to govern, but women's equality and gender issues were not what they

wished to talk to governments about. World Bank policy, like most agencies providing support to Asia, made little mention of women outside of their own specialist groups. Broad WB assertions included, for example, that project benefits trickle down to women, or that handicrafts are the most appropriate approach to dealing with issues of women and development (Scott 1979).

The gender work of the World Bank, as well as other agencies with major policy oversight related to women, was still marginal. The main thrust of the 1980s and 1990s centered on the game changing structural adjustment programs (SAPs) that enveloped the globe but where gender considerations failed to penetrate. By the World Bank's own admission, SAPs discriminated heavily against women who disproportionately bore the largely negative brunt of these programs (Blackden and Morris-Hughes 1993). This was particularly acute in Asian countries such as Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Philippines, and Indonesia that all suffered heavily from World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF) implementation of SAPs, and again later in response to the Asian Economic Crisis of 1996 (Ito 2007).

It was not until 1985 at the UN Conference on Women in Nairobi that, what could now be considered a "global feminism," emerged (Moghadam 2000). This was in part because the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), which called for more independence from the UN and other multilateral agencies such as the World Bank and IMF, had a women's caucus that met in New Delhi prior to the Nairobi conference. With input from this strong women's caucus, NAM crafted a position that "linked women's inequality to underdevelopment and unjust international relations" (Jain 2005: 83). Capitalizing on the strengthening women's movements in Asia, (Roces and Edwards 2010) it was fitting that India hosted the NAM. Therefore, it was rather ironic that at the 1995 UN Women's Conference in Beijing it was Western feminists who brought out issues of marginalization due to the intersection of gender with

race, caste, sexuality, and the like. They were merely restating the concerns Third World women raised some twenty years earlier (Moghadam 2000; Jolly et al. 2004).

The question that arises from these global commitments on gender and women's rights is this: Where have the mainstream development agencies been during all of this? I would argue that they were "missing in action." Women and development was a marginalized topic and treated almost as a fringe issue for most of the last 50 years. Anita Anand challenged the dominant 1980s view that focused on increased income generation, education, and nutrition projects targeted to women. As laudable as such projects are, she argued that the view avoided the central problem of the male dominated system itself: "Unless there is better understanding of how both patriarchy and economic systems propagate oppression, no effective and inclusive work on bringing about a new order can be done" (Anand 1982: 24).

The Development Assistance Committee (DAC) can be described as the voice and the heart of OECD's mission focusing on poverty reduction, improvement in living standards, increased well-being, and sustainable development (OECD-DAC 2017). The lack of movement on gender and development can be illustrated by looking at DAC data over the last thirty years. In 1995 only six to eight percent of OECD-DAC members' Official Development Assistance (ODA) went to WID-specific and WID-integrated projects (DAC Secretariat 1995), only slightly more than from 1987. By 2007, only 26 percent of projects had "gender related actions," a looser definition than contained in the 1995 report (OECD-DAC Secretariat 2007: 28). By 2016 only five percent of aid went to women's equality as a primary objective and 32 percent of aid went to projects with women's equality as either a primary or secondary objective. Of course, if gender was truly mainstreamed, one would expect the volume of aid being spent on women's equality, as either a primary or secondary objective, would be close to 100 percent (OECD-DAC Secretariat 2016).

A study of Dutch NGOs found that individual staff lack the institutional structure and "enabling policy environment" to translate a political gender agenda into their work (van Eerdewijk and Dubel 2012: 354). The study also found "that the meaning of gender becomes vulnerable to depoliticization and instrumentalization" due to a weak integration of gender at the middle level management of departments or sectoral programs. The issue probably is broader than what has been discussed here. While gender policies advance, implementation lags behind. This is not only because of latent patriarchal structures within organizations, but also because the process of negotiations with partners over a range of issues relegates gender to a lower order priority among a complex list of often contradictory policy requirements. This is also combined with the "weakness of the women's movement and public accountability in the aid recipient countries (that) constrain their own [recipient country] mandates" (Jahan 1992: 14; DAC Secretariat 1999).

THE NEW AID AGENDA AND ASIA

While the idea of neoliberalism as a paradigm for national governance may be fading very fast in the 2010s, it is being replaced by a new nationalism, or neocorporatism, which is even *less* gender or women's-rights friendly. At the same time, Western foreign aid is in competition with China and other non-western donors, mainly from Asia (Kilby 2015; Koehler 2015). Asia's ODA landscape varies greatly, and sees substantial aid to developing Asia from its rich East Asian neighbors, especially Japan and Korea. The West is ready to soften or dilute some of its social conditions, including women's rights, in aid programs (Mawdsley et al. 2014). This political shift does not auger well for the further advancement of women's equality and other pressing gender issues in national development beyond appearances: the less that happens on the ground leads

to “a propensity to emphasize mainstreaming in symbolic gestures and publicity materials than in real work programs” (Jahan 1992: 16). Gender is still treated as a “social” issue with a reluctance to bring it more broadly into political and economic life. Most ASEAN countries, for example, have forms of restrictive legislation that limits women’s participation in economic life (UN Women 2016). In the UN itself, hard won advances on women’s rights are being systematically pushed back (Goetz 2015; Halperin-Kaddari and Freeman 2016). Goetz (2015) notes that:

... in recent meetings of the Commission on the Status of Women an increasingly coordinated misogynist backlash has been building unconventional alliances that transcend familiar geopolitical divisions and draw on the resources of religious organizations. States that have in the past been seen as defenders of women’s rights are losing ground in negotiations. There is a growing reluctance to expend political capital in defense of what has been constructed and maligned as a Western social preoccupation.

(Goetz 2015: 1)

At the 2015 CSW session celebrating the Beijing Women’s Conference, the Declaration re-affirming the Beijing commitment was negotiated for the first time behind closed doors prior to the formal session. This meant that feminist and human rights organizations were kept at arm’s length, and could not lobby delegations to have changes made to the text. In the end, the Declaration made no mention of gender, sexual, and reproductive rights, and removed references to human rights agreements. This organized backlash to keep these items from even being discussed came from countries calling themselves the “Group of Friends of the Family,” which included Indonesia, Iran, Kuwait, Libya, Malaysia, Pakistan, Qatar, Russia, Saudi Arabia, Somalia, Turkmenistan, and Yemen. The largest Asian Muslim nations in the globe were represented. All these countries are very strong theocratic or quasi-theocratic states in which religious

organizations with patriarchal agendas have a powerful voice in government policy.

These religious voices coalesce with the rise of the more authoritarian states associated with strong masculinist cultural norms. Gender advocates, therefore, have even less chance of addressing issues about male dominance and power, and at best, “medicalize” gender issues such as domestic violence, by providing counseling and shelters. In turn, the more fundamental issues of power that drive this violence are avoided (Al-Ali 2012; Coşar and Özkan-Kerestecioğlu 2017; Duncan et al. 1997; Fincher 2016; Johnson and Saarinen 2013). China is not only cracking down on local feminist organizations, but is emphasizing that women’s roles need to be connected to domestic issues. The Beijing Women’s Legal Counseling Service was closed down in 2016 (Phillips 2016). It is also backtracking on previous commitments, putting the brakes on the application of the Marriage Law of 1950 that abolished many oppressive practices disproportionately affecting women in the traditional Chinese family. For example, child betrothal was banned and free-choice marriage was instituted. However, the law is under assault since today too many women want divorces. References are escalating in official media, and by the Chinese leadership, to Confucianism and its patriarchal values (Otis 2015). The feminist “threat” in China appears to be growing.

... feminists present a unique threat to the Communist Party’s vision of a patriarchal family at the core of a strong, paternalistic state [which] pushes a revival of Confucian values, urging women to return to the home and have two children rather than one.

(Fincher 2016: 87)

Part of this move to push women out of the labor market is a response to the specter of rising unemployment as economic growth falters, together with an aging population in the longer term. Hence women are cajoled to stay at home

and take on motherhood as their primary role. Japan is having the opposite problem. As the economy recovers, it needs a greater participation rate of women to avoid labor shortages and to decrease immigration, thus encouraging women into the labor force (Otis 2015).

Across Asia the same pattern is repeated. In India, the government of Narendra Modi, which has Hindu nationalist support, is highly critical of the Muslim marriage law and seeks to amend it. At the same time, however, it is not working actively to stem the escalating tide of sexual assault of women across India. Nor has the government been overtly critical of the nationalist Rashtra Sevika Samiti (RSS) women's wing that promotes "family values" within a patriarchal society. These certainly do not auger well for women's greater autonomy (Iyengar 2017). In Indonesia, the government has backtracked on its commitment to abolishing local Sharia laws targeting women, and has attacked activists fighting for lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) rights (Human Rights Watch 2017). In Turkey, the Erdogan government "has been marked by gender inequalities and patriarchal norms," and it actively promotes stay-at-home policies for women, particularly in the light of a declining economy (Kaneva 2016: 1).

Some of these more authoritarian states are also donor states and in Asia, these include China and India. Their policy of non-interference in the affairs of their aid recipients means that aid programs that target gender will be further marginalized. Western donors offer "conditions" for aid that not only refer to structural adjustment provisions, but can also refer to human rights provisions, such as gender equality. China's preference in its international relations and aid programs is to focus on group rights over individual rights and, as such, are highly critical of European and Western approaches (Paradise 2009). On top of this, women's rights fall into the realm outside of government purview: "violations of personal integrity and disrespect for these rights is usually an undesirable, but nevertheless

integral part of social conventions, norms, and behavior" (Neumayer 2003: 516).

China's policy in its aid programs of non-interference in recipient state matters was first announced by Zhou Enlai in 1964. As one of his eight principles of China's foreign aid, this has been adhered to even since (Cheng et al. 2012). At the Busan high level conference on aid in 2011, China even publicly questioned DAC principles such as "the universal validity of the claim that democratic ownership, human rights and citizen empowerment are necessary to achieve (economic) development" (Mawdsley et al. 2014: 33).

The implications of this shift in donor power relations and the diminution of the role of donor groups such as DAC, means that greater gender integration in aid, as limited as it may have been, will have an even more muted voice (Mawdsley et al. 2014). Like rights-based development, gender and development may take a back seat, if not fade away altogether.

The other side to this shift is that the state of development is clearer in its resistance to policy prescriptions. The more nationalist Asian states such as Cambodia, the Philippines, and Laos, among others, have all actively resisted policy prescriptions around human rights. They have threatened the Western donor relationships since China is ready to support them without such human rights conditions (Sedara and Öjendal 2014; Singh 2014; Sending and Lie 2015). In all these cases, aid recipients have been able to resist pressures from the West on issues such as democracy and human rights, and apart from token efforts, are unlikely to translate aid in the pursuit of gender justice in their societies. "The era of Western-dominated aid institutions and regimes is far from dead, but it is certainly starting to rupture" (Mawdsley et al. 2014: 29).

CONCLUSION

This chapter has tracked the history of gender and development policy of foreign aid agencies

with a focus on Asian countries as both recipients and donors. While international agencies may have advanced their theoretical understanding of gender issues, this has tended to be ghettoized in women's units and women's sections in government and NGO aid organizations. Any notion of gender equality as mainstreamed is far from the center of aid policy. At an organizational level, women's rights and gender issues remain largely at the level of rhetorical flourish, avoiding the fundamental issues of inequality, especially a lack of rights as driven by power relations and latent patriarchies. I argue that this is an issue across all development agencies, NGOs, and multilateral organizations, and governments.

Second, even where policy has been "mainstreamed," it has not been reflected in practice. The global commitment to gender justice is probably as weak as it ever has been. While there have been advances on issues related to gender and women's equality with some donors, the changing aid landscape has opened up new threats, including increasing authoritarianism in more nationalist aid recipient countries. They are less inclined to be lectured to on how they behave to their citizens and to the international community. This is due in part to the gendered nature of partner governments and organizations. Gender is a residual field to be looked at after attending to "more important" issues.

Finally, across Asia, the rise of the more illiberal neocorporatist state and a reversion to "traditional values" has meant that 50 years of overall work on women and development is under threat. I have been critical of the emphasis by development agencies that focus on women's economic roles without challenging how gender relations play out in the household or in broader society. States throughout Asia are shifting back to more authoritarian regimes, in turn inviting a return to stronger patriarchy. The work of agencies supporting local feminist NGOs, therefore, will be more important than ever.

NOTES

- 1 Mexico City (1975), Copenhagen (1980), Nairobi (1985), Beijing (1995).
- 2 UNGA. 1975. United Nations General Assembly Resolution 30/3520(XXX); United New York: UN Documents.
- 3 UNIFEM, United Nations Fund for Women; INSTRAW, United Nations International Research and Training Institute for the Advancement of Women.

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Chapter four

Globalization and Gender Equity in China

Linda L. Lindsey

INTRODUCTION

China's "opening up" and subsequent economic reform in the late twentieth century spawned the most powerful socioeconomic transformation in its history.¹ Fueled by globalization and the massive increase of women in the labor force, this transformation ushered in rapid economic development, but at the expense of loss in social equality, especially for women. Research centering on issues related to globalization and gender has exploded but sources making the linkage explicit are difficult to uncover. As noted in Chapter 1, gender issues in much of developing Asia are discussed mainly in the context of development and tend to be marginalized from the larger globalization picture. Research on gender and development is exceedingly rich and robust, with meaningful contributions useful to development planning, policy studies, and interdisciplinary theory building. It fails, however, to connect the widening global economic gap to the women who are in the poorest ranks, and often overlooks women in advanced economies who fall prey to negative development outcomes inspired by globalization. To inspect gender equity in China, rather than treating gender equity as a determinant of development success, this chapter treats globalization, specifically its neoliberal variant as the independent measure. Except for early partnering with

Soviet bloc countries on certain economic and political initiatives, China was largely devoid of external development programs. Because opening up occurred swiftly, China offers an excellent case to examine neoliberal globalization's (NLG) impact on gender equity without the development entanglement. We will see that NLG and gender equity play out differently in China than in other societies with or without comparable development and economic strategies.

To shed light on these issues, three linked cost-benefit analyses are presented related to: the defenders and detractors of NLG; how gender issues are framed and unfold in NLG; and how gender equity is navigated under NLG in China. With the World Bank as a backdrop these analyses suggest that NLG and gender equity in China stand at a crossroads. A paradigm shift from NLG to hybrid models with a state capitalism thrust may offer successful economic policies that are especially beneficial to women, not only in China, but throughout Asia.

Globalization 101: From Economic Globalization to Neoliberal Globalization

To frame gender equity in the discourse of globalization, this section provides a sketch of the

“basics” of globalization. This brief conceptual and historical overview sets the stage for considering globalization’s powerful effect on gender equity in China.

As early as the 1950s the term “globalization”—sometimes referred to as “globalism”—frequently surfaced in media, scholarly, and business sources. These outlets highlighted the variety of sociocultural and economic processes connecting people on global paths, allowing them to borrow, learn, cooperate, exchange, and compete with one another. With the backdrop of the Cold War coupled with the rapid industrialization of the developing world, governments and fledgling transnational corporations (TNCs) alike advocated benefits of globalization, highlighting its potential for expanding democracy through capitalism and suggesting that poor nations not only provide a huge, cheap labor force, but are the untapped consumers to generate corporate profit and to retard the economic isolation that plagues the developing world.

Over the next two decades globalization became synonymous with global capitalism, ideologically grounded in “free market” approaches emphasizing the benefits of unfettered trade, foreign direct investment (FDI) in developing world economies, and strategies fostering global financial integration. Embraced by powerful and allied economic organizations such as the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF), this model of economic globalization (EG) included structural adjustment programs (SAPs) to remove barriers to increase flow of capital between, and within, nations. SAPs are associated with “austerity” policies required for developing world nations, already mired in debt, to qualify for loans and a range of development assistance. Markets are compromised with interference from “non-market” forces, such as organized labor, subsidies on goods and services, obstructionist cultural norms, and onerous regulations on the conduct of business. EG affirmed “top-down” economic paths viewed as business-friendly and efficient for job creation, economic growth, and development.

By the 1980s EG became more focused as NLG was rapidly ushered in, with reinvigorated principles related to “trade openness and market liberalization” as its global mantra. NLG intensified deregulation and privatization in sectors that were previously more immune, such as water, basic foodstuffs, pharmaceuticals, education, and small farming. The alignment of political, financial, and corporate interests further cemented global economic power, especially among TNCs. With unity of purpose, this power worked to infuse market-driven initiatives with “free market” solutions for social problems, a process that soon became normative (Rodan 2006). With the World Bank at the steering wheel, the most powerful global players constructed policies according to these principles, including the World Trade Organization (WTO), the IMF, and TNCs, as well as the United Nations and a range of non-governmental organizations (NGOs), civil society organizations (CSOs), and newly minted inter-governmental organizations (IGOs). Global stakeholders serving the needs of noncorporate constituents must work with NLG strategies, regardless of how they might wish it to be otherwise. Neoliberal globalization, therefore, is redundant (Akram-Lodhi 2006)

NEOLIBERAL GLOBALIZATION IN ASIA: FOR BETTER OR WORSE?

With the World Bank blessing, TNCs maintain that trade openness maximizes corporate profit and enhances growth, innovation, and prosperity in nations with firmly rooted NLG policies. Accelerated by energy and information and communication technology (ICT) as Asia’s sectoral leaders, growth was experienced throughout all other sectors, a pattern most evident in Asia’s urban centers such as Bangalore, Bangkok, Jakarta, Shanghai, and Kuala Lumpur. With semiconductor technology in the forefront, the ICT revolution is a key driver of economic

growth across the globe, but especially in developing Asia's new economic order, notably represented by China and India (Jorgenson and Vu 2016). East Asian countries have clearly benefited from trade and investment liberalization, and people have positive attitudes about economic globalization (Chang 2014). Aggregate wealth, as measured by GDP, increased in virtually every Asian nation that fully embraced NLG.

Globalization's migrant labor force centered in Asia also suggests an NLG benefit. Legions of young, female domestic and care workers provide substantial amounts of remittance income, often surpassing the income from development assistance and FDI (Rosewarne 2012). The feminization of migrant labor is led by Filipino women. Often viewed as the globe's "caretakers," these women and other migrants like them, contribute to the economic growth of their labor-exporting countries. International debt and inflation sparked implementation of relaxed labor-export policies as strategies to jumpstart economic revival in Indonesia and the Philippines. With remittances driving economic growth and enhancing the well-being of the families left behind, labor-exporting nations encourage cross-border migration with policies offering ease of access and less regulation. (Oishi 2005; Cheng and Choo 2015).

NLG ushers in the "rule of law," offering transparency and a foundation for stability to entice TNCs to nations previously sealed from FDI. Driven by NLG faith in the certainty of financial gain, a converging global political order unfolds, based on the wedding of democracy and liberal economics (Cliteur 2006: 29). Business and trade agreements by all entities, notably those under the WTO umbrella, are protected under legal assurances overseen by state and international regulatory agencies (Charnovitz 2015). These directives, signed off on by TNCs and approved by regional associations such as the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC), detail obligations of all partners in their business initiatives and the penalties that accrue for failure

to abide by them. NLG strategies are also implicitly embedded in the top-down economic messages offered to the public. In the Asia-Pacific region, for example, trade policies are often encased in pro-development discourse (Hsieh 2017). Enticed in by business-friendly regulatory agreements, political stability, and an abundant, cheap labor force in service and manufacturing sectors, businesses will be encouraged to put down corporate roots.

A "rhetoric of fairness" ensues. For employees, this translates to rights connected with fair labor practices, safe and secure work environments, and legal social protection policies put in place by the state, all of which are expected to be implemented throughout a company, including headquarters and subsidiaries (Chopra 2015; Poster 2008). Companies negotiate labor contracts with migrant workers, and offer mechanisms of redress, for example, if employees lodge complaints against their employers, whether they work in private homes or larger businesses. For businesses, it translates to trade fairness and patent and intellectual property protections channeled through international legal agreements. Benefits of diversity are additionally advanced for businesses and employees in the society in which they reside, and TNCs are scrambling to implement management programs to allow for human capacity building in their workforce, harnessing under-utilized employees, seeking talent from locales in which they do business, and as channels to cultivate leadership at all employee levels (Forbes 2008; McCarthy 2017)

Competitive success requires a strong diversity component at all corporate levels. Cultural understanding is encouraged, and social capital is built. Corporate social responsibility (CSR), a buzzword in global business, is highlighted in media messages about corporate contributions to communities in which they operate (Walker-Said and Kelly 2015). Gender diversity in corporate management and on boards is especially celebrated by businesses capitalizing on CSR messages. Businesses are well aware that diversity

is profitable, and with the help of female employees, are keen to devise marketing strategies attracting new ethnic minority customers (Choy 2007; Shen et al. 2009; Rao and Tilt 2016).

A “growth with equity” pattern emerged early and was maintained throughout the 1980s, especially in East Asia’s rapidly expanding mid-level economies, including Taiwan and South Korea. Growth accelerated in Japan and Southeast Asia. With infrastructure enhancement provided by the state and increased employment options provided by private firms, large numbers of the very poor transitioned from informal sector workers to wage earners throughout developing Asia. Asia’s rural transformation, catapulted by globalization, is largely responsible for economic benefits accruing from diversified sources of household income, including a combination of farm and off-farm employment, and expanded educational opportunities for females (Chapter 1). The poorest regions of Central and South Asia witnessed modest, if steady, economic growth and rising standards of living. These foundations are seen as helping to avert the social unrest associated with rapid social and economic change, offering further incentives for FDI in the Global South. Indeed, developing Asia became the poster child as the best site for factories to make goods, and in more prosperous East Asia, for retail outlets to sell them. Overall, NLG ideology assumes it to be a success for profit and a social good that improves human well-being through markets that are inherently fair, efficient, and equitable.

Although this picture is tantalizing, NLG’s liability in Asia offers a starkly different perspective. Although the impact of globalization is uneven, decades of data clearly document the glaring flaws of top-down economic models that significantly increases inequality and maximizes benefits for the few, not the many (Houseman 2008; Burgmann 2016; Nunn and White 2016).

Hardest hit are poor regions with little control over how new privatization initiatives are carried out. For example, in northeast India increasing

demand for electricity is met through “the dirtiest, most inefficient means.” Many areas that used to have pristine air and negligible emissions of global warming gases are dreadfully polluted (Bradsher 2007). Also in India, after a decade of “galloping economic growth” and rising GDP, child malnutrition rates have worsened, even in comparison to many sub-Saharan African countries (Sengupta 2009). In Bangladesh, environmental destruction is rampant. Many factories do not treat wastewater, spawning the purple canals and noxious smells urban dwellers learn to tolerate (Yardley 2013a). Drought and climate change influenced by manufacturing and automobile pollution continue to deteriorate Beijing’s already noxious air quality, exacerbated by drought, and global warming. Recent sandstorms carrying particles to Beijing from the Gobi Desert have pushed smog so high that it is literally off the pollution charts (Cummins and Wang 2017).

Diversity initiatives notwithstanding, NLG reestablishes, bolsters, or fuels new economic elites. The consolidation of corporate and banking power in turn discourages the innovation and free trade envisioned by NLG principles. It is easier to unleash a market than to build the “social and political governance” within which markets need to operate. State power is used to advance powerful business interests (Robison 2006). Infrastructure is harmed, environmental and safety standards in factories are weakened, living conditions deteriorate, and financial instability increases, fueling social tension and the political repercussions that follow. Benefits emanating from the rule law and policies related to worker rights and workplace protection are often shattered.

Dangerous working conditions in factories with little oversight of third party sub-contractors by TNCs is the garment-industry norm in Bangladesh. Nominal owners rather than the TNCs manufacturing for them were held responsible for 112 deaths of mostly female workers at the Tazreen factory in Bangladesh in 2012 while

making clothes for major brands. A year later the deadliest garment factory tragedy in history—in any country—again occurred in Bangladesh, when the Rana Plaza factories, housed in an eight-story building, collapsed, killing over 1100 workers, the majority of them young migrant women. The disorganized, haphazard post-disaster inspections of a handful of over 5000 factories in Bangladesh revealed massive structural and safety violations of even minimal building codes. A maze of confusing sub-contracting layers renders it difficult to trace accountability to any one culprit, a fact retailers routinely seize upon to deny knowledge of factory hazards. Retailers rely on trade associations, independent third-party assessors, and in-house auditors to monitor suppliers (Al-Mahmood and Wright 2013). With little headway, attempts to avert another disaster are tenuous (Yardley 2013b).

A seamstress who survived the collapse says: “I’d like to find alternative work but I don’t know what I can do.” Her previous informal position job was as a housemaid paying \$20 a month. Bangladesh guarantees a minimum wage of \$38 a month in factories. The \$18 difference literally prevents her family from starvation (Al-Mahmood 2013). Like other women surviving the Rana tragedy, she was anxious to return to work.

The Rana tragedy confirms a key peril associated with NLG. Political turmoil and economic damage go hand in hand. Festering turmoil in Bangladesh between secularists and Islamists is escalating, its fallout associated with millions of dollars in lost garment orders due to mass protests over how Bangladesh is either too harsh or too easy on TNCs and their subcontractors, and the outrage over the factory collapse that closed ports and blockaded streets (Banjo 2013). In a nation dependent on the garment-industry, Bangladesh is alarmed when Western companies rethink their presence in this poor economy. Disney has retreated and Nike had already reduced its Bangladesh footprint over concern for working conditions (Al-Mahmood and Banjo 2013).

Businesses are rightly alarmed when a nation’s social fabric begins to unravel. Rather than enticing businesses to stay, the irony is that economic uncertainty, infrastructure harm, environmental deterioration, political unrest, and worker peril ushered in with NLG cause businesses to retreat.

The Global North enlarges the economic subordination of developing Asia, with TNCs and their financial partners often controlling the fate of the poorest nations. The state regulates “free markets” by dismantling perceived barriers to profit, such as pensions, social services, environmental standards, and workplace safety rules, but also through bailouts to a banking industry struggling with fallout from failed decisions. TNCs reap advantages from their allied financial institutions and an altered version of “market discipline” not granted to the public (Marshall 2012). Depending on one’s place in the NLG food chain, the myths and flaws of “flat world” economics become exposed for what they are: collusion between Western-based corporate giants, and increasingly their rich East Asia counterparts, where trade is neither open nor fair and wannabe competitors are crushed.

Most importantly, this liability picture reveals growing inequalities and wealth gaps between and within countries. NLG intensifies inequitable distribution of resources. Economists increasingly call into question GDP as a valid measure of national wealth and how it meaningfully translates to per capita income, a universal marker to track economic progress. The GINI-coefficient, the much-used measure indexing the differences in income between rich and poor parts of the world, show consistent patterns of increased income inequality accelerated with NLG. Although GINIs are increasing in the Global North, the income variance is more extreme within developing countries (de Kort 2006: 102). Earlier economic gains in Asia’s developing nations are stalling and the bargaining power of workers relative to employers is evaporating (Ghosh 2017). The NLG celebrated “growth with

equity” pattern turned on its heels to become the “great reversal.”

Neoliberal Globalization: The Emerging Picture

Interlocking sets of discourses and the institutional structures in which they are embedded assure the NLG paradigm remains virtually intact. Explanations for this pattern center on three important points. First, its discourse is hegemonic—it is accepted, expected economic practice, espoused in dominant management theories and taught in business schools and economics courses globally (Mitry 2008; Marsella 2009). Second, its discourse is Western. Collectivistic values are subordinated to individualistic ones. NLG opposes all forms of social solidarity—such as unions, village-based farming, public ownership, and community profit centers—in favor of individualism, free choice, private wealth, and personal responsibility. In China, the values of collectivism became older, smaller, and weaker throughout the 1980s (Feng 2011). Third, global news and entertainment media reinforce NLG as right, proper, and good—the heralded strategy to lift the world’s people out of poverty—and rarely challenged in meaningful ways. Consider, too, that the *Wall Street Journal*, the bastion of NLG, is the most widely read paper in the world.

These discourses intertwine with the political, financial, and corporate alignment mentioned earlier. Regardless of capitalism-democracy rhetoric, the form and structure of government does not predict its economic system. NLG flourishes in democracies, monarchies, and socialist countries and those with one-party or revolving military rule, such as Kuwait, Thailand, and Brazil, and in nations characterized by high degrees of political repression such as Saudi Arabia, the Gulf States, China, and regimes throughout Africa (Lindsey 2004: 656–657). NLG’s laudable goals are divorced from how it plays out in practice.

NEOLIBERAL GLOBALIZATION: THE GENDER CONNECTION

The second cost-benefit analysis connects gender to neoliberal globalization. The World Bank maintains that globalization is a vital force for gender equity and development. It is again trade openness and increased FDI that are the necessary ingredients to alleviate global poverty and enhance development prospects for women. Arguably the globe’s most influential development document, the annual *World Development Report* (WDR) is steeped in NLG language, a steadily increasing pattern since the publication of the first WDR in 1978. Gender issues gained more prominence in the WDR with the upsurge of interest in “women in development” (WID) in the 1990s. In 1995 the World Bank issued a series of WID reports in conjunction with the Fourth United Nations Conference on Women. Convening in Beijing, it was the largest gathering of women in history. Both the official conference and the parallel NGO Forum garnered worldwide support for the Platform of Action that served as the springboard for the later UN Millennium Development Goals and for gender-friendly development policies. Women take center stage in WDR 2012, *Gender Equality and Development*.² Consistent with other World Bank documents, globalization in this report is understood as: the combination of economic integration, technological diffusion, and greater access to information (operating) through markets, and formal and informal institutions to lift some of the constraints to greater gender equity.

The World Bank maintains that globalization disproportionately benefits women more than men due to “changes brought about by trade openness and technological change.” Information and communication technology (ICT), for example, translates to more jobs for women, moving them out of the informal sector and connecting them to markets. Girls have greater

incentive than boys to stay in school since “brain jobs” favoring girls increase and “brawn jobs” favoring boys decrease (WDR 2012: Ch. 6).

Feminization of employment in export firms is largely responsible for any decrease in the gender wage gap. The World Bank highlights Bangladesh’s garment-industry as a globalization success story for women. This Muslim society opened its doors to trade and FDI, enabling women to migrate from poverty-stricken rural areas for employment in cities. Estimates of the number of clothing factories in Bangladesh are in the 5000 range, providing employment for four million people, 90 percent of them women. Although wages hover near the poverty line, they are double the wages women earned (or could earn) as agricultural laborers. Families benefit since women with spendable income are more likely than men with such income to use it for family sustainability, such as education for children and siblings. In this highly patriarchal society a woman’s employment increases her household status (Goldin and Reinert 2006: 53).

Gender inequality has more costs in a globalized world. As noted earlier, as a component of diversity, gender is a force for equality in businesses. Restricting women’s employment in firms with products and services geared to females and a large female work force risks both harm to the company and the society in which it operates. Transparency in formal agreements reduces a firm’s ability to discriminate against women.³ Remembering, too, that neoliberal globalization is redundant, globalization’s powerful, long-standing effects can be harnessed to improve a woman’s life through employment, education, and entrepreneurship, enhancing her own and her family’s well-being.

Decades of research, however, paints a far different picture of NLG for women. With Ester Boserup’s (1970) pioneering work, *Woman’s Role in Economic Development*, and the explosion of research that followed, the differential gender consequences of development are well documented. Notwithstanding World Bank conclusions,

over a half century of research demonstrates a pervasive global pattern connecting development programs to women’s impoverishment, marginalization, and exploitation (Tiessen 2007; Lindsey 2015: Chap. 1). Recently this pattern has accelerated through the “deep marketization” of NLG-led development theory and practice (Carroll and Jarvis 2015). These strategies serve co-opted NGOs, CSOs, and volunteers working on behalf of women. Because development and globalization discourses are entangled, messages about gender equity benefits are heard but difficult to verify. When development is empirically traced back to its globalization roots, gendered risks are glaring, maximized for women with an intersection of minority statuses (Everett and Charlton 2014). This intersection looms large in selections of NLG’s liabilities for women.

For the corporate women who may benefit most from NLG’s multicultural embrace, diversity is repackaged, filtering the rule of law and rhetoric of fairness (Poster 2008). Regardless of size of firm or its eagerness to maximize potential for profit, diversity implementation is fraught with tension. Gender inequality and the underutilization of women’s talent is rampant throughout Asia (Cho et al. 2015: 407). In deeply paternalistic corporate cultures that parallel cultural norms outside the workplace, women are compromised for leadership and promotion. In factories and firms globally, the least skilled and lowest paid women, many of whom are the ethnic minorities businesses seek to recruit as new consumers, will never ascend beyond their workstation rank (Morgan 2009; Vargus 2009).

NLG reinforces outmoded visions of gendered spheres, refusing to acknowledge in economic terms the overlap for the majority of the world’s women residing in both the so-called public, male workplace sphere and the private, female household sphere. Risks associated with NLG are maximized for minority women navigating intersections of statuses in both spheres. Women whose domestic work includes subsistence farming are at increased risk. In Asia’s

rural transformation, husbands often sell these plots, migrating to cities in search of employment, and abandoning families in rural areas that are further impoverished when commercial crops are ushered in with agribusiness (Lindsey 2015: Chap. 6).

Paid and unpaid labor burdens increase. NLG deregulates state resources such as welfare, health, education, and child care benefits and reprivatizes them to the household. Any decrease in a gender wage gap is offset by increases in spending due to loss of public supported resources, especially subsidies on basic foodstuffs such as grain and cooking oil, clean water and fuel, and necessities for maintaining a semblance of a healthy lifestyle.

Microcredit, the hallmark capitalistic development strategy conceived with the world's poorest women in mind, is undermined. Originating in Bangladesh, it is associated with successful peer lending strategies, literacy, and entrepreneurial programs. Such programs are eroding as for-profit financial institutions enter and are increasingly dictating microcredit policy in Asia (Chapter 24). Competing with international firms, for example, women lose markets for traditional crafts with cheap, low quality imports and their micro businesses have higher failure rates. Unlike the nonprofit village bank model from which microcredit was spawned, an NLG-based banking industry often discounts the economic activities of the informal sector which comprise the majority of the work women perform, such as subsistence farming, child and elder care, and operating small stands with products for barter or trade. Asset qualifications for loans are higher and women are denied an essential benefit of a program originally designed for them.

There is a loss of voice for women from NGOs which traditionally have been their front-line advocates. Women-oriented NGOs are deploying the "neoliberal discourse of volunteerism, self-reliance and private initiative," co-opted by donors serving corporate and political interests (Calás et al. 2009). Women receive messages

about resilience and agency but often the structural and cultural bases on which the NLG discourse is founded are ignored (Rao 2017; Rigg and Oven 2015). It is poignant that the development schemes called upon to mitigate NLG's fallout are correlated with deepened poverty and marginalization in both the developing and developed worlds.

World Bank on the Defensive

World Bank is not immune to criticisms that development programs have been "less than successful" in its quest to erode gender inequity through NLG strategies. As indicated in the 2012 World Development Report:

Public opinion in developed countries generally connects globalization with sweatshops, where child labor is common, and workers are denied basic rights. Frequently it is argued that women are especially hurt by this process. The fact that women willingly take on this type of job is usually explained by the lack of better options and the destruction of their traditional ways of life caused by globalization. In reality the impact of trade liberalization on working conditions varies across firms, sectors, and countries. In many cases, these jobs (subcontracted work) was the only possible paid employment they could do to mesh with "family responsibilities and social norms"

(WDR 2012: Chap. 6)

Given NLG's entrenchment in World Bank programs, it is not surprising that World Bank traces gender inequality back to state restrictions on trade and FDI. WDR 2012 suggests that "in the absence of public policy globalization alone cannot, and will not, reduce gender inequality." NLG is not the culprit of gender inequality. Gender equality is stalled *because* economies remain too closed. It is the state's responsibility to address those pesky cultural norms that prevent women's empowerment. Therefore, *intensified* NLG is

encouraged. Armed with entrepreneurial, free market strategies, WDR offers avenues to do just that (Chapters 6 and 9).

Since the boom began in the 2000s, Bangladesh's garment-industry has grown to over \$20 billion. Yet Bangladesh remains mired in poverty, with an increasing wealth gap. NLG has not been the savior to bring the vast majority of its citizens anywhere near a reasonable standard of living or to seriously address the abject poverty and peril for the women whose factory work is necessary to keep the entire economy afloat. Given the overall picture, World Bank's assertion that Bangladesh is a success story for women is indefensible.

World Bank acknowledges that "some things" have not worked for women but does not account for its own policies contributing to the dire effects of gender inequality. A multitude of World Bank publications offer contradictory, even paradoxical, advice for enhancing development opportunities for women.⁴ If the state is expected to address problems—such as gender discrimination in hiring, pay, and promotion—it interferes in the very policies that TNCs depend on to do business in many countries, such as state support for collective bargaining, establishing minimum wage requirements, and legally assuring workplace protections for women and ethnic and racial minorities.

GENDER AND NEOLIBERAL GLOBALIZATION IN CHINA

On the brink of economic collapse after the disasters of the Cultural Revolution, it is not historical coincidence that NLG coincided with China's opening up that began in earnest by 1980. Despite the fact that the Peoples' Republic of China (PRC) was less than three decades old and the world's largest communist country, with its vast, untapped consumer market and a cheap labor force spurred by the feminization of export manufacturing, China was (and is) viewed as the

globe's most fertile ground for foreign direct investment (FDI). The sharp right economic turn continued, even under U.S. foreign policy designed to contain China's nationalistic appetite, and more important, I believe, pardoning NLG culpability in the 1997 Asian financial crisis, and the lead-up to the 2008 global recession. NLG serving the alignment of economic interests centered in the Global North trumped suspicion associated with Chinese political motives.

It is speculated that China's late entry to the ranks of globalization as a serious contender, explains the relative lack of specific information in World Bank documents on China's economic activities, particularly women's activities. This changed dramatically with China's admittance to the World Trade Organization (WTO) in 2001.

With China's distinctive site in the global economy as the world's largest market and a political system orchestrating economic change with minimal outside interference and virtually no internal interference, it appears to be in a better position to manipulate its globalization path compared to its Asian neighbors as well as the rest of the developing world. In 1979, creating Special Economic Zones (SEZs) as hosts to foreign investment firms, what was labeled as "market socialism," was fueled. With wealthy Hong Kong entering China's fold in 1997, the massive growth of foreign investment firms in the Pearl River Delta and Guangdong Province, and the spectacular growth of Shanghai, the catalyst of Chinese industrial and urban expansion remains centered in south China (Cartier 2001). Farming was reorganized from communal to family-based, further shifting development efforts away from those led by agriculture to those led by industry. To the chagrin of the WTO and continuing allegations that China circumvents mandates on trade policies, intellectual property rights, patent protection, and FDI in its central banking and financial institutions, China still appears to be the puppeteer, pulling its own economic strings.

Chinese Women and Economic Reform

As noted, China's socioeconomic transformation was powered by women's massive entry into the ranks of the paid labor force. Although this transformation rapidly opened new alternatives for urban women, rural women were gradually able to embrace the possibilities it offered, a pattern found throughout Asia. Although this pattern continues to play out in Asia, its accelerated pace in China is traced to three key factors unique to China's political economy: Communist commitment to assuring women's equality from the founding of the PRC, ongoing efforts by the state to revise gender representations to bolster modernization schemes, and strategies encouraging economic reform through capitalist initiatives (Guthrie 2006; Tsai 2002). The first two factors laid out the gendered foundation on which the third factor—"Chinese style" capitalism—could explode.

The third cost-benefit analysis sheds light on the question of how gender equity is impacted in China's meteoric rise to global powerhouse status. Previous state policy and current economic reforms appear mutually supportive, fostering gender equity and women's economic integrity. Support for this contention is strong. Women's paid employment is normative and expected. Their new activities in both rural and urban areas have significantly increased household income, directly linked to improvement on measures of education and diversification of household income. Regardless of China's lifting of the one-child policy in 2016, allowing two children per couple, and the spurt of new births that year, Chinese couples increasingly say they desire only one child, believing the family will be more prosperous as a result (Hardee et al. 2004; Levenson 2017). As a potent global pattern, social development is driven by female education, in which China has excelled, and a trend that will likely put the brakes on fertility.

A small family frees women for more educational opportunities and employment options. Although more pronounced for men than for women, urban couples are increasingly delaying marriage and childbearing until more schooling is completed and the couple is comfortably ensconced in the labor force (Tian 2016–2017). For urban families, the educational gender gap in single-girl homes and single-boy homes in urban areas largely vanished almost two decades ago (Merli and Smith 2002; Tsui and Rich 2002).

Despite lagging behind their urban counterparts, increased rural income is eroding poverty, partly explained by remittances from children working in cities. Off-farm activity is led by the younger and better educated, including women who were previously excluded from employment. When women carry on-farm work because husbands and children migrate, the expense may be offset by higher levels of household decision-making. Women report more confidence, independence and freedom from patriarchal and parental control. For urban working couples, women have more job choices based on their educational and professional priorities (Matthews and Nee 2000; de Brauw et al. 2002; Fan 2008). Women's college graduation rates have skyrocketed. They welcome market reforms offering flexibility for their on-farm work and opportunities for off-farm employment commensurate with their education.

Since globalization's market liberalism generally hinges on ICT, the sector that has catapulted in China, pathways for NGO involvement have accelerated. China's ancient collectivism founded on obligations to one's family was coupled with Maoist socialism, and effectively created barriers keeping NGOs out of China. Unlike other developing nations with long established NGO networks, China has had little experience with NGOs or with the role they play in civil society (Morton 2005). Bolstered by the advocacy of the international women's movement, however, NGOs are increasingly visible. With overseas Chinese as key donors, NGO development

efforts offer a range of opportunities for women and girls, especially young migrant women, looked down upon by urban dwellers and whose rural upbringing severely impeded their education in their rural areas and their employment opportunities in urban areas. Although central government keeps a wary eye on them, NGOs may help with loss of subsidies in China's transition to market liberalization. Government "approved" women's organizations under the umbrella of the All-China Women's Federation, have been established to oversee changes in employment with the transition from state-owned to private enterprises.

Equity gains may also be traced to China's WTO entry where women benefited from formal guarantees, related to pay, hiring, transparency, and non-discrimination requirements. Garnering earlier global prestige for hosting the spectacular Fourth UN Conference on Women in 1995 and the also spectacular 2008 Olympics—China's "coming out party"—these events also served as a barometer of progress for China's economic ascent. With NGO support, thousands of women were trained for work at the Olympics, including migrants who leveraged their new skills for post-Olympic employment.

These trends are impressive, but like NLG globally, its downside for women's well-being in China is also well documented. Labor force participation of women has skyrocketed at the same time as massive increases in unemployment for both men and women. The sustainability of South China's SEZs is threatened as competition heats up for cheaper labor in other nations, especially in developing Asia (OECD 2017). China is already pricing itself out of garment-industry labor with its monthly minimum wage at \$138, compared to India at \$65 and Bangladesh at \$38 (Al-Mahmood and Wright 2013). Although there are reports of a slight downturn in women's unemployment, the data are suspect since unemployment nudges women into the informal sector, which is more difficult to monitor. Trends also suggest that men and women are competing for fewer higher skilled

production jobs and that women are being displaced by men in more technologically oriented manufacturing jobs. Occupational segregation by gender has intensified and the gender wage gap has increased (Knight 2016). Overall, highly educated men and women find themselves without the jobs their education calls for, but women are much more likely to take on factory work rather than risk unemployment.

Globalization has widened existing gender disparities in state sectors which historically hired more women, and are the first to be laid off with privatization. If fortunate enough to be rehired after their workplace is privatized, salaries and benefits are cut (Giles et al. 2006; Solinger 2002). As NLG accelerated, in those areas where family-based farming was normative, it has shifted to older, less educated women. Husbands and children migrate to cities and older women are left behind, taking on more household and farm work (Parker and Dales 2014). Despite greater household income, women gain less than men, and in female-headed households there is an overall net loss. Economic viability is weakened and future earnings compromised, because when family members migrate, not only must additional help be hired, but girls often drop out of school to work on the farm. Regardless of household type, domestic responsibilities for women have increased. If households become centers of production, women have less control over household-based sources of income than if it were earned outside the home (Hare 1999), a pattern continuing today. The burden of employment surplus also falls on women, especially migrants, further increasing gender wage differentials.

Traced to a gendered technological chasm, labor intensive jobs favoring women decrease and technologically driven jobs favoring men increase. (Shu 2005). Employment is further gender segregated and women find themselves competing for the fewer lower wage jobs available. Gender-segregated and stratified offices and factories are normative. Companies invest in young men as human capital and expect women to

return to their rural home, get married, or find other sources of employment. Women are paid less than men regardless of education or experience, further reducing their college benefit.

Women's organizations have been unsuccessful in meaningfully challenging the obvious gender inequity in this division of labor. The All China Women's Federation (ACWF) has the credentials of an "official" NGO, but inside China it is viewed an arm of the government and broader national economic policies take precedence over narrower gender-friendly economic policies (Chapter 5). Before NLG, Chinese labor policies accounted for the overlap of gendered spheres. Women's reproductive roles—such as paid maternity leave or day care—were mandated employee benefits throughout China. But as NLG accelerated, benefits to help with family responsibilities have been reduced or eliminated, driving women out of the labor market. In village enterprises with small manufacturing facilities spawned as joint ventures with start-up capital from FDI, women engage in paid labor, allowing them to remain in their villages and maintain their households, even in the absence of farming. However, gender wage discrimination continues, regardless of whether the village enterprises are joint ventures, owned by foreign investment firms, or owned by the state, township, or village (Dong and Bowles 2002). Opening up may have improved the purchasing power of women, but China's labor organizations, the ACWF, and NGOs have had little power to alter the negative side of market liberalization for them.

As in other global workplaces, assumptions about legal protections and fairness are filtered through culturally expected gender norms. Gender consciousness is eroding, and most women accept this reality as part of personal fate. Adding to the mix, essentialist beliefs about the "proper" place of men and women have reemerged, highlighting the incompatibility of employment and family roles (Yi and Chien 2002; Howell 2006; Wang 2015). If job and family are incompatible

problems of unemployment will "be solved" when women return to hearth and home. But women hear other messages that they are wanted and needed in the labor force. Constrained choices for women are summed up as "being successful" or "marrying well" (Wu 2010: 159).

Despite the demise of the one-child policy and preferences for smaller families overall, the disastrous legacy of the one-child policy for females will live on for decades. The one-child policy collided with increased life expectancy, which should be a benefit associated with globalization and development. Market liberalization reduces subsidies for social services, such as direct assistance to the elderly and support for caregivers. Whereas men may take on financial obligations for infirm parents and grandparents, women assume daily caregiving roles, driving them out of the workplace. The unfolding caregiving crisis for China's burgeoning elderly population provides more ammunition for essentialism, nudging women into what is perceived as their "natural" and expected caregiving roles.

China's national fertility is below replacement level at 1.5, and the resulting demographic imbalances are massive. In areas with sex ratios as high as 115–140 (males per 100 females), security issues are evolving. China's estimated 150 million "floating population" is comprised mostly of migrant males, many of whom are unmarried and will remain so.

In a strong son-preference culture, China has been unable to deal effectively with artificial gender imbalance harmful to females, including infanticide, coerced abortions, and neglect of female infants. Kidnapping, prostitution, trafficking, and selling girls are frequent, increasing in areas with a shortage of females (Ebenstein and Sharygin 2009; Bulte et al. 2011). Even today China appears more concerned about security issues stemming from legions of unmarried, undomesticated men on the loose on the urban fringes and in the hinterland than for the dire consequences of how the continuing effects of the one-child policy played out for girls (Lindsey 2015: 175).

Although China's economic leverage appears to help women buffeted by NLG, it does not diverge appreciably from the "classic" model documenting its negative impact. With two main components, a gendered paradox emerges:

- Contradictory and stagnant attitudes about employment and equity persist. Conservative attitudes about paid work for women continue to go down—but progressive attitudes about gender equity do not go up.
- Market discourse under China's state capitalism celebrates individualism and personal responsibility but flourishes in a culture that remains highly collectivistic in traditions, including gendered caregiving.

The paradox translates to weak enforcement of government policy. China is officially committed to women's equality, but legal means to enforce it in the workplace are feeble or absent and virtually nonexistent in the home.

Alternative Globalizations for Women in China: Profit or Protection?

Globalization is made up capitalist subsystems that will continue to diversify into hybrid models congruent with culture specific patterns. Since globalization accelerates diversity, cultures will respond to economic pressures according to political structure, population diversity, and values. Economic forces released in crisis can be mobilized in innovative ways. Jolted first by the 1997 Asian financial crisis and then the Great Recession, neoliberals are at odds as to the role of regulation in markets that serve the interests of capital to the detriment of labor and the stability of social systems on which business depend (Gamble 2006; Petras and Veltmeyer 2012). Despite capitalist initiatives, given the Marxist tenets upon which

the PRC and other socialist nations draw ideological strength, there is concern about rising inequality that has galvanized workers and electorates more sympathetic to an increasingly unified and expanded anti-globalization movement (Otis 2012; Hong 2015; Gemici and Nair 2016).

As currently configured, NLG is unsustainable (Nieuwenhuys 2006). With the mounting inequality gap inside and outside of China, it is a win for some and lose for most and will become lose-lose for everyone. In the throes of massive economic change, China effectively transitioned from a socialist economy to a market economy. (Carney 2016). However, China's version of a market economy retains nationalistic, economic, and cultural trappings not matched by any other nation on the globe. With planning based on incrementalism, central coordination of private and state-owned enterprises, a balance of centralized and decentralized development programs, and most important in times of economic crisis, a huge foreign exchange reserve, China's "state capitalism" weathered global recession, buffering its people better than other capitalisms (Ravallion 2009). China did not plunge into the "high-interest austerity budget medicine" prescribed by the World Bank and International Monetary Fund for other ailing economies (Zhu 2009: 58). With China at the forefront, various state capitalism models emerged as stronger global contenders than before the recession. Early in reform China recognized that if state subsidies bolstering poor people declined at too rapid a pace and outstripped the market's ability to spur economic growth in a timely manner, gains could quickly evaporate. Policies were put in place to tackle the severe side effects of unrestrained growth to "build a harmonious socialist society" (Lindsey 2007; Burnett 2010).

China does not see state-owned enterprises and private enterprises in conflict but working together to build this social ideal (Angang 2012). Unlike the U.S., China puts less trust in markets and more in "state guidance." NLG

economic policy is committed to profit, stockholder confidence, and investor return. NLG's state capitalism in China is committed to market-driven initiatives, especially in solving development needs, such as eroding poverty and raising wages and living standards (Ernst 2011). China's successful "national innovative system" is associated with economic growth in rural sectors by promoting social entrepreneurship (Wu et al. 2017). Efficiency may be sacrificed for political power, national pride, and global prestige. Leadership under Xi Jinping will not sway far from this path. Since access to open markets is necessary for its ongoing economic growth, NLG is "deeply integrated" in all sectors in China and in the global economy, also in symbiosis with the United States (McNally 2013). Being critical of the dangers of neoliberalism does not mean rejecting it. NLG will likely be tempered—not abandoned—and melded into China's ever evolving model of state capitalism (Breslin 2006).

Akin to sociological functionalism, China's state capitalism may plant the seeds for a gradual, smooth paradigm shift which minimizes mass disruptions associated with swift implementation of crisis-oriented policies. It is expected that discussion of state capitalism models will be central in regional associations such as APEC, new political networks forming around common challenges facing BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa), and throughout NGO and IGO networks in Asia (Singh 2012). Like China, Vietnam and Lao are struggling with the goals of building a "civilized and equitable society" under socialist (communist) principles but without deteriorating the well-being of its labor force. Also, like China, it has the strong trappings of a market economy but with a socialist orientation (Bui 2017; Tran and Nørland 2015). The progressive labor laws Vietnam maintains that seem to counter NLG mandates, can work to the benefit of women.

CONCLUSION: GENDER AND NEOLIBERAL GLOBALIZATION AT A CROSSROADS IN CHINA

As suggested in this chapter, the economic leverage China has amassed due to its status as the world's largest market appears to "officially" help women buffeted in the transition between a planned economy and one based on NLG's market liberalization. On the other hand, China appears to fit the classic model of the negative impact of globalization, economic reform, and development that erodes women's path to gender equity. The cursory cost-benefit analyses point to several scenarios that help elucidate these two seeming paradoxical trends. First, in the scenario evoking the most negative outcome, hegemonic NLG will continue its gut-wrenching comeback, regardless of its culpability in the millennium recession and unfolding global economic trends that appear to be replicating the pre-recession path. Globally, this argument is bolstered with the election of Donald Trump, who ushered in the most extreme so-called "business-friendly" agendas put in place by any nation, particularly any OECD member nation in decades. These policies are shattering regulations related to consumer protections, environmental safeguards in manufacturing, enforcement of labor rights, and ironically, have scaled back mandates for sexual harassment oversight in schools and workplaces. The freefall loss of global esteem for the U.S. at this point does not seem to be strongly connected to policies advanced by Trump, even as they are armed with NLG strategies. Considering that China and the U.S. are symbiotic in the global economy, none of this bodes well for women in either country.

Second, whether China's state capitalism will help or hurt women in the long run may depend on China's ability to continue to orchestrate its own terms and commit resources to bolster all economically vulnerable segments of its

population. Massive social problems spawned by industrial expansion (e.g. black rivers contaminated by industrial and human waste, grinding rural poverty, the expanding floating population) and problems spawned by repressive communism (e.g. human rights violations, information suppression, ruthless anti-democratization methods) disproportionately impact women. However equity oriented it appears, China's state capitalism is first and foremost pragmatic. Although not an objective, gender equity may be augmented, with women its accidental or unintentional beneficiaries. It is unlikely that gendered economics will be mainstreamed in China's quest for market dominance globally.

Third, NLG globally may be waning in favor of models veering toward state capitalism that offer some protections for employed women traversing rapid socioeconomic change. In China, migrant women from rural villages may be its biggest beneficiaries. They encounter discrimination at every step in their rural to urban path, as menial laborers, as migrants, and as women. Without assurances by the state, however minimal they might be, migrant women find themselves in temporary jobs and subject to the abuses in an "emergent capitalist system of class inequality" (Gaetano 2015). China's pragmatic state capitalism not only recognizes the necessity of women's labor in ongoing economic reform but, coupled with NGO advocacy, is aware that any policies put in place related to women will have political repercussions. Unlike the U.S. in the Trump era, China acknowledges that global regard, "soft power," is associated with political and economic advantages.

Fourth, related to the development-globalization enigma, the gendered consequences of market reform in China without the development entanglement can be ferreted out. Before opening up, China was like a world before television. Even when China was partnering with the Soviet bloc on policies related to politics, it was also a world essentially devoid of external development programs. Since globalization is clearly a central component in explaining the well-known

pitfalls of development schemes that undermine women, research on the periods before and after opening up can offer guidelines to a variety of stakeholders for mitigating these pitfalls.

Finally, in considering the "alternative globalizations" for women scenario, NLG and state capitalism, of course, should not be dichotomized, nor should state capitalism be idealized as the model that serves as a panacea to alleviate the serious economic liabilities facing women in China. It is likely, however, that a continuum of global economic policies identified with one or the other general path will emerge. State capitalism(s) as played out in China may offer the sensible balance of private and public economic initiatives Asian nations are seeking, regardless of their governmental structure.

Whether women will be helped or hurt in the long run may depend on China's ability to resist those demands of NLG that are deleterious to women and to commit more resources to bolster all economically vulnerable segments of its population. If state subsidies bolstering women continue to decline at too rapid a pace and outstrips the market's ability to spur economic growth in a timely manner, two important questions remain: How long is too long? Will the policy be too little and too late? Answers to these questions will determine the fate of socioeconomic well-being for women in China in their quest for gender equity.

NOTES

- 1 Chapter is revised and adapted with permission from "Sharp Right Turn: Globalization and Gender Equity." *The Sociological Quarterly*. January, 2013 55(1):1–22.
- 2 The online version of WDR provides no page numbers so only chapters are referenced. These are organized well, and easy to navigate so quotes and material discussed should not be difficult to find.
- 3 Note that these are "backhanded" benefits. The assumption is that without the formal agreements or a reasonable profit, gender discrimination would be acceptable.

- 4 WDR2012 references commissioned background reports. Investigating these sources is important to help determine World Bank criteria for who is selected to do the reports as well as their affiliations. Other World Bank documents are not available to the public.

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Chapter five

China's "State Feminism" in Context

The All-China Women's Federation from Inception to Current Challenges

Yingtao Li and Di Wang

INTRODUCTION

Attempts at women's liberation were a significant and integral part of the May Fourth Movement, which ushered China into its modern history in 1919. Since the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1949, certain core features of China's cultural and historical legacy, as well as the institutional and organizational structures put in place by the new government, formed the bases of Chinese women's ongoing struggle for recognition and equality. The complex social and institutional history of China's "state feminism" still figures prominently in twenty-first century China, especially with regard to how contemporary Chinese society perceives and conceptualizes the relationship between women and men and between women's liberation and nationalist revolution. The All-China Women's Federation (ACWF) was established by the Communist Party of China (CPC) as the foremost organization representing Chinese women. Its founding is considered a landmark achievement in the process of women's liberation. Through analyzing the trajectory of Chinese women's liberation as embraced by the state, particularly with emphasis on the ACWF, this chapter advocates first, for a stronger connection between Marxist inspired state feminism and

gender theories that came out of the Western academic tradition, and second, a better and more cooperative relationship between the ACWF and grassroots women's organizations in China.

Precursors to Chinese Women's Liberation

China's awakening to feminist consciousness and the start of Chinese women's liberation is often traced to the end of the nineteenth century, a period when China was in the throes of internal conflicts, exacerbated by both its defeat in the Sino-Japanese War in 1895, and the invasion by Western powers (Wang 1999). Sparked by Chinese disarray, the Reform Movement of 1898 (the Hundred Days' Reform) lent momentum to the fledgling Chinese women's movement (Xiao 2009). Although the movement was short-lived, reforms benefited women by energizing women's inclusion in institutions such as education and politics, and by deemphasizing canonical Confucianist texts and practices. Scholarly consensus is that the turn of the twentieth century witnessed the rise of the "new women" as a critical conceptual model to adapt tradition according to cultural demands of modernity, as much as to

imagine far-reaching nationalist reforms. As will be documented, the feminist cause succeeded for as long as the spirit of reform lasted. However, the women's movement in China was periodically stalled by unforeseen developments in national politics, as well as by historical elements and cultural practices that are antithetical to progressive change.

PRE-MODERN SOCIO-POLITICAL CONTEXTS SHAPING CHINESE WOMEN'S LIBERATION

Two distinct socio-political contexts initially shaped and challenged Chinese women's liberation. Internally, the challenge for early activists was to navigate culturally specific gender relations; internationally, China was forced by a patriarchal international order to reckon with its "feminized" status in the global community.

Cultural Features of Pre-Modern Chinese Gender Relations

To deal with the conundrum of the "dualistic" power structure in its philosophical thought, Western scholars often look East for inspiration. Western political tradition is often viewed as dominated by dualistic discourse: man vs. woman, public vs. private, masculinity vs. femininity (Elshtain 1981). Some Western scholars are enchanted by principles of *yin-yang* dialectics that prevailed in traditional Chinese philosophy, especially in Daoist classics. Such dialectics are expounded, for example, in L.H.M. Ling's *The Dao of World Politics*: "Daoist dialectics give us gender as an analytic" (Ling 2014: 15). *Yin* and *yang* are analytical categories. *Yin* signifies feminine qualities such as cold, soft, and weak, while *yang* signifies masculine qualities

such as hot, hard, and strong. What differentiates *yin-yang* dialectics from Western dualism is its porous boundary. The analytical categories do not stay opposed; the polarity recognizes that each end exists within the other, *yin-within-yang* and *yang-within-yin*. Complementarities prevail despite the contradictions between, and within, the polarities, underscoring co-creativity, co-responsibility, and co-power of *yin* and *yang* (Ling 2014: 53).

Although gender as an analytic category emphasizes male and female in terms of equal partnership models, the question remains whether there is historical evidence that the dialectics of *yin-yang* can transform political and social relations of women and men. The struggle to put in practice the subtle nuances detailed in *yin-yang* dialectics is as ancient as it is modern. According to Du¹ (1995, 1998, 2011, 2013), gender hierarchy and binary oppositions in pre-modern Chinese are just as pronounced as they are in pre-modern Western cultures, if not more severe. In practice, *yin* and *yang* are associated with fixed attributes, and the nuances of fluidity give way to priorities in the social and political order. Gender relations in modern and contemporary China are deeply rooted in a pervasive pre-modern Confucian-based cultural paradigm.

The *Analects*, the canonical text of Confucianism, defined and dominated mainstream ideology of pre-modern Chinese society since the Han Dynasty (206 BC–220 BCE). With regard to women, one of its most quoted passages is:

... of all people, girls and servants are the most difficult to behave to. If you are familiar with them, they lose their humility. If you maintain a reserve toward them, they are discontented.

(Confucius [trans. Legge] 2016: 251)

There are competing interpretations of this axiom. Some scholars point out the text alone is insufficient to explain the dire circumstances for women during late imperial China. It is the

imperial structure and apparatus that helped to create the trappings of a patriarchal society (Rosemont 2013: 15). However, this axiom is often quoted as one of the canonical roots of gender discrimination in China.

Another prevalent cultural phenomenon with regard to women has its root in ancient Chinese mythology. The oft-quoted Christian biblical creation story where Eve is born second after Adam, created from his rib, seems to insinuate a secondary status for women. In ancient Chinese folklore, however, the story has a female creator. The goddess Nüwa creates man and woman side by side, from the same substances, clay and water. Although the matriarchal myth of Nüwa was quickly replaced by the patriarchal clan in practice, the legend lived on as part of the “Mother Culture” element of Chinese philosophy, teaching people to respect their mothers. Filial piety is partially inspired by this element. The *Analects* canonizes filial piety in a highly pragmatic passage: “while his parents are alive, the son may not go abroad to a distance. If he does go abroad, he must have a fixed place to which he goes” (Confucius [trans. Legge] 2016: 45). It is important to note, however, that respecting mother is not the same as respecting women, let alone women’s rights.

Pre-modern Chinese social thought defines an individual largely based on a network of relationships. Individuals are understood by their relationship to members of their family and by their role in society. Thus a woman’s status derives from motherhood, dependent on her ability to reproduce. Women’s reproductive value correlates highly with the right of primogeniture. This set of social practices distinguishes “sterile” women, from women who are able to bear sons. At the same time, however, a mother of sons, especially of the eldest son, is often elevated to manager of the household, in turn, she has tremendous power over daughters-in-law. If they are lucky enough to have sons, the cycle repeats when, after years of service to the household and to childbearing, daughters-in-law

become the next generation of mothers-in-law. Such “mother power” is complicit in perpetuating the patriarchal system. It largely confined women to the domestic sphere and effectively restrained feminist consciousness from full awakening.

In traditional Chinese society, the family and the state are parallel constructs. They are both organized around a patriarch: the emperor and the father/husband. Since the family is considered a microcosm of the state, the patriarch of a family runs the household under the same goals and methods used by emperors in governing the state. The *Three Cardinal Guides*, devised to uphold the family-state structure of pre-modern Chinese society, puts women at the bottom of the ranks: ruler guides subject; father guides son; husband guides wife. In the comprehensive imperial hierarchy, women obey the rules from a subservient position, in turn making them more vulnerable than men (Du 1998: 52).

Prevailing evidence from women’s history of pre-modern China suggests that the *yin-yang* relation and Western dualism are more similar than different in practice. The dichotomy of man/woman and masculinity/femininity also existed in the center of Chinese culture and society (Li 2003a: 38). In the pre-modern Chinese state and household, the balance and complementarities of *yin-yang* were established essentially for upgrading the *yang* and men, while downgrading the *yin* and women. From this perspective, idealizing *yin-yang* dialectics as a potential to cure gender discrimination is neither to pit Chinese thought against Western thought, nor to treat China as an anomaly in world historical processes. An assessment of discrimination against women in China is suggested in the following rather pithy statement:

The discriminatory consciousness against women is gained by perception, not by faith; it is historical, not essential. There [have] not been women’s rights in Chinese history that [are] grounded in society and the public sphere, but there is the Mother

Power in the private sphere. There is a consistent history of looking down upon women, but no notable upsurge of resentment towards women and xenophobia. Therefore, women's response to the male centered society has always been relatively moderate.

(Li 1988: 175)

In its effort to capture continuity, however, the statement overlooks a key fact. Efforts to regulate as well as to mobilize women, concurred historically with dynastic changes and episodic upsurges of nationalism. The alliance forged by educated women and men as a united national front against Western powers at the turn of the twentieth century, is a revealing example.

Effeminate China in a Patriarchal International Society

Chinese women's liberation arose in a particular moment when Western imperial powers and Japan were looming large, and the Chinese state, administered by the Qing, China's last imperial dynasty, was ridiculed as the "sick man of Asia." When Western gunboats forced the Qing government to open China's long standing isolationist policies, the effeminate image of China was subject to wild humiliation by a highly patriarchal and hierarchical international community. The Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895) ended with the Treaty of Shimonoseki, in which the Qing government recognized the independence of Korea, ceded the Liaodong Peninsula, Taiwan, and Penghu Islands to Japan, and agreed to pay Japan 200 million taels of silver as war reparations. The terms of the treaty increased Russia's concern about Japan's influence that might infringe on its own sphere of influence in China's northern borderlands. Through the "Triple Intervention" from the alliance of Russia, Germany, and France, Japan agreed to return the Liaodong Peninsula

to the Qing government in exchange for another 30 million taels of silver (Yuan 2001: 67–68). These events drove China into semi-colonial status, deepening its national crisis.

To save China from sliding further into devastating circumstances—being poor, being weak, and being defenseless—the Reform Movement of 1898 (100 Days' Reform) was launched. The first Chinese-run girl's school was opened in Shanghai during this period.

In the heady years of 1895–1898, the critical energies of many concerned and educated men—now joined by an intrepid few educated women, often family members—centered on reforming the dynastic structures of rule so as to allow for a fuller flexibility in political, social, cultural, commercial, and military organization and development.

(Liu 2013: 29)

Learning from Japan's successes and Qing's failures, reformers advocated women's rights, especially targeting women's education. Because women would be the mothers of future citizens of the Republic, education was espoused in ways reminiscent of Mother Culture. In the influential essay "On Women's Education," written in 1897 as a response to China's defeat in the Sino-Japanese War, Liang ([1897] 2013) argued that the root cause of a frail nation state lies in women's lack of education. Using the United States and Japan as counterexamples, he notes:

... of all the nations of the West, America is by far the most prosperous. Of all the ascendant nations in the East, Japan is the strongest. The idea of equality between men and women was first advocated in America and was gradually practiced in Japan.

(Liang [1897] 2013: 201)

The Qing government was overthrown in 1911 and the Republic of China was established, ushering in a strong nationalist agenda, that also embraced the discourse of women's rights.

CHINESE WOMEN'S MOVEMENT: 1911–1949

From the very beginning of the Chinese women's movement, feminism and nationalism developed side by side. It was strongly influenced by Western and Japanese feminist thought, often with the support of male reformers. Two features of the movement stood out during this period of development: first, the Chinese women's movement as part of the "national salvation," and second, efforts by the Communist Party of China to incorporate the women's movement in its overall revolutionary agenda.

The Women's Movement as Part of the National Salvation

At its foundation, the Chinese women's movement was always intertwined with the fate, and indeed redemption, of the Chinese nation. Encompassed in the rhetoric of "national salvation," reformers and revolutionaries, male and female, hoped to return China to one of the strongest and most competitive nations, especially likened to the Western countries and Japan. Promoting women's rights was one of their strategies. Jin Tianhe, a male scholar and essayist, wrote the first feminist manifesto in China in 1903, the *Women's Bell*, closely echoing the idea of "Republican Motherhood," an idea emerging out of the American Revolution when America was searching for its own national destiny. He states that "a nation must have a base on which to establish itself between heaven and earth; this base is called the people of the nation. And women are the mothers of the nation's people" (Jin [1903] 2013: 284). Quoting the ancient Greek scholar Plutarch, Jin also admires the cry of Spartan mothers who rejoice in the heroic sacrifice of their sons: "I hope that you come back carrying your shield, or that you come back carried on a shield" (Jin [1903] 2013: 211).

Influential female revolutionary Qiu Jin also advocated for women's education and women's rights, but in a much more pragmatic approach, as to how to mobilize women for national salvation. As the following saying often attributed to Qiu Jin attests: "if women's education does not prosper, the nation will stay weak; if women's rights do not thrive, the state will stay powerless" (Zhang and Huang 1996: 509). Unlike Qiu Jin, who was made into a communist heroine in the following decades, the legacy of other radical feminists could not be easily contained in a conservative canon. For example, He Zhen identified herself as a feminist as well as an anarchist. As historian Peter Zarrow suggests, she called for the forcible end to male oppression of women, as well as resistance to capitalists and the ruling class, simultaneously endorsing traditional values such as perseverance and respect for the larger community (Zarrow 1988). He Zhen belongs to the brand of "anarcho-feminism:" "He Zhen never sacrificed her belief in the equality of women for any political consideration; at the same time women's liberation was but one aspect of the anarchist revolution" (Zarrow 1990: 130). Even Qiu Jin's radical elements had to be tamed and tailored in the process of her canonization. Her voluptuous figure and flamboyant image, for example, were incorporated into a textbook heroine, but given a chiseled jawline.

The New Culture Movement: 1910s–1920s

In the early twentieth century, large cities in China experienced a wave of what was referred to as the "New Culture Movement." Likened to a kind of Chinese enlightenment, the movement called for the end of the patriarchal family, and among other revolutionary agendas, promoted individual freedom and women's emancipation. The New Culture Movement initiated heated debates on women's emancipation, moral revolution, individual autonomy, and household

upheaval. The movement's two buzzwords were "democracy" and "science." The women's movement in this period was akin to Western-style feminism (Shih 2005: 7). New Culture feminism circulated widely during the May Fourth era, provoking rapid and sweeping social changes in early twentieth-century China.

[T]he rapid development of feminism in China and its achievement in the first few decades of the twentieth century were remarkable . . . After May Fourth, the women's movement became a badge of modernity that both the Communist Party and Nationalist Party claimed to wear. The two parties' institutionalization of the women's movement dampened the prospects for an independent women's movement in China. In spite of this, their appropriation of the New Culture feminist agenda had positive effects for women. When either party controlled state power, it incorporated women's equal legal rights into its legislation.

(Wang 1999: 358–359)

During the span of the New Culture Movement, China won in the battlefields of the First World War as a member of the Allies, but lost at the diplomatic table during the Paris Peace Conference. The Treaty of Versailles (1919) transferred German concessions in Shandong to Japan, instead of back to China. The Chinese delegation refused to sign the Treaty of Versailles, regarded as a principle reason for precipitating the May Fourth Movement in 1919. Students and allies—citizens from all walks of life—took to the streets to protest imperialism and what was perceived as an extremely incompetent government. There was a "dual variation of enlightenment and nationalism" in modern China (Li 1999, 2003b). In the course of the May Fourth Movement, nationalism gradually overwhelmed enlightenment, as China was forced to assume a defensive posture against encroaching imperial Japan. With the outbreak of war against Japanese aggression in the 1930s, the women's movement was even more closely aligned with national salvation.

Characterizing the early development of Chinese feminism during this period, Liu (2013: 54) suggests: "the early enlightenment of feminism was not to return women's rights to them unconditionally. It did not have the intention to liberate women from the traditional bondage, but to readjust women's position in the nation-state."

Liu's opinion is not an anomaly. Party historian Song (2015a: 48) also points out that Chinese feminist thought was infused with nationalism from the moment of its birth. Shouldering the burden of the nation-state, feminists pursued self-improvement in order to prove their worth in the eyes of men. They gained men's sympathy and support, but lost sight of patriarchal oppression in the process. After the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) women's emancipation was often secondary, overcome by priorities regarded as more urgent tasks of national development and centralized policies. Often fraught with conflict, the women's movement, therefore, had an uneasy relationship with the idea of national salvation.

The Women's Movement in the Chinese Communist Revolution

Marxism spread like wildfire in China after the October Revolution of 1917. Russia set an example as an alternative for China's future, especially among urban educated young men and women. Early revolutionary activism and protest were consolidated with the establishment of the Communist Party of China (CPC) in 1921. This consolidation in the organized body of the CPC included radical thoughts of the May Fourth Movement (e.g. anarchism and communism), Marxism by way of the Russian Revolution, and grassroots movements for social justice. These systematic and sustained efforts to integrate the women's movement both in the overall revolutionary agenda and government structure, yielded notable successes, but amid ongoing tension and conflict.

On one hand, the CPC was determined to build a gender-based department within its umbrella organization to channel its focus on what is known as “women-work.” Since its birth, CPC goals included the achievement of women’s emancipation and equality between men and women (SCIO 1994). In 1922, at the Second National Congress of the Communist Party of China (NCCPC), the first *Resolution on Women’s Movement* was passed, declaring that:

... women’s emancipation cannot be achieved under the capitalist mode of production ... Ever since international capitalism has infiltrated China, proletariat women have been gradually reduced to wage slaves ... (and) all China’s women are still shackled by feudalist doctrines and rites and live the life of prostitutes ... Women’s emancipation is accompanied by the emancipation of labor; only when the proletariat takes control of the government, women will truly be emancipated.

(NCCPC 1922)

Not only did the Resolution establish the CPC’s mainstream position on women, it also promised to form a special women’s committee to promulgate its work to the female population, to build a women’s department, and to designate a column for women in the Party newspaper.

When the young revolutionary Mao ([1927] 1965: 44) reported from Hunan province on the peasant movement in South China, he highlighted the dire circumstances facing peasant women. Mao thought that a man in China is usually subjected to the domination of three systems of authority—political, clan, and religious—but women are subjected to an additional layer.

... they are also dominated by the men (the authority of the husband) ... These four authorities—political, clan, religious and masculine—are the embodiment of the whole feudal-patriarchal system and ideology, and are the four thick ropes binding the Chinese people, particularly the peasants.

(Mao [1927] 1965: 44)

Mao observed a new wave of women’s activism that emerged out of the anti-feudalist peasant movement, one that developed organically, and perhaps independently, from the urban women’s movement. He also observed that:

... with the rise of the peasant movement, the women in many places have now begun to organize rural women’s associations; the opportunity has come for them to lift up their heads, and the authority of the husband is getting shakier every day. In a word, the whole feudal-patriarchal system and ideology is tottering with the growth of the peasants’ power.

(Mao [1927] 1965: 44)

However, the revolutionary zeal for the women’s movement could not easily translate into a well-articulated strategy to fully integrate women on all levels. Even during the initial phase of the International Communist Revolution, women held an ambiguous status compared to top level decision makers (Wang 2005a). Both Engels and Lenin endorsed gender-based labor distribution in their attack on ruthless capitalism, driving women away from less physically demanding home and office jobs. Integration of women was not the priority of the early Communists. It was the news about the heroic peasant women of the Paris Commune of 1871 that convinced Marx to incorporate women in the leadership of his proletariat organization. Until then, most male Communist leaders were reluctant to address women’s rights (Wang 2005a: 232). In fact, the Second NCCPC’s Resolution did not fully adopt advice on women-work ordered by the Third World Congress of the Comintern held in Moscow in 1921. The CPC ignored several highly specific directives such as: to fight for women’s equal rights and responsibility in the Party, the union, and other proletariat organizations; to educate both women and men about gender discrimination; to organize community centers, child day care, and kindergartens; and to initiate basic education for women workers. It also

did not encourage women to step out from the domestic sphere to participate in socialized labor, nor did it attempt to mobilize women to vote in the Soviet elections (Wang 2005a: 240). Women-work, yet again, gave way to more pressing and urgent tasks of national salvation and class struggle.

Internal critics of the CPC, such as Ding Ling, a woman communist and highly accomplished writer, did not refrain from speaking out. In her essay “Reflections on March 8th,” she questioned the Party’s alleged commitment to change popular attitudes toward women, and satirized men’s double standards concerning women that prevailed in Communist controlled districts. She also criticized male cadres’ abuse of divorce provisions to rid themselves of unwanted wives (Ding 1942).

The essay spoke directly to the question of the women category in theory and praxis and vigorously contested the idea that women best served the Party when contributed their domestic and sexual labor to it.

(Barlow 2004: 193)

Feminists were also highly critical of the Party’s portrayal of women’s emancipation in its popular propaganda (Liu 1996). The opera-ballet, “The White Haired Girl,” widely performed across many phases of the Chinese Communist Revolution, depicts the emancipation of Xi’er, the peasant girl heroine, through a just and charming male savior. She suffers feudal oppression under her ruthless master, then escapes into the mountains until rescued by her fiancée, who triumphantly returns after defeating Japanese invaders. Women’s liberation, national liberation, and class liberation were achieved simultaneously and single-handedly by a savior-hero (Liu 1996). Certainly, we have recourse to trappings of male chauvinism. It was easy, therefore, to trivialize women’s emancipation, compared to the overwhelming tasks of total class struggle.

Integration of the Women’s Movement into National Policies

From the founding of the socialist International Working Men’s Association in 1864, later known as the First International, to the Sixth NCCPC in 1928, women’s visibility in the Communist Revolution was being constantly negotiated. During the early twentieth century, the CPC grew increasingly self-reflective on its neglect of women, and “passive” attitudes of its members in dealing with women-work. Women-work was always framed with “pre-emptive” self-inflicted criticism in Party discourse: first, do not treat women-work with passivism, that is believing in the secondary nature of women-work, thereby neglecting or even canceling it in the overall Party agenda; second, do not single-mindedly promote feminism, thereby causing the women’s movement to lose sight of the Communist Revolution’s total work (Wang 2005a: 242). The pre-emptive apology is both suspicious of self-indulgence, as well as indicative of latent conflicts between the Party’s central task and women-work. In the following decades, even after the founding of the PRC in 1949, this tension put continuous strain on the long-term goals of the women’s movement. However, initial efforts to carve out space for women-work in CPC discourse and organization deserves due credit.

CHINESE WOMEN’S MOVEMENT: 1949–1995

The outbreak of the Cultural Revolution in 1966 fatally disrupted China’s transition into a fully integrated member of global community. The most salient feature of the Chinese women’s movement during this turbulent, disruptive period and after the demise of the Cultural Revolution in 1976, however, is the continuity of what we now refer to as “state feminism,” as carried out by the All-China Women’s Federation (ACWF).

State Feminism and the Birth of the All-China Women's Federation

Chinese style “state feminism” is often associated with pejorative views, imbued with negative connotations in academic discourse outside of China. It is sometimes understood as the manipulative strategy of the party-state to tame and silence discontent. However, it is part of the reality of the contemporary Chinese women's movement. After the founding of the PRC, “equality between men and women” became part of mainstream ideology and translated into legal principles. The PRC promulgated a series of policies to promote women's equality, helping women gain legal rights enjoyed by men. Although the CPC eschewed “bourgeois feminism” as part of the anti-capitalist campaign, “it was nonetheless a radical political organization shaped by May Fourth feminism and attracted many feminists” (Wang 1999: 359–360). The CPC built legitimacy by embracing women's emancipation as one of its goals. Once the party gained political control of the nation, it delivered its promise to women by implementing institutional changes originally espoused by May Fourth feminists.

In September 1949, during the first plenary session of China's “People's Political Consultative Conference,” Article Six of the program was adopted: “the PRC shall abolish the feudal system which holds women in bondage. Women shall enjoy equal rights with men in political, economic, cultural, educational, and social life. Freedom of marriage for men and women shall be put into effect” (CPPCC 1949). The New Marriage Law, passed in 1950, gave women equal power in marriage. Women's equal rights in all spheres of political, economic, cultural, social and domestic life was finally written into the Constitution of the People's Republic of China, and adopted in September 1954 (National People's Congress 1954).

Between the founding of the PRC and the disruption of the Cultural Revolution, discourses of

national independence, democracy, and peace were sold as one package. Efforts to stabilize China and to (re)construct an independent nation-state from the pillages of war took top priority. With a centralized organization, a rapidly expanding national infrastructure helped consolidate women-work into state feminism. The foremost organization that also wields the biggest influence on women-work in China is the All-China Women's Federation (ACWF).

Founded in April 1949, the ACWF played a vital role in mobilizing women in the (re) construction efforts of the PRC. The mission of the ACWF is to represent and uphold women's rights and interests, and to promote equality between women and men (ACWF 2013). It serves as the government's outreach, providing information about its work to the population in general, but to women in particular.

The ACWF is distinctively a product of the PRC in its organization and operation. Some describe the ACWF as “one of China's government-funded and Communist Party-supported ‘mass organizations’” (Wesoky 2002: 1). An even more cynical view would define it as no more than “an organ of the party-state that takes on the project of making Chinese women into statist subjects” (Wang 2005b: 520). A more favorable view acknowledges its dedication to the principles of women's emancipation.

The All-China Women's Federation has, since its establishment in 1949, promoted an agenda of emancipation that was based on, but not limited to, the Marxist interpretation of marriage relations and employment rights. Despite political radicalization in the Maoist era, the Women's Federation exhibited a high degree of commitment to its founding principles.

(Tsimonis 2016)

Others describe it as a government agency, as the official leadership of the Chinese women's movement, as the guardian of children's welfare, and as the representative of Chinese women to the

international community (Tsui 1998). Until the reform and opening-up of the 1980s, the ACWF was likely the only women's organization in China that brought about dramatic changes in all areas of life, but particularly in terms of gender relations.

ACWF Identity Struggles

The PRC bid to host the United Nations Fourth World Conference on Women (FWCW) and the parallel Non-Governmental Organization (NGO) Forum in 1995, was also used as an opportunity to improve China's international image in an era marked by rising tensions between China and the West. The decision to host the FWCW was mainly out of political expedience (Wang 1996). The official conference convened in Beijing, with neighboring Huairou the site of the NGO Forum. Bringing together 50,000 women at both locations, FWCW was a watershed event, the largest gathering in history spotlighting issues centering on gender equality. It had immediate positive effects on Chinese women, especially in reshaping the terms and discourse of gender and women-work. Not only did the conference introduce the concept of "NGO" to many Chinese, it pushed the ACWF to act more autonomously and remake its role at the dawn of the new millennium. In preparation for the official FWCW and NGO Forum, ACWF applied for "Consultative Status" to the UN Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) as an NGO. It was granted NGO status in 1995. However, ACWF's transition to its new NGO identity has been far from smooth.

An NGO is usually identified as a non-profit, voluntary citizen's group which is organized on a local, national, or international level. Implications of this definition constantly throw ACWF's identity as an NGO into question. How can an organization, as viewed by both people in China and abroad, as "official," or "semi-official," "a state organ," or at best, "a mediator between the

state and its people" suddenly become an NGO? Its close relationship with the Chinese government and the CPC is indisputable, which renders its credibility as an NGO dubious, subjecting it to mockery or even public shame. Political scientist Sharon Wesoky notes a scene during the Asia-Pacific Regional Preparatory Meeting for the NGO Forum held in Manila in November 1993. Two Chinese delegations attended the meeting, one a Fulian (ACWF delegation), and the other a group of Chinese women sponsored by the Ford Foundation.

At the meeting, other delegations objected when the Fulian representative—a man—took the floor, saying that they did not want to listen to an 'official' delegation, because Fulian "to a very large extent was representing the official viewpoint." These objections led to Fulian vigorously terming itself an "NGO" following the Manila meeting.

(Wesoky 2002: 178)

After Huang Qizao, the vice president of the ACWF at the time, actively identified her organization as an NGO, the Forum was in an uproar. As a consequence, the Chinese government formally designated the ACWF as "China's largest NGO, whose aims are raising the status of women." The ACWF has ever since assumed the label of an NGO during international appearances, although not in domestic matters (Min 2017).

There is a history of the ACWF yet to be written that captures its own struggle to maintain some degree of autonomy from the central government and the CPC. Founded with the endorsement of top CPC leaders, the ACWF was designed as an umbrella of existing women's organizations throughout China. To allow ACWF to be seen as an independent organization, nonetheless coopted and willing to collaborate, requires a rejection of a view of the party-state as "a coherent, seamless, and monolithic body." It also requires paying close attention to moments of fractures, "details of fissures, gaps, disputes, contestations, and conflicting goals and interests

in the internal workings of the state apparatus” (Wang 2005b: 522).

Meticulous archival work on the history of the ACWF relocates those women and men who used political maneuvers to preserve the organization when it was threatened to close down. The ACWF’s struggle to survive the Anti-Rightist Campaign of 1957 is a revealing case. When Mao Zedong circulated his May 15th 1957 article, “Things are Beginning to Change,” a sweeping political purge was on the horizon. Mao took offense at his political opponents, labeling them as “bourgeois rightists.” Steeped in a political witch-hunt, the Mao administration turned toward its internal enemies. “Now merely talking about problems in socialist China could qualify one as a rightist.” As for ACWF officials, to avoid political suicide meant to keep silent on potentially explosive subjects, such as women’s oppression in the PRC. They were forced to accept the compromising position that “Chinese women have already been liberated.” However, shrewd ACWF officials and party leaders, like Deng Xiaoping, were determined to save the ACWF by temporarily suspending gender equality as the primary goal for the organization, and instead emphasized women’s role in Mao’s new campaign for the planned economy.” It was no other than Deng Xiaoping who helped to design and promote a new principle for women-work: “diligently and thriftily running the family.” This move not only saved the ACWF from sliding into obscurity and irrelevance, it helped to elevate its work to become one of the two most urgent central tasks, the other being “diligently and thriftily building the country.” Deng’s jumping to the rescue was not an accident; he was courted by early ACWF officials for support (Wang 2006).

The combination of close proximity to power and relative autonomy worked to the advantage of women. The nature of the ACWF as a women’s mass organization, its history of carrying out women-work under the leadership of the Party, and its close relationship with both the Party and the government, have earned it the trust and

support from both the Party and the government—even after its identity as an NGO was confirmed (Liu 2001: 147). The ambiguous status of the ACWF also presents tremendous challenges: how to carry out independent, autonomous, and effective work to satisfy the needs of the majority of women confronted by a transitioning economy; how to reconcile those women who hold deep mistrust and suspicion toward top-down policies channeled through the ACWF including: how to maneuver the family planning policy; how to best utilize its influence within the given political structure to pressure and collaborate with the government to further integrate gender equality in its policies and legislations; and how to remake its identity in the new millennium when tasked with new ideas and possibilities.

ACWF IN THE NEW MILLENNIUM

Gender equality is understood as China’s mainstream ideology and as translated to legal principles. However, the gap between “legal” gender equality and how it plays out in the daily lives of women, looms large in China (see Lindsey, Chapter 4). Chinese women take notice of such a gap. Major events such as the FWCW, massive social change prompted by the introduction of a market economy, and ongoing political reform, have stirred the Chinese women’s movement into multiple directions.

Introducing “Gender” to China

By the early 1990s, the so-called “women’s problem” caught the attention of Chinese academics, and Chinese women scholars began to engage in women’s studies. In 1992 some were invited to Harvard University for a conference titled “Engendering China: Women, Culture, and the State,” allowing them become familiar with the concept of gender (Gilmartin et al. 1994). The analytic

category of gender officially arrived in Chinese academia at the “Symposium of Chinese Women and Development,” convened at Tianjin Normal University in 1993 (Du 2011: 98). China-based historian Du Fangqin and U.S.-based historian Wang Zheng, were instrumental in introducing gender analysis to their Chinese academic colleagues and to a general audience.

As noted above, hosting the FWCW in Beijing brought great changes to the Chinese women's movement. Gender was one of the key concepts at the conference, used more than 200 times in the *Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action*, the global agenda for women's empowerment, produced at the conclusion of the FWCW (UN Women n.d.). Employing gender as an analytic category opened many hidden issues concerning women and the women's movement. “Gender” is now widely adopted and used in official documents and academic papers. “While we advocate ... the essential state policy of equality between women and men, we should advocate for the *Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action*” (Huang 1996: 10). As a supplement to Marxist-inspired state feminist tenets, gender analysis reinforced the development of women's studies and gender studies in Chinese academia. Its usage extended to disciplines of philosophy, politics, economics, sociology, history, literature, anthropology and international relations.

New Challenges Confronting Chinese Women on Gender Equality

Notable progress is evident in the women's movement in China since reform and opening-up of the 1980s. The many accomplishments of the women's movement in China over the last two decades are documented in a variety of sources. Two of the most important are: *Gender Equality and Women's Development in China* (SCIO 2005, 2015) and *Report of the People's Republic of China on the Implementation of the Beijing*

Declaration and Platform for Action, 1995 (PRC 2015). Among the latest achievements is the passage of China's first domestic violence law in 2015.

Other sources of data on women's progress in China demonstrate mixed results. Two of the globe's most important sources for accurate and credible data to assess gender progress are the UN Development Programme's *Human Development Report* (HDR) and the World Economic Forum's (WEF) *Global Gender Gap Report*. HDR offers rankings from the Human Development Index (HDI), Gender Development Index (GDI), and Gender Inequality Index (GII). GDI takes composite data from the larger HDR and dis-aggregates it according to sex (gender), providing male-female ratios on key gender indicators, including life expectancy at birth, expected and mean years of schooling, and estimated gross national income per capita by gender. In 2016, China is ranked 90 out of 188 countries on the HDI, slipping down two slots, from 88 out of 188 countries in 2014. Although China generally shows a steady upward trend in human development ranking since 1990, gender measures as revealed in GDI and GII are likely culprits in lower overall HDI rank. In life expectancy, GDI favors females (77.5) over males (74.5), a global trend, but males favor females in mean years of schooling 7.9 to 7.2 years, and perhaps most important, the gender wage gap is approximately 67 percent (UNDP 2014, 2015, 2016a, 2016b).

GII incorporates additional measures, revealing a wide gender gap in China on labor force participation (63.6 percent female to 77.9 percent male); at least some secondary schooling (69.8 percent female to 79.4 percent male); and share of seats in parliament at a dismal 23.6 percent held by women. Even compared to other indicators, it seems that Chinese women's political representation has met a glass ceiling. Between 2010 and 2016 China's GII rank oscillated between 35 and 40, now hovering at 37 out of 188 countries (UNDP 2010, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2016a, 2016b, 2016c).

The *Global Gender Gap Report* ranks China even lower, 100 out of 144 countries, with data that is much more contextual than that used by UNDP, including type of work, proportion of unpaid work per day, advancement of women to leadership roles in companies, and share of political rights at all levels (WEF 2017). Consistent with these gendered economic participation patterns, a detailed report, *Gender Equality in China's Economic Transformation*, found significant gender disparities in employment opportunity; expanding gender disparities in income; and unrecognized value of women's unpaid care work (Liu et al. 2014). As WEF indicates, the integration of women into the talent pool of a country is a must for the country and the well-being of its citizens (WEF 2017). China is falling short in capitalizing on women's talent. Although China's ranking of GDI and GII have been relatively stable, and Chinese women's status has marginally improved by most indicators, it is apparent that women have reached a plateau that has been difficult to overcome. Gender inequality in China still persists.

Indeed, reform and opening-up, and the subsequent market revolution ushered in by transformative globalization, might have harmed important prospects for gender equality (see Chapter 1). China's growing economic diversity and a renewed energy for dissent throw sociopolitical norms of the bygone socialist era into flux. The new climate has produced intense economic expansion on one hand, and suppressed political ambition on the other. Fear and uncertainty about a rapidly changing society propels the administration to assert social control over potential dissent, which unfortunately creates room for a swift comeback of patriarchal values. For example, Chinese women are largely shut out of the biggest accumulation of real estate wealth in human history because of their social and legal status (Fincher 2014). Even Hu Shuli, the editor-in-chief of media giant Caixin Media and purportedly one of the most powerful women in China, is not exempt from widespread gender discrimination: Her political rivals recently

attempted to defame her by alleging an illicit sexual affair (Wang 2015). As indicated in Chapter 1, China may have the strongest policies and laws in place in support of gender equity in all of Asia, but the gender gap at how they play out in the daily lives of women may also be the widest.

Feminist aspiration runs counter to China's drive for integration with global capitalism and consumer culture, where commodification of women is rampant. Without watershed political reform, wealth—the leading virtue of President Xi Jinping's “core socialist value” campaign—remains the most expedient way to empowerment for China's citizens. The slogan, “to get rich is glorious” has literally plastered over “women hold up half the sky” in China (Erbaugh 1990: 9). When financial crisis hits home, it is now popular for women to return to the domestic sphere. As early as 1994, scholars seriously entertained the idea whether women's liberation is “ahead of the times” (Song 2015b; Zheng 1994). The phenomenon is summarized below.

Throughout the 1980s, China's high growth economy created millions of jobs annually, with women as well as men sharing in expanded and diversified employment opportunities. Since the 1980s, however, many women workers in the state sector have found themselves in the category of “surplus labor.” Disproportionate numbers of women were among those laid off or forced to retire prior to the legal retirement age.

(Wang 2003: 165)

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE CHINESE WOMEN'S MOVEMENT GOING FORWARD

The Chinese women's movement is at a critical crossroads, facing challenges of cultural essentialism on one hand, and limited political and economic access on the other. The ACWF's fraught

relationship with the CPC, and its dubious status as an NGO, are realities with which Chinese feminists must reckon. Women activists must navigate a landscape of economic growth without substantial political reform. The growing quandary regarding the fast-shifting future of women drives many to join grassroots organizations, hoping for more expedient and effective solutions. NGOs often apply a rights-based approach combined with strategies of gender training and mainstreaming. While the work of NGOs has recently become more visible to citizens and decision makers alike, the extent to which they can get involved in the actual process of decision-making is uncertain and often depends on informal relations and networks. For decision makers, these include personal views of the NGO, their relationship with women's organizations, and access to various levels of information (Cai 2012).

Moreover, NGOs can easily arouse suspicion that they are anti-government. The tension between the establishment and widespread grassroots organizations, however, can be a constructive opportunity for the ACWF, not necessarily a hurdle. The ACWF and its local branches should proactively adopt new measures to deal with independently run NGOs made up of women in different walks of life. For example, the Shanghai Women's Federation promotes collaboration across "official" and "civil" organizations: "it is a foremost priority for our organization to initiate contact with and to nurture other women's civil organizations, to proactively advance the development of [all] women's social organizations" (Shanghai Women's Federation 2007: 23–25). The ACWF could also help facilitate formal channels of engagement between grassroots actors and government decision makers, holding both groups accountable while also maximizing effective collaboration.

Another way to amplify women's voice is through building synergy across all types and all levels of women's organizations, individual activists, and scholars. New initiatives attempt to capitalize on strengths among different sectors to

support each other's work and to achieve shared visions. For example, the "Gender Equality Policy Advocacy Project" brought together feminist scholars, grassroots NGO activists, and women's federation cadres advocating for change in deep rooted son-preference culture through community mobilization, raising gender awareness, and policy intervention (Cai 2012). We need to bring both bottom-up and top-down forces to the same table, to rally them behind common and concrete causes.

The legacy of denial concerning women's oppression within the socialist premise creates toxic, willful neglect of inequality. It is time to review the Marxist-inspired state feminist tenets and think more deeply of how to utilize new critical tools, such as gender analysis, to elucidate old problems. Historian Heidi Hartmann famously noted that although Marxism provides great insight into laws of history and economy, it falls short in addressing sexism.

As feminist socialists, we must organize a practice which addresses both the struggle against patriarchy and the struggle against capitalism. We must insist that the society we want to create is a society in which recognition of interdependence is liberation rather than shame, nurturance is a universal, not an oppressive practice, and in which women do not continue to support the false as well as the concrete freedom of men.

(Hartmann 1981: 33)

As proposed by Young (1981), it is time to entertain the idea of a dual system theory that is not to patch up an unhappy marriage of Marxism and radical feminism. The project of socialist feminism should be to develop a single theory out of the best insights of both.

NOTE

- 1 In-text citations of Chinese names are presented in conventional usage in Chinese publications, with the surname followed by given name. The references are listed alphabetically by surname.

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Chapter six

Gender Equality and the Limits of Law in Securing Social Change in Hong Kong

Amy Barrow and Sealing Cheng

INTRODUCTION

This chapter explores the adoption of anti-discrimination laws and equality policies in Hong Kong and their role in securing social change around gender equality. In the period leading up to the handover of British Colonial Hong Kong to the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1997, several laws were adopted, including the Sex Discrimination Ordinance (Cap 480) in 1995, which also provided for the creation of an Equal Opportunities Commission (EOC). This institutional mechanism, together with the Women's Commission, provides the infrastructure to support the regulation and promotion of laws and policies on gender equality. However, stereotypes remain around gender roles and identities, as well as an institutional inertia to address the complexity of gender inequalities at the intersection of class, ethnicity, immigration status, age, and other identity characteristics, which serve to inhibit the full and equal participation of all members of society. Drawing upon qualitative research interviews conducted with multiple stakeholders, including lawmakers, women's organizations, scholars, and members of both the Equal Opportunities Commission and Women's Commission,¹ the chapter considers the advances made toward equality and social change. We situate Hong Kong laws and

policies on gender equality and political and social change in their historical context and identify a number of important advances in women's legal and social status, including anti-discrimination laws and institutional mechanisms to support the advancement of women. Ongoing challenges for securing equality are teased out, including inadequate legal protections, and structural conditions that have proven detrimental to women's empowerment. Some of the key equality strategies adopted by the Women's Commission are evaluated in light of the ongoing challenges for gender equality.

GENDER EQUALITY, POLITICAL, AND SOCIAL CHANGE IN HONG KONG

Hong Kong has experienced significant social change in its relatively short history. Initially a collection of small fishing villages in Southern Guangdong province, the British first colonized Hong Kong Island in 1841, followed by Kowloon districts, before subsequently leasing an area of land referred to as the "New Territories" in 1898 for a period of ninety-nine years. Following the Chinese Civil War in the 1940s, the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1949 led

to a period of regime change in Mainland China, which saw significant social unrest in the 1960s and early 1970s. During the Cultural Revolution swathes of refugees arrived in Hong Kong from the PRC. Additionally, in the 1970s, several refugee camps were set up to accommodate the arrival of “Vietnamese boat people” fleeing the Vietnam War.

Hong Kong emerged as a global financial center in the early 1970s. Negotiations between the then British Colonial Government and the PRC over the impending expiration of the New Territories lease led to the signing of the Joint Sino-British Agreement in 1984. Although Hong Kong became a Special Administrative Region (SAR) of the PRC in 1997, the *Basic Law*, Hong Kong’s quasi-constitutional document, provided for the continuation of Hong Kong’s common law legal system for a period of 50 years through to 2047 (Basic Law 1990 [entered into force 1997]: Art. 5 and Art. 8).

Post-1997, Hong Kong’s population continued to grow with the arrival of new immigrants from the PRC, who entered Hong Kong under a permanent settlement scheme (One Way Permit). Although Hong Kong’s success as a global financial center is undisputed, there is significant inequality within society which has manifested itself in several social problems, such as the increasing numbers of marginalized and vulnerable groups, including refugees, asylum seekers, and new immigrants, as well as a growing wealth gap between rich and poor (Barrow 2015: 277). It is important to consider the development of gender equality in the context of these political and socioeconomic changes in Hong Kong.

Although Hong Kong is often perceived as a homogeneously Chinese society, there are a number of minority ethnic groups, including migrant workers from Indonesia (153,299 persons) and the Philippines (184,801 persons), resident Indians (36,462 persons), Nepalese (25,472 persons) and Pakistani (18,094 persons), as well as a large expatriate community representing a broad

range of nationalities (Hong Kong Government By-Census 2016). Prior to the 1980s, the strong influence of Chinese patriarchy, combined with the colonial administration’s double standards, hindered the development of the women’s movement (Lam and Tong 2006: 9). At the political level, there was limited scope for women to organize since individuals were appointed rather than elected to the Executive Council, Legislative Council, and other advisory bodies (Lam and Tong 2006: 9). Further, the colonial government’s non-interventionist approach in governance did not support the development of “progressive social policies that would benefit women” (Lam and Tong 2006: 10).

Fanny Cheung, a protagonist of the Hong Kong’s women’s movement who initiated the “War-on-Rape” campaign in 1977, pioneered a communal psychology approach that placed emphasis on services for women (Lim 2015: 34). In 1985, Hong Kong’s first Women’s Center opened with a focus on improving community resources to better serve all classes of women, but particularly those at the grassroots level who lacked access to existing community resources (Cheung 1989: 102–103). Cheung, who at that time was Chair of the Women’s Center, distinguished the “conciliatory approach” adopted by feminist movements in Hong Kong and Taiwan, from that of the 1970s radical feminist campaigns seen in Western contexts. In contrast, Hong Kong’s movement was premised upon educating the public and fostering the support of both sexes (Cheung 1989: 105).

Women’s groups in Hong Kong called for the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW), adopted by the United Nations (UN) in 1979, to be extended to the existing British colony as early as 1989, including the adoption of a commission within the government to promote women’s interests (Lim 2015: 39–40). In the early 1990s, the status of women in Hong Kong gained international attention during the Female Inheritance Movement, when indigenous women in

Hong Kong's New Territories sought equal inheritance rights (Merry and Stern 2005: 387). Indigenous persons in Hong Kong are those inhabitants who were residents of established villages in the New Territories at the time the British extended their territory by leasing land from the Qing Dynasty in 1898.

Unusually, the Female Inheritance Movement brought together a cross-section of Hong Kong women, from indigenous villagers to women's organizations, including the Association for the Advancement of Feminism. Christine Loh, a lawmaker who spearheaded the issue at the Legislative Council, submitted an amendment to the New Territories Land (Exemption) Ordinance (Cap 452) in 1994 to include rural land (Merry and Stern 2005: 393). The Female Inheritance Movement faced strong opposition from the Heung Yee Kuk, a body founded in 1926, to represent the interests of indigenous villagers, who argued that the movement would undermine clan identity and lineage (Ng 2016). The public largely supported granting equal inheritance rights to indigenous women villagers. Despite opposition from the Heung Yee Kuk, the British Colonial Government did not object to Loh's proposed amendment and the New Territories Land (Exemption) Ordinance (Cap 452) was passed in 1994 (Merry and Stern 2005: 394).

The Female Inheritance Movement occurred following the 1989 Tiananmen massacre in the PRC, at a point of growing human rights awareness in Hong Kong (Lim 2015: 40). In 1991, the British Colonial Government adopted the Bill of Rights Ordinance (Cap 383), which formally implemented the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) in domestic law and also strengthened "rights" consciousness (Petersen and Samuels 2002: 24). In addition, the Basic Law, the quasi-constitutional framework for Hong Kong SAR, provided that rights contained within the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), and the International Labour Organization

(ILO) Conventions (Basic Law: Art. 39), remain in force in Hong Kong.

In 1991, Hong Kong's electoral system was partially democratized with the introduction of direct legislative council elections for forty out of the seventy seats in the Legislative Council, thus providing a channel for women's participation in politics (Lim 2015: 40). The remaining seats are comprised of those voted in by functional constituencies representing a range of professions and industries. The first female member of the Legislative Council was appointed in 1965, but it was not until 1991 that the first woman, Emily Lau, was directly elected to it. Lau played a key role in initiating debate on the need for a women's commission, by forming an ad hoc group at the Legislative Council to consider the issue (Lim 2015: 41). Women have since made up no more than 20 per cent of the Hong Kong legislature, taking 12 out of 70 seats in the 2016 election (Legislative Council Secretariat 2010; Hong Kong Government Census and Statistics Department 2017a).

LEGAL ADVANCES TO SUPPORT GENDER EQUALITY

In the aftermath of the Female Inheritance Movement there was increased momentum for social change related to women's rights. Although the movement had been focused on land and property inheritance rights of indigenous women villagers in the New Territories, it proved to be a pivotal point for discussing gender equality in Hong Kong more generally, as revealed in an interview with a lawmaker:

... it was the moment that had arrived for a really intensive and lengthy discussion in Hong Kong about gender issues.

In 1993, lawmaker Anna Wu tabled a private member's bill at the Legislative Council. The

broad reaching equality bill was met with opposition from the British Colonial Government, although it acted as a catalyst for the introduction of two government backed bills on sex and disability that would subsequently be adopted as the Sex Discrimination Ordinance (Cap 480) (SDO) in 1995, and the Disability Discrimination Ordinance (Cap 487) in 1995, both taking effect in 1996. The SDO recognized both direct and indirect discrimination on the grounds of sex, sexual harassment, and pregnancy-based discrimination. Section 63 of the SDO also provided for the creation of an Equal Opportunities Commission (EOC), the functions of which include overseeing the compliance of employers with anti-discrimination legislation. The EOC facilitates a system of complaint investigation and conciliation, and in some cases provides limited legal assistance. CEDAW was also extended to Hong Kong in 1996. Subsequent anti-discrimination legislation, such as the Family Status Discrimination Ordinance (Cap 527), was adopted in 1997, followed much later by the Race Discrimination Ordinance (Cap 602) in 2008.

Despite the adoption of the SDO in 1995, the Committee on CEDAW expressed concern that the legislation, while an important means of redress for women experiencing sex discrimination, did not fully address the need for a high-level central mechanism to support the promotion and implementation of CEDAW in local laws and policies (CEDAW Committee 1999: para. 318). The government sought to rely on the existence of the EOC as an institutional mechanism to promote gender equality and women's empowerment. But this claim was rejected by Anna Wu, Chair of the EOC at that time, on the basis that the EOC did not have capacity to fulfill the role of a central, high-level mechanism (Cheung and Chung 2009: 387). Responding to the CEDAW Committee's suggestions, in 2001 the Hong Kong Government formally established the Women's Commission as an advisory body, which is situated under the Labour and Welfare Bureau.

The Chief Executive appoints members to the Women's Commission on an honorary basis and, to date, most members appointed have been prominent, elite women representing a range of professions in Hong Kong. The principle aim of the Women's Commission is to serve the well-being and interests of women in Hong Kong "to fully realize their due status, rights and opportunities in all aspects of life" (Women's Commission 2008). At the UN Fourth World Conference on Women in 1995, paragraph 79 of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action formulated the concept of "gender mainstreaming," calling upon governments to mainstream a gender perspective into all policies and programs (UN Women n.d). In order to provide an enabling environment for women, in 2002 the Women's Commission designed its *Gender Mainstreaming Checklist* as a "simplified analytical tool" for use by government officers to evaluate the impact of policies on men and women at all stages of their design, implementation, and monitoring (Women's Commission 2009). An interviewee with a former member of the Women's Commission suggested that several women's organizations, including the Association for the Advancement of Feminism, have criticized the Checklist, which was revised in 2009.

Alongside creating an enabling environment, the Women's Commission sought to empower women by developing a Capacity Building Mileage Programme, established in 2004. The aim is to encourage women to participate in continuing education programs run in conjunction with the Open University of Hong Kong and Commercial Radio (Metro Broadcast Corporation Limited). Courses are flexible in nature and run through mixed modes of delivery, including radio broadcasts and e-learning. In its first year, 127 women graduated from the program, and in 2016, 760 women graduated (Women's Commission 2016). In the next section, the effectiveness of these strategies is questioned in light of the continuing challenges for gender equality in Hong Kong.

CONTINUING CHALLENGES FOR GENDER EQUALITY IN HONG KONG

Hong Kong has a rights-based legal framework, which provides the infrastructure to support gender equality. The SDO provides redress for incidents of sex discrimination in employment and educational settings, as well as pregnancy-based discrimination. The Family Status Discrimination Ordinance provides legal redress for persons experiencing discrimination on the basis of their family status, applying to those persons who have the primary responsibility for care of an immediate family member.

The EOC also conducts research and facilitates educational activities with the aim of promoting broader equality in Hong Kong. In recent years, research has been conducted on the feasibility of anti-discrimination legislation on the grounds of sexual orientation and gender identity (Suen et al. 2016). The EOC has also partnered with other organizations, including the EU Office to Hong Kong and Macao, to facilitate conferences and other educational forums. The Women's Commission, responsible for advising the government on its obligations under CEDAW, potentially complements the role of the EOC. However, the question of whether this infrastructure has helped to secure social change around gender equality remains open to scrutiny.

The Sex Discrimination Ordinance

Since the adoption of the SDO in 1995, approximately forty cases have proceeded to the courts. This number of cases includes both equal opportunities actions (direct claims under the SDO usually on the grounds of sex discrimination, or harassment) that are usually handled by the EOC, as well as constitutional, civil, or administrative actions. The relatively low number of legal

cases may be attributed to a number of factors. Before the EOC will consider the provision of legal assistance, conciliation must be proven to have been unsuccessful (Petersen et al. 2003: 49). Scholars have also suggested that Hong Kong does not have a litigious culture, but rather a preference for education measures (Wu 2008: 72) and alternative forms of dispute resolution, such as mediation behind closed doors. Rarely has the EOC initiated legal cases in the absence of any specific complaint. The landmark High Court case, *EOC vs. Director of Education* (2001), challenged the “Secondary School Places Allocation” system on the grounds of both direct and indirect sex discrimination and raised awareness of the way in which anti-discrimination legislation works. Due to the “conciliation-first” model adopted by the EOC, however, the outcomes of complaints brought under the SDO usually remain private, thus limiting public education around the importance of anti-discrimination legislation as a tool to support equality in society (Kapai 2009: 343; Barrow 2013: 299).

Despite the Female Inheritance Movement of the early 1990s, which successfully granted equal inheritance rights to female indigenous villagers, and drew attention to broader issues of gender equality, some controversial administrative policies remain in practice and are exempt under the SDO. The Small House Policy (SHP), adopted by the British Colonial Government in 1972, is an administrative policy that entitles indigenous villagers to apply to build a small house on private land. An “indigenous villager” is defined as a male person of at least 18 years old (Small House Policy 1972). Colloquially referred to as “Ding” (literally male) rights, there was no formal legal recognition of Ding rights in law prior to the adoption of the SHP.

The SDO exempts the SHP from any claim of sex-based discrimination. Article 2 of CEDAW is a core treaty provision requiring states “to take all appropriate measures, including legislation, to modify or abolish existing laws, regulations, customs, and practices which constitute

discrimination against women.” As early as 1994, the UN Committee on Economic Social and Cultural Rights noted that the SHP discriminated against women (ICESCR Committee 1994: para. 24). In 1996, Christine Loh tabled a proposed law to amend the SDO and remove the exception applied to the SHP. However, the Hong Kong Government made a substantive reservation under Article 2 of CEDAW to “continue to apply laws enabling indigenous male villagers in the New Territories to exercise certain rights over property and to enjoy certain privileges in respect of land and property” (Centre for Comparative and Public Law 1998). Over a decade ago, the CEDAW Committee called for a review of the SHP to eliminate discrimination against women indigenous villagers (CEDAW Committee 1999: para. 333), but the government has not taken any proactive steps to amend the legislation.

The SDO has been the primary means of redress for sex discrimination, sexual harassment, and pregnancy-based discrimination for more than two decades, but without any significant law reform. In 2014, the Equal Opportunities Commission (EOC) undertook a major review of all the existing anti-discrimination legislation, and in 2016 submitted its findings to the Hong Kong Government for their consideration. The EOC also questioned whether the continuing exemption applied to the SHP (under SDO) still serves a legitimate aim or is proportionate, whether or not the legislative objective is sufficiently important to justify the SHP’s continued exemption from claims of sex-based claims of discrimination (Equal Opportunities Commission 2016: 25). However, as of this writing, the government has not proactively responded to the EOC’s suggestions.

Inadequate Legal Redress for Minority Groups Experiencing Discrimination

There are also notable gaps in legal provisions, which inhibit the recognition and full participation

of all members of Hong Kong society. There is currently no anti-discrimination legislation on the ground of age, sexual orientation, and gender identity, with the Hong Kong Government favoring education and self-regulation. Rather than adopt any specific legislation, the Hong Kong Government has relied upon organizations voluntarily pledging to adopt its Code of Practice against Discrimination in Employment on the Ground of Sexual Orientation, adopted in 1997 (Constitutional and Mainland Affairs Bureau 2017). The majority of organizations that have voluntarily pledged to adopt the code tend to be large employers or multinational companies, not small and medium enterprises, thus the reach and influence of the Code within an employment context is limited (Barrow and Chia 2016: 95).

Currently, transgender individuals experiencing discrimination in employment have been able to frame their complaints under the Disability Discrimination Ordinance; however, this requires complainants to acknowledge their gender identity as a disability. In the 2001 case of *The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints Hong Kong vs. Stewart J. C. Park*, AKA Jessica Park, an individual with gender identity dysphoria, was excommunicated from the Church of Latter-Day Saints in Hong Kong. In their reasoning, the Court of First Instance interpreted the Disability Discrimination Ordinance as prohibiting discrimination on the ground of gender dysphoria. Substantial damages for employment discrimination have been awarded to some transgender individuals following the EOC’s process of complaint investigation and conciliation (Petersen 2013: 66).

In recent years, there has been growing awareness of gender variant and sexual identities, in part due to a series of landmark legal cases, drawing attention to the lived experiences of gay and transgender individuals in Hong Kong. The 2012 Final Court of Appeal case of *W vs. Registrar of Marriages*, granted a post-operative transgender woman the right to marry her male partner. When W first gave notice of her intention to

marry her male partner, she was required to present her birth certificate as proof of identity. Although W's Hong Kong ID card had been amended to reflect her transitioned gender, her birth certificate stated her sex at birth as male. The 1951 Marriage Ordinance (Cap 181) defines marriage as the "voluntary union for life of one man and one woman to the exclusion of all others" (section 40(2)); therefore, W was denied the right to marry her partner. Article 37 of the Basic Law of Hong Kong protects the right to marry and raise a family. The Final Court of Appeal found that the Marriage Ordinance was unconstitutional. As a post-operative transgender woman, by denying W the right to marry her male partner, W was effectively denied the right to marry at all (Barrow 2015: 285). The ruling allowed W to marry her partner.

The case highlighted the role of the courts in interpreting the scope of existing legal provisions such as the Marriage Ordinance, but it is not within the scope of the judiciary's powers to specify the course of action to be taken by the Hong Kong Executive. The Final Court of Appeal could only recommend that the government look to experiences in other jurisdictions, referring to the Gender Recognition Act of 2004 in the United Kingdom. Following the ruling, the contentious Marriage (Amendment) Bill of 2014 was debated in the Legislative Council. The Bill required that transgender individuals undergo a full sex reassignment in order to be able to marry their partner. However, legislative council members from across the political spectrum vetoed the bill, and there has not been further discussion of how the Marriage Ordinance should be effectively amended to reflect the Court's ruling. Thus, although strategic litigation has raised public awareness of lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and intersex (LGBTI) rights, it is not sufficient as a means of law reform.

Other legislative instruments provide legal protection to women subjected to domestic violence. The 2009 Domestic and Cohabitation

Relationships Violence Ordinance (Cap 189) (DCRVO), provides civil legal remedies, including non-molestation orders and ouster orders, whereby the Court requires the perpetrator to leave the family home. It also provides a Batterer Intervention Programme that Judges may attach to these orders. The law covers a broad range of familial relationships, but migrant domestic workers, who are required to live with their employers, are excluded from the legislation. Following reforms in 2009, the legislation was extended to same-sex couples, but the Hong Kong Government has clearly stated that this does not amount to any formal recognition of same-sex relationships (Barrow and Chia 2016: 96). Currently the law only formally recognizes same-sex relationships when they turn violent. Research has found that civil legal remedies under the DCRVO are rarely utilized due to two principal reasons: first, a lack of awareness about the legislation and the scope of the remedies available; and second, socio-cultural reasons which deter those women experiencing domestic violence from seeking legal redress (Barrow and Scully-Hill 2016: 72).

State-Based Violence Against Sex Workers

Particular groups of women, including sex workers, are also vulnerable to state-based violence as a result of laws and policies that penalize rather than protect women. Sex workers experience a unique set of risks and violence from both state and non-state actors. While the act of selling sex is decriminalized, sex work is heavily regulated and sex workers can be fined under the 1972 Crimes Ordinance (Cap 200) for loitering, or solicitation "for any immoral purpose." A common form of commercial sex is a "one sex-worker-apartment," also known as a "one-woman brothel." Sex workers are forced to work alone because more than one person working in the same venue would make the said venue a "vice establishment"

under section 117 of the Crimes Ordinance. While women, men, and transgender persons engage in sex work, the majority of sex workers are women. In Hong Kong, the sex industry is stratified by age, ethnicity, immigration status, location, and setting, such as karaoke bar, nightclub, one-woman brothel, or on the street, all of which create diverse vulnerabilities (Choi 2016: 240). In 2008 and 2009, ten sex workers in Hong Kong were murdered, and nine had worked in “one sex-worker-apartments”—all of them women (Action for Reach Out et al. 2014).

In 2016, Amnesty International published a report “Harmfully Isolated: Criminalizing Sex Work in Hong Kong,” that provided extensive evidence of police misuse of the laws and powers to set up, punish, and abuse sex workers. Sex workers are vulnerable to police entrapment, coercion, or deception, and condoms are used as evidence of engaging in prostitution. Among sex workers, transgender sex workers and migrant sex workers are particularly vulnerable. Migrant sex workers from Mainland China and other countries are especially easy targets for police abuses, as they often breach their conditions of stay in Hong Kong (Amnesty International 2016). Transgender sex workers are often handled according to the gender identity on their identity cards rather than their own identification. Transgender women are subject to full body searches by policemen, sent to male prisons, and sometimes put in isolation cells or psychiatric centers (Amnesty International 2016: 33–34). Further, sex workers’ right to health has been compromised because the police have used possession of condoms as evidence against them—causing thirty percent of sex workers to choose to possess fewer or no condoms to avoid prosecution (Action for Reach Out et al. 2014; Amnesty International 2016: 31). Discussed in the next section, migrant domestic workers in Hong Kong face the risk of abuse and exploitation due to restrictive immigration policies and inadequate enforcement of their legal rights.

Migrant Domestic Workers: Exploited and Unprotected

Since the 1970s, Hong Kong has outsourced care services for the elderly and children, relying on migrant domestic workers from the Philippines, Indonesia, and other Southeast Asian countries, providing a very large source of domestic labor to middle class families (McArdle 2016: 205). Women make up 98 percent of the more than 351,000 migrant domestic workers in Hong Kong (Hong Kong Government Census and Statistics Department 2017b). As of 2016, there were 184,762 female migrant workers from the Philippines, 153,823 from Indonesia, and 2,429 from Thailand. While there are migrant worker’s organizations which engage actively in advocacy, organizing, and networking activities (Constable 2009; Hsia 2009), there remain widespread rights violation and abuses of these migrant women.

In 2014, the atrocious abuse of Indonesian domestic worker Erwiana Sulistyaningsih by her Hong Kong employer made international headlines. Even though the employer was found guilty and jailed for six years (Lau 2015), there is still little protection for migrant workers, both as migrants and as workers. As a receiving country, Hong Kong has yet to ratify the 1990 International Convention for the Protection of the Rights of All Migrants and Members of their Families, a multilateral UN treaty, despite the fact that sending countries, including Philippines and Indonesia, have done so. While the International Labour Conventions are entrenched in the Hong Kong Basic Law, the enforcement of labor inspection and labor rights against forced labor, debt bondage, and compulsory work days, for example, is inadequate.

Migrant domestic workers are employed according to standard employment contracts (Form ID407), requiring workers to live in their employer’s household, leaving workers susceptible to a range of labor abuses, including extremely long working hours and extended psychological,

physical, and sexual abuses. Amnesty International (2013) and the Mission for Migrant Workers Limited (2014) found that the abuses, made possible by the live-in requirement, are both widespread and not limited to isolated incidents. Domestic workers are often subjected to exorbitant agency fees, therefore, find themselves in a form of indentured labor for a year or more. In addition, the “two-week rule” mandates that upon termination of their contract, a migrant domestic worker must leave Hong Kong within two weeks, unless they are able to find a new employer within that time frame.

These regulations seriously undermine the basic rights of migrant workers, yet the Hong Kong Government has made little attempt to enforce international labor standards in this particular sector. Migrant domestic helpers are exempt from the 2010 Minimum Wage Ordinance (Cap 608) and have been excluded from applying for permanent residence in Hong Kong. This exemption was a result of the judicial review case involving migrant workers’ Evangeline Vallejos and Daniel Domingo (BBC News 2013). Vallejos had worked with the same Hong Kong family for more than two decades. Domingo had been in Hong Kong since the 1980s. Both sought to apply for permanent residency and the right of abode, but their applications were denied. This contrasts sharply with expatriate immigrants who may apply for permanent residence after seven years of regular abode in Hong Kong.

The limitations of laws on the books to protect rights are well illustrated by the experiences of migrant domestic workers in Hong Kong. On paper, they do enjoy some of the same statutory labor rights as other employees, for example, maternity leave under the 1997 Employment Ordinance (Cap. 57). Migrant domestic workers are also protected by the SDO. However, the standard employment contract does not explicitly outline their employment rights (McArdle 2016: 210–211). By virtue of the specific domestic nature of their labor, as well as their nationality,

these migrant women’s access to rights protection has been seriously undermined. This is due to their exclusion from core legislative protections, such as the Minimum Wage Ordinance, as well as the insufficient enforcement of legal standards for migrant workers, all which render them second-class citizens. Despite the continuing challenges for gender equality, as we will see, a number of strategies that have been adopted by the Hong Kong Women’s Commission, are open to further scrutiny and analysis.

EVALUATING EXISTING EQUALITY STRATEGIES

The range of courses offered through the Capacity Building Mileage Programme concentrate on the dynamics of family life, with themes spanning financial management, health, and interpersonal relationships. However, equipping women with the capacity to “build a harmonious family,” manage “household keeping” and be part of “Happy Couples” (Open University of Hong Kong 2017) does not necessarily empower women to achieve their full potential as participants in both the public sphere and private life. As one interviewee explained, the program, which is targeted at working class women, does not lead to employment opportunities:

... the qualification is not well-recognized in the labor market—just for their personal development.
(Former member, Women’s Commission)

Further, the courses are only offered in Chinese. The nature of these educational programs, therefore, reinforces a heteronormative model of citizen engagement that effectively excludes groups of women, including those who are non-Chinese speaking, not heterosexual, or unmarried.

The revised 2009 Gender Mainstreaming Checklist includes a series of twenty-nine questions focused on design, consultation, implementation, and monitoring. Government officers

responsible for policies, law, and legislation must complete these in consultation with frontline staff where appropriate (Women's Commission 2009). While the Women's Commission refers to the Checklist as a "simplified analytical tool," the format of questions does not allow for any detailed feedback or "analysis." For example, one question focusing on allocation of resources asks whether resources have been allocated to address the identified needs of women. Yet beyond a simple "yes," "no," or "not applicable" answer, officers are not required to explain further about how such resources have been allocated.

The Checklist is also heavily weighted toward considerations on the impact of policies, legislation, and programs on women, rather than *both* men and women, with one section dedicated specifically to "impact on women." The framing of this section thus reinforces a male comparator standard against which women's lived experiences are measured. Though the Gender Mainstreaming Checklist's protagonists may have been well-intentioned in endeavors to remove obstacles that prevent women's full participation in Hong Kong society, inevitably, neither the format nor its application, do not radically challenge the way in which laws and policies are formulated. Further, although the Checklist has existed for more than a decade, it was voluntary in nature until 2015. Only then did the Chief Executive announce that all policy bureaux and departments should refer to the Gender Mainstreaming Checklist in designing major government policies (Hong Kong Government 2015: para. 149).

Although the Women's Commission devised a number of equality strategies, at an institutional level, a major challenge remains as to its organizational structure. As an advisory body, the Women's Commission receives secretariat support from the Labour and Welfare Bureau, which oversees the Checklist. Compared to the Equal Opportunities Commission, a statutory body, one EOC member interviewee stated that the Women's Commission "... doesn't have any real

power." A former member of the Women's Commission echoed this view:

The main problem of the Women's Commission is that it's not high ranking—not a high-ranking central mechanism—they don't have real power, they can't push, or even monitor the different government departments to work on—or develop the policy for women, or check if their policy is [of] benefit to women's development . . . they don't have this power.

Although the Women's Commission promoted the use of the Gender Mainstreaming Checklist, the Secretariat of the Labour and Welfare Bureau is responsible for administering it and interacting with various government policy bureaux, as a member of the Women's Commission emphasized in an interview. The Women's Commission, therefore, has little oversight of the process and its policy influence is limited.

As indicated in another interview, the Women's Commission has also been criticized by some women's organizations, which question the political will of the advisory body:

. . . when it comes to the policy level, they don't dare to move, their position is always similar, or should I say it tends to be on the government side . . . they seldom talk about negative things, like equal work equal pay, standardizing work hours.

Despite legislative advances made to support equal opportunities and the adoption of gender equality strategies by the Women's Commission, Hong Kong remains a deeply conservative society with continuing gender stereotypes around gender roles and identity, particularly in relation to family life. Although labor force participation rates for women have steadily increased since the early 1980s, from 47.5 percent in 1982 to 55.3 percent in 2017, it is not uncommon for women to leave the labor force due to their family status. In 1986, the number of women in

the workforce age 20–24 was quite high at 84.3 percent. But for the next age cohorts of women, rates of participation subsequently dropped to 71.5 percent for women age 25–29, and further dropped to 55.4 percent for women age 30–34 (Hong Kong Government Census and Statistics Department 2017c).

In recent years, this gap in labor force participation across age groups has closed somewhat, which may be due to a combination of factors. Women seem to be entering the workforce later. For example, from 1986–2015, labor force participation rates by age group and sex reflect a significant decrease of women age 20–24 in the workforce, from 84.3 per cent to 63.7 per cent (Hong Kong Government Census and Statistics Department 2016: Table 4.4), which may indicate that greater numbers of women are entering higher education or pursuing other training opportunities. However, the labor force participation rates consistently drops for women age 30–34 and older, suggesting that although there are more women in the labor force in general, there remains a “leaking pipeline” when women start to have children.

There has also been a lack of momentum for considering gender equality and its intersection with class, ethnicity, and immigration status. For example, in relation to economic class, according to an Oxfam report, *Hong Kong Poverty Report, 2011–15*, income inequality has increased and gender inequality in particular has exacerbated: more than one in every seven persons lives in poverty, while one in every six women lives in poverty (Oxfam Hong Kong 2016a). The pay gap between women and men in poor households is forty percent (Oxfam Hong Kong 2016b). The percentage of women living in poverty is higher than men in all age groups, except for people under fifteen, and women make up more than 85 percent of all single parent households (Oxfam Hong Kong 2016c). Poor working women face structural and long-term problems, such as fewer job choices due to their household responsibilities,

irregular employment, and unfavorable work conditions (Oxfam Hong Kong 2016b). Ethnic minorities experience particular challenges in a society that still imagines itself as homogeneously Chinese.

The cases of migrant domestic workers from the Philippines and Indonesia discussed above are good examples of how limited residence rights and labor rights reinforce migrant workers’ second-class status in Hong Kong. In the last decade, Mainland Chinese immigrants have been the targets of increasingly hostile attacks in the new surge of “right way nativism” (Ip 2015: 410). The immigration status of Mainland immigrants, ethnic minorities, asylum seekers, and refugees offers distinct insights into the diverse expressions of gender inequalities in Hong Kong. These are structural conditions and socioeconomic responses that legislation, including the SDO and the Family Status Discrimination Ordinance, have not been able to address. Much broader interventions are required in social and economic policies and in public education, as well as in collaboration with the private sector, to mainstream gender well beyond the scope of what the current Gender Mainstreaming Checklist offers.

Hong Kong’s status as a SAR of China also has potential ramifications for securing social change around gender equality and diversity. Although Hong Kong SAR has a high degree of autonomy, the Central Government of the PRC has responsibility for foreign affairs relating to Hong Kong (Basic Law: Chapter II, Article 13), as well as defense (Basic Law: Chapter II, Article 14). This status impacts the region’s ability to implement and ratify international laws, and has shaped activist discourses around equality and rights (Lim 2015: 130–131). In recent years, Hong Kong has experienced a political reform crisis with regular political demonstrations and clashes since the pro-democracy “Umbrella Movement” of 2014. A side effect of these tensions over political reform is the crippling effect on law-making at the Legislative Council.

CONCLUSION

In Hong Kong, the introduction of laws to support gender equality has not been accompanied by comprehensive public education or policy measures. Even with a rights-based legislative framework and institutional infrastructure in place, it appears that equality rights-based consciousness, which occurred in the aftermath of the Female Inheritance Movement, has dissipated, and the political will to support gender equality and diversity strategies to enable and empower all women is lacking. Current tension around Hong Kong's political reform also potentially undermines the reform of discriminatory and outdated laws.

The Women's Commission—the most prominent government body with the mandate to promote gender equality—has highly circumscribed powers and cannot hold any government bureau accountable to its goals of gender mainstreaming. The Gender Mainstreaming Checklist adopted in 2002 (revised 2009) is one of the major achievements of the Women's Commission, yet it has not been systematically applied to all legislation, policies, and programs. Since the policy address by the Chief Executive in 2015, policy bureaus are only required to apply the Gender Mainstreaming Checklist to major government policies. Furthermore, the Chief Executive appoints members of the Women's Commission. These members have not been highly critical of government policies, nor are they empowered to envision any comprehensive reforms. In effect, the potential of the Women's Commission to take on a leading role in spearheading gender equality has yet to be explored.

Fundamentally, laws on the statute books cannot be the end of any gender equality project. The rights-based legal framework that recognizes female inheritance, for example, needs to be translated into policies that create enabling conditions for the pursuit of gender equality. As the examples of transgender individuals, sex workers, and migrant domestic workers illustrate,

the complexity of inequalities engendered at the intersection of class, ethnicity, sexuality, immigration status, and age, for example, takes shape outside of the realm of the law, requiring a grounded understanding of human experiences. Furthermore, gender equality is not just a women's issue, but requires consideration and participation of both men and women. Legislation can be a good first step, but as the only step, it is certainly inadequate in securing equality, embracing diversity, and procuring meaningful social change in Hong Kong.

NOTE

- 1 This chapter is grounded in qualitative research interviews conducted in 2015 and 2016 by author Amy Barrow (Principal Investigator) of a Hong Kong General Research Fund Grant on "Evaluating the Effectiveness of Institutional Mechanisms for the Advancement of Women in Hong Kong" (U414000) 2015–2016. Amy Barrow would like to thank Michelle Suet Yi Ng for her research assistance during the project.

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Chapter seven

Women's Experiences of Balancing Work and Family in South Korea

Continuity and Change

Sirin Sung

INTRODUCTION

Work-family balance issues became prominent from the late 1980s onward in Korea (also referred to as South Korea) with rapid economic development and women's increasing participation in the labor market. Recent policy developments have supported women to balance paid and unpaid work and to encourage men's involvement in childcare. Nevertheless, gendered patterns in the division of household labor have not greatly improved in practice, as women continue to spend more time on unpaid work than men do (Joo et al. 2016), despite their increasing involvement in paid work. Traditional views on gender roles persist in the Korean family, as unpaid care work is mainly considered to be women's work.

Gendered patterns in the division of household labor are not peculiar to Korean society, as they have been found among all 35 Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) countries as well as in other countries (OECD 2016f). However, Korean women balancing work and family life may encounter more pressure due to their responsibility for their parents-in-law. Married women's responsibility for their parents-in-law is strongly associated with

the traditional views of gender roles in Confucian patriarchy, which clearly defines the role of women in the family (Lee 2005b). Confucian patriarchal traditions may not be as strong as in the past, as a result of relatively recent socioeconomic and demographic changes. However, the notion of care work and household tasks as women's work has not changed significantly, as married women in paid employment continue to take more responsibility for unpaid work (domestic/care work) than men do (Sung 2013). Given this context, this chapter examines the impact of gender role ideology on women's experiences of balancing work and family life in Korea. It will also explore the influence of Confucian culture on women's experiences of the unequal sharing of domestic work and care work between men and women within the Korean family.

WOMEN BALANCING PAID AND UNPAID WORK

Korea has achieved rapid economic development following the industrialization era of the 1960s. Recently, this rapid economic development has been accompanied by particular

socioeconomic and demographic changes, such as the increasing participation of women in the labor market, higher educational attainment, an aging population, and low fertility rates. Women's participation in the labor market has gradually increased since the 1960s in Korea, from 34 percent in 1965 to 51.1 percent in 2018 (KOSIS 2018). Educational attainment for women has considerably improved, with similar numbers of women and men completing university degrees; 63 percent of women and men aged 25 to 34 completed tertiary education (OECD 2012). However, the significant improvements in educational attainment have not yet fully translated into enhanced labor market outcomes, as the female labor force participation rate is lower than the OECD average of 58 percent (OECD 2016a).

In addition, there have been rapid demographic changes, including an aging population and a low fertility rate. Life expectancy at birth has gradually increased in Korea; for women, it has reached 85 years compared to the OECD average of 83 years (OECD 2015). Also, a sharp decline in fertility from 4.5 in 1970 to 1.2 in 2013 (OECD 2016d) suggests that there is a need for further improvement in work-family balance policies in Korea. Moreover, there have been cultural changes in attitudes toward gender roles; a longitudinal survey on gender and family shows that the proportion of men doing housework two or three times a week has slightly increased, from 9 percent in 2007 to 15 percent in 2014 (Joo et al. 2016).

Despite these recent changes, married women in paid employment continue to encounter difficulties and inequalities in both the workplace and the home. For instance, the gender pay gap in median earnings of full-time employees in Korea is the highest (37 percent) among the OECD countries, and significantly higher than the OECD average of 15 percent (OECD 2016b). Women continue to spend more hours in unpaid work (domestic/care work) than men in Korea; women spend 208 minutes per day on average

doing unpaid work, while men spend only 47 minutes per day (Kim 2015). According to the OECD Family Database (OECD 2016f), while women spend more time on care work relative to men in all countries, gender differences are particularly acute in Korea, as women spend four to six times more time on care work than men. This indicates that men's involvement in unpaid work has not kept pace with the increasing level of women's participation in paid work.

Moreover, the organizational culture of long working hours can also be an obstacle to men's involvement in unpaid work in the Korean family. The OECD (2016a) economic surveys show that annual working hours in Korea were 17 percent longer than the OECD average in 2014. Although the standard working hours per week in Korea was reduced from 44 hours in 2000 to 40 in 2011, employees working in small firms with fewer than five employees are not included in the standard workweek scheme. Furthermore, overtime hours (12 hours per week) and additional hours during the weekends, which can add up to a total of 68 hours per week, are also not included.

Along with a culture of long working hours, the traditional notion of care work as woman's work persists in the Korean family. Therefore, married women in paid employment may encounter difficulties in reconciling paid and unpaid work, as women are the primary providers of both child and eldercare for family members. Korean women, living in a transitional period where tradition and change coexist, may encounter a contradiction between traditional gender roles and the ideal of gender equality. For instance, women's involvement in paid work is a reflection of the recent changes, whereas their primary responsibility for domestic/care work is closely associated with their traditional gender roles (Sung 2014). Therefore, women's experiences of balancing work and care and how they perceive the gender division of labor in the Korean family is a crucial issue to explore.

GENDER ROLE IDEOLOGY AND CONFUCIAN CULTURE

Gender role ideology is conceptualized as “a set of attitudes about the appropriate roles, rights, and responsibilities of men and women in a given society” (Lucas-Thompson and Goldberg 2015). Concerned mainly with how individuals identify themselves with regard to gender roles (Greenstein 1996), such ideologies range from the traditional to the egalitarian. Traditional ideologies clearly distinguish between male and female work and care roles, while egalitarian ideologies support the idea of a more equal sharing of work and care between women and men (Hochschild 1989; Rajadhyaksha et al. 2015). Gender ideology has been considered an important contributor to individuals’ attitudes about how they balance work and family, as it is associated with a range of gender-relevant behaviors, such as marriage, division of household labor, educational attainment, and labor force participation (Davis and Greenstein 2009). According to Qian and Sayer (2016), men are more likely to endorse traditional gender roles than women, and women are more likely to show disagreement with the traditional ideas in East Asia, including Korea. Also, a gender hierarchy and traditional gender role ideology seem to persist in East Asia, together with the Confucian cultural heritage and patriarchal family structures, which may lead to difficulties for married women who combine work and family responsibilities.

The impact of the Confucian patriarchal system is particularly evident when examining the role of women as caregivers within the Korean family. Despite women’s increasing participation in paid work, childcare is primarily considered to be mothers’ work, as the traditional notion of married women’s role as “good wives and wise mothers” still prevails (Choi 1994). Regarding eldercare, the Confucian cultural value of filial piety retains great importance in East Asia, although the tradition has become less prevalent

(Schwarz et al. 2010). Confucian patriarchy dictates that for a married woman, filial piety toward her husband’s parents is more important than her obligations to her own parents (Lee 2005b). Therefore, married women involved in paid work often carry a double burden of work and care (Sung 2014).

The issue of care has been central to feminist debate, as it is mainly women who do care work (Graham 1991). The feminist scholar, Tronto, suggests that the moral implications of giving care are an important aspect in human life. In the ethics of care, responsibility is a central moral category, which can have “different meanings depending upon one’s perceived gender roles, family status and culture” (Tronto 1993: 133). Regarding the practice of care and gender roles, the allocation of care responsibilities becomes a crucial issue when a certain group of people is allowed to avoid responsibility. Tronto (2011) describes this phenomenon as “privileged irresponsibility,” as exemplified by the household division of labor. For instance, in the traditional breadwinner model, the husband may be excused from daily housework and caring responsibilities because he has fulfilled his duty by bringing income into the household. As Tronto (2011: 167) suggests, this notion has implications from “both a moral perspective as a way of shirking responsibility by claiming that one’s own responsibility lies in some other area, and from a political perspective as a kind of power through which one is able to force others to accept responsibilities.”

In the Korean family, husbands are often granted a “pass” from domestic/care work, which means that they are not expected to engage in domestic/care work because they are considered to be the main financial provider for the family. The gendered practice of care responsibilities can even be found in dual-earner families where the traditional breadwinner model does not apply. Gender role ideology comes into play here. That is, because care work is considered to be women’s work, the husband can be exempt from this duty. In Confucian patriarchy, the husband’s

exemption from responsibility for domestic/care work is often related to the traditional gender ideology of his parents, as household tasks have traditionally been performed by daughters-in-law. Parents-in-law often are found to interfere in the division of household labor between husband and wife in Korean families.

POLICY CONTEXT: WORK-FAMILY BALANCE POLICIES IN KOREA

The Korean government established the Ministry of Gender Equality and Family (MOGEF) in 2000 to improve gender equality and to achieve gender mainstreaming in policy and society. Equal opportunity legislation, which was originally introduced in 1987, developed into the Equal Employment and Support of Work-Family Balance Act in 2007, in recognition of the importance of work-family balance for working parents (Sung 2014). In particular, the recent reforms of work-family balance policies in 2014 and 2016 led to a significant improvement in childcare-related leave, such as maternity, paternity, and parental leave. Maternity leave became more generous in terms of pay, providing 100 percent of income replacement for 60 days; Employment Insurance covers the remaining 30 days up to 1,350,000 Won (\$1,191) (MOEL 2016). Unpaid paternity leave (three days) has evolved into paid leave; fathers are now entitled to three to five days of paternity leave, but they are paid for only three days.

Furthermore, parents with children under eight years of age can now take up to one year of parental leave (up to three years for employees in the public sector). Previously, parental leave was referred to as “childcare leave” in Korea, but the term was changed to “parental childcare leave” in 2014 to emphasize the father’s role in childcare (MOLEG 2014). In fact, the importance of fathers’ involvement in childcare has been the center of attention in the reformed

policy (MOLEG 2016). For example, a “daddy months” program was introduced to encourage fathers to take parental leave. Like Sweden’s “daddy quota” policy, “daddy months” enable fathers to take parental leave immediately after mothers take leave. Although limited to 1,500,000 Won (\$1,323) per month, fathers taking “daddy months” are entitled to 100 percent income replacement of their monthly wage for three months (KWDI 2016a). In spite of these developments, however, low uptake by fathers (6 percent) in these programs indicates that traditional conceptions of gender roles remain largely unchanged (KWDI 2016b).

Also, total public expenditure on early childhood education and care in Korea (0.8 percent) is significantly lower than in Nordic countries, although it is slightly above the OECD average (0.7 percent) (OECD 2016e). In particular, public spending on pre-primary education is considerably lower than in the UK and some European countries, including Sweden and Norway (OECD 2016e). Therefore, lack of publicly funded childcare amplifies reliance on informal care and adds to the pressure imposed upon dual-earner families in balancing work and family. The informal childcare rate for 0 to 2-year-olds in Korea is particularly high (28 percent) in comparison with Nordic countries (e.g. Sweden 0.27 percent) (OECD 2016c).

The official family care leave program was introduced in Korea in 2007 and was revised in 2012 as part of the reform of work-family balance policies. This type of leave serves mainly to enable an employee to take unpaid leave when a family member or dependent needs care due to illness, an accident, or old age. The family member may be a spouse, child, parent, or parent-in-law (Park 2016). Employees can take up to 90 days per year, but the period of leave must be at least 30 days each time (Choi et al. 2014). Although this leave was first introduced in 2007, take-up rates have been particularly low. According to the survey on the effectiveness of work-family balance policies undertaken by the Ministry

of Employment and Labor (Kim 2016b), only 1.2 persons on average used the *family care leave program*, whereas most employees took *annual leave* when they needed time off to care for a family member. Only about 30 percent of employees were aware that such *family care leave* was available (Park et al. 2016). Low take-up rates seem to be associated with a lack of awareness and anxiety about financial loss, given that family care leave is unpaid (Park 2016). Flexibility regarding the length of leave (e.g. allowing short-term absences of less than 30 days if needed) might encourage employees to make more use of the leave.

Since the 1990s, the Korean population has been aging (Statistics Korea 2011), with the result that eldercare policies have become a crucial concern for the government. The introduction of long-term care (LTC) insurance in 2008 led to a significant improvement in eldercare policy, in that it recognized care as a societal as well as a familial responsibility (Kim 2016a). That said, LTC insurance was developed mainly in response to urgent socioeconomic pressures, such as low fertility rates, unemployment, and a lack of care services, rather than for the purpose of the socializing care (Kim 2016a). “Maintaining the family system” remains central to the 2015 reformed policy for eldercare, and the significance of “the enhancement of the spirit of respect for the elderly and filial piety” is still highlighted (MOLEG 2017: Chapter 3, Article 1). Evidently, eldercare policy in Korea is still focused on family responsibility for care, as it continues to give prominence to the Confucian virtue of filial piety.

RESEARCH METHODS

To examine issues related to work/family responsibilities, qualitative research methods were selected to explore women’s experiences and beliefs regarding traditional gender roles and their effects on the ability of women to balance

work and family. As Denzin and Lincoln (1998) suggest, qualitative research is useful in examining experiences of the *constraints of everyday life*. To give more flexibility to participants and to allow people to give their own opinions and experiences, semi-structured interviews were carried out with thirty married women in paid employment in Seoul, Korea, in 2014. The interviewees, who were aged between 19 and 60, were recruited, selected, and drawn equally from the public and private sectors. Although the level of income varied between the low-middle to upper-middle income range, most participants were from the middle-income group. The interview topics focused primarily on women’s experiences of balancing work and family responsibilities, including the division of household tasks (e.g. domestic work, childcare, and eldercare) between the women themselves and their husbands. Pseudonyms have been used throughout the chapter to maintain confidentiality and anonymity.

WOMEN’S EXPERIENCES OF BALANCING WORK AND FAMILY RESPONSIBILITIES: THE IMPACT OF GENDER ROLE IDEOLOGY AND CONFUCIAN CULTURE

Korean women’s experiences related to the division of household labor were explored by examining how unpaid household work and care work are shared between the respondents and their husbands. More specifically, this section focuses on the accounts of these employed women and how they perceive the sharing of household work. The extent to which gender role ideology has influenced the ways in which unpaid work is shared between men and women is also examined, in addition to whether Confucian culture has had an impact on the unequal sharing of unpaid work between them.

Domestic Work: Unequal Sharing of Housework between Men and Women

All respondents stated that domestic work is not equally shared between their husbands and themselves and that these women take more responsibility for doing housework than do their husbands, despite the women's involvement in paid work. None of the respondents seemed to perceive that the household labor can be equally divided between their husbands and themselves. Thus, no egalitarian trend was found from the interviews regarding gender roles. However, in some cases, respondents did mention that their husbands helped with dishwashing and laundry occasionally, indicating some degree of change in the traditional view of gender roles. Although this change was far from the egalitarian level of equal sharing of housework, it is a clear indication of a cultural shift in Korean family life, however slow. Furthermore, respondents tended to use the expression "my husband helps me with housework" when they talked about how this work is shared in their home, suggesting that housework continues to be perceived as primarily the woman's responsibility with which husbands sometimes assist.

When asked why they do more housework than their husbands, about two-thirds of the respondents stated that the reason is closely associated with the traditional culture of gender roles in Korea. Only one respondent said that she had traditional views on gender roles herself stating that "*for men, work is more important than doing unpaid work at home.*" Others suggested that the primary reason is that their husbands and parents-in-law have traditional ideas on gender roles. They also cited the wider influence of traditional culture on Korean society. This experience is exemplified by Yumi, a 40-year-old mother of three young children, who talked about how her husband responds when she asks him to share household tasks:

My husband never helped me with housework. He is a bit traditional and patriarchal. He would say, "How can a man do this kind of thing." He'd say, "It's a woman's job."

A college graduate working for a private company, Yumi lived with her parents-in-law for five years at the beginning of her marriage, an arrangement which she felt obligated to accept as her mother-in-law had particularly requested it. She found the experience of co-residence with her parents-in-law rather stressful, as they had traditional ideas on gender roles similar to those of her husband.

Roughly half of the respondents said that the traditional ideas of their parents-in-law had influenced the unequal sharing of housework between them and their husbands. For example, Sumi, a 40-year-old with three young children, said her parents-in-law often made remarks about why men should not engage in domestic work, which they saw as mainly a woman's responsibility:

My mother-in-law said, "Men should not enter the kitchen. In the past, it was only the male servant who entered the kitchen. My son should not be treated as a servant."

Sumi also said that her husband had tried to help her with housework a few times but that his mother had not allowed him to do so. "*I cannot help you as my mother doesn't like it,*" he told her. Sumi also described the difference between her own mother and her mother-in-law when they visit her house. While her mother would do most of the housework out of concern that Sumi might be too tired after work, her mother-in-law would want Sumi to do the housework after she came back from work. Her husband, by contrast, would not be expected to do anything after work.

Further, in some cases, respondents mentioned that Confucian traditional culture influenced wider society as well as their parents-in-law. Susie, a 38-year-old civil servant, described how traditional Korean culture affected her work

performance, because wives are expected to do housework. She described herself as a highly educated woman with a postgraduate degree, and yet she still believed that she must conform to her traditional gender role, as a wife, mother, and daughter-in-law at home:

In Korean traditional culture, a wife has to cook for her husband, so marriage affected my work somehow. My parents-in-law have strong Confucian traditional views. My mother-in-law told me that "it's a woman's job, daughter-in-law's job in particular." So I do all the housework when I visit my parents-in-law during the weekends or celebration days [e.g. New Year's Day, Autumn Festival].

In turn, Susie hires a domestic helper who comes two or three times a week to help her with her own housework. Nevertheless, she found it difficult to cope with both paid work and housework, as making sure that the house is clean and that family meals are well prepared is considered to be mainly her responsibility. Lee's (2002) study of middle-class Chinese families in Hong Kong also found that having a domestic helper does not necessarily release working mothers from their family responsibilities, as they often have to supervise the domestic helper. Moreover, wives often are blamed when the domestic helper does not perform well, as this is considered evidence that they lack supervisory and organizational skills. In a few cases, mothers-in-law had refused to hire a domestic helper although they could afford to do so. Bini, for example, explained the difficulties she experienced in combining paid work and her responsibilities at home, as her mother-in-law did not want to hire a domestic helper:

I have been living with my parents-in-law for ten years as my husband is the eldest son. I want to hire a domestic helper, but my mother-in-law doesn't like the idea. So I end up doing most of the housework after I come back from work.

From the interviews, none of the participants in this study perceived housework to be equally shared between their husbands and themselves. Thus, there was no egalitarian way of sharing household labor. Moreover, roughly half of the respondents indicated that their husbands either did less housework than they did or were reluctant to perform any housework because their parents-in-law held traditional ideas about gender roles. This finding is also consistent with the examination of the reasons as to why women take more responsibility for childcare.

Childcare: Why Women do More than Men

As with their experience of unequal sharing of domestic work, all respondents also indicated that they took more responsibility for childcare than did their husbands. Further, more than half of the respondents stated that this is because their parents-in-law and/or their husbands adhere to traditional ideas on gender roles. However, there was a difference between the respondents' perception of the share of domestic work and of childcare. While only one respondent stated that she adheres to traditional views of gender roles regarding domestic work, nearly half of the respondents expressed a certain degree of agreement with traditional views on gender roles and motherhood-ideology as they pertain to childcare. For example, Jimin, a 38-year-old teacher, described childcare as something that mothers naturally do better than fathers, highlighting the biological differences between men and women:

I think it's just natural. I am the mother. I breastfed my daughter and biologically men and women are different. My husband is a good father . . . but I do more childcare. My children also look for me [not my husband] when they are unwell or in need of something.

According to Lee (2002), in Hong Kong it is widely believed that women are better at caring for children than men. Men are also more likely to engage in recreational tasks with children rather than adopt a caring role. This was also evident in this study as respondents often made comments, such as “*my husband is good at entertaining children,*” that emphasized his role in recreational activities or in outdoor sporting activities with children.

Importantly, for Korean women, childcare is considered to be the first priority among other household tasks, and women assume more responsibility for childcare despite their involvement in paid work. As some respondents emphasized, many working mothers regard looking after their children to be more important than doing well in their career. Indeed, feeling guilty about not being a good mother was highlighted by some of those interviewed, for whom not being able to pay enough attention to their children was their main concern, as they were not being able to spend more time with their children due to their responsibilities in their paid work.

While some respondents emphasized the traditional notions of the mother’s role in childcare, a few others suggested more practical reasons for why they are deemed to be more responsible for childcare than their husbands. For them, having husbands who worked long hours in inflexible work settings was the main reason why they spent more time on childcare than their husbands. As one respondent, Sunhee, explained:

My husband’s job is not flexible. Also [he works] long hours. His colleagues mostly have wives who are not in paid work. Therefore, his colleagues would not understand why he needs to take time off for childcare/family reasons, instead of [his] wife.

Sunhee works as a civil servant in the public sector. Consequently, she is likely to work more regular hours from 9:00 am to 5:00 pm than her husband and finds it easier to take time off work for family emergencies. However, it is crucial to

note the impact that the organizational culture of her husband’s workplace has on how the couple organizes their childcare responsibilities, particularly in relation to taking time off for family reasons. Sunhee’s experience provides evidence that in dual-earner families, the traditional gender role ideology of the husband’s colleagues and the organizational culture of his workplace can affect the ways in which individuals organize and manage childcare within their households.

As in the case of domestic work, more than one-half of respondents said that the traditional views of their husbands and parents-in-law explained why they were more responsible for childcare than their husbands. For example, Gina, a 52-year-old head-teacher of a pre-school, stated that she took more responsibility for childcare when her children were young because her husband held strong traditional views on gender roles:

My husband is very traditional, so he said it’s not a man’s job to look after children. He only focused on his work . . . did nothing for childcare.

Gabi, a 42-year-old pre-school teacher who lived with her parents-in-law for six years immediately after her marriage, described similar difficulties in sharing childcare with her husband. From her point of view, her husband did not help her with childcare because her parents-in-law would not like the idea of men doing care work. In fact, her father-in-law asked her to quit her job to focus on housework and childcare. She did not work for the six years while she lived with her parents-in-law, but instead looked after her two young children and her mother-in-law, who had health problems. At one point, she also looked after her husband’s brother’s two children, as he was divorced and his former wife did not want to be responsible for the children:

My parents-in-law told me to quit my job after marriage. For three years I had to look after my mother-in-law who had cancer, as well as my young

children. My husband's brother got divorced at that time, so I also had to look after his two children for three years. It was very hard for me. I felt like I was their servant. My parents-in-law did not like the idea of my husband doing childcare.

Gabi's experience demonstrates the level of interference by parents-in-law in decisions made by Korean couples regarding the sharing of housework and care responsibilities. Their ability to excuse their adult sons from such activities places greater pressure on their daughters-in-law to take more responsibility for housework and childcare, similar to Tronto's (1993) idea of "privileged irresponsibility." To understand Korean family relationships, it is important to examine the power dynamics between the daughter-in-law and parents-in-law as well as the relationship between husbands and wives. Indeed, the relationship between husbands and wives can often be affected by the interference of parents-in-law in the Confucian patriarchal family (Sung 2003).

Eldercare and Confucian Culture: Gender Ideology

All those interviewed for this study stated that they took more responsibility for their parents-in-law, than for their own parents, in terms of both financial support and care. To follow up, respondents were asked to explain why they did so and whether or not they perceived this as fair. Being the eldest daughter-in-law or the only daughter-in-law was one of the important reasons they gave. According to Confucian tradition, married women are obligated to be more responsible for their parents-in-law than for their own parents (Sung 2014). Therefore, in the Korean family, it is often the daughter-in-law who takes on the responsibility for looking after her parents-in-law in their old age rather than the parents-in-law's own daughters. Sons are considered to be the main financial provider for their parents in old age, while daughters-in-law traditionally

perform a care-giving role. When there is more than one son, the eldest takes primary responsibility for his parents in their old age (Lee 2005a). Bomi, a 41-year-old accountant, explained the importance of being the eldest daughter-in-law in a Korean family:

I have done much more for my parents-in-law. I give more financial support to them than to my own parents. I visit them more often and regularly. My husband is the eldest son and that means a lot to my parents-in-law. My husband often says, "I am the eldest son, so should be responsible for my parents." In Korea, being an eldest son and daughter-in-law is a big responsibility.

Although Bomi found it difficult to communicate with her mother-in-law, who adheres to traditional views on gender roles, she too accepted traditional views as they pertained to responsibility of a daughter-in-law. For instance, she described how annoyed she was that her own brothers' wives did not do enough housework and that her mother was helping them: "*It should be their responsibility as daughters-in-law to do housework, not my mother's, especially when they are housewives.*" Despite her belief that she was being unfair to her own parents, Bomi felt more responsibility toward her parents-in-law. This view was mitigated somewhat by her belief that her brothers would look after her parents, as it is the social custom in Korea for sons to be responsible for older parents.

While some other respondents, such as Minju, who had stated that "*it's my obligation to live with my parents-in-law if they get older or sick,*" also subscribed to traditional views on gender roles in relation to eldercare, about two-thirds of respondents said that they took more responsibility for their parents-in-law not because they held a traditional view of their role as daughters-in-law but rather because their husbands and parents-in-law held traditional views of gender roles. Thus, primarily, they perceived their husbands and parents-in-law as having been influenced by

traditional culture and its customs, which affected their role as daughters-in-law. Duna explained this well:

My parents-in-law are too traditional. They think a daughter-in-law has to be responsible for parents-in-law. I disagree with this idea but it is just how it is done, traditional custom in Korea.

Interestingly, whether they held traditional views on gender roles or not, virtually all respondents stated that it was unfair that they were more responsible for their parents-in-law than for their own parents. Although they were aware of the unfairness of the custom, especially in light of recent social and policy changes, most of them made comments such as “it is just part of tradition in Korea” and “it’s easier to follow the custom and conform to the tradition.” As Sunju, a 41-year-old nursery assistant, explained:

My father passed away, so my mother does memorial service for him every year. But I can’t attend it, as it is the same day as the memorial service of my grandparents-in-law. My parents-in-law told me that it is my duty to be there as a granddaughter-in-law.

According to the Confucian tradition, adult children should show respect to their deceased parents by carrying out memorial services every year. Demonstrating respect for deceased parents and ancestors is part of the Confucian tradition of ancestor worship, as filial piety is one of the most important Confucian virtues (Schwarz et al. 2010). In Sunju’s case, her parents-in-law perceived her responsibility toward her grandparent-in-law as taking priority over her duty to attend the memorial service for her own father.

Indeed, the Confucian tradition of respecting one’s parents and ancestors persists in contemporary Korean society, albeit to a lesser degree than in the past (also see Schwarz et al. 2006). And at times, it is practiced in different ways, depending on particular religious beliefs and on

family tradition. For example, one respondent described how her parents-in-law who are Christian still hold the memorial service for their deceased parents in their church, although it is performed differently from the Confucian practice. They normally invite a clergyman to pray for the deceased parents/grandparents, rather than following the Confucian tradition of ancestor worship.

In contrast, several respondents explained their attempts to challenge the tradition by giving financial support to both their parents-in-law and their own parents, and by visiting the latter regularly. However, they found it difficult to continue giving the same level of support to both parties, as their income and time was limited. Nevertheless, their efforts reflect a cultural transition in Korean society in that women are increasingly aware of the inequality that they encounter in terms of gender roles.

CONCLUSION

Korea has undergone numerous socioeconomic, demographic, and policy changes, including the increasing number of women in the labor market, longer life expectancy, lower fertility rates, and the development of equal opportunity legislation. As a result of increased female participation in the labor market, work-family balance issues have come to the fore, leading to the development of policies designed to promote work-family balance, such as maternity, paternity, and parental leave. These policies have been reformed several times and have become more egalitarian (Sung 2014). However, such policies need further development to encourage an equal sharing of domestic work and care work between men and women. Despite the recent development of policies related to paternity and parental leave, the participation rate for men is still low, and paternity leave policies, in particular, require improvement in terms of pay and duration. In addition, childcare policies must be

developed to meet the needs of working mothers, to reduce the heavy reliance on informal care, and to increase the number of publicly funded childcare institutions.

Along with these changes, gendered patterns in the division of household labor must be challenged, as traditional conceptions of gender roles persist in the Korean family. Because domestic work and care are still regarded as women's work, men are often exempt from family responsibilities, thereby making it more difficult for Korean women to reconcile paid and unpaid work. The evidence from the interviews clearly indicates that women continue to assume more responsibility for domestic work, childcare, and eldercare and that they do so because of the traditional views of gender held by their husbands and parents-in-law. In particular, eldercare responsibilities are strongly related to *Confucian patriarchal views*, as married women continue to take more responsibility for their parents-in-law than for their own parents. Further, findings from the interviews indicate that *traditional gender role ideology* significantly influences Korean women's experiences of balancing work and family, with unpaid work continuing to be shared *unequally* between men and women. The impact of Confucian traditions on gender roles is particularly notable in relation to eldercare, given married women's presumed responsibility for their parents-in-law. In the end, this signifies the importance of cultural change in the wider society as well as in individual/family life, as the gendered division of household labor remains relatively unchanged despite policy developments intended to foster greater sharing of family responsibilities.

It is also important to note that women in this study continued to take more responsibility for their parents-in-law than for their own parents, even though most believed that doing so was unfair. This reflects the difficulties encountered by Korean women living in the transition between tradition and change (Sung 2014). In the midst of the transition, women themselves often face a

contradiction between traditional views of gender roles and gender equality (Sung 2013) and experience uncertainty about the path to follow. *Therefore, along with policy developments, cultural shifts in traditional ideas on gender roles are necessary in order to achieve an equal sharing of paid and unpaid work between Korean men and women.*

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Chapter eight

Gender Equality in the Japanese Workplace

What has Changed since 1985?

Chikako Usui

INTRODUCTION

Responding to internal demographic changes and international pressure, Japan initiated a series of ambitious government policies to promote gender equality in the workplace. The number of female workers in Japan increased steadily from 15.5 million in 1985, to 24.7 million by 2015. Women constituted 35.9 percent of the total Japanese labor force (men and women combined) in 1985, but their share increased to 43.3 percent by 2013. Further, female labor force participation, expressed as the percentage of the total number of productive-age women (age 15–64), increased from 53.0 percent in 1985, to 64.6 percent by 2015. Women occupied just slightly over 2 percent of middle and senior-level management positions in 1985, but 8.7 percent in 2015 (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2016). Although these indicators of female employment show steady progress, Japan's rankings in broader measures of female equity continue to lag behind in global comparisons.

Japanese policies and employment data over time do not paint the full picture on female equity. A number of obstacles in the workforce continue to slow progress, and some unanticipated new challenges have developed as a result of policy changes designed to advance gender

equity. Pro-equality policies have not slowed the low marriage rates and falling birthrate. Tax laws continue to favor married females working part-time, as secondary to male family workers. Women in senior-level leadership positions in the business and government sectors have not made substantial progress in spite of government's efforts, for example, that encourage promoting women on boards of directors (*Japan Times* 2016). Part of the problem of gender equity comes from the concentration of women workers in the “nonregular” workforce that preclude them from career training and advancement. Almost 60 percent of working women in Japan are in nonregular, part-time or temporary jobs, without promotion opportunities. The proportion of Japanese women workers in such nonregular positions has increased rather than decreased in the past three decades, largely due to prolonged recessions and slow recovery of the Japanese economy. In addition, women face difficulties in balancing work and family needs. With its long established “M-curve” pattern of female employment, over 60 percent of women still remove themselves from the labor force after first childbirth (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2015: 14). These women return to work part-time while raising children or stay at home as full-time mothers.

This chapter reviews major policy strategies and the changes in women's employment conditions during the past three decades. It evaluates the extent of these changes as well as the effects of cultural, institutional, and structural challenges to gender equality in the workplace. By highlighting the obstacles to the promotion of women to leadership positions and benchmarks of Japanese progress on gender equality against other developed economies, attention focuses on areas of productive policy changes for the future.

CONTEXT OF CHANGES AND CONTROVERSIES ON GENDER EQUALITY

By the 1980s, Japan's demographic squeeze was becoming apparent. The country's fertility rate was falling steadily and its population was rapidly aging. These demographic trends placed increasing financial pressure on the active, income-earning segment of the labor force to carry an increasing percentage of the older population (Usui 2003, 2005). Immigration helped ease these demographic pressures in other developed economies, but Japan resisted this option. Instead of adding foreign workers to put a brake on the shrinking working population, and to boost future economic growth, Japan turned to increasing the female labor force participation (Usui 2008). Policymakers have attempted to increase female labor force participation, but without lowering birthrates, by improving child-care and family leave options. They have done this by initiating a series of policies designed to maintain birthrates while increasing female involvement in the economic, political, and civil life of society (Usui and Palley 1997).

These demographic forces helped propel Japanese government initiatives, and provide a context within which to understand the unfolding multifaceted policies designed to eliminate barriers and provide opportunities and incentives

for increasing the female labor force participation. The strong impetus for the push for greater gender equality initially began during the United Nations Decade for Women (1976–1985). Japan ratified the United Nations Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) in 1980. Capitalizing on global momentum related to women's issues, the United Nations convened four major "World Conferences on Women." All these conferences had parallel forums, largely made up of non-governmental organizations (NGOs) and women activists throughout the world, held in conjunction with the official conferences. Marking the opening of the UN Decade for Women, the first conference was convened in Mexico City in 1975 followed by conferences in Copenhagen (1980), Nairobi (1985), and Beijing (1995). The 1995 Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing, convened, under the name "Action for Equality, Development, and Peace," was by far the largest and most influential, with 5,000 events and an estimated 50,000 women attending the NGO Forum alone.

The Beijing Declaration and the Platform for Action, considered the most progressive blueprint in history for advancing women's rights, was adopted by 189 countries, spelling out twelve "critical areas of concern," including women's empowerment in health, education, political participation, and employment (UN Women 2017). Although there has never been a conference since to match the scope, magnitude in numbers, or worldwide attention as Beijing, UN or otherwise, official delegates and thousands of women from NGOs returned home to work on a vigorous agenda to address the critical areas of concern. Smaller follow-up gatherings since Beijing to assess progress on behalf of the world's women have occurred at five and ten year intervals over the next two decades, the latest in New York in 2015 (Beijing Plus 20).

Japan's ratification of CEDAW in 1980 set the stage for national policy initiatives regarding gender equality. In 1985, Japan enacted the Equal

Employment Opportunity Law (EEOL), going into effect in 1986. The EEOL required companies “to make efforts” against gender discrimination in three major areas: recruitment and hiring, job assignment, and promotion. It heightened people’s awareness to discriminatory practices in the workforce and reduced overt discrimination, primarily in hiring and job assignment. However, in a pattern that would repeat itself over the next three decades, the law lacked legal obligations on employers. Thus meaningful changes in employment patterns regarding women did not materialize (Lam 1992; Gelb 2000).

Although the original EEOL did not successfully translate to significant changes in the labor force activities of women, it did generate greater awareness of gender discrimination in the Japanese workplace. Demographic realities may open the door for further changes to this picture. Japan enjoys the world’s longest life expectancy, but its low birth rate has aggravated challenges associated with population aging, population decline, and the shrinking size of the future labor force. Data show that the proportion of people age 65 and older accounted for 10.3 percent of the population in 1985. It increased to 17.1 percent by 2000, and to 26.6 percent by 2015 (National Institute of Population and Social Security Research 2017). More than one in four persons is older than 65 years of age. Japan is the world’s oldest society, with aging occurring at hyper speed, and is often described as sitting on a demographic time bomb.

Similar to the experience in other advanced countries, the birthrate in Japan began falling in the middle of the 1970s, and it became a serious social concern by the late 1980s. The total population peaked at 127.7 million in 2005, decreasing to 126.8 million by 2017 (Statistics Bureau of the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications 2017). The population is projected to shrink to 120.7 million by 2025, and population aging will continue. The percentage of people age 65 and older will increase from one-fourth in 2015, to one-third by 2025 (Ministry of Internal Affairs

Statistics Japan 2017). Women’s reproductive choices became the center of Japan’s “depopulation dilemma” and “hyper aging society” (Usui 2003). The problem of “depopulation” occurs when birthrates drop below the “replacement level” of 2.1 children per woman for an extended period of time. Many advanced countries have experienced below-replacement birthrates over the same period, but it is particularly severe in Japan.

With the expected shortage of the working age population and the future decline in national economic output, policy directions during the 1990s shifted to strategies to facilitate female labor force participation in greater numbers. Alongside the original target of EEOL, policymakers began to focus on the untapped supply of married women, emphasizing the importance of alleviating conflicts women face in combining work, family, and childcare. Instead of the male-breadwinner family model, policies focused on the importance of a husband’s participation in childcare and home responsibilities in an effort to lessen family burdens on employed mothers. The Childcare Leave Law, enacted in 1991, and the “Angel Plan,” introduced in 1995, provided the groundwork for the introduction of childcare leave for *both* parents, along with other support systems. The idea of childcare leave for both mothers and fathers was a radical departure from previous policies (Gender Equality Bureau Cabinet Office 2006). With initiatives from Japan’s Ministries, including Finance, Education, Science and Technology, and Health, Labour, and Welfare, they were in part responding to the 1995 Beijing Platform of Action to support new policies.

The Japanese government periodically reviews actual implementation, usually every five years, and the Childcare Leave Law and Angel Plan are revised accordingly. The original policy title “Angel Plan,” changed in 2004 to “Assisting Families and Children” (2004–2009), and in 2010, to “Visions for Childrearing.” Through these incremental processes, policymakers have addressed

shortcomings from previous initiatives, and revised the approaches for improving childcare needs and working conditions for both working mothers and fathers. For example, the benefit level was raised to 40 percent of worker's wages in 2001, 50 percent in 2009, and to 67 percent in 2014 (Oshima 2013; Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2014). In 2013, the maximum length of childcare leave was extended to 1.5 years in certain circumstances, and in 2016, up to 2 years (*Mainichi Daily News* 2016).

Policy makers expected that up to 80 percent of working mothers and 10 percent of working fathers would take advantage of the new parental support program. However, the use of such childcare leave by fathers did not increase, and in 2010, the Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare created the "Ikumen Campaign," to promote a "positive image" of men (*ikuji*) who were actively involved in childrearing (Hughes 2011).

Again, the influential 1995 Beijing Conference and Platform for Action that called for increases in female employment and promotion of women to leadership positions in business and government sectors, allows a backdrop for Japan's next key initiative on gender equality. In 1999, Japan put in place the "Basic Law for a Gender-Equal Society," to begin in 2000. The law banned gender discrimination in employment, and subsequent revisions prohibited indirect forms of discrimination in promotion, such as unfair treatment for reasons involving marriage, pregnancy, and childbirth. To demonstrate Japan's commitment to gender equality, in 2001 the Koizumi Administration established the cabinet level Gender Equality Bureau to facilitate the process, with the Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare tasked with implementation of the law (Gender Equality Bureau Cabinet Office 2006). Thus nearly two decades after Japan ratified CEDAW in 1980, Japan reached its full commitment to eradicate all forms of gender discrimination in the workplace (*Japan Times* 2006). The original Angel Plan and its subsequent revisions, and the Basic Law for a

Gender-Equal Society, all focused on women's conflict between work and family responsibilities by increasing the number of childcare facilities and facilitating paid childcare and family leave for men and women. The law acknowledged men's responsibilities in sharing childrearing and home responsibilities.

The adoption of the Basic Law for a Gender-Equal Society in 1999 paved the way for Japan's government to broaden initiatives on gender equality. Female leadership in corporate and government sectors was seen as a necessary step in such initiatives. In 2003, the Koizumi Administration announced the goal of increasing the number of women *senior* managers in government, in business sectors, and in elected offices, to 30 percent by 2020 (Ueno 2014; Hasunuma 2017). Since women occupied only one percent of senior positions in the private sector in 1985, and a paltry 1.6 percent almost two decades later in 2003, it was a very ambitious goal. Moreover, this target was going to be accompanied with the use of "positive actions," similar to the concept of affirmative action, involving preferential treatment of women under certain conditions (Cabinet Office 2011).

No one expected that Japan would reach this 30 target by 2020, but the continuous focus on gender equality, addition of women leaders, and improving work-family life balance, led to greater public awareness about how the society as a whole, and business practices in particular, need to change. The Koizumi Administration promoted studies on how best to strike a work-family life balance. It provided incentives to private companies to review their hiring, labor management, and promotion practices. It also attempted to provide support for women who opt out of work due to childcare and to elder-care responsibilities (Gender Equality Bureau Cabinet Office 2006: 22).

Prime Minister Shinzo Abe succeeded Junichiro Koizumi in 2006 and carried the torch for gender equality. Although he left his first term due to illness, he returned in 2012 and

began serving his second term. He introduced “Abenomics” to revitalize the economy with his “Three Arrows” model. The first arrow involved monetary policy, the second arrow, fiscal policy, and the third arrow, structural reform. Boosting the number of women in the workforce to counter future decline in economic output was the major component of the structural reform in his third arrow. Its focus on women became known as “womenomics” (Hasunuma 2017). The original policy goal included several impressive targets: a three year leave on the birth of a child; an increase in the number of childcare facilities so that no child would be on a waiting list; and the inclusion of at least one woman on the board of directors among large firms. The third arrow, therefore, explicitly connected gender to issues of employment, leadership, and family.

Women became the centerpiece for reviving the Japanese economy in Abe’s policy initiatives, and in March 2015 his administration developed a new slogan, translated to English as “Create a Society in Which All Women Shine.” In the same year, companies with more than 300 workers—there are about 15,000 in Japan—were legally required to set numerical targets for the promotion of women in senior management positions. He also declared at the 2015 World Assembly of Women (WAW) that Japan will expand a corporate culture that values working efficiently within a limited number of hours. Husbands will also actively take childcare leave, and couples will share responsibility for household chores and child rearing. This will be made the ordinary practice in Japan (Mizuno 2016).

Like earlier ambitious goals, however, reaching 30 percent of women in leadership positions in government, business, and political sectors by 2020 was unrealistic. In December 2015, the Abe Administration scaled down the target to 15 percent of section chief positions (middle-level management), and 7 percent of section chief positions in the national government bureaucracy (*Japan Times* 2016).

ASSESSING THE REAL CHANGES SINCE THE PASSAGE OF EEOL IN 1985

This review has focused on some major government initiatives designed to remove discriminatory practices in hiring and promotions in the workplace, and assessed how they have fared in facilitating more gender equal work-family life. Now we turn to the discussion of policy outcomes and new obstacles that emerged. Perhaps the biggest of those obstacles is the ongoing issue of female labor force participation.

There are several ways of assessing changes in the level of female labor force participation: the absolute number of women working; the number of women working expressed as a percentage of the female population, age 15 and over; and the number of women working expressed as a percentage of the female “productive” population, age 15 to 64. According to the first measure, the total number of women workers was 15.48 million in 1985, and 24.74 million in 2015, indicating an almost 60 percent increase over 30 years. As to the second measure, the number of working women expressed as the percentage of total female population age 15 and over for the same period, changes are less apparent, from 47.4 percent in 1985, to 48.0 percent in 2015. It is important to note, however, that this slight change reflects the demographic shift to the higher number of older women in the population as a whole.

The third measure, female labor force participation expressed as the percentage of the total number of productive-age women (age 15–64), shows marked increases over time, from 53.8 percent in 1985, 56.7 percent in 2000, and 64.6 percent in 2015. The largest increase occurred among women age 25 to 44: 56.5 percent of this group were in the workforce in 1985, but they increased to 71.6 percent by 2015 (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2015: 5). This dramatic increase is critical because it includes a large

swathe of the female population that is single and, whether married or not, of childbearing age.

As we have seen, the general employment rate among women has gone up sharply in Japan, but the leadership component of Abe's third arrow has stagnated. For example, women held about 10 percent of administrative and managerial positions (section chief and above) among companies that employ ten or more workers in 2009, and about 12 percent of such managerial positions in 2016 (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2016: 2). This recent figure is still far below the average level in other advanced countries. In 2014, for example, women accounted for almost one-third of managerial positions in Germany and just under half in the U.S. (Japan Institute for Labour Policy and Training 2016: 88).

Most telling, the rate of women occupying corporate leadership positions in Japan declines as company size increases. The 12 percent of middle and senior-level managerial positions women held in 2016 account for 5.4 percent of such positions among very large companies employing more than 5,000 workers; 4.2 percent among large companies with 1,000–4,999 workers; 4.8 percent among companies with 300–999 workers; 4 percent among companies with 100–299 worker; 13.7 percent among companies with 30–99 workers; and 22 percent among companies with 2029 workers (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2016: 2). With the “M-curve” of female employment holding steady, over 60 percent of women quit their jobs after their first childbirth, and thus become far removed from the promotion race. No large company will hire women workers (or men for that matter) in mid-career for career track positions. Women's problems are further compounded by Japan's male-centered corporate culture and practices that demand total commitment to work. For example, there is strong pressure not to take sick days or use paid leave if such leave puts extra burdens on their peers. Women with small children who violate such norms are seen as

“nuisances.” Many women on a career path find it impossible to take on work roles similar to their male colleagues, spend hours in commuting, and still meet childcare and family needs. A recent study of 1,000 women is instructive. Study subjects were the women on a career path who were hired by large firms in 1986, after the passage of EEOL. The study found that after 30 years, as of 2015, just 20 percent of the women prevailed in their career paths, while the remaining 80 percent had dropped out of the race long ago (*Japan Times* 2016).

It is important to reiterate that all these gender equality laws and governing policies designed to improve the work-family balance are not legally enforced, a pattern that continues to repeat itself over time. There are no formal penalties for companies failing the stated targets. Instead, Japan largely relies on monitoring, administrative guidance, and incentives. Abe's policies included a stronger monitoring mechanism to improve compliance from business leaders and employers. Companies with more than 300 employees are *legally* obliged to “report how they plan” to increase women in management positions, and set numerical targets to recruit women. As intended, most companies have rushed to comply and set targets. It is embarrassing to have a company's name revealed to the public, and to college students soon to be on the job market, as “unfriendly to women.” Many companies, however, especially larger ones, considered the target unrealistic. In 2014, the government offered grants of \$3,000US to small and medium size companies for training women managers for senior-level positions. This was also unsuccessful. No company applied for the training grant. In 2015, therefore, Prime Minister Abe announced revised targets, scaled down for women at the section chief level and above, for example, which called for women attaining 15 percent of these positions in businesses, 7 percent in the national government bureaucracy, and 15 percent in the local government bureaucracy (Aoki 2015; Gender Equality Bureau Cabinet Office 2015; Mollman 2015).

Are Japan's efforts to promote women leaders a dismal failure? It may be so. However, there are some encouraging new trends. Yuriko Koike, who became the first female governor of Tokyo in 2016, is a symbol of the shifting political landscape. A graduate of the University of Cairo, Japan's first defense chief, and the third woman who holds the governor's position in Japan, Koike is committed to mentoring and empowering women. Since she was elected, women's representation in the Tokyo Metropolitan Assembly (which holds 217 seats) increased from 19.7 percent to 28.3 percent (Aoki 2017). At this pace, Tokyo will be well on track to reach the 30 percent target by 2020.

In the area of childcare and family leave, there are some positive results. We have seen that over three decades, Japan's public policies for childcare and family leave became more generous. The percentage of women who took childcare leave increased over twenty percent between 2005 and 2015. Also, almost one-third (31.1 percent) of these women took between 10 to 12 months leave, with 27.6 percent taking between 12 to 18 months by 2015 (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2016: 11–12).

The rate for males taking family leave is still very low, but also shows a ten-year marginal increase. While only a tiny 0.1 percent of men who were eligible to take such leave actually took the leave in 2005, it increased to slightly over four percent in 2015, with about two-thirds taking it for five days or less. Altogether, those men who took the leave for less than one month accounted for 80 percent of *all* men who took childcare leave (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2016: 11–12). The recent Ikumen Campaign, encouraging men to take a more active part in childrearing, was a radical shift from traditional men's roles. Since it was introduced by the government (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare) in 2010, the campaign gained momentum with a new image of "guys" taking time from their work to spend more time with their wives and children. Although this is a small statistical

change, younger men appear to be adjusting themselves to the realities of the new economy. This is a marked departure from the traditional male role of their fathers.

As for new challenges, a sharp rise in postponement of marriage is perhaps one of the most important. In 1985, less than one-third of women age 25 to 29 remained single, but in 2015 slightly over 60 percent of women in the same age group remained single (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2015: 1–2). Young women's postponement of marriage is the direct cause of Japan's baby drought and shrinking population size. Women who remain single and postpone marriage may not get married at all. Delaying marriage, therefore, may also mean many women are making choices not to have children. Both the marriage rate and fertility rate continue to decline in Japan, and unlike other countries such as the U.S., nonmarital childbirth is less acceptable. Nonmarital childbirth in 2014 constituted 2.3 percent of all births in Japan, as compared to 40.7 percent in the U.S. (OECD 2014). Thus the pursuit of gender equality in the workplace since 1985, coupled with family-friendly policies to ease family-work conflicts, has not gone far enough to reverse trends hampering both declining birth rates and population aging. Young educated women no longer see marriage as the only option for a fulfilling life. Even those who are open to marriage know that family responsibilities will fall disproportionately on them, since men's work-driven corporate lifestyle hinders fathers from childcare responsibilities.

Regular Workers versus Nonregular Workers

It is perhaps ironic that more than half of the Japanese female workforce lives without the aforementioned benefits that were geared to promote gender equality and to reduce work-family conflict. In Japan, workers are divided into two broad categories: regular employees and nonregular

employees. Regular employees are those workers on a career path with job security, wage increases, promotion opportunities, and various benefits, including those for healthcare and pensions. Nonregular employees, largely comprised of those who are temporary, work part-time, or do contractual work, rarely receive such benefits. They do not receive employer-based pension and health benefits, which are more generous than national pension and health care options that are available to everyone in Japan. Nonregular women workers accounted for 56.3 percent of all women workers in 2015, as compared to 37.4 percent for men (Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2015: 9). Due to the challenges in solving work-family conflict, most married women enter nonregular temporary and part-time employment.

During Japan's economic boom of the 1970s and 1980s, the middle-class family ideal was the "salaryman," and his full-time housewife. Except for female business owners and women professionals, women working full time were doing so out of economic necessity. Married women who needed to bring supplemental income to the family worked part-time. In doing so, these women served to stabilize labor markets by moving in and out of the work force that paralleled changes in the economy. This pattern is similar to other well-off Asian nations, such as Taiwan and South Korea, where women serve as a temporary labor force to be called upon or discarded as needed. The post-WWII "salaryman" model, with a man employed in one company for his lifetime, has eroded in significant ways in Japan, but it continues to hold sway as the dominant male-breadwinner family model. Today's families increasingly need two incomes, but women are still bound by traditional role expectations over childcare. To make the matter more complex, the Japanese tax system conspires to relegate employed married women to secondary worker roles. It supports the male-breadwinner family model that disproportionately benefits full-time wives and women working part-time.

As dependents, they receive company-sponsored family benefits and are enrolled in employee pension and healthcare through their husbands for free (which is similar to spousal benefits for Social Security in the U.S.). If they switch to full-time work, they not only lose these entitlements, but they become responsible for their own income taxes, as well as the contributions to their employee pension and healthcare plans.

Coupled with the ongoing trend of postponing marriage and the rising number of employed women, one may expect an increase in the number of women in regular workforce. On the contrary, the number of women in the nonregular workforce increased, rather than decreased, accounting for over two-thirds of all working women (Japan Institute for Labour Policy and Training 2017). After the burst of Japan's bubble economy in 1989 and the even greater shock of the Asian financial crisis of 1997, Japan has weathered a series of prolonged recessions and low economic growth. Companies have steadily reduced the number of regular employees, increasingly relying on the nonregular workforce. In 2016, nonregular workers accounted for over one-third of the total workforce.

It is worth repeating that ongoing government initiatives to improve women's positions in the workplace hinge on how well these policies reduce gender inequality and facilitate the work-family life balance. One way to examine the impact of the Childcare Leave Law is to examine whether women's first childbirth changed, or did not change, their employment status. As we have seen, the "M-curve" trend in women's employment remains strong, with women withdrawing from the labor force with marriage and pregnancy. However, there have been some marginal changes to this trend. In 2001, over two-thirds of married working women withdrew from the labor force at the birth of their first child. In 2015, it was 62.1 percent (Cabinet Office 2015; Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare 2015). Table 8.1 shows the extent of changes in women's withdrawal from the labor force upon first childbirth in relation to their

Table 8.1 Percentage of women who took childcare leave by employment status and availability of childcare leave (Translated from Japanese)

<i>Employment Status</i>	<i>Year</i>	<i>Stopped Working due to Childbirth</i>	<i>Continued Working without Taking Leave</i>	<i>Continued Working while Taking Leave</i>
Regular Employee				
With companies providing childcare leave	Before 1998	39.30%	14.60%	46.10%
	1999–2004	32.70%	9.25%	58.20%
	after 2005	20.40%	3.70%	75.90%
Non-regular Employee				
without childcare leave	Before 1998	83.90%	16.10%	NA
	1999–2004	80.30%	16.20%	NA
	after 2005	57.60%	39.40%	NA

Note: Table is modified by author and translated from Japanese.

Source: Ministry of Health, Labour, and Welfare (2011).

employment status. The data are cross-tabulated with women's access to childcare leave and presented for three different time periods: before 1998, 1999–2004, and after 2005. Recall that 1999 is when the paid childcare leave policy went into effect in Japan.

The top row in Table 8.1 indicates that the percentage of women withdrawing from the labor force at childbirth has declined steadily over time, especially among women who are regular employees. The percentage of regular employee women quitting the job after childbirth was cut in half from approximately 40 percent before 1998, to 20.4 percent after 2005. In contrast, the percentage of these women who continued working by taking their company's childcare leave provisions increased from 46.1 percent before 1998, to 75.9 percent after 2005. These are positive signs since these are the women employed on a career path, and those who stay employed will have opportunities for career advancement. They are setting a new standard in work environments that have been inhospitable to women, especially related to pregnancy and childcare needs. According to one annual survey conducted in 2017, women still worry how they are viewed by their bosses and colleagues when they do take such childcare leave (*Japan Times* 2017).

Among nonregular employed women, data show that approximately 84 percent withdrew from the labor force at childbirth before 1998, but after 2005, this decreased to 57.6 percent. The percentage of nonregular employed women who continued working after childbirth more than doubled, from 16.1 percent before 1998, to 39.4 percent after 2005. Since these are the women without company-sponsored childcare leave provisions, the increase most likely reflects rising economic needs among families. To improve work-family balance, but also in light of Japan's challenging labor force trends, policies should target these nonregular women, not just those women who are in the regular employee workforce.

GENDER EQUALITY IN JAPAN COMPARED TO OTHER ADVANCED COUNTRIES

Japan's progress in gender equality over time may be increasing, but it is seemingly too little, largely because of entrenched cultural and structural norms that obstruct such progress in multiple facets of life. One method of measuring progress

on gender equality in the workplace is to “benchmark” changes in different areas related to female equality in Japanese society, against such changes in other advanced economies. Given the uniqueness of gender circumstances in each country, this benchmarking comparison offers standardization from which to assess Japan’s progress in implementing gender equality in the workplace more broadly, and more precisely. Thus, whether Japan’s ten percent increase in female employment between 1985 and 2015, for example, can be considered successful in terms of gender equality, the rate needs to be benchmarked against employment trends in other developed countries during the same period.

Data for 2000–2015 suggest that women’s employment rate has gradually increased in most northern European countries, especially in Scandinavia (OECD 2017). The overall average female employment rate (age 15–64) in 2015, was approximately 73 percent for these countries, compared to 64.6 percent in Japan. It is instructive to note Japan’s position relative to the United States. The female employment rate in the U.S.

has steadily declined from 67.8 percent in 2000, to 63.4 percent in 2015, with the U.S. as the only advanced country in this comparison group showing this trend. Women have high employment rates among leading OECD countries such as Germany (69.9), Sweden (74.0), Canada (74.2), and Ireland (81.8). These trends suggest that it is maybe realistic for Japan to set the next target to 75 percent, by furthering improvements to women’s working conditions and their access to family-friendly policies.

We will finish this chapter by looking at the World Economic Forum’s (WEF) *Global Gender Gap Report* that measures and ranks countries on gender disparities, and also puts these figures into perspective. Since 2006, this WEF report measures gender equality in terms of four key dimensions: economic participation and opportunities; educational attainment; health and survival; and political empowerment. The report offers greater awareness about existing gender gaps across countries, and also alerts policy-makers to women’s positions in a cross-national perspective (World Economic Forum 2016: 4).

Table 8.2 Global gender equality ranking for selected countries

<i>Country^a</i>	<i>Overall Rank</i>	<i>Economic</i>	<i>Educational</i>	<i>Health</i>	<i>Political</i>
Iceland	1 (.874)	9 (.806)	1 (1.00)	104 (.970)	1 (.719)
Finland	2 (.845)	16 (.794)	1 (1.00)	1 (.990)	2 (.607)
Norway	3 (.842)	7 (.818)	28 (1.00)	68 (.974)	3 (.576)
Sweden	4 (.815)	11 (.802)	36 (.999)	69 (.974)	6 (.486)
Ireland	6 (.797)	49 (.709)	1 (1.00)	54 (.979)	5 (.502)
Germany	13 (.766)	57 (.691)	100 (.906)	54 (.979)	10 (.428)
France	17 (.755)	64 (.676)	1 (1.00)	1 (.980)	19 (.365)
Denmark	19 (.754)	34 (.735)	1 (1.00)	106 (.970)	29 (.309)
U.K.	20 (.752)	53 (.700)	34 (.999)	64 (.974)	24 (.335)
Canada	35 (.731)	36 (.732)	1 (1.00)	108 (.969)	49 (.222)
U.S.	45 (.720)	26 (.752)	1 (1.00)	62 (.975)	73 (.162)
Italy	50 (.719)	117 (.574)	56 (.995)	72 (.974)	25 (.331)
China	99 (.676)	81 (.656)	99 (.967)	144 (.919)	74 (.162)
Japan	111 (.660)	118 (.569)	76 (.990)	40 (.979)	103 (.103)
South Korea	116 (.649)	123 (.537)	102 (.964)	76 (.973)	92 (.120)

Note: Index ranges from 0 to 1, with 1 indicating full gender equality.

Source: World Economic Forum (2016).

Of concern in this chapter, the index of gender disparities for economic participation and opportunities is measured by several key variables expressed as male-to-female ratios. These ratios include variables for labor force participation, wage equality for similar work, estimated earned income, and leading positions. Linked to economic participation and leadership, is the gender gap in political empowerment measured by ratios for seats in parliament, ministerial level positions, and heads of state in the last 50 years.

This broader set of equity gap measures and its comparison to advanced, mid-level, and developing countries, reveals a disappointingly weak report card on issues of equity in Japan. Using the 2016 *Global Gender Gap Report*, Table 8.2 summarizes data from selected countries out of 144 included in the full report. Scores range from 0 to 1. The closer the score is to 1, the closer the attribute measured is to gender equality. As expected, Scandinavian countries continue to rank the highest on overall gender equity, a consistent pattern for at least three decades. Although Japan's health and survival dimension in the index is strong, it is not enough to offset the large gender disparities in other dimensions, specifically the economic dimension. Japan's low rank of 118 out of 144 countries on gender equity, does not compare favorably to other richer nations. Japan actually slipped in rank over the last decade, from 79 in 2006, to 94 in 2010, to its current place at 111. This ranking gives pause to optimism.

CONCLUSION

In reviewing three decades of policies in Japan designed to promote gender equality, this chapter identified some of the obstacles to meaningful progress. Yet, to understand the progress, or lack thereof, more context is needed. During the past three decades, government policies have offered ambitious "gender-friendly" goals for employed women. Major drivers of these policy

responses include international pressure, foreign diplomacy, future economic concerns, and perhaps most important, the reality of demographic challenges that overlaps all the others. These circumstances offered various paths for government policies to enhance gender equity. Policies in certain areas appear to have made some steady progress, particularly in terms of increases in female labor force participation and in corporate and government leadership. Recall, too, that female employment in Japan is now slightly higher than that of the U.S., a fact that *does* give an opportunity to reflect, for those who hold overly pessimistic views about Japan, when it comes to women's issues in general, and gender equity in particular. Koike became the first governor of Tokyo in 2016, and women occupy over 28 percent of the Tokyo Metropolitan Assembly. However, multiple indicators of gender equality presented in this chapter show the depth of institutional challenges. Some of the government goals were overly optimistic, for example, since they were without sufficient public-private coordination for aiding in goal attainment.

Japanese policies to date—both government and corporate—show ambiguous capacity for achieving gender equality and solving fundamental conflicts between work and family life. Japan tends to adopt a "gradualist" strategy that meshes with Japanese culture and values. This strategy interlocks with a policy structure and cultural norms that resist quick solutions to solving problems such as gender inequality. For those women in the regular employee workforce, corporate culture still resists their full integration as equal partners in the workplace. There is a serious lack of policy coordination and enforcement to help women achieve this balance. For those women in the nonregular workforce, government policies have not effectively addressed the unique challenges they face. It is perhaps ironic that the jobs *are* economically and socially practical, since these very jobs serve to absorb the ebb and flow of an expanding and contracting economy.

Women's choices to delay marriage and child-birth have reverberated throughout Japan. Policy-makers clearly understand that women are the conduits to defuse the demographic time bomb. Given the seriousness of Japan's demographic challenges, and capitalizing on the lessons learned over the last three decades, this chapter offers hints for future policies that hopefully will address the gendered realities of the work-family balance issue in more meaningful ways.

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Chapter nine

Addressing Women's Health through Economic Opportunity Lessons from Women Engaged in Sex Work in Mongolia

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INTRODUCTION

In our previous research, we reflected on the traditional ideologies regarding the identity of Mongolian women, and in particular, how women engaged in sex work were perceived (Carlson et al. 2015). In this chapter, we revisit that concept with an eye toward health status as it relates to the economic, social, and political transition of Mongolia since its independence in 1992. Women's place in Mongolian society is complex. On the one hand, the post-communist *conservative nationalist ideology* emphasizes expectations and conceptions of women as reproductive and family-oriented, which contrasts with the *civic nationalist ideology* that views women as highly-educated, professional, and independent, and that takes great pride in the promotion of women in civil society and government since transition to a free-market economy. Civic nationalists view Mongolia as distinct from other Asian countries, recalling with great pride the long history of Mongolian women's gender equality and women's rights. Tumursukh (2001) has argued that the conservative nationalist ideology, on the other hand, further defines women's sexuality by subscribing to the patriarchal tradition suggesting

that one's father must be of Mongol blood to be considered ethnically Mongolian. Thus, according to Tumursukh (2001), Mongolian women's sexuality manifests national importance in preserving Mongolian ethnicity and culture. Such beliefs are often threatened, and thus intensified by globalization resulting from the growing economy and foreign investment, particularly threats from Russia and China. For Mongolian women, and especially for those engaged in sex work, these perspectives are in constant flux, contradiction, and negotiation (Carlson et al. 2015). Because Mongolians cannot regulate women's sexuality in accordance with conservatism through formal, political mechanisms without contradicting their self-image as progressives upholding human rights, control of women's sexuality occurs through informal mechanisms of social norms, the media, and the family (Tumursukh 2001), including exclusion from certain types of employment and income-generating opportunities, and we argue, all forms of interpersonal violence. In this chapter, we examine the pressures that political and economic transition in Mongolia exert on the female population as well as the critical link between economic opportunity and health, as highlighted by a savings-led microfinance intervention.

HISTORICAL, SOCIO-POLITICAL, AND ECONOMIC CONTEXT

Historically, Mongolian women played such important economic roles in the pastoral households that they enjoyed rights generally inaccessible to women in other parts of Asia. They offered a critical role in caring for family and livestock, allowing men to go off to war and return with continuity and stability in the economy (Rossabi 2005). While not always positive, Mongolia's establishment of a socialist society in the early 1920s, and increasingly close alignment with the Soviet Union, brought increased access to education, health care, and equal rights within the law for Mongolian women (Robinson and Solongo 2000). At the point of transition to a market economy in the early 1990s, women were highly educated due to former Soviet-style education policies, were highly engaged in the workforce, and enjoyed access to medical care at minimal or no cost. Further, government support for needy groups, including children and the elderly, relieved working women of additional demanding responsibilities related to their role as primary caregivers (Rossabi 2005).

Situated between China and Russia, Mongolia, with a population of almost 3 million, maintained seven decades of Communist rule before adopting a new constitution and transitioning to a multi-party representative government in 1992. Growing pains resulting from its newly minted democratic constitution and free-market economy saw nearly one-third of the population still struggling below the poverty line twenty years later (UNDP 2011b). These changes have been particularly devastating to the female population. The transition period brought state cutbacks in funding, which led to great instability in social services, education, healthcare access, and pensions (Rossabi 2005). As property became privatized, women were held at the fringe while property titles were distributed to male household

members (Robinson and Solongo 2000). Economic policy, based on Western models favoring trickle-down approaches to job creation at the expense of funding for social welfare, failed to slow growing poverty rates, and in-migration from rural areas to the capital city in search of food or jobs increased pollution and public health hazards due to inadequate infrastructure (Rossabi 2005). State sector employment decreased, state entitlements diminished, and women faced the challenges of obtaining employment in the formal sector while primarily shouldering family caregiving responsibilities (Burn and Oidov 2001). Accustomed to the role of heading households, and without legal employment options, more women became engaged in sex work (NAF 2001, 2003).

In 2009, the World Bank included Mongolia among the 33 countries where women were most significantly and disproportionately affected by economic crisis (World Bank 2009). Economic challenges exacerbated women's extant struggles related to Mongolia's political transition. Unpaid work such as childcare and housework typically still fell to women, and their purchasing power lagged behind that of men (UNICEF 2009). Meanwhile, women struggled to make their voices heard in the political arena, as men held most leadership positions in local government, and prior to the 2012 elections, women held only 3.9 percent of the positions in Parliament (UNDP 2011b). With the 2012 general elections came an increase in women's representation in Parliament to 14.5 percent, a figure that ranked well below the world average of 21.9 percent. As such, the new ruling party set a quota of no less than 25 percent representation of women by 2016 (Bayarsaikhan 2016), and this movement toward greater representation joined formal illegality of gender discrimination as a point of national pride and an essential element of the push for Mongolia to gain greater acceptance in the global community (Tumursukh 2001).

By 2012, the Mongolian economy had become one of the fastest-growing in the world because

of its booming mining industry and an influx of foreign investment (World Bank 2012). Yet, the financial gains from this mining boom benefited only a small proportion of the population, creating massive economic inequality (Isakova et al. 2012). Furthermore, by 2016, the economic optimism had faded with the global economic downturn and political and economic losses, and the Mongolian economy was suffering an extraordinary fiscal crisis (Riley 2016).

ECONOMIC TRANSITION AND THE IMPACT ON MONGOLIAN WOMEN'S HEALTH AND WELL-BEING

Major shifts in the Mongolian political and economic systems since the beginning of the period of political and economic transition created opportunity but also shifted burdens on women who, as they worked toward equality also faced significant health-related challenges, such as intimate partner violence, sexually transmitted infections, and alcohol dependence. More specifically, along with these rapid economic and systemic changes, Mongolia saw growing rates of alcoholism, eroding health and social services, and increased migration of workers through and outside the country (NAF 2003). Combined with women's increased participation in sex work for survival income, the stage had been set for higher rates of sexually transmitted infections (STIs). More Mongolians were afflicted by an STI than any other type of communicable disease (UNGASS 2010), and infection rates were just as high in the general population (Amindavaa et al. 2005) as among samples of women engaged in sex work and STI patients (Ebright et al. 2003; Garland et al. 2001; NAF 2001; Tellez et al. 2002). Furthermore, being under the influence of alcohol increased the risk for contracting STIs, including HIV (Cook and Clark 2005; Weinhardt and Carey 2000).

Women who engaged in sex work were at especially high risk of STI and HIV infection (Campbell 2000; Côté et al. 2004; Wechsberg et al. 2004), in part because of forgoing condom use as a way to receive higher payment or as a result of trust between themselves and their regular paying partners (Le et al. 2010; Murray et al. 2007). Alcohol, too, was a factor; as many as 60 percent of Mongolian women engaged in sex work reported alcohol abuse as a primary reason for non-condom use (NAF 2001, 2003). Economic, social, and gender inequalities made it difficult for all women, not just those who engaged in sex work, to persuade male partners to use condoms (Dworkin and Ehrhardt 2007; Hagan and Dulmaa 2007; Witte et al. 2000). Nonetheless, and quite strikingly, HIV prevalence in Mongolia remained historically *low* even while predictors of HIV infection—including poverty, migration, rates of sexually transmitted infections in the general population, disproportionate unemployment among women, alcohol use and social isolation—were especially *high*.

Sex work remains illegal in Mongolia, according to the 1998 Mongolian Law against Pornography and Prostitution that banned the organization and facilitation of prostitution (Carlson et al. 2015). Despite this law, it is estimated that at least 4,000 commercial sex workers—primarily women—operate in the capital city, Ulaanbaatar (UNICEF 2009), with the number of women engaging in sex work in Mongolia fluctuating seasonally, as many women engage in sex work only during the warmer summer months (Carlson et al. 2015).

Disproportionate unemployment among Mongolian women (Skapa and Benwell 1996) has meant that more women have engaged in sex work for survival, and their clients represent a key bridge population to a more generalized HIV epidemic (National Committee on HIV/AIDS 2010; UNGASS 2010). Although Mongolia recently formally transitioned to an upper middle-income country, its low-income

to middle-income problems persist. For example, employment remains low and health and social services still lag. Growing awareness that individually focused HIV interventions for women are severely limited by such social and structural factors has led to an increase in interventions that attempt to address such factors (Dworkin and Ehrhardt 2007). Women who engage in sex work as a primary source of income, for example, tend to find economic need more pressing than concerns about longer-term health consequences. Therefore, Mongolia is a particularly important location in which to test health-related interventions that may offer the secondary benefit of increasing sources of income for women. Thus, we collaborated in a planning study among women engaged in sex work to develop and test a culturally informed, gender-specific intervention (Witte et al. 2010), which ultimately led to a larger clinical trial and further pilot work culminating in an integrated health-related intervention that included *elements of microfinance*.

A PERSPECTIVE ON WOMEN'S HEALTH IN MONGOLIA

Even as ideals toward democracy and universal human rights burgeon within Mongolia, firm definitions of traditional family roles and an emphasis on preserving the Mongolian gene pool remain not just in hearts and minds but written into official documents. Where bloodlines are held out for considerations of purity, true global perspectives can only lag. Still, as borders open and the socialist economy fades away, so do the structural mechanisms that long dictated female sexual and reproductive behavior (Tumursukh 2001). Using maternal mortality as a marker of women's health and status, Mongolia has lagged but made recent gains. During socialist rule, when healthcare access was strong, pronatalist policies and related lack

of contraception caused increases in maternal mortality (Rossabi 2005). High maternal mortality persisted post-transition, but by 2016, Mongolia was among a handful of countries experiencing dramatic declines in maternal mortality, surpassing United Nations Millennium Development Goals (Alkema et al. 2016). Nevertheless, Mongolian women still suffer a bottom-tier breast cancer survival rate: 57 percent, compared with the more than 80 percent survival rate enjoyed by women in wealthier countries (Ginsburg et al. 2017).

As elsewhere, globalization, rapid development, and social change have brought new complications to life in Mongolia. Women's health has seen some gains, but considerable gaps in service persist and are exacerbated by slow change in social norms related to women's relative safety. In this chapter, we use the lens of women engaged in sex work because their well-being is closely linked to globalization and economic changes rippling through Mongolia. Indeed, this marginalized segment of society illustrates challenges that also confront the general population of Mongolian women who face these same health issues, especially sexually transmitted infections (STIs), gender-based interpersonal violence, and alcohol use.

VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN

Violence linked to economic issues and to gender inequality is a far-reaching problem that creates some health issues and exacerbates other health issues. As such, violence presents an especially complicated obstacle for a society in transition, such as Mongolia. Indeed, gender-based violence remains a significant health issue for women in Mongolia. Widespread and hidden from public view, gender-based violence is a reality for more than one-third of Mongolian women. A previous study of 5,500 people in 1,000 households randomly selected from two

districts of Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, found that 37.7 percent of respondents reported having been affected by some type of domestic violence during the previous 6 months; 17.9 percent of all respondents reported physical violence, 21.9 percent reported emotional violence, 10 percent reported sexual abuse, and 6.9 percent reported financial violence. Women with only a primary education were more likely to experience such violence, as were those with low income who lived in rented homes and/or with a partner who was unemployed and used alcohol. Thus, greater employment for men, which would lessen poverty and alcohol abuse, was identified as a means to reducing intimate partner violence (Oyunbileg et al. 2009).

Furthermore, intimate partner violence in Mongolia exacerbates and is often accompanied by a myriad of health conditions. Indeed, previous research found that physical abuse in the home was among the variables most strongly associated with maternal depression (Pollock et al. 2009), and studies of women in their childbearing years have indicated that intimate partner violence is among the top three health concerns (Takehara et al. 2016), and is both a cause of health issues and a barrier to health care. Among women engaged in sex work, rates of violence are even higher and come not just from intimate partners but also from paying partners, police, and others. Indeed, rates of violence by intimate partners against women who engage in sex work are more than double the rates for women in the general population. Fifty-nine percent of women reported experiencing physical violence, and 22 percent reported experiencing sexual violence from an intimate partner (Oyunbileg et al. 2009; Parcesepe et al. 2015). Traditional values whereby domestic violence is accepted as a justified matter, or at least a private matter, may contribute to the problem (Billé 2014) as may the stigma of engaging in sex work and alcohol use.

Notably, where greater financial stress exists, so does increased violence from intimate partners.

For these women, earning an income from sex work may provide a means by which to escape or avoid violent relationships. Yet, given the statistics related to violence and sex work, turning to sex work to escape one violent relationship may be the start of a vicious cycle wherein slight material gains coincide with increased physical harm.

It is also notable that many women engaged in sex work have a history of childhood sexual abuse and violence. For example, one study of sex workers in Mongolia revealed that 55 percent of the women had experienced some form of childhood sexual abuse. As adults, women experienced the most violence from paying partners, as 84 percent of the women experienced physical violence and 52 percent experienced sexual violence (Parcesepe et al. 2015). Options for relief do exist but remain weak. Efforts to address intimate partner violence began with passage of legislation more than a decade ago, however accountability and structural support for ensuring the implementation of such legislation has been difficult (Jones 2006). Stigma and shame associated with sex work keep women isolated, erode their health and safety, and inhibit them from trusting the law or justice systems. In fact, women who engage in sex work sometimes find little or no protection from police and, instead, sometimes are placed in detention or are victims of gender-based violence by the police (Witte 2014).

WOMEN'S WELLNESS PROJECT

In addition to confronting violence, Mongolian women engaged in sex work also face significant health issues. More specifically, an effort to address women's health through prevention of HIV and STI transmission, alcohol abuse, and intimate partner violence culminated in the Mongolia Women's Wellness Project beginning in 2007. Through this project, we developed a

research agenda to begin testing locally adapted and culturally compatible interventions aimed at reducing HIV risk and harmful alcohol use among women engaged in sex work (Witte et al. 2010, 2011). The Women's Wellness intervention project resulted from and was tested by a collaborative team of researchers from Mongolia and from the United States between 2008 and 2010. As the first behavioral clinical trial of an intervention addressing both HIV/STI prevention and reduction of alcohol use in Mongolia, the study examined the efficacy of a combined sexual risk reduction and motivational interviewing intervention on reducing sexual risk among alcohol-dependent women who exchange sex for money or goods.

Our early work generated important insights and successes related to feasibility and implementation of a behavioral change program with these highly stigmatized and vulnerable Mongolian women. We successfully demonstrated the ability to reduce HIV risk behaviors and harmful alcohol use among women engaged in sex work (Witte et al. 2011). We learned that an HIV risk reduction program could be implemented at relatively low cost. The research team was able to recruit hundreds of women engaged in sex work and to successfully enroll these women over time, while also maintaining them in the study. Attendance in the study was very high as 88 percent of the women in the study attended all the intervention sessions and completed a six-month follow-up assessment. And in a satisfaction survey completed by all participants, 92 percent positively endorsed the program experience. Further, by integrating activities related to reducing exposure to violence in women's lives, we demonstrated reductions in violence experienced by women in both their intimate and paying partnerships, during and following the intervention sessions (Carlson et al. 2012). These findings highlight the importance of integrating and combining intimate partner violence prevention with more general health-related issues among women.

SAVINGS-LED MICROFINANCE FOR INCOME-GENERATION AND HIV PREVENTION

Ultimately, our previous research pointed to a theoretical framework that is now commonly recognized in the field of global health: namely, that poverty, gender inequity, and violence are among the social factors responsible for most health inequities. From the narratives of women engaged in sex work and their data from our HIV prevention studies, we found significant interest in, and subsequent use of, HIV prevention programs. These women also told us clearly that what they truly wanted was *not to manage risk* but rather to have *options for income-generation that would not be detrimental to their health and well-being*. They recognized the dilemma of risk-taking and health compromises in order to support themselves, their dependent children, and their parents but were unable to find alternatives. In a series of focus groups after the Women's Wellness studies, women expressed these concerns and were clear and intentional in requests for programs and projects that were more innovative and included diversified income-generating options.

Microfinance programs constitute one of the major strategies to address poverty in developing countries. Microfinance is defined broadly as financial information and services provided to low-income individuals. More specifically, *microloans* or *microcredit* refer to small loans given to people who are otherwise unable to borrow money. *Microenterprise* refers to the building of a small business, in this case begun with a microloan/microfinance. *Microsavings* initiatives, in turn, allow low-income clients to create and maintain a savings account by reducing barriers such as minimum opening amounts and required balances (Armendáriz and Morduch 2010). Some controversy remains regarding the success of microfinance at reducing poverty among some groups and in some regions (Banerjee et al. 2015).

However, a systematic review of combined microfinance and HIV prevention programs showed that income-generating interventions may lead to reductions in sexual and/or drug-risk behaviors among women engaged in sex work (Cui et al. 2013). And a number of studies in other countries have demonstrated that microfinance improves sexual risk outcomes among women engaged in sex work (Kim et al. 2008; Odek et al. 2009; Sherman et al. 2010).

Microcredit and microloan programs can pose important limitations, however, for poor women who experience intersectional marginalization due to their sex work, alcohol or drug use, and associated stigma (Mayoux 1999). Microloans by themselves, whether usurious loans from money lenders or subsidized microcredit loans by non-governmental organizations (NGOs), represent “saving down,” which may keep women in a vicious cycle of debt and poverty, making it impossible for them to reduce their reliance on sex work and thus further expose them to violence and to HIV/STI risks.

Though microfinance has been one of the leading poverty-reduction strategies in Mongolia (UNDP 2011a), no microfinance programs specifically targeted Mongolian women engaging in sex work, a highly marginalized and hard-to-reach population. At the urging of the women in our program—and with their input through interviews and focus groups—we developed and tested a savings-led microfinance approach to HIV prevention—the *Undarga intervention*—which built on extant literature and the Women’s Wellness pilot work (Tsai et al. 2011; Witte et al. 2011). *Undarga*, which in Mongolian literally means “natural spring or fountain,” carries the figurative connotation of being a source of good things.

As a pilot program, *Undarga* consisted of financial literacy sessions, business development trainings, and industry-specific group mentorship and support designed to assist women in implementing lessons learned in the trainings. A final and key component was a matched savings program. For the duration of the intervention period, a woman

who made a deposit into her savings account received a matched amount in a parallel bank account kept on her behalf from which she could withdraw funds for business development or vocational education. Participants were compensated financially for attending each of the training sessions, at the end of which they could have built sufficient matched savings to enter vocational training or start a small business if they saved payments from training participation.

Findings from this pilot project demonstrated the feasibility of a savings-led microfinance intervention with an HIV sexual risk reduction program for women. Women participants indicated that the pilot program helped build confidence in their ability to manage finances and gave them hope for pursuing their short-term and long-term goals. Women demonstrated moderate knowledge gains in banking services, savings, financial negotiations, and small business development. Through their own initiative, at least five participants reduced their hours in sex work to pursue alternative employment, to undertake vocational training, or to start a small business (Tsai et al. 2011).

Following the successful pilot program, we were funded to implement a full trial to test the combination of microfinance and HIV risk reduction intervention. This trial was novel in that it incorporated a savings-based approach to microfinance, enabling participants to build assets faster and to pay for life-cycle events without accumulating debt or fostering an over-reliance on microloans. Further, savings accounts and matched savings accounts were established in each woman’s name to give her control over accessible economic resources. As such, we hypothesized that increasing financial literacy, business development knowledge and skills, and personal savings would lead to more significant reductions in sexual risk behaviors compared to a sexual risk reduction intervention alone (Witte et al. 2015).

As part of this trial, we examined for the first time the financial lives of 240 Mongolian women engaged in sex work (Tsai et al. 2013). What we

found was not surprising: Most women were the primary financial providers for their households and relied on an array of earning strategies to provide for themselves and other dependents, with sex work often constituting the primary household income source. Many of the women participating in this study had experienced various difficulties associated with the transition from a socialist to a market economy. These women had obtained high levels of education during the era of the socialist economy and reported high financial self-efficacy. Yet, with the emergence of the market economy, 63 percent of the women had entered sex work due to financial difficulties or family financial crises, usually because they were unable to find other kinds of employment. The devastating economic changes in Mongolia since the early 1990s have had a disproportionately adverse impact on women, as noted earlier in this chapter.

Like women throughout Mongolian history, the women in our study demonstrated great resilience while balancing numerous financial, personal, familial and health challenges. Few women reported having savings, and more than half reported having debt, primarily store credit and debt from moneylenders. Most women were the primary income earners in their households, and they indicated that their main partners and spouses faced their own difficulties obtaining i. e., employment, used alcohol to to an extent that interfered with their ability to earn, and/or used their limited financial resources to support others outside the women's households (such as extended family networks, multiple trust partners, and/or their own children). Many women expressed clarity of purpose in their need to engage in sex work despite the stigma and dangers. As one woman summarized: *"There is no other option. We have to feed our families . . . who else would do it?"* (Tsai et al. 2013). Indeed, high levels of financial responsibility for household welfare, when combined with low reported savings, debt, higher payments offered for sex without a condom, and high levels of harmful alcohol

use, may heighten women's risk for HIV and other STIs.

Women participating in the *Undarga* program who were assigned to the microfinance program experienced better health outcomes. First, they demonstrated significantly greater reductions in the number of paying sexual partners, as well as fewer sexual partners at the six-month follow-up. Furthermore, women in the microfinance program were more likely to report no unprotected sex over the past three months at the six-month follow-up (Witte et al. 2015). When asked in a focus group about what has changed in her life since participating in the study, one woman said:

A lot, a lot! First of all, emotionally, I am stable. And we all feel this way. Emotionally we are a level up. Self-confidence has increased because before at home I would be afraid of everyone and everything, but now even knowing that I can start my business at home, makes me feel so much more confident. It feels like a step up in security of our life.

In addition to these health improvement outcomes, women also experienced positive economic outcomes. The study found significant reductions in women's percentage of income from sex work, increased odds of women reporting no income from sex work, and increased odds that sex work was not their main source of income. Women showed no significant changes in their personal or household income, thereby assuring us that there was no loss of income but rather overall a shift in income sources. Thus, this study reinforced the critical importance of interventions targeting the economic structures that influence risk among women engaged in sex work (Tsai et al. 2015).

While shifts in women's income occurred, not all were able to stop engaging in sex work completely. One woman explained:

Going out is less now than before . . . Itchka and others are doing the vocational training so they say that they have no time anymore to do sex work

because after the training they have to run home. But I will be honest and say that when a few clients call me I will also go to make some money in order to buy some of the fabric and materials in order to keep my business going.

Unique to this study in Mongolia, however, was the demonstration that sexual risk reductions resulted from (1) a matched savings program for asset-building paired with (2) financial literacy and small business development. Achieving these outcomes without the incorporation of a microloan component, often risky for economically vulnerable women, was an important finding. Further, the study demonstrated the feasibility of incorporating a savings-led approach among women engaged in sex work.

A concern, in the microfinance literature, is the risk for increased violence against women where interventions increase their economic independence (Vyas and Watts 2009). No adverse events were reported during the *Undarga* study related to increases in violence associated with an accumulation of assets or participation in a microfinance program. Furthermore, we compared reports of violence against women by paying partners before and after participation in the project. Findings revealed significant reductions over time in both conditions for overall, sexual, and physical paying partner violence. No significant differences between groups were found, suggesting that microsavings participation did not significantly impact women's risk for violence (Tsai et al. 2016).

EMPLOYMENT AND NEW BUSINESS START-UP

At least 25 women participating in the *Undarga* project reported gaining employment during the project, including jobs such as receptionist, housekeeper, tutor, customer service, and sales. Women were connected with employment through friends, family, and newspaper ads. Seven women

reported that the most notable challenge regarding employment was that they were told that they were too old for the job. A number of women also reported that they believed their physical appearance and the fact that they did not have adequate identification paperwork impeded employment. Others mentioned challenges that they faced due to a lack of required certification in a vocation related to a position or lack of work experience in general.

In turn, more than one-third of the women participating in the *Undarga* microfinance program reported that they “*tried to start a business since joining Undarga.*” Twenty-two women described businesses in a range of vocational domains. The most frequently noted type of business was sewing of traditional dresses, children's clothing, factory worker gloves, or small tailoring. Two women reported selling cigarettes, gum, and candy, and two other women sold plants for herbs and medicinal purposes. Other businesses reported included clothing repair, selling of secondhand shoes from Germany, selling traditional Korean snacks along with clothing repair, running a public bath, opening a DVD rental store, hairdressing, farming sheep, farming pigs, purchasing a small kiosk for sales, and purchasing a cafeteria to operate. To our knowledge, all of these businesses were considered legal and followed related local or national regulations. Business start-up was challenging in a number of ways, however, as expressed by this woman:

... from our classes we have learned that for the first several months we will not have sufficient income. This gives us patience for moving forward ... if I did not anticipate this I would probably be so very disappointed and frustrated with myself so I could not keep going.

Thus, most of the types of businesses women started were more traditionally female-dominated and low-paying businesses. The longstanding nationalist ideology that discourages the professional advancement of women and holds them to domestic and

reproductive roles continues to influence or determine these choices. As such, vocational training or programs to prepare women to participate in more traditionally male-dominated businesses ultimately might be more empowering for women and provide a more competitive income alternative to sex work.

When asked what would improve such programs and increase their sustainability in Mongolia, women in *Undarga* shared concerns related more to expanding access and ensuring structured support and less to concerns regarding male-dominated or female-dominated industry. This is reflected in the following comments from three different women:

Woman 1: Should expand your activities to cover more women. Women sell their bodies not because they like it but because of hardship in their lives.

Woman 2: Provide these sessions to high school students and also provide business training and financial literacy for women who are heads of households. Conduct these sessions in collaboration with vocational training agencies.

Woman 3: Provide a service for getting a job and afterwards monitor women to see if they do or do not get the job and assess needed improvements. I believe that if you will monitor based on more regular meetings, counseling, giving your heart, then it will be overall more effective.

CONCLUSION

Combining interventions that may simultaneously improve health outcomes while enhancing choices for income-generation or employment is important in countries like Mongolia that still struggle with high rates of poverty, economic instability, and lack of health and social services for the most needy. Our research in Mongolia has

demonstrated that a savings-led microfinance-based intervention aimed at providing alternative means of income-generation can also provide health benefits and increase the overall well-being of Mongolian women engaged in sex work.

On a final note, we recognize that the decisions of Mongolian women to enter sex work are often personal choices, based on a rational strategy as they confront social and economic inequities. Our microfinance-based intervention targets sexual risk reduction by shifting women's income from sex work to alternative income-generation and is intended to be implemented with women who are motivated to make such a transition so that they may reduce their risk for HIV and other STIs. Further, we note that even when a country's transitional economy struggles to provide access to healthcare and social services, as is the case in Mongolia, women can benefit from low-impact interventions. Within great challenges to health and well-being lie opportunities to empower even marginalized factions, such as women engaged in sex work, so as to reduce their health risks and to better provide for themselves and their families in spite of cultural and economic factors that impede their efforts toward greater income-generation. Many women throughout the world confront health concerns, gender-based violence, and cultural restrictions that reduce or limit their options. In Mongolia, we have seen that savings-led microfinance-based intervention enables even the most vulnerable women—those engaged in sex work—to improve their economic circumstances and reduce their health risks.

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Part III

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Chapter ten

Women, Globalization, and Religious Change in Southeast Asia

Barbara Watson Andaya

INTRODUCTION

The region we now know as “Southeast Asia” consists of 11 countries (Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos, Vietnam, the Philippines, Malaysia, Singapore, Brunei, Indonesia, and Timor Leste). Although there are marked differences in language, religion, economies and political cultures, it has long been argued that gender relations in this region have traditionally been relatively favorable to women. This broad generalization obviously requires qualifications in specific contexts, but it is supported by comparisons with the neighboring world areas of South and East Asia (Reid 1988: 146–172). In conjunction with this regional distinctiveness, “her story” in Southeast Asia has also been shaped by the global influences that resulted from its geographical location and tropical environment. Lying athwart the maritime routes linking China, India, the Middle East, and Europe, Southeast Asia became a magnet for international commerce because it supplied the rare jungle and ocean products so desired in world markets. For centuries the ideas that have moved back and forth along the lines of communication established by trade have had a direct bearing on the processes by which Southeast Asian societies conceptualized the position of women, both in ideal terms and in actual practice.

THE “FIRST GLOBALIZATION”

During the sixteenth century the circumnavigation of the globe and regular voyages across the Pacific linked Europe, the Americas, Asia, and Africa, initiating the far-reaching changes that mark the “first globalization” of world history (Gunn 2003). Against this background the penetration of incoming religions in Southeast Asia deserves particular attention because the consequences for women have endured to the present day. While religious and philosophical influences from India (Hinduism and Buddhism) and China (Buddhism, Confucianism, and Daoism) can be tracked from very early times, strengthening connections with the Perso-Arab lands hastened the spread of Islam, whereas the European arrival was inextricably tied to Christianity. Like earlier religious and ethical systems, Islam and Christianity projected specific views of “correct” gender relations, which were often at odds with indigenous practices and frequently in competition with each other. Women were inevitably caught up in the complexity of this religious interaction, and the sixteenth century thus marks a new chapter in the history of gender in Southeast Asia.

The sixteenth century is also important historiographically because the increase in written

sources, both indigenous and European, greatly expands the opportunities for documenting the female experience in Southeast Asian societies. While generalizations across such a culturally varied region are problematic, outsiders were struck by the prominence of women in local markets, their influence as mediators, their pragmatic attitude toward sexual relations, and their influential position in court politics. Even more significantly, the historical material highlights the centrality of fertility in Southeast Asian conceptualizations of the natural world. In societies where maternal and infant mortality was high and where tropical diseases exacted a heavy toll, life was fragile and every birth an occasion for rejoicing. But community well-being was itself dependent on the monsoon rains that replenished the rivers and fertilized the earth, ensuring that plants, animals, and humans would all thrive. In this sense the sexual union of male and female became a metaphor for the reproductive powers inherent in the environment on which human and animal life relied.

Although one must be wary of imagining a “golden age” for women in the Southeast Asian past, the small kinship communities that characterized the region in early times conceived of gender relations in terms of complementary dualities, with the sexual potency of men matched by the reproductive capacity of women. In a world animated by spirits—of trees, of mountains, of caves, of rivers, of rocks, of seas—it was vital to facilitate communication with the supernatural. The ability to act as a spirit medium was open to all individuals, but women were regarded as especially suited to act as conduits to the spirit world. Because illness or unexpected death was attributed to supernatural causes, such women were enlisted to tap benevolent influences, particularly as midwives and healers. European accounts often refer to female knowledge of “antidotal herbs” that could cure diseases ranging from simple fevers to gangrene.

In this context, older women had a distinctive status, for as mothers they had survived the

dangers of childbirth, and through their longevity had acquired the wisdom and experience that enabled them to mediate with the supernatural. Beyond the age of fertility, they had also moved into a liminal zone where they occupied a woman’s body but lacked the reproductive capacities that lay at the core of femaleness. The mysterious processes associated with conception, pregnancy, and birth were vital for the survival of the community, and a girl’s first menses, marking the advent of fertility, could be an occasion for solemnities and rejoicing. But it could also be a time of ritual seclusion, for of all the bodily fluids, menstrual blood had the potential to work the greatest magic and potentially vitiate male strength. Numerous restrictions were applied to menstruating women, and they were normally prohibited from entering sacred spaces or from touching a man’s weapons or tools. Freed from such taboos, older women resembled the ritually transgendered individuals, often prominent in spirit veneration, who embodied deep-seated beliefs that sacral power was most potent when male and female elements mingled. While this blurring of gender boundaries imparted a singular facility to communicate with the spirit world, its very power was ambiguous, because it was always possible that mediums could be accused of marshaling the malevolent forces that caused illness, misfortune, impotency and even death (Andaya 2006).

RELIGIOUS CHANGE FROM THE SIXTEENTH TO THE EARLY NINETEENTH CENTURY

The ambivalent female position in indigenous belief systems was reinforced as Southeast Asian states developed “gender regimes” that were informed by ideals promoted by incoming religious texts (Andaya 2006: 75–103). In the early centuries of the Common Era connections

with India brought not only Hinduism and Buddhism but also provided political models that fed into new conceptualizations of kingship and statecraft. Hindu beliefs stressed the power that came through the union of divinities such as Shiva and his female consorts, but simultaneously strengthened the veneration accorded the male role in creation. Ideas about gender relations, including those that spread from China into Vietnam, tended to depict women as more attached to material things, less able to attain high spiritual standing, and seductive distractions to men's intellectual and religious progress. Yet women were not necessarily in the inferior position that such beliefs might suggest. They owned property, made donations of land and goods to religious foundations, were entitled to inheritance, contributed to community decision-making, and were a key element in marriage alliances. Vietnam, under China until its final independence in 1427, provides a useful example of these cultural negotiations. Certainly, the Confucian view of female subservience maintained a strong hold on constructions of gender well into the nineteenth century. Nonetheless, Vietnamese law was modified to allow greater latitude for women, so that in the absence of sons, the eldest daughter could officiate at the rituals of ancestor worship. Spirit possession empowered women mediums in village communities, while the meshing of Buddhism and Daoism with indigenous beliefs gave ample space for local cults focused on some female deity. The Buddhist *bodhisattva* Quan Am (Guan Yin in China) acquired a special standing as the protector of mothers and children (Kiernan 2017: 91–94, 203–204).

The Chinese-based religions that exercised such influence in Vietnam were largely absent from the rest of mainland Southeast Asia. In Myanmar, Thailand, Laos, and Cambodia the Buddhism of the Theravada school, closely linked to Sri Lanka, became overwhelmingly dominant. Although Buddhist texts confidently asserted that birth as a woman rather than as a

man was evidence of inadequate merit in former existences, the disadvantages of being female were far from insurmountable. At all levels, from dowager queens to humble villagers, mothers wielded considerable influence over their sons, who were perpetually indebted for the gift of life. A young man entering the monkhood transferred the merit he acquired to his mother, and although women were denied full ordination as nuns, it was quite possible to become a renunciant who was respected for her ascetic lifestyle. However, the ideal of Buddhist women as dutiful daughters and wives was countered by stereotypes of the alluring but sexually voracious seductress who could only impede a man's spiritual progress. This ambivalence was reinforced by reformist trends from Sri Lanka that downplayed veneration for female spirits and affirmed the spiritual superiority of men. Nonetheless, despite the eagerness with which Buddhist women sought the protective powers of Christian baptism for their children, European missionaries made few converts in Theravada societies. Though they had only limited success in Vietnam, a lasting legacy was a women's Catholic sodality, the *Lovers of the Cross*, founded in 1670 (Alberts 2013).

In terms of socio-religious change, the most important development in this period of strengthened global connections was the spread of Islam and Christianity. Muslim prestige had been considerably enhanced when the Malay *entrepôt* of Melaka adopted Islam around 1430, and its example was subsequently emulated by other trading ports. Islam's advance through the Malay-Indonesian archipelago in the sixteenth century has been attributed to various factors, such as the admiration for Ottoman Turkey and the pragmatic advantages of attracting Muslim traders. However, scholars have also stressed that Sufism, the mystical stream of Islam, was particularly appealing in maritime Southeast Asia, where Hindu-Buddhist ideas sat lightly. Sufi texts often employed images that women could appreciate, comparing, for instance, the

acquisition of mystical knowledge to steps in the weaving process, and likening devotees to a batik cloth that Allah paints in colors chosen according to the divine plan. Indeed, it can be argued that it was women who were most immediately affected by conversion, since the regulation of male-female relations was specifically addressed in Muslim teachings that allowed for polygyny and stressed premarital chastity, wifely obedience, and male authority. Muslim women were expected to conceal their bodies in accordance with Qur'anic injunctions, although face covering never became a standard feature of female dress. Food preparation, an essential female task, was fundamentally affected by the prohibition against the eating of pork, often consumed in ritual, since oversight of domestic animals, including pigs, was women's responsibility. In other respects, the practicalities of life for village women was probably largely unchanged. Healers and midwives incorporated Islamic prayers and invocations into their rituals, and channeled advice drawn from Islamic treatises on ways to maintain a husband's affection and ward off his desire for a second wife. Women worked in the fields and sold goods in the markets, and this economic independence helped sustain the perception of marriage as a partnership by which a wife's family would be dishonored if she were not treated with respect (Andaya 2006: 104–133, 227–228).

At the elite level, where women registered their Muslim status by remaining essentially house bound, change was more obvious. Although there is no Qur'anic support for the practice, girls in devout families may have undergone a very modified form of circumcision, a prick to the clitoris or clitoral hood, as a sign of full inclusion into the Islamic community (Clarence-Smith 2012; Merli 2012). With religious sanction, wealthy Muslim men could take a second or even a third wife, and in royal households the tensions resulting from competition for a husband's favor could also involve the numerous concubines who populated the women's quarters. Behind

the scenes, well-born women might still exercise considerable influence, and they could sponsor Islamic teachers, become learned in their own right, and gain a reputation for piety and religious commitment. Their public space, however, was circumscribed. Emblematic of this new constriction was a 1699 *fatwa* from Mecca that forbade governance by women and ended long periods of rule by Muslim queens in Aceh and Patani (southern Thailand) (Andaya 2006: 134–164).

In the sixteenth century the missionary projects of the Spanish in the Philippines, and the Portuguese in eastern Indonesia, provide dramatic evidence of the expansion of global influences. From the outset women were targeted for conversion, and they themselves responded, seeing baptism as a source of protection for themselves and their children, and drawn by the veneration accorded the Virgin Mary. Yet ambivalent attitudes toward female spirituality combined to relegate women to a secondary role. In the Philippines the Catholic orders established religious houses for pious women, but the stress was on manual labor rather than spiritual growth, and there were few opportunities to develop independent organizational structures and leadership skills. More culturally destructive were the unrelenting attacks on indigenous “priestesses” and spirit mediums, condemned as witches in league with the devil (Brewer 2004). It is not surprising, therefore, that female ritual leaders were prominent in many of the rebellions against the Spanish, or that spirit practitioners invoked Christian symbols and vocabulary in an effort to maintain a hold over their following. The Church was nonetheless highly successful in promoting the “feminine qualities” of virtue and piety among the Hispanized elite. In later years it was this religious entanglement that incensed a new generation of Philippine nationalists, educated men who saw Filipino women in perpetual thrall to the Catholic friars, whom they denounced as agents of colonialism (Reyes 2008: 136).

COLONIALISM, RELIGION, AND THE FEMALE EXPERIENCE

At the beginning of the nineteenth century Spanish control was well established in the Philippines, apart from the remote highlands and the Muslim south. During the next 100 years European colonialism was imposed over all Southeast Asia except for Thailand. Frequently justified by the claim of spreading civilization (which implied Christian values, if not the religion itself), the global reach of religious imperialism was manifested most obviously in the Catholic Philippines, but also in the proliferation of Protestant missionary societies. Their influence was particularly strong in societies that had not adopted a mainstream religion, and Christianity thus became a key element of ethnic identity among Indonesian groups, such as the Toba Batak of Sumatra, and the Minahasans of northern Sulawesi, as well as tribal communities in Borneo and various hill groups in mainland Southeast Asia. At the margins of state authority, girls in such areas came under the tutelage of European and American women who, as teachers and missionary wives, were fervent advocates of female education.

In the early twentieth century the colonial powers began opening secular government schools, providing educational opportunities for women that would have been unthinkable in traditional society. At the same time, these initiatives raised disturbing questions about appropriate responses when Western models challenged the priorities that shaped a traditional female upbringing. In Myanmar, for instance, monastic education only slowly moved beyond the male population, despite a long history of women's scholarship. It is thus significant that there was a noticeable rise in female enrollment in schools administered by the colonial British government. Exposed to new ideas, educated Burmese women used the "women's pages" of

vernacular newspapers to express their views on a range of topics, from male-female relations in marriage, to the place of women in nationalist movements (Than 2014: 20–48).

Across Southeast Asia—indeed, in Asia as a whole—politicized women and “modern girls” became a focus for controversy because the perceived female role as guardians of the cultural legacy appeared to clash with claims for greater equality with men (Edwards and Roces 2000; Ikeya 2011). The gendered dimensions of a Sinitized heritage meant that these debates were particularly intense in Vietnam, where even French schools used textbooks that stressed Confucian values and Buddhist beliefs such as karma. Although the revival of Buddhism in the 1920s helped foster the idea that Vietnamese women were keepers of religious tradition, it also emphasized social engagement. In thinking about the responsibilities of society toward the disadvantaged, women were made more aware of their own position in a patriarchal culture (DeVido 2007: 278–279).

Vietnam's most contentious issue, however, concerned collaboration with the colonial regime. Left-wing groups were highly critical of French-educated women, accusing them of indifference toward both the sufferings of the poor and their less privileged sisters. The newly formed Indochinese Communist Party specifically listed female emancipation as a goal, and in 1930 it oversaw the formation of the Vietnamese Women's Union, dedicated toward the promotion of nationalism and the achievement of full gender equality. Given the global spread of anti-religious radicalism, church authorities in Vietnam redoubled their efforts to rally the faithful. The lay community organization, Catholic Action, mounted a concerted campaign to attract women, even though their denunciation of “godless Communism” placed them in direct opposition to left-wing nationalists (Keith 2012: 161). In an environment where competition to generate and retain ideological loyalties was growing ever more antagonistic, the demands for gender equality were

regarded by many men as a distraction from the goal of freeing Vietnam from French control. Indeed, in 1937 the Communist leadership even implied that the struggle of “women against men” was one of the reasons for the failure of the anti-colonial uprisings of 1930 and 1931 (Marr 1984: 190–251).

Against this background, Southeast Asia’s Muslim societies deserve particular attention, for here, too, the position of women became a flashpoint for the collision of different views on nationalism, social change, and religion. Christian-Muslim relations in Southeast Asia had long been infused with tension, but in the early nineteenth century the Islamic heartlands of the Middle East generated a new and formidable challenge to colonial assumptions of Christian superiority. In 1803 religious zealots (known as *Wahhabi*, after their leader) took control of Mecca, determined to eliminate all practices considered un-Islamic, including “innovations” by which the faith had been adapted to local customs. In the Indonesian archipelago the repercussions were soon apparent. Communities were fractured as reformist leaders outlawed customs previously regarded as religiously acceptable and enforced aspects of *syariah* law, such as the veiling of women and restrictions on male-female interaction. Many women, energized by the call for a purer Muslim society, became active agents in the promotion of reformist teachings, producing texts on matters such as the duties of a good wife, who should be submissive to her husband’s wishes even if he entered into a second marriage (Roff 1987; Hadler 2008; Hijjas 2011).

For the most part, the colonial powers (the Dutch in Indonesia, the British in Malaya) made little effort to interfere with Islam, despite their disapproval of child marriage and polygyny, which was common among the elite. Yet by the early twentieth century, despite the argument that European-style feminism was unsuited to Asia, some educated Muslim women were calling for change. In the Netherlands Indies, Raden Adjeng Kartini (1879–1904) became a national

icon because of her support for female education. In addition, her private correspondence lays out her opposition to polygyny. She felt powerless to express her views publicly because she believed that such practices were sanctioned by Islam; Kartini herself was the daughter of her father’s unofficial wife and agreed to her own marriage as a fourth wife (Robinson 2009: 37–40).

It was during this period, however, that Southeast Asian Muslims felt the impact of a new wave of reformist teaching that addressed the deteriorating condition of global Islam. Though subject to considerable criticism, several leading clerics attached to the great Al-Azhar University in Cairo argued that Muslim societies could only advance with the emancipation of women. Advocating legal provisions that would improve the female status, they denounced customs such as polygyny, seclusion, arranged marriages, and male control over divorce. The ripples of these ideas were soon felt in Southeast Asia, where the modernist Singapore journal *al-Imam* championed property rights for Malay women, criticized polygyny and was guardedly supportive of female education (Roff 1987; Hadler 2008: 158–160).

In the Netherlands Indies women themselves entered the fray, and in 1928 around a thousand participants representing over 30 different organizations came together in the first Women’s Congress. Although supportive of nationalist goals and the general uplifting of women, at this stage, these organizations were primarily concerned with improving female education and equipping girls for their traditional roles as housewife and mother. Although such gatherings did provide a forum for participants to express their views on polygyny, child marriages, divorce, child custody, and forced marriage, they also exposed significant ideological divisions. For example, *Aisyiyah*, the women’s arm of the modernist movement *Muhammadiyah*, concentrated on improving women’s access to education and assisting Muslims to better understand the obligations of their faith. Polygyny and other aspects

of marital relations were sensitive topics because any debate would raise questions about accepted practices believed to be condoned by Islamic law. Wanita Katolik, the organization of non-Dutch Catholic women, was predictably opposed to polygyny, but its members wanted to avoid controversy and stay outside politics. Their main focus was to support Catholic women and better the lives of disadvantaged groups, like poor and illiterate factory girls. The radical nationalist movement, *Isteri Sedar* (“Aware Women”), also condemned polygynous marriages, and argued vehemently that equality between men and women was necessary if independence was to be achieved. These divisions continued to prevent the women’s movement from adopting a common stand in relation to marriage reform. The lack of consensus was painfully apparent in 1937, when Muslim suspicion of government interference in private matters and fears of creeping Christianization frustrated Dutch colonial efforts to introduce a marriage ordinance that supported monogamous marriages and gave wives more rights in divorce (Martyn 2005: 42).

During World War II all Southeast Asia except for Thailand was occupied by the Japanese, and for most women, this was simply a time of survival. Stories of heroism and remarkable courage include women as well as men, as do darker memories of suffering and victimization, particularly for those compelled to service the sexual demands of Japanese soldiers. However, in the immediate post-war years, when it became clear that colonialism would soon give way to independence, questions about what this new world would offer to women resurfaced. While village women wished simply for an improvement in their material existence, middle-class and elite women hoped for more lasting changes, envisioning a fundamental restructuring of society in which their relationships with men would become akin to a partnership (Blackburn and Ting 2013).

Despite commitments to gender equality in government-drafted constitutions, it was difficult to dislodge ingrained attitudes that affirmed a

male-dominated hierarchy. In Vietnam the leadership of the Communist Party ensured that religion would play no part in the new state, and female commitment to its ideology of gender equality was apparent in the many “long-haired warriors” who answered the call to join battle against the French. However, Vietnamese who had grown up with the Catholic faith found it infinitely harder to place nationalism above religious allegiance, and the French defeat in 1954 led to the flight of thousands of Catholics from the Communist-controlled north to South Vietnam. Here religious communities reassembled under the leadership of priests and nuns, with the most striking example being the Vietnamese women’s order, the “Lovers of the Holy Cross”, known for their extensive charity work. In a time of chaos, their influence with the refugee community was as deep as that of the male clergy (Hansen 2008: 269–270).

Resolving the conflicting loyalties of nationalism, gender and religion became a particular issue in other Communist-led guerilla movements committed to overturning capitalist society. In the Philippines, the *Hukbalahap* resistance was initially formed to fight the Japanese, but by 1950 it had been reorganized as the armed wing of revolutionary communism. In a deeply Catholic country, the Huks avoided direct confrontation with the Church, but created their own marriage forms and rituals. In this “alternative” society men and women entered into unions that affirmed their devotion not just to each other, but also to the revolution (Lanzona 2009: 144–147). Yet regional comparisons also show that women who joined radical movements found them to be permeated by male privilege, and by an implicit gender hierarchy which ensured that men dominated the highest ranks. In British Malaya, socialism’s failure to deliver on its promises was a source of deep disappointment for politicized Malay Muslim women who defied family and social disapproval to join the left-wing AWAS (Angkatan Wanita Sedar), modeled after Indonesia’s *Isteri Sedar*, and later the Chinese-led Malaysian Communist Party.

In Indonesia the debates about the place of Islam after independence and the overlap between nation and religion were highly emotional and have never been fully resolved. The organizations of Muslim women naturally supported the campaign for an Islamic state, while secular nationalists as well as Catholic and Protestant women were opposed. Eventually, it was decided that despite an overwhelming Muslim majority, Indonesia would not identify itself as a Muslim state, although belief in God would remain a platform of Indonesian citizenship.

Indonesia's declaration of independence raised other issues. The Dutch refusal to relinquish colonial authority, and the war of resistance that followed, injected fresh urgency into old questions about male-female relationships. In times of struggle, what was the place of women? Were they primarily supporters of male resistance or could they take an active role as freedom fighters? The answers are equivocal. Women were certainly welcomed as cooks, couriers and nurses, but those who joined the Javanese "bamboo spears" (revolutionary units, made up primarily of young men), encountered a general feeling that their place was at home. Christian women who supported the nationalist revolution faced the added burden of colonial association, and underlying doubts from fellow-Indonesians regarding the depth of their commitment to the new nation (Andaya 2001; Blackburn and Ting 2013; Steedly 2013).

By 1950, international pressure had forced the Dutch to recognize Indonesia's independence and a mood of exuberance helped galvanize the women's movement. In some cases, shared goals could overcome ideological and religious differences, but it was not long before old fissures reopened as the issues of polygyny and marriage reform divided women along religious and secular lines. As the nascent Indonesian state grappled with economic decline and political uncertainty, women's issues were not high on the government's agenda. Despite hopes of a new beginning in the post-colonial world, many women felt that there

had been virtually no advance since the time of Kartini (Martyn 2005: 124)

WOMEN, RELIGIOUS APTITUDE, AND LEADERSHIP IN CONTEMPORARY SOUTHEAST ASIA

Over the last 60 years, rather than retreating into the private space of the household, as secularization theorists once predicted, religion and the place of women have moved to the forefront of public discourse. In Southeast Asia the argument that globalizing influences have had adverse effects on women's "traditional" status has led to some reexamination of cultural constructs of gender, and the subversion of older ideas by male-dominated religions that present a specific model of approved female behavior. The position of Southeast Asian women who have attained positions of political leadership exposes the extent to which religiously-shaped attitudes have contributed to the ambiguities with which femaleness has long been invested (Ong and Peletz 1995; Edwards and Roces 2000; Blackburn and Ting 2013). Indeed, like their counterparts in other societies, women as national leaders are acutely aware that their hold on authority is ultimately dependent on male support, whether as voters or allies. Regardless of their personal preferences, it is not easy to prioritize gender issues in government policies, especially when any challenge to accepted gender norms may alienate the very men on whom their career depends.

In the Philippines, for example, women were well represented among the left-leaning Catholic groups opposing President Ferdinand Marcos after his imposition of martial law in 1972. Militant nuns, inspired by the principles of liberation theology, joined rallies and demonstrations, publicized injustices, and addressed issues ranging from prostitution on American military bases

to support for tribal minorities (Claussen 2001). In 1984, a Benedictine nun, Sister Mary John Mananzen, co-founded the General Assembly Binding Women for Reforms, Integrity, Equality, Leadership, and Action (GABRIELA). Named after an eighteenth-century heroine, GABRIELA brought together over 100 groups that had different political ideologies but were united in their desire to advance women's causes and redress social inequality. Following the fall of Marcos, there were expectations that such causes would be high on the government agenda, and the marked rise in population made the need for family planning and reproductive health patently obvious. Yet in a society where political leadership had been a male domain, the two women who have held the office of president (Corazon Aquino, 1986–1992, and Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo, 2001–2010) could not have survived without support from the Catholic hierarchy, which entailed their acceptance of the Church's position on abortion, divorce and contraception. Feminists were disappointed with what they viewed as Corazon's weak leadership and pious subservience to Catholicism, while charges that Gloria had manipulated election results seemed to affirm stereotypes that women in power maintained their position primarily through scheming and secret deals.

Such stereotypes also bedevil women in the predominantly Buddhist society of Thailand, where female representation in politics remains low even though women are active voters. It is therefore intriguing that 2011 saw the election of the female Prime Minister, Yingluck Shinawatra, a politically inexperienced businesswoman who headed the *Puea Thai* (For Thais) party as a surrogate for her brother, the self-exiled former Prime Minister. Although women's issues did not figure in Yingluck's policies, some Thais, especially women, considered her electoral success to be a step forward in elevating female leadership in politics. While her own actions partially account for her downfall in 2014 on charges of abuse of power, misogynist attitudes were influential, and

foreign observers were shocked by the crude and sexually explicit epithets used by her critics (Murdoch 2014). Furthermore, the Buddhist monkhood, so influential in Thailand, was divided. While many of the young men who enter the monastery temporarily during the rainy season came from rural areas where her support was strongest, her "black-hearted government" was the target of condemnation by activist monks linked to her opponents.

In Myanmar a major development was the 2015 victory of the National League for Democracy, led by Aung San Suu Kyi, daughter of a national hero and herself recipient of the Nobel Peace Prize. Though an advocate of a secular state, Daw Suu Kyi (now state councilor) has positioned democratic reform within a Buddhist framework. Stressing the need for Buddhists to be socially engaged, she frequently mentions her own practice of meditation (Schober 2011: 108–127). With the support of the monkhood, Suu Kyi represents a telling response to the common perception of women as less capable than men, especially in regard to public office. Although Suu Kyi has expressed strong support for women's rights, some observers argue that real progress is impeded by a national narrative which asserts that gender equality is already part of Myanmar culture (Than 2014). Nor has it been a simple matter for Suu Kyi to maintain her reputation as both a devout Buddhist and defender of human rights. As leader of a country where "to be a Burman is to be a Buddhist" she has been reluctant to condemn the continuing violence against Myanmar's minority Muslim Rohingya which is led by the military but encouraged by radical monks.

For Buddhist women, debates surrounding the acceptability of female leadership have raised other issues, particularly the denial of full ordination as nuns (*bhikkhuni*). In Thailand, transnational connections have provided a partial answer, since links to Sri Lanka have enabled devout women to be ordained in the Theravada tradition, while others have been received through a

Mahayana lineage in Taiwan. Yet in societies where a woman is valued primarily in her role as mother, the presence of celibate Buddhist *bhikkuni* challenges both social norms and the convention that renunciation is a male prerogative. The monkhood's Council of Elders in Thailand still considers female ordination to be illegal, although aspirants can be accepted as devout lay women (*maechi*). A female professor, herself a leading Buddhist scholar, has argued forcibly for change, contending that the issue of ordination is related not only to women's rights but to the philosophical universality of Buddhism itself. In response to calls for a change in cultural attitudes, Thailand's first all-female temple has now included a program to train lay female devotees with the goal of promoting greater gender equality (Holt 2017: 171, 182).

Overall, there can be no doubt that women are becoming increasingly active within Southeast Asia's Buddhist cultures, since membership of lay meditation groups has provided them with alternative paths to spiritual progress (Jordt 2007: 158–159; Kawanami 2013: 32). In Cambodia, the involvement of ordinary women was critical after the dark days of the Khmer Rouge, when thousands of monks and devout women (*tun ji*) were killed and Buddhism was virtually exterminated. Because there were so few men, it was women who returned to their villages to rebuild destroyed temples. In 1995, as a result of an international conference attended by Buddhists from around the world, the Association of Nuns and Laywomen was formed. Promoting reconciliation and improvements in health and education following the trauma of the Khmer Rouge period, it used older women “*wat* (temple) grannies” as councilors and advisors. Some temples run by women have even expanded to include men who wish to adopt a Buddhist-focused lifestyle (Guthrie 2004; Wight and Muong 2013).

The diversity of Protestant churches in Southeast Asia, and their differences from Catholicism (they are listed separately in Indonesia's list of

approved religions), render generalizations difficult. In Minahasa, a majority Protestant area of Indonesia, women were being trained as ministers as early as the 1950s, and by 1990 they made up 50 percent of local pastors. Conversely, although women of all ages make up the bulk of congregations in the rising number of Charismatic/Pentecostal churches, they are rarely represented among senior pastors because it is thought they are less receptive to the “gifts of the spirit” needed for leadership (Chao 2012; Gudorf 2014). In the Philippines, although Catholicism does not ordain female priests, women can conduct prayers before huge audiences in the lay Catholic movement (*El Shaddai*). Rather than shutting the door on localization, the Church has accepted Mount Banahaw (three hours from Manila) as a sacred site for the Philippine nation that attracts hundreds of pilgrims, especially during Holy Week. A number of the cults located here, regarded as examples of popular Catholicism, are headed by women, including the largely female Ciudad Mistica de Dios [Mystical City of God] (Claussen 2001: 143–157).

ISLAM, GLOBALIZATION, AND MUSLIM WOMEN

Perhaps paradoxically, global reaction to the rise of extremist Islam and the subjugation of women have led many observers to see more liberal attitudes toward gender as markers of “modernity and progress” (Basarudin 2016: 231). This view has obvious implications for Southeast Asia, where young Muslim women have adopted the headscarf in accordance with Islamic prescriptions, where calls for a stricter application of *syariah* law are growing louder and where feminism is often regarded as a Western and secular ideology. Malaysia, for instance, is not an Islamic state and all religions are constitutionally guaranteed freedom of worship. Islam, however, is the official religion, and the Islamization of the government, and society more generally, has not

been advantageous to women. Gender discrimination is especially evident in relation to Muslim family law because the *syariah* courts often favor men in matters such as divorce and custody of children. There is nonetheless some pushback. Sisters in Islam (SIS) was established in 1988 by professional Muslim women and is committed to promoting women's rights within an Islamic framework. Disparaged as deviants by male clerics, SIS has been accused of promoting alien Western values and of employing unacceptable interpretations of Islamic texts (Basarudin 2016).

Observers of contemporary Indonesia, the world's largest Muslim population, have also commented on the increase in public religiosity and a hardening of religious borders. While this has led some to ask whether the country's reputation for moderate Islam is being undermined, these developments should be contextualized. In 1965, General Suharto assumed the presidency after an alleged Communist coup. Communism (including the women's wing, "Gerwani") was immediately banned and under this "New Order" all Indonesians had to declare their affiliation with one of the five recognized religions (Wieringa 2002). Women were exhorted to devote their energies to husband and children, but simultaneously to support national development and economic progress by engaging in home-based enterprises that would augment the family income. Successfully curbing political Islam, the Suharto regime instituted a marriage law in 1974 that required men to apply to religious courts to obtain divorce and to obtain the court's permission if they wished to take a second wife. Apparently in an invincible position, Suharto was even able to gain Muslim support for his family planning program, which he believed was necessary to move the country ahead (Robinson 2009: 79–80).

Ironically, it was Indonesia's increased engagement with global capitalism that intensified the impact of the Asian financial crisis in 1997 and led to the fall of the Suharto government the following year. Together with widespread access to

social media, the restoration of democratic government has initiated unprecedented public debate and discussion. Religion figures prominently in these exchanges because of global trends that call for Muslims to reexamine themselves and their relationship to their faith. A greater stress on public piety has raised new questions about the degree to which the state should oversee public morality and whether women should accept that their role is fundamentally different from that of men. The continuing ambivalence toward female leadership was openly exposed in 1999, when Megawati Sukarnoputri, daughter of Sukarno, Indonesia's first president, herself became a presidential candidate. A generation of younger and more educated women was supportive, and she was endorsed by Muslimat Nahdlatul Ulama and Aisyiyah, the two largest women's Muslim organizations. As a whole, however, Muslims were divided. Those who contended that capacity rather than sex should be the deciding factor for leadership were countered by arguments based on classical Islamic texts that place men above women. In addition, there was widespread public concern that Megawati would not be able to maintain her obligations as a housewife and would be subject to manipulation by her husband. When she finally assumed office in 2001, she proved to be a lacklustre president. Admittedly hampered by the entrenched sexism in Indonesian politics, Megawati's lack of concern for gender issues disappointed women's organizations, who had hoped for real advances under a female leader. Nevertheless, official encouragement for political parties to identify electable women candidates has had positive results at the provincial level, where women viewed as good Muslims are considered to be less venal and more committed to their community than their male counterparts (Martyn 2005: 210; Robinson 2009: 143, 167–171).

Other concerns have surfaced in the post-Suharto period, most particularly the influence of fundamentalist Islam. Indonesia is commonly

seen as an exemplar of tolerant Islam, but disagreement about what it means to be “Muslim” has become a major preoccupation, especially on social media. The application of aspects of *syariah* law have increased across much of the country, but the most pronounced expression as instituted in Aceh (northern Sumatra) has highlighted ambiguities in the legal position of Muslim women. While it seems evident that patriarchal interpretations of *syariah* have resulted in discrimination against women, controversies regarding the introduction of Islamic law, especially at the local level, have coincided with a time of democratic reform. In consequence, an important space has been opened in the public domain for arguments that recognize women’s rights as a fundamental Islamic value, thus avoiding the accusation that proponents are importing Western feminism. Women who have received an Islamic education have cooperated with secular feminists to develop the vocabulary to express such views, and in Aceh activists have even adopted the word *timang* as a substitute for the English term “gender” (Afrianty 2015: 139).

There are other ways in which Muslim women have gained from the piety movement. A growing number have joined study groups that support the development of skills such as Qur’anic recitation and encourage a deeper knowledge of religious texts (van Doorn-Harder 2006). Several female *ulama* (scholars) are already known as popular preachers, both in person and through television, and training projects are helping women to reach the standards for preaching demanded by the male leadership of Muslim organizations (Nor 2016). It is encouraging to see that in April 2017 a Congress of Women Ulama, supported by the Religious Affairs Ministry, the local government, and male clerics, attracted around 1,700 participants. Recalling the concerns of the Women’s Congress of 1928, its proceedings publicly affirmed Indonesia’s tradition of moderate Islam, stressed that Islamic texts should be reexamined in the light of gender

equity, and rejected polygyny, child marriage, and all violence against women.

CONCLUSION: GLOBALIZATION AND THE LEGACY OF THE PAST

In our modern world globalizing forces have locked women and religious change together in an ongoing history that stretches back to the sixteenth century. All Southeast Asian states have ratified CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Discrimination against Women), but a noticeable trend toward greater public religiosity means that society’s expectations of women are often at odds with the worldwide and largely secular feminist movement. Many Muslim parents still see female circumcision (albeit in a relatively mild form and sometimes simply symbolic) as a sacred act and a religious obligation. The reluctance of the Indonesian government to take a forceful stand against this practice has aroused considerable international criticism (Clarence-Smith 2012). The ease of global communication has generated fresh debates about the degree to which the universality of the world religions can be interpreted in ways that are compatible with local mores and maintain the localization that has always been a hallmark of Southeast Asian cultures.

In this environment it is important to note that globalization, modernity, and development have not extinguished the traditional roles by which so many Southeast Asian women acquired community respect and status. Certainly the state and institutionalized religion have often been allies in the effort to displace or restrain popular practices considered to be at variance with the officially-espoused vision of modernity and rationality. Nonetheless, female spirit mediums are still seen as conduits to the supernatural, although they now typically position themselves as devout believers and incorporate the prayers and invocations of mainstream religions into

their ritual (Cannell 1999: 108–128; Smith 2008). The knowledge and experience of older women is respected, especially as traditional birth attendants, but also in child-rearing generally. The belief that women are better equipped as intermediaries has been evident in conflict zones where religious differences have provided the vocabulary to fuel violence, notably eastern Indonesia, the southern Philippines, and southern Thailand. Women from different religious backgrounds have come together in interfaith organizations dedicated to finding workable solutions to festering resentments—the Concerned Women’s Movement in Ambon, the Women’s Agenda for Peace in southern Thailand, and the Women’s Peace Table in the southern Philippines.

Yet the deeper ambiguities that have been part of the female condition for centuries still remain. The powers of fertility and reproduction, regarded with awe by early Southeast Asian societies, have been recast by the world religions as polluting, dangerous, or shameful. Stories of legendary queens abound, but the tendency to see women as weak leaders who will be manipulated by men, or who will maintain their position by devious means, has undermined the female position in politics. Age-old fears that women might use “black magic” for malevolent purposes have not disappeared, and the conviction that they have a limited capacity for spiritual advancement has perpetuated a “gender gap” in religious praxis.

As this chapter has shown, the global expansion of the world religions has been fundamental to evolving constructions of gender in Southeast Asia. Indigenous beliefs embraced the allegories of fertility and reproduction symbolized by the female body, allowing women significant roles in ceremonial life even as these same powers necessitated their exclusion from many male activities. Equally important was the rise in status that transpired as an older woman, no longer embodying emasculating female forces, was welcomed into a larger ritual space. By contrast, the sacred writings of the world religions almost invariably privileged male authority. Though references to

female spiritual and intellectual inferiority were persistent and persuasive, these traditions were amenable to alternative interpretations, and it would be misleading to assert an unambiguous narrative of declining female status. Women have always been attracted to the imported faiths, and over the centuries they have seized opportunities to enhance their own reputation for piety and to demonstrate their standing in the religious domain. Such opportunities have broadened as the expansion of education for women has allowed access to the knowledge and experience that was previously a male privilege. Yet as the world has become smaller, global expectations that Southeast Asian women should wholeheartedly embrace modernity and economic independence, have frequently conflicted with their traditional roles as guardians of tradition and preservers of social norms. Women have thus been faced with difficult choices that have involved often competing allegiances to family, ideologies, and religious conviction. As the twenty-first century advances, their quest to participate in the globalization process in ways that allow retention of their cultural and religious identity will remain a major preoccupation.

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Chapter eleven

Adapting Human Rights Gender-Based Violence and Law in Indonesia

Shahirah Mahmood

INTRODUCTION

In the final days of the 2004 parliamentary session, the Indonesian women's movement received a 'gift' from the then president Megawati Sukarnoputri. She had signed into law a bill that criminalized rape in marriage, wife-beating, and other forms of gender-based violence within family life. Given that family matters are conventionally addressed through religious law and cultural norms, the passage of *Law 23/2004 on the Elimination of Violence in the Household* was significant in emphasizing the importance of violence against women as an issue requiring community and government action. The law also marked a significant win for Indonesian women activists who, since the early 1990s, had established women's crisis centers that offered refuge for battered women, counseling services for violent spouses, and tracked data on cases of gender-based violence.

Several Indonesian practitioners have explained that consensus between women's rights actors and Muslim women activists, with support from key religious elites, were pivotal in both shaping the law and its passage (Munti 2008). However, these accounts often depict ideas on women's rights and women's rights policy as emerging from the West. Through interviews with Muslim women activists and discourse analysis of Muslim

women's organizational documents, Muslim women's activists are placed at the heart of the analysis, focusing on the role they played in adapting discourses on women's rights and applying them in a culturally nuanced manner.

In their attempts to be cultural intermediaries with respect to global discourses on women's rights, Muslim women's groups undertake several strategies. First, Muslim women activists and secular feminists sought consensus-seeking solutions to adapt the United Nation's framework on gender-based violence to fit the local legal context. This meant excluding measures to eliminate discrimination in matters related to controversial issues such as polygamy. Second, the government redefined the target population, and excluded victims of domestic violence in homosexual and non-married partnerships from receiving protection from the state. This exclusionary language was a concessionary measure by the women's movement to Islamic elites and the government for the bill to be passed. Third, Muslim women activists provided secular feminist groups with symbolic resources—frames and language that resonated with Islamic law and ethics—to ensure that women's movements' arguments affirmed Islamic institutions. This meant identifying and emphasizing the gender-egalitarian principles inherent in the Quran and *hadith* (recorded sayings and actions of the

Prophet Muhammad) and applying them to the cultural context.

MUSLIM WOMEN ACTIVISTS AS HUMAN RIGHTS TRANSLATORS AND INTERMEDIARY ACTORS

Indonesia provides an ideal case for analyzing how global discourses on women's rights are contextualized and adapted. Indonesia is home to approximately 235 million Muslims, the largest Muslim population of any state. This includes Muslim women's organizations affiliated to the world's largest Islamic organizations: Nahdlatul Ulama (often referred to as NU) and Muhammadiyah. Aside from organizing religious activities, NU and Muhammadiyah are also service-based organizations with education, health, and economic enterprises. As mass-based organizations with group presence at different levels of government, NU and Muhammadiyah have also established fairly autonomous and vibrant women's affiliated groups that tend to be age-based. Aisiyah (older women over the age of 45) and Nasyiatul Asiyah (younger women between the ages of 20–45) are affiliated to Muhammadiyah, and Muslimat NU (older women over the age of 45) and Fatayat NU (younger women between the ages of 20–45) are affiliated to NU.

Muslim women's activism in Indonesia offers a useful lens through which to examine how discourses on Islam and women's rights are adapted and combined to shape normative attitudes and policies related to gender equality. As insiders within Islamic institutions, Muslim women activists possess religious knowledge and share similar cultural and normative systems with Islamic institutions. They understand the discursive and normative context in which social change can occur. At the same time, Muslim women activists have been at the heart of mobilizing the public

for women's interests since the 1920s. As activists with one foot in women's rights activism and the other in Islamic faith, they are constrained by the demands of both secular women's rights activists and those of Islamic institutions.

The anthropological literature on "cultural translation" serves as the framework for this chapter. The literature investigates how translating cultural categories and ideas across diverse communities would either preserve or alter their meanings (Merry 2006:41). A fundamental claim of the anthropological literature on cultural translation features the role of actors who occupy "middle" positions, those who translate concepts and ideas between different worldviews and cultural settings (Merry 2006: 42).

This insight is extended into this work, employing the conceptualization of Muslim women activists as translators of women's rights. Muslim women activists who participate in both Islamic and women's rights discourses have to negotiate in the middle of the field of power, limited by constraints, but also creating opportunities. While attempting to challenge conventional interpretations of Islam, they must assess the extent to which they can challenge existing modes of thinking without risking their religious affiliation with Islamic institutions. The latter provide Muslim women's organizations with a degree of authority and religious credibility, as well as access to Islamic networks, to maneuver for internal institutional change. At the same time, Muslim women activists pursue certain demands and agenda, promoting women's rights and women's concerns which may be unacceptable to Islamic institutions. As intermediary actors moving between Islamic and women's rights discourses, they also possess knowledge on how to translate and frame human rights ideas in ways that appeal to the cultural and religious vernacular.

Muslim women activists in Indonesia frame discriminatory Islamic practices and interpretation by portraying them as violating human rights ideas and fundamental Islamic principles. At the

same time, they synthesize ideas on human rights with Islamic principles and apply these newly formed ideas to resolve concrete difficulties confronting women in their communities. In doing so, they refashion ideas on women's rights, making them qualitatively different from the liberal perspective on women's rights. For example, since the early 1900s, Aisiyiah and Muslimat NU have been committed to promoting women's welfare and security in marital relations, and improving women's access to education and healthcare. However, they have mobilized for women's rights in ways that are critical of Western standards of morality. As discussed below, this tension is further illustrated by Muslim women's activists' perspectives on gender-based violence and their application of gender-egalitarian Islamic principles to the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill.

MUSLIM WOMEN'S ORGANIZATIONS' PERSPECTIVES ON GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE

In 2009, five years after Law 23/2004 on Elimination of Violence in the Household was passed, Komnas Perempuan (National Commission on Violence against Women), together with several leaders of the Muslim and Catholic communities, produced three sets of books, each directed for adherents of their respective faith groups. As the two largest mass-based Islamic organizations in Indonesia, NU and Muhammadiyah wrote separate books for their communities. Close reading of these texts, prior to interviews with Muslim women activists and religious leaders, enabled the author to get a thorough grasp of the debates and contentious issues regarding gender-based violence. Although these books were written for the NU, Muhammadiyah, and also for the Catholic communities in Indonesia, the authors who were elites from Muslim women's organizations had written most of the content of

the books. This meant that these booklets portrayed the perspectives and attitudes of Muslim women activists.

Because the focus is on examining how ideas on women's rights and arguments challenging gender stereotypical roles and responsibilities are translated into local contexts, the interviews would quickly move from general questions on gender-based violence to how an organization that opposed government's intervention in the family domain would respond to arguments advocating for women's protection within the private sphere. A brief analysis of the books is necessary to get a sense of the arguments made by Muslim women activists in the "pro-direction" of the bill.

Muslim women activists highlight certain verses in the Quran that emphasize women's rights for fair and just treatment. They refute a dominant interpretation of Quran verse 4:34 which guides religious elites' perspectives on *nusyuz* (Ar) or disobedience, and methods for resolving marital disputes.¹ Interviews with Islamic scholars from NU and Muhammadiyah largely agree that when a wife is disobedient, "light tapping and slapping" is permissible for the purposes of "educating" the wife. Muslim women activists challenge the concept of "wifely disobedience" by highlighting Quran verses which reveal how husbands are equally capable of being "disobedient" in Islamic law. They argue that the idea of wifely obedience or *taat suami* (Indonesian) is a cultural and religiously entrenched behavior expected of women in an Islamic marriage.

To excavate the concepts of rights and individual choice, Muslim women activists refer to Quran verse 4:128. This verse legitimizes a woman's choice for seeking divorce and justice should her husband mistreat her: "If a wife fears cruelty or desertion on her husband's part, there is no blame on them if they arrange an amicable settlement between themselves; and such settlement is best, even though men's souls are swayed by greed" (Quranic Arabic Corpus 2011a). A similar

verse is quoted by Ali Yafie, an Islamic scholar from NU. He argues that Quran verse 4:128 allows women to seek divorce in the event a husband neglects his responsibilities, or in the event he has harmed her, and refuses to divorce her (Rofiah 2010: 17).

Nor Rofiah, a scholar in Islamic studies (a member of Fatayat NU and also of Alimat, a loose alliance of Muslim feminists attempting to reform Islamic marriage law), is a primary author of *Breaking the Silence: Religion Bears Testimony to the Victims of Domestic Violence to Achieve Justice*, produced for the NU community (Rofiah 2010). According to her, Quran verse 4:34 is often cited without other verses, such as 4:128 and 4:19, that enjoin men to treat women with respect and kindness. Quran verse 4:19 proclaims, “O ye who believe! Ye are forbidden to inherit women against their will. Nor should ye treat them with harshness, that ye may take away part of the dower ye have given them, except where they have been guilty of open lewdness; on the contrary live with them on a footing of kindness and equity. If ye take a dislike to them it may be that ye dislike a thing, and Allah brings about through it, a great deal of good” (Quranic Arabic Corpus 2011b). Nor Rofiah contends that in patriarchal societies such as Indonesia, where women have been socialized to be subservient to men, gender discrimination occurs in the methodology of reading the Quran, for example, because verse 4:34 is more often quoted than verses 4:128 and 4:19. By emphasizing less quoted verses, Muslim women activists are educating the community on the Islamic origins of a rights-based discourse, highlighting women’s rights to just, fair, and equitable treatment.

Another discursive strategy used by Muslim women’s organizations is in reinterpreting Quranic verses to demonstrate how dominant interpretations not only violate human rights, but also contravene ethical principles of Islamic justice. Muslim women activists from affiliated and age-based groups advocated for the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill, by challenging dominant ideas

regarding the “roles and responsibilities” of husband and wife, and husband’s “leadership,” especially as it pertains to the interpretation of Quran verse 4:34.

The interpretation of the Arabic word *qawwam* (“leader”), and its meaning in Quran verse 4:34, has been a subject of intense debates between Muslim women activists and male religious leaders. Aisiyah, Muslimat NU, and Fatayat NU, however, adopt distinct interpretations of this verse. Both Aisiyah and Muslimat NU interpret the Arabic word *qawwam* as meaning “leader” but argue that men’s leadership is contingent on their qualities to lead: that is, to provide, to protect, and to support one’s family (Djohantini 2010: 122; Rofiah 2010: 145). Ultimately, this enables both husband and wife to create a harmonious and stable family, the main goal of an Islamic marriage. Women of Aisiyah and Muslimat NU also argue that it is important for the husband to provide a livelihood for the family, especially when women are performing their biological duties of giving birth and breastfeeding. The trope of the “responsible husband” is invoked in a way that emphasizes both reciprocal and complementary duties, particularly when women are bound to their biological roles. Still, some Muslim women activists from Aisiyah and Muslimat NU who were interviewed, argue that for a husband to be a good leader, he must allow his wife to actualize her full potential, which includes supporting her wishes to pursue an education or earn an independent income.

Fatayat NU prefers to engage in a contextual analysis of Quran verse 4:34, adopting Asghar Ali Engineer’s exegetical method of interpreting the Quran. Engineer is an Islamic scholar and activist from India, known for reformist writings on Islamic theology. He identifies two types of verses in the Quran: normative and contextual. Normative verses extol what God desires, while contextual verses describe actions that are contingent on the context of revelation. He suggests that 4:34 is a contextual verse as it describes the

marital relations between husband and wife in Arab society in the context of revelation. Nor Rofiah's booklet quotes Asghar Ali Engineer at length:

The Quran states that men are qawwam (one who provides a livelihood and manages family affairs), but it does not state that men should be qawwam. As such, the phrase they (men) "are qawwam" is a contextual statement and not a normative statement.
(Rofiah 2010: 98–99)

Rofiah, therefore, concludes that Quran verse 4:34 tells us that:

Understanding the verse in the context of the social conditions in which the verse was revealed, Quran verse (4:34) reminds us that men's dominance over women is not innate or natural but it is contingent on their roles as the breadwinners of the family. In reality there are more women who are sole breadwinners or work to supplement their husbands' income. This indicates the interchangeability of a husband's role as the breadwinner of the family with a wife. Instead, it can be said that it is 'society's will' (kodrat masyarakat) that men become the breadwinners of the family.
(Rofiah 2010: 98–99)

Unlike Fatayat NU's contextual approach to interpreting 4:34, Muslimat NU and Aisyiyah argue that men's leadership is contingent on an equitable exchange of responsibilities, and a husband's ability to not only provide and protect the family, but also to encourage his wife to live up to her fullest potential. Muslim women's activists' criticisms of gender normative roles shape the way they understand how sexual relations are conducted and how marital conflict should be resolved in family life. This background in interpretation frames understanding of the strategies employed by Muslim women activists, and the Indonesian women's movement in general, that shaped the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill, leading to its successful passage.

ADAPTING CEDAW TO THE LOCAL LEGAL CONTEXT

Indonesia ratified the United Nations Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) in 1984. Despite global acceptance, however, CEDAW is without necessary sanctions and enforcement mechanisms. Lack of meaningful enforcement renders it largely ineffective for the Indonesian women's movement to pressure the government to comply to its standards about women's rights. CEDAW covers both substantive and formal equality, emphasizing the principles of non-discrimination and legal equality. All thirty articles in the convention encompass a broad array of social, political, economic, educational, employment, health, and cultural inequalities, as well as discrimination faced by women. Article 16 specifically outlines measures to "eliminate the discrimination against women in all matters relating to marriage and family relations on the basis of equality of men and women" (UN Women 2009).

It was not until 1993, when the United Nations Declaration on the Elimination of Violence against Women was adopted, that helped enable the Indonesia women's movement to discuss violence against women, particularly notions related to marital rape, wife-beating, military rape, and the gendered effects of war on women (Blackburn 2004: 194). The 1995 Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing also led to an influx of foreign aid to organizations conducting studies and for programs dedicated to addressing gender-based violence.

The battered women's movement in Indonesia began with the founding of Rifka Annisa, Indonesia's first Women's Crisis Center in Jogjakarta in 1993. As stated on its website, Rifka Annisa (2013) galvanizes around a vision that "struggles for the existence of a gender-just society that does not tolerate violence against women through the principals of social justice, awareness and care, independence, integrity, and maintaining local

wisdoms.” Its primary services include psychological counseling, legal consultation, and assistance for women and children survivors of gender-based violence. It also provides counseling services for men with the aim to change the behavior and attitudes of perpetrators of violence. By the mid-1990s, apart from Rifka Annisa, women’s rights organizations, like Kalyanamitra in Jakarta, began monitoring and collecting data on cases of workplace sexual harassment and domestic violence (Blackburn 2004: 203).

Opponents of human rights are skeptical about existing “Western” standards of human dignity that can be planted and applied universally. For example, local religious leaders were initially hostile to the crisis center. They believed that a husband and wife should deal with their domestic concerns in private. They sarcastically made comments that Javanese women were emulating American women, and that Javanese women should not bother themselves with setting up a women’s crisis center. Given that protecting women’s rights would occasionally be at odds with cultural and religious expectations, such as family stability and gender-prescribed roles, organizations caring for battered women in Indonesia faced immense obstacles when they first began their activities.

At the same time, the women’s movement’s inability to agree on what constitutes domestic violence stymied the initial formulation of a law against it. Ruhaini Dzuhayatin, from Aisyiyah, and founding member of Rifka Annisa, described how women’s organizations with liberal ideological leanings were in disagreement with Rifka Annisa regarding their methods for resolving cases of domestic abuse:

We knew that preaching about gender equality wouldn’t work, not only because it is a “Western concept” but because women as wives and mothers have been socialized to support their husbands and be obedient. When Rifka first started out, we encountered a lot of friction from other women NGOs. For example, Rifka is not of

the opinion that women in polygamous marriage should seek divorce, as polygamy, according to other women’s organizations, constitutes a form of violence. We were accused by them (other women NGOs) of being pro-polygamy! Our main concern was to ensure women’s rights were defended, but at the same time, we knew working with families and husbands was important. When we first started out, we were fighting a dual war – one externally against patriarchy and the other, internally, against other women’s organizations whose advocacy for equal partnership is not realistic given our social reality.

Dzuhayatin’s insights were particularly revealing in depicting different ways local translators of global discourses on gender equality adapted ideas on women’s rights. Starting out as a battered women shelter and catering mostly to Muslim women, Rifka Annisa recognized the discursive constraints, eschewing approaches that prioritized “rights” at the expense of reconciliation and collective/family welfare. By identifying their goal as “defending women’s rights” and simultaneously acknowledging that polygamy exists, Rifka Annisa is refashioning global rights agendas for local contexts. In the process of “translating transnational ideas and practices down as ways of grappling with local problems,” and “reframing local grievances up by portraying them as human rights violations” (Merry 2006: 42), Rifka Annisa is allowing local religious and cultural understandings of marital relations to shape their advocacy and programs around domestic violence. Yet, by educating women that they have the right *not* to be hit, the right to bring their batterers to court, and the right to stand up for themselves against abusive husbands and non-married partners, Rifka Annisa is offering human rights “interventions” to victims of domestic violence. These interventions are similar to programs developed in the late 1970s and early 1980s in North America and Europe, that were the sites of production for global human rights and women’s rights (Merry 2006: 40).

As mentioned by Ruhaini Dzuhayatin, not all women's rights groups in Indonesia agree on the extent religious and cultural traditions should be accommodated, and how underlying gender hierarchies should be dismantled to make way for an individual rights-based perspective. To understand the different ways women's rights groups in Indonesia frame their approach and advocacy around domestic violence, the author spoke to members of Kalyanamitra, one of the first women's resource centers, that emerged in the 1980s, with a focus on promoting gender equality. Their vision, as stated on their website, centers on a "generating and egalitarian community through collaboration with social actors in the community to fulfill women's rights." (Kalyanamitra 2017). Listyowati, chairperson of Kalyanamitra, spoke about the center's advocacy against domestic violence by citing differences in the way her organization approached the issue compared to other women's organizations:

Our main vision and mission is to eliminate all forms of violence towards women and according to us, polygamy constitutes a form of violence. That (polygamy) to us is a form of violence, (pauses) I know that other women's organization may not agree (tidak sepakat) with our opinion but polygamy to us, is a form of violence. To that extent, in all our activities we try to socialize how polygamy is a form of violence. Other women's organizations may not be so insistent, but for us we insist that polygamy is a form of violence – it is a form of violence that is not only physical but causes mental and emotional anguish. Since 1998, we have been assisting victims of domestic violence and we found that polygamous marriages are one of the main sources of domestic and sexual abuse, and is a main cause of emotional and psychological trauma.

As a secular women's organization staffed by both Muslim women and men, Kalyanamitra's mission and methods are underpinned by liberal ideology and norms. They are at the frontlines of advocating

for a gender equality bill and are strong proponents of the complete prohibition of polygamy in Indonesia. Following the broad conceptualization of violence in CEDAW Article 1, Kalyanamitra argues that polygamy constitutes a form of psychological violence, and hence should be abolished. Kalyanamitra is careful not to substantiate the inclusion of polygamy in the bill by referencing CEDAW Article 16. They reason that a more effective tactic would be to frame their advocacy against polygamy as a form of "psychological" violence, instead of as a way to promote gender equality within the family domain.

Both Rifka Annisa and Kalyanamitra were operating from distinct discursive constraints. As a women's crisis center, Rifka Annisa adopts a pragmatic approach to resolve tangible problems afflicting battered women. This meant modifying concepts of "women's rights" in order to continue to provide care and counseling services in an environment opposed to a "Western-sounding" human rights approach. On the other hand, as a resource center for data gathering and for offering workshops and dialogs on gender discrimination, Kalyanamitra's focus is to challenge ideas and perspectives without necessarily having to deliver solutions to tangible problems. Whether polygamy should be accommodated and tolerated, or should be seen as a form of "violence," became a fractious issue during the initial phases of mobilizing around the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill.

Despite these differences, by 1997, four years after the first women's shelter was formed, the women's movement, together with Muslim's organizations, began lobbying for the Anti-Domestic Violence Law. The Indonesian Women's Association for Justice and Legal Aid Institute (LBH APIK) spearheaded the drafting and advocacy for the bill. Founded by a group of female lawyers in 1995, LBH APIK is committed to providing legal defense for women who are impoverished, and face religious and cultural discrimination. With vast experience and expertise in lobbying the government, LBH

APIK led the women's movements' advocacy for the bill.

On June 8, 2012, the author spoke to LBH APIK's director Ratna Batara Munti regarding the challenges faced in their lobbying efforts, in particular forging consensus between women's groups around the definition of violence. Her response was surprising. She immediately recognized that she was being asked her opinion on whether polygamy should be seen as a form of violence against women. She explained that in 1997, LBH APIK organized a workshop "Religious and Legal Response to Domestic Violence in the Household," which invited Muslim women's groups like Aisiyah, Muslimat NU, and Fatayat NU, as well as Islamic institutions, including Islamic scholars from Muhammadiyah, NU, and Indonesian Ulama Council (MUI). The workshop was perceived as a resounding success because overall participants agreed that existing laws within the criminal code did not provide domestic violence victims with access to legal assistance and legal protection from perpetrators of the violence. Nevertheless, in order to move forward, Munti said that they had to "drop" the clause on polygamy, as it was seen as being too much a religiously sensitive issue. The workshop was the first step for the women's movement to gain support from prominent Islamic elites to promote the bill. Nevertheless, this meant precluding CEDAW Article 16 that specifies measures against gender inequality in marriage and family relations, in particular, thus failing to proscribe polygamy.

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES ON THE DEFINITION OF HOUSEHOLD

After over a year's wait by the women's movement and legislators who submitted the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill to parliament, the Indonesian government, represented by the Ministry of Women's Empowerment and Child

Protection (MWECP), issued their version of the bill in 2004. Three main issues the government found particularly contentious were excluded from the draft bill. These issues revolved around the inclusion of: "economic violence" as a form of domestic violence, "marital rape" as a form of sexual violence, and the definition of the household. As will be discussed, Muslim women activists, many of whom were also parliamentarians, were influential in shaping discourse and policy points related to these controversial issues.

The legislative version of the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill defined "household" to include domestic workers, ex-wives, and girlfriends. The government's version of the bill narrowed the scope to only include "husbands, wives, and children" and "individuals who share family ties (biological or adopted) or through marriage." Except for the nationalist party, Indonesian Democratic Party of Struggle (PDIP), there was clear consensus between all other parties that only individuals within the confines of a legal marriage and who share biological ties can attain the status of a legitimate victim.

The MWECP's notion of victimhood abided by the conventional interpretation of Islamic law. Since the 1990s, there has been an ascendance of what is considered "pious practice" among middle-class Indonesians. Along with increased observance of Islamic practices such as prayer, and dietary and dressing requirements, there is a greater tendency to accept a stricter interpretation of Islamic law regulating male-female interaction. This includes not only interaction in the public sphere, but also within the household. Islamic law specifies guidelines differentiating individuals who are *mahram*, unmarriageable kin with whom sexual relations would be considered incestuous, and non-*mahram*. For example, individuals who are considered a women's *mahram* are generally the father and brother, while individuals who are non-*mahram* can be a family relation such as a male cousin, or non-family relations such as male friends. In turn, there are clear guidelines covering dress codes and interaction with members of the

opposite sex who are *mahram* and non-*mahram*. Hence, the definition of household adopted by the MWECP is in line with Islamic legal terminology of kinship relations.

In the context of the bill, Islamic kinship relations dictated who deserves protection from abuse and violence. Extending the realm of household relations to include non-married partners, ex-wives, and domestic workers would mean to aid and protect battered women as individuals. This would include individuals in relational arrangements, specifically cohabitation (*kumpul kebo*) and homosexual partnerships (*relasi homoseksual*), perceived as sinful in Islam. Hence, it is the perceived relational context in which “victimization and abuse” occurs that determines whether an individual is worthy of protection.

Despite consensus on the issue, Surya Chandra, a male member of parliament from PDIP, expressed that middle-class households in Indonesia typically consist of individuals who are *not* related through blood ties or marriage, such as domestic helpers or tenants. He argued that preserving the broader definition of household was unrelated to condoning free sex and homosexuality. In a press interview he asserted that language protecting the rights of domestic workers should be included in the law. While domestic workers can be considered non-*mahram*, the reality is that the relational arrangement is viewed as morally appropriate, in contrast to cohabitation and homosexuality.

Muslim women’s groups such as Aisyiyah and Muslimat NU abided by a definition of household that is aligned with an Islamic understanding of individuals who are of similar *mahram*, advocating for the inclusion of domestic workers to be protected as members of the household. Aisyiyah asserted that domestic workers are easy targets for violence in households where they are employed. Often domestic workers who have been abused are afraid of reporting instances of violence because they may lose their jobs (Pusat Aisyiyah 2011). Ratu Dian, a member of Fatayat NU and from the National Awakening

Party (PKB), explained that it was important for the bill to exclude language endorsing sexual relations outside of marriage and homosexuality; however, she agreed with including “domestic workers” in the definition of the household. While acknowledging the prevalence of violence between non-married partners (*pacaran*), she explained that an expansive definition of household risks having the bill stalled in parliament. Thus for Dian, abiding by an Islamic legal understanding of kinship relations was not only a moral choice, but one that was pragmatic and strategic. While disagreements persisted, the law that was finally passed included domestic workers as part of a household but excluded non-married partners and ex-wives/ex-husbands as part of a household.

In an interview with Latifah Iskandar, from Aisyiyah, also a member of the Islamic party National Mandate Party (PAN), the author asked how her party came to a resolution on the issue:

It is reality in Indonesia that domestic helpers are often abused and mistreated. If we are to ensure this law protects all individuals, we need to include those in our society that are the easiest targets for abuse. As domestic helpers work in the private domain, it makes sense for this law to protect them.

Although from different parties and activist groups, Ratu Dian and Latifah Iskandar advocated for domestic workers’ rights and fought for them to receive protection from the state. Nevertheless, for both religious and strategic reasons, they preferred to adhere to a narrow definition of household, excluding non-married and homosexual partnerships, perceived as sinful in Islam. Navigating between Islamic and women’s right discourse means that Muslim women activists must assess to what extent they can challenge existing modes of thinking and to what extent they can frame non-conventional ideas in familiar packages. At times, this means promoting ideas that militate against women’s sexual freedom and individual rights.

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES ON CONTROVERSIAL CLAUSES

Debates on the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill revolved around two important and contentious clauses. While secular parties like PDIP and Golkar, and Islamic party PKB, supported the inclusion of economic violence and marital rape in the bill, the Islamic party Prosperous Justice Party (PKS), and the military-police party, TNI-POLRI, were against the inclusion.

First, the concept of economic violence in the draft bill proposed by the People's Representative Council (DPR) meant: "neglecting the household; negligence applies to any individual who restricts someone else from working inside or outside the home so that the victim is dependent and under the control of the individual" (DPRRI 2004: Art. 9, para. 2). Economic violence was included to promote a woman's individual right to earn an income. This perspective runs contrary to a cultural, albeit conservative, understanding of a husband's role as the primary breadwinner of the household. Similarly, establishing women's independence and right to economic autonomy stands in contrast to a common interpretation of Quran verse 4:34 that "Men are the protectors and maintainers of women, because Allah has given the one more (strength) than the other, and because they support them from their means" (Quranic Arabic Corpus 2011b). MWECP argued that the clause "economic violence" not be included as a form of violence because:

the government should focus on trying to raise the economic standards of everyone in society, such that both husband and wife can be economically independent without destroying the harmony and togetherness which will be more constructive between the two of them.

(DPRRI 2004: 125)

MWECP promoted an understanding of economic independence that prioritized family harmony and welfare, in turn undermining the intent of the draft clause to protect a woman's right to an independent livelihood, and developing her fullest potential, regardless of her husband's permission. PKS member Aan Rohanah agreed with the MWECP's stance on the issue. She argued that a husband is guilty of economic violence if he forces his wife or children to work for the family against their will (Nurjanah 2013: 72).

The second point of contention in the bill surrounded the issue of marital rape. According to PKS and MUI, marital rape is a non-issue because a dutiful wife would not turn her husband away (Nurjanah 2013: 73). This opinion is legitimized on a controversial hadith that states, "If a wife stays away overnight, leaving her husband's bed, then angels will curse her till morning" (Bisri 2001). PKS legislators argued that sexual relations between a husband and wife should remain a private matter. If marriage is a form of worship for God, the relationship between husband and wife holds a strong devotional dimension. Although Huzaemah Tanggo from MUI recognized that the hadith is widely disputed, she also rejected the inclusion of marital rape.

Although marital relations are between the husband and wife, Islam lays out permissible actions and ethics regarding intimate relations (*bersetubuh*) between partners. She believes it is unnecessary to include marital rape because if a husband is guilty of abusing his wife (whether physically or sexually), Islamic law offers mechanisms to resolve marital disputes. It is, therefore, unnecessary for the government to intervene and regulate intimate relations between a husband and wife. The government, represented by MWECP, shared similar opinions:

With regards to marital rape in marriage, the government understands and acknowledges that this is a problem. However, when considering

the implications (of including the clause) and in view of ideological and cultural factors that are ingrained in our society, which may inevitably impact the effectiveness of this stipulation, we believe that it will be better to find a concrete solution that ultimately contributes to the overall welfare and harmony of the nation and community.

(DPRRI 2004: 152)

The quotation suggests that to legitimize state intervention within the private domain, the state's solution was to redefine the target population by excluding the notion that married women could experience marital rape.

Preserving economic violence and marital rape in the definition of domestic violence proved to be much more challenging than the women's movement anticipated. Detailed records from LBH APIK's indicated that the women's movement took several approaches to pressure legislators not to exclude the two clauses. Tactics ranged from monitoring the developments in both open and closed door parliamentary sessions, presenting data on sexual and economic crime committed in marriage, and working with media to inform citizens about why including these clauses was important.² Muslim women activists clarified how misinterpretation of Quranic verses and lack of knowledge of Islam created the misperception that Islam legitimizes wife beatings (Munti 2008: 86).

Overall, secular parties like PDIP and Golkar, and Islamic party PKB, supported inclusion of economic violence and marital rape into the bill, while Islamic party PKS and the military-police party TNI-Polri rejected their inclusion. A press conference organized by LBH APIK and the National Commission on Violence Against Women that brought together religious leaders, women's groups, members of parliament, and survivors of domestic violence, was strategically held on the same day the special committee would convene for the final time to discuss the bill (Eko 2004). Organizers documented the

prevalence of domestic violence and the inadequate measures within the criminal code to protect and prosecute such cases. The aim was to ensure that the most controversial clauses, especially economic violence and marital rape, would remain in the final draft, before it was sent out for a final vote in parliament.

Although PKS initially rejected both clauses, the Elimination of Domestic Violence Bill, renamed *Law 23/2004, Elimination of Violence in the Household*, was passed on September 14, 2014 with both clauses successfully preserved. PKS agreed that, with respect to economic violence, husbands and fathers are responsible to ensure that women are protected, since many women and children have been dragged into prostitution by close relatives (DPRRI 2004: 256). Yuyoh Yusroh from PKS explained that economic violence should not be interpreted as a husband preventing his wife from working, but instead suggested that economic violence could include a husband who has not provided for his family for several months, or one who forced his wife and children to work. Despite the fact that PKS still rejected the idea of marital rape, arguing it is a "Western-minded" concept, it agreed to preserve the substance of the article. Yuyoh Yusroh stated that a husband's responsibility toward his wife extends to his treatment of his wife, especially in the bedroom (DPRRI 2004: 256).

Parliamentary discussion on the bill reflects changes in PKS's approach to gender roles in general, and husband-wife relations in particular. To understand how consensus on such contentious issues was forged, Ratna Batara Munti, director of LBH APIK, the NGO that formulated the legal drafting of the bill, offered additional insights. In an interview with her, she provides details on how religious leaders and Muslim women activists were closely consulted in its final draft:

In 1993, Rifka Annisa had started a program dealing with the problem of domestic violence towards women. I went to Jogjakarta to visit the

center and based on our experience in legal drafting and advocacy, we took on the leading sector role. Before we formulated the bill we conducted comparative country research looking at anti-rape laws in Vietnam, Philippines, Turkey and Malaysia. Based on that we agreed that the title of the bill should contain the word “household” (rumah tangga) because if the bill’s focus were only to protect women, it would be rejected. This process took several months.

Domestic violence is an entry point to change the legal system, because it is the system that needs to be changed. We were invited by TAF (The Asia Foundation) to a conference and we learnt a lot from activists from Vietnam and Philippines as they had just successfully passed their anti-domestic violence law. When we wrote the initial draft we knew it would be revised multiple times to include the perspectives of the religious community. We worked closely with a core team (team inti) of individuals consisting of women activists within women’s crisis center such as Rifka Annisa, Kalyanamitra and Mitra Perempuan. We also coordinated our work with Ibu Musdah Mulia, who was then the head of the research division for MUI.

Finally, we examined existing laws and noted that Article 351 and 316 of the penal code were inadequate to protect women from battery especially within the private domain. We also held a workshop on “Handling Domestic Violence” and invited police, judges, lawyers, religious leaders and NGOs to underscore the reality of violence and abuse confronted by women and children. With this we established our network of teams (tim jaringan). While we had engaged with the religious community, it was important to get the active participation of Muslim women from Muhammadiyah and NU. We had to stress to them and explain how this bill does not lead to divorce and disintegration of the family, in fact this bill is important to establish a harmonious family (Keluarga Sakinah). We had to involve them in every step of the way. Based on all of their suggestions and input we wrote the first draft of the bill in 1997.

She said that the first draft of the bill, written in 1997, was revised four times before being submitted to parliament. She also pointed out how key legislators, Aisyah Baidlowi and Safira Rosa Masruchah, members of both PKB and Muslimat NU, and Dr. Musdah Mulia, Senior Advisor to of the Ministry of Religious Affairs from 1999 to 2007, were pivotal in influencing PKS’s decision to include controversial clauses. They pushed for an expansive definition of violence to be preserved in the bill. Several weeks before the bill was passed, a group of legislators held a seminar in the parliament building on “Supporting the Passage of the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill to becoming Law.” The seminar was attended by parliamentarians from Islamic parties such as PKS. Others included influential Baidlowi and Masruchah, who attempted to assuage opponents who continued to argue that the bill would lead to the disintegration of the family:

RUU KDRT (The Anti-Domestic Violence Bill) is an effort to create a Sakinah (harmonious) family. With this bill, women who are often the victims of abuse can depend on the cooperation of their family members, friends and neighbors, the police and the government to prevent the occurrence of domestic violence. This bill has been long-awaited by victims of domestic violence, whose numbers have steadily increased. Many women become victims of violence, especially women in minority groups, indigenous women, women refugees and migrants, disabled women, elderly women and women in armed conflict. Women are also vulnerable to economic violence when their needs are neglected and when they are not allowed to work and provide for themselves and their families. Currently, there are insufficient laws to address these problems. This bill would ensure that women and citizens are free from abuse, torture, inhuman acts and neglect that would lower the dignity of our collective humanity.

(Eko 2004)

Both Baidlowi and Masruchah advanced their agenda by presenting data from the Integrated Crisis Center in Jakarta of actual cases of women and their children who experienced mistreatment and financial poverty as a result of being financially dependent on their husbands. They demonstrated how there had been an increase from 68 to 112 cases of domestic violence from 2000 to 2003, indicating the urgency of passing the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill. They demonstrated that data from Rifka Annisa Women's Crisis Center revealed that abusers are normally husbands, the ones closest to the victims. Data collected by Rifka Annisa indicated that wife beatings and battery increased from 10 to 117 cases between 1994 and 2004 (Eko 2004). They also explained that the stipulation on economic violence was vital to protect the livelihood of women and their families, especially if a husband neglects his marital responsibilities. Emphasizing PKB's position, Baidlowi also argued that marital rape is not condoned in Islam. She explained:

Islam teaches us to value both men and women for their good deeds. Islam also teaches us that a husband should value his wife, and that a wife should value her husband. The Quran verse (2:187) states, "They are clothing for you and you are clothing for them." Islam enjoins husbands to treat their wives well, and as such, a husband should not compel his wife to have sex against her wishes.

(Gemari 2004)

As a representative of the Ministry of Religious Affairs, Dr. Musdah Mulia pointed out the impact of domestic violence on children and on society:

The Ministry of Religious Affairs finds that children who grew up in households where there is domestic violence will reproduce the violence and consider domestic violence as something to be taken for granted; they will grow up resorting

to using violence to solve their problems. I am currently counseling a girl who was raped when she was a junior in high school by a close family member. Until now she still lacks self-confidence. For example, she would say, "I am that ugly and revolting for someone to do this to me?" The trauma suffered from domestic violence is real and lingers for a long time, this is detrimental for our children, youth and the country's future.

(Gemari 2004)

In another workshop, organized by the Ministry of Religious Affairs in 2004, Mulia emphasized Islamic ethical principles that bestows equality between men and women:

All religious leaders that I spoke to in this workshop have mentioned that religion teaches us to appreciate the essence of man-kind. Forced sexual intercourse by a husband against his wife, does not fulfill this religious principle, where husbands should appreciate and treat his wife kindly. In Islam, the Quran emphasizes that equal relations between men and women as God is the only superior being.

(Gemari 2004)

These Muslim women activists utilize the "responsible husband" trope to advocate for the inclusion of controversial clauses. By referencing Quranic verses that elevate women's rights, and Islamic ethical principles that emphasize equality in relations between men and women, they are projecting an alternative interpretation of a responsible husband. While their arguments have not displaced the mindset that a responsible husband should protect and provide for his family, they emphasized that he should respect and treat his wife kindly, and not limit her ability to pursue an education and gainful employment.

Islamic party PKS accommodated the inclusion of economic violence and marital rape into the definition of household violence for different

reasons. For PKS, invoking a husband's responsibility meant that, as the leader of the household, he should be the main provider for the family and respect the sexual rights of his wife. The notion of individual rights and women's rights are unimportant and unrelated for an understanding of marriage as an act of devotion. Conversely, using the frame "husband's responsibility," legislators from PKB imbued the frame with ideas on women's rights, arguing that invoking a husband's responsibility may restrict a wife's actions. But it can also mean securing a women's autonomy to enact her agency and pursue financial independence. Framing human rights ideas in a culturally and religiously familiar vernacular, women's rights translators run the risk of unintended interpretations. Nevertheless, this enabled them to influence policy on domestic violence, culminating in the eventual passage of a consequential and historic law that included the notions of economic violence and marital rape, represented by the clause "sexual violence."

Given Indonesia's contentious political and religious climate, the success of including such controversial clauses in the final Elimination of Violence in the Household law is monumental. By working together, Muslim women's organizations and secular women's groups issued a bill on domestic violence that subsequently *excluded* polygamy as a form of "psychological violence," which then enabled the bill to be officially accepted for discussion in parliament. We saw that policies promoting women's rights sometime begin in spaces that circumscribe individual rights for different groups of women. Represented by the Indonesian government, the MWECP denied the notion that married women can be victims of sexual violence. It also preserved the conventional understanding of men as providers for the family, which prompted their attempt to exclude the clause on economic violence. They tried to adapt the bill to suit cultural and religious sensibilities in a manner that diluted provisions for empowering women's agency and rights. Nevertheless, there was push back against

their version, and the clauses, as controversial as they were, remained in the bill.

CONCLUSION

There are clear parallels between the opinions espoused by Muslim women's activists advocating for the Anti-Domestic Violence Bill, and the organizational discourse espoused by both older and younger women of Aisiyah, Muslimat NU, and Fatayat NU. Some activists emphasized that men's leadership is not a given natural right, but one that is normative (Fatayat NU) and dependent on various qualities of a responsible husband (Aisiyah and Muslimat NU). Similarly, the trope of the responsible husband was utilized by Muslim women activists. In both instances, applying a rights framework does not come at the expense of emphasizing a husband's responsibility. Both a rights framework *and* an appeal to the principles of Islamic ethics were employed while bargaining with parliamentarians from PKS. Muslim women activists, caught in the middle of Islamic and women's rights discourses, framed women's rights language in a way that was relatable to Islamic institutions. At the same time, they emphasized an alternative interpretation of the responsible husband: one that prioritizes equal (and equitable) responsibilities between a husband and wife.

Navigating between Islamic discourses and women's rights discourses requires Muslim women activists to move between highly polemical discourses, such as a rigid interpretation of wifely obedience and marital roles as espoused by groups like PKS, and a "radical" interpretation of psychological violence to include polygamy as demanded by Kalyanamitra (even though polygamy was eventually excluded from the first version of the bill). As translators of women's rights, activists must assess the extent to which they can reference rights' ideas in ways that do not reinforce liberal discourses, as defined by Western feminists, at the expense of Islamic religious principles. They must

be able to excavate Islamic passages within the Quran and hadith to validate their arguments, or refer to Islamic ethical principles that tie in with the concept of rights, justice, and fairness. Last, if these rhetorical strategies fail, then Muslim women activists rely on data compiled by women's rights activists and their experiences counseling battered and sexually abused women and girls. Largely unfamiliar to policymakers, their experiences at the grassroots level conducting workshops, speaking at seminars, and holding study circles, contribute toward their ability to convey rich and nuanced narratives on the discrimination that women face in Indonesia.

NOTES

- 1 The notion that women should be obedient to their husband stems from an emphasis on the Quranic verse (4:34): "Men are the protectors and maintainers of women, because Allah has given the one more (strength) than the other, and because they support them from their means. Therefore, the righteous women are devoutly obedient, and guard in (the husband's) absence what Allah would have them guard" (Pimpinan Pusat Muslimat NU 1979, 10–12). Another often quoted hadith that promotes wifely obedience states, "If a wife prays five times a day, fasts during the month of Ramadan, guards her sexuality, and obeys her husband, she will enter paradise through any door she desires."
- 2 Activists monitored close-door sessions via text messaging, with particular legislators from PDIP, Golkar, and PKB who were supportive of the bill. The final phases of the parliamentary discussions on the bill were not open to the public.

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Chapter twelve

Experiences of Financial Vulnerability and Empowerment among Women who were Trafficked in the Philippines

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INTRODUCTION

Human trafficking is a significant violation of human rights that impacts upon women in various regions of the world, including Asia. Such rights include the right to liberty and security, freedom from gender-based violence, freedom from forced labor, slavery, or servitude, just and favorable work conditions, freedom of movement, freedom from inhuman or degrading treatment, and an adequate standard of living (United Nations High Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights 2014). The exact scope of human trafficking in the Philippines and globally is not fully known due to methodological challenges that pervade such research, including difficulties associated with sampling trafficked persons, the hidden nature of the trafficking industry, differing definitions of human trafficking, and issues related to the collection of accurate information from trafficked persons (Choo et al. 2010; Cwikel and Hoban 2005; Di Nicola 2007; Duong 2015; Tyldum 2010; Zhang 2009).

Nonetheless, the Asia-Pacific region is estimated to have the largest number of persons trafficked into forced labor, as it accounts for over 50 percent of all forced laborers in the world

(ILO 2012). The Philippines, in turn, is a significant source country for human trafficking, and to a lesser extent, a transit and destination country. Women, men, and children in the Philippines are trafficked for work in a variety of industries, including domestic work, sex work, online sexual exploitation, janitorial service, fishing, agriculture, forced begging, and hospitality-related jobs (U.S. Department of State 2016). Such trafficking takes at least two forms. First, Filipinos in impoverished communities and conflict-affected areas are trafficked internally within the Philippines to major metropolitan centers and major tourist destinations, such as Metro Manila, northern Luzon, Cebu, Boracay, Angeles City, Olongapo, Puerto Galera, and Surigao. Second, Filipinos are also trafficked from the Philippines throughout Asia, North America, and the Middle East to destinations including Hong Kong, Singapore, Japan, Malaysia, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Bahrain, the United Arab Emirates, and the United States (ECPAT International 2016; U.S. Department of State 2016).

The macroeconomic context of the Philippines has heightened women's vulnerability to human trafficking. Economic growth in the Philippines has trailed behind other countries in the Southeast Asian region (Bayangos and Jansen 2011).

Structural adjustment programs implemented by the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank have led to ruinous economic consequences in the Philippines (Guevarra 2007; Sassen 2002a). Additionally, economic growth has not kept up with population growth, with its associated controversies surrounding the use of contraception due to the strong presence of the Catholic Church in political, social and cultural life in the Philippines (Austria 2004; Balisacan 2007). To address the lagging economy, the government of the Philippines has promoted the international migration of Filipino workers (Bayangos and Jansen 2011; Eviota 2004; Sassen 2002a), and the Philippines has become one of the largest suppliers of migrant labor in the world. In 2010, the Philippines was the world's fourth highest net remittance-receiving country in absolute terms, following India, China, and Mexico (World Bank 2011). Women comprise the majority of migrant workers from the Philippines, with common professions including domestic work, entertainment work, factory work, and nursing (Eviota 2004; Guevarra 2007; Sassen 2002b). Remittances are so crucial to the Philippines' gross national product that the state has referred to migrant workers as the "*Bagong Bayani*, the modern-day heroes of the Philippines" (Guevarra 2007: 526–527). Through their labor and remittances, women help build the revenues of the home country in addition to supporting their families (Sassen 2002b). Qualitative research with Filipina women has shown that helping one's family financially is an overwhelming motivation for many women to pursue work abroad. Migrating for the sake of one's family has become a dominant cultural script (Asis et al. 2004).

The entertainment industry has played an important role in the Filipino economy, and one of the key contributing factors to the growth of the sex work industry was the decades-long presence of US military forces at bases in the Philippines (Eviota 2004; Ryan and Hall 2001). When US military bases closed in the early 1990s, the groundwork had already been laid for an

extensive sex work industry, targeting foreign customers in the Philippines (Ryan and Hall 2001). Growth in tourism has been accompanied by a proliferation of the entertainment industry in the Philippines, as in many other countries (de la Cerna 1992; Sassen 2002b). Stereotypes of "the exotic is the erotic" have further driven international demand for sex tourism (Cwikel and Hoban 2005: 308). Western stereotypes of Asian women and girls as submissive and/or eager to please have fueled demand for the trafficking of Asian women and girls into commercial sex work (Chung 2009). With entry into the sex industry being one of the few options available to women seeking work out of economic necessity (Law 2000), traffickers can prey upon such vulnerable women, deceiving them about the nature of their work and working conditions (Sassen 2002a, 2002b).

The most prominent international definition of human trafficking is found in the *United Nations Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children*, adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2000. This protocol emphasizes preventing and combating human trafficking (especially of women and children), providing services to victims of human trafficking, and promoting cooperation among states to achieve these objectives (United Nations 2000). More specifically, the protocol defines human trafficking as "... *the recruitment, transportation, transfer, harbouring or receipt of persons, by means of the threat or use of force or other forms of coercion, of abduction, of fraud, of deception, of the abuse of power or of a position of vulnerability ... for the purpose of exploitation*" (United Nations 2000: 1), with such exploitation including not only "sexual exploitation" but also "forced labor."

The Philippines was one of the first countries in Asia to enact anti-trafficking legislation (Republic Act 9208 2003), adopting a similar definition of human trafficking as the one articulated in the United Nations (2000) Palermo Protocol; anti-trafficking legislation in the Philippines

was expanded in the Republic Act 10364 (2012). According to the Republic Act 9208 and the Palermo Protocol, any minor (below the age of 18) engaged in sex work is classified as a trafficking victim, regardless of whether or not the minor consented to engage in sex work and regardless of whether or not the means of exploitation were utilized in his/her recruitment. Specific to trafficking into sex work, adults who willingly engage in sex work as a source of income are *not* considered victims of human trafficking. However, adults who are forced to engage in sex work (e.g., through physical force, fraud, or coercion) are classified as trafficked persons per this legislation.

Women who have been trafficked are viewed by human rights and humanitarian groups as being among the most vulnerable women in Asia. In the counter-trafficking movement, significant attention is directed toward human rights abuses that occur during the trafficking process. Yet, comparatively little research has been conducted with trafficked persons to understand their lives after they exit human trafficking (Richardson et al. 2009). Although survivors' experiences are often characterized by stigmatization, poverty, and lack of sustainable livelihood options, the challenges experienced by survivors upon their escape from trafficking have been given less attention (Kempadoo et al. 2005; Le 2016; Richardson et al. 2009). The anti-trafficking sector has historically been fraught with tension surrounding the distinctions between sex work and sex trafficking, and the nature of oppression and women's agency in the sex industry (Cavalieri 2011). Irrespective of one's ideological position on sex trafficking and/or sex work, scholars and practitioners should be able to agree on the importance of promoting economic justice, employment, and education for all women, including women who have been trafficked (Sloan and Wahab 2000).

In this chapter, I explore the experiences of trafficked women in the Philippines following their exit from human trafficking and return to

life in the community, specifically focusing on women's experiences of financial vulnerability and empowerment. In doing so, I integrate findings from three separate research projects with women in the Philippines who were trafficked into sex work and domestic work: a grounded theory study exploring the process of managing family financial pressures among women trafficked into sex work, a financial diaries study examining financial vulnerability among survivors and their family members, and a photovoice study rooted in feminist theory that documents the experiences of trafficking survivors in a savings and financial capability program. Drawing from each of these studies, the following highlights experiences of female survivors in three areas: (1) the intersection of financial vulnerability and familial responsibility; (2) access to sustainable livelihood options; and (3) economic empowerment services for survivors.

INTERSECTION OF FINANCIAL VULNERABILITY AND FAMILY RESPONSIBILITY

In the Filipino context, family-based social and cultural norms influence trafficking survivors' experiences of financial vulnerability during the re-entry process. The family is commonly regarded as the basic unit of Filipino society and provides financial support, assistance during crisis, psychological support, and social status (Asis et al. 2004; Jocano 1998; Medina 2001). Family members are expected to show responsibility for one another financially during times of need; loyalty (*pagkamatapat*) to help family members in challenging circumstances is multidirectional. Furthermore, those who have received help are expected to help other family members in a time of need. Neglecting this responsibility can lead to a loss of respect, loss of face, and/or family conflict (Jocano 1998; Medina 2001).

Individuals are expected to exhibit *utang na loob* in the family. *Utang na loob* (“debt of one’s inner self”) denotes the gratitude and respect a Filipino is expected to show to her family and those who have assisted her (Enriquez 1994; Parreñas 2001; Pe-Pua and Protacio-Marcelino 2000). According to Dancel (2005: 114, 118) “. . . *utang na loob* is essentially very difficult, if not impossible to repay, primarily because the debt is an informal and intangible one . . . this ‘unrepayability’ results in a Filipino feeling that he is all the more indebted, and thus strives even more to repay *utang na loob*.” Refusal to exhibit *utang na loob* can lead to a person being labeled as *ingrato*, or someone who is without gratitude.

Research with trafficking survivors in the Southeast Asian context has revealed the intersection of filial piety and survivors’ experiences of financial stress and vulnerability. A sense of responsibility to one’s family can lead survivors to pressure themselves to provide financially for their family, even to their own detriment (Richardson et al. 2009; Smith-Brake et al. 2015). Financial stability for survivors during the community re-entry process is closely linked to family cohesion, acceptance, and stigmatization. Returning home without adequate income can trigger tension with family members over the returnees’ “failed migration” (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012a: 24). Thus, apart from sheer survival, economic stability during the re-entry process is vital to survivors’ psychological well-being and their successful reintegration into the family environment (Derks 1998).

Qualitative research with women trafficked into sex work in the Philippines has revealed the degree of responsibility that some trafficking survivors feel to repay their families. Such research has shown that survivors commonly face regular pressure from family members to provide financially for the extended family and that this responsibility exceeds what is often realistic, given the jobs they can access in the labor market (Lisborg 2009). In a grounded theory study with women trafficked into sex work in

Cebu, Philippines, survivors discussed the gratitude they felt toward parents/caretakers and how this contributed to their decisions to seek employment, including risky employment (Tsai 2017a). Some women reported that they were initially trafficked while looking for income in a time of financial crisis for their parents or caregivers. Confronted with limited employment options, participants, most of whom were adolescents at the time, felt they had no other choice but to take risks in looking for work so that they could help their family (Tsai 2017a). For example, Antonia [pseudonym], a single mother with a young son, who was trafficked as an adolescent during a family crisis, explained the events leading up to her trafficking:

The time when my father got sick, I was like, like the breadwinner at that time. That’s why I worked. And I thought that the work that I got into is a good work . . . [pause, deep breath]. You would realize that it is a bad work, but you really don’t have a choice. I have my son, then my father got sick, so I’m the one who was raising my family that time. So our money was really divided for everyone, for my son and my family. Then I have two sisters and two brothers in school. They are in school and [deep breath] that time, I’m the one [wavering of voice] because I’m the eldest. So that’s it. I would really try hard at this time. [softly] I don’t have any choice. I also couldn’t find a good job because I’m just a high school [student] and I’m not graduated.

(Tsai 2017a: 8)

However, once women exit human trafficking, many survivors report continuing to be the ones that family members rely on for assistance in times of crisis. Survivors also reinforce the disproportionate burden that daughters carry for providing financial assistance to their parents. For instance, one survivor, Caren [pseudonym], explained this phenomenon as she emphasized that parents turn to their daughters for assistance “because the parents know they [daughters]

understand the situation. Yes, and they [daughters] will look for ways to help” (Tsai 2017a: 8). Indeed, trafficked women reported that, even when other female family members (such as sisters) have gainful employment, they themselves as survivors continued to be the ones to meet their parents’ financial needs despite the fact that other family members could have done so.

In this study, women trafficked into sex work described themselves as the ones who were most understanding of their parents’ pressures and needs and therefore the most willing to sacrifice themselves to provide assistance. Their efforts to support their family in crisis led trafficking survivors to experience satisfaction that they had been able to help their parents, but at the same time have regret for the past. Looking back on her trafficking history, Christine [pseudonym] commented:

I thought that we will work at a videoke house, but she [the owner] told us that it is a store that has a videoke and like we will be giving serve [serve orders] but when we got there it's like we are the one being served. Then we just wondered why and I asked [the lady] if we could just go home because I didn't know our job here, but she told us that we cannot because we already owe her a lot. And then after that, I don't have anything that I can do. I just sold myself there. . . It's actually hell where I am going. But I am thankful because even if it is small, I was able to help my Mom. I was able to send some money to her.

(Tsai 2017a: 9)

Although survivors expressed satisfaction in being able to assist their family members, they also expressed frustration that parents and other family members heavily dependent upon debt, would constantly come to them for money when they fell behind on debt payments or had insufficient money to cover daily needs. Jhazel [pseudonym], a 21-year-old survivor who lived with her partner during the study, shared about the impact

that her mother’s financial requests had upon her own financial stability:

We cannot [save]. Even though we save, but my mom will text that they don't have rice. . . There is no day that she [my mother] will not say 'rice, rice.' I will problem about it because our money runs out and it's only Monday. And I would say, 'where would I get [money]?' I will borrow from my partner's mom and she won't let us borrow . . . There is no one that my mom can run to. It's only me, although I have siblings that are married already, she can't ask from them because they also have problems. She will only run to me because I am the only one who understands her.

(Tsai 2017a: 9–10)

When survivors were unable to provide financially for their parents, women expressed concern for their parents’ well-being and guilt for not being able to help them. For instance, Antonia (referred to previously) worried about her father who worked as a mechanic, as he experienced pain due to an ulcer when he did not rest enough or when he was unable to eat on time. Although she would give him extra money and ask him to rest from work for a few days whenever she could, sometimes she had no money to give. As she commented “*Sometimes like I really disappointed if I don't have [any money]. I can't provide help to them. I worry. My father has an ulcer. So like I pity [him] when he works a lot*” (Tsai 2017a: 10).

Findings from the abovementioned research in the Philippines are consistent with research conducted with women who have been trafficked in other parts of Southeast Asia. For example, research with female survivors of trafficking in Vietnam who had returned to live in the community also revealed strong sentiments of filial piety among survivors, especially toward their mothers, many of whom had experienced their own forms of abuse. An inability to provide financially for family members caused anxiety and emotional distress among survivors (Le 2016). Additionally, in a longitudinal study with trafficking survivors

in Cambodia, survivors reported experiencing continuous anxiety about their families' survival over the course of many years following their escape from human trafficking. In this study, a sense of responsibility to provide financially for one's family was associated with feelings of hopelessness and despair, an inability to concentrate, lack of motivation, delaying plans for oneself, sleeplessness, suicidal ideation, headaches, and other physical illnesses (Smith-Brake et al. 2015).

ACCESS TO SUSTAINABLE LIVELIHOOD OPTIONS FOR SURVIVORS

As noted earlier, financial vulnerability is a key risk factor for human trafficking (Bales 2011; Simkhada 2008). People who have been trafficked commonly experience a range of financial challenges prior to trafficking, including family financial crises, a lack of suitable job options, household debt, a sense of responsibility to one's family, and a desire for respect that comes with financial resources (Lisborg 2009). Urgent financial need is often a precipitating factor that impels trafficked persons to migrate in search of work. For example, a survey of female human trafficking survivors in the Philippines found that one of survivors' primary reasons for leaving home prior to being trafficked was to find income generation opportunities so that they could provide financially for their families (Artadi et al. 2011). During their trafficking history, trafficked people are often deprived of wages or may lose wages during police raids (Cavalieri 2011). Upon exiting human trafficking, it is common for survivors to return home without sufficient savings and/or in debt (Lisborg 2009), and the same challenges that originally made them vulnerable to human trafficking are often still present (Le 2016; Tsai 2017a, 2017b).

Upon community reintegration, survivors often face the same lack of adequate labor market opportunities that initially propelled them to

migrate (Lisborg 2009). Research in the Philippines has demonstrated that women who have been trafficked into sex work often face considerable challenges in finding employment upon exiting human trafficking. For example, a six-month financial diaries study with 30 female survivors of sex trafficking in Cebu, Philippines, found that only one-tenth of survivors were able to obtain salaried employment upon exiting human trafficking. All of the women who secured employment did so through assistance provided by Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs). Women who were unable to obtain employment survived predominantly through financial dependence upon their parents or an intimate partner. These survivors, however, faced increased vulnerability to family violence, controlling behaviors from household members, and a perceived need to return to sex work to support the family financially (Tsai 2017b).

Without access to adequate employment within their communities, survivors may have no other choice but to migrate again in search of work (Hennink and Simkhada 2004; Simkhada 2008). For women and girls who have been trafficked into sex work, narratives of family duty and gratitude may influence daughters to return to sex work (Lainez 2015; Simkhada 2008). This dynamic is reflected in the experiences of one of the participants in a financial diaries study with women who were trafficked in the Philippines. Geynalyn [pseudonym], a 20-year-old trafficking survivor, resided with her mother, father, and four younger siblings during the financial diaries study. Her mother had seven children in total. Although Geynalyn's parents had sporadic income, household income was insufficient for daily needs. Upon exiting human trafficking and returning to live in the community, Geynalyn, who had not graduated from high school, was unable to find employment. She returned to work in sex work full-time so that she could financially support her family, and her mother in particular, who struggled to cover basic expenses. Even with Geynalyn's contributions, the income per capita

in this household was well below the poverty line at 804 Philippine pesos (\$US19) per month; household income was, however, substantially higher than it would have been without Geynaly's contributions from the money she earned from sex work (Tsai 2017b).

The financial diaries study also revealed that survivors without employment faced heightened vulnerability to violence and exploitation, from both partners and parents. For example, Jelena [pseudonym] was a 20-year-old trafficking survivor who was unemployed, and with the support of a local NGO, was studying in the Alternative Learning System (ALS). ALS provides access to flexible basic education and allows learners to earn the equivalent of a high school degree. For the majority of the financial diaries study, Jelena resided alone with her father. Her mother was in prison for selling methamphetamines. Although Jelena received small NGO stipends for her education and her participation in reintegration support group meetings, these stipends were insufficient for her needs. During the study, her father (who earned all of the income for the household) raped Jelena. The day following the sexual assault, she fled her home. Although she informed her social worker of the assault, Jelena chose not to press charges, as her father regularly sent money to her mother in jail and she was afraid no one would take care of her mother if her father was imprisoned. During the final three months of the financial diaries study, Jelena moved between various households, and after the study completed, she returned home to live with her parents once her mother was released from prison, as she was unable to financially support herself outside of their household (Tsai 2017b).

Consistent with marital dependence theory, research with trafficking survivors in the Philippines has shown that when survivors are economically dependent on their partners, they are at heightened risk of experiencing Intimate Partner Violence (IPV). Women with limited economic means cannot easily leave violent relationships,

and as such, may have a higher threshold for tolerating violence (Postmus et al. 2012; Shobe and Dienemann 2008; Vyas and Watts 2009). Further, economists have utilized bargaining models to assert that when women's economic resources and opportunities are increased, women are enabled to bargain for better positions for themselves and to leave violent relationships (Vyas and Watts 2009). The grounded theory study of women who had been trafficked into sex work, referred to previously in this chapter, provides an example of financial dependence where a woman remained in an emotionally and physically violent relationship to make sure that her son's material needs were supported. In that case, the partner was emotionally abusive: offering to give her away to his friends, calling her stupid, embarrassing her in front of other people, and accusing her of being unfaithful. Further, the partner regularly hit her and threatened to kill her numerous times. This woman characterized his conduct toward her as "worse than the [sex work] customers before" (Tsai 2017a: 16). Yet, she explained that without an income source of her own, she had no other options than to remain with her partner, as she was uncertain how she would otherwise provide financially for her son (Tsai 2017a).

Such experiences reinforce the link between survivors' financial vulnerability and other forms of vulnerability and violence. Indeed, research with trafficking survivors in the Philippines has shown that once survivors are able to secure employment, family members may prevent them from controlling their own income (Tsai 2017b; Tsai et al. 2017). For example, in the financial diaries study, one survivor, Jehn [pseudonym], who had obtained employment in a fast-food restaurant, had her salary confiscated by her mother each payday; Jehn's income was then utilized to cover the financial needs of the entire household (Tsai 2017b). While it is common in the Filipino context for household members to turn their incomes over to the senior woman in the household who controls much of the household

spending (Ashraf 2009; Eder 2006), survivors' control over their own income is a salient issue, given trafficking survivors' prior experiences of wage confiscation and given the complex relationship between familial expectations and survivors' emotional and financial well-being. Such experiences highlight the importance of attention to control structures within the household that impact upon the use of financial resources, as well as women's safety and well-being.

ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT SERVICES FOR SURVIVORS

When trafficking survivors are asked about their interests and needs following their exit from human trafficking, economic stability and employment are among their highest priorities (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012a; Lisborg and Issara Institute 2017; Lisborg 2009; Richardson et al. 2009; Tsai 2017b). In one qualitative study with Filipina and Thai women who had been trafficked, some women indicated that economic challenges were of greater importance to them than any personal trauma they experienced during their trafficking history. Several women noted that their primary fears upon community reintegration were household debt, a lack of savings, and anxiety about being stigmatized for returning home as a "failed" economic migrant (Lisborg 2009: 4).

At the same time, development agencies serving trafficked persons often face difficulties providing sufficient economic support services to survivors during the community re-entry process, and therefore, many survivors are only given short-term financial assistance upon returning to the community (Le 2016). In addition, many vocational and skills-training programs for trafficked women in Asia only offer a narrow set of gendered vocational training options (such as cooking, knitting, or sewing) and/or provide vocational training that is not relevant to local job markets in survivors' home communities

(Richardson et al. 2009; Surtees 2012). Furthermore, many programs do not adequately consider the interests, desires, goals, and skills of survivors, and do not help survivors access sustainable employment opportunities, or help with financing for business development (Surtees 2012; Tran et al. 2017). Survivors themselves are often critical of the practical merit of NGO or government-run training programs that do not translate into sustainable livelihood options in a competitive market place (Richardson et al. 2009). Programs aiming to link survivors to sustainable livelihoods must duly consider the interests, skills, desires, capabilities, and prior experiences of survivors, and support women in achieving the goals they set for their own lives (Lisborg 2009). At the same time, to ensure sustainability, economic empowerment programs should also position women for success in competitive marketplaces in their community of re-entry or re-settlement (Hennink and Simkhada 2004; Richardson et al. 2009).

Although evidence-based models for promoting economic security for trafficked persons are limited, increasing attention is being given to the design and implementation of economic empowerment programming for trafficked persons in the Philippines. For example, the BARUG program is a financial literacy and matched savings intervention in Cebu City, Philippines, that aims to support the financial stability of trafficking survivors and their families. BARUG is implemented by Eleison Philippines, with funding from the Eleison Foundation. BARUG means "to stand up" in Cebuano, denoting that the program aims to support the economic self-sufficiency of participants. It was designed to supplement other education and employment-related services for trafficked persons in Cebu (Tsai et al. 2017).

BARUG uses a three-pronged approach: financial literacy education, matched savings, and support group meetings. The financial literacy training consists of 12 sessions wherein participants establish long-term and short-term

financial goals and generate individualized plans to achieve their goals (Fry et al. 2008). The second prong of the intervention is a matched savings program, an evidence-based asset development intervention that begins concurrent with the financial literacy training (Sherraden 1991). Informed by asset theory (Sherraden 1990, 1991), BARUG strives to meet institutional gaps in access to safe financial services, providing survivors with the support needed to open a savings account with a vetted financial partner and/or to use a savings deposit service provided through BARUG. For each peso that participants save during the program, their savings are matched at a 1:1 ratio, up to a maximum of 1,000 pesos savings per month (totaling up to 12,000 pesos in matched savings in the one-year program). Upon completion of the financial literacy course, monthly support meetings are held for nine months. Participants meet with program staff monthly to revisit their long-term and short-term goals, review progress toward reaching goals, celebrate accomplishments, and discuss solutions to any difficulties that may arise, and they also participate in monthly peer-support groups (Bandura 1986, 1997). Furthermore, due to the relationship between family financial stability and successful reintegration, and the significance of familial support during the reintegration process, survivors have the option of inviting a family member to join the program with them (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012a; Smith-Brake et al. 2015; Tsai et al. 2017).

In 2016, a participatory assessment was conducted of BARUG utilizing photovoice (Tsai et al. 2017). Photovoice is a Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR) method rooted in feminist theory (Wang et al. 1996), empowerment education (Freire 1970), and documentary photography (Wang and Burris 1994). Participants take photographs of their experiences, providing an opportunity to discuss their lives and relate their experiences in their own voices (Foster-Fishman et al. 2005; Molloy 2007; Sutton-Brown 2014). A participatory approach to assessing

survivors' experiences in the BARUG intervention was adopted in order to engage survivors as active stakeholders in the research process, rather than simply as "subjects" of research, and to promote a sense of ownership over the project while gathering information pertaining to programmatic effectiveness (Cargo and Mercer 2008; Marcu 2016; Miyoshi and Stenning 2008; Palmer et al. 2009). Respect for survivors' autonomy and voices, and for trust building, are central to conducting research with survivors that is sensitive to their experiences (Easton and Matthews 2016; Kelly and Coy 2016; Tsai 2017c). Participatory methodologies may be especially appropriate for research with trafficking survivors, as survivors' trust has routinely been violated through their trafficking histories (Yea 2016).

The photovoice assessment revealed several key implications for the design and implementation of financial capability services for trafficking survivors. Although the BARUG intervention was originally designed as a savings and financial capability program, during the program numerous survivors revealed that they had each taken loans equivalent to the size of their monthly salary from a moneylender who charged them 20 percent interest each payday. Similar to Smith-Brake et al.'s (2015) findings with reintegrated trafficking survivors in Cambodia, survivors were entrenched in an ongoing cycle of debt from which they felt unable to escape. Although survivors were no longer being "trafficked," some of their post-trafficking experiences echoed dynamics inherent in their trafficking histories. As a result, the BARUG team incorporated a debt repayment component into the intervention in response to survivors' input. During the photovoice process, survivors revealed that the support they received to get out of a cycle of debt appeared to be one of the most essential aspects of the program for their emotional well-being and one of the most urgent concerns for survivors themselves (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012a; Smith-Brake et al. 2015).

The photovoice assessment of BARUG also underscored the value of incorporating asset development into economic empowerment programming for women who have been trafficked. Many people who have been trafficked do not have networks they can turn to in emergencies; even temporary financial obstacles can have dire consequences (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012a; Smith-Brake et al. 2015). As referenced earlier, when survivors are living at a subsistence level and face consistent financial pressures from family members, it can be challenging for them to envision a hopeful future or take tangible steps toward future goals, furthering their vulnerability (Smith-Brake et al. 2015). These challenges are also compounded due to the level of trauma that many women who have been trafficked have experienced, not only during their trafficking history, but also in their lives prior to being trafficked (Surtees 2012; Zhang et al. 2009). BARUG participants reported experiencing positive psychological and financial benefits from asset development, stating that having assets helped them build self-efficacy, inspired hope, created a positive orientation toward the future, improved household stability, and generated a heightened sense of control over their financial situation (Sherraden 1991; Tsai et al. 2017). One of the most commonly reported benefits of participation in the BARUG intervention was the positive emotional benefits that survivors said they obtained from heightened financial stability. For example, one woman participating in the photovoice study expressed the following about her experience of getting out of debt during the BARUG intervention:

I remember that I always think that I don't have hope in life because of lots of debts . . . I even thought about committing suicide because my debt affected me so much. I kept thinking about it. I was irritable and I easily get angry. We always fight with my partner and parents because of my problems with debt, but now I feel hopeful again.

(Tsai et al. 2017: 11)

Findings from the photovoice study highlighted the importance of services that are sensitive to survivors' socio-cultural realities and that provide an emotionally supportive environment in which survivors can process financial pressures in their family environment. Survivors in the photovoice project grappled with the extent of their responsibility to their families when confronted with their own needs (Brunovskis and Surtees 2012b; Smith-Brake et al. 2015). During the photovoice process, survivors reported that they found BARUG to be a safe space in which they could explore familial tension and make progress in resolving how to meet their own needs while honoring responsibilities to family members (Tsai et al. 2017). Such findings reinforce the importance of ensuring that economic empowerment interventions for trafficking survivors are facilitated in such a way that survivors can openly discuss filial piety and financial responsibilities within the family and that survivors receive emotional support pertaining to financial challenges within the family context (Smith-Brake et al. 2015; Tsai et al. 2017). Additionally, as demonstrated through the photovoice process, meaningful participation of survivors throughout all stages of the program development, implementation, and evaluation process can be instrumental in not only building survivor ownership, but also in gathering vital information for enhancing programmatic effectiveness (Miyoshi and Stenning 2008). Authentic and active partnership with trafficking survivors themselves is vital to efforts to improve services in the counter-trafficking sector (Boontin and 2012).

CONCLUSION

Considerable attention in the counter-trafficking movement has been rightfully given to human rights abuses experienced during the trafficking process. Survivors' experiences after they exit trafficking have, however, been insufficiently addressed. When women are asked about their

interests and needs upon escaping human trafficking, access to safe and sustainable livelihoods is often one of the highest priorities articulated by survivors. However, as demonstrated through the survivors' voices highlighted in this chapter, economic empowerment for trafficked persons cannot be reduced to a single element, such as employment. As articulated by survivors themselves, interventions that support survivors in reducing debt and building assets, while also providing an emotionally safe environment in which to discuss financial responsibilities within the family, show promise. Furthermore, proactive efforts to minimize risks of family violence and financial exploitation, as well as monitoring any adverse impacts of participation in interventions, are crucial in order to ensure that reintegration support and economic empowerment interventions genuinely reduce survivors' risk of violence and exploitation. Likewise, efforts to strengthen economic empowerment services in the counter-trafficking sector must be conducted in partnership with trafficked women themselves and with survivors' voices and experiences at the center. Although economic empowerment interventions alone are insufficient to facilitate healthy community re-entry for trafficking survivors, economic empowerment services represent one important component of a holistic system of care aimed at supporting survivors' well-being and security upon escaping human trafficking.

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Chapter thirteen

Women as Natural Caregivers? Migration, Healthcare Workers, and Eldercare in Singapore

Shirlena Huang and Brenda S. A. Yeoh

INTRODUCTION

Many of the world's more affluent nations are confronting an extremely critical situation, if not a crisis, pertaining to aged care. With the percentage of working-age population as a proportion of the total population falling steadily over the last few decades, the challenge of aging populations is now a reality for many governments across the world. According to the World Bank, the age-dependency ratio (for the working-age population) is now 53.9 percent, down from 76.5 percent just 50 years ago (World Bank 2017). Not surprisingly then, there has been a growing demand for healthcare workers for the elderly, across the whole spectrum of care labor, from skilled medical professionals to mid-skilled personnel to less skilled nursing aides, in countries of the Global North, including those in Asia, such as Japan, Korea, and Singapore that are among the fastest aging societies in the world.

This “labour-demanding ‘silver tsunami’” is a result of “the convergence of demographic and epidemiological factors” (Connell and Walton-Roberts 2016: 164), with people living longer but not necessarily healthier lives, and with a rise in chronic diseases. In conjunction with falling fertility rates, high labor force participation rates of women, and the economic ability to “outsource”

healthcare beyond the family, the demand for healthcare workers in the world's more affluent countries is not expected to decline anytime soon. At the same time, however, these countries are also facing the challenge of on the one hand having tight domestic supplies of acute and long-term care workers due to aging care worker populations, and on the other hand the lack of renewal of the local nursing and care workforce, as many of their citizens shy away from care work. The shortage is particularly critical in the less desirable sectors and in areas of care work such as eldercare, which as well as being demanding and sometimes “dirty” work, is often also poorly paid (Folbre 2006). While the demand in wealthier countries has been largely met by bringing in migrant healthcare workers from developing countries, there is a global shortage of workers of about 174 million healthcare workers, over half of whom are nurses and midwives, as well as community health and personal care workers. Ironically, while the largest needs-based shortages of health workers are found in the Global South, such as in Southeast Asia (WHO 2016: 44), some governments (such as India, Nepal, and the Philippines) produce an oversupply of nurses specifically for export as part of their development strategy (Connell and Walton-Roberts 2016; Khadria 2007; Kingma 2006).

Foremost among developed states' concerns is how to provide adequate and cost-effective healthcare and social care for the growing numbers of dependent elderly. To decrease the burden on state resources, many governments in high-income countries have adopted a neoliberal approach, with a shift toward market regulation and greater dependence on voluntarism and communities to support the aging in place, as the burden of eldercare has been transferred onto the elderly and their families (Milligan 2017). Those who can afford it are able to turn to the market by paying for institutional or private home care; those who cannot must depend on themselves, community home-based care, or (female) family members. In this context, a large vein of academic literature has coalesced around the sustainability of alternative modes of healthcare provision as the state has stepped back, with concerns and debates focusing on the effects of the privatization of healthcare and the increasing dependence on foreign care workers (see Yeoh and Huang 2010).

Feminist scholars also have pointed out the strongly gendered nature of care work/labor. By care work, we refer to any interpersonal, often hands-on, service that contributes to the physical, emotional, psychological, and cognitive maintenance and development of the individuals receiving the care (see Huang 2017 for a fuller discussion). Whether done in the market, community, or home, and regardless of whether it is done for pay or out of love or obligation, care-giving as a woman's province has continued to be a feature of modern society (Power 2017). This is patently obvious when examining how care duties are often "offloaded" by women in wealthier countries down the global care chain to other women from less developed countries, whether in the reproductive sphere for domestic service workers (Hochschild 2000) or in the productive arena for healthcare workers, including nurses and other paraprofessional staff, such as certified nurse assistants, home health aides, and personal care attendants (Huang et al. 2012;

Yeates 2009). In the process, migrant care workers often end up experiencing downward occupational mobility through deskilling (e.g., from doctors to nurses; from nurses to nursing assistants) as well as racism and disempowerment through systematic patterns of discrimination by employers (e.g., assigned less desirable work or provided only limited promotion prospects). Immigration policies often exacerbate labor market inequalities by restricting migrants to particular categories of jobs, often for a limited time period, despite migrants' skills, educational histories, and previous class positions in their home countries. Thus, even for trained healthcare workers such as nurses, the "[t]ransition between labour markets is rarely smooth, and regulatory barriers exact costs through credential devaluation" (Connell and Walton-Roberts 2016: 164). In combination, these mechanisms redefine the class position of migrant care workers as they move across transnational space, calling attention to the gendered, classed, and racialized/ethnicized ways in which migrant others are inequitably incorporated into care networks.

Regardless of whether the work is taken on by locals or migrants, care work continues to defy the traditional logics of economic theory with its economic value remaining low, even when demand outstrips the supply, in the face of rising demand for such care workers as the number of elderly citizens has increased in societies across the globe. As discussed below, it has often been argued that this is because those who undertake paid care work—typically women—do so out of duty and altruism, gaining satisfaction from being able to help those who need care rather than from monetary reward. In this chapter, we examine these assumptions by focusing on the case of healthcare workers in Singapore's nursing homes. Before doing so, we examine in greater detail, the notions of care and care work, and how they have come to be associated with women and have come to be undervalued.

DISCOURSES OF (PAID) CARE WORK

As feminists have consistently pointed out, a discourse of devaluation, in terms of both status and remuneration, marks all levels of care work despite it being a valuable service to society. This is first and foremost because “care enters the market as historically gendered and domesticated practices” (Green and Lawson 2011: 650), an extension of the nurturing work that women, as daughters, wives and especially mothers, do in the home out of love and obligation (Ryan 2008). Care work is also recognized as highly relational work requiring not only physical interaction, but also emotional labor between caregiver and recipient, with women assumed to “possess the desired attributes of face, touch and voice that effectively communicate affective caring” (Huang et al. 2012: 208). Moreover, as we have argued elsewhere (Huang et al. 2012), it is not simply care work but the “dirty parts of care work”—and eldercare work is thought to be particularly dirty work as it involves dealing with bodily effusions and excrement—that are associated with femininity and female-dominated work in most cultures. This is because “intimate care seems to be difficult to combine with ideas of masculinity” as it threatens male identity (Isaksen 2005: 123–124) on the one hand, and in contrast to women as maternal and protective, on the other hand hegemonic masculinity constructs men as potential sexual predators, especially in relation to hands-on care work of the body (Twigg 2000). These gendered associations are so strong that when demand for caring labor cannot be met domestically, it spills across national borders and women migrants are brought in to fill the demand rather than relying on the male citizenry (Jacoby 2006: 7).

Indeed, the extent to which care is idealized as a feminized activity is such that when commoditized, care work suffers from a wage

penalty not just in relation to other jobs, but also relative to other *women's* jobs of similar skill levels that do not involve care. Devaluation also occurs because care workers are said to be motivated primarily by altruism and a strong sense of “duty to care,” embodying “notions of vocation, self-sacrifice and philanthropic benevolence” (Bridges 1990: 851). This is not simply a Western notion born out of the iconic image of Florence Nightingale, but it is also reflected in several Asian cultures. For example, for the Chinese, Confucian teachings have influenced the way caring and nursing are performed through the notion that “active benevolence implies a centrality of care and the ability to help others” (Holroyd et al. 1998: 1290). In Japan, Gregg and Magilvy (2001) noted how nursing is not merely motivated by benevolence but also associated with accessing one's humaneness, while for the Thais, the Buddhist notion of *kreng jai* (the idea of always thinking of the other person first) permeates nursing culture and practices (Burnard and Naiyapatana 2004).

The intrinsic fulfillment gained from the job itself (especially as the people who need care the most are usually least able to afford it) supposedly compensates for the lack of recognition and low pay they receive (England et al. 2002). More specifically, in her study of home care aides, Stacey (2011: 107) argued that care workers manage their difficult (and at times exploitive) work conditions and disenfranchised social status by constructing a “caring self”: a situated workplace identity that enables them to “communicate to themselves and others that their work is altruistically motivated and of high quality” and that gives meaning to their work, despite the inequalities they experience on the job. According to Stacey (2011), the “caring self” is constructed through three types of “identity talk,” namely by narrating care as being a natural ability and/or a gift or calling from God; by emphasizing an ethic of care and service to others, underscoring their altruistic motives and the real difference their work makes to the lives

of those they care for; and by underscoring their superior caregiving skills relative to uncaring others (such as doctors, fellow care workers, and family members) to give themselves a sense of dignity and moral worth. The “caring self” identity justifies the heavy emotional investment in their work and clients, but it also results in workers struggling to erect boundaries between their professional and personal time, and some may even come to believe that they are indispensable. Stacey (2011: 63) found that care workers often provided “surplus care,” taking on additional hours of work, tasks and expenses without compensation, and giving themselves “familial titles” (e.g. wife, mother, child, grandma) in relation to their patients. While the “caring self” identity leads to self-validation for the care workers, it also demonstrates how care workers themselves contribute to the continued understanding of care work as gendered and altruistic by essentializing the disposition to care as a natural skill or ability, by reinforcing the stereotype of care workers as ministering angels who are prepared to go beyond duty, innately motivated by selflessness and compassion, as well as by focusing on the relational dimensions/nonmaterial impulses (the emotional and relational gains) rather than the material factors (monetary) of their work.

Yet, the literature also highlights that the meanings of and motivations for care and care work, especially when performed in an institutional setting, are more complex than these essentialized notions. More significantly, since Hochschild’s (1983) ground-breaking study on *The Managed Heart*, it is now generally recognized that care work, like other service work, is a form of emotional labor wherein workers are expected to overtly manage their emotions and expressions of these emotions in the form of either “‘surface acting,’ when emotions are displayed on the surface of the body ... without being felt by the worker” or by suppressing unwanted emotions and manufacturing desired emotions (Entwistle 2017: 1). In the case of

nursing, for example, it has been noted that nurses do not always manifest authentic caring because they are often overextended at work and have little time or inclination “to do the little things that matter to patients.” Indeed, some healthcare facilities have thus endorsed a “scripted discourse” in nurses’ communications to improve patient satisfaction scores and ensure the financial bottom line because “dissatisfied consumers are not an option” (Duffy 2011; Hogan 2013: 375).

That care work may be managed, manufactured and scripted is evidence that care is not necessarily a natural attribute of care workers, but it does little to dispel care work’s normative gendered associations since much of service work remains female-dominated (Entwistle 2017). Beyond challenging the notion that caring is a natural attribute of women care workers, in this chapter we examine the idea that care workers are primarily motivated by altruism and have genuine care and emotional connection with their care recipients. In other words, is a highly skilled nurse, who scripts her performance, a less effective care worker than one less skilled but with higher natural empathy? As a means to move away from universalist visions of care, we examine gendered and ethnicized/cultural dimensions to explore how male and female healthcare workers providing eldercare in Singapore’s nursing homes validate their identity and worth as care workers. We have chosen to focus on care workers in an institutional setting because, while institutional frameworks of healthcare systems have received considerable attention, the healthcare workers employed in these institutions have remained “largely in the background,” like “ghosts in the machine,” distinct from the institutions in which they work (Connell and Walton-Roberts 2016: 162). In the next section, we first set the context of the discussion by describing the looming eldercare crisis in Singapore and the state’s response to it, and how nursing homes feature in the city-state’s eldercare landscape of care.

THE SINGAPORE CONTEXT: MANAGING THE ELDERCARE CRISIS

As a society with one of the fastest aging populations in Asia, Singapore is facing an impending “silver tsunami.” By 2030, it is expected that the elderly (defined as those 65 years or older) will comprise almost a quarter of the population (about 900,000 people), up from the current 13 percent (Ministry of Health 2016: 8). With life expectancy being high (80.4 for men and 84.9 for women in 2015) and the total fertility rate remaining low (1.24), the old age support ratio (those aged 20–64: ≥65) has declined steadily. While one elderly person was supported by 9.9 working persons in the year 2000, the ratio has dropped to only 5.4 in 2016 (Department of Statistics Singapore 2016) and if current trends continue, it could decline further to 2.1 by 2030 (National Population and Talent Division 2013: 13).

The implications of these trends for the health-care and social support services in the country, as well as for the elderly’s family members, are significant. Specifically, research has found that the elderly in Singapore are about four times more likely to be hospitalized and also require more long-term care in the community (National Population and Talent Division 2012: 3). Furthermore, the independence of Singaporeans has declined considerably with age; for example, the prevalence of chronic ailments (including high blood pressure, high blood cholesterol, diabetes, arthritis, and eye/vision problems) for those 75 years old and above was generally double the levels of their counterparts aged 55–65 years, and over 7 percent of those 75 years and above required some/total physical assistance or were bedridden (Kang et al. 2013: 60, 67–68). Gender differences in health are also observable, with Singapore women spending 10.7 percent of their lives in ill health compared to 9.4 percent for men (*Straits Times* 2017a). By 2030, it is expected that one in three people will need some form of

eldercare service and the majority of these will be women. While older women are at higher risk of chronic illnesses and mental illness than men, partly because of longer life expectancy (Chan et al. 2010), they have “a lower likelihood of access to appropriate health and social care which represents out-of-pocket expenses” and a greater dependence on their children for financial resources than men of the same age (Wu and Chan 2011: 514, 523).

As with other developed countries, Singapore has employed “a cost containment strategy” to manage the rising fiscal concerns in eldercare, while also developing “healthcare technology and the restructuring of healthcare work from skilled healthcare professionals to less skilled caregivers” (Yantzi and Skinner 2009: 403). The state promotes the family as the primary caregiving unit and institutional care as the last resort (MCDS 2001: 8) for those needing chronic care.¹ In this step-down model of eldercare, the state continues to manage the funding frameworks as well as ensuring the provision of acute care of the elderly; all other aspects of responsibility for the elderly, including their long-term care, are transferred to the community, the family, and the elderly individuals themselves (Teo 2004). In other words, the Singapore state sees “home and community care as the anchor of [its] aged care system” (Khor 2015). Although this is consistent with “Asian values” of filial piety that have children taking care of elderly parents and relatives, in most cases this translates into the burden of care falling primarily on the women in the family. If the elderly are not (too) ill, families that can afford it often either delegate the care to foreign live-in domestic workers or place the elderly in nursing homes. Beyond providing residential care, nursing homes also play a crucial role in delivering both day care facilities and home care services for the elderly. Elderly needing more specialized medical care may also be placed in community hospitals or “chronic sick hospitals,” or families can arrange for home visits by nurses and doctors.

Recognizing that “population ageing will be massive in the next decade,” the state “has been building up capacity rapidly, and enhancing the quality and affordability” of facilities to support “ageing in place”: for example, increasing the number of home care places by 71 percent, the number of home palliative care places by 32 percent, and the number of day care places by 48 percent (Khor 2015). The state has also begun to increase the number of nursing home beds from the current 12,000, with a target of 17,000 by 2020 (*Straits Times* 2017b). Critics have noted that this is inadequate. Despite the increase in absolute capacity, the number of beds per 1,000 people aged 65 and above has fallen from 27.9 in 2000 to 26.1 in 2015, and will probably be insufficient to meet the demands of the 50,000 elderly who will need some form of residential care by 2030 (Basu 2016).

The number of elderly residing in nursing homes in Singapore is still relatively low, at about 3 percent, compared to about 5 percent in the United States, Australia, and Finland (Basu 2016). There are various negative perceptions associated with nursing homes in Singapore as they are viewed as “dark, depressing places, filled with moaning, sick, demented people, most of whom [have] no family or . . . [have been] abandoned by loved ones” (Basu 2016: 26). However, the number residing in nursing homes in Singapore is expected to increase quite rapidly over the next few years because of the rising numbers of physically and cognitively frail elderly (as noted earlier), the number of elderly staying on their own because they are single (as marriage rates have declined) or because they have lost their spouse, fewer family members available to provide care at home as both spouses hold full-time jobs, and a changing attitude toward nursing homes as newer, more affordable, and higher quality options have come onto the market. Indeed, nursing homes in Singapore, particularly the more affordable ones, are run by Voluntary Welfare Organizations (VWOs), currently already have waiting lists of several months (Basu 2016;

Straits Times 2016a). Because of this, some Singaporean families have resorted to “exporting” their elderly family members to neighboring Malaysia where nursing homes are new and more affordable, and have better facilities and beds that are readily available (*Straits Times* 2015a, 2015b). A recent survey of nearly 1,000 younger Singaporeans found that approximately half would be willing to move into a nursing home when they get old; nine in ten of these preferred to do so only if they could stay in single or twin rooms, rather than the dormitory-style facilities with six to eight beds that are most commonly available in Singapore currently (*Straits Times* 2016b).

The expansion of the intermediate and long-term care sector, including nursing homes, in Singapore has been crucially limited by the lack of local healthcare workers, both skilled (nurses) and less skilled (nursing aides and healthcare attendants). Active steps have been taken by the state to raise the productivity of the healthcare sector as well as expand the local supply of nurses—including raising the pay, expanding the “local training pipelines,” and encouraging retired nurses and those who make mid-career switches, “especially women,” to become healthcare workers (Khor 2015). Despite this, the number of new entrants is still below the levels needed to replace those who are retiring, and turnover is high. Locals continue to shun eldercare work, particularly in nursing homes, because the job is regarded as dirty, smelly, and difficult, with demanding workloads yet offering low pay and little prospect for career advancement (Basu 2016; Huang et al. 2012). While acknowledging the language and cultural issues that foreign healthcare workers need to overcome in adapting to local work practices, the state has also recognized that Singapore has had to, and will continue to, depend on migrant healthcare workers to augment its local supply (Khor 2016). For example, it is expected that 70 percent of the 9,000 new support healthcare staff positions that will be needed between now

and 2030 will be met through foreign recruitment (National Population and Talent Division 2012: 5–6).

Most of the migrant healthcare workers for Singapore's long-term eldercare sector are recruited from Burma, China, the Philippines, India, and Sri Lanka, and the overwhelming majority are women. Many of the foreign-trained nurses from Asia moving to Singapore to work are employed as healthcare attendants, nursing aides, or "enrolled nurses" on work permits (as semi-skilled to unskilled workers) instead of full-fledged nurses. Further, they are employed in one of Singapore's 70-plus nursing homes, rather than hospitals, because their qualifications and training are not fully recognized or are deemed inadequate to work as a staff or registered nurse in Singapore.

Only rarely do migrant healthcare workers enter as registered nurses on an intermediate level visa called an S-pass. Those who do enter on the S-pass are allowed to bring in their dependents once their pay crosses a certain minimum threshold, and in due course, they may also apply for permanent residency and citizenship. In contrast, those on work permits do not enjoy such privileges. Given the reluctance of local nurses to work in nursing homes, these institutions have little choice but to depend on migrants for the majority of their workforce. Because the role of nursing homes in the provision of eldercare in Singapore is recognized as crucial by the state, they have been allowed some flexibility in employing migrant workers, sometimes up to 90 percent (although the official limit has been 80–85 percent) of their workforce, particularly at the level of enlisted nurses and below (Huang et al. 2012). Not surprisingly, then, local nurses are usually at the top of the nursing home hierarchy (as nursing directors and staff nurses), while migrant workers fill the lower levels as enrolled nurses, nursing aides, and healthcare attendants who, as we discuss later, do the most demanding "hands-on" eldercare work in the nursing home.

In the remainder of this chapter, we examine whether care work is seen as more natural for women than men in Singapore's nursing homes and also how and why healthcare workers (both local and foreign) employed in Singapore's nursing homes negotiate their motivations for becoming nurses with the heavy demands, difficult conditions, and lack of prestige of eldercare work: and for migrant workers, the discriminatory treatment they may receive from the elderly patients and the latter's family members. As cultural understandings of care and care work affect how nursing and care work are understood, performed and validated, we also seek to draw out the gendered and ethnicized differences in how the workers validate their identity and worth as care workers. The data for the analysis is drawn from personal interviews conducted with 35 migrant care workers (13 from Burma, 11 from the People's Republic of China (PRC), 7 from the Philippines, and 4 from India) and 9 local (Singaporean) care workers employed in nursing homes in Singapore.² Of the 44 respondents, 38 were women. We also interviewed men so as to better understand the gendered differences in undertaking care work. Of the six male respondents, five were foreigners and one was a local. In utilizing a feminist approach, we employed qualitative methods to understand the meanings of health and healthcare in everyday contexts. In-depth interviews with respondents were conducted in either their native language and/or English, and we also visited several nursing homes in Singapore.

DOING ELDERCARE WORK IN SINGAPORE

Are Women Naturally Better at Care Work?

Dahle (2005: 130) has argued that in healthcare work such as nursing, "men are regarded as

intruders . . . in a system over which women claim full jurisdiction.” This is largely evidenced in Singapore’s nursing homes where we found that almost all levels of healthcare work—except for the very top (doctors) and bottom ranks (healthcare attendants)—are culturally coded as women’s work. The healthcare workers themselves also tend to accept this stereotype. Female healthcare workers, in particular, often observed that “as women,” they “naturally” paid more attention to details and were more sensitive to patients’ needs as opposed to the men who tended to be careless and could be rough. A PRC nursing aide even claimed that being a woman made her a better caregiver *“just like a mother takes better care of a child than a father.”* As a local female staff nurse stated, *“for nursing care, a lady is better than a male because of the soft side of a woman.”* She also noted that the elderly patients appeared to prefer female nurses, as did other nurses, some of whom shared that *“some female patients refuse to be touched and taken care of by a male nurse.”* However, the men felt that care was not necessarily the natural province of women; as an Indian healthcare attendant commented, *“I don’t think whether you are a man or woman makes a difference. I think it is really based on the individual.”* Regardless of this, societal perceptions mean that *“female nurses have an advantage . . . no matter how well I do [as a male nurse], they [the patients] still look at me as a man”* while what the patient is looking for in a caregiver, according to a Singaporean male nursing manager, is *“the image of the mother, the image of a sister, and [for male patients] the image of the wife.”*

While societal stereotypes place male caregivers at a disadvantage, it is important to make several caveats to this gendered generalization. *First*, the healthcare workers note that “natural” caregiving ability varies across cultures. As we have argued elsewhere, “[a]ttributes ascribed to nationality can disrupt the idealized image of the female nurse” (Huang et al. 2012: 208), with care seen as being part of (or lacking in) the culture of

a nation. In the main, healthcare workers across all nationalities spoke of the Burmese (and to a lesser extent, the Filipinos) as more “naturally” caring and compassionate over other nationalities, and Singaporeans (and PRC nationals) as being on the other end of this caring scale. This ability to project care is important as it can overcome language and communication barriers between the foreign healthcare workers and the patients (Yeoh and Huang 2015). National stereotypes were often self-attributed, either positively—for example, a Burmese nursing aide noted that *“We are a very caring people”*—or negatively as more than one PRC care worker observed that the lack of ability to emotionally care for others cuts across the whole current generation of young Chinese, many of whom have been raised as pampered singletons and therefore suffer from the “Little Emperor/Empress Syndrome.” Thus, inasmuch as it is assumed that caring may generally come more naturally for women, culture and nationality act as important mediating factors to this generalized perception.

Second, healthcare workers contend that even if one does not initially exhibit the feminine attributes of caring, one can learn to care, and not simply in a scripted fashion. A PRC enrolled nurse shared how she learned to emotionally care for her elderly charges through physical acts of care, such as having to bathe and feed them, and interact with them:

Having to do these things [manual tasks] made me learn more about my “caring side.” I learnt how to care for the elderly patients. It’s very hard to explain . . . you have to observe how they behave to know exactly whether they need something or whether they are feeling uncomfortable. I also learnt patience. This is very important when dealing with elderly dementia patients.

Thus, while not a “natural” caregiver, this worker learned to care about the patients through her work, rather than just physically caring for them and/or learning to stage an act of caring. This is

consistent with what Gregg and Magilvy (2001) found in their study of Japanese nurses. In their study, the participants moved through six stages of commitment to nursing, beginning with “learning from working experiences” before progressing to “recognizing the value of nursing” until they reached a stage where their professional and personal identities merge; notably, as they continued working as nurses, they learned about nursing and themselves through their interactions with clients and other nurses, and their commitment became increasingly focused on care (Gregg and Magilvy 2001: 50–51).

Third, the workers also argued that possessing the skills to care for a patient are as, if not more, crucial as one’s “natural” ability to care. This includes having the requisite knowledge and training to deal with challenging patients and unexpected circumstances (especially given that many of the elderly have dementia and are liable to be temperamental and even violent). As a female enrolled nurse countered when asked whether she thought women make better care workers than men:

Well, it’s hard to say. [When] I think in terms of technical skills and knowledge, I remember that when I was still studying, a lot of the top students in my cohort are the men. Their clinical skills are excellent.

Thus, she concluded that while women make better caregivers, they do not necessarily make better nurses or healthcare workers. Similarly, while a PRC nursing aide concurred that “*Burmese are the best carers*,” she also made it very clear that, for her, actual competencies to provide care were more important than stereotypes of “*caring nationals*.” She recounted an incident in which a female Burmese nursing aide “*was just too shocked to react*” when she failed to adequately support a patient as she was transferring him from his bed to a wheelchair, but another Filipino nursing aide standing nearby was the epitome of professionalism as she “*knew exactly*

what to do, like checking whether the elderly patient had broken any bones or hurt himself badly” (see Yeoh and Huang 2015: 255).

Why do Care Workers Engage in Eldercare Work?

Given the gendered associations of care with women, it is not surprising that “caregiving as altruism” is argued to “derive from mothering instincts” (Abel-Smith 1960, cited in Bridges 1990: 851). But is altruism really what motivates care workers to undertake eldercare work in a nursing home, which is not only difficult, dirty, and demanding but also entails low pay and low recognition? Basu, for example, records the case of Ms Gunasekara, a Sri Lankan healthcare worker in a nursing home in Singapore, who was the sole care giver for 33 residents and was overworked. Among her many duties, she would change diapers and tube-feed residents. She felt underpaid and left her job in the nursing home to work as a domestic helper for an elderly couple. “The way she [Ms Gunasekara] told it, looking after just one elderly couple was a cakewalk after struggling daily with 33 bed-bound old folks” (Basu 2016: 47).

Indeed, Ms Gunasekara’s duties and work schedule are quite typical for the healthcare workers in Singapore’s nursing homes. A Singaporean nursing aide we interviewed noted how her duties required that she “*juggle feeding and bathing up to 18 elderly patients*” every day. With some being slow eaters or needing to be fed, she could only manage bathing two-thirds at breakfast and had to bathe the rest at teatime. Some healthcare workers also described how bathing and feeding became like a production chain where one would bathe the patient, another would dry and change him/her, while a third would handle the feeding. An often-repeated refrain we heard from the respondents—“*bathing patients and changing diapers is not what we trained as nurses for*”—reflects the “dissonance

between workers' identification and training to value the relational aspects of care" (for example, being nurturing, and engaging emotionally with the patients) and their inability to follow this model in the workplace, leading to internal conflict for the workers (Duffy 2011: 72, 89). On the other hand, the overextended care worker may have little inclination "to do the little things that matter to patients" (Hogan 2013: 375).

Yet, as Stacey (2011) also found in her study, while there was some frustration in the way healthcare workers described their work, there was also a strong sense of pride in the way the workers spoke about being able to handle the smells, long hours, and even abuse from patients with dementia. Several foreign healthcare workers spoke with scorn about colleagues who struggled with the difficult aspects of eldercare work. A PRC nursing aide recalled, with some derision, a Singaporean nurse who had quit after just two days of work at the nursing home. She commented, "*If you are afraid of the bad smells, then you are not suited to be a nurse. A nurse should never be turned off by filth,*" implying that she was not put off by bad smells and bodily fluids. A few (mainly the female nurses from Singapore and the male foreign nurses) took pains to highlight how a nurse's motivation must come from a desire to make a difference in the lives of the elderly patients, even at the expense of pay. For example:

It's good to help people, that's my aim . . . so when I came here, you know, my pay was not very good [but] I never think about that part of it . . . I didn't go and ask them why you give me only this [amount]?

(Female Singapore staff nurse who took a "significant pay cut" when she joined the nursing home.)

I'm very happy to take care of the elderly. It's because of my nature—I just love to see people happy. I'm proud to work in a nursing home even if it's one step down [from a hospital].

(Female Singaporean nursing aide explaining why she made a mid-career switch to

nursing and chose to work in a nursing home rather than a hospital.)

I feel that a nursing job is really for those who are interested in caring for others and those who think they can really serve others.

(Male PRC nursing aide.)

It sounds very stupid but nursing is really a very good job. You help a lot of people. It's not like a normal worker where you just earn money.

(Male Burmese nursing aide.)

Workers also highlighted their own or their colleagues' dedication to the patients by describing how they treat the latter "*like family*." For example, a female Filipino enrolled nurse commented: "*Because we live in the nursing home and we see them every day, we don't treat them like patients. They are like part of our family.*" This discourse of "fictive kin" (Stacey 2011) was especially prevalent in the identity talk of the Burmese and Filipino respondents. Others spoke with admiration about the Burmese workers' dedication in terms of not drawing a boundary between personal and professional time; for example, a female PRC nursing aide shared that "*Even during the nights, after working hours, they will walk around and make sure that everything is alright.*"

But altruism and selflessness were not part of the motivations of many of the workers. For the foreign healthcare workers, there was general resentment at having to stay in the nursing home, resulting in them being "on call 24/7." Further, almost all of the migrant healthcare workers shared that their initial impetus to become a nurse was to get a job (because the job market was poor in their countries) and/or to travel. Indeed, many saw Singapore as a stepping-stone to achieving their longer-term career goals. For example, a female PRC enrolled nurse noted that "*after working in Singapore, I can go to any other country to work. Other countries love hiring healthcare workers from Singapore . . . I think it's because Singapore has a good reputation for*

producing quality healthcare workers." The higher pay overseas was also a key motivation for undertaking care work. Indeed, the Singapore senior nurses we spoke to all highlighted how the foreign workers took the earliest opportunity to apply to work in hospitals once they became Permanent Residents (PR), and/or had gained sufficient local nursing experience and passed their evaluations with the Ministry of Health so they could register with the Singapore Nursing Board. As a local female staff nurse lamented:

Once they have PR, they will check the market to compare salaries at other institutions, and they usually will leave for the highest salary . . . They want to go to the hospital to learn more things. Once they are a PR, they know there is a career path overseas.

A female nursing manager pointed out that putting career over care was not unique to the migrant worker and that most of the current generation of younger Singaporean nurses, *"if they're ambitious, very ambitious, they would not want to come to a nursing home. Only if we can offer them a nursing director position, they may consider."* Another local nursing manager, a male, noted that *"younger nurses today are very calculative in demarcating what they will do . . . but I don't blame them because it's not glamorous and status-wise, it's not that great."* According to them, it is primarily the older workers, who make a mid-career switch to join nursing, who *"really like to serve the elderly."*

Overall, then, while some degree of selflessness does permeate the way most healthcare workers, both local and foreign, view themselves as eldercare workers and they do try their best to extend authentic care and compassion while on the job, the hard work, low pay and lack of prestige mean that the workers often do not stay long. Thus, not only does the long-term sector find it difficult to recruit care staff, but nursing homes find it a challenge to retain their care workers because of the realities tied to the demanding work involved and workers' career ambitions.

CONCLUSION

Like many other rapidly aging developed countries, globalization has meant that Singapore's demand for eldercare workers has so far been met by *migrant* healthcare workers. Socio-demographic changes (including people living longer, a decline in fertility rates, and the rise in nuclear two-income families), however, will present continued challenges of an aging population. While this deepening care deficit crisis increases Singapore's reliance on foreign care workers for eldercare, there is no guarantee that it will continue to enjoy the availability of migrant labor flows, given the growing global competition for these workers as more societies age and as migrant care workers see Singapore as only a stepping-stone to better career prospects elsewhere. With the Singapore state pushing responsibility onto the community, family, and the individual elderly, alongside efforts to expand its local workforce of eldercare givers, a more fundamental change is needed in how care is understood and how care work is valued in Singaporean society.

In this chapter, we have demonstrated that although care and care work are still socially constructed as more "naturally feminine" than masculine, this gendered generalization does not always hold to the same degree across cultures and nationalities (e.g., female care workers of some nationalities were thought to lack this ability to care). We also argued that care can be learned and acquired in the course of carrying out care work, and that technical skills are deemed to be as crucial as the relational aspects of care in looking after the elderly. Furthermore, while some care workers demonstrate dedication and selflessness in looking after the elderly, undertaking care work is rarely motivated primarily and solely by an intrinsic desire to serve others. Instead, for many, eldercare work is less about care than it is about work and a stepping-stone to enhanced employment in the future. It is thus crucial to challenge traditional and essentialized gendered notions of care as primarily women's

responsibility, whether in the form of care labor provided by a family member or as a paid service performed by either migrant workers or locals. We argue for the need to move away from an asymmetric reliance on women's labor to shore up the "care front" and to expect men to contribute to care-giving, both in the home setting and in the workplace. This will require both state and society to affirm care as a significant aspect of masculine identities and men's contribution to care as a vital resource. The defeminization of care should help to improve how it is valued socially and valorized in monetary terms, leading to better pay in this sector which, hopefully, will facilitate recruitment and retention for all forms of care work, including care work in nursing homes. In combination, this should lead to more sustainable eldercare support in the longer term.

NOTES

- 1 Anticipating the rapid silvering of its population, Singapore previously set up several committees to make policy recommendations on eldercare, e.g., the Committee on the Problems of the Aged (1982–84); the Inter-Ministerial Committee on the Ageing Population in the late 1990s.
- 2 The interview material is drawn selectively from a research study conducted in 2007–2010 which included a survey of nurses and nursing aides (n = 412) and interviews with 43 migrant healthcare workers, half a dozen nursing home operators, two major hospitals with geriatric departments, as well as representatives of relevant ministries and non-governmental organizations (NGOs), two professional nursing bodies in Singapore, and ten healthcare worker recruitment agencies. Since 2011, we have continued to closely follow the developments in Singapore's eldercare sector and these observations also inform the discussion in this chapter.

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Chapter fourteen

Elected Women Politicians in Singapore's Parliament

An Analysis of Socio-Demographic Profile

Netina Tan

INTRODUCTION

Globalization and rapid development have, to varying degrees, enhanced the well-being of women in Southeast Asia during the past several decades. Most scholars and policymakers have paid attention to improvements in women's well-being, especially in the areas of education, health, and employment. However, there has been a lack of attention to women's political participation, and therefore, in this chapter, I address the issue of the socio-demographic profile and supply of women politicians in Singapore. Specifically, the percentage of female candidates in Singapore's General Elections has increased during the last three decades from zero in 1968 to a high of 19.3 percent in 2015.¹ Consequently, the total of elected female parliamentarians and female cabinet ministers has also risen to 23.5 percent and 10 percent respectively. Although we know that more Singaporean women are participating in politics because of electoral incentives and pragmatic party initiatives (Tan 2014a, 2016), little is known about the educational or professional background of women who run and win elections. There is little information about the age-group, social-ethnic background, marital status, party

affiliation, or social-political support of the women political candidates. Thus far, no systematic research has examined the demographic background of the female candidates, elected female Members of Parliament (MPs) or cabinet ministers. Because of this information gap, we are less informed about the opportunities and obstacles that women face when they contest and their prospects of winning. Developing an in-depth knowledge of the background of the elected women leaders would thus enhance our understanding of their electability and representation of their constituencies.

In this chapter, I address this empirical gap by studying the social demographics of all women candidates elected into the Parliament and appointed to the Cabinet in Singapore between 1984 and 2017. This time period begins in 1981 when three women contested in the General Elections and all three were elected in the Single Member Constituencies (SMCs). In the last decade, more women have stepped forward to join political parties, campaign, and win. In fact, in the 2015 General Elections an unprecedented 36 women (19.8 percent) contested, out of 181 candidates from the People's Action Party (PAP), opposition parties, and one independent.

My research indicates that elected Singaporean women MPs are highly educated professionals or former civil servants and are predominantly from the ruling PAP. Furthermore, most entered politics at an older age, around 43 years old. Although Singapore is a multi-racial and multi-religious society, only Chinese women were elected as MPs during the earlier years, with no representation from Malay, Indian, or other racial groups until 2006. Unlike their male counterparts who were largely recruited from the military or statutory boards, most women MPs were recruited from the ranks of the civil service or other professional sectors. After elections, women leaders were typically appointed to traditionally low-prestige ministries and/or ministries traditionally perceived as “feminine,” such as community development, youth, family, and culture rather than to “masculine ministries” such as Defense, Foreign Affairs, or Transportation, that have been largely reserved for men. Thus far, all the four women who have been appointed to the Cabinet were first given ministerial positions without specific portfolios or ministry to helm. Most were only appointed to the ministry of community, culture, and youth at a later period.

To understand the background and electability of Singaporean women politicians, in this chapter I first provide a brief introduction of the country's party and electoral system, followed by the research method and data used in analyzing the socio-demographic background of women MPs. Next, I review the key explanations for the demand and supply of women in politics, before considering the limited supply of women candidates in Singapore. Further, I compare the recruitment and selection of women candidates between parties before reporting the findings of the background of elected women MPs in the last three decades. Finally, I consider why capable women face difficulties achieving cabinet positions, and I conclude by summarizing the implications for increasing the supply of women politicians in Singapore.

HEGEMONIC PARTY, ELECTORAL SYSTEM, AND WOMEN IN SINGAPORE

Singapore is one of the richest and least corrupt countries in the world. It has a healthy population with low drug use and high education performance, especially in math and science (BBC News 2013; Coughlan 2016). Both Singaporean men and women have performed well in terms of various international indicators in life expectancy, literacy rate, educational level, and economic participation. Indeed, the Fifth Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) reports that: “[W]omen in Singapore have made great strides in various fields, e.g. from higher literacy rates to increased representation in traditionally male-dominated sectors. Singapore recognizes that enhancing the status of women is a continuous process and remains committed to this effort.” (CEDAW 2015: 2). However, more equal education or work opportunities have not brought equal outcomes in political leadership positions. While the number of women politicians has increased, the overall number still falls short of the target of 30 percent “critical mass” (Dahlerup 2006) of women necessary to make a visible impact on the substance or content of political decision-making, a benchmark endorsed by the United Nations Economic and Social Council.

Women played a minimal role in politics in the early years after Singapore achieved self-government from the British in 1955. The country inherited a Westminster unicameral parliamentary system and held its full Legislative Assembly Election in 1959. Since gaining full suffrage, all citizens above the age of 21 years old can contest and win seats in the unicameral Parliament. After the only woman MP retired in 1970, there was not a single woman in Parliament for 14 years from 1970 to 1984. Singapore provides an instructive case study for examining the rise of women

politicians, as it has a unique electoral system and a hegemonic party government that could boost women's political participation without formal affirmative action. Electoral reforms in the late 1980s guaranteed the political representation of ethnic minorities and transformed more than 90 percent of the single seats into multi-member or Group Representative Constituencies (GRCs), and while the government dismissed the idea of legislated quotas or reserved seats for women, the introduction of the ethnic quotas increased the nomination of women candidates in the GRCs. As the magnitude of the GRCs has increased over time (from groups of three in 1988 to groups of four to six by 2006), more "safe seats" were made available for not only ethnic minorities but also for women (Tan 2014a).

Aside from the electoral incentives to ensure ethnic minority representation in Parliament, the PAP government also created new schemes to allow for non-elected members in the House. Currently, there are three types of parliamentarians, namely: 1) elected MPs, 2) Non-Constituency MPs (NCMPs), and 3) Nominated MPs (NMPs). Candidates have to contest in general or by-elections for the first two categories of seats. On the other hand, those who wish to be nominated as MPs have to be selected by seven functional groups² and appointed by a Special Select Committee of Parliament from a list of candidates (Rodan 2009).

Here, it is useful to distinguish between two categories of women politicians in Singapore: elected and non-elected. Currently, there are 21 elected women MPs (23.5 percent) and three non-elected women NMPs (33.3 percent). In Singapore's history, only two women, Sylvia Lim from the Workers' Party (WP, 2006–2011) and Lina Loh from the Singapore People's Party (SPP, 2011–2015) have gained parliamentary seats as part of Singapore's NCMP or "best-loser" scheme. In the following, I focus only on the elected women MPs, and exclude the non-elected or nominated MPs, because their candidate selection process and path to political office are

vastly different as NMPs do not need to navigate party politics, raise funds, campaign, or mobilize constituency support to win.

RESEARCH METHOD AND DATA

As noted, in this chapter I focus on the social and political backgrounds of elected women MPs from 1984 to 2017. The biodata of these elected women leaders were gathered from a variety of publicly available sources such as newspapers, political party websites, Singapore Elections Department³, the Parliament of Singapore⁴ websites and other online and published work that feature the characteristics or careers of women politicians in Singapore. All efforts were made to maintain consistency in the data collection, focusing on the date of birth, age, date when they first competed in elections, ethnicity, marital status, education and occupational background, party affiliation, grassroots experience, and years in political office. Additionally, I interviewed party leaders and compiled results gathered from an online survey that I conducted from February to May in 2013 with 17 women candidates who contested in Singapore's 2011 General Elections. In this online survey, I asked these women respondents 20 questions with regards to their age when joining political parties, motivations for joining politics, years in grassroots activities, candidate selection process, attitudes toward their gender in politics and policymaking, gender quotas, and other women-friendly policies.⁵

DEMAND AND SUPPLY OF WOMEN CANDIDATES

There are many reasons why women run for political office. One dominant explanation has focused on the demand and supply of women political candidates (Norris and Lovenduski

1995). While the demand-side explanations highlight the structural obstacles, beliefs of the party leaders in the nomination or candidate selection of women, the supply-side explanations tend to focus on women's decision to run for office or not. Typically, demand-side theories tend to consider how party selectors' discrimination—based on the applicants' abilities, qualifications, and experience—lead to few women candidates (Norris and Lovenduski 1995: 24). Voters' stereotypes of male and female candidates (Huddy and Terkildsen 1993) and partisan politics (Wolbrecht 2000) are often seen as discriminatory against women candidates. Furthermore, biases held by party gatekeepers (Cheng and Tavits 2011; Niven 1998; Sanbonmatsu 2006) or the party's objective of winning seats also affect the selection of women candidates (Spary 2014).

Other related institutionalist explanations examine how district magnitude (the number of seats per district) and the electoral system shape a woman's political recruitment and prospects of winning (McAllister and Studlar 2002; Matland and Brown 1992; Rule 1981; Vengroff et al. 2000). Broadly, majoritarian electoral systems are considered less women-friendly than their proportional representation counterparts (Kunovich and Paxton 2005; Rule 1981). In Singapore, the introduction of multi-member constituencies, or the GRC Scheme based on party bloc vote plurality rule, is found to favor the nomination of more women candidates (Tan 2014a). This dovetails with other studies that found SMC systems to be less conducive for women and minority candidates (Matland and Studlar 1996; Norris 1985).⁶ District magnitude matters in Singapore as the multi-member districts or GRCs allow parties to nominate more women. The larger GRCs not only mandate the parties to field minorities but also allow parties to include more women to balance the ticket.

On the other hand, supply-side explanations highlight why women voluntarily shun political careers. For example, Norris and Lovenduski's (1995) research on women's political recruitment

found little evidence of discrimination by party members to exclude women in the British Parliament. Similarly, studies based on the North American experience also suggests that women candidates are not at a disadvantage to men when they seek nomination (Lawless and Fox 2005, 2013; Rule 1981). In fact, Lawless and Fox contend that women's lack of political ambition is a key reason for why women avoid political office.⁷ They argue that women do not run because of their "greater aversion to campaigning, lower levels of political recruitment, and traditional family arrangements and responsibilities" (Lawless and Fox 2008: 13). A related supply-side explanation highlights how women's low self-esteem or self-perceived low capability deter them from competing. While the causal mechanisms of election aversion differ, most see traditional gender stereotypes as deterring women from pursuing prestigious careers, which lead to their underrepresentation in more prestigious fields (Bian et al. 2017). Women become election-averse as they are afraid of being judged or because of prior experience of exclusion (Brands and Fernandez-Mateo 2017). In Singapore, this is reflected in women holding fewer board positions than their Asian counterparts. Unlike other Asian countries, more Singaporean women are leaving their high-paying corporate jobs *voluntarily*. In fact, a McKinsey & Company (2012) survey found Singaporean women to be more self-limiting and reluctant to promote themselves.

WHY RUN? THE SUPPLY OF WOMEN CANDIDATES IN SINGAPORE

In reality, both demand and supply-side explanations interact to affect women's willingness to run for political office (Krook 2010; Norris and Lovenduski 1995: 14–15). The decision to run or not comes down to a variety of considerations, including the candidate's current position

(Johnson et al. 2012); district magnitude (Matland and Brown 1992); party politics (Murray et al. 2012; O'Neill and Stewart 2009), political efficacy and ambition (Campbell and Wolbrecht 2006; Maestas et al. 2006). A confluence of factors such as cultural biases, the strongly embedded social norm of female domestic responsibility, and a patriarchal and masculinized political culture result in men being valued more for leadership than women. Furthermore, although Singapore has socio-economic and institutional factors that favor women's access to political power, varied social-cultural factors continue to hold back educated and resourceful women. For example, in 2012 a survey by the World Values Survey (2014) found Singaporeans to prefer male leaders, as a total of 45.6 percent of respondents agreed with the statement that: "On the whole, men make better political leaders." Another survey by Ketchum Global Research in 2014 also found a similar trend. In fact, the Ketchum survey found that 83 percent of 500 Singaporeans agree that men are better in making tough decisions, while 77 percent of those surveyed thought men are better in providing a clear overall, long-term vision than women. A majority of respondents also believed that male political leaders are more capable than females in leading the country over the next five years (Today Online 2014). While these survey results cannot confirm the discrimination of women candidates or voter bias, the perception that there may be a preference for male leaders could deter potential women from considering a political career (Tan 2016).

Indeed, in Singapore, the impact of traditional gender and family roles remains a key constraint. Women have to spend more time maintaining the household and rearing children than men. As is the case in many other countries, Singaporean working women face a "double burden" as they are tasked with a paid and unpaid job, each requiring their attention and energy (Lawless and Fox 2005). Singapore has a very high literacy rate for women (94 percent) and almost equal numbers of women attend

university as men. However, more women than men cite the need for work and family balance as a key reason for leaving their high-paying corporate jobs (McKinsey & Company 2012). Similarly, in my online survey with 17 women candidates in 2013, 47 percent of the respondents reported "family and childcare commitments" to be the biggest obstacle that deters women from joining political parties and contesting in elections. In turn, family support was also a key factor that influenced the women respondents in their decision to join politics, with 62 percent of all respondents citing "family" and "spouse" to be two key sources of support for their political aspirations.

While women may need their family or spousal support to join parties and participate in political activities, they need the support and nomination of party leaders to run for elections. In my online survey, 50 percent of the women respondents cited "party leaders" as the most important person to encourage them to run for party executive positions while 45 percent of respondents cited a "political leader" or "woman leader" as having the most impact in their decision to contest in the General Elections. Given that party leaders are the gatekeepers, the next section will examine the critical candidate selection process in Singapore.

SELECTION OF WOMEN CANDIDATES, 1984-2015

In Singapore's hegemonic party system, the PAP's candidate selection is the "choice before the choice" that determines the composition and representativeness of the legislature (Rahat 2007). Indeed, it is the PAP that unilaterally increased the total number of women candidates. After years of fielding only three to four women, the PAP surprised many by nominating ten women in the 2001 General Election. The party's

decision to nominate more women candidates directly increased the supply of women candidates. Over the last nine elections, the PAP fielded more women in elections than all the opposition parties combined. In fact, the total number of women candidates rose from 1 in 1980 to a high of 36 by the 2015 General Election.

More women from the PAP are contesting than from the opposition parties. This is not surprising given that the probability of winning is higher as a PAP candidate than as an opposition candidate. The PAP is what Sartori (2005: 204) considers to be a “hegemonic party” as it has ruled Singapore uninterruptedly over the last five decades with an average of 95 percent seat shares for the last 12 elections. As the hegemonic party, the PAP has unparalleled access to state resources and is able to attract and recruit candidates widely from across the different sectors. In fact, the PAP could extend its recruitment activities to universities to attract outstanding female undergraduates and scour the top female civil servants to join its party ranks, unlike the opposition parties. The PAP leaders know that including women in politics provides a positive image for the party, thereby broadening the party’s appeal to a wider range of voters (Tan 2016). Furthermore, to widen its support base, the PAP created its powerful Women’s Wing⁸ in 1989 to recruit women members.

There is no primary election for the PAP’s selection of legislative candidates. This party is known to select its candidates through an elaborate screening, nomination, and appointment process (Tan 2014b). Generally, this party’s candidate selection includes four key stages: 1) “talent-spotting” of high-performing women from the civil service and professional fields such as the law, finance, and healthcare sectors, 2) inviting potential candidates to tea sessions to meet with senior ministers, 3) sending candidates to respective constituencies to shadow MPs and see whether the candidates are comfortable working the ground, and 4) identifying high-

performing candidates with potential ministerial qualities to undergo psychological tests with over 1,000 questions that lasts one-and-a-half days (Neo and Chen 2007: 334). The PAP’s “talent-spotting” scheme is highly elitist as it seeks to attract highly educated, career women from the civil service or other professional sectors. The names of candidates are typically recommended to the party’s recruitment committee by party activists, corporate leaders, MPs and senior civil servants. In the 1984 General Election, about 2,000 potential names were drawn from government scholars, professionals, and party ranks (Tan 2008). In the last three elections, the trend for the PAP has been to nominate around 22 percent of women in its list of candidates.

In contrast, most opposition parties are small, weakly institutionalized, and resource poor (Tan 2014c). Unlike the PAP, they do not have the resources or capacity to recruit women candidates aggressively. The opposition parties also do not have primaries or an institutionalized candidate selection process. Typically, the party leader or a small group of leaders nominate the candidates before the polling date, as reflected in my survey where 73 percent of the respondents cited “Party nomination and selection by party leaders” as the key method of selection in elections.

Thus far, only the opposition Workers’ Party has managed to successfully field and win parliamentary seats in the 2011 and the 2015 General Elections. My interviews with opposition leaders reveal that the recruitment of women remains an uphill task (Goh 2010; Jeyaretnam 2010; Pao 2011). It is thus remarkable that the opposition parties managed to field 14 to 15 women in the last two elections. Currently, the Workers’ Party has the highest level of women’s representation, with six women in the Central Executive Committee (CEC) (35.5 percent). And the National Solidarity Party was the first party to elect a woman, Hazel Pao, to become the party’s Secretary General, thereby making her the first woman party chief in Singapore (Tham 2015).

WHO WINS? SOCIO-DEMOGRAPHIC BACKGROUND OF ELECTED WOMEN MPs

In Westminster parliamentary systems such as in Britain and Canada, women candidates and elected MPs are found to be unrepresentative of the average British or Canadian woman (Norris and Lovenduski 1995; Tremblay and Trimble 2003). In turn, my study of the socio-demographic background of Singapore women MPs also found a similar pattern. Like their British or Canadian counterparts, Singapore women MPs are largely drawn from the elite class and rarely are drawn from the working class or from small-business backgrounds. Singaporean women leaders are also older, professional women with careers in law, academia, health care, or business. Typically, Singaporean women MPs are more highly educated than the average voter. Indeed, my study of the socio-demographic background of the women MPs over the last three decades shows that elected women MPs are not representative of Singapore's general population, as there are no women MPs from the working class, trade unions, or other lower strata social-economic groups. This finding also resonates with a cross-country study of 4,000 MPs from 16 countries in Asia, which found female MPs to be unrepresentative of their country's female populations, especially in terms of social class and generations (Joshi and Och 2014).

As noted, elected women MPs in Singapore are highly educated and are older professional women. As Table 14.1 demonstrates, women MPs tend to enter politics at an average age of 43 years, and thus these women likely enter politics as part of their second career or after their children have reached a certain age of independence. The "double burden" on women could have made it more difficult for them to enter the political arena at earlier age. With the exception of the nomination of one candidate, Tin Pei-Ling at

the age of 27 in the 2011 General Election, most women from the PAP and opposition parties enter politics later in life. Besides, most women MPs, except for five over the time period examined, are married with children. Given that the ruling PAP is a socially conservative party that is eager to address the falling fertility rate in the country, the party leaders may be deliberately selecting older married female candidates with children to showcase the party's pro-family policies.⁹

Furthermore, Singapore is a multi-racial and multi-religious society. However, the women MPs elected in the earlier years were Chinese. There were no woman representatives from the Malay or Indian groups for 17 years from 1984 to 2001. As shown in Table 14.1, it was only after the 2001 General Election that a Malay and an Indian woman were nominated and elected. The ethnic representation of women MPs has only become more representative after the 2011 and 2015 elections. As of 2015, there is a more diverse representation of women MPs with 15 Chinese (71 percent); 4 Malays (19 percent), 1 Indian-Chinese (4.8 percent) and one Eurasian (4.8 percent). This breakdown reflects the national composition of 74.3 percent Chinese, 13.4 percent Malays, 9.1 percent Indians, and 3.3 percent others in the country (Statistics Singapore 2016: 5).

What is also distinctive about the slate of Singaporean women politicians is their high education background and professional careers. As Table 14.1 shows, the elected women leaders are more educated than the average Singaporean woman. Most elected women MPs are tertiary educated, with many with postgraduate or professional degrees. In the last two elections, most women MPs have held high-ranking positions, either in the civil service, or in the business sectors as company directors or consultants. Women MPs tend to hold professional careers such as lawyers, bankers, engineers, financial consultants, or university professors. The professional background of the elected women MPs differs from

Table 14.1 Socio-demographic background of elected women MPs, 1984–2015

<i>Parliaments, Years</i>	<i>13th, 2015–</i>	<i>12th, 2011–14</i>	<i>11th, 2006–10</i>	<i>10th, 2001–5</i>	<i>9th, 1997–2001</i>	<i>8th, 1991–6</i>	<i>7th, 1988–1990</i>	<i>6th, 1984–7</i>
Average Age of Women First Entered Elections	44.7	45.2	47	46	43.5	38.5	42.8	42
Race/ Ethnicity								
Chinese	15	16	15	8	4	2	4	3
Malay	4	3	1	1	0	0	0	0
Indian	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0
Eurasian/others	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Education								
Postgraduates	13	13	14	8	4	2	4	3
Graduates	8	6	4	2	0	0	0	0
Non-graduates	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
Occupation								
Civil Servant	5	3	1	0	0	0	0	0
University Professor	1	1	0	0	1	1	2	1
Doctor/Surgeon	1	1	1	1	1	0	1	1
Lawyer	4	4	4	2	0	0	0	0
Company Director	8	6	6	3	1	0	0	0
Banker/Finance	2	4	2	1				
Other	0	0	2	2	1	1	1	1
Total Female MPs	21	20	17	10	4	2	4	3

Source: Compiled based on data extracted from newspaper articles and CVs of MPs from *Singapore Parliament* website, retrieved March 18, 2018 (www.parliament.gov.sg/).

their male counterparts, who are mostly from the military, civil service or government-linked corporations (Tan 2014b), and once elected, women are less likely than men to be placed into positions of power.

WOMEN'S ELECTABILITY

Recent election results suggest that Singaporean voters are not averse to women leaders. In fact, there are indicators that when women contest, they win with at least as much frequency as do men. In the 2011 General Elections, Dr. Amy Khor won by a large margin and was the PAP's best performing candidate. Dr. Khor's victory dispelled the common-held myth that women are unelectable in the SMCs. In fact, the average vote share of both women candidates at 68.8 percent was ten

percentage points higher than the average vote shares of all PAP candidates who contested in the nine SMCs. In another by-election in 2013, the victory of a female candidate from the Workers' Party, Lee Lilian, against a male PAP counterpart also showed that Singaporeans do not vote along gender lines. Rather, party affiliation and party platform are more important (Au Yong 2013).

Party affiliation rather than gender is a better predictor of electoral success in Singapore. As Singapore has SMCs, and multi-member GRCs where a group of 4–5 male and female MPs compete as a team, we can assess the electability of women candidates by their respective vote shares in the SMCs in the 2011 and the 2015 General Elections where women were fielded in SMCs after a long hiatus. The PAP did not field any woman in SMCs for twenty years after a PAP woman candidate, Dr. Seet Ai Mei, lost her seat

to the opposition in the 1991 General Election. On average, female PAP candidates perform better than female opposition candidates. Except for the Yuhua SMC where two women candidates competed head-to-head in the 2011 and 2015 General Elections, female candidates faced male candidates in the SMCs. If we compare the vote shares of all the female candidates in SMCs, we see a clear voting pattern along party rather than gender lines. Among the different parties, there is also stronger support for the Workers' Party and the Singapore People's Party than other smaller opposition parties.

Given the popularity of women candidates, a total of nine women candidates from the PAP and the opposition competed in 13 SMCs in the 2015 General Elections. The PAP fielded four women candidates, including an untested, new candidate in Fengshan SMC. On the other hand, the opposition parties fielded high-profile opposition female leaders such as lawyer Jeannette Chong-Aruldoss and Lina Loh in SMCs such as Mountbatten and Potong Pasir against resource-rich PAP male counterparts. On average, the PAP women candidates continued to out-perform, averaging 67.9 percent popular vote shares while the opposition women candidates dropped in their vote shares, largely due to rising nationalism and patriotism for the PAP after the death of Lee Kuan Yew in 2015 (Dobson 2015: 201; Lee and Tan 2016). The electoral performance of women candidates thus dispels the myth of voter bias against women.

WHO GETS CABINET POSITIONS AND WHAT PORTFOLIO?

More Singaporean women are winning elections, but few have attained positions in the Cabinet. Compared to the other developed East Asian countries, the pattern of "the higher, the fewer" (Bashevkin 1993) persists. Currently, two women sit in the Cabinet of 20 members (10 percent, after the 2017 cabinet reshuffle). And when they

are appointed to cabinet or government positions, they are often relegated to "feminine" and low-prestige policy areas (Borrelli 2002; Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson 2005; Studlar and Moncrief 1999).¹⁰ Similar to various other countries (Paxton and Hughes 2007: 270), Singaporean women ministers are often appointed to social welfare, education, and health portfolios.¹¹ This is also the case for the women cabinet ministers in Singapore.

To date, four women have been appointed to cabinet positions in Singapore. Dr. Seet Ai Mei became the first woman to be named Acting Minister for Community Development after a cabinet reshuffle in July 1991. However, she was also the first cabinet member to lose a parliamentary seat when she lost by a narrow margin of 1.4 percent votes to a SDP candidate in the 1991 General Elections. After 18 years, Mrs Lim Hwee Hua became the first women minister without specific ministry to helm under the Prime Minister's office in 2009. However, Lim's cabinet position was short-lived as her GRC team in Aljunied was defeated by the Workers' Party in the 2011 General Elections. Lim was voted out of office after two years in the Cabinet. After the 2015 General Elections, another PAP woman MP, Grace Fu, was appointed Minister for Culture, Community, and Youth, the first female minister to hold a full ministry portfolio. However, as Krook and O'Brien have pointed out, the portfolio of Culture, Community, and Youth is largely considered a feminine or low-prestige position. Despite Fu's past extensive corporate experience in finance and flagship port terminals in Singapore, she has yet to take on more prestigious or masculine ministries such as in Finance, Trade, Foreign Affairs, or Defense. In the latest cabinet reshuffle in April 2017, Senior Minister Josephine Teo was promoted to Minister without portfolio. This means that Singapore has two female cabinet ministers for the first time in its political history (see Table 14.2).

The PAP government remains cautious in promoting women to the Cabinet. Based on the electoral experience, occupation, and education

Table 14.2 Biodata of women Cabinet Ministers in Singapore, 1991–2015

	<i>Dr. Seet Ai Mei</i>	<i>Lim Hwee Hua</i>	<i>Grace Fu</i>	<i>Josephine Teo</i>
Age when first entered politics and birth Year	43 years old, 1943	38 years old, 1959	42 years old, 1964	43 years old, 1968
Party Affiliation	PAP	PAP	PAP	PAP
Years in politics before Cabinet Appointment	3 years, MP since 1988	12 years, MP since 1997	9 years, MP since 2006	11 years, MP since 2006
Ministry Appointment	Acting Minister for Community Development and Sports (Jul–Sep 1991)	Minister under PM's Office, 2009–2011	Ministry of Culture, Community and Youth, 2015–present	Minister under PM's Office
Age when appointed Cabinet Minister	48 years old	50 years old	51 years old	49 years old
Occupational Background	Biochemistry Researcher, Managing Director of Consultancy company	Administrative Office, Ministry of Finance Managing Director, Temesek Holdings	Corporate Banking Chief Executive Officer, Port of Singapore Authority	Former Civil Servant, Economic Development Board, A*STAR
Education	Ph.D. Biochemistry (NUS)	Mathematics and Engineering (Cambridge) MBA in Finance (UCLA)	Bachelor of Accountancy (NUS) MBA (NUS)	MSc (Economics)
Ethnicity	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese
Marital Status	Divorced (two children)	Married (three children)	Married (three children)	Married (three children)

Source: Compiled based on data extracted from news articles and from Singapore Parliament website, retrieved March 18, 2018 (www.parliament.gov.sg/).

background of the four female cabinet ministers, the PAP leaders appear to value women with professional and policy expertise more than political or grassroots connections (see Table 14.2). If more women were to be appointed in the future, the next potential women ministers are likely to come from the list of Senior Ministers of State. There are now three women out of eight Senior Ministers of State with the potential to be appointed. The three Senior Women Ministers are Dr. Amy Khor (Professor, 59 years old), Indranee Rajah (Lawyer, 53 years old), and Sim Ann (former Civil Servant, 42 years old). Given their age, years in political office, professional career, and

past experience in civil service, more women should be expected to assume full cabinet ministerial positions in the future.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I have examined the socio-demographic background of all the elected women MPs in the Singapore Parliament and their cabinet appointment. The study of the background of the women MPs over the last three decades shows that the elected women MPs are unrepresentative of the general population of women in Singapore.

Typically, the woman who runs and wins elections is more educated than the average Singaporean woman. The elected women MPs are found to be typically older, highly educated professionals or former civil servants. Most women MPs have a university education with either postgraduate or professional degrees in law, medicine, or finance. While Singapore is a diverse society, the earlier groups of elected women MPs were all Chinese, with no representation from Malay, Indian or other racial groups until 2006. One reason for the lack of diversity and representation in the Parliament is the PAP's elitist "talent-spotting" system which recruits only particular types of women: highly educated, high-powered career Chinese women from the civil service, legal, or financial professional sectors. The lack of representation from the working class, trade unions or other social-economic groups could raise problems as the elite women may be detached and unable to empathize with the struggles of the common people. The older women MPs may also be detached from the aspirations of the younger electorate.

Singaporean women MPs are less likely than men to be placed in positions of power and instead are relegated to work on "feminine" social issues such as community development, culture, youth, family, and health care. Clearly, more has to be done to dismantle the socio-cultural factors that hold women back from joining politics. Families and political parties could organize more political activities to encourage younger women to join and run in elections. Enlisting the support of families and spouses to support women's political ambitions also is a step forward to reducing the political gender gap.

NOTES

- 1 I wish to thank Victoria Musial for her able research assistance in the writing of this paper.
- 2 The functional groups are from business and industry; professional careers; labor movement; social service organizations; civic and people sector; tertiary education institutions; the media, arts and sports.

- 3 *Singapore Elections Department* website at www.eld.gov.sg/
- 4 The *Parliament of Singapore* website at www.parliament.gov.sg/
- 5 See "PROWA: Online Survey with 17 Women Candidates in Singapore, Feb 2013" at <https://netinatan.com/datasets/> for the list of survey questions and compiled answers.
- 6 Broadly, women and ethnic minorities are perceived to be electorally risky and are less likely to be nominated by party leaders in SMD plurality/majority systems, where parties choose only one candidate per constituency.
- 7 They found an ambition gap between genders as women are less likely than men to be encouraged by parents, teachers, or party leaders to run. Women are more likely to underestimate their abilities and assume they need to be much more qualified than men to run for the same office (Lawless and Fox 2005, 2013).
- 8 See the People's Action Party, Women's Wing website at <http://womenswing.pap.org.sg/>.
- 9 In 2016, Singapore's fertility rate stood at 1.2 (Statistics Singapore 2016). The People's Action Party governments have launched pro-fertility campaigns and slogans such as "Strong and Stable Families" (2000), "Romancing Singapore" (2003), and "Singapore: A Great Place for Families" (2004) (Nasir and Turner 2014: 22).
- 10 See Krook and O'Brien for the distribution of the different government ministries into "masculine," "neutral" and "feminine" gender types and by prestige type. Defense, Military, Finance, and Economy are seen as "High Prestige" while Children and Family, Culture, Heritage, Minority Affairs, Youth, and Women's Affairs are seen as "Low Prestige" (Krook and O'Brien 2012: 846).
- 11 As Krook and O'Brien (2010) also found, political rather than social factors affect gender parity in cabinets. Cabinet positions that concern "public sphere of politics" are delegated to women with political influence while ministries that control financial resources but have less status and visibility are delegated to women with policy expertise.

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Chapter fifteen

Globalization and Increased Informalization of Labor

Women in the Informal Economy in Malaysia

Shanthi Thambiah and Tan Beng Hui

INTRODUCTION

In various regions of the world, increased numbers of workers—including women—have shifted from agriculture and subsistence production to waged employment in the expanding manufacturing and service sectors. Women's employment in the formal economic sector, however, is generally lower than that of men. Women are far more likely to occupy part-time jobs, due to their roles as primary family caregivers, and when they are employed full-time, they are less likely to occupy decision-making positions. In emerging economies, women are mainly found working in both the agricultural and the manufacturing sectors. Shifts from agriculture to manufacturing, and from lower-wage to higher-wage employment in Asia, still lag behind most developed regions.

The factors driving global integration, namely, globalization, trade expansion, technological change, and the internationalization of production, have altered production patterns in both developed and developing countries, and have promoted growth and development. This has led to changes in regional and national employment patterns. The patterns of employment and income generation among women in Asia tend

to differ from the predictable global trends in important ways, suggesting that forces shaping global integration affect women in diverse ways (Christensen and Kowalczyk 2017: 547; Mehra and Gammage 1999: 533–534). Therefore, while structural adjustment and trade liberalization are occurring, in most cases, only limited improvements have been made in women's work conditions, employment, and income.

Indeed, the adverse consequences of economic globalization have been felt by all countries and especially by their respective labor forces. For instance, discourses on labor from developed countries have focused on the relocation of work away from those countries to countries with less expensive costs of production. The narratives of local jobs disappearing and wages stagnating in the industrial sector has been used by politicians from developed nations as a campaign strategy to win elections, drawing on the sentiments of the working class and the unemployed. However, very little is said about the situation of those in the developing world who are allegedly taking away these jobs, or how stable employment there has declined and been replaced by growing informal economies, and by self-employment and temporary employment.

Three decades ago, Benería and Roldan (1987) had already shown that due to the desire to lower labor costs and increase profits, many formal sector jobs in urban areas of developing countries were becoming informalized. Subcontracting became a common mechanism, and such arrangements led to the proliferation of home-based work (Boris and Prügl 1996). This drew greatly on gender norms relating to women's roles and the lower value of their work. Yet, many women in developing countries have accepted this type of work because it allows them to combine income generation with domestic responsibilities and care work. Keeping production costs low, through the casualization and informalization of labor, has enabled certain industries to develop a competitive edge in the international market, but at the social cost of keeping women outside of formal employment and related benefits. The informal economy—or unregulated economic activity—is an important element in most national economies. In this chapter, we use the term “informal economy” rather than “informal sector” to recognize that since informal work can take place via formal and informal enterprises, the primary concern should be on the type of labor relations involved: that is, on labor relations that are not regulated nor provided with basic legal and social protections. The term “informal sector” is retained only when originally used by the sources cited.

A higher percentage of women than men worldwide work in the informal economy (Carr and Chen 2002; Chen 2016), and in Malaysia there has been an upward trend in the involvement of women in the informal economy. As a result, the link between working in the informal economy and being poor is also stronger for women than for men. Globally, informal incomes tend to decline as one moves across different types of employment: from employer to self-employed, to informal and casual wage workers, to industrial outworkers.

Historically, there has been a growing body of literature on the range of social, political, and

economic factors that are contributing to the development of the informal economy (Böröcz 2000; Bosch and Maloney 2010; Davies and Thurlow 2010; Kaya 2008; Williams and Round 2008; Xavier 2008). More specifically, these studies provide valuable evidence on various aspects of the informal economy. The traditional view of the informal economy was that it was related to subsistence activities, and that it was the remnants of a pre-capitalist economy (Sethuraman 1976). However, the persistence and growth of the informal economy in both developed (Sassen 1997, 2001; Schneider and Enste 2002) and developing countries (Maloney 2004; Schneider 2005; Schneider et al. 2010) contradict this view of the informal economy (Roberts 2014). Economic globalization is also seen as a primary force causing the expansion of the informal economy in developed and less-developed countries (Carr and Chen 2002; Chen 2016; Phillips 2011; Runyan and Peterson 2014; McMichael 2017; Standing 1999).

Likewise, historically, the literature on women's employment has demonstrated a lack of recognition of women's participation in the informal economy (Chen et al. 1999; Elson 1999). Factors contributing to this gap were the lack of data availability, as well as perceptions that this sphere represents a residual category, and that it does not contribute significantly to either the national or global economies. This was contrary to research showing that the informal economy has been vital for the economic survival of poor women and for economic growth (Berger and Buvinic 1989). Indeed, the informal economy has consistently provided more employment for women than the formal economy, and more employment for the majority of the labor force overall in most developing countries, including middle income countries (Chen 1996). Further, the informal economy has become increasingly important in the transition countries, especially for women who have been removed from the formal labor force (Moghadam 1994). Today, an enhanced understanding of women's roles in the

informal economy is widely recognized as being critical to broadening our knowledge of both economic issues and of women's well-being (Benería et al. 2016; Chen 2016; McMichael 2017; Runyan and Peterson 2014).

Why should we be concerned about globalization, women, and the growth of the informal economy? There is a considerable connection between being a woman, working in the informal economy, and being poor. There is also an important overlap between being a woman, working in the informal economy, and contributing to Malaysia's growth. Using the Malaysian example, this article examines gender, the growth of the informal economy, casualization in patterns of female employment, wage dispersion, and linkages to globalization and economic growth. We begin by *first* briefly explaining what constitutes the "informal economy" and by drawing on national statistics to provide a profile of informal women workers in Malaysia. *Second*, we focus on the voices—the views and experiences—of these women workers so as to provide insights into some of their reasons for engaging in such work as well as the challenges that they face. And *third*, we also focus on perspectives of employers about the benefits of this kind of work. *Finally*, we conclude with a discussion and overview of relevant issues.

THE INFORMAL ECONOMY

Both scholars and policymakers widely acknowledge that official labor force data provides inadequate coverage of women's informal remunerative work. This inadequacy relates to definitions and conceptual categorizations of work, as well as to the ways in which these are operationalized for data collection. A segmented labor market implies the existence of dual sectors in the labor market. Over the years, the concept and definition of the "informal sector" has been broadened to incorporate certain types of informal employment that were not included

previously. In brief, the new term, the "informal economy," focuses on the nature of employment in addition to the characteristics of enterprises (WIEGO 2017). For instance, many informal enterprises have production or distribution relations with formal enterprises, and many formal enterprises hire wage workers under informal employment relations. Part-time workers, temporary workers and homeworkers may work for formal enterprises through contracting and subcontracting arrangements. The informal economy thus comprises a complex range of informal enterprises and informal jobs which can be categorized as follows:

- *Self-employment in informal enterprises.* For example, workers in small unregistered or unincorporated enterprises, including employers, own-account operators (both heads of family enterprises and single person operators), and unpaid family workers.
- *Wage employment in informal jobs.* For example, workers without worker benefits or social protection who are hired by formal or informal firms, households, or have no fixed employer, including employees of informal enterprises, other informal wage workers such as casual or day laborers, domestic workers, unregistered or undeclared workers, some temporary or part-time workers, and industrial outworkers also called homeworkers.

Thus, the informal economy is the sum total of income-generating activities, which are not subject to national regulations and laws but are engaged in the production of goods and services (Portes and Haller 2010).

WOMEN AND THE INFORMAL ECONOMY IN MALAYSIA

Malaysia's experience with globalization, and market and trade liberalization, spans back to the

1970s when the government first embarked on an export-oriented industrialization policy. A major part of this early neoliberal strategy was thus focused on attracting Foreign Direct Investment (FDIs) through setting up Free Trade Zones for the manufacturing (electrical and electronics) as well as textiles and garments industries. Alongside diversifying away from the nation's reliance on primary commodities, this aimed at boosting employment and propelling growth. The move also coincided with global capital relocating itself from the North to the South to take advantage of the latter's promises of market and trade deregulation (Jomo 2004; Teik and Jin 2010; Yusoff et al. 2000).

As the structure of the Malaysian economy underwent changes, it contributed to women's participation in paid employment. Manufacturing emerged as a key economic sector and became the largest employer of women (Thambiah 2010). This was also the first time that women, in particular Malay rural women, entered the labor force in large numbers. Consequently, many gained economic independence but at a price: exploitative working conditions, including low wages, long hours, and being denied the right to unionize. Hence while Malaysia boasted having an average Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of 8 percent per annum by the late 1980s (up until the Asian Financial Crisis in 1997)—and with it, the label as a newly industrializing economy—the reality was that this growth came at the expense of an underclass of workers, a large portion of whom were women (Chee 1994; Grace 1990; Mohamad et al. 2001; Thambiah 2010), a situation which continues to persist.

The effects of building the nation's growth on labor-intensive industries became clearer by the turn of the twenty-first century. With the domestic labor supply falling short of demand, and other countries in the region rising to offer equally flexible and even cheaper labor, Malaysia saw its earlier "comparative advantage" quickly vanish (ILO 2016). Employers decided to outsource various parts of the production process to home-based or

casualized labor in an effort to lower production cost to retain that advantage. For example, industrial home-based subcontracting in the garments industry saw large numbers of women becoming casualized labor (Loh-Ludher 2003). As seen below, in addition to being typically unprotected by the law (which meant harsh working conditions, low wages, and no social benefits), the fate of such workers was dependent on fluctuating markets and thus was highly insecure. With capital seeking to keep production costs low, local women workers in the manufacturing and textiles and garments industries—with few prospects of upskilling for better work—soon found themselves displaced by migrant workers, and pushed into the periphery of the same industries which they had earlier helped build.

The increasing size of the informal economy in Malaysia, of which "casual work" forms a subset, is an area of importance (Pearson 2012; Suhaimi et al. 2016; Xavier 2008). Nevertheless, there is a high likelihood that the informal economy is under-recorded and under-reported in official statistics. In Malaysia, there was no such information on the informal economy prior to a Department of Statistics publication that noted how the informal sector contributed significantly to certain economies, especially in developing countries where it played a major role in employment creation, production, and income generation (Franck and Olsson 2014; Kamaruddin and Ali 2006; Thambiah 2016; also see DOS 2013). Mixed income estimates in 2005 also indicated that the informal sector contributed 13 percent to GDP (Baharudin et al. 2011). Following a pilot study for all of Malaysia in 2006, a regular survey for the informal sector was introduced from 2009–2010 onwards (Ridzuan and Ponggot 2009). The first time the Malaysian government released the findings of this survey, however, was in 2013. This has provided better insights into the large share of workers who remain outside the realm of regulated economic activities and protected employment relationships. Nonetheless, more still needs to be

done to gather statistics that more accurately capture these dynamics and other patterns in Malaysia's informal economy.

Based on the data compiled in 2012, there was an estimated one million participants in informal nonagricultural activities, or 9 percent of total nonagriculture employed persons (DOS 2013 cited in UNDP 2014: 96). By 2015, this number had increased to 1,403,100 persons or 11 percent (DOS 2016). These latest figures show that own-account workers—"a person who operates his/her own farm, business or trade without employing any paid workers in the conduct of his/her farm, trade or business" (DOS 2016: 75)—comprised the largest group within the informal sector (55 percent), followed by unpaid family workers (30 percent), then employers (6 percent), and employees (3 percent). This differs from 2012 when own-account workers constituted 67 percent of the informal workforce, while employees were the next largest group at 24 percent. The educational levels of informal economy workers, expectedly, showed lower attainments than their counterparts in formal employment (UNDP 2014: 96). Nevertheless, there appears to be a small but growing proportion of those with tertiary education working in the informal economy (9 percent in 2012 versus 12 percent in 2015), with women representing 53 percent of this category (DOS 2016).

Gender differentials prevail in other important ways, not least being how women's share of the informal workforce is growing while that of men is declining. In 2012, women constituted 41 percent (427,300) of the total employed in the informal economy; in 2015, this proportion had increased to 49 percent (689,100). Sectorially in 2015, out of all informally employed women, the largest numbers were congregated in human health and social work (27 percent); manufacturing (26 percent); and accommodation and food service activities (20 percent). In turn, the proportion of such women in manufacturing fell from 28 percent in 2012, while the proportion in the human health and social work industry rose from 24 percent to

overtake manufacturing as the most common industry for informally employed women.

In contrast, even as percentages show signs of declining, men continue to be highly concentrated in construction (40 percent of total informally employed men in 2015, down from 42 percent in 2012), and motor repair, wholesale, and retail trade (20 percent versus 22 percent). Furthermore, occupationally, the largest segment of male informal workers was classified as craft workers (43 percent in 2015, 43 percent in 2012); followed by sales and services workers (26 percent versus 21 percent), and by elementary workers (16 percent versus 19 percent). Among female workers, even more were found in services and sales in 2015 (63 percent) compared to 2012 (56 percent), while female craft workers dipped slightly to 26 percent in 2015 from 27 percent in 2012 (DOS 2013, 2016). As noted elsewhere, men have been predominantly engaged in construction, which includes skilled and manual labor, and in motor repair, which involves varying skill levels, while women have dominated both the services industry, especially food, and home-based manufacturing, which offer minimal opportunities for skills development (Thambiah 2016; UNDP 2014: 96–97).

The majority of employed persons in the informal sector in Malaysia were found in urban areas: 656,800 persons (63 percent) in 2012, and this figure continues to grow (1,011,800 persons, 72 percent in 2015). From the total in 2012, the number of urban informally employed men was 382,000 persons (58 percent), while females recorded 274,800 persons (42 percent) (DOS 2013). Unfortunately, the same type of information was not made available in the latest report. Own-account workers have consistently registered the highest numbers in the informal sector, growing from 67 percent in 2012 to 70 percent in 2015. Employees of informal enterprises recorded the second highest in 2012 and 2015, i.e., 24 percent and 19 percent, while the numbers of unpaid family workers increased (7 percent to 8 percent). In 2015, women in the informal economy were

overwhelmingly own-account (77 percent) or unpaid family workers (13 percent) while most men were own-account workers (64 percent) or employees (29 percent) (DOS 2016).

The share of women employed as informal workers also increases with age, and peaks in the 45–54 year-old cohort. This is unlike their male counterparts who, in 2015, were more actively engaged as informal workers when they were younger (25–34 years old) (DOS 2016). One explanation attributes this to women who drop out of the formal labor force as employees, and reenter the workforce via the informal economy. In fact, the reason the relatively low female labor force participation rate in Malaysia is only partially understood is because a large number of women in the category “outside the labor force” are considered as missing from the labor force, i.e., not being productive (Franck 2010; Loh-Ludher 2007). On the contrary, based on global data about the informal economy, women tend to be productively engaged in informal work as own-account workers, casual informal wage workers, and industrial outworkers. Hence, although Malaysia’s female labor force participation rate has been categorized as a single-peak graph (World Bank 2012), the second peak is hidden in the informal sector (see also Franck 2012). The rate of informality or informal economy participation not only increases with age but is also higher among the poorly educated, and informality itself subjects women to very precarious working conditions. As the narratives in the next section show, it is clear that informality among the poorly educated is caused by exclusion and not by choice.

VIEWS OF MALAYSIAN WOMEN WORKING IN THE INFORMAL ECONOMY

From our in-depth interviews with women working in the informal economy, we observed that

those employed in the lower-end occupations such as cleaners, childminders, coffee-shop attendants, hawkers, petty traders, and subcontract or home-based workers had extremely low income each month. More importantly, for many, this income was irregular and often conditional on factors beyond their control. Because their wages were so meager, some took on a combination of different informal jobs, but that still did not provide enough income. Those who were the sole or main sources of income for their household had the greatest difficulties in this regard. Only those who previously had been formally employed had some form of savings from contributions to the Employees Provident Fund.

Another reason for taking on informal work was due to difficulties in obtaining any other type of work, and indeed, participation in informal work is very much connected to one’s educational background. Many of those found working in low-end jobs had, at most, a secondary school certificate. Understandably, lower levels of educational attainment limit women’s work opportunities, and the lack of access to programs that would improve their skills is also a major impediment to women’s ability to obtain better paying employment. Further, women are then more likely to take on jobs that pay poorly and that, in some instances, entail hazardous working conditions which can adversely affect their health.

While a significant number of those with lower-level or no education make up the bulk of those performing informal work, as reflected among the women we interviewed, there is also an increasing number of women in the informal economy with higher qualifications (e.g. tertiary level), and accordingly, they have had more employment options and make considerably more money than their working-class counterparts. These included higher-end jobs such as consultants, entrepreneurs, and project coordinators, as well as those in the food, music, and financial advisor professions. Even so, like any other person working in the informal economy, these

women also experience job insecurity and they lack employment benefits.

In the following, we focus on giving Malaysian women a voice in expressing their views and experiences related to working in the informal economy. From these interviews, we have drawn specific themes (such as “*Not knowing better*”) that capture the women’s sentiments and perceptions. To maintain the confidentiality and privacy of the women, we use only the first letter of each woman’s name rather than her full name. The voices presented here are compiled from our in-depth interviews and from a Focus Group Discussion.

Not knowing better: K was working in a bank as a clerk when she opted to leave and become an insurance sales agent. She did so because at “*that time still young, that’s why didn’t know how to think in the long run*” hence the lure of “*getting more*” despite already having a stable job. It did not help that her previous job was monotonous, plus her husband, who had begun selling insurance, needed to recruit her as part of his team in order to be promoted in his job. For her, it was thus not so much about obtaining more money but the attraction of time and freedom, a move she subsequently regretted for having given up a stable income. But she also acknowledged that “*it’s always like that,*” i.e., one only “*learns in retrospect.*”

No choice: When asked if she would like to return to formal work, S said: “*I am already old, it is difficult to get a job. If the workplace is far I do not have the energy to commute, nearer is easier to go back and forth to work [breaks down and cries].*” Those women with lower qualifications do not have a choice as the formal sector does not provide employment for women with low education. The formal sector also does not cater to older women who need employment for their livelihood. The distance to work places is another obstacle to formal employment because many poor women cannot afford the cost of transportation. For others who lack adequate formal education, the system does not provide

an opportunity to be re-skilled or retrained for jobs that would pay higher wages. At another level, those women who are older but still actively working in the informal economy do not have the time for additional education or training because they are too busy trying to earn enough money to support their families. Therefore, their opportunities for any upward mobility are suppressed.

Vagary and unpredictability of the job: Given how “contract” work is organized (with contractors and sub-contractors), employees sometimes are unclear as to who their actual bosses or employers are. This opens them to being further exploited. As mentioned, even those in higher-end occupations are not spared from the financial insecurity that comes with informal work. In the case of H, a contract teacher, who sometimes had students and other times did not, there was the uncertainty of how much income she would make as a result. She also shared that it was hard to state exactly how much she earned because while she may have made more at the beginning of the year, by the end, when her students stopped classes because they had school exams, “*then I’m pretty broke.*” Consequently, she adjusted her expectations and lifestyle in line with the lack of certainty:

[D]oesn’t bother me because I am used to it – on the months I earn less, I spend less . . . even if I don’t have enough, I will try to pay the bills. Food I can get cheap stuff from Tesco, I don’t need to eat at restaurants, and I can cook it myself. So on lean months, I don’t go shopping . . . even if I do have extra, I lead a very simple life.

What future?: When asked about whether she saved for the future and how she would pay for her health care, another woman said: “*It’s already hard to make ends meet, very hard* [emphasis by respondent].” Nevertheless, she appeared to console herself by saying “*in my line of work, I don’t have to retire if I don’t want to.*” On the other hand, when asked what she would do in the event

that she were to fall ill, she confessed, “[I] *didn’t think about that, but so far so good . . .*” before commenting:

When I really need to use a lot of money, I can sell my apartment and then get a cheap one . . . I’m more on the optimist type. I take every day as it is. Because sometimes in situations like this, you cannot afford to think too far and then get stressed.

Financial assistance from the government: Most of the women interviewed expressed the view that some of the welfare benefits that were available to the poor should also be extended to them. They complained that they had no access, or only limited access, to some of the benefits and programs that were offered by the government to the poor. Besides that, they wanted minimum wage regulations to be extended to them, and some form of inspection of this to be put in place. The only assistance S had received was an occasional government payment which is a form of cash transfer, as well as the *duit Raya* (financial assistance during *Eid*) that the religious authorities extended once a year. Her attempts at getting social welfare or assistance from the Islamic authorities (*zakat* department) had been futile. As she related:

If there is no zakat (financial support from religious authorities), I don’t mind. I have tried asking for help from them but they say you have children who should take care of you. I tell them that my children are not working or cannot find work . . . I cry . . . but they do not want to help.

Even so, S felt that welfare aid was secondary to her needs: “*If the government does not help, it is ok but they must increase our wage . . . money is important.*” Another woman, MT, a 56-year old working single mother, with only seasonal income and with two grown-up children, had been marginally more fortunate and was receiving welfare support (*bantuan am*) from the state.

However, this amounted to RM120 a month (previously when her children were younger, she received RM160), grossly insufficient to survive on. On the other hand, MT’s attempts at securing housing, despite the preexisting policy for single mothers, came to naught as she commented:

You apply for DBKL flat, apply for single mother you cannot get it . . . direct apply from DBKL, then woman ministry also help to write a letter to DB. Could not get it . . . [so] no need to apply anymore, no need to apply anymore.

At the Focus Group Discussion that we conducted with members of civil society groups, the representative of the Single Mothers Association (*Persatuan Ibu Tunggal*) echoed how difficult it was for its members to obtain affordable housing, even though the state has announced that it would facilitate this process. Among those in the higher-end jobs, H pointed out that the government ought to intervene to improve living conditions as a whole, but in particular, exert more stringent price controls: “*Do not simply keep raising prices . . . inflation is very bad, housing is not affordable.*” Housing prices, she felt, had been adversely affected by the “Malaysia My Second Home” scheme, where demand by foreigners had “*disturbed*” (increased) housing prices.

Women’s rights and organizing the informal economy: Most women engaged in the informal economy do not know their rights, and there is a need to organize the informal economy and to empower these women to negotiate their wage rates. SW mentioned that women in the informal economy lacked confidence:

A lot of these women I think, like we have L, she’s an informal worker, she has got Form 3 education, but she still prefers to do home-based work. It is because she says she’s so afraid to go out there to work. She has to negotiate with the employers, how much salary. Whatever they give, she will accept . . . don’t have the confidence to ask why they can’t pay more.”

She went on to say that the unions needed to also strategize and organize with the women in the informal economy:

So, the unions have to also think about the kinds of jobs that are being outsourced, and the women who are going into those sectors, how to empower them, how to start organizing them also. Because if their rights are protected then there will be less of them [women in the informal sector].

VIEWS OF MALAYSIAN EMPLOYERS ON THE INFORMAL ECONOMY

The views of employers were solicited from a Focus Group Discussion on the informality of employment and most were positive and hopeful about informal sector work. They justified informal employment in various ways: for example, as a global trend, as helping to relieve labor shortages, as benefiting workers who do not want to report their earnings, and as encouraging entrepreneurship. The following are some of their views.

Outsourcing or casualization, a global trend: According to a large employer (KOS), which is an outsourcing company, outsourcing or casualization or unregulated labor is a global trend, and temporary labor is a big market. The employer said that there were five types of labor: full-time labor, contract labor, long-term contract labor, temporary labor, and independent contractors. He went on to say that women should take up such work contracts because they provide flexibility.

Labor difficulty: MAI, an employer who was against regulating the informal sector, said that employers resort to using casual labor because they faced difficult labor situations. She said that she would not want casual labor to be regulated. It was very difficult to get labor into the workforce, so employers looked for workers who do not want to work outside the home. They take

work to these women, for example, who work from home as sewers and are paid on piece-rate.

A matter of terminology: Another employer said that we should not use the term casual labor because these workers were independent contractors. She gave the example of how some companies regard the “tea lady”—whose job is to provide tea and other beverages and snacks to company employees—as an independent contractor. So, if there was a meeting, the tea lady would get all the things that were ordered, and one only had to pay for whatever services she provided. In this way, it was really a negotiation between the two parties where the tea lady was an independent contractor who is potentially paid a higher rate than if she is in permanent employment.

In relation to recent debates over whether this type of work needed to be regulated, the KOS spokesman indicated that there were people who are working from home, doing business online, and were unregulated. Unregulated labor is a terminology that is accepted. He went on to emphasize that there was nothing negative or wrong about casualization of the workforce, and that, in fact, he saw it as a benefit because women want to take short-term work if they needed a break. He highlighted E-homemakers which had 25,000 [unverified number] tertiary educated women members, who wanted to work from home and were a part of this unregulated labor.

Outsourcing or independent contractors and entrepreneurship: An employer participating in the Focus Group Discussion was rather hopeful that being an independent contractor could be a stepping-stone toward becoming an entrepreneur. She said that when these women got the job, sometimes they took on a few jobs and then outsourced these to their contacts. Such independent contractors are very entrepreneurial, and they need to be encouraged to be entrepreneurs: “It is a very good training ground for them to start being an entrepreneur.”

Outsourcing as specialization: The employers in the Focus Group Discussion were also of the

opinion that outsourcing could lead to the specialization of certain services like security and cleaning, which are not their core business. Some banks also outsource their IT services to get the best talent in the industry for the job at hand. So, employers believe in outsourcing to specialists who know how to perform in a more cost-effective and efficient manner.

Outsourcing as shared services: KJ, a health care provider, said that the term outsourcing should be replaced by the concept of shared services. There are certain types of services that are shared by different sectors and by many employers. It is no longer cost-effective and efficient to employ full-time staff to do such work.

Outsourcing of labor as a solution to address attitude of local workers: At the Focus Group Discussion, most employers also commented on the attitude of local workers. In some industries, work increased during the weekend and local workers tended not to want to work then. Besides that, they could also apply for emergency leave or get a medical leave and not turn up at work. So one of the ways employers overcame such problems was by outsourcing labor. MA complained that “*business had to go on*” and that they had no choice.

Public sector outsourcing: A representative from the public sector said that the government was also outsourcing services that were not its core business and was cutting back in terms of public sector employment. She said that in her department they did not need full-time staff to handle certain services, so they outsourced these tasks.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

In Malaysia, gender differentials prevail where women’s share of the informal workforce is growing while that of men is declining. Out of all informally employed women, the largest numbers are in human health and social work,

manufacturing, and accommodation and food service activities. In contrast, even as percentages show signs of declining, men continue to be highly concentrated in construction and motor repair, wholesale and retail trade. Furthermore, occupationally, the largest segment of male informal workers is classified as craft workers followed by sales and services workers and elementary workers. Among female workers, larger numbers of workers were found in services and sales in 2015 compared to 2012, while female craft workers dipped slightly. Men were predominantly engaged in construction, which includes skilled and manual labor with varying skill levels. In contrast, women have dominated the services industry, especially food, and home-based manufacturing, which offer minimal opportunities for skills development. Women working in the informal economy receive very low wages, and the majority of these women lack income and employment security. Further, they do not receive protection or benefits such as health insurance, which contributes to the vulnerability of the majority of women working in the informal economy.

Unsurprisingly, the findings on the informal economy, as discussed in this chapter, include various contradictions. While most informal economy workers interviewed felt vulnerable, not protected and exploited, employers were more hopeful and confident in the potential of informality and outsourcing. The less educated poorer women had fewer skills, including negotiation skills, to ask for a higher and fairer rate for the work they performed. In addition, they tended to enter the informal economy at a later age, and this also contributed to their lower wages. The cost of labor is much lower in the informal sector, compared to the formal sector, even for upper-level jobs, which possibly explains the conflicting perspectives of workers and employers in the informal economy.

This chapter puts forward the proposition that the global economy functions by means of the deployment of labor that is formal and informal,

and the participation of women in various kinds of unregulated labor arrangements is increasing. This also reflects asymmetrical gender relations and ideologies. Women enter into such arrangements for it is predicated upon gender differences in both the domains of production and reproduction. Furthermore, enterprises and companies in the global economy have taken advantage of this context as it provides greater global competitiveness through the employment of female workers and thus lower labor costs. Moving employment where possible from the formal to the informal economy transnationally is supported by the employers in this study, thus increasing the demand for casualized female labor.

Economic globalization and the burden for greater competitiveness through lower labor cost, as mentioned above, encourage the growth of the informal economy. In turn, the expansion of informal employment among women is one way in which women have been incorporated into the global economy. This, however, is an element of labor market segmentation on a global scale that contributes to increasing profitability by employing unregulated female labor. Bearing in mind the function of gender norms and ideologies, it is no wonder that despite women's role in the growth of the national and global economy, they are still not reaping its benefits even though they play an important part in this process. By accepting lower wages and poor working conditions in the informal economy, women function as "subsidizers" and "shock absorbers" of the neoliberal national and global economy. Reduced and stagnating wages for men are also forcing the number of women seeking income-generating activities to increase, be it in the formal or informal economy.

Many women in developing countries accept this kind of work as it allows them to combine income-generating activities with domestic responsibilities and caregiver activities. These gendered contexts have contributed to increasing the competitive edge of certain industries in the international market by keeping production costs low

through the casualization of labor; women, rather than men, are predominantly kept outside formal work relations and the related benefits. In the Malaysian context, intensification of global integration and global trade has induced local firms to utilize informal labor as a strategy to reduce production costs so as to maintain competitiveness.

As a substantial number of poor people, and particularly women, earn their livelihoods in the informal economy (which does not necessarily shrink with economic growth), policies aimed at increasing employment and reducing poverty will be more effective when they take the activities of this sphere into account. This means that measures such as skills development, the promotion of entrepreneurship, and improved working conditions must be provided for workers in the informal economy. Measures that facilitate the process of formalization of firms and labor should generate more productive employment and improved work settings. Such measures should also improve social protection and reduce poverty. This includes extending the Employment Act, minimum wage regulations, and other protections accorded to formal employees, to cover the large number of women workers in the informal economy who are currently excluded from these benefits. The role of labor inspections is very vital in the informal economy. Also, strategies need to be developed for improving the enforcement of gender-relevant legislation and directives with respect to the informal economy (including the development of appropriate indicators and monitoring processes). Trade unions also need to make relevant adjustments so as to cater to part-time workers, especially women. There is a need for an internal review in trade unions and how they can orient their activities to assist informal labor and also migrant labor, because if they do not, their very existence will also be under threat.

Despite the benefits of globalization in terms of increasing female employment, be it in the formal or informal economy, there is political

backlash in the form of “new isolationism” in some realms. The time has come for a remodeling of globalization for the well-being of all people. The growing informality of employment due to the need for maintaining or increasing global competitiveness of industries and nations is not sustainable in the long term. There is an obligation to facilitate global collaboration in production processes for mutual gain, and by so doing, to assure worker’s rights and well-being. This should be the new spirit in the rebooting of globalization.

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Chapter sixteen

Women Politicians in Cambodia Resisting and Negotiating Power in a Newly “Implemented” Democracy

Mikael Baaz and Mona Lilja

INTRODUCTION

Following the end of the Cold War, the concept of liberal democracy became a catchphrase on the agendas and in the rhetoric of various international agents operating in an ever increasingly globalized international society (Baaz and Lilja 2014). In accordance with this spirit, the United Nations (UN), by the adoption of Security Council Resolution 745 on February 28, 1992, established the United Nations Transitional Authority in Cambodia (UNTAC). The undertaking, which aimed at building sustainable peace and establishing an independent and democratic state in Cambodia, lasted for 18 months, deployed some 22,000 military and civilian personnel, and cost some US\$1.7 billion. This was the first occasion ever that the UN took over the administration of an independent state completely and ran an election (rather than only monitoring and supervising it) (Berdal 1996; Baaz 2015: 159–160). The elections, in which some 90 percent of eligible voters participated, were held in May 1993, and in September a new constitution was adopted, ushering in “implementation” of a new democracy. Since then, general elections have been held in Cambodia in 1998, 2003, 2008, and 2013.

The Parliament of Cambodia consists of two Chambers: the National Assembly (NA) and the Senate. In total, it is composed of 184 members: 123 in the NA and 61 senators. It should be noted that as of 2013, only 25 of the 123 seats are held by women. In the Senate, the figures are even lower, with only 9 of the 61 seats being held by women. These numbers reflect a decrease of women in parliament from the previous election in 2008 (Ellen 2013; Kaner 2013; Ministry of Women’s Affairs of Cambodia 2014). At the communal level, despite efforts to increase female representation, in the 2017 elections, Cambodian women lost almost 100 seats since elections were last held in 2012 (Kijewski 2017).

We will see that these numbers may suggest that the political lives of Cambodian women politicians are scripted by gender in ways that hamper their legitimacy and reduce the number of women participating in politics. This chapter explores performances of discursive resistance carried out by Cambodian women politicians, in relation to power that operates in ways that shape their political possibilities, practices, and subject positions. In the context of the chapter, “subject positions” is loosely defined sociologically as “statuses” that are associated with varying levels of prestige and risk. As will be displayed,

current discourses and figurations of women politicians are constantly changing due to cultural and localized challenges, practices of resistance, global trends, and political interventions. In addition, the chapter reveals how both power and resistance are entangled in a complex web that simultaneously undermines but also strengthens each other.

GENDERED SCRIPTS

Judith Butler approaches gender issues through the concept of “performativity”. In her early works, she argues that language does not simply describe reality, it *creates* reality: What does the statement “you are a woman” mean? How we act is due to how others have acted before us. We tend to repeat behaviors that we observe. The act that one performs is, in a sense, an act that has been going on before one “arrived on the scene.” “Gender acts” are those that have already been practiced. A gender act can be seen as a script that survives those who use it, but requires new actors in order to be actualized and reproduced again. In other words, gender has a history that exists beyond the person who enacts those conventions. Our continual repetition of these gender acts in the most ordinary of daily activities, such as the way we walk, talk, and gesture, makes gender a dominating script that is a fundamental ingredient in the organization of society. As Butler points out, since gender is maintained through repetition, it inevitably is in a process of constant change (Butler 1990, 1995, 1997).

In her later work, Butler (2015) emphasizes the importance of the material aspects of gender, “materiality of bodies,” and the intersectional character of gender. The female subject is multi-layered, dynamic, and situated in shifting contexts. Feminists are way ahead when they display the complexity of female subject positions. Their repertoire already contains powerful “re-figurations” of women in their “great diversity” (Braidotti 2002). Kathy Ferguson has also

embraced the notion of multiplicity of the female subject position through the concept of “mobile subjectivities” that “need irony to survive the manyness of things” (Ferguson 1993: 178). This chapter acknowledges gender in its complexity, intersectionality, and its importance in relation to material bodies.

Gender in Cambodian Culture

Gender is also intricately bound to what is considered culturally appropriate. Like in many other cultures, complex, intersectional gendered scripts play out in Cambodia according to ideals that are rooted in narratives found in religious texts. Different cultural codes establish ideals for women, men, children, migrant workers, monks, and other categories of people, through recognizable and repeated verses and proverbs learned and reinforced over a lifetime. For example, the *Chbap Srei* (“Code for Women”) combines popular custom with Buddhist principles to offer practical advice in regard to appropriate behavior for women. The guiding rules of *Chbap Srei* are disseminated by mothers and embedded through socialization and education. It instructs women to move quietly around the house, to be polite, and to preserve the dignity and feelings of her husband, despite any indiscretion on his part (Brickell 2011).

According to Brickell, there was probably a close correspondence between the ideals articulated in the *Chbap Srei* and the ways women addressed their lives in Cambodia before the 1970s. Today, however, it remains unclear to what extent the traditional ideals of womanhood correspond to the lived realities of women in Cambodia. Brickell highlights some of the disjunctures that currently characterize men’s and women’s narratives regarding ideals and practices “appropriate” for women. Overall, an accelerated pace of change in regard to gender ideals is recognized mostly by urban women in Cambodia. Here, younger and middle-age women often

sense that traditional gender ideals cannot fully be adhered to, in spite of what many men would desire.

Still, gendered memories of the past “are influencing the perpetuation of gender inequities in the present, so . . . historical constructs of womanhood (are) likely to shape expectations for the future” (Brickell 2011: 458). This contributes to a simultaneous conservation of past gender ideals, as the “ideal woman” in contemporary Cambodian society is both creatively negotiated and changed due to the multiple, and often contradictory, demands placed on her by society, family, globalization, and self (Brickell 2011). These gendered memories often re-emerge, coming into play in Cambodia’s contemporary political arena.

Gendered Politics in Cambodia

Contemporary gender scripts maintain stubborn vestiges of narratives speaking to ideals for women, including how women conduct themselves as political leaders. They also influence the new democratic arena, and how bodies move and act within different political spaces, such as the Cambodian Parliament. Through discussions with female politicians, we have generated themes surrounding gendered politics in Cambodia.

These themes emerged through in-depth interviews conducted in the Phnom Penh area of Cambodia, carried out between 1997 and 2014, with politically involved women from various political parties in Cambodia.¹ These political parties included: the National United Front for an Independent, Neutral, Peaceful, and Cooperative Cambodia; the Cambodian People’s Party; the Human Rights Party; and Sam Rainsy Party. The Sam Rainsy Party and the Human Rights Party later merged to form the Cambodia National Rescue Party. Respondents included a range of public actors, from members of parliament and senators, to grassroots activists. Interviewees included various stakeholders to the Extraordinary Chambers in the Courts of Cambodia (ECCC).

The ECCC was created in an agreement between the Cambodian government and the UN to hear crimes committed during the rule of Pol Pot and the Khmer Rouge (International Bar Association 2017). To complement these interviews and map civil society-based activities, interviews with women activists, non-governmental organization (NGO) workers, and people in the media were also conducted.

CONSERVATIVE IMAGES OF WOMEN

In Cambodia, mainstream discourses often provide monotonously narrow, limited, and rather conservative images of “women.” Female politicians acknowledge these discourses, as expressed by the following two women:

Women can be successful as politicians if they remain gentle, soft, quiet and, in addition, as intelligent as men are.

Women in Cambodian society are seen as inferior to men. They are considered mentally weaker. This view is stronger in the rural areas than in the towns.

Women are not equals. Men see themselves as the intelligent actors.

These quotes can be better understood through the image of the “perfectly virtuous woman,” that continues to persist in Cambodian society (Ledgerwood 1990: 32; Kent 2011; Lilja 2016a, 2017).

Social life in Cambodia is complex, containing multiple figurations continually performed in numerous ways. Discussing such complexity in meaningful ways is compounded, since powerful images such as the perfectly virtuous woman exist side-by-side, and in interaction with, other figurations (Ledgerwood 1994; Ebihara and Ledgerwood 2002). Like female politicians, there are numerous categories of women in different subject positions that call attention to gendered

norms. For example, specific gendered norms are associated with a woman who traverses various statuses, such as the migrant woman, the woman resister, and the NGO worker (Lilja 2008, 2016a). These represent a few of the many different categories of women with intersectional statuses associated with more or less risk or opportunity (Ledgerwood 1994; Ebihara and Ledgerwood 2002). Adding to the complexity, current discourses and figurations are also constantly changing due to global trends, practices of resistance, and political interventions.

In an important sense, however, this very complexity offers an advantage to women, especially the female politicians of our focus. Cambodia's public arena has been male dominated and there is no longstanding, well-established figuration of a “female politician.” The door is left open to “negotiate” what such a position offers to political women as they begin traversing it. The culturally coded prevailing images of women seldom overlap with the image of a politician “into which various characteristics of dominant masculinities (for example rationalism and individualism) are smuggled” (Monro 2005: 169; Lilja 2016a). One female politician said:

In one way it is an advantage to be a woman. People just do not believe that women can be politicians. Therefore everyone comes to listen to you. They want to see how a female candidate acts. They think, is it possible? Can a woman really be a politician?

The same view was held by respondents discussing the ECCC in 2010. Interviewees reflected on the character of the women's testimonies in Cambodian courts, with some remarking that women's testimonies get more attention, since it is so rare to see women talk publicly. On the other hand, an NGO-worker stated that: “women politicians were marginalized before, and they still are.” Rather than acknowledging marginalization as insurmountable, however, women have the opportunity to negotiate new figurations that

challenge the dominant masculinities embedded in Cambodian politics. Such challenges can translate to practices of resistance.

RESISTANCE AND GENDERED POLITICS IN CAMBODIA

How do women politicians practice resistance? In our analysis, several discursive practices of resistance by female politicians in Cambodia are identified. These practices aim to negotiate binary images, hierarchies, and uneven relations of political power.

Women as Particular Politicians and Strategies of Normalization

In Cambodia, narrow images of women highlight stereotyped characteristics, such as shy, subaltern (lower-ranked and outside of the power structure), or mentally weak (Lilja 2016b). Some respondents in the Phnom Penh area, however, emphasized that women make better leaders than men. This alternate image claims that a female leader is more compassionate and understanding than a male leader. Women politicians claimed themselves to be responsible, capable, good speakers, understanding, and even brilliant. One female politician said:

In [the] NA people are treated equally whether they are men or women. People respect politicians. They think women understand people better as they take care of basic needs, domestic duties, etc., at the same time as they are politicians.

Such skills are positively associated with “women in the domestic sphere (and) are considered valuable in rebuilding the nation” (McGrew et al. 2004). In drawing on social capital and “goods” of femininity, and the nation's responsibilities to

care for its citizens, an image of the caring female politician has been constructed (Lilja 2008).

Fueled by globalization, the practice of constructing positive competing images in the public sphere will continue to grow in significance (Thörn 2002: 126). Globalization allows more interpretive struggles to occur. Various characteristics of what is regarded as masculine or feminine are “co-opted in new or old configurations to serve particular interests, and particular gendered (and other) identities are consolidated and legitimated, or downgraded and devalued” (Hooper 2000: 60). However, this interpretive struggle over what it means to be a woman or a man involves not only gender negotiations, but also how the genders are constructed in relation to different political arenas. For instance, one female politician focused upon the image of a “Western state” in order to legitimize women’s presence in the political sphere. She stated:

[Women are] capable of sensitizing the whole crowd. Better than men, you know . . . I think if Cambodia, I am sure . . . if Cambodia is a democratic country like the Western countries, women would be brilliant in politics.

While arguing in favor of women’s exceptional qualities, therefore, this woman drew on the idea of a democracy “like the Western countries,” utilizing a discourse made accessible by globalization, to explain the impressiveness and distinctiveness of women in politics (Lilja 2008).

Striving Toward Sameness

As we saw above, different femininities are used as grounds to negotiate gender hierarchies. However, in resisting power, women emphasized their uniqueness as well as their similarities. A discourse of likeness, unity, and homogenization is used to resist prevailing gender stereotypes. For political reasons, “sameness” has often been manipulated to create uniformity and to

subordinate the individual to the group, a strategy, for example, used by different fascist movements. A common position is said to provide “the safety of sameness” (Gilroy 1997: 310–313), and sometimes becomes a tool of resistance. The concept of sameness is related to security or political manipulations, but it also contributes another discursive strategy of resistance promoted by these female politicians.

Power thrives on the presence of difference—in this case the separation between men and women—where the latter risk being lower-ranked or stereotyped. This was reflected in interviews with female politicians who tried to remove both differences and the multiple categories in favor of sameness. This tactic was likely to avoid the power constructions that often go with it. For example, one woman said:

Women are the same as men. Men are not more intelligent than women are, even if there are people that are convinced that this is the case.

This sentiment was echoed by another woman:

The strategy is talking about women as also human resources . . . And when we talk about women’s rights, then we also talk about equal rights. You need to talk about equality as well.

The usage of words such as “also human resources” implies that women strive to include themselves into the notion of “humans.” It may be favorable for women to explicitly insert themselves into a taken-for-granted category that is supposed to include both women and men. Given that men are generally more privileged in terms of status and capital, a “human,” inclusive category may help evaporate the binary division of the sexes. This can be understood as a practice of resistance that undermines the very foundation for any hierarchy that ranks women lower than men.

Referring to the notion of human, women appear to justify women’s rights to political

power. This may be a successful strategy, since the concept of human is commonly associated with the global discourse of human rights. The rhetoric of human rights is used by numerous agencies, state leaders, civil society activists, business executives, academics, journalists, lawyers, and celebrities. The discourse is characterized by the call for practices and policies to be addressed in the name of human rights. By repeatedly addressing and interpreting torture, war crimes, religious intolerance, gender-based discrimination, mistreatment of immigrants, poverty, and under-development as human rights abuses, for example, the discourse has rapidly advanced globally, especially during recent decades (Manokha 2010), and in conjunction with sweeping social change.

What is revealed above is that there is a paradox between what is presented as an emancipatory goal and what is presented as an imagery of power. For many feminist, gay, and anti-racism activists, for example, the existence of multiple images and discourses, and the space to display them, is seen as desirable. Hierarchies are shaped by multiple statuses and their intersection, such as gender, sexuality, and race, with some intersections ranked higher and associated with more power than others. Discourses that negotiate the binary images associated with power open up the possibility for new hierarchies to be created. Although at the outset it seems paradoxical, strategies for emancipatory goals may simultaneously produce hierarchies and reduce stereotypes. Such discursive strategies can be used by female politicians to challenge male domination in politics.

Normalizing as Potential or Problem?

Another strategy is to use existing gender hierarchies as a beginning point for negotiating. In Cambodia's political realm, some subject positions and the norms associated with them

are recognized as desirable. Acting according to the norms associated with these subject positions (statuses) can bring rewards, such as decision-making power (Lilja 2016b). Some female politicians strive to “normalize” their actions in ways that are congruent to the image of a male politician, with the idea that it will make them “better politicians.” For example, several argued that in politics, women must be more outspoken and active, traits usually associated with men (Lilja 2008, Lilja 2016b). One woman said:

Women are not really active like they are. So I think we have to show them (men), you know, that we can do something, in action, so they (men) can see.

Adapting to hierarchies and stereotypes in order to gain political power in some sense maintains the power relation *per se*. By gaining political positions through normalization, the mechanisms of exclusion and the injustices of the political systems remain. It is ironic, therefore, that when women, repeat a “male” political image, they may also be resisting their lower-ranked position, since it is a position they refuse to perform. Therefore, such normalization may not only be viewed as a form of power that shapes supposedly docile, lower-ranked women, it may also be viewed as an act of resisting.

Nevertheless, for many it is only possible to mimic the male norm. Women trying to discipline themselves to move in the direction of adopting the standard male norm will probably fail. Deborah Johnston (1991) suggests that rehabilitation to the normal cannot be fully attained, since the system rests upon the existence of both the normal and the abnormal. On the other hand, female members of parliament, who adjust themselves to the standard behaviors of the male political sphere, might successfully “shake up” the cultural order by performing an “in-between” position, not corresponding to either male or female gender stereotypes.

For example, one female member of parliament described how strong and outspoken women were perceived in the NA:

Sometimes, when you do like this (gesture of speaking), everyone looks at you: So brave, so intelligent, but not so nice to be around . . . Are you single, too; no one will ask you to marry. Oh I'm scared of a woman like that.

Mobilizing Different Subject Positions

Another theme that emerged is how women in the political arena possess a repertoire of positions to draw upon as needed. Women organize different subject positions according to context, which may also be addressed in terms of resistance. One female politician argued that it is better not to perform as a “woman,” but to represent oneself just as a leader:

[A]s leaders women have also some difficulty. But somehow not all people know what women can do, they always think that men can do better, than women. But, through my work as a Minister, I tried to explain these issues. To be a leader I did not like to say, “I am a woman.” But as leader I had to do the job as a leader and not connect being a female with the job.

A woman in a position of leadership may be seen, first and foremost, as a leader while she is simultaneously “hiding” the fact that she is a woman. Women may use this strategy in response to stereotypes that assume women are essentially “non-political,” views expressed by one woman politician:

But as leader I had to do the job as a leader and not connect being a female with the job . . . as leaders women have also some difficulty. But somehow not all people know what women can do, they always think that men can do better, than women.

For this woman, it is preferable to talk from the position of leader in order to move up the political ladder. It might also be possible for her to negotiate the female low-status subject position by speaking from a high-status leader position: “through my work as a Minister, I tried to explain these issues [about what women can do].” As “a leader,” she probably possesses the status and impact needed to maintain her capacity in a trustworthy manner. Thus the trick would be an attempt to redefine a low-status subject position, while talking from another high-status subject position (Lilja 2016b, 2017).

Another woman, representing a local NGO, discussed the possibility of moving between different subject positions. She separated the female subject positions from the image of a politician, and still argued for the ability for women to have both. She suggested that women must be trained to live up to the standards of a politician. This results in having two different subject positions to alternate between: that of a woman and that of a politician. This alternating between different images or figurations reveals a bodily resistance, which unfolds from the interpretation of local discourses of gender. Reflecting on the dominant gender discourses, women “hide and show” different “identities” as a form of resistance (Lilja 2016b, 2017).

DISCUSSION

We have discussed a number of patterns or “themes,” which reveal some interesting, discursive, everyday practices of resistance of women politicians in Cambodia. First, it seems that some women politicians resist power-loaded discourses by mixing or weaving together different “truths,” thereby producing new hybrid truths. The image of the need-oriented, gentle, peaceful woman that informs the image a female politician, creates a hybrid image of the “caring female-politician.” Thus, while the figuration of “women” in contemporary Cambodia seems to repeatedly contradict the image of a “politician,” the former occasionally imbues the latter with meaning.

Second, “sameness” was a continual theme expressed by the respondents. Some women tried to obtain rewards and appreciation from behaving according to what they perceived as the perfect, non-feminine politician. However, at the same time, these women seem to disrupt the cultural order and challenge narrow images and understandings of women. They perform a figuration that has been established and used mainly by men in the male-oriented political sphere. In this way they dispute the very discourse that presents men as (natural) politicians. Practicing and performing the so-called male norm can be understood as resistance (Lilja 2008).

Third, in order to obtain access to the NA, other women expressed themselves as alternating between different subject positions. There are some subject positions that women are “allowed” to assume and speak from. For example, in a transnational situation, in the nexus between violence, memory, and political legitimacy, subject positions such as woman, wife, politician, migrant, and NGO worker are imbued with different meanings and authority. Due to their legacy, different images were explored, hailed, or abandoned by women politicians. One woman in a position of leadership tried, first and foremost, to correspond to the image of a (male) leader, while “hiding” the fact that she was a woman. Several researchers have emphasized this “sliding” between different subject positions. To this we would like to add how sliding seems to be used by some Cambodian women in order to gain greater authority over the discourses (Lilja 2016b, 2017).

Finally, the sameness strategy not only included women “becoming like men,” or assuming male-imbued knowledge, but some respondents may have constructed an all-embracing “human” subject position that included both men and women. Women may behave “as men,” or claim themselves to be “humans,” within the political sphere. It is important to show how these practices of resistance are linked to the construction of power. By promoting the concept of human, the women try to erase categorizing

men and women into separate, binary types and minimizing the creation of gender hierarchies (Lilja 2008).

CONCLUSION

The politicians we interviewed practice resistance by “playing” with different gendered images. Providing diverse stories of contestations from female politicians demonstrates how resistance profits from, creates, and/or challenges power. Resistance and power exist together.

Different practices of resistance where women used various gendered images to challenge different discourses and/or gain political power seem often to simultaneously strengthen and to challenge power. While strategies of sameness undermine hierarchies, they may also strengthen certain stereotypes, and conceal power relations. Women disciplining themselves against a male norm may hide the power relations between men and women by denying the existence of the different images that the hierarchy is based on. They redefine the female gender by “recharging” the appearance of being female with male qualities. On the other hand, emphasizing an image of a unique, superior, female political actor, who gained her ability from domestic experiences, might strengthen the stereotypical divide between the sexes. However, it might also upgrade the rank of the female image by constructing alternatives to existing female stereotypes. Many strategies of resistance, therefore, involve the danger of both challenging and strengthening power.

NOTE

- 1 Interviews quoted in this chapter were carried out in the Phnom Penh area, mainly in 1997, 1999, 2007, 2010, and 2014, mostly conducted by Mona Lilja and Mikael Baatz. Other interviews conducted by Mikael Baatz, Michael Schulz, and Stella Vinthagen in 2013 and 2014 serve as a background to, and context for, issues addressed in the chapter.

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Chapter seventeen

Freedom to Choose? Marriage and Professional Work among Urban Middle-Class Women in Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

Catherine Earl

INTRODUCTION

Marriage is a recognized means for women to gain social status, economic security, and new experiences beyond the natal family, a pattern that is observable globally and throughout most cultures. Yet patriarchal “marriage strategies” (Bourdieu 1976) can be risky for young middle-class Vietnamese women in realizing their desires for a secure future. The influences of state-led development and globalization in post-reform Vietnam arguably make professional work an alternative that may be more readily realized and more rewarding. In contesting, shaping and imagining their futures, marriage or professional work is presented to Vietnamese daughters as a choice through the pervasive social institutions of family, school, workplace, mass media, and others. Such social institutions conventionally represent marriage as a match between a Vietnamese man and a Vietnamese woman that is heteronormative and harmonious, but also hierarchical. Fields of work are represented as highly gendered, being suitable either for a Vietnamese man or a Vietnamese woman. These socially constructed ideals have remained central in processes of socialization that form encultured dispositions and reproduce

class cultures in post-reform Vietnam. However, as Bourdieu (1984) and others argue, differential access to privileges enables individuals to transform themselves, and symbolically, if not actually, rise socially to occupy qualitatively different, and ideally relative higher, social status positions. This takes place so long as the pertinent “forms of capital” (Bourdieu 1997) they embody can be deciphered by others as signals of cultural sophistication and relatively higher status. Through this lens, marriage and professional work can be conceptualized not as oppositional but as relational, and the choices women make can be understood not simply as individual choices, but more complexly as choices that are embedded in and shaped by the varying influences of social institutions.

This chapter is conceptualized through a theoretical framework derived from classic Bourdieusian sociology, modified with feminist, cultural, and globalization theories. The discussion draws on ethnographic fieldwork, comprising participant observation among urban middle-class women in Ho Chi Minh City (Saigon), Vietnam from 2000 to 2015 (see Earl 2008, 2014b). Specifically, it centers on the life experiences of six women, three pairs of sisters, who migrated to Ho Chi Minh City from rural areas in

the years after the 1986 macro-economic reforms (*Đổi Mới*), that opened the centralized economy to global markets. In this chapter I reconsider these women's stories as the interconnected stories of sisters whose futures are entangled with their natal families as well as their (future) husband's families. Their stories illustrate the massive impact of globalization on women of Vietnam, and how this plays out differentially in processes of development and social change in urban middle-class women's lives. This occurs particularly in the context of choices about professional work and marriage in achieving desires for normative social status, as well as in meeting desires for upward social mobility and a secure future in post-reform Vietnam. Grosz (2011) usefully frames choices in terms of a spectrum of freedoms shaped by enabling and constraining factors in individual women's lives. I draw on this interpretation in analyzing choice-making in urban middle-class Vietnamese women's lives.

The hopes, dreams, and fantasies of the three pairs of sisters reveal that urban middle-class futures can be realized with investments of considerable resources in creating opportunities for new social, economic, and gendered status. For some, this can be achieved through education and career. For others, marriage continues to offer a viable alternative, although perhaps not within the Vietnamese cultural sphere, since new opportunities for transnationalism in post-reform Vietnam appear to enable urban middle-class women to more freely evade cultural expectations that would have obliged their subordination to oppressive feminine norms.

FEMINISM, DEVELOPMENT, AND SOCIAL CHANGE IN URBAN VIETNAM

Contemporary Vietnamese society is without question undergoing significant development and change. The lives of women in Vietnam are transforming, but are doing so unevenly and unequally.

A culturally specific and widely circulated cliché that regards a Vietnamese woman to be the “general of the interior” (*nội tướng*), implies that she is empowered to make choices about the domestic realm. However, there is little information about the choices Vietnamese women actually make in their daily lives. Beyond some literature about a migrant's decision to migrate (Bélanger et al. 2013; Hoang 2009), we do not know much about how Vietnamese women make choices, such as which career to pursue, which organizations can support career development, when and with whom to have a family, and how to balance the demands of work and family.

A growing interest in Vietnam's middle-classes among anthropologists has generated a considerable body of literature which, firstly, presents overlapping and competing ideas about gender through a particular focus on the individual and her choices. Secondly, it tends to overlook the persistence and relevance of social structural forces in documented transformations of gender and gendered behaviors of women and men (Nguyen-Marshall et al. 2012; Schwenkel and Leshkowich 2012). Gill (2007: 153) points out that “a grammar of individualism” underpins notions of choice, being oneself, pleasing oneself, an emphasis on empowerment and taking control so that “The notion that all our practices are freely chosen . . . present women as autonomous agents no longer constrained by any inequalities or power imbalances whatsoever.” Such an individualist notion of agency mirrors a neoliberal agency that systematically overlooks structural reasons in framing freedom in terms of choice limited only by possibility, or alternatively by equating freedom not with choice, but with the ability to act on one's calculations for managing risk and fashioning one's own future (Gershon 2011). An individual's capacity to make such choices in Vietnam occurs in the context of kinship and other social relations that shape social power and relative social status. Currently, we know little about the nature and extent of the influences of social structures in Vietnamese

women's choices about their careers and family responsibilities.

Ways of understanding Vietnamese women's location in patriarchal kinship and social relations vary. In state discourses, Vietnamese women are located in the family which, although neolocal and nuclear in urban contexts, remains strongly patriarchal. Like post-reform China, in post-reform Vietnam, a multivocality of competing feminist discourses and a range of feminine expressions has emerged. While these may no longer be state imposed, these may persist in sending out a diverse range of messages from socialist mass organizations and other social institutions to play a role in shaping expectations for the daily lives of women (Spakowski 2011). In Vietnam, these include a range of competing discourses such as: socialist feminist narratives that advocate the equal participation of women in society and their liberation from imposed forms of colonial or imperial oppression (Werner 2009); liberal feminist narratives that advocate the rights of women to be mothers, carers, and wives (Pettus 2003); East Asian neo-Confucian patriarchal inspired narratives of normative feminine behavior (Ngô 2004); and universal rights-based models of non-antagonistic, more harmonious gender relations and shared concerns, focusing on humanity through the lenses of the family and welfare (Rydström 2010). These overlapping and competing ideas about women's lives and gendered experiences comprise a layering of the sociocultural landscape. New ideas are stacked up on legacies of the past and remnants of qualitatively different regimes and globalized orientations that are particular, historical, and independent; are situated with various local and global roots, and involve complex interactions between idealized and lived subjectivities (Thomas 2002; Earl 2008). Modern-day femininity, as Genz and Brabon (2009: 7–8) argue, is a “complex, multi-layered puzzle,” characterized by its hybrid qualities, multiple layers, and oppositional meanings.

The puzzle of modern-day Vietnamese femininity is particular to its context, which includes the state notion of normative gender identity. In Vietnam it is represented not as plural but as singular, with femininity (or masculinity) associated with a socially constructed life course, stepping from girlhood (or boyhood) to marriage and motherhood (or fatherhood). Alternative gender identities, such as “single” heterosexual adult women (see below), are recognized by the state, but these are routinely portrayed as non-normative. Vietnamese feminine normative social roles are communicated to Vietnamese women most prominently via the state mass media (Pettus 2003), although there is an observable gap between the discursive and the phenomenal with respect to the ideologically shaped status of women and women's experiences in Vietnam (Earl 2014a). This chapter asks to what extent do women accept and embody such normative social roles in the phenomenal experiences of their daily lives? How and why do urban middle-class Vietnamese women make choices about retreating from the influences of social structures and normative socialization processes? What roles do globalization and development play in such transformative social changes?

URBAN LABOR MIGRATION AND A WOMAN'S CHOICE TO RETREAT FROM THE METROPOLITAN CONTEXT

Tuyết, the youngest daughter in a large village family from Vietnam's rural Southeast, arrived in Ho Chi Minh City in 2000. Supported materially by remittances of cash and food from her elder sister Hai, a petty trader, Tuyết worked studiously to graduate from the Vietnam National University and win a highly desired job in a foreign-owned company. The high salary enabled her initially to repay her debts and eventually to support the graduate education costs of her new

husband, and the schooling of her niece (Hai's daughter), as well as to provide the modest salary she paid Hai who was employed as her housekeeper. With the arrival of her own children, Tuyét made a choice to retreat from her stressful city job and from the metropolitan environment. She retreated to a more modestly paid position in a small private organization and to a new home, one she had designed and built, in a rapidly developing provincial city near her natal village. She hired Hai's daughter as a nanny for her young children, enabling the niece to commence university studies whilst also earning a modest income. This retreat afforded Tuyét a relatively higher standard of living, and offered her more time to spend with, and care for, both her aging parents and young family. Tuyét's retreat also enabled her to buy a car. The small second-hand recent model car cost around the same price as a mid-range motorbike. While motorbike ownership had become ubiquitous in urban Vietnamese households, private car ownership, although growing, remained relatively rare (Hansen 2016). Consequently, car ownership conferred prestige on middle-class households through its relative scarcity value (Bourdieu 1984). This was especially the case outside Ho Chi Minh City.

Retreatism for urban labor migrants, such as Tuyét describes a return to the home from the workplace, as well as a reverse migration and return to the village. Importantly, a retreat for an urban labor migrant is not a return to the past, as the experiences of being away, however successful, rub off and reshape the individual's relative social position. Out-migrants are among the most able members of a sending community, and most households in rural Vietnam appear to have absent family members. Carruthers and Dang (2012) argue that the village remains a powerful center of social gravity for those who have left, and those rural-urban migrants in the major cities who traveled further from their village spatial location, also ascended further up a symbolic ladder of relative social mobility. Urban statuses are differentially valued in the village

and the city. Becoming an urban factory worker, for example, does not confer prestige in the village as much as becoming a professional worker, because the former is not generally associated with a transformation of identity into an urbanite.

Retreating from her career in management in the foreign sector to her natal family played an important part in enabling a rise of Tuyét's relative social status. Remittances and resources, including money sent from afar, can have a powerful effect in producing inequalities between haves and have nots in Vietnam, as well as leveling inequalities between an individual's rural family and kin, and others. Retreatism illustrates the vast potential power of resources that Tuyét could afford; for example, for her to give up high-paying and high-resource facilitating work to return to a situation far less financially rewarding, but much more socially and morally rewarding. Rather than maintain her absence to build her relative social position, Tuyét gave up her city life. While this may be considered as giving up independence and autonomy, if she is exercising an individual capacity to make choices, it might also be argued as giving up her isolation, if she is considered as belonging to a family, a village network, and a regional or national culture. Tuyét's experiences illustrate that her capacity to make choices was not simply individual, but also influenced by the social institutions of workplace and family.

The further choices Tuyét made, similarly reflect the extent to which social institutions influence urban middle-class Vietnamese women's choices. Individual capacities to make choices among urban middle-class women in Vietnam are shaped by their access to accrued reservoirs of various forms of capital, particularly social, cultural, and economic (Bourdieu 1997). Without such resources available to them via the social institutions of family, school, workplace, and mass media, urban middle-class women may be unable to achieve the goals set by themselves and by their families to realize a higher standard of living materially, and

subsequently a better future with a new and relatively higher social status.

As the main income earner in her household, Tuyết was able to make the choice to buy the car. Although her intentions were to benefit the members of the family, they had also agreed to the expenditure. Her choice conformed with the expectations placed on an idealized Vietnamese mother, such as those promoted in the Vietnamese state mass media which center on a woman's responsibility to meet the needs and interests of the family, before the self (Drummond 2004). In Vietnamese state propaganda, throughout the years the sisters were growing up, the heart of the ideologically imbued "happy family" (*gia đình hạnh phúc*) was a devoted and sacrificing wife-mother: firstly who chooses to remain within and follow a traditionalized subordinate and dependent genderized role; secondly who contributes to the family culturally by raising children and supporting emotionally her husband; and thirdly who contributes to the household economy through employment (Rydström 2010; see also Phạm 1999; Shibuya 2015). Retreating from the foreign sector and the metropolitan context provided Tuyết more time and resources to direct to her family. Tuyết's choices, although unconventional, appeared to conform with this idealized model and thus to a normative gender identity. Contrasting with notions that all our practices are freely chosen and women are no longer constrained by power inequalities and imbalances (Gill 2007; Gershon 2011). McNay (2004) proposes an idea of agency rethought around a non-reductive notion of experience that may account for changes within gender norms over time. She argues that normative discourses can be defended, challenged, and reconfigured by individuals within the constraining forces of cultural relations, in order to meet their differing needs.

Purchasing the car was a creative strategy Tuyết employed to improve the standard of living and the relative social position of her family. It enabled her to transform her individual identity

by making plausible claims on a relatively higher social position, whilst conforming to the normative expectations of the state idealized model of a good mother and responsible daughter. By choosing a car, a powerful symbol of elevated social status of Ho Chi Minh City and beyond its physical location, Tuyết was transforming a normative ideal of motherhood, as well as ways of being a daughter in her natal family after marriage. In the context of rapid development and profound social change after reform, Tuyết's choices illustrate that urban middle-class women are empowered to transform and reshape gender identities, such as by remaining a breadwinning daughter in the natal family after marriage, or becoming a high-end consumer (e.g. in buying a car), as a new and unconventional way to comply with conventional femininity and heteronormative gender roles.

WOMEN'S EMPLOYMENT AND A WOMAN'S CHOICE TO RETREAT FROM A GLOBALIZED CAREER PATHWAY

Sisters Cúc and Hạnh arrived in Ho Chi Minh City in the 1990s. They came from the Mekong Delta to study at metropolitan colleges and train for white-collar professions. Their move to the city had been supported by two of their older siblings, an orchardist and a rice trader. Like Tuyết, both Cúc and Hạnh also retreated from the foreign sector. Cúc chose to move to a low-paying position in a state sector company and Hạnh chose initially to move to a small private company that supplied the growing manufacturing sector. Hạnh then moved to home duties beyond the spheres of influence of formal organizations but within those of other social institutions, such as family and mass media.

The goal of stable and/or well-paid employment as a main vehicle for achieving relative

upward social mobility is one of the motivations driving a feminization of migration in Vietnam since the 1980s, and with its rapidly expanding foreign-invested, manufacturing and industrial sectors, Ho Chi Minh City is the main destination of labor migrants (General Statistical Office 2011). Young women, in particular, move to Ho Chi Minh City to work: in wage employment in factories and department stores (Bélanger and Pendakis 2009; Peters 2012); in the service sector as domestic servants or restaurant and hotel staff (Nguyen 2015); or in the informal sector as street traders, commercial sex workers, or in private manufacturing workshops (Nguyen-Vo 2008; Jerneck 2010; Agergaard and Vu 2011; Nguyen and Earl 2018). Their moves are not simply individual choices, but influenced by decision making in their natal families and shaped by the needs of their family members.

A strongly normative socialization of young people in Vietnam via families, schools, workplaces, the state mass media, and state mass organization supports, if not encourages, the judging of individuals against a normative ideal. In doing so it confirms preexisting expectations about normative gendered behaviors such as the genderizing of employment. In the context of post-reform Vietnam, women's pursuit of paid employment is not constructed in opposition to raising a family. Even though they are socialized to identify with future motherhood (Pettus 2003; Werner 2009), most women in Vietnam are economically active in line with state socialist expectations. Urban middle-class Vietnamese women are not faced with a choice between family and career. Rather, they face a choice between family and *which* career, since different tasks, jobs and employment sectors are valued differentially as appropriate for women or not. Research on Vietnam's expanding manufacturing sector has revealed pervasive notions of an inherent biologically determined feminine character (*tính nữ*) (and a corresponding masculine one) that shape Vietnamese perceptions about women's and men's abilities in different occupations and

employment sectors (Rydstrøm 2004; Tran 2004). For example, it is widely accepted that Vietnamese women's and men's positions are remunerated differentially, with women in general receiving lower wages than men—on average women earn about 85 percent of men's wages—and incomes are more irregular than those of men (Giang 2010). However, in Ho Chi Minh City's competitive labor market, the influence of organizations in women's employment prospects is evident. Different employment sectors offer women different benefits, with the foreign-invested sector offering the most attractive employment opportunities to young women and the possibility to earn higher salaries than men, albeit in different roles (Earl 2014b).

Hạnh, the older sister, commenced working in the foreign sector, but she had given up the demanding and tedious job for a more interesting one. Her experience moving between positions, referred to in Ho Chi Minh City as “switching,” taught her that temporary and short-term contract positions in private companies were far easier to secure and more beneficial in building a career than settling into a permanent job. Small private companies offer more robust opportunities for social mobility with more challenging work, greater opportunities for networking, and a relatively more secure income.

It is not simply individual choice, but choices, made in the influence of social structures, that shape the career pathways of urban middle-class women. Firstly, like Tuyết, Hạnh opted to move out of unstable employment in the foreign sector to a less stressful but more secure job in a small private company. This choice was influenced by the organizations and the expectations and conditions of the contrasting employment sectors. Middle-class youth in urban Vietnam may opt out of a high-pressure and competitive environment for a less demanding position in the private sector, or a more autonomous role in entrepreneurship (Turner and An Nguyen 2005). Adkins (2001) observes a connection between the feminization of workplaces and emerging

middle classes, noting that more flexible gender codes are evident among urban middle classes. With Vietnam's foreign sector being female-dominated (General Statistical Office 2011), it potentially offers educated young women a greater spectrum of freedoms and opportunities to reconfigure gender subjectivities beyond a stronger normative influence of the state sphere. However, the choices the sisters make suggest they prefer to retreat to other employment sectors where they are able to conform to conventional gendered expectations.

Secondly, Hạnh later opted to move out of the paid workforce and into home duties after her marriage. Her choices to retreat from the workforce were also influenced by social institutions. The choices she made were not socially stigmatized (Goffman 1963), reflecting that her retreat from the workforce was deemed "right" or appropriate in the eyes of those around her, in part because her occupation as a homemaker enhanced her husband's relative social status as a wealthy middle-class breadwinner who could independently support a household. Hạnh's circumstances are relatively rare and contrast with the widely circulated negative stereotyping of middle-class housewives, generated in part by social institutions seeking to promote socialist gender equality discourses (Pettus 2003). Hạnh, thus, is also transforming normative gender roles ascribed to women.

After her own marriage, Cúc retreated from seeking work in the foreign sector to focus on employment in the state sector, where the salary was relatively low but the working conditions were excellent in terms of balancing family life and child care. Working in a state company provided a permanent position with guaranteed conditions, including medical checks and maternity leave. Her family-oriented interests aligned with those of her colleagues; the other women in her office were also young mothers. Like Tuyét, Cúc's choice to retreat from the foreign sector aligned with the influences of normative social institutions of family and mass media in paying

attention to the needs of others before the individual self. But, unlike Tuyét and Hạnh, Cúc was not attempting to challenge normative femininity. These women's contrasting choices, following Grosz (2011), can be understood as a spectrum of freedoms, with respect to the influence of social structures, such as family, workplace and the mass media, on their individual capacities to make choices. In Vietnam, Marr (2000) contends that concepts of individuality have been present in urban middle-class lives under globalizing influences dating from at least the late colonial era in the early twentieth century. Urban middle-class women in contemporary Vietnam may appear to be relatively autonomous, in part as a result of the reservoirs of cultural, social, and economic capital they accrue-, and Neoliberal discourses centered on individuality do not fully explain the complex puzzle of their new social power, since the choices they make appear to remain oriented to the varying needs of their family.

TRANSNATIONAL MARRIAGE AND A WOMAN'S CHOICE TO RETREAT FROM NORMATIVE CULTURAL EXPECTATIONS

Sisters Chi and Yến arrived in Ho Chi Minh City with their natal family in the late 1980s. Their widowed mother, a petty trader originally from central Vietnam, had brought her four daughters and one son south in the hope of providing a better life for them in the city. Both Chi and Yến had failed marriages, and to combat experiences of social stigma as "single" women (*phụ nữ đơn thân*) (Lê 2008), had returned to live in their widowed mother's house. The opportunity presented in the post-reform era to move abroad with new husbands and retreat from the sphere of Vietnamese cultural influence, freed them from the normative expectations of patriarchal kinship conventionally leveled on women.

Beyond the education system and workplace, Vietnamese women's lives are influenced by messages from other "socially structuring" organizations, particularly the Vietnam Women Union (VWU). The largest mass organization in Vietnam, the VWU plays an official dual role in representing the collective interest of women, and channeling their wishes, needs, and concerns to the Party's decision-making level, as well as disseminating official information (state propaganda) and relevant state policies to them (Hakkarainen 2015). Its messages center on an idealized normative womanhood, one that contrasts with the actual lives of many Vietnamese women, including sisters Y  n and Chi who, due to their single status, do not match the idealized model of wife-mother represented by the VWU.

For the Vietnamese, marriage is an integral part of a model life. Most young people in Vietnam marry, as Y  n and Chi had done. Their marriages symbolized a shift from childhood to adulthood, and a move to a household independent of a woman's natal family. However, for Y  n, as her husband had been a labor migrant and his work commitments took him outside the city, she did not share a household with him, and instead remained in her mother's house after her marriage. The husband visited his family regularly for several years, but he eventually abandoned his wife and their two children, leaving Y  n with the stigmatized social status in peacetime Vietnam of a single woman and sole parent.

Despite her stigmatized position as that of a single woman portrayed by Vietnamese state discourses as vulnerable, and as a victim of "misfortune" and limited socio-economic capacity (L   2008), Y  n expressed no interest in marrying again, even though her children had no father or grandfather. In considering the choices of single women in Vietnam, it is helpful to conceptualize agency and choice as Grosz (2011) does, not as bifurcated between choice and choiceless, but in terms of a spectrum of degrees of freedom

that take into account various intersections in enabling and constraining choices. Y  n made her choices in the sphere of influence of the social institutions of family, mass media, and state mass organizations, particularly the VWU.

Like Y  n, the younger sister Chi had also been married previously, and also had returned to her widowed mother's house. While divorce continues to attract some social stigma in urban Vietnam, having chosen to divorce a violent husband, Chi did not experience the same degree of stigma as her sister, who had been abandoned by a hard-working man. Chi had recently drawn on transnational kin networks to arrange a second marriage and reinstate a normative status for an adult woman as a wife (and potentially as a mother). As a socially constructed notion, stigma varies with values placed on behavior and practices in a particularized context. In Vietnam, stigma is a significant issue, as honor and shame are important dimensions in Vietnamese social relations (Ph  m 1999). Being a single woman may be stigmatizing in Vietnam today, but marrying outside one's social and cultural status position can also be controversial.

Chi had chosen to marry a foreign man. Choosing a much older or a significantly wealthier husband, or one who does not share a similar sociocultural upbringing, such as Chi's new husband, or one who is much younger or significantly poorer, is considered by Vietnamese to risk marital disharmony, and can also attract social stigma. Through her marriage to an older widower, Chi was able to overcome the stigma she had experienced as a divorced and childless woman, achieve a new social status as a legitimate wife and, in time, as a foreign citizen. Yet, the choice to marry a foreigner was not simply an individual choice. Chi's marriage required the approval of the state and the consent of her family members. Moreover, as the couple intended to leave Vietnam and live abroad, agreement and co-operation was required, and these parties were called upon to participate in completing the lengthy and onerous series of interviews and character

assessments that comprised the application process, involving authorities as well as members of the whole family.

The transformation of Chi's status via a transnational marriage led Yến to re-evaluate her own future and that of her children, who had experienced social exclusion and economic disadvantage stemming from their mother's stigmatized single status. Drawing on the same kin network as her sister had, and the encouragement and support of their family, Yến consented to marrying a foreign man, more than 20 years her senior, to work as his housekeeper, cook, and personal care attendant, in exchange for her new nationality status, and school and university education for her children. With degrees, their future employment prospects would be improved. Additionally, Yến's teenage daughter would be freed from the patriarchal gender expectations of the Vietnamese sphere of cultural influence and its socially structuring institutions. Yến herself would have an alternative experience to the stigmatized gender status as an abandoned wife.

Yến's choices demonstrate that she is neither ignorant nor naïve, contrasting sharply with Vietnamese state mass media portrayals of transnational brides (Bélanger et al. 2013). In making these "right" choices to sacrifice her own desires to foster the future prospects of her children, Yến was conforming to Vietnamese gender norms about the role of a wife-mother centered on the domestic context and caring for others. Yến's transnational move was a retreat not only from the sphere of Vietnamese cultural influence, but also from the paid workforce, where she had worked as a cook in a private restaurant, to the unpaid workforce, where she would work as an unpaid carer and housekeeper as a married woman. This reflects a comparable retreat to the one Hạnh had also made. Like Tuyết and Hạnh, Chi and Yến were also transforming gender identities by reshaping what it means to be a sacrificing wife and mother in post-reform Vietnam.

CONCLUSION

The experiences of the sisters illustrate that femininity in contemporary Vietnam is a complex puzzle, influenced by individual desires as well as social institutions in the context of post-reform development, globalization, and social change. Some recent research asserts that the post-reform era in Vietnam offers urban middle-class women new ways of being that liberates them from disciplinary regimes associated with Vietnamese patriarchal cultural traditions (Bui 2010). Nevertheless, there remains a wide circulation of disciplinary regimes promoted as traditional Vietnamese womanhood, with which women may be expected to conform, in terms of their housekeeping skills (*công*), their physical beauty for their husbands and not other men (*dung*), their humble, submissive, and polite conduct (*ngôn*), and their faithful, obedient, and subservient behavior (*hạnh*). Conventionally, this set of regimes was codified as the Four Virtues (*tứ đức*) and this neo-Confucian code has variously operated as a measure of normative elite and middle-class femininity in Vietnam (Marr 1981; Ngô 2004; Rydstrom 2010).

In recent history, as part of an ongoing morality campaign earlier in the post-reform era, the VWU used the state women's mass media to target urban women with a reassertion of a conventional femininity. In the contemporary context, Vietnamese women do not face a choice between family and paid employment. Rather, they face a choice between family and *which* career. An expectation that women are also needed in the workplace underpins notions of femininity in Vietnam and illustrates the overlapping and competing ideas about gender normalization that circulate there. Interestingly, the reasserted virtues recommend that a woman should maintain her physical beauty not for the gaze of a man, but for her own pleasure and confidence. She should maintain her moral integrity in order to raise her children well, which might be aligned with a liberal feminist ideal, and one identified by

Bourdieu (1976) as a traditional marriage strategy to ensure upward social mobility through social reproduction. A woman should develop and refine her household skills, not meaning she should learn cooking and embroidery, but rather she should learn how to manage household staff (a cook, a cleaner, a driver, a nanny), and decorate a renovated suburban villa, as Tuyét appears to have done. She should conduct herself in a polite, conservative, and respectable manner. This reflects her accrual and display of an underlying reservoir of highly valued cultural capital that can be exercised to ensure social reproduction, not social change (Bourdieu 1984). It is important to note these ideas are entangled with a diverse range of feminist and anti-feminist discourses, including the influence of neo-Confucian patriarchy from which Vietnamese women are understood to be not liberated, even though the extent to which it influences their daily lives is disputed (Hakkarainen 2018). The influence of state discourses on women's choices cannot be overlooked, as the family, school, workplace, state mass media, and state mass organizations offer strongly normative ideals that remain pervasive in the socialization of Vietnamese young people.

This chapter set out to explore how women in Vietnam make choices in the context of globalization, development, and social change. It is particularly centered on how urban middle-class Vietnamese women choose to accept and embody normative social roles in the phenomenal experiences of their daily lives, and how and why they make choices to retreat from the influences of social structures and normative socialization processes. Despite an observable layering of discourses, including those oriented on femininity in post-reform Vietnamese social life, new ways of being do not necessarily liberate women from normative disciplinary regimes associated with patriarchy. Rather, it can be the opposite: new ways of being in post-reform urban Vietnam may be more conservative and retreat further into patriarchal disciplinary regimes. These may

become invisible and buried in a grammar of individualism entangled with neoliberal discourses of choice and agency. For educated career women, who juggle the expectations of family and the workplace, as socially structuring institutions, the demands placed on them may be very great. A range of constraints influence the choices made about marriage and career by urban middle-class women. In exercising choice—understood as a spectrum of freedoms that oscillates from choice to choiceless (Grosz 2011)—urban middle-class Vietnamese women are empowered to opt out of the spheres of influence of social institutions and retreat, temporarily or permanently, from the paid workforce to the family home, from a narrowly defined normative family structure to a more flexible concept of family. In doing so they may move from the metropolitan center to a provincial city or even abroad. Choices for urban middle-class Vietnamese women are made in the context of the pervasive influences of social institutions that shape processes of normative socialization, thus, are not simply individual choices shaped by individual desires.

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Chapter eighteen

Entrepreneurial Women in Lao People's Democratic Republic

Nittana Southiseng and John Walsh

INTRODUCTION

Lao PDR (Laos) is located within the Greater Mekong Subregion (GMS) as part of mainland Southeast Asia. With a population slightly greater than 7 million as of 2017, Lao PDR is a landlocked country, which makes all forms of economic development more expensive than for its neighbors, who can ship goods through their own ports. Principal economic activities include selling hydroelectricity to neighboring Thailand from the many dams and extraction of its mineral resources, principally through overseas investment. The success of the mineral extraction sector has led to a form of Dutch disease in the economy (Insisienmay et al. 2015), by which success in one sector produces inflation in other sectors which have not grown, and which suffer, therefore, from stagflation.

Nevertheless, development is being achieved through the building of transportation infrastructure such as the Asian Highway Network led by the Asian Development Bank, which will help to convert the country into an important network node. Already, improved links with Thailand mean that, particularly during weekends and holidays, cities such as Nong Khai and Udon Thani in the northeast of that country witness numerous Lao families and social groups traveling

for leisure, retail, and health purposes. Furthermore, it is quite common for middle-class women in the capital of Vientiane to cross the border in order to give birth, owing to the superior facilities available in Thailand. Similarly, patients seek better treatment in Thailand for heart disease, cancer, and other conditions for which only general facilities are available in Lao PDR.

The economy is also developing Special Economic Zones (SEZs), which have been opened and promoted by the government to host domestic investment and foreign direct investment (FDI) as the country has begun its trajectory along the Factory Asia paradigm of export-oriented, import-substituting intensive manufacturing based on low labor cost competitiveness (Khatthiya 2011; Pongkhao 2017, 2018). These actions draw people from the agricultural sector into the industrial sector in the early part of the trajectory when demand for labor outstrips existing supply. In particular, such zones provide opportunities (or create threats) to women to exchange their role of unpaid providers of domestic and emotional labor for that of waged employees with more agency over their lives and their personal relationships and social relations more generally (Aggarwal 2007; Hui 1996). A similar path was previously taken in Thailand, and the concentration on market relations and growth maximization there led to a generation of un-empowered women

working in often dangerous and unhealthy conditions where workplace relations could be problematic. There is a need, therefore, for the Lao government to take steps to ensure that women, and indeed all workers, have the chance to gain skills and knowledge that will make them employable above and beyond being minimum wage factory hands (Hesse-Swain 1998; United Nations 2015).

The Lao government is keen to promote the SEZ approach to rapid economic development, not just because seemingly all Asian states are taking this approach but because the example of China provides evidence to authoritarian countries that a market-based economic system may be embraced without the necessity of yielding to political plurality. The Pathet Lao government is not willing to cede the national unity and sovereignty achieved by the Communist revolution of 1975. This revolution marked the first time that a unified, independent country existed in its current form. Lao history is marked by the conflicts between competing city-states (*muang*), and endemic warfare aimed at capturing slaves for forced relocation to expand the production base of *muang* kings in a chronically underpopulated region. The French colonization of Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam led to the creation of a transnational colonial region ruled from Vietnam. Vientiane, which at that time had been completely abandoned, was rebuilt as a colonial administrative center and this explains the Haussmannesque boulevards and avenues that characterize the architecture of the city (Askew et al. 2007). Only with independence could the Lao government declare its principles of equality for all in a modern nation-state. Equality referred not just to the now abolished class structure and gender but also to the complex nature of ethnic relations in the country. Numerous ethnic groups live in the country and are often broadly divided between the Lao of the lowlands, who have been politically and economically privileged, and the Lao of the uplands. This division hides a plethora of individual cultural practices and traditions

that are of great importance in defining the identity of different groups. In some cases, particularly for swidden agricultural groups who may speak a language not belonging to the Tai-Kadai group that includes Lao, their relationship to the state is more similar to what Scott (2009) considers to be the advantage of not being governed.

The Lao government has sought an inclusive approach to governance that does not recognize these differences as being essential in nature, although a sanitized form of diversity is occasionally celebrated when it appears advantageous to acknowledge this. Article 1 of the Constitution of Lao PDR states: “The Lao People’s Democratic Republic is an independent and sovereign country with territorial integrity covering both territorial waters and airspace. It is a unified and indivisible country belonging to all ethnic groups.” Article 3, meanwhile, reinforces the unity of all ethnic groups: “The right of the multi-ethnic people to be the masters of the country is exercised and ensured through the functioning of the political system, with the Lao People’s Revolutionary Party as its leading nucleus” (Lao PDR National Assembly 1991).

That there is a need to recognize the equality of women with men in the new political settlement has also been made explicit: “Lao women have historically lived in a state of under-development and gender inequality, due largely to differences in geography, ethnicity, traditions and customs. They have generally been perceived as the ‘weaker’ members of society, and have been subordinated by men for centuries” (NPCFWCW 1995). To address this acknowledged intersectionality, the Lao Women’s Union was established (among other institutions), which will help to complete the emancipation of women, which is still hampered by “. . . the lingering influence of the former regime, backward traditions, and poverty” (NPCFWCW 1995). According to state policy and ideology, then, the right of the individual to freedom from oppression supersedes the right of ethnic groups to pursue practices which are thought to contradict this freedom. Yet, in practical terms, people

have not been treated equally when, as with the case of relocations following the beginning of a dam construction project, communities of people are moved to alternative locations (Dalasavong et al. 2015). Further, as market-based relations are increasingly introduced to the country, these initial inequalities would be expected to increase. In some cases, remittances, migrations, and returns have been able to mitigate some inequalities by providing new resources to local communities (Southiseng and Walsh 2011a). However, Lao women still suffer from inequitable access to education, are overwhelmingly tied to subsistence agricultural activities in rural areas linked by poor infrastructure, and their income-generating opportunities are limited to the informal sector. While discrimination against Lao women is not the worst in the region, levels of knowledge about laws and persistent cultural values mean that women's roles are widely undervalued (GRID 2005).

In this chapter, we explore the situation of women in contemporary Lao PDR with a particular emphasis on entrepreneurial economic activities. First, we focus on the roles of entrepreneurial Lao women in the context of a dynamic and changing environment. It is important to understand why change is taking place as well as the effects of that change. We then consider the prospects for women in the formal sector and the interactions between formality and informality, and we conclude with a discussion of policy and institutional change that will be required to bring about equitable change in this regard.

In our discussion of entrepreneurs, we employ a broad definition. Kao's (1993) definition is a useful beginning: "... entrepreneurship is the process of doing something new and something different for the purpose of creating wealth for the individual and adding value to society." In this case, the meaning of "new" is not absolute but relates to the immediate environment: selling vegetables or loose cigarettes by the side of the road is not new in itself but it is different if there is no one else nearby doing the same thing. Even

if there are other vendors, in this case it is considered an entrepreneurial alternative to the formal sector of retailing.

ENTREPRENEURIAL LAO WOMEN

Lao PDR, in common with other GMS countries, can still be vulnerable to food insecurity in both urban and rural settings (Walsh 2016). One means by which communities have historically sought to avoid such insecurity in subsistence agricultural households is to employ entrepreneurial techniques, perhaps based on household craft production. For example, Lao women have traditionally spun household clothing using silk looms from local production. This is an arduous and time-consuming process and it is not difficult to imagine some items changing hands in barter trade if cash is not immediately available. When external organizations attempt to work with local communities to identify potential income-generating activities, they often start with household-based activities of this type, especially when women (who are mainly involved) can be gathered together to enhance opportunities for fostering networks and solidarity, as well as information transfer processes. The common taboos about women's freedom to move and act in the Lao PDR exist as they do in many countries but there are opportunities for women to participate in market activities, even in those activities where it might be expected that men will be predominant (United Nations Women 2016; Walker 1999).

There are many opportunities for small-scale entrepreneurial activities in which women are involved. Before the opening of the Second Friendship Bridge across the River Mekong linking Savannakhet in Lao PDR with Mukdahan in Thailand, a group of Lao women would cross the river by ferry to buy goods on the Thai side which they would bring back with them, mark them up and then sell them in evening markets on the

Lao side. After the bridge opened, this trade became dominated by (mostly) men driving pick-up trucks across the bridge and using economies of scale to obtain better arbitrage opportunities than the women were able to do. Now, the men employ the market vending women as full-time retailers (Gomez et al. 2011).

Not all stories have negative outcomes. Other research (e.g., Kusakabe 2004) has found that, in part depending on the relationships that the women involved can establish with important stakeholders, they can benefit from the liberalization of regulations affecting cross-border activities and use their entrepreneurial skills to gain money and agency over their lives, at least to some extent. Previous research (Southiseng and Walsh 2011a) identified the connection that some women were able to make between capital acquisition (i.e. through remittances) and entrepreneurial activities. One woman from our research stated:

I am now a member of the sales team that sells exercise outfits for a company in Thailand. I often spend some of the remittance for my transportation, such as paying for petrol, paying for the bus or air ticket and taxi in order to go to attend a meeting and meet customers in other areas.

Another woman stated:

I used the money to build rooms on my land for renting to others. The remittance is not just money, but it is very valuable to me and my family because it comes from my daughter's effort. She works hard there and spends her life in an unfamiliar environment and culture. So, before spending it, I need to consider carefully. So, I firstly try to save and eventually I can build the room for rent.

It is evident that agency and social relations have changed as a result.

In general, cross-border trade in the GMS is increasing, including those border posts involving Lao PDR. In part, this is because of improving transportation infrastructure in the region and

the general progress made in trade facilitation processes in each country. The trade and the opportunities that it provides might also increase as a result of the current Thai regime's approach to border SEZs, which presently rests on the provision of an industrial estate with attached duty-free market areas. There is a tradition that cross-border markets flourish in all parts of the GMS and many are gender-based depending on the products involved. For example, the jade markets on the Myanmar-China border are dominated by men. Women in these cases are restricted to subservient positions and the entertainment sector.

These entrepreneurial activities for women are nearly always limited in scope and scale. There is very little chance that working on an own-account basis will one day lead to building a Small or Medium-sized Enterprise (SME). Lao PDR suffers from the missing middle phenomenon when it comes to the SME sector, although it remains true that this sector is vital to the future growth of the economy. The lack of access to capital, skills and markets all contribute to the difficulties that women, as small entrepreneurs, face in Lao PDR and in other developing economies. There have been some attempts to help create clusters of complementary activities in products in which Lao PDR might demonstrate some competitive advantages and there has been some limited success in this regard (e.g., Southiseng et al. 2016). However, these ventures tend to succeed only where genuine and persistent demand for the products exists or can be fostered. A previous study (Southiseng et al. 2008) revealed that most women entrepreneurs lack knowledge of market conditions and lack relevant skills, and that they would benefit from continuous and lifelong learning, which would, in turn, necessitate external support. It was also found that, at least for urban-based entrepreneurs, joining the Lao Business Women's Association (LBWA) might prove beneficial in terms of self-education, sharing knowledge of market conditions, and developing new resources collectively. This continues to be the case and there

remains the need to provide business development support services for women throughout the country. The LBWA, for example, is ostensibly open to all female entrepreneurs, 18 years of age and older, who submit their application and abide by association policies. However, this leads to a self-selecting, urban membership and is not a mass membership association. The Lao PDR Women's Union is a mass movement organization but focuses on political engagement, household security, and preservation of cultural values. It has very little capacity in the area of business development otherwise.

WOMEN ENTREPRENEURS AND THE SPECIAL ECONOMIC ZONE ECONOMY

The Lao government has announced that ten SEZs and additional specific economic zones have been opened or will be opened in due course. The SEZ concept is quite different from that of industrial estates, which were precursors to the new form. The new concept focuses on a time and space-limited area of territory in which certain laws are relaxed to privilege capital above labor. To encourage FDI further, the state or its private sector partner undertake to provide basic infrastructure and stable services such as electricity, water, waste management, and telecommunications. In some cases, a local agency handles recruitment of labor and any workplace issues. Although industrial facilities are expected to feature heavily within the SEZs, it is also possible to build accommodation and leisure facilities, hotels and tourism resorts, golf courses, and schools. These might be intended for the use of managers and employees engaged in working in the SEZ or they might exist to encourage tourism. As one example, the Boten Golden Land SEZ was opened in 2003 as a casino tourism complex, attracting visitors from across the border in China,

who were exempted from visa formalities for this case. However, after a series of scandals, including murder, the zone was closed and became virtually deserted, before more recently being reinvented along more conventional commercial lines.

The value of SEZs to a local economy lies in the direct effects of job creation and financial investment and the hoped-for indirect effects of technology transfer and industrial deepening. This last phenomenon means the connections between the investing companies and local companies, usually in the SME sector, who can enter into value chains and, thereby, have the chance to increase their capabilities and skills as a result. In general, it has proved more difficult than expected to bring about this kind of "backward linkage" effectively. Once the SEZs have reached a suitable level of maturity, the opportunities for entrepreneurial women include the following:

- At the simplest level, women entrepreneurs can provide basic services like freshly cooked meals and basic household goods, as already is the case at factory gates;
- At a slightly higher level, entrepreneurs can form all or part of the chain connecting manufacturing and domestic consumption of consumer goods. Although most manufacturing is intended to lead to exports, FDI can be a more attractive proposition if this is supplemented by local sales to provide immediate cash-flow. Making the connection between factory gate and suitable local retailers is a distinct opportunity for an intermediary. For example, the fertile soil of the Bolaven Plateau offers good opportunities for coffee growing and processing. That coffee is not yet made widely available in local value-adding coffee shops;
- When overseas companies invest in a SEZs in significant numbers from the same source (e.g., from Japan or South Korea), there are opportunities for local entrepreneurs to provide services catering to that incoming community (e.g., Japanese or South Korean restaurants and other culture-specific goods and services).

However, it is likely that, at least for the immediate future, most female Lao entrepreneurs will be relegated to the lower levels of economic activity because they lack the necessary capital, skills, and networking.

WOMEN ENTREPRENEURS AND MIGRATION

Within the definition of entrepreneurialism provided previously, it is evident that any act of migration (whether within country or cross-border) for the purposes of work can be considered to be entrepreneurial. Women can travel to take up work elsewhere or they may be required to take on more responsibilities if other household members migrate. Owing to the close cultural, linguistic and historical relationships between people on either side of the border, cross-border movement has been common throughout history. The lengthy border is difficult to police and it is convenient for people to use their own boats to cross the Mekong informally, when that forms the border. Indeed, the closeness of the relationship and the untidy nature of history mean that considering the border to mark a division between two distinct sets of people would be simplistic and inaccurate.

Although Lao PDR has borders with China, Vietnam, and Cambodia, it is the border with Thailand that is overwhelmingly important in terms of labor migration. That level of migration has increased further in recent years for various reasons:

- Improved transportation infrastructure and the opening of new branches across the River Mekong have made travel more convenient and it has become much easier for Lao women to cross repeatedly in response to different opportunities;
- High levels of penetration of mobile telecommunications and internet usage make it much easier for women to keep in contact with their

family members, including their children and thus working away from home is less daunting to those for whom this would be a constraint;

- International banks have begun to open branches in Vientiane and the improvement in the banking system that this indicates has made remittances and money transfers more convenient;
- As Thailand's income levels increase, there is a parallel increase in the demand for domestic labor. Lao women are viewed as popular solutions to this demand because of their language compatibility, wage expectations and, in some cases, the perception (misguided though it is) that Lao women will be timid, deferential, and unwilling to cause trouble or stand up for their rights. This is an aspect of the global chain of care (Hochschild 2000) that has in part been responsible for the significant increases in the number of women working internationally and the number and type of jobs in which they might find work;
- A recent new step in the ASEAN Economic Community (AEC) dictates that skilled workers in a small number of categories of professional work are free to move anywhere within the ten nations of Southeast Asia and to work without hindrance. To date, these new provisions have not been utilized very widely because of difficulties in reaching agreements on qualifications on a bilateral basis and, in the case of Lao PDR, because there are only limited numbers of people with professional qualifications that are recognized internationally.

The work that Lao women can take up in Thailand is controlled by regulations, and these are more stringently maintained by the current military regime. However, these are regulations that are in conflict with demand and supply conditions for labor and are widely considered to be optional. Of course, having to live outside the law makes migrant women vulnerable to harassment by officials and makes it more difficult for them to receive their full wages and obtain

decent working conditions. There have also been periodic outbursts of orchestrated nationalism on both sides of the border, which convince many workers to return home for at least a period of time. New announcements of labor market regulations made by the Thai junta, which often have not received sufficient thought and consultation beforehand, can also cause panic. Yet, it is also possible for Lao women, who are accompanying their husbands, to undertake the same type of work that some Thai women do under similar circumstances. For example, they may engage in market vending on a mobile or sedentary basis or work in a restaurant or as a hairdresser.

When women return from overseas employment, it can be difficult for them to return to their previously limited social position, especially if they have become accustomed to autonomy or agency over their actions. Having worked once overseas, it is more likely that such women will consider returning or, in the future, might work in SEZs.

FOSTERING ENTREPRENEURIALISM IN LAO PDR

There are some constants in small business development that are consistently found in nearly every country of the world. Among these are the difficulties that small business owners face by dint of lack of time, lack of capital, and lack of understanding of market access. Providing support in these areas will necessarily help all entrepreneurs, including Lao women. However, there are some areas that are particularly suited to Lao PDR, and these include the following:

- The connection between the agricultural sector and the retail sector is constricted. Some products have become available in international markets through the efforts of specific companies (e.g., ground coffee and products based on inca inchi nuts). However, there is

still scope for more agricultural and forest goods to be marketed. White charcoal (*binto-chan*) is exported to Japan and South Korea for use in barbecue restaurants, but this is a result of entrepreneurs from Korea organizing the trade with local producers (Southiseng et al. 2016). There is certainly a role for private sector actors (Lao or overseas) to help raise the quality and consistency of local products so that they can be placed in retail outlets (and a more open and receptive attitude from the government toward foreign retailers would also help):

- Some Lao farmers have de facto advantages in organic agriculture, and demand for this is developing locally, as demonstrated by the regular organic products market now opening in Vientiane. However, there is no mechanism for becoming registered as a bona fide organic producer in Lao PDR and, instead, producers must use the Thai facility, and this can cost up to US\$5,000 (Southiseng et al. 2016). Clearly, therefore, introducing such a mechanism to the country would be beneficial;
- Many local production groups rely on a cooperative style of organization and management, which can be positive. Yet, negative interpersonal relations within the work group context can derail the whole enterprise (Southiseng et al. 2016). Providing a means of helping entrepreneurs to develop their own interpersonal skills would reduce the likelihood of interpersonal problems occurring and, therefore, increase prospects for success.

A study of the tourism sector in the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Luang Prabang (Southiseng and Walsh 2011b) found that while some entrepreneurs wanted to integrate all aspects of a particular product offering within a single agency, in other cases a hub-and-spoke model was adopted by which combinations of services would be put together in unique configurations according to what was required at the time. For example, transportation services, guides, and

access to various destinations could be managed for individual groups of tourists. This coordinating role might initially be played by someone supported by the public sector so as to help the smaller, less experienced service providers to gain confidence in what they were doing and knowledge about how to do it. In due course, it will be possible for the original coordinating mechanism to be withdrawn and allow it to be replaced by market solutions.

CONCLUSION

Lao women are entrepreneurial to some extent by choice but also because of necessity. A poor country with comparatively low density of population has meant that communities have had to develop means of self-sufficiency. Overlaying this is now a government system which has not prioritized the provision of consumer goods to the people of the country. As a result, at least in some cases, women have taken the initiative to meet personal preferences and to meet the needs of their families through their entrepreneurial activities. It would be helpful to explore how this takes place in different parts of the country, since one of the limitations of the research reported here is that the geographical focus is not as broad as might be desired.

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Chapter nineteen

Persisting Inequality, Rural Transformation, and Gender Relations in the Northeast of Thailand

Buapun Promphakping

INTRODUCTION

The economic growth of Thailand during the past four decades has resulted in improvements in many areas such as infrastructure, education, and health, and consequently this has led to improved living conditions for the population as a whole. However, these improvements have gone hand-in-hand with persistent inequalities, particularly as they relate to the widening inequality in the distribution of wealth and resources. Historically, it has been argued that the economic transformation of Thailand is actually an instrument to remove a surplus of economic resources from the agricultural sector of the Northeast in order to fund the economic growth of Bangkok, or the modern sector (Bell 1969). The resulting regional economic inequality between the Northeast of Thailand and the wealthier modern sector including Bangkok has persisted over time (Phongpaichit et al. 2009).

The relationship between inequality and gender has not been a central issue of study by academics or policy makers. This is partly due to the dominant perception that Thai women continue to hold equal status with their male

counterparts, when compared with the rest of Southeast Asia. This perception is based on various factors including high levels of education achieved by women, an increasing participation of women in the labor market, and women occupying high-level positions as business executives. However, this perception has been challenged by those who argue that the situation of Thai women actually does not differ significantly from women in other countries in the region and that they are subordinate to men as reflected in cultural notions prescribed by Buddhism, in the small percentage of women being elected to be Members of Parliament, and in the participation of some Thai women in the sex industry.

Therefore, in this chapter, I provide an analysis of gender relations in the context of the social and economic transformation of Thailand. Gender inequality in Thailand is not only the result of economic transformation, but it is embedded in the process of change. In the following, I review economic development with a focus on rural transformation in Thailand. I then sketch out social and economic inequalities, followed by examining gender relations in Thailand.

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT AND RURAL TRANSFORMATION

The Northeast region of Thailand is the largest region in terms of land size, representing about 33 percent of the total area of Thailand, but it also has been the poorest region of Thailand economically. Poverty in the Northeast is largely seen as a result of factors such as poor-quality land condition (low soil fertility and increasing salinity) and paucity of rainfall. Several hundred years ago, the population of this region was sparse, and Lao ethnic groups migrated and occupied parts of this region following conflict among the rulers of Vientiane, the present capital city of Lao PDR. During the Rattanakosin reign (from 1782 onward), the war between Siam and Laos resulted in a forced relocation of war captives, and a large number of people were sent to reside in the Northeast of Thailand. Today, the population of the Northeast is dominated by Lao ethnic groups.

It is commonly cited that the Bowring Treaty (signed in 1855 between the United Kingdom and Siam) marked the incorporation of the Thai economy into the global market because this treaty enlarged the avenues of trade. However, the incorporation of the Northeast region, specifically, into the global market came about considerably later. The Northeast was very distant from the main seaport of Bangkok, and at that time transportation within Thailand was difficult. Before 1900, the only means of transportation was by animal-powered transport that could cross over the mountain ranges of Khao Yai. However, this changed with the construction of a railroad in 1900 connecting Bangkok to Korat, the largest town of the Northeast, to Khon Kaen in 1933, and to Nong Khai, a border town with Lao PDR, in 1958.

The start of operations of the railway to the Northeast resulted in a significant spur in trade. This was coupled with the construction of the

Mittraphap (Friendship) Road, linking the Northeast with Bangkok, which was completed in 1958 and led to numerous feeder roads being developed. The road construction was initially for security purposes because Thailand was, at that time, faced with the growing threat of communism. However, these roads also provided access for farmers, scattered in remote areas, to the broader market. Before the 1960s, the population of the Northeast was basically self-contained and self-sufficient. The residents produced almost everything they needed, and they consumed all their production within their families. With the advent of the railways and roads, they started to produce some surplus rice to sell to the market, while most of the rice, their main staple food, continued to be for family consumption. Meanwhile the residents also diversified their crops to include cash crops such as kenaf, cassava, maize, and sugarcane. Indeed, after “modern development” was introduced into the Northeast, the livelihood of the people became more dependent on the market. Nevertheless, the extent of incorporation of the economy of this region into the wider or global economy remained comparatively lower than for the other regions of the country.

Thailand entered into the “modern development era” around the end of the 1950s. The development approach adopted by Thailand has been essentially centered on the promotion of growth by economic liberalism. The growth that concentrated in Bangkok, the capital city of Thailand, was supposed to “trickle down” to the rural areas. During the early stages of the National Development Plan that began in 1960, the focus was on building economic infrastructure and promoting import substitution industries. Since the mid-1980s, the focus has shifted to become export-oriented, and at present, the economy of Thailand continues to be dependent on exports.

The export-oriented economic growth of Thailand during the mid-1980s and 1990s generated an impressive rate of economic growth, and

the development model was considered as a “miracle” (Jansen 2001). Thailand was about to join the organization of Newly Industrialized Countries (NICs). However, in the second part of the 1990s, Thailand confronted a bubble economy, leading it into an economic crisis in 1997 (Bello et al. 1998). Nevertheless, Thailand quickly managed to resume building economic growth, with populist policies put into action by the Thaksin government when he began his first term as Prime Minister of Thailand in 2001. Along with the economic growth, the rate of urbanization of Thailand had been considerably lower, when compared with other countries in the region. Fifty years ago, over 85 percent of the country’s population lived in rural areas. According to current statistics, the rural population now constitutes about 50 percent of the population (Mahidol University 2017). Yet, despite the significant increase in the urban population, the rate of urbanization in Thailand still lags behind that of Malaysia, the Philippines, and Indonesia.

Although, traditionally, agriculture has been the main source of livelihood for the rural people in Thailand, their sources of income have become greatly diversified. Thai government statistics indicate that Thailand, with an overall population of over 68 million, has almost 6 million farm households and almost 20 million household members, with an average of about 3.3 members per farm household (National Statistical Office 2014). Further, farms are relatively small, averaging about 18 rai or about 7 acres (Department of Agricultural Extension 2016). The small size of their farmland leads to low incomes for the farmers, and thus poverty in Thailand is heavily concentrated in rural areas, as the modern economic sectors generally are more lucrative than agricultural or rural sectors.

Since the 1960s, when Thailand first introduced its National Development Plan, the industrial GDP has risen steadily. From the 1990s to the present, the agricultural GDP has

maintained at about 9 to 10 percent, however with an increasing trend. The actual value of agricultural production in terms of GDP increased more impressively, from 200,000 million baht in 1990 to 1,200,000 million baht in 2012. If the values of the industries and services connected with agriculture (i.e., the agro-industries that use agricultural products as raw materials) are taken into account, the level of agricultural GDP would rise to 22 percent in 2012 (NESDB 2017). Thus, although the share of agriculture within the GDP is obviously lower than that of industry and services, the actual size of the agriculture sector continues to grow, i.e., more people working in agriculture, more land used in cultivation, and more agricultural outputs produced. *Yet, although the GDP contribution of agriculture is relatively low, the rural or agricultural sector obviously continues to play a significant role in providing employment for a larger number of people than any other economic sector.*

Rice farming has dominated agriculture in Thailand, as government statistics indicate that, during 2006 and 2014, rice farming accounted for 70 to 80 million rai (28 to 32 million acres) or about 46 percent of total agricultural land. During the past ten years, rice production has varied from 30 to 38 million tons, and a large portion of the rice has been exported. Normally, the level of rice export varies between 6 to 10 million tons (Paupongsakorn et al. 2013). Given the small size of their landholding and the variations in market prices, coupled with uncontrollable rainfall, rice farmers in Thailand sustain their living while being either on the brink of prosperity or on the brink of being destitute. One way of coping with this situation of uncertainty is to diversify their income sources, especially in the form of the non-agricultural sector. An official report from the Government of Thailand Office of Agricultural Economics shows that agricultural households are drawing larger parts of their incomes from the non-agricultural sector. For example, only 36 percent of the net income

of all Thai agricultural households actually comes from agriculture, while the remaining income comes from the non-farm sector. However, this figure varies greatly across the regions. In the South, for example, 51 percent of net household income is from agriculture, which is in stark contrast to the Northeast where only 22 percent of net household income is derived from agriculture (Office of Agricultural Economics 2014; Sopabhume and Simanoi 2016). The low incomes available from agriculture constitute the major factor in forcing agricultural households to diversify their income sources.

Changes in the socio-cultural aspects of rural Thailand, following the economic transformation described above, are also evident. In rural areas, the “village community” forms the foundation of the socio-cultural lives of the people. Within the village community are groups of kin, and the key socio-cultural aspects of the village community are structured around these kin relations. Over a hundred years ago, the government issued a law stipulating that the “head” of the village be appointed by the state. And during the period of modern development, the head of the village has played a key role in managing development, as well as in representing the state in its security oversight at the village level. However, the presence of the state, along with the modern development introduced into the village, has resulted in a weakening of the socio-cultural institutions of the village community. For example, the size of rural families has become smaller, with members of some families migrating to work outside the village for long periods of time. Further, previously, village elders were usually respected leaders of the village community, and thus, conflicts among members of the village were resolved by older members. However, at present, management of the village rests with the village “headman” who is elected by residents of the village but who must be endorsed and approved by the District Head, the official line of command under the Ministry of Interior.

THE FACE OF INEQUALITY

Labor Force Participation and Income

The participation of Thai women in the labor force has increased dramatically during the past decades. Indeed, the International Labor Organization has estimated that 63 percent of Thai females, aged 15 years and above, are participating in the labor force (World Bank 2016b). However, the high rate of participation by women in the labor force is largely due to female domination of labor in the export industries such as garments, electronics, and tourism. *In turn, this has meant that the high rate of economic growth in Thailand has been carried more on the shoulders of women than of men because it is these export industries that are mainly contributing to Thailand's economic growth.*

Furthermore, participation in the labor force has not directly translated into increases in incomes and decreases in the poverty level. As such, the most striking element of inequality in Thailand is inequality in income. In 1988, for example, the aggregated incomes of the lowest quartile income group amounted to only 5 percent of the total, and shares of income have remained essentially unchanged over the past several decades, with the lowest quartile income group earning only 4 percent in 2013, the latest year for which specific data are available. Meanwhile, particular segments of the Thai population continue to control a disproportionate portion of income. In 1988, the top quartile income group earned 54 percent of the total income of all groups (Center of Academic Services 2008), and this pattern has continued to persist. Clearly, the income gaps between the wealthy and the poor in Thailand have been, and continue to be, quite significant (World Bank 2017).

As I have noted previously, poverty in the Northeast is higher than in the other regions of the country. Government statistics indicate that, overall, 11 percent of the national population live

below the poverty line. However, regionally only 2 percent of the people who live in Bangkok live below the poverty line whereas the percentages below the poverty line are significantly higher in the regions. Specifically, 13 percent of the people who live in the North region, 14 percent in the South region, and 17 percent in the Northeast region live under the poverty line. In this regard, the inequality of incomes and resulting poverty are clearly reflected by the disparity between rural and urban. Such regional disparities are further indicated in 2015, when the average monthly household income in Bangkok was approximately twice that of households in the Northeast, where most of the population reside in rural areas (National Statistical Office 2016). Phrased differently, of all the poor in Thailand, more than 80 percent reside in rural regions (World Bank 2017), and over 70 percent of the poor reside in only two regions, the Northeast region and the North region (World Bank 2016a: 25–27).

Land Ownership

Apart from the income gap, an inequality in landholding is also evident as statistics show that 10 percent of land owners own over 60 percent of the land. Statistics further show that 889,022 farmers are landless, and 1.2 million farmers illegally occupy state land (National Statistical Office 2014, 2016). Some large land owners invest in land for price speculation, with the expectation that the value of the land will increase over time, and these lands are not put to use. Several attempts have been made over the years to pass a law for a progressive rate of land tax, in order to minimize inequality in land-holding, but all such attempts have failed.

Health

Disparities in government health services are also prominent. Specifically, government statistics

indicate that the overall ratio of physicians in Thailand is 1:3,305: that is, 1 physician for 3,305 Thai citizens. However, inequality in the distribution of the physicians across the regions is quite striking: Bangkok (1:897), Central, excluding Bangkok (1:3,234), North (1:4,534), South (1:3,982), and Northeast (1:7,466). The gap in dentists per head of population across regions is even more dramatic: Bangkok (1:5,583), Central excluding Bangkok (1:15,775), North (1:16,039), South (1:15,620), and Northeast (1:24,699) (NESDB 2017).

Previously, over 40 million Thais lacked any type of health security. However, in recent years, the government has attempted to narrow the gap by providing health insurance for those without health security. Specifically, in 2008, the Taksin government launched a Universal Coverage Scheme known as the 30-Baht Scheme, the scheme which is still in operation. Currently, there are three major types of health security; 48.12 million Thais are under the 30-Baht Scheme, 10.17 million are under social security, and 4.96 million are government servants. The 30-Baht Scheme has been praised by the Thai public and by the international community as a mechanism to provide health security, especially to the lower income group. Yet, questions remain as to whether such an extensive public health scheme is economically sustainable (National Health Security Office 2012; NESDB 2017).

Education

Another important element, though less evident, is inequality in education. Thai children have equal access to primary and secondary education provided by the government, at present up to 12 years of grade levels. However, the quality of education, especially between Bangkok, the urban centers, and rural areas is unbalanced. Inadequate education is especially problematic in rural areas where there are insufficient numbers of teachers and insufficient numbers

of experienced teachers, as well as a lack of appropriate teaching materials. Overall, almost 33 percent of Thai pupils, aged 15, are “functionally illiterate” and lack “reading skills beyond a basic level,” a problem that is especially prominent in rural areas (World Bank 2015). This is evident in the scores for National tests of Thai, English, mathematics, and science of the pupils in primary, lower secondary, and higher secondary schools. Specifically, scores for pupils in Bangkok were higher than those of pupils in other regions, in all subjects. Further, test scores of pupils in the Northeast region were the lowest, in almost all subjects (Office of the Education Council 2014: 180). Inequality in the quality of education has meant that although the youth have equal access to education, the youth of “up country” are less able to compete with the youth of Bangkok in pursuing higher education. They are, consequently, also less able to compete for higher-paying jobs due to their low performance in education.

From the discussion above, it is clear that such inequalities in Thailand are associated with economic aspects. Disparities among the regions are quite evident with the most extreme inequalities found in the Northeast compared to Bangkok, which is consistently at the top. This inequality is not recent as it has been clearly manifested since the 1970s. In this respect, inequality has become deeply permeated into various socio-cultural institutions within Thai society. In the next section, I focus on the impact of economic inequality on gender.

GENDER RELATIONS IN A RAPIDLY CHANGING THAILAND

In the past, gender equality was not considered to be an important issue and gender was rarely brought into view by scholars or policymakers in Thailand. In this light, the work of Bui and Permpoonwiwat (2015) is among the few studies focusing specifically on gender inequality. Their

research examines gender wage inequality in Thailand from a sectoral perspective and covers the period from 1996 to 2013. They found an impressive improvement in gender gaps. Specifically, whereas the earnings of men have been 15 percent higher than women, the earnings gap declined to 10 percent in 2006 and to only 1 percent in 2013. This finding seems to reinforce the perception mentioned previously that gender inequality in Thailand is not an important problem. But this report went further to disaggregate the gender differences by sector of production and found that wage inequality, between men and women, had increased even in some female-dominated industries. Thus, in 1996, the wage gaps were high in community and social services, and also in construction. In contrast, in 2013, the wage gaps were high in the hotel and restaurant industry and also in manufacturing, in which female laborers are dominant.

Focusing on the historical context, Bui and Permpoonwiwat’s (2015) findings are consonant with the formulation of Iawsriwong (1992) in that the analysis of gender in Thailand must recognize the different arrangement of gender relations between the *upper* and the *lower classes*. Historically, in Thailand, upper-class women were confined to the domestic sphere and their roles were limited, while the men were serving the king, the source of their rights and prestige. Women of the upper-class were, therefore, subordinated, and this arrangement has contributed to the persistence of inequality between men and women in Thai society. Conversely, lower-class women played a greater role. They took responsibility for all aspects of their households, when the men were conscripted and left their family to serve the king for a certain period of time every year.

Also, historically, the arrangements concerning gender relations in the regions considerably favored women. For instance, in the Northeast of Thailand, men would traditionally leave their families to reside with their wife’s family after their marriage. The parents’ land would typically

be passed down to the daughters. Men, as sons-in-law, were therefore under the control of their father-in-law and of their wife's clan. Women were well-protected under the community institutions that revolved around women's kin. For instance, verbal violation, either directly against a woman (wife) or her relatives, would result in the husband being subject to a fine, or in a serious case, the husband could be forced to leave his wife's family. Similar institutional arrangements of gender relations were also common in Northern Thailand, and elements of these arrangements have evolved to the present day. Nonetheless, given recent economic changes and as land has become more scarce, men in the Northeast region have increasingly claimed their right to inherit their own parents' land.

The end of the absolute monarchy and the advent of modern development have released women from the domestic sphere. Women of the upper-class have become educated, especially by attending universities or colleges. They have joined the modern economic sector, with a number of women having attained high positions while some have established and oversee their own businesses. Well-educated women of the upper-classes have entered into employment in government service and in universities, and they operate various businesses. However, this has not meant the end of women's subordination within the upper-class. *Indeed, the traditional ideology of gender relations in which men and women are perceived as unequal has further permeated and expanded as the upper-classes have been successful in maintaining and continuing their power and hegemony in Thai society.*

The arrangements and practices related to unequal gender relations within government agencies clearly illustrate the point mentioned above. In Thailand, government service has been an important source of prestige and privilege. The word *kahratchakarn* (government service) in Thai literally means "king's servant," this meaning reflecting that those serving the government are not accountable to the "public" but

rather to the "nation," which effectively describes the top leaders within government service. At present, there are about 2.19 million civil servants, 1.27 million of whom are government servants (Office of Civil Service 2015). The structure of the government service is distinctly hierarchical, and patronage practices are common. Those who wish to get promotion must serve the patrons, the ones in top executive posts. The government servants are supposed to provide service to their bosses, even where it is not a function of their jobs; it is commonly said that "even a scholarship student, who completed a high-level education overseas, must serve the top executive by carrying his briefcase and following him around." However, male and female government servants get promoted differently. The Office of Civil Service (2015) reported that although the proportion of female civil servants (52 percent) is slightly larger than males, male civil servants dominate as police officers, attorneys, and judges while women dominate within education and social services. The same report also revealed that only 25 percent of the top posts, within the civil service, are occupied by women and only 5 percent of women have been promoted as a permanent secretary of a government ministry, which further reveals gender inequality.

Furthermore, one of the practices that reflects the continuity and persistence of upper-class gender inequality ideology is that of men having extra-marital relations. Although, historically, polygamy ended many years ago, the high-ranking leaders of the civil service or military officers still continue the practice of extra-marital relationships. *Mia noi* (literally "minor wife"), *mia kep* (secret wife), and *gik* (a lover or partner) are words used to exemplify the different forms of extra-marital relations of the high-ranking officials. Indeed, as the civil servants, under the control of the upper-class, have become the hegemonic force, the ideology of extra-marital relations has permeated down to the lower echelons of the service.

The notion that husbands, or Thai men in general, are granted (by the tradition of polygamy) a certain degree of freedom to have multiple sexual relations also has spurred the sex industry in Thailand. The modern sex industry was introduced into Thailand during the Vietnam War, when Thailand, besides being a military base for the US army, also became a site for the recreation of personnel serving in the war. But sex services were not only provided to American war personnel. Along with the economic growth of the 1960s and 1970s, brothels, massage parlors, and other segments of the sex industry sprung up in every town in the country to serve the local Thai men. For example, male university students during this period would find that there was a common practice of their seniors providing the first-year students with a sex lesson by providing “funding” to visit a local brothel. After the end of the Vietnam War, the sex industry in Thailand continued to expand to serve tourists, and today Thailand is among the key destinations for those tourists who seek such services.

Relatedly, there is a common practice among high-ranking officials which furthermore exemplifies the rampant nature and the continual permeation and expansion of the upper-class gender ideology underpinning inequality between men and women. When these high-ranking officials travel to supervise their subordinates or relocate to serve “up country,” their subordinates normally welcome them by joining with local businesses to offer them a large feast, including a “dessert” that normally is a young woman who earns an income from providing sexual services to high-ranking officials or to the rich. Usually, these women would be recruited from local vocational schools, high schools, or local universities. Some of these women may have won beauty queen competitions, and some may be aged below sixteen. These women are not prostitutes, but they are willing to have temporal sexual relations with these men, who are unknown to them, so as to gain income. Indeed, some of them may develop continuing relationships and become “minor wives.”

As discussed previously, economic and social changes in Thailand have also impacted gender relations among lower classes in rural areas. As economic changes have disintegrated community and kin institutions, these changes have also created opportunities for both men and women to escape from rural poverty and to seek jobs in Bangkok and other urban centers. There is no significant cultural bias restricting women’s migration. However, sons and daughters within families are bound by different obligations and responsibilities. Sons would generally migrate in order to seek a job and gain income in order to fund themselves in a marriage, while daughters migrate to support their parents at home. Although the duty to support parents also rests with sons, parents often view their daughters as being more effective in actually providing the necessary support. This is due to the Buddhist cultural notion of *Bunkhun*, the idea that someone is “indebted” to others, i.e., children are obligated to provide for their parents because of the goods and services that the parents provided in raising the children in the past. However, sons can escape from this bond by adopting another Buddhist cultural prescription in that they can return *Bunkhun* by becoming ordained in the monkhood, whereas daughters are precluded from such ordination. In Thailand, to become a monk is a source of prestige. Although, today, the concept has been fading, the claims of *Bunkhun* by parents rests mainly on their daughters (Promphakping 2000). This is supported by the observations that remittances to rural households received from female migrants constitute a greater proportion than those from male migrants.

Other phenomena related to gender inequality include the growth of the sex industry and trans-national marriage. Both phenomena are sometimes related. As discussed previously, the sex industry expanded during the Vietnam War, and the brothels and other forms of sex services continued to grow, even after the war, in order to serve local demand. The sex industry received a

further boost with the growth of tourism, with many tourists visiting Thailand for the purpose of engaging in sex services. Marriage of Thai women to foreigners can also be traced back to the Vietnam War, but trans-national marriage has grown significantly since the late 1980s, and it is not unusual that Thai women from the middle and upper-classes also marry Westerners. However, women, who enter the sex industry and who marry foreigners, typically are from the lower-class and often are stigmatized as being “hungry for money.” The words, *mia farung*, literally mean “Westerner’s wife,” and these women are looked down upon by many Thai people (Promphakping et al. 2005).

The economic growth and development that Thailand has achieved has been uneven, and rural areas have tended to lag behind the urban centers in all aspects of economic development. Although agricultural outputs and the income of rural people have increased, the increase has not been sufficient for them to maintain an acceptable level of quality of life. Thus, rural people have coped with poverty and sought to improve their quality of life by diversifying their sources of income away from agriculture, although their options have been limited.

For example, perhaps the most common option has been to send family members to work in urban centers, where most of them find employment in low-wage jobs due to their low skills and education. In most cases, rural people are able to support their children only up to secondary-level education, as the minimum required by most employers. Yet, the quality of the rural education is lower than that in Bangkok and in other urban centers, thus again placing rural men and women at a disadvantage.

Another example is found among women from rural areas who have gone to Pattaya, Phuket, and other tourist destinations, to engage in sex work. And some of these women have sought out Western men who want Thai wives. Making the choice to marry a foreigner is a crucial decision, especially for those who have never

experienced living overseas. However, there are women who are married to foreigners and who send money back to Thailand to support their families, and these families are consequently better off financially than others in their rural village.

Still one more example includes Western spouses who reside with their wives and live financially sound lives in the village. These conditions have persuaded other rural families to consider marriage with foreigners as a means of improving their livelihood. A number of these rural women were not involved in the sex industry previously. Some of them divorced their husbands for a number of reasons, such as when their husbands were not industrious enough to earn sufficient income to support the family. Others made contact with foreigners through the internet. In general, the families whose daughters married foreigners have increased their financial and material status, but this also has brought about an unevenness within the rural village.

CONCLUSION

Inequality generated by social and economic transformation is enmeshed in all social institutions in Thailand. This process of transformation has been complex, and government policy measures designed to create an equitable society have further widened the gap of inequality. While inequality is common throughout the various regions, it is most pronounced in the Northeast of Thailand. The transformation has also transformed the social institutions by which gender relations are defined. Changes in gender relations have occurred both in the upper and lower classes. The conservative gender ideology of the upper-class, in which women are subordinated, has permeated and expanded into new institutional settings. Meanwhile, the transformation also has altered and weakened the traditional institutions of rural villages in which women have equal status with men.

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Chapter twenty

Challenging Gender Inequalities through Education and Activism

Exploring the Work of Women's Organizations in Myanmar's Transition

Elizabeth J. T. Maber and Pyo Let Han

INTRODUCTION

Notions of gender and expectations of gendered roles and behavior in Myanmar are intertwined with legacies of colonialism, conflict, and understandings of religion. Under British colonial rule from the mid-nineteenth century to formal independence in 1948, the legacies of colonialism continue to be evident in Myanmar's education system, language policies, and penal codes, as well as in attitudes toward gender relations (Aung 2015; Crouch 2015). While there has been a tendency to romanticize historical gender constructions in Myanmar (see James 2005: 111; Steinberg 2013: 189), the impact of colonialism in reifying binary gender roles and expectations of behavior is undeniable. As elsewhere in the region, colonial-era laws, such as Section 377 which criminalizes same-sex relations, remain and they codify gender hierarchies and heterosexuality (Colors Rainbow 2013). Likewise, reflecting the perpetuation of such hierarchies, the penal code has continued to disadvantage women, including through unequal provisions for marriage and divorce, the absence of regulation for parental leave, and the lack of protective provisions against

domestic violence and marital rape (GEN 2013b; Maber 2014). Militarization has played a key role in preserving such structures of inequality and entrenching social stratifications, allowing little opportunity to reformulate institutional power structures.

However, women's activist movements have long sought to contest such inequalities, and have frequently drawn on non-formal education practices to do so, through delivering community-based classes covering issues of women's rights, (in)equality, empowerment, gender awareness, or leadership skills (Maber 2014). These learning environments differ considerably from education practices evidenced in formal learning environments and also from the more generic and decontextualized training courses offered by international organizations frequently encountered in development contexts (Maber 2016a).

In this chapter, we explore the relationship between education, learning, and activism within Myanmar by highlighting the connections between gender inequalities in formal education environments, which reflect broader social and cultural notions of gender, and responses from women's activist organizations. We also place emphasis on the role of international actors and

organizations which complicate this transitional context and can provoke resistance among activist movements attempting to construct contextualized responses to the priorities they themselves have identified for social development. Therefore, in this chapter, we present three main sections: initially, we present the context of Myanmar's political and civil conflicts, followed by an outline of the implications of current processes of reform and political transition for women's equality activism; we then present an overview and analysis of gender issues in the education system, drawing on research conducted within educational settings by both authors; finally, we highlight, through the case study of Pyo Let Han's organization, RAINFALL Gender Study Group, the opportunities and challenges for women's organizations in seeking to contest pervasive social inequalities.

CONTEXTUALIZING MYANMAR'S TRANSITIONS

Myanmar's current position in the region with regards to both economic and social development reveals multiple contradictions which reflect its turbulent political history. Despite recent economic advancements, the country continues to have the highest rates of poverty in the South East Asian region, with approximately 26 percent of the 51.4 million population living below the national poverty line (Asian Development Bank 2017), a figure which doubles for the 70 percent of the population that live in rural areas (UNDP 2017). Nevertheless, the 2014 census revealed a comparatively high literacy rate of 89.5 percent among those over the age of 15, with significant regional and gender disparities ranging from 62 percent of women in Shan State to 98 percent of men in urban Yangon Division (Department of Population 2015: 136–151). Since 1990, life expectancy has increased by seven years, reaching 66 in 2016 (World Bank

2017), but again remains low in comparison to Myanmar's South East Asian neighbors.

Although statistics vary considerably in their reliability, school enrollment rates have increased particularly at the primary level, with approximately 72 percent of children aged 5–14 enrolled in school, and with a gender parity index of 0.98 (Ministry of Education 2014: 29). Evidence continues to suggest that in many areas girls and women are staying in school longer than their male counterparts, with higher enrollment rates in tertiary education among women than men (Asian Development Bank 2012; Department of Population 2017; JICA 2013). However, this relatively high level of education among women has not translated into equal participation in the workforce: among the 67 percent of adults of working age (15–64) participating in the labor force, in 2014 the percentage of men was 85.2 percent in comparison to 50.5 percent of women (Department of Population 2015). The effects of gendered expectations, as well as the diversity of gendered experiences in education, explored further below, therefore continue to hold significant influence over men and women's participation in Myanmar's processes of economic, political, and social transitions alike.

NAVIGATING CONFLICT AND REFORM

As indicated above, tensions in Myanmar's current transitional context have been shaped by the turbulent experiences of its recent history. After an uneasy passage to independence, which saw the assassination of independence hero and transitional leader General Aung San (father of current State Counselor Daw Aung San Suu Kyi) in 1947 along with six of his cabinet colleagues, conflict continued to mar the nascent independent government (Transnational Institute 2013). Although the military claimed absolute power in a coup in 1962, it had already

held significant political influence during the intervening years of the caretaker governments since independence (Metro 2013). Successive military juntas in Myanmar, from 1962 to 2011, reinforced an environment of authoritarianism and oppression during which democratic opposition and social activism were highly constrained and fraught with risk. Political militarization was interwoven with multiple civil wars fought with Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs) over demands for auto-determination, which have persisted since independence in 1948 and which provided a pretext for military domination and control (Metro 2013; Transnational Institute 2013).

Despite intermittent ceasefire agreements, these multiple conflicts with the EAGs, in some cases enduring for upwards of sixty years, remain largely unresolved, with renewed active fighting ongoing in the northern states of Kachin and Shan, while ceasefires are tenuously holding in eastern regions of the country. Sexual violence, particularly directed against ethnic-minority women, has been a pervasive feature of these conflicts, and ethnic women's organizations have made use of transnational connections and cross-border movements with Thailand to campaign against military impunity (Women's League of Burma 2014). As a result of the conflicts in ethnic territories and crackdowns on political opposition parties, tens of thousands have been displaced across Myanmar's borders, with refugees and exiled activists particularly establishing themselves over the eastern border with Thailand (Border Consortium 2013; Maber 2016b). These forced migrants have added their number to the additional economic migrants who have equally fled across Myanmar's borders, particularly to Thailand, China and Malaysia, in the hope of securing greater compensation for their labor (International Organization for Migration 2017). Successive generations have therefore lived with the impacts of conflict, authoritarianism, and militarization which have shaped gendered

experiences of livelihoods, political participation, and for many, displacement.

POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC TRANSITIONS

The election of the Union Solidarity and Development Party, under the leadership of President Thein Sein, in late 2010 marked an official end to military rule, although the military retained political dominance. The quasi-civilian government, inaugurated in 2011, began a series of reforms across multiple sectors including opening economic markets, relaxing media censorship, controversial land reforms, and highly contentious education sector reforms (Lall 2016). Despite ongoing political and social tensions, these reforms nonetheless signaled a shift in political orientation for Myanmar, which was accompanied by the re-engagement of a host of international actors seeking to negotiate bi-lateral trade agreements, capitalize on economic development opportunities, and/or influence social development trajectories. For northern donors, development organizations and multi-lateral corporations alike, the politics of engagement in Myanmar has also been closely linked with the perceived response to democratic activist movements, with the release of political prisoners including Daw Aung San Suu Kyi, herself under house arrest for 15 years, as a key condition of the lifting of economic sanctions (Bächtold 2015; Hlaing 2012).

Consequently, following the 2010 elections, as the quasi-civilian Union Solidarity and Development Party government established itself during the subsequent 18 months, the risks associated with democratic and social activism, that saw many activists imprisoned or exiled by the military junta, became less intense amid a climate of tentative optimism in the reform process. Simultaneously, the relaxing of censorship laws and restrictions on internet and mobile phone access, once all but prohibited, increased opportunities

for information sharing across civil society organizations, community groups and activist movements as well as easing communication with cross-border networks. Women's organizations that had long been operating under great restrictions within Myanmar therefore found greater space for their activist and knowledge-sharing activities.

However, the risks associated with contesting political and social hierarchies continued to remain high and the hopes of genuine civil society recognition did not materialize, with the re-arrest of political activists, crackdowns on student protest demonstrations, and violence against labor and landrights activists undermining initial aspirations for significant change to power structures (Zin 2015). The shift in donor alignment from a previously oppositional stance to the military junta to increased partnership with the Union Solidarity and Development Party government was also reflected in shifts in funding for civil society organizations, particularly those in the Thai border regions, away from projects perceived as too contentious to the new government's interests (Maber 2016a, 2016b). Consequently, as explored further below, civil society organizations have experienced an ambivalent relationship with international donors and agencies who are perceived as more closely aligned with national interests than community concerns (see Karenni Civil Society Network 2014; Women's League of Burma 2014).

In addition to the ongoing civil wars fought between the state military (Tatmadaw) and EAGs, religious tensions have also increased since 2011, resulting in violent inter-communal conflicts between majority Buddhist and minority Muslim communities, particularly in the western state of Rakhine (Walton and Hayward 2014). Changes in political leadership have not seen these tensions abated and there are growing concerns over the continued exclusion and displacement of minority Muslim groups in Myanmar's western state of Rakhine,

with incidence of violence increasing (OHCHR 2017; Schonthal and Walton 2016).

CHANGING DYNAMICS OF WOMEN'S POLITICAL PARTICIPATION

The election victory of the National League for Democracy (NLD) in 2015, under the leadership of Daw Aung San Suu Kyi, was hailed by many activists as the first democratically elected civilian government and as an opportunity for women's increased political participation, aided by strengthened engagement with civil society organizations. With the NLD's inauguration, the number of women who hold seats in the national Parliament has more than doubled, with approximately 10 percent of the total seats in the lower and upper parliamentary houses occupied by women, including two of the seats reserved for military appointees (Macgregor 2015), compared to a previous 4.6 percent of seats held by women (GEN 2012). The number, however, is still alarmingly low, and remains the lowest percentage of female parliamentarians in the ASEAN region (Macgregor 2015), despite the expressed intention of the NLD to promote female candidates and activist campaigns to "vote for women."

Nonetheless, some indications of increasing attention to addressing women's concerns at a policy level are emerging. The Department of Social Welfare has committed to supporting the establishment of a safe house for women seeking refuge from abuse and also instigated a pregnancy support fund to enable women to receive 10,000 *Kyat* per month (approximately US\$10). Likewise, there is renewed attention to stalled legislation to prevent violence against women. The Prevention of Violence Against Women (PoVAW) bill was originally proposed by women's rights activists and civil society organizations in 2013, after extensive public consultation, to address the lack of protection mechanisms for women and girls in the existing penal code

(Faxon et al. 2015; GEN 2015). However, in attempting to progress the bill through Parliament, advocates were met with significant resistance, especially from military and defense representatives, to the extent that the successively weakened bill floundered and lost support from many of its original advocates. The renewed attention to reviving the original aims of the legislation reflects the potential opportunities to expand alliances between women's civil society movements and efforts from within the nascent government.

Yet, progress in consolidating these alliances into tangible results for women's equality claims has remained limited, particularly where seeking to promote gender justice runs against military interests. Although there has been some incremental increase in the number of women representatives included in peace negotiations, women's participation in formal peace processes remains highly constrained. Since late 2015, civil conflicts with the multiple EAGs have continued, or indeed intensified in certain areas, increasing tensions and uncertainties between the incumbent NLD, the military, and ethnic states. While multi-party peace talks have continued to advance, through large-scale forums and round table talks, visible pragmatic results for ordinary citizens are crucially still needed. Although to a certain extent it is recognized by some parties that women have been significantly affected by the conflicts in many ways, including through basic human rights violations, direct (sexual) violence, and structural violence, they have remained frequently excluded from peace talks among both government and EAG representatives. Women peace activists have sought to gain access to these forums and have campaigned to make their voices heard through initiatives such as the Alliance for Gender Inclusion in the Peace Process (AGIPP), drawing attention to the roles that women are playing in managing families, communities, and livelihoods in conflict-affected areas, as well as in contributing to peace-building efforts. However, campaigners

have also highlighted the undermining of the women's activism by the persistent presentation of women as victims of war, particularly in the media and public discourse, rather than as leaders and advocates of peace who can participate in peace-making processes (AGIPP 2015).

This social construction of women as passive and obedient, reinforced through religious instruction, formal schooling practices, public media, and policy discourses, continues to perpetuate the reduction of women's experiences in conflict to victimhood. Similarly, beyond conflict environments, the cultural stigma associated with women's leadership as threatening to male-dominated power structures continues to exclude women from decision-making processes. Although across urban and rural areas women can be found heading households, managing farming activities and family businesses, leading civil society groups, and increasingly entering male-dominated sectors, nonetheless the lack of framing women's collective power as dynamic leadership and decision-making holds women back from meaningful participation in political affairs.

As we explore further below, these constructions of notions of gendered roles and duties are highly intertwined with religion. With 88 percent of the 56 million population estimated to be Buddhist (Department of Population 2016), the association of national identity with Buddhism has been systematically reinforced through education practices and through legislation, thereby exacerbating the potential for conflict. While religious violence has historical precedence, tensions have been inflamed by the recent emergence of controversial ultra-nationalist movements, known as the 969 and the MaBaTha, led by a small number of extremist Buddhist monks who claim to seek to defend the Buddhist majority from perceived threat (generally portrayed as coming from the minority Muslim community, which accounts for an estimated 4.3 percent of the population of Myanmar, in comparison to the 87.9 percent Buddhist majority.) The disproportionate political influence of these erstwhile

fringe movements has generated new challenges for women's rights activists, as emphasized through the package of legislation known as the "Protection of Race and Religion." The four bills cover the "Health Care on Controlling the Population Growth Law," the "Myanmar Buddhist Women Special Marriage Law," the "Monogamy Law," and the "Religious Conversion Law," and include restrictions on Buddhist women's right to marry as well as establishing mechanisms to limit birth numbers and to mandate birth spacing for communities perceived to be expanding (Walton et al. 2015). Members of the women's rights movements were not consulted in the preparation of the bills, and their objections did not alter the rapid approval of the bills, passed in 2015, reinforcing the fragility of the gains made by gender activists in political spheres.

A rhetoric of women's supposed "ignorance" (maintained in part through exclusion and subordination in education systems) has been deployed as a justification for the laws and the need to protect Buddhism from perceived threat, setting up paternalistic control over women. This was underscored by comments made by the Chairperson of the Theravada Dharma Network that: "Our Buddhist women are not intelligent enough to protect themselves" (U Aung Myaing, quoted in Walton et al. 2015: 38). In this way, women are being positioned within public discourse as passive representations of the nation state, and they are denied active agency and individuality in determining their own futures. In resisting this discourse, and in using community education as a means to engage others in this resistance, women activists are seeking to gain greater space to engage in gender transformative work.

CONNECTING GENDER, EDUCATION, AND ACTIVISM

Education systems have played a central role in constructing notions of idealized citizenship, and

reinforcing hierarchical social structures which advantage certain religious, ethnic, and linguistic identities, as well as gender identities. The inherently gendered nature of notions of citizenship (Yuval-Davis 1997) becomes particularly revealed within state school practices as simultaneously reflecting ideologies of national identity (such as through standardized curriculum texts) and broader societal norms (such as through teacher practices) (Apple 2012).

Reflecting the dual pathways for education in contributing to inclusion and exclusion (Davies 2010), while certain practices within formal education systems reinforce gender hierarchies, education also offers a means to contest inequalities and to formulate more inclusive notions of gender roles and identities. Non-formal community education spaces have, therefore, been key sites of activism and sharing learning within movements for gender justice. The sections below highlight these parallel practices, first through briefly exploring some of the enactments of gender inequalities evident within education practices, and subsequently considering activist responses. Supporting data for this analysis is drawn from two recent research projects undertaken by the authors on gender fairness in the Myanmar state curriculum (RAINFALL 2017) and the roles of formal and non-formal education in constructing female citizenship (Maber 2017).

REINFORCING GENDER HIERARCHIES

Various factors influence state learning environments in Myanmar, including the geographical location of schools, the availability and source of resources (human, material, and financial), the training available to teachers, language use, and international involvement. While acknowledging these variations, certain experiences are common across school practices. In particular, these include curriculum, the presentation of duties

and responsibilities within the classroom, and the role of teachers in contributing to women's experiences of inequality in relation to their male counterparts.

Historically, it was commonly accepted that women needed only to be prepared to be effective wives and mothers; consequently, their education was most often confined to emulating their mothers and obeying their fathers within the home. These patterns have continued to be reproduced in curriculum texts, particularly for the subjects of history, geography, civics, and Myanmar literature which have reinforced models of the expected roles of men and women in society (GEN 2015; Higgins et al. 2015). Associations between men and positions of power, leadership, and financially more lucrative employment contribute to the replication of expected pathways for young men, while young women find representations of their futures limited to domestic spheres, or less financially rewarding professions such as teaching and nursing (GEN 2015; RAINFALL 2017). Likewise, an analysis of the curriculum for 8th and 9th grade subjects found that, despite some modernization, boys continued to be presented in curriculum texts as adventurous, physically stronger, and as having more choices, while girls were depicted as more caring and eager to please, more interested in domestic matters, and more suitable for the role of a follower rather than a leader (RAINFALL 2017: 21).

Additionally, the glorification of state military violence, evident particularly in history narratives, presents a normalization of violence against those outside the male, Buddhist, ethnically Bamar ideal, which subordinates not only women, but all those perceived not to live up to this ideal, including ethnic and religious minority, lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT), and disabled students (Maber 2017: 148). However, seeking to ensure greater inclusion of women in historical narratives during ongoing processes of education reform has not always met with positive responses. For example, during an interview

conducted for the study of gender fairness in the curriculum (RAINFALL 2017), a member of the committee for curriculum development for the Ministry of Education gave his view on why text books continue to obscure women from history teaching: *"You cannot read the history to be gender equal. History is mostly about the heroes, [and there are] only a handful of woman heroes in the past on a global scale."*

Allied with those roles mentioned above, while presentations of expected duties for men and women in curriculum texts are strongly associated with Myanmar Buddhist notions of the roles of men and women, these cultural and religious affiliations are also enacted in performative ways within the classroom. Physical positioning whereby young women are not expected to sit on the right-hand side of men, or to stand above them, for fear of diminishing their innate masculine power (*hpon*), reinforces a pervasive and visible subjugation of women which is extended to non-Buddhist students (see also Nwe 2009). Girls may therefore find themselves physically separated from boys within the classroom, and not encouraged to play sports or games with them for fear of undermining essentialized male authority. The dual effect is therefore created of simultaneously projecting an image of Myanmar citizenship as uniquely Buddhist, while also reinforcing the social construct of women as being inherently inferior to their male counterparts.

In our focus group discussions conducted with 60 state teachers (see RAINFALL 2017), indications emerged that female teachers may also perpetuate gendered assumptions within the classroom. One female teacher explained: *"Yes girls are more obedient than boys, they behave [better] than boys, I prefer to teach girls [rather] than boys but I have to admit boys are more smart than girls. They are good at math and science."* The majority of female teachers in discussions gave similar responses, with male teachers frequently agreeing. Additionally, female teachers were also found to commonly view male

teachers as more effective in teaching. One female teacher interviewee, whose husband is a private teacher, reflected:

Male teachers can attract both girl and boy students at teaching. They would like to obey male teachers [rather] than female teachers. And I think this is true that male teachers are better at teaching than female teachers. Speaking from my experiences. Students like my husband's teaching [more] than mine.

However, female teachers are also themselves navigating cultural constructions of their roles. The vast majority of state school teachers at primary and secondary level are female, and they receive low salaries in return for their efforts. In contrast, more lucrative roles in private teaching and senior education positions are largely taken up by male teachers (Higgins et al. 2015; RAINFALL 2017).

Many of the above issues may be seen as examples of structural inequality in which “women” are socially constructed as subordinate to their male peers, and excluded from participation in wider roles and opportunities both as students and as teachers within educational settings. These structural inequalities, indeed, provide the conditions to justify direct violation of rights and violence against women and other marginalized groups, through the reinforcement of social hierarchies in which more powerful groups are awarded authority and privilege over others (Davies 2011; Maber 2017). Additionally, as corporal punishment is also widely practiced as a form of discipline within schools, the model of violence as an act of control and as punishment for transgressing accepted patterns of behavior is already established, and violence becomes normalized as part of the (gendered) school experience. Beyond school environments, sustaining patterns of direct violence therefore becomes legitimized, compounded by a lack of political and legal support to address violence more broadly.

CONTESTING GENDER HIERARCHIES

Women's activist and community-based organizations have devoted their attention to varied dimensions of women's experiences of inequality in Myanmar, which include emphasis on political participation and promoting leadership, providing psycho-social support and legal services to those who have experienced violence, public campaigns to end harassment in public spaces, and challenging religious and cultural traditions, among many others. Even within this great diversity of activism and community-based responses, education activities occupy a central position, with a recent survey of 109 women's community organizations revealing that the majority focused their activities on some form of education and training activities (WON and GEN 2016). Experiences in formal education—which have reinforced social constructions and portrayals of women as subordinate through curriculum representations, teaching practices, and classroom roles—have contributed to activism within learning environments, seeking to construct alternative presentations of gender roles and to question what it means to be a woman in Myanmar society. This activism is highlighted in the case study discussion below.

Additionally, non-formal education and training practices have provided a means for women activists in Myanmar to expand the reach of their activities, to continue to challenge dominant discourses, and to gain support for women's increased political and social participation. The feminization of education, seen as a culturally appropriate occupation for women, has resulted in many women activists gaining experience as teachers either in state schools or in the alternative education systems supported by ethnic opposition groups. For women activists, community classrooms therefore have been a suitable environment for campaigning for gender equality, mentoring young women, and raising

awareness of the subordination of women that has been fostered through the practices of the military and authoritarian state and through cultural and religious traditions.

As a result of the enduring social marginalization of women, particularly within the socio-politically conflict-ridden environment, women's organizations have often been viewed as apolitical within their communities (Laungaramsri 2011). Consequently, these organizations have been able to garner space for social activism, particularly among the youth and in the traditionally feminized spheres of education and training. Organizations have therefore been able to gather and share information on what are highly politically charged issues, including the state-sanctioned, if not actively promoted, use of rape and sexual violence against women in the armed conflicts (Women's League of Burma 2014).

WOMEN'S MOVEMENTS CHALLENGING INEQUALITY: A CASE STUDY OF RAINFALL GENDER STUDY GROUP.

For women's movements in Myanmar, there is an evident concern to support women's political participation in the context of transition, both in terms of women's leadership and representation in parliamentary and ministerial roles and in terms of participation in community decision-making and reducing the fear of political engagement. However, as highlighted above, there is a frustration among women activists that formal education practices have not prepared women to lead, nor have they prepared men to accept this changing social role (GEN 2013a; Maber 2014). Consequently, redefining learning environments has become a feature of women's activist work.

In the following *case study of women's civil society activism* in contesting gender inequality through alternative learning practices, Pyo Let

Han describes the work of her organization, RAINFALL, and how her work has evolved to address emerging issues within the processes of socio-political transition.

RAINFALL Gender Study Group came into being in 2011 through the initiative of four young Myanmar women: Zin Mar Aung, Shunn Lei Swe Yee, Khin Myo Kyi, and Pyo Let Han who had been engaged in protesting and questioning all forms of discrimination against women in Myanmar society. We originally started as a reading club in 2010, when women from different areas, religions, and backgrounds came together to discuss what issues we were facing as Myanmar women. We not only read and discussed about women's movements across the world through magazines and books but also shared our own daily lives and experiences as women. In reading the history of women's movements around the world, we wanted to encourage this kind of movement in Myanmar too. Women's activism is not new in Myanmar, but in the past, particularly during colonial struggles, it was largely led by elite women. In 2011, we saved up our own money and also received some donations in order to organize a "Gender and Society" forum, although "gender" was still an uncommon word to encounter. Since that time, our group has focused on the study of gender.

International connections have certainly played a role in RAINFALL's development, not only through learning about global women's activism but also through initial support from the British Council for the launching of our member-based network in 2011. At that time many members were interested in women's empowerment, and we organized bi-weekly meetings and presentations by various resource persons linked to international development and gender topics such as the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW). However, international discourses on women's rights in Myanmar—focusing particularly on individual rights and on improving the number of women in the political system, public

spheres, and workplaces—are often far from the reality of local women. Women in Myanmar from different backgrounds, religions, and ethnicities are facing and enduring sexism in very different ways, and consequently varied and contextualized responses are required. Moreover, our women's history is very different from that of Western countries, particularly as we navigate through our pre-colonial, colonial, and post-colonial struggles, the subsequent military regime, and now democratic transition.

Therefore, our hope was to enhance the empowerment of women and the understanding of the role that a woman is assigned in the Burmese cultural context. To accomplish this goal, we prioritized working as a study group network, and in 2014, we re-formed RAINFALL into an official organization with an office in the downtown section of Yangon. Initially, we provided “women's political empowerment training,” as at that time many urban women were afraid to talk about politics and were not always aware that their rights were being violated. From 2014 to 2016, RAINFALL provided six basic residential trainings and two advanced trainings on “women's political empowerment.” Some of our alumni are now working on various activist activities, and they include current members of Parliament, as well as a journalist covering gender-related news and stories. Additionally, RAINFALL worked closely with other women activists and leaders during the 2015 general election to support the “vote for women” and took part in campaigns to oppose the anti-interfaith marriage bills.

However, two of the founders of RAINFALL—Shunn Lei Swe Yee and Pyo Let Han—still felt that at least two things were missing in women's activism: specifically, (1) greater background theory on what it is to be a Myanmar woman; and (2) the meaning of women's activism in the context of Myanmar. Hoping to collectively work toward addressing these gaps, we published the *RAINFALL Myanmar Feminist Magazine* in 2015 so as to question our deeply patriarchal systems, institutionalized sexism, and religious

ideologies which construct women as second-class beings, or “perfect assistants” for their men, governments, and institutions. We have come to see the Myanmar education system as one of the main institutions which trains women as “perfect assistants.”

RAINFALL is now attempting to stand as a feminist organization which focuses on gender study and on developing a Myanmar feminist theory which can be applied as a tool for sustainable activism in the Myanmar context. We want to address certain key questions for the women's movement, such as why we need women's activism, what the historical context is for Myanmar women and what “gender” means for the Myanmar people. We think that by developing understanding around concrete concepts and issues related to women's rights activism, we can avoid facing a negative reaction in the future.

Continuing this work, we currently have four main projects: (1) conceptualizing feminism in the Myanmar context by conducting research on Myanmar society linked to gender study; (2) providing workshops and trainings based on assessments and research; (3) publishing quarterly magazines and publishing books to address the gaps in learning about gender, women's history, and feminist literature to provide a platform for Myanmar women (“voiceless to voices”); and (4) conducting public advocacy forums and community dialog related to gender issues in the Myanmar context.

Standing as an organization which is based on studying Myanmar society from feminist perspectives and conducting gender-based research is not easy for RAINFALL. We have to conceptualize feminist philosophy while many women's and gender organizations have tended to focus on enacting legal reforms and on making gender-related policies. Furthermore, we have seen contradictions in the approach of some gender activists in Myanmar which reinforces the social construction and presentation of women as the “weaker sex,” and we maintain that we will not make progress on issues of

women's equality unless we examine *patriarchy* and the way it functions to maintain political and social hierarchies in Myanmar. This does not always fit with discourses by some international non-governmental organizations (NGOs) and agencies, including the United Nations, since some international organizations tend to view local women as activists who should follow the NGOs' standards. This lack of respect for—and acknowledgment of—local women as experts of their society is unfortunately common among donor organizations and is part of the reason that RAINFALL operated without international donor funding from 2011–2013. Consequently, we prefer to focus on the social and intellectual development of women through studying, learning, and exchanging knowledge which, for us, is as important as development which focuses on economic growth.

DRAWING CONCLUSIONS

As Myanmar is navigating political transition from military rule to emerging civilian democracy, multiple competing spheres of public discourse on women are apparent. *First* is the now generic international language of women's rights, empowerment (in its depoliticized form), gender development indices, and the "advancement of women" as espoused to varying degrees by United Nations agencies, the European Union, the World Bank, and the Asian Development Bank.

Second is the continuing rhetoric in Myanmar of the military-dominated processes of transition instigated in 2011, which simultaneously replicated international directives and built alliances and trade agreements with donor governments, while also reinforcing gender conservatism and systematic inequalities for women under the law. Increasingly finding its way into this presentation of womanhood in public discourse has been the insidious rhetoric of (Buddhist) women's protection from threatening (read Muslim)

forces which has its origins in a recent movement led by extremist Buddhist nationalist groups.

But a *third* discourse in Myanmar is progressively finding a voice in the political sphere which contests the multiple limitations in the framing of women, including the reservation of women's "advancement" for elite military wives, the image of docile women needing protection from their own choices in marriage, and the exclusion of identity constructions beyond the mainstream metropole (including rural and ethnic women's cultural heritage, the LGBT community, and women with disabilities). Small but growing numbers of women activists are contesting the image of Myanmar women reproduced in the media, rejecting the use of their bodies as sites of both political violence and domestic abuse, and demanding a legal system that recognizes their rights to security as well as their rights to choice. These women are challenging the assumption that behavior is a justification for acts of force committed against them or that their educational pathways and career options should be restricted based on socially preconceived notions of their gender. In contesting these expectations of gendered behavior and roles, women activists in Myanmar are seeking to undo pervasive gendered-learning which has been interwoven with cultural notions of identity and belonging. In so doing, they are questioning not only the practices that have enacted and maintained subordination of women within Myanmar but also the role of international donors, agencies, and organizations in supporting and perpetuating the institutional power structures that crystallize social hierarchies.

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Part IV

South Asia

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Chapter twenty-one

Young Women's Situation and Patriarchal Bargains

The Story of a Son-Less Family in Rural Bangladesh

Roslyn Fraser Schoen

INTRODUCTION

In this chapter, I examine the intersection of development policies and son preference through the story of a son-less family in Matlab, Bangladesh. Based on my qualitative research on changes in daughters' situation and status amid economic and demographic shifts, I use a case study of one family to illustrate how economic development, gender hierarchies, and labor migration intersect at the micro level. Headed by a labor-migrant father who has been away for several years, this family of five, including three daughters and no sons, has moved away from agricultural land in order to access schools in town where the girls can receive a formal education. I focus largely on Asha, the mother of the family, and on Saalima, the eldest daughter and Mina, the middle daughter. In doing so, I intertwine their "life stories" with discussion of key gender-related elements such as public space, patriarchy, and work and family life. As will become evident from my discussion, the family in this case study must negotiate their future economic survival in the face of threats to their social status against a backdrop of regional changes in formal education, marriage practices, and women's mobility. Using Kandiyoti's (1988)

concept of the *patriarchal bargain*, I demonstrate how bargains are not only made by individual women navigating patriarchal systems, but that the patriarchal bargain also occurs at the family level, with ongoing consequences for household members, including fathers.

PUBLIC SPACE RENEGOTIATED

A footpath from the non-governmental organization (NGO) to Asha's house winds around a shared pond and through a cluster of houses and yards. There are no cycle or auto rickshaws on the footpath, only people and chickens. Children yell "hello," and sometimes follow behind us until their mothers call them back home. But the footpath only gets us as far as Asha's house. We have to walk along the main road to get to the school or the market.

Taking the footpath is more of a journey through the backyards of neighborhood friends. You feel allowed, even *invited* to be there. The main road isn't so welcoming. Part of the shift in feeling comes from the occasional rumble of buses or the whirl of auto rickshaws that chance too close to your shoulder as they pass from

behind. But mostly, the main road is different because the rules change. It feels as though you may be allowed, but you certainly were not invited.

Next to the far wall of Asha's house there is a large metal gate that separates the footpath from the road. It is at this gate that we always waited for one another, literally to regroup. We might have spread out on the footpath, but on the main road we stuck together. Asha and her daughter Mina joined us at the gate and, after some checking of sandal straps and adjustments to headscarves, we stepped through the small door beside the gate and walked along the road.

I first met Asha and her family in 2010 when I was in Matlab for six months assisting on a research project as a graduate student. I returned to the study area in 2011 to complete fieldwork for my doctoral dissertation. The goal of my research was to understand child gender preference and the value of daughters within a local context of fertility decline and male labor outmigration. The data and analyses supporting this chapter come from ethnographic observation and approximately 30 semi-structured interviews that took place over a five-month period in 2011–2012. Because the data presented here reveal many of Asha and her family's personal experiences with what many consider a sensitive or difficult topic, all names presented have been replaced with pseudonyms.

Today it is common in rural Bangladesh to see groups of girls, some wearing burkha or hijab with their school uniform, walking along the roadside or riding across rivers in wooden country boats on their way to and from school. This was not the case in the past, as Asha's 55-year-old neighbor, Atfa, points out when I ask her about changes she has seen during her lifetime:

Girls' education wasn't considered a priority when I was growing up, otherwise I would have studied. Nowadays, the government is female-headed and they have declared women's education a priority. In my time we couldn't even go out

onto the road. Nowadays, girls don't have that level of restriction.

While most residents in Matlab with whom I interacted say they agree that girls must be educated, there is social tension around allowing girls to attend school. This tension is evident during family conversations about what kinds of things girls and young women should be allowed to do and how far from home they should be able to travel. As an unmarried woman myself, who had clearly traveled quite far from home and away from the security of my own relatives, my very presence held the potential to hush these conversations or to fuel them. One time, while sitting beside me in her father's shop, Mina tried to use me as an example in an argument with him, saying, "See! It's a new era! Women go out now, they live alone! They go to university! They earn!" Fearing that her father would become angry with me, I turned red and shrugged an apology. My reaction to being the center of her argument was in no way indicative of the independent strength Mina claimed for me.

The social tension around where girls should and should not go is, unfortunately, also evident in the amount of "Eve-teasing," endured by young women and girls in public. Eve-teasing is a local euphemism for sexual harassment, usually perpetrated by groups of boys or young men on the road. Eve-teasing can include sexual comments, name-calling, and inappropriate jokes. The phrase is also used to refer to acts of sexual assault, including a girl or woman having her scarf or other clothing pulled off her, witnessing a man expose his genitals, and unwanted physical contact such as embracing, shoving, or slapping (Mia 2010).

Girls and women in Matlab experience public sexual harassment by boys and men, including while walking to and from school. I encountered this regularly while walking with the neighbor's girls, who ranged from 7 to 14 years old. This is part of the reason we always traveled in groups, and why we waited for Asha to lead the way.

The presence of a higher-status adult woman like Asha lends a limited amount of protection from Eve-teasing. Young men may still verbally harass the girls in the presence of an older woman, but it is less likely that the men would say anything highly sexual or perverse, and far less likely that they would try to touch any of the girls when Asha was present. I would love to be able to say that when Eve-teasing happened to me, I ignored and dismissed it with ease, shielded by the mythical social distance of an observing researcher. But the truth is, over time, the harassment becomes unbearable, with a volume and repetition that is more than enough to conjure my angry, frustrated tears.

BARGAINING WITH PATRIARCHY

The entire process of gathering in a group of women and girls and walking in public can be understood as a kind of patriarchal bargain. Kandiyoti's concept of "patriarchal bargains" reflects the trade-offs women make within patriarchal structures. Specifically, the concept highlights how women's actions can simultaneously be forms of resistance to and complicity within patriarchy (1988). Women and girls who walk along roadsides to attend school or go to the market are engaging in an act of resistance because they are not observing the public/domestic spatial dichotomy. In this way, they are eschewing old expectations, shaped by *purdah*, and are instead collectively resisting the idea that public space is only for men. However, the notion of *purdah* is still signaled through their behavior while in public.

Purdah, also referred to as the veil or curtain, is the practice of female claustration for the purposes of assuring modesty (Papanek 1973). While wearing a veil in the form of burkha or other covering is "its most obvious manifestation to the casual observer," *purdah* is more appropriately described as a set of customs based on the

maintenance of family honor via limitations on women's public movement (White 1977: 31). *Purdah* in Bangladesh is religiously justified as part of Islamic principles, but this does not mean that patriarchal structures were introduced by Islam. Notions of *purdah* and female claustration guide gender expectations for all women in Bangladesh, regardless of religion. The existence of *purdah* in Bangladesh is anchored in a history of religious and cultural syncretism across the Bengal region, as Rozario points out:

[T]he subordinate status of women in Bangladesh could largely be understood by reference to local patriarchal Bengali gender values which were and are common to all the Bengalis, whether Muslim, Hindu, Christian or Buddhist. It is not that the various religions did not contribute to this gender hierarchy; indeed they have often aggravated and reinforced it. On the whole, however, the lives of Bangladeshi women from different religious groups were guided by a common [patriarchal] world-view.

(Rozario 2006: 369)

Women and girls journey in groups, with bodies covered, and sometimes with head and face covered. They walk swiftly, close together, and avoid eye contact with unknown men. In these ways, their resistance is couched within the enduring, normative ideas of feminine space as places where women and children congregate and are shielded from the male gaze. In our roadside walking group we are, to borrow the term from Papanek (1973), creating *mobile shelter*. Together the girls stretch the boundaries of the feminine sphere out onto the road and into the schoolyard or bazaar, while still partly conforming to normative codes of dress, movement, body positioning, and eye contact.

I did not initially intend to study *purdah*, and I still do not find it to be the most important aspect of life for girls and young women in Matlab. Nonetheless, in my research, it kept coming up as central to how women in Matlab described their world. Interestingly, the women and girls I spoke

with did not link *purdah* with religious ideas; instead, it was used as a shorthand way to indicate all the various kinds of social constraints on women's physical and social mobility. And just as observance of *purdah* varies tremendously across Muslim societies, the experiences of social constraint among Bangladeshi women vary a great deal based on their class and status position, and based on where they live (Feldman and McCarthy 1983; Rozario 2006; for an example of this among Pakistani women, see Papanek 1973). The middle-class women and girls in Matlab town negotiated local social constraints by striking bargains that let them simultaneously resist the notion that women should not be out in public space, while adhering to the new rules of modesty on the road.

WORK AND FAMILY LIFE

Given that households are the primary sites where power and gender relations are constructed (Kabeer 1994), one needs to understand how families operate in order to understand the intersections of economic change and gender. Although households in Matlab today are comprised of nuclear, joint, and extended families, many norms are still based on the assumption of a joint family arrangement wherein groups of patrilineal kin live with each other on family land in their paternal *bari*. A *bari* is a cluster of houses that share a common yard and usually a kitchen. In rural Bangladesh, where residence patterns are patrilocal, boys and girls grow up in their father's house with their mother and their paternal relatives around them in the *bari*. After marriage, sons stay with their wives in their father's *bari* while daughters marry out and move to their husband's family's *bari*.

Social norms in the area are anchored by South Asian Islamic practice and patriarchal gender structures that predate and extend beyond religious belief systems (Rozario 2006). Marriage is heterosexual and almost all young women say

they expect to get married at some point. One-third of brides in the Matlab area are married before turning 18, with most brides married before the age of 25 (HDSU 2014). Dowry, which is the exchange of money, jewelry, furniture, or other goods from the bride's family to the groom's family, has been illegal since the 1980s; however, the vast majority of marriages are still arranged by the brides' and grooms' parents after they negotiate a dowry (Nasrin 2011). Many families in the Matlab area rely on small-scale agricultural work performed by men and women of the household. Other opportunities to earn include fishing and shrimping, day labor, retail trade, construction, and handicraft production; however, these jobs are mainly reserved for men.

Many villages in the Matlab area remain socially and geographically isolated from urban centers, particularly during monsoon season when boat travel becomes the primary means of transportation. The availability of indoor plumbing, electricity, and mobile phones has increased but these technologies are not universal. Approximately 60 percent of rural households are without electricity (Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics 2010; World Bank 2013b) and, due to frequent load-shedding and brown-outs, access to electricity does not mean the household receives a constant supply of power. As one community member explained, "Here we do not talk about when the electricity goes out. We talk about when it will finally come."

Though still quite rural, and with sporadic electricity supply, Matlab town offers a few more amenities than the surrounding villages, with a major bus stop, a decent-sized bazaar, many masjids (mosques), and a large Hindu temple. The town has several educational institutions, including primary schools, high schools, and madrasas. Housing is a mixture of *bari* dwellings with small fields, single homes that sit close together, and multistory apartment buildings. Of all these housing types, the multistory apartment complex appears to be proliferating. Several buildings are under construction and there is

talk of agricultural fields being sold to developers who plan to build more. Matlab town also has a government hospital, an NGO research hospital, and a handful of health clinics and pharmacies. There is even a cinema theatre in Matlab town, though I am told it is not the kind of place that women or respectable people should go to.

Of all these amenities, it was the schools in particular that drew Asha and her daughters to the town. Not only were there better schools in town, but acceptance of sending girls to school beyond primary education was more widespread. At first, Asha worked hard to cultivate an attitude of academic achievement in each of her daughters. Thinking about their current situation, now that her eldest daughter is married and not working, she wonders whether it was all worth it. She wonders whether they made the right bargains.

What about Micro-Credit Programs and Garments?

Westerners are usually familiar with the development agenda in Bangladesh through news stories about microcredit programs and the ready-made garment (RMG) industry. Microcredit loans are often cited as a significant source of positive change for rural women. To my surprise, such programs were not mentioned by a single respondent during the larger research project, and those directly asked about microcredit had only a vague sense that microcredit programs existed.

Since the 1980s, economic restructuring has produced a boom in the RMG sector in Bangladesh, and with it, a significant increase in women's participation in paid labor in urban spaces. Hoping to recruit a docile, cheap labor force, the RMG industry attracted women from rural areas who moved to Dhaka in search of financial security (Feldman 1992; Ahmed 2004). The young women who migrated for employment in export-oriented manufacturing were often daughters who needed to contribute to household finances due

to family hardship or landlessness; other women who migrated for manufacturing jobs included those experiencing widowhood, abandonment by their spouse, or separation from their kin network (Feldman 1992, 2009; Kabeer and Mahmud 2004).

Families who can afford to keep their daughters in the village and not send them to work in manufacturing will do so. During my time in Matlab, I heard many people say that work in the garment sector was an option of last resort, reserved for the destitute. Manufacturing jobs were considered too risky or seen as low-status work. Some women discussed fears of moving to Dhaka city for work, including fear related to their own safety and that of any children they would bring along. Others expressed concerns over the cost of living, the quality of urban schools, and the availability of housing. In one conversation, two young women spoke at length about stories they had heard about sexual harassment in the workplace and sexual exploitation from men in management positions. News stories of building collapse and factory fires also reach rural households, as do stories about wage disputes between women, the state, and employers in the city. Of all the ways women and their families bargained with patriarchal structures to make economic ends meet, it was work in the garment sector that seemed to be the most difficult bargain of all.

The number of women entering the paid labor force is increasing, but in rural areas this is the exception rather than the rule; women in Matlab are not entering the labor market en masse. Nationally, just 34 percent of rural women participate in the paid labor force compared to 82 percent of rural men (Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics 2017). The women I spoke with in Matlab did say that educated girls might be able to work for wages in the future, but they were hesitant about sending young women into the workforce for two reasons. First, they worry about women's safety in a context where cultural norms limit women's movements in public space; second,

families rely on the work, both in agriculture and within the household, that women perform.

Although it is not yet typical, some women in Matlab do participate in paid work. Given sufficient training and education, women work locally as teachers, health outreach workers, social workers, health professionals, and domestic workers. These jobs are viewed as offering gender-appropriate work, but their availability in the Matlab area is limited. It is possible that more young women would seek wage-based or salaried work if more suitable jobs were available in the area.

Household Work and Family Land

Because agriculture and fishing remain staple occupations in the area, land rights and land inheritance are important. Families divide their land equally among their sons, and occasionally give smaller shares to their daughters. In practice, however, daughters who do inherit land often give their shares directly to their brothers so as not to jeopardize family relationships. Despite the fact that fertility in Matlab has shrunk tremendously over the last 35 years—from approximately 7 children per woman in the 1970s to 2.6 children in 2012 (HDSU 2014)—population pressures and resource competition persist, sometimes causing significant conflict within families.

People in the Matlab area expect the responsibility of caring for family land and aging parents to fall to sons and the daughters-in-law they bring into the family through marriage. The kind of care sons provide is primarily articulated in terms of financial support, but also includes shopping for food, medicine, and clothing; performing major transactions like buying or selling property; deciding whether children will go to school or receive tutoring; making burial and funeral arrangements for parents; and being responsible for the general well-being of family members.

The status position of daughters in Bangladesh has historically been lower than that of sons (Ahmed and Bould 2004; Kabeer and Mahmud 2004). This is partly because women's movements are limited in order to reinforce a gendered division of labor that ensures women will fulfill household duties while men are responsible for family economic security (Feldman and McCarthy 1983; Dil 1985). Although daughters are becoming more highly valued in Matlab, almost everyone still hopes to have a son. Today, son preference exists, but is more likely to be expressed in the belief that daughters are wonderful, but every family needs at least one son. This continuity of son preference is tied to normative gender roles and the patrilocal residence pattern, which dictates that (1) sons stay with their natal family and become the financial provider for parents as they age while (2) daughters require a dowry to be married and will move away to be with their marital family.

In many ways, Asha's household represents a break from these practices. After marriage, she did something very few women in rural Bangladesh would even imagine: she followed her husband to Saudi Arabia when he migrated for work. It was not easy to do. Asha remembers the entire journey in vivid detail, including her seat number on the plane and how she cried the entire flight, making herself physically ill. Her overall sense of fear was only momentarily interrupted by her awe of the airplane and her amazement at the clean, air-conditioned airport in Jeddah. "Truly, that airport seemed like Heaven to me," she said.

Asha gave birth to her first daughter, Saalima, while living abroad. After a few years, Asha returned to Bangladesh with Saalima to live in her husband's parent's household on their family land. She told me she did not like living in Saudi Arabia; she missed home and she wanted to raise Saalima closer to family. Her husband continued on with his job abroad, visiting Bangladesh about every two years. Several years after the birth of her third child, Asha left her in-law's village and moved into town with her children to take

advantage of the town's schools. To this day, it remains a family controversy that neither Asha, her husband, nor any of her children have been living in her in-law's *bari* and working the land. Though the matter has not yet been settled, their extended absence means that Asha's husband may lose any rights he had to inheriting family land.

DEVELOPMENT POLICIES AND FAMILY CHANGE

Many researchers and international organizations point to recent positive changes in rural Bangladesh, arguing that such changes are hallmarks of economic development and modernization efforts. These changes include the decline in fertility rates, increased access to formal education for all children—but particularly for girls—improvements in life expectancy for men and women, a reduced reliance on agriculture, and the entrance of men and women into the wage labor system (Cleland et al. 1994; IMF 2013; World Bank 2013a, 2014). Each of these changes has been supported or accelerated by policies that aim to end poverty by encouraging a dramatic decrease in family size and promoting wage-based labor over and above household-based agricultural production. This latter goal has been promoted through policies that encourage rural men to seek work in urban areas and abroad, and a growing network of recruitment agencies, both regulated and unregulated, in rural areas (Asfar 2009).

Rural Bangladesh is increasingly tied to global labor markets as economic development in Bangladesh is marked by large waves of labor out-migration of young men to urban centers in Bangladesh, and to countries like Malaysia, Singapore, and Saudi Arabia (Asfar 2009). Between 2000 and 2010, the number of families without land continued to rise, yet poverty rates began to decrease over the same period (World Bank 2013a). The decoupling of

the poverty rate from rates of landlessness is evidence of the growing significance of wage-based labor, an increased reliance on remittances from abroad, and a move away from dependence on agricultural production. Still, meeting the demand for wage-based jobs within the country has been difficult. To address this, the government of Bangladesh and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) have set a goal of increasing the rate of overseas employment of all skilled and semi-skilled Bangladeshi workers to reach 50 percent by 2021, up from the current rate of 35 percent (IMF 2013). According to data collected in 2011 by a local NGO, migration rates for men who are leaving the Matlab area in search of work in urban areas and abroad are moderate, but increasing among those aged 20–34 years, with over 15 percent of young men aged 20–24 years out-migrating (HDSU 2014).

The same joint IMF–Government of Bangladesh plan that advocates male labor migration also includes language about continued population management. Fertility control has been an integral part of the national policy agenda in Bangladesh since the early 1970s, with leaders identifying high population density and low income as major challenges to the new nation. The low-fertility agenda remains highly visible in the Matlab area. It is carried out on multiple platforms, including slogans in the media, advertisements in public places, in children's lessons at school, and through home visits by health outreach workers employed by governmental organizations and NGOs.

The dramatic decline in fertility is socially significant for multiple reasons. First, it results in smaller families, which means parents have fewer children to care for, making it easier to afford family necessities on men's wages. However, smaller family size also means parents have fewer children who, in turn, can help with work in the household and care for parents when they are old. Finally, having fewer children increases the likelihood that parents will have no sons or only one son, in a social context where sons have

historically been, and remain, the future source of household economic security. Overall, reduced fertility in Matlab has led to smaller families and changing household dynamics as families strategize new ways to achieve economic security.

Asha once told me the story of the births of her three children. Although she had grown up in a family of fourteen, including eight daughters and four sons, she tried to limit the number of her own children to two. Having fewer children was becoming a common idea due to the success of low-fertility campaigns. Asha said she accepted that her first child was a daughter, but was absolutely devastated when her second child turned out to be a girl as well. She said she cried so much, the nurses at the hospital avoided her. Eventually her husband was able to console her by asking her to imagine infants born into the world with serious disabilities and illnesses. She was slowly won over by the thought that, compared to those unfortunate babies, at least her daughter was healthy. After their third child was born a girl, Asha and her husband accepted that this was their family: three daughters and no sons. They have strategized around this reality ever since.

FAMILY BARGAINS

Today it is more common than ever for a daughter to be born into a family with no sons. In the absence of a brother, young women begin to wonder: what kinds of opportunities have opened up for me? What kinds of limits are set? It appears that families with no sons are creatively negotiating gender roles within existing social parameters. Although Kandiyoti (1988) theorizes patriarchal bargains as deals struck by individual women within patriarchal systems, Asha's family shows us that the demands of changing demographic and economic circumstances can force a family, including fathers and husbands, to strike such bargains as well.

Asha's husband had been away in Saudi Arabia for almost 20 years, visiting every two years. He

rented a small ground-floor flat in Matlab when Asha and their daughters moved off his parents' agricultural land and into town. Asha took over most of the parental responsibilities in the household while her husband, like thousands of other men from the area, lived and worked in Saudi Arabia, sending home a regular remittance that she could use for rent, food, and the girls' schooling. Financially, they did quite well compared to others in their village.

As the years went by, Asha and her husband came to see their eldest daughter, Saalima, as their hope for financial security. Saalima received some of the highest grades and exam scores in the entire *thana* (district) and was, by all measures, a level-headed and responsible daughter. That is, until one day when Asha discovered text messages on a mobile phone from a *dusho* (naughty, ill-mannered) boy in the town. It was clear from the texts and call records that Saalima was deeply involved with a boy whose reputation was not good, in a society that forbids her from dating or having serious relationships before marriage. Crushes and light flirting were allowed, but Saalima had gone too far and her parents were concerned that she would elope.

Asha and her husband panicked. Upon learning this news, her husband immediately returned from Saudi Arabia and sought to take back control of his family. From his perspective, the future of his daughter, her status, and the security of their entire family was at stake. Despite Asha's promises that Saalima could apply to and attend the university, they searched for a groom and arranged for her to be married as soon as she turned 18. The decision was made, dashing Saalima's hopes of becoming a doctor. This reality was also devastating for Asha. She reflected on the situation:

On her marriage night she asked us to stop the marriage and begged for us to allow her to study further. She begged for the opportunity. But my husband didn't agree. He feared possible danger, especially the continuation of her prior relationship.

What suffering came over me on that day! I became almost mad/crazed.

Upon seeing her older sister's devastation and shock, their middle daughter, Mina, was determined to have a different fate. Almost immediately, Mina began lobbying her parents for a different kind of life, particularly one that includes a university education and a lucrative career. She insisted that allowing her to stay in school and not be married would enable her to look after them financially. I asked Mina about her plan and she told me she wants to be a lawyer. Asha and her husband agree that Mina's life should be different from that of her older sister, but their plans do not include law school.

Asha explained what she and her husband have planned for their middle daughter Mina, who is around 13 years old. When I commented: "You were saying that you expect a lot from your daughters since you have no sons," Asha replied:

Yes, my husband believes that Mina will look after us by doing a formal job. According to him, Mina possesses the mentality for it. Though she doesn't study the hardest of all our children, she is very dynamic and intelligent. She could do it. She's very outgoing.

Asha's husband never returned to Saudi Arabia. Instead, he opened a small clothing shop in the local market, just beyond where the girls attend school in town. He plans to teach Mina how to run the shop so well that one day she can operate it without his support. In fact, he even named the shop "Mina's Fashion House," establishing her name in the local market long before she will begin working there. This is significant because, not only are there currently no shops in the local bazaar that are owned or run by women, but the number of men who shop in the marketplace also far outnumber the number of women who shop there. Some women, particularly those whose husbands are abroad, do shop in the market, but the bazaar is still very much a male-dominated space.

Saalima's marriage also became part of the plan. Asha's husband had arranged for Saalima to marry a young man who imports cloth from India and other countries. The plan is that one day Mina can run the shop by purchasing the cloth that her brother-in-law imports from abroad, which mitigates the need for Mina to travel outside the Matlab area or conduct non-local business in order to stock the shop. This creative strategy allows a family with no sons to ensure their future financial security through their daughter's labor, yet without asking their daughter to venture into unknown places in the public sphere. Maneuvering within the strictures of gender, Asha and her husband have devised a way for Mina to earn for the family that only requires her to journey a short distance between her house and her family-owned clothing shop – a distance barely farther than her current daily commute to school. Mina can rely on her brother-in-law to perform the most public tasks of the clothing business, and in this way, the family collectively helps to maintain her modesty and safety.

CONTINUITY, CHANGE, AND THE PATRIARCHAL BARGAIN

Many class- and status-based negotiations of gender structures can be understood in terms of "patriarchal bargains" wherein women make strategic decisions within the structural constraints of patriarchal systems (Kandiyoti 1988). Drawing an analogy from Kuhn's (1962) work on scientific revolutions, Kandiyoti theorizes that patriarchy oscillates between two phases, a normal phase and a crisis phase. Perhaps Bangladesh, before the demographic and economic shift of the last 20 years, represented a normal phase of patriarchy when the majority of women adhered to the rules of the gendered public/private dichotomy. At that time, expressions of *purdah* significantly limited women's mobility and solidified the gendered division of labor. Perhaps the new

realities of small family size and male labor out-migration that have emerged more recently are an example of a patriarchal system shifting into a crisis phase. During the crisis phase, Kandiyoti writes, “the impact of contemporary socio-economic transformations upon . . . the gendered division of labor inevitably lead to a questioning of the fundamental, implicit assumptions behind arrangements between women and men” (1988: 286). Now, the gender system itself is forced to adjust to new household dynamics.

For Kandiyoti, the crisis phase is one of intense suffering and upheaval, but also one of great potential as long as people, particularly women, begin to question the underlying assumptions of the status quo. But what happens when the crisis phase is consumed by the struggle for survival, and filled with nostalgic stories that promote a longing for the normal phase of the past? Rather than resulting in “the breakdown of a particular patriarchal system” (Kandiyoti 1988: 286), it is likely that we instead experience a return to yet another normal phase that is still patriarchal, but somehow different. What appears as change may actually be a repackaging of the past. The system is reconstituted in new ways that adhere to the rules of masculine dominance, but defy recognition as such. That is, new practices such as moving women into the public sphere to sell their labor may *appear* as a new, empowered position because women’s mobility is technically extended beyond domestic space. However, in reality, the tentative acceptance of women’s movement into public spaces ushers in increasing expectations for women’s activities that include household duties, care work, child rearing, family business errands, shopping, and daily-wage work. These shifts also mean women may be increasingly called upon to act as self-reliant and independent agents who must ensure their own economic security rather than relying on the shelter of family networks as they have in the past.

In Mina’s case, it means a future of work outside the household, but not the kind of work she wanted for herself. Her dreams include going to

university and becoming a lawyer, not managing a clothing shop in bazaar of her small town. Much to the discomfort of her father, Mina has not given up on her dreams of going to a university.

In conclusion, it may not be accurate to think about patriarchal bargains as the strategies that only women use to negotiate in a patriarchal system. The gender system defines life for women as well as men. In a family without sons, the confines of a strict division of labor based on gender presents problems for fathers as well. Although they do not enter into negotiations from a systematically weakened position as do women, men like Mina’s father who opened the clothing shop must also strike strategic bargains within patriarchal systems to ensure their own survival in a tightening economic system.

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Chapter twenty-two

Livelihoods, Households, and Womanhood in Nepal

Mira Mishra

INTRODUCTION

Rural households are transforming rapidly in Nepal as elsewhere in the world. There has been a large scale change in the structure of production and occupational diversification within the last three decades. The market for goods and services now operates within a nationwide and increasingly global network. State agencies have spread out and have a standard presence across the country. Access to communications has rapidly increased. Like in other rural regions of South Asia, in rural Nepal there has been a rapid increase in access to schools, marketplaces, transport, and communication services (Axinn and Yabiku 2001; Ghimire and William 2006; Mishra 2013). Thus, although a majority of Nepalis live in rural areas, rural residents are increasingly acquiring urban characteristics, a pattern similar to neighboring India (Shah 2012; Mishra 2013).

As Smith and Wallerstein (1992: 13) note, households are historically and socially created, and closely tied up with the nature of economy and polity—including at the national, regional, and global levels. Anderson (1980: 65–84), Kertzer (1991), and Macfarlane (1986) show that the nature of household, gender roles, and marital relations are shaped by rules of inheritance, land tenure, and structures and rules of access to other resources. Several others theorists have long argued

and demonstrated that changes in the mode of production and generation of livelihood, shape a society and its political economy in general, and gender relations and womanhood in particular (Engels 1891; Boserup 1970). Afonja (1981) explores the nature of the gender division of labor in the lineage-based subsistence mode of production, and compares it with a modern capitalist mode of production. Therefore, the passing of the control over land from generation to generation is central to the formation and nature of a household. In societies such as Nepal, for example, an adult male becomes the head of the household by owning and controlling access to land and, in the process, relegates other adult members of the family to subordinate positions. In these societies, therefore, women's labor as well as their sexuality, remains under men's control.

Other theorists suggest that women's ownership over productive assets enhances women's economic status. Agrawal (1994) identifies ownership of farmland as a major factor in the economic and political empowerment of women. She also argues that empowerment demands that women adapt to, and engage in, changing and shifting livelihoods as active agents, not passive recipients. Kelkar and Nathan (2005) note that South Asia is transforming from a dominantly agricultural society to one in which non-farm economic activities are becoming dominant. Such transition has a

definite and profound gender impact. Women's roles have been altered because more and more women are becoming engaged in non-farming economic activities and contributing to household income. With rapidly changing economic relations in households, gender relations between women and men have also fluctuated.

In the context of changes in the political economy, Chattopadhyay and Seddon (2002) explore the lives and livelihoods of people in a rural Bengal village in India over a period of 20 years. Using the life history method, they find that women-headed households, already likely to be poor, are often hit harder by poverty. Widows, who are overburdened by work, rely on daughters more than sons for help and, consequently, daughters are more likely to leave school at an early age. Diversification of economic resources may be considered as asset, but female and widow-headed households generally possess a very limited assets base and cannot benefit as much, if at all, from diversification, whether at the household or village level. Some research on the changing lives of wives of rural migrants finds that the household structure plays a crucial role in whether or not "left-behind" wives acquire greater autonomy in making domestic decisions (Desai and Banerji 2008). Similarly, Gulati (1995) suggests that older wives of migrants derive more benefits from husbands' migration than do younger wives. On the other hand, countering the arguments of Ellis (1999) and Smith and Wallerstein (1992: 5), Kabeer and van Anh (2002) find that there is an overall household benefit, and women's status is raised if they become engaged in nonagricultural activities or diversify occupationally.

A few researchers offer some clues to livelihood and gender in Nepal, such as Cameron's (2005) insights on economic change and empowerment among Dalit woman. Her research showed that a high rate of male labor out-migration encouraged women to engage in economic activities in addition to domestic chores. A weakening of patron-client occupational relations also gave women the opportunity to move out of traditional

artisanal labor. They became, in effect, free labor. Further, some "low caste" women began to compete with "high caste" women who had recently entered the modern labor market, allowing both categories of women to question the presumed "fixity" of caste and gender-based identity and relations. The resulting fluidity also led "low caste" women to question, and to resist, their historical attachment to menial labor. However, material on households is limited on gender and its relationship to economic expansion and diversification, tending to concentrate on issues related to gender and migration (Maharjan et al. 2012; Adhikari and Hobley 2015). It is necessary, therefore, to investigate emerging linkages between womanhood in Nepal in relation to rural livelihood, households, and migration.

METHOD AND CONTEXT OF STUDY

To investigate these linkages, this ethnographic exploration is centered in a village 17 kilometers east of Hetauda, the headquarters of the Makawanpur District, which is located south of the Kathmandu Valley. It takes about 90 minutes to reach the village from Hetauda by local bus. The ethnically mixed village has a population of nearly 7,000, and includes the Bahuns, Chhetris, and Tamangs as the largest ethnic groups, but also Dalits and Newars which have a much smaller presence.

The history of settlement of the village goes back only as far as the 1950s. It is economically, politically, and culturally dominated by the "high caste" Chhetris in terms of land ownership, as well as leadership, in most state institutions in both the village and the district. "High caste" Brahmins are also located in such dominant positions. Exclusion by ethnicity, caste, and gender continues to remain the rule. However, during the last two decades, with increased demand for labor, higher wages, and diversification of occupation and sources of income, the relative class

position of households has been changing rapidly. Internal and international labor migrations, as well as several eventful and sharp democratic openings, have helped accelerate these changes. Such changes have been sweeping across all levels of society, ranging from the state, to the community I describe. These changes have permeated perceptions about the “self” and its linkage to neighbors, to the village, and to wider society. Rural society and the women and households located there are becoming more public and more voiced.

Women’s engagement in the public sphere, such as their work as teachers, government employees, members of various local social service organizations, leaders, and students, is expanding. Similarly, the number of women who work for wages in nonagricultural sectors is increasing. Women are beginning to take the lead in securing loans for, as well as providing loans to, neighbors and others in the village. Young women in the village and the vicinity are increasingly involved in wider, nonfamilial networks compared to their mothers and grandmothers. Consequently, as we will see, both women’s images and gender relations are being transformed.

To explore womanhood in a variety of contexts, especially economically, the village study required in-depth information from the women there. As such, my mode of inquiry is primarily qualitative. Long conversations, preceded by rapport building, were the principal means of generating information (see Kvale 1996). I pursued “feminism based” interviewing that emphasizes emotionally engaged and trust-based relationships between a researcher and an interviewee (Oakley 1981). I utilized the oral history method that allowed women, particularly older women, to recount their past and then target those experiences salient to the study goals. As Reinhartz (1992: 126) notes, “oral history . . . creates new material about women, validates women’s experience, enhances communication among women, discovers women’s roots and develops a previously denied sense of continuity.”

I talked with women in various places and social settings that included a courtyard, kitchen, kitchen garden, family shop, farm, and cowshed. The interviewees chose the location for the conversation. Often their “choice” was determined by where they were working. I had to approach some interviewees more than once for them to agree to be interviewed. There was no fixed time for the interview. Some interviews lasted a long time and some were relatively short, but the average interview took a minimum of two hours to complete. Because interviewees often had to attend to other activities and work, interviews were conducted in two or more sessions. Middle-aged women, in particular, could not afford the time required for a long interview. If their work was disrupted, it might never have been completed.

I also interviewed several husbands and local leaders, who were key informants. Another key male informant, who was a former chairperson of the village council, offered a history of the village. Throughout my time in the village I was able to interact with men while walking, stopping for tea, or resting after a long walk on a steep street. Other information was gained by organizing three small-group conversations—two with adult women and one with younger women. Although all these informants, both men and women, offered excellent information and provided their insights, they were not my primary interviewees.

Characteristics of Interviewees

My primary interviewees were 40 married women from patrilocal and patrilineal joint and nuclear households. Patrilocality is the predominant rule of residence in Nepal and in the study village. It is normative for most women to enter into early, village-exogamous marriage. A large majority of interviewees were married off before they reached 18 years of age. Although the majority of the interviewees were spouses to a male head of household, a few were household heads themselves. Most household assets were owned by the male

head of household. A woman would often become the head of a household at the death of her husband. In such cases, women heads of household could also eventually own larger assets. Most of my women interviewees, therefore, did not personally own large assets such as a farm or the house they lived in. It should be noted that 19 percent of women nationally hold titles to farm plots and/or the house (CBS 2012).

The women interviewed differed by generation and belonged to diverse backgrounds, not only in terms of ethnicity and whether they were married to migrant husbands, but also according to class, occupation, education, employment, and marital status. Another important characteristic, related to diversity, is that some women were involved in small-scale savings and credit groups, an important site of public engagement by women. In terms of generation, almost all of the women in the second generation were engaged in community activities. A few in the youngest generation were employed outside of the household. When linked to education, an overwhelming majority in the oldest generation, and a majority in the next generation were illiterate. Although a few of these women did attend literacy classes, their knowledge and skill were limited to barely sketching their names. A few young, married interviewees, however, had completed 12 years of schooling. “Ethnic” and Dalit women, even the younger ones, lagged far behind “high caste” women interviewees in regard to schooling. For women as a group, however, a large majority were primarily engaged in traditional agriculture, while some were engaged in small-scale commercial farming. Only a few women headed households as widows or wives of labor migrants.

ECONOMIC EXPANSION, DIVERSIFICATION, AND EMERGING WOMANHOOD

As noted earlier, economic expansion, while relatively slow at first, has accelerated since the

early 1990s. Nationally, the annual economic growth rate since 1990 has been estimated at 3.5 percent, helping to explain why the nearby large town of Hetauda is expanding rapidly. The highway from Kathmandu to the southern plains of Nepal passes through the town. The study village, in turn, derives employment, income, and social service benefits from the growing town.

While diversification has been fairly rapid nationally, interest here is on occupational and income-source diversification at the household level. Like the nationwide trend, such diversification has been increasing in the households of the study village. It has also given women many more openings and in the process, created newer “womanhoods,” especially when compared to households that are not diversifying. Specifically, this notion of newer womanhood applies to households holding sizable farmland, an asset that allows family members to engage in a variety of non-farm jobs. These households have the necessary skill base and social clout that help create the social space to forge new images of women.

Although women are overburdened, they seek to adapt to, and engage in, a number of emerging jobs. Such engagement sometimes makes contradictory demands. But it is these very contradictions that craft new womanhood. The security that diversification often provides, for example, is a cushioned financial platform from which these women can operate. Such a cushion also enables them to switch between jobs. Because they perform paid jobs, the women are no longer fully dependent upon their husbands or in-laws, thus making gains in personal independence. This sense of enhanced independence is expressed by 45-year-old Januka who runs a family owned shop:

I was married at seventeen years of age. I have been working hard to run this family ever since. My husband was sixteen at that time. I don't fear my husband. I sometimes quarrel with him when he does not help me out to run the shop. He is a

good man. But he sometimes spends time playing cards with other men. Men in this village either go to foreign countries to work or gamble. I don't like husbands who gamble.

Even as traditional agriculture continues to be the dominant mode for livelihood, households in the village have been relying less on agriculture, and more on occupations, and income sources have significantly diversified over the last two decades. Livelihood strategies in almost all households, however, also include subsistence farming and pooling income from various sources, many of which were unavailable only a short time ago. These include remittances, rent, old-age, widow and disability benefits, agricultural and nonagricultural wage work, salaried jobs, investments, shops selling tea or liquor, and even beauty parlors. Domestic rearing of cows and buffalo, and chicken and goat farming, has been longstanding. However, these domestic activities, especially sizable poultry and goat farming, have recently been commercialized. Although these may be small-scale initiatives, they provide women with personal income. The growing and selling of cash crops such as mushrooms, ginger, chili, and tomatoes are additional sources of household and personal income. Normative practices allow women to keep such income for personal use and nobody else in the household, including husbands or in-laws, can lay claim to it.

Remittances by migrant workers in Nepal, Southeast Asia, and West Asia have become a highly salient source of household income. During the last ten years, although both men and women have migrated to other countries for work, men far outnumber women in labor migration. Nationally, a majority (57 percent) of all households in Nepal receive remittance (CBS 2012). Diversification and additional income are also utilized in the learning of new skills and augmenting women's knowledge to negotiate with the wider world, in turn strengthening kinship and friendship networks (Mishra 2015: 93–94).

This was hardly the case even a short time ago. Subsistence farming and agricultural wage work were about the only sources of livelihood for a large majority of households. Agriculture was exclusively rain-fed and rice was the only major crop in the village. Bir Bahadur Tamang, 47, a farmer and a schoolteacher recalls:

We did not know how to grow other crops at the time. We just cultivated rice for subsistence purposes and, to a limited extent, for the market. Most households, however, did not produce enough to sell. Only larger landowners could sell rice. Maize was cultivated in the adjacent higher lands. It was considered food for the poor.

Commercialization of agriculture, while still limited, is changing this pattern since it provides substantial income even for the small landholder. The introduction of ginger in the early 1990s, for example, diversified traditional agriculture, improved productivity, and increased household income for small landholders. In addition, ginger cultivation was possible even in the uplands. Its cultivation became so popular that it had to be sold in the larger markets of Kathmandu and across the border in India. Indeed, ginger was initially regarded as a magic crop! However, the high price for ginger in the larger Indian market did not last long. The price plummeted and household income went down sharply. Households that diversified both crops and income sources were less adversely impacted. Ginger is still grown now but newer cash crops, such as chilies and mushrooms, have been introduced and dairying is making headway. As a result, opportunities for agricultural wage work have increased. The wage rate has increased substantially because of higher cropping intensity and commercial farming. Most importantly, perhaps, an increased supply of labor to the international labor market renders labor scarce in the village, in turn increasing the local wage rate. Even members of the traditional “elite households” now engage in wage work. However, a key downside

of international labor migration comprised primarily of men, is the increase in the work burden of women in the village.

It is primarily middle-aged women who are active in producing and marketing cash crops. Some women in the village have become “women farmer leaders,” a function which requires much skill and one that confers considerable prestige. However, as mentioned earlier, women are also becoming overburdened with work as most of them continue to attend to domestic and farm duties that include marketing. On the other hand, they are also happier because they have earned a higher status at home and in the community. This enhanced sense of well-being allows yet another womanhood to emerge that, unlike some of the images of women in the past, is prized by all.

One key upshot of all these changes has been a substantial decrease in household poverty, which hits women harder. Because opportunities for wage work is mostly taken up by the poor, and because “idle” labor is being put to use internationally, and at a higher wage rate locally, there has been a substantial decrease both in household poverty as well as in household economic inequality. Sita, a middle-aged woman, summarized this dynamic in the following way:

We do not have poor households in the village these days. I mean to say no one has to suffer for two meals a day. Even by engaging in wage labor, they can feed themselves and their families. The wage rate has gone up so much.

Wage work has increased for women as well as men. Apart from a few households with sizable landholdings, all women I spoke with had worked at wage labor. Some would eventually quit wage work as they aged. Some others would quit because their husbands started to earn enough to support the family. But a few also quit because their husbands migrated out for work and the wives had to run the household and the family farm by themselves, lacking the time needed for wage work. Suggesting the sense of well-being

coming from friendship networks, noted above, the women reported that they missed not only the wages but also the camaraderie with other women wage workers.

Unlike in the recent past when women were discouraged from working in non-domestic settings, having a woman earner is now regarded as beneficial for the entire household. The parents-in-law of an employed woman are considered to be fortunate. In such instances, the parents-in-law are very often willing to help with household tasks; this reduces a woman’s domestic burdens, allowing her wage earning to continue.

A few women receive much appreciated old-age and widow benefits, a program that the government initiated in the mid-1990s. The benefits are small in scale but many feel that the income gives them some personal autonomy. This is particularly the case for older women, most of whom had no access to any personal income, and until recently, had no right to inheritance.

Economic expansion, diversification, and reduction of poverty and gender inequality have given women much more freedom. Unlike even in the recent past when women could neither inherit assets nor had acquired the skills to engage in business, one can now find a few women in an altogether unaccustomed vocation—that of a moneylender. Relatively well-off women, wives of labor migrants in particular, lend money to needy villagers at a fairly high rate of interest. Khami, 48, an illiterate mother of four children whose husband works in a Gulf country noted, “I feel good these days because even wives of larger landholders ask me for a loan. Earlier, I used to go them and was often humiliated. I had never thought of the day I would offer them loans. What a change!”

FEMINIZATION OF AGRICULTURE AND WOMANHOOD

Nationally, fewer than 40 percent of men are involved in the agricultural sector while the

proportion of women in the sector exceeds 60 percent. In the village, among households where men are out for labor migration or are engaged in local nonagricultural pursuits, women continue tending to household and caregiving demands of their children, as well as from other members of the household, such as elderly parents-in-law. Subsistence farming and raising cows, buffalo, goats, and chicken are labor and time intensive but are considered normative domestic tasks for women. Women comprise most agricultural wage laborers. Women's networks also facilitate inter-household exchange of labor that may help alleviate some of these burdens. Some fortunate women whose husbands earn a sizable income, also carry out financial duties, such as receiving remittances, banking, investing, and managing the money. Those who are able to manage savings and investments, however, rarely engage in wage work.

Women from poorer households may lease out their farms to other richer households. These poorer women currently participate in "circular migration;" they have otherwise left the village to live, work, and educate their children in better schools in nearby towns and cities. These owners who lease out their farms do not demand much financial return. But they wish to retain the title to the farm and wait to sell it when the price is relatively high. The Dalits, who are the poorest and who often do not own farms themselves, benefit the most from this process. Bimali, a Dalit woman in her late twenties, whose husband works in Kathmandu and comes back home twice a year for planting and harvesting the crops, informed me that she is commercially farming in a small leased-in plot. She mentions that she cultivates tomatoes in the leased plot so she will be able to send her two sons, age six and four, to better schools. These women work hard and are exhausted but are also full of future plans. Owning land is a matter of great pride and huge economic security for women (Agrawal 1994; Ellis 1999).

Agriculture is becoming more and more feminized, especially for women from poorer

households who work on leased-in farms. While feminization of agriculture does restrict women in general from nonagricultural, skilled, higher paying, and urban jobs, poorer women can enhance access to employment and income by farming leased-in farms. Such a farming mode is a "leftover" job, but it does enhance both income and self-respect for poorer women. They are, for the short term at least, better off with it than without it.

Feminization in agriculture is also heavily concentrated among middle-aged women. It is these women who work the family farm. Most young men and many middle-aged men do not necessarily evade farm duties, but remain on the lookout for nonagricultural wage and salaried work and, most important, opportunities for labor migration. One young man with seven years of schooling noted that farming was meant for uneducated and unskilled persons like his parents. Children now go to school and can no longer be expected to help in farming—except during the holidays. A major change from only the previous generation is that young daughters invariably go to school, at least until they are in their early teens. When they get older, all of them would opt out of farming if given a chance. It is thus the middle-aged woman who bears the brunt of farming. Radhika, a woman in her late fifties who also runs a retail store, said:

My granddaughter is glued to either TV or books. She never helps her mother in the kitchen. There is no question of her working in the field. I am fed up with her way of life. As a teenager, she should have at least some sense of womanly things such as cooking and cleaning. But she does not listen to us at all.

Many younger daughters-in-law also work fewer hours at home and on the family farm. They are either at school or college, or learning trades in skill-based training centers. Young married women also continue their education if they wish to. Sundari, a "high" caste woman in her mid-seventies and from a relatively well-off

household, compares womanhood from when she was young with the present:

I compare myself with my granddaughter and granddaughter-in-law. Aged twenty and twenty-two years, respectively, both go to college. Even my daughter-in-law goes out to community and women's group meetings, despite the fact that she was not schooled. What a change! I still recall my times I came to this house as a child bride. My main responsibilities were to give birth. Giving birth to sons was a necessary condition to remaining married. I raised children, cooked, fetched water from a well that was very far from home. I collected fuel wood and fodder from the nearby forests, raised animals, cleaned cowsheds, worked on the family farm, participated in exchange labor and occasionally wage worked in farms. I had no time for anything else. And I did not question the routines in my life because all the women did the same.

NEW SOCIAL NETWORKS AND WOMANHOOD

Friendships that are not attached to the kinship network provide considerable freedom for women and help shape another new womanhood. Expanded public engagement of women, noted earlier, provides the platform that women utilize to form friendship circles. Schools, workplaces, exchange labor gangs, savings and credit groups, and a myriad of local self-help associations provide such platforms. It should be noted that because most of the marriages are patrilocal and village-exogamous, most women are often structurally unable to utilize their parental network. Patrilocality seeks to control the non-domestic activities of a daughter-in-law. Patrilocality also seeks to limit a married daughter's contact with her parents and parental relatives. Village exogamy, in turn, often implies considerable physical distance between residences of parents and in-laws.

Wives of migrants, in particular, seek out and cultivate new friendship circles. Although some

women and their absentee husbands arrange to have an adult relative to come to live with them during the migrant's absence and help with a range of household tasks, this is rather rare. More often, a migrant's wife seeks help from members of the new friendship network, for example, to help with children, and find seasonal labor. Such networks often transcend traditional divisions of caste and ethnicity. The women share farm work, lend money to one another, and cooperate in a variety of ways. They also share the distress and joy of being migrants' wives, a similar pattern in other parts of Nepal (Adhikari and Hobley 2015).

Occasionally, the friendship circle cultivated by a migrant worker husband in his place of work, serves as an instigator of a similar arrangement among wives (and sometimes entire families) in villages of Nepal (Mishra 2015: 93). Notes are exchanged among migrants' wives about their husbands' work that encompass a host of activities and issues, including income, work hardships, sickness, job uncertainty, employer regulations, the nature of telephone conversations with husbands, and even "bad behavior" of husbands. They also exchange notes on the nature of their relationship with their husbands (Mishra 2015: 94).

Wives of migrants report that farm work is becoming increasingly difficult. In the absence of the husband, a woman is most often overburdened with work. Male labor is scarce and the wage rate is high. On the other hand, wives of migrants often cannot quit farming because their farms are subsistence and even in a limited sense, also commercial. They grow both their food staples as well as produce what can be marketed, such as tomatoes, ginger, and green vegetables. Income from marketed crops helps maintain the household, meets the schooling costs of children, and provides for personal expenditures. Juna, a young wife of a migrant worker, explains:

We can't leave agriculture altogether. We were born into it and we are living our lives with it. I just hope

my sons, aged six and four, have a better future. If they do well in education, they would not have to work fields as we did for the whole of our life.

HUSBANDS' INDEPENDENT INCOME AND WOMANHOOD

Wives with husbands who earn sizable incomes do not work on the family farm as much those whose husbands earn less, especially if the wife lives within a joint family arrangement. There is also a tendency for a joint family to “split” if one of the sons or brothers earns a sizable income and others do not. The “sizable earning” conjugal unit sometimes sets up an independent kitchen within a “joint” roof. The children of the nuclear unit, nonetheless, are cared for by members of the larger family unit, most often by grandparents.

Among labor migrant households, some “sizable earning” households have already moved away from farming and agricultural wage work, with others preparing to do so. The male migrant husband now sends funds directly to his wife—and not to his own parents, which was often the rule earlier. Young or middle-aged wives in nuclear households with husbands who earn sizable incomes, however, are often confined to domesticity and childcare. They do not work on the family farm nor do they raise goats or cows for personal income. However, they spend relatively more time saving and investing their husbands' earnings, caring for children, and planning for the future.

For example, Munu, age 33, and the wife of a labor migrant to Japan who is earning a good income, considers herself more privileged than others in the village. Privilege here is defined as not having to work on the farm or raise cows, buffaloes, goats, and chicken; and, perhaps more important for the image of a new womanhood, not having to live under the control of in-laws. Bina, 25, and a sister-in-law of Munu, whose

husband is preparing to go to Japan, is beginning to regard *all* farm activities as rather demeaning. She considers such tasks to belong to the “rustic people.” As such, she is beginning to distance herself from all such tasks. Bina's story reveals how a substantial increase in income could lead to the creation of a new womanhood:

I have stopped cleaning the cowshed for quite some time now. I feel dirty if I have to handle a dung cake. I know my mother-in-law is not happy with me. But I don't pay much attention to her. She is a village woman. She does not know other kinds of life. Even village women back bite upon me. But I don't care. Because they don't know how people in the city live. I never liked farm work and village life. I had always dreamt of city life. That is why my parents married me to an educated man. My husband says my main duty is to take care of my son who is now two years old. We have a shared dream of a much better future for him. We are even planning to leave the village to live in Hetauda [the nearby bustling town and the district headquarters]. I don't listen to the others these days. I only listen to my husband, nobody else.

Importantly, Bina's husband is fully on her side when there is a dispute in the household regarding work-sharing.

In contrast, Juneli, 63, the mother-in-law of Munu and Bina, was married at nine years of age. She became a mother at fifteen and gave birth to six children, only four of which survived past childbirth. She also had three miscarriages in between. She spent the whole of her life giving birth, raising children, householding, working on the family farm, and raising cows, buffaloes, and goats. Since she had a smallholding, she also worked for a wage. She contrasts her womanhood with that of her daughters-in-law and notes:

I cannot now recall my wedding because I was too young then. I was a child really. My husband was nine years older than me. I was afraid of my

husband and mother-in-law. I still fear them. My mother-in-law is now 90. All my life I have spent on household chores and farming. My mother-in-law was controlling. I was so afraid of her anger. When she was angry with us daughters-in-law, she would refuse us food. My daughters-in-law, on the other hand, do not fear me. They don't even work the family farm. I have no control over them. They don't listen to me. Daughters-in-law are more powerful than we aged women. They do not listen to me because their husbands earn independently and hand over the income to them. My own husband had no independent earnings. We all worked on the family farm. He did not listen to me. Even today, after so many years of living together, he still does not listen to me.

HEADSHIP OF HOUSEHOLD AND NEW WOMANHOOD

Headship of a household has very often been historically gendered in such a way that a man—mostly the most senior man, functions as the “chief” of a household, particularly in a joint household. New notions of womanhood, on the other hand, have overwhelmingly implied *absence* of headship. As indicated in the life histories presented, womanhood and subordination have often simultaneously “walked together.” However, nuclear families, which were also often headed by men, probably outnumbered the rest at any one point during the last 100 years or more. In addition, a short life span precluded the numerical dominance of the joint family, a pattern that applied to the study village as well.

It is interesting that in the village there has been an increase in claims of headship by women. The claims, however, are made rather covertly, in a rather nonassertive manner. Wives of migrants become *de facto* heads of their households. They often cannot claim headship when their husbands are around for an extended period of time. But since some men have become

long-term labor migrants, women now have the opportunity to function as head of her household. A husband might come back periodically but he would leave again within a few months. Even when the husband is present, he might have lost touch with the community. It is often the wife who has taken over what, until recently, would have been the responsibilities of her husband, such as paying the bills and interacting with village authorities, schoolteachers, repairmen, and wage workers. Despite the fact women are taking on all these activities, the norms are still against women's headship. Parbati, a 39-year-old woman noted:

My husband has been in Kuwait for the last two years. I now function as the head of our household. But he will become the head once he gets back home. This is the tradition of the village. Who would consider a woman the head of the household? Regardless of how much effort we put up in running a household we are valued less than men.

In some other instances headship remains contested. If the husband is much older, sickly, disabled, and unable to function fully, and if it is the wife who runs a household, she often makes a claim to headship. Kanchhi, age 65, tells a similar story:

My 74-year-old husband can't work in the field because of age. He only tends to the goats. I have been performing all householding chores by myself for the last seven years. Although I am getting old myself, I have no one to share the burden with. That is why I think I am the head of the household. By the way, I forgot to tell you that I also have the title to this house, very small as it is. We also bought a small plot of land with the funds generated from wage work performed by all members of the family. Everyone worked. But I contributed the most.

Kanchhi's husband, who came from a landed household in another district but migrated here as a poor person because the floods washed

away his farms, however, does not agree with Kanchhi. He says:

I am getting older. I can't work much. My wife does most of the things these days. I feel bad. As a woman, how could she run a family like a man does? I am always worried what will happen to us old persons some years ahead. As of now, however, I am the head of the household.

Kanchhi, who was listening to our conversation, did not utter a word, but her expression showed a sharp dissatisfaction with her husband's comments.

Another woman, Sarita, age 48, runs her household mostly from her own earnings. She earns from farming, wage work, and selling goats. She is also involved in exchange labor. She and her husband have four children, two daughters and two sons. The daughters are studying and working in Kathmandu. They independently maintain themselves there, but cannot support her. The sons, both with ten years of schooling, are looking for nonagricultural jobs and are reluctant to work in the fields. Her husband, who is 50, occasionally finds work as a carpenter. He tells her he is too old for farm work. Sarita considers herself the head of the household also because she finds herself more responsible for running the household. She argues:

I am the one responsible for feeding all of us. If I don't work hard, the household stops running. Besides, I own this house. I earned a small sum through several income-generating activities and bought this small plot of land where this house stands. That was 15 years ago. My husband does not want to work in the field. Nor does he raise domestic animals that could be sold in the market. He says he is much too old to work in the fields. In fact, he is only two years older than I am. I know people won't accept a woman as the head of a household. Regardless, I think I am the head of this household.

Her husband, with whom I had a brief chat about this, however, disagreed with Sarita's claim.

He flatly said: "Who else? I am the head of the household."

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

Rural Nepal has been transforming rapidly over the last 20 years. As elsewhere in Nepal, the economy has gradually expanded and diversified. Most notably the structure of production is becoming less skewed to agriculture, and more skewed to areas such as the service sector, which is drawing more rural migrants to rapidly growing urban areas in Nepal, as well as to international destinations for work. Changes in the structure of production have enhanced the magnitude of occupational and income diversification. The rural wage rate in general and the agricultural wage rate in particular have gone up rapidly. All these processes have substantially decreased household poverty and overall inequality. Women's schooling and literacy have also made impressive headways. The fertility rate, as well as both maternal and child mortality, has sharply declined, thus bringing down the "reproductive burden" of women. Inclusionary policies in education, jobs, and political representation have begun to generate a positive influence on the lives and well-being of women. Consequently, the construction of gender and gender relations has changed significantly. In turn, these changes have laid fertile groundwork for the emergence of new womanhood even as traditional womanhood also remains strong.

This study validates the significance of some macro-variables within a micro-context, especially in a context that is done with the aid of qualitative research techniques, such as a life history approach. This research has identified salient factors that point to new womanhood, such as economic expansion and occupational and income-source diversification, even within a patrilineal and patrilocal form of household. Other key economic factors are the independent

earning base of a conjugal unit in general, and the husband in particular, and the feminization of agriculture. Emerging womanhood is also influenced by the generation and age of a husband and a wife, as well as their respective health status. It is the labor migration of men that may have the most influence on the creation of new womanhood. Men's absence can lead to the evolution of particular kinds of social networks. Taken together, these shape and reshape beliefs and norms about headship of a household.

Finally, although most women have gained in economic and political power during recent decades, the ambiguity and divergent perceptions in regard to the headship of a household shows that, although patriarchal norms may be weakening, they remain very strong. Similarly, it is both surprising and disheartening that it is primarily a husband's independent earning—and not that of his wife—that is often the key factor that leads to new womanhood. Ironically, a rise in a husband's income—and very possibly wealth—may squeeze out his wife's income producing role, forcing her to return to a life of domesticity. In this case, although womanhood is associated with positive outcomes, a new one may emerge which does just the opposite. This potential scenario is yet another path to explore with further research.

Overall, however, assuming that macro and local trends of the last two decades continue, it is likely that women in the village will increasingly and confidently interface with the public domain and take on non-domestic roles by choice that will enhance the well-being of themselves and their families. As more women and wives earn independently, it is expected, too, that they will gain more equity with their husbands.

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Chapter twenty-three

Negotiating Gendered Violence in the Public Spaces of Indian Cities

Globalization and Urbanization in Contemporary India

Subhadra Mitra Channa

INTRODUCTION

In contemporary India, violence against women and their bodies expresses itself in many diverse ways. Female feticide in India, for example, describes the illegal but widely practiced abortion of a female fetus after an ultrasound, used ostensibly to screen for fetal abnormalities (Larsen 2011). Even the routine lecherous looks from men on public transport, and pervasive sexual harassment at the workplace, may be regarded as precursors of the all too common sexual assault and murder of girls and women escalating throughout India. A woman reportedly is raped every 15 minutes in India (Khan 2016). The city of Delhi, the capital of a modern and seemingly progressive nation, also has the dubious reputation of being one of the most unsafe places for women in the country. With 1,813 reported rapes in 2014, up 1,441 from the previous year, Delhi has earned the disreputable label of “rape capital” of India (Rukmini 2016). This is indeed a shock for earlier generations under British rule, who claimed moral superiority focused primarily on the “purity” of Indian women, and the respect accorded to the Hindu goddesses gracing Indian

homes, who continue to be worshipped and accorded high status (Chatterjee 1993; Channa 2013a). “Respect” for women is a metanarrative, built into an escalating right-wing Hindu nationalism that demonizes the “other,” both Muslim and Western women, often on these very premises. Stories abound in North India, in particular about hordes of Muslim invaders who forced Hindu women into *purdah*, creating a culture of confinement, symbolized by veiling when venturing outside their homes. Apart from how facts are recorded, these invasions live in the collective imagination and in popular culture of fiction, and folklore, and feed into the construction of what is understood as “communal history” (Thapar 2002: 19). This worldview also questions the lack of purity of Western women, maligned for their disregard for feminine virtues of modesty and honor, building up a model of virtue in the ancient period of Hindu history, and lamenting at its loss.

What is happening in India’s megacities, however, is not to be understood only in reference to the past. It is a product of the contemporary forces of globalization and the accompanying, often profound, social and lifestyle changes it

ushered in. Modernity has come as a mixed blessing for women, making some things better in their lives, but in certain ways, making some things worse (Channa 2004). There is increasing tension between the aspirations and desires that women are acquiring as a result of education and global exposure, and the persistence of regressive values and patriarchy in the domains in which they are expected to negotiate their lives. Indians have begun to enjoy the benefits of globalization (van Dijk 2017: 20) but at some cost, especially to women and the marginal urban poor.

This chapter focuses on the city of Delhi and its surrounding region, and is based on media reports, my ongoing anthropological research, and although anecdotal, my personal experiences as a Delhi-born woman and lifelong resident. I am at present engaged in a restudy of the Dhobi (washermen¹) community whom I had studied intensively in the 1970s (Channa 1985) and with whom I have kept up my social interactions. I have been deeply influenced and reshaped by my intensive engagement with this marginal, lower-caste community (Channa 2013b). I follow what is referred to as “participatory, intersectional anthropological praxis,” whereby engaging in an intimate intersubjective relationship with my field, I believe I am able to override the hierarchy that exists between the researcher and the researched (Harrison 1991; Hosbey 2016: 307). I also share my reflections as a woman who continues to negotiate her way in the various public spaces of Delhi. This complex and historical city provides the backdrop against which I have analyzed contemporary gender relations, focusing on violence against the female body.

DELHI: A BRIEF SOCIAL, POLITICAL, AND HISTORICAL SKETCH

Delhi is situated in India’s Northwest, the cultural region known as the Hindi Belt. It is strongly influenced by the culture of large numbers of

Punjabi migrants, perhaps India’s original refugees, who fled their homes after the “Great Partition” in 1947. Coinciding with India’s independence from Britain, partition created the country of Pakistan, led to the displacement of 15 million, and resulted in the deaths of more than a million in the bloody Hindu-Muslim violence during the exchange of population. The demography of Delhi changed almost overnight, from being dominated by the Muslim aristocrats and the British colonial rulers, to a city of refugees and migrants who were engaged in a fierce struggle for life on its streets. These streets had seen the flow of blood and rape and murder, not only during the riots of Partition but also in earlier times, as successions of invaders plundered the city. Delhi is a city that has witnessed violence and political turmoil for centuries. For example, not only was Delhi and its surrounding regions the site of wars, recounted in India’s mythological epics such as the *Mahabharata*, dating from the ninth century BCE, but also sixteenth-century battles setting the stage for the Mughal Empire (1526–1857), that exerted control over much of the subcontinent of India. Delhi remained the seat where bloody power struggles were clinched, with the British storming the city in 1857, overthrowing the last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar (Hennessy 1925). This history suggests that violence is routinely played out during such times, and despite norms regarding their personal and sexual safety, women were its likely victims. These norms varied according to caste and rank, but nonetheless, applied to almost all women and girls.

The colonial period also saw the enhancement of the physical space of the city of Delhi with the building of New Delhi. Today the city of Delhi is divided into what is referred to as the “Old City” (or the Walled City), and New Delhi, the planned city, architecturally known as “Lutyen’s Delhi,” the seat of political power of the newly formed Indian nation. Along with ever expanding new neighborhoods, rural hinterlands are rapidly eroding as “development becomes concentrated in

selected urban enclaves” (Kuldova and Varghese 2017: 2). Delhi constitutes the integral part of the National Capital Region (NCR), administratively functioning to aid inter-state regional planning. Given Delhi’s massive demographic shifts, however, NCR has barely kept up to its promise of being a well-planned and functional urban space (Kuldova 2017). Following the refugee influx of 1947, especially from its poorer regions, today almost 40 percent of Delhi’s population consists of what is known as “floating population.” We will see how these shifts impact caste, gender equations, and ultimately, violence against women in the region.

The Old City is identified with the walled city of Shajehanabad, built by the emperor Shah Jahan, in the seventeenth century on the banks of the river Yamuna. The original inhabitants of the Old City were primarily Muslim, descendants of the Mughal rulers who made Delhi the center of their empire, as well as converts from the local Hindus, especially from the lower castes. The local Hindu caste groups included the trading caste of Baniyas, or the “Aggarwals,” the Brahmins of North India, and the Kayastha communities, who historically served as scribes in the Moghul courts. There were also large numbers of lower castes, providing many kinds of services to these upper castes, like the washing of clothes, cutting of hair, cleaning of toilets and streets, vending vegetables, and working as butchers, leather workers, and water carriers. As caste was the prevalent cultural norm, both Hindus and Muslims were served by these lower-caste communities. Each group had its own counterpart, like Muslim Dhobi (washermen) and Hindu Nai (barbers). The caste-based services included valuable work provided by women. Most caste-based occupations also had a gender-based division of labor that allowed women of these castes to move around in the public space of the city, although, as we will see, for them the definition of “public” was different (Channa 2013a). Although the upper castes dominated and determined the “space” of the city, with the marginal castes

segregated, everyone lived in close physical proximity to one another.

The city expanded with urbanization and exploded with globalization, opening industries, creating various new occupations, and more diversified streams for income and cash flow. Delhi has more cash flow and easier avenues for income than other parts of the nation. India represents the largest expanding middle class in South Asia.

From 72 million people, South Asia could have a billion middle-class consumers by 2025, representing one-quarter of the global total. South Asia would become a largely middle-class region, with India’s middle class having the same share of its population, as the United States does today.

(Kharas 2011: 68)

Urbanization has gentrified marginal neighborhoods, pushing out the lower classes to make way for restaurants, boutiques, business houses, and what Kuldova (2017: 39) refers to as “Luxotopias.” In Old Delhi, I found that some of the residential neighborhoods of the Dhobi have been vacated to build apartment or shopping complexes.

Major state-run development projects continue to displace and dispossess the poor. Two decades of modernization and expansion of the Indira Gandhi International Airport—now the tenth busiest airport in Asia—for example, displaced several villages, with many of those displaced still unable to find permanent, affordable homes in the city. Ongoing state projects like airport, highway, and subway construction, employ large numbers of laborers, both men and women, from the poorer classes, sometimes the ones displaced from these very sites. Cash flows in quickly but it is intermittent, and abruptly ends on project completion. Many laborers find themselves homeless and penniless, relying on informal sector work, with little monetary compensation.

Despite the work of NCR, the orthogenetic progress of Delhi has proceeded in a haphazard and unplanned manner, leaving islands of rural life surrounded by the megastructures of a rapidly

modernizing city. In Delhi, it is common to see huts and vestiges of “rural looking” communities next to five-star hotels, high-rise office buildings, and massive commercial and shopping complexes. It is also a city that beckons to the poor and marginal from all over India, as a place that promises money, prosperity, and the enticement of a good life. Migrants often leave their families behind, trying to maximize savings, with dreams to return home, to rebuild a house, to buy land, or to earn sufficient income for providing dowry to get a daughter married. These dreams are quickly shattered as most of the migrant poor find themselves on the streets, under bridges or huddled in slums with no amenities. Yet Delhi, like other megacities of India, such as Mumbai, Kolkata, and Bangalore, keeps attracting more and more of this floating population. Some may succeed partially in their dreams. But a larger number remain with shattered hopes, facing the violence of a city with extreme contrasts of rich and poor.

As Delhi began to absorb surrounding rural hinterland, a large amount of land was converted to “modern” sectors, leading to the creation of new residential and commercial areas. There are significant differences of lifestyle and values in the city’s three sectors: the conservative Old City, the aristocratic New Delhi, housing the political, social, and economic elite, and the newly developed zones with a mixed class/caste population. Although commercialized and overcrowded, the Old City sector still retains some remnants of the traditional style of living. It has closer-knit communities and neighborhoods, and based on my analysis of newspaper reports, the crime rate is significantly less than in the newly built parts of Delhi. Delhi, therefore, has a pattern of crime and violence that is less associated with the simple question of poverty, than with life in the so-called developing sector that has greater economic differentiation and cultural diversity. Until recently, the richest and poorest sectors have touched but have not mingled. These interactions were structured within the ambit of caste

relations. Each had its own versions of the others, and stereotypes abounded.

This is the backdrop to understand escalating violence against women as it coalesces with class, caste, and gender. We will see that the targets of this violence are often those from the newly developed areas of Delhi where interaction between the sectors is becoming more common. For all these groups, cultural attitudes and norms about appropriate gender behavior are in a state of flux, more likely for women, but not as likely for men.

RAVAGED BODIES, DESTROYED LIVES

I report on three cases of violence toward women, illustrative of the clash of beliefs about gender when encounters with men take violent turns.

The first case took place on May 13, 2017, the eve of Mother’s Day, when people across India were shocked by the rape and horrific murder of a 23-year-old Dalit woman in Haryana, just on the border of Delhi. *Dalit* is a term used to refer to the lower castes in India, especially those under the label of “untouchable.” The woman was abducted by car near her home, drugged, and gang-raped by a group of four men. Sharp objects had been inserted into her genital areas, and her skull was smashed. The relatives of the victim claimed that police ignored a previous complaint filed against one of the men, whom she apparently knew, accusing the police of not taking the complaint seriously (*Hindustan Times* 2017).

Let us take a look at a second case, the assault on a 45-year-old woman journalist who was grievously injured when taking her regular walk in a popular park near her home. A 22-year-old man arrested in her attack was described by police as a drug addict and alcoholic, who drank regularly in the park and periodically stalked the journalist, to “watch (her) walk.” Reportedly rebuffed when attempting to initiate a conversation, he became enraged, striking her with a rock,

causing severe brain injuries. She was found bleeding and unconscious by a passerby (*India Times* 2017; NDTV 2017a). Both these crimes are grim reminders of perhaps one of the most brutal murders of a woman that riveted India in 2012. Known as the “Nirbhaya”² case, a young paramedical student was out shopping with her boyfriend; they boarded a bus in the evening, happening to be the only passengers. Others on board were the driver, helper, and conductor, and their three male friends. The couple was assaulted, the male companion brutally beaten, and the woman subjected to horrific torture, apart from being repeatedly raped. Both of them were then pushed out of the running bus and presumably left to die. The woman’s boyfriend managed to revive himself and get help. After struggling for life for some days, she died. She managed to identify the men who had ravaged her and her testimony, along with that of her boyfriend, lodged the perpetrators in jail, where one committed suicide, one was put in a juvenile detention center for the maximum three-year sentence, and the four others received the death sentence (NDTV 2017b).

The death sentence was supposed to have acted as a deterrent to similar crimes, but as the crime record from that fateful day to the present indicates, the sentence has had no such effect. Even as this chapter is being written, crimes of rape and murder are being reported on a daily basis. As the mother of the murdered Dalit women said, “When the accused in the Nirbhaya case were punished, our village spoke about the verdict. We thought at least this will deter men, but unfortunately, even today, girls are not safe and men are not scared” (NDTV 2017c). There seems no respite.

Now let us look a bit deeper into what contributed to triggering these incidents. Except for the attacks, what does a Dalit of the untouchable class, a journalist, and a paramedical student have in common? The Dalit woman was working as a packer in a pharma company, hoping to save money for college, but also helping with family finances, when she was abducted near

her home. The journalist was smart, educated, a respected writer, and middle-class. She had a good income and moved independently. She was assaulted walking home from a park. The paramedical student was raped and murdered, also in a public space, in this case a bus. All three women stepped out of the bounds of cultural and gender-prescribed norms and were punished or died for doing so.

Before the technological revolution and economic liberalization (globalization), most people lived fairly segregated lives that only touched marginally. Seen as part of God-ordained “natural order,” hegemonic control by elite castes was widespread. The poor accepted their fate with resignation and as a result of their own misdeeds (Karma), in this and the past lives. The rich accepted theirs with arrogance. Whatever charity and welfare was practiced was in the garb of acquiring religious merit, within the same religious ideology often used to justify these inequalities in the first place.

Although the consequences of globalization continue to be debated, it has ushered in a strengthening of democratic values, social justice, and political will to work toward greater equality. With these strengthened values, the passive acceptance of one’s condition is being challenged. The media, through television and radio, easily and cheaply available to rich and poor alike, also spreads messages of hope and possibilities of social mobility. Even ubiquitous Bollywood, a usually affordable staple of people’s lives, are showing more movies, which ostensibly at least, call into question the belief that status cannot be, or should not, be changed.

At the same time, the media’s visual images overshadow the stark economic and demographic realities continuing to divide rich and poor, and men and women, throughout Delhi. Screen images of love, sexuality, and independence, for example, run counter to the lives of both men and women, regardless of class. Most people rely on family and kin to arrange meetings with suitable marriage partners. Those who

venture into sexual relationships outside of marriage indulge in hurried sex in brothels, cars, and cheap hotels. The rich may have the world at their feet, but most marry according to family negotiations rather than personal choice.

Demographic and economic realities collide, too, because of the extremely skewed sex ratio in India. The 2011 census indicates that in the state of Gujarat, there were 6.29 hundred thousand unmarried men between the ages of 30–40 years, and only 886 girls per 1,000 boys in the 0–6 age group. It is important to mention Gujarat since it is one of the most economically well-off regions in India, and the location of some of the biggest industrial houses (Ministry of Home Affairs 2011). Data for Delhi indicate a 2013 sex ratio of only 866 females per 1,000 males (Panditl 2014). Like Gujarat, Delhi is one of the most highly urbanized and economically well-off regions of India. It is the base of India's power elite and has more modern facilities than anywhere else in the country. Haryana, the state adjoining Delhi, has a sex ratio of 879 females per 1,000 males (Ministry of Home Affairs 2011). Reports also indicate the rampant sale of women into this region, where wives are often bought (UN Women 2014). Men at the lower end of the social and economic ladder may never manage to find a bride.

Men from better-off families with disposable cash income frequent bars, dance halls, and brothels for paid or unpaid sex. These men may come from so-called traditional households where marriages are arranged by kin. As we will see, however, these non-marital sexual liaisons are justified by the belief that the women in these liaisons are not “decent,” *because* they are available and sexually active. Marriages in India continue to be for the family and are rarely for the couple's self-fulfillment or enjoyment.

Family narratives and the depiction of feudal society in literature and academic writings reinforce the disheartening belief that extramarital sexual activity can be legitimate, and the exploitation of *some* women acceptable, especially from those women in the lower castes (Channa

2013a: 71). The bodies of Dalit women were always there for exploitation by upper-caste men in a socially sanctioned and approved manner. Within the joint household, a young widow was often the object of lust by her own affinal kin. These activities were known, but took place covertly. Their ravaged bodies were already set apart and constructed as “available.”

In India, the role of the extended family and community was often to cover up rather than prevent the sexual exploitation of vulnerable women (Channa 1998). In the traditional Old City, people lived in the *mohalla*, a residential neighborhood of close social networks. The architecture of the houses facilitated the easy mixing of people on the streets. Each house had a kind of projected platform outside where people, usually older retired men and women, sat and watched people going by. Most persons were known to each other and greeted each other in a familiar way. These conversations were carried out throughout the day and even late into the night. What any one was doing and what was happening inside any home was practically common knowledge. Even today remnants of this kind of social interaction exist in the Old City. Anonymity is rare and a kind of collective vigilance is practiced. Walking down these lanes, I still meet elderly men sitting outside their homes, keeping an eye on whatever is happening, and keeping up a conversation with most people passing by.

New housing complexes in the developing sector of Delhi, however, are built with closed-in apartments that do not allow for ease of communication, even with those living in close proximity. There is no place for people to sit outside their homes, so interaction with neighbors is very limited. Village communities have also been broken as migrants, disconnected from their families, move into these neighborhoods. In India, the moral sanctions largely emerge from a person's embeddedness in the community and social networks. People act according to “what others will say.” When pushed into the anonymity of this

kind of city life without community and social support, violence may follow.

As typified by Delhi, urban India is caught in an imperfect exposure to alien worlds that appear to be too glamorous for the harsh realities of existence in a Third World economy. Indian society is historically informed by certain values where gender constructs intersect, and indeed collide, with those of caste and class. Only if we can understand some of these values can we contextualize some of the gender-related violence in contemporary India. It is important to note, however, that being disconnected from a community may *explain* a path to violence, but should never be used to *justify* ensuing behavior. Although social disruption is ushered in with globalization, the idea that any violent turns are inevitable and cannot be thwarted, is unacceptable.

CASTE, CLASS, GENDER AND THE "RIGHT" WAY TO LIVE

The streets in India are negotiated by each person, placing himself or herself in relation to others, and in turn, being evaluated by appearance, age, gender, and other social markings that indicate caste, class, and social personhood. The way one is likely to be treated on the street, whether walking, driving, or riding the subway, depends a lot on how one's identity is recognized and one's body language evaluated, in turn rendering a collective cultural judgment of one's appropriateness or inappropriateness to be present at a particular time in a particular place.

A Hindu worldview, and by default of most of peninsular India, is informed by the general concept of *dharma* (appropriate action). It can be seen more as a cultural rather than a religious term. Whenever an Indian is referring to *dharma*, he or she is more likely to be talking of "appropriate action" than religion *per se*. The Indian worldview also does not look at living beings as equal, equivalent, or uniform. The animate world,

both human and non-human, is divided into species-like divisions called *jatis*. The term *jati* may be used to refer to gender, caste, ethnic group, or any other category that is used as an identity marker. As Inden (1976) elaborated from his study of Hindu scriptures and texts, the Hindu body is not of an individual, but the embodiment of a *jati*, composed of various elements such as food that one eats, air that one breathes, soil in which one is born, and worship material that one chants, all passed down from one's parents, both mother and father. A person of "correct" *jati*, hence personhood, is only born through a "proper" marriage, a *vivaha* that takes place with the gift of a daughter from one *kula* (descent group) to another. "One of the specific purposes of marriage was to provide a caste and its clans with children, and especially sons, embodying the coded substance of their parent's caste and clan" (Inden 1976: 92).

Thus each *jati* has its appropriate *dharma*, and each social status (householder, wife, husband, child, parent, teacher, pupil etc.), has an appropriate code of conduct. In popular culture and folklore, it is believed that each *jati* has its own innate nature and ways of doing things. A being following its own *jati dharma*, therefore, cannot be accused of wrongdoing, for that is what it is *supposed* to be doing. This being said, the very ambiguity of such a differentiated universe makes every action open to debate and conflicting evaluations. A folktale illustrates this ambiguity.

A sage saw a snake drowning. He took pity on it and fished it out of the water. As soon as the snake came out it bit the person who had rescued it. When the sage asked it, "Why did you bite? I saved your life." The snake replied, it is my dharma to bite. I cannot help it. The sage realized that the snake had done nothing wrong and he forgave it.

A contemporary version of the folktale related to this chapter's focus on ambiguous images of women, can be applied to international tennis star, Sania Mirza. I was watching a television

show where some middle-aged Muslim men were interviewed about the appropriateness of this Muslim girl appearing in public wearing a short dress. All the men said that there was nothing wrong in her wearing a short tennis dress to play. "It is the appropriate dress to be worn to play. What is wrong in that? We are proud of her. She has done her community and her country proud. However, we will not support her wearing such dresses when she is not playing."

In India, this notion is known as *desh-kaal* (place and time) appropriateness of action, and is inherent in the culturally collective thought process. There are rarely any rules that are fixed, and they can also be manipulated according to the situation. This notion of appropriateness is also operative on the roads and public spaces. There are some bodies that can be seen in certain places and some that cannot be seen. Those that are "out of place" can be subjected to punishment. Young men who assault women, for example, are often defended by the elders, saying it is their jati dharma to be attracted to women. They cannot help it. But reinforced by victim-blame ideology, the women must take care of themselves.

With jati lurking in the background, the appropriateness of action in India is largely determined by one's class and caste. Gender narratives that challenge victim-blame for women venturing into a world offering more independence are subverted to those based on more important ones related to class and caste. Throughout India, the most deprived belong to the lowest castes or Dalit ranks, and women rank lower than men, even within these ranks. The women of these marginalized communities have always engaged in labor outside of their homes. They have been subjected to physical and sexual exploitation and with impunity. Upper-class men have claimed them as a matter of right and caste privilege. Upper-caste women, however, are not supposed to be seen in public, or to be working outside of the home. If they are employed, they should be in high-status, prestigious jobs congruent with their status. Most middle and upper-class families do

not allow their daughters, wives, and daughters-in-law to travel by public transport. Thus in South Asia as a whole, women have been accepted as heads of state, because of their family/caste status. Those who are wives and daughters of rulers are entitled to rule themselves. However, even they are secluded from the ordinary public (Channa 2004, 2013). Again, these beliefs demonstrate that the violence perpetrated on poor women, or on upwardly mobile women, whether richer or poorer, for stepping out of bounds is seen as justified. Norms remain unscathed and victims are blamed for perceived gender-norm transgressions.

With economic liberalization and globalization, a large number of aspiring women have begun to venture outside the home for schooling, work, and recreation with non-kin. The three victims of violence described earlier demonstrate that these women fall into a gray area, not represented by either the lower ranks of working women who participate in the manual labor force, or women of elite families. Until the 1970s, many upper and middle-class women did not work even after graduating from college, or worked in highly skilled professional jobs, such as professors, schoolteachers, lawyers, and doctors. Few women worked in lower-level white-collar jobs. If they did, they were looked upon as being in dire circumstances and in need of money.

Since the 1990s, as the economy opened up, women began working in lower-level, semi-skilled white-collar jobs, like in offices for data entry, call centers, hotels, and stores catering to the well-off. Commercial establishments flooded the market with earning opportunities. Women entering these white-collar jobs were mostly from poorer but upwardly mobile families. These also included many young migrant women from rural areas and small towns, coming to Delhi with many dreams and aspirations (Dicky 2002).

When these women come to the city, they tend to live in paying guest accommodations (popularly known as PG). They go to work on public transport, and dress as fashionably as they can

afford. These women are often major breadwinners for their families. In the city they occupy an ambiguous position. They are not equivalent to the women who are typically seen on the streets: the women of the lower castes, the traditional working women, whose presence goes unnoticed, such as the ubiquitous Dhobi caste women, who are to be seen ironing clothes on makeshift platforms in every corner of urban Delhi. Nor are they from the scavenging caste group, such as women who sweep the city streets. They do not belong to the construction labor force where husband, wife, and family members often work together on the ongoing building projects in the city. They are not power holders, to whom men pay respect out of deference to their elite class. These two groups are women—both richer and poorer—typify those who are accepted as fulfilling their caste dharma, or are in “appropriate” positions in the city space. The “middle range” women are not.

If we examine the victims of reported rape and other forms of violence in general, and the three victims whose stories are described in this chapter in particular, the violence is most often directed to those women who inhabit Delhi’s “middle range” locales and workplaces. The smartly dressed, but not quite elite young women, who are seen traveling unescorted by public transport, walking in parks, or stepping out at night to restaurants with other women from their workplaces, often become targets of abuse. Men justify the abuse by “othering” the women they abuse. They do not identify them with the women of their own families. “They are not like our mothers and sisters!” (Channa 2004).

Blurring caste and gender lines, outrage is conditioned by the social status of the victim. Even the involvement of many Indians, as represented by civil society, is often contingent on whether the victim is from their own strata, or there is some way they can identify with her. This may explain why collective outrage is not found in the almost routine murder, rape, and torture of Dalit women, women from the slums, women

from tribes, and even women who belong to the ethnic minorities. To reiterate, Indian society is compartmentalized and hierarchical, and any constructive forces of globalization and economic liberalization so far have not found a place within the historically received value system still operative among the majority of the population. Appropriate actions, roles, and images remain informed by existing caste/class hierarchies. Concepts of *jati* and *dharma* still dominate the collective consciousness. Discussions related to misogyny and victim-blame are subverted to those related to class and caste, and existing norms go unchallenged.

MARKING BODIES IN THE PUBLIC SPACE

The public debate on gender appropriateness is depicted in the movie *Pink*, about four young women from small towns near Delhi, belonging to not so well-off families. They are trying to live independent lives, but in doing so, “proper conduct” for these young women may be violated. Not surprisingly, people in India tend to put blame on the women for negative repercussions occurring, since they are not playing according to rules. In the movie, the young men who harass and intimidate these young women plead innocence. These women transgressed the norms of being “decent” women, simply for being invited to dinner and having few drinks. The irony is that these are “inappropriate” acts, and signal to these same young men issuing the invitations that they can take advantage of the women. The refusal of these young women to oblige these men is taken as an affront to their masculinity that in the movie triggers violence and sexual assault.

The attitude of the young men in the movie also reflects the attitude of the rapist in the 2012 rape and murder case. The oldest man in the group, who was married and the patriarch of a family, reportedly said that if the girl had not

struggled so much and had been compliant, they would not have gone to the extent of brutalizing her. In the courtroom he practically blamed the girl for her arrogance. “*We had to teach her a lesson.*” In the aftermath of this case that had made international news, many stalwarts of society, including policemen and policewomen, politicians, and lawyers, were publicly heard decrying not the perpetrators of this and other similar crimes, but the young women who transgressed the code. By their very actions, they “bring this upon themselves.” It is not the actual exposure, but the construction of appropriateness that is informed by purely cultural notions of what is right and what is wrong.

Ideals of “modesty” in dress also inform this gender narrative. Anjum (2010: 52) has interesting observations regarding Muslim women in Delhi who often wear the *burqa*, a whole-body veil where only the eyes are revealed. Some of these veiled women admitted that “minus the burqa they would never have had the courage to go out to the market so often, at night, at odd hours.” In this sense, the burqa provided anonymity (Anjum 2010: 53). Burqa-clad women may be “seen and not seen at the same time” in public. While other women may view the burqa as restrictive, some women did not.

Women are restricted, however, when a sense of honor is invoked to maintain adherence to normative or “proper” behavior that curtails a woman’s quest for more independence. Aspiring women may be breaking caste, hence gender, norms simply because they are working outside the home or living alone. For example, even if income is needed, not only is family honor violated, but a man’s inadequacy to provide for his family is revealed if wives or daughters are employed. All these examples suggest that powerful cultural beliefs about family honor, which is essentially men’s honor, is used to restrict women’s movements outside the home. In turn, women’s agency is denied. Women become common property as power games between men are played out.

CONCLUSION

Globalization and its media constructions offer options for young women to make a life of their own. As theorized by van Dijk (following Žižek 1993), “Fantasies comprise imaginary images, forces, and agents that hold the ‘Real’ of society at bay” (van Dijk 2017: 22). This is often incompatible with collective public sentiments. Since it takes several generations for such sentiments to change, class and caste norms related to women’s place and appropriate, proper, correct roles still outweigh misogyny and victim-blame as explanations for the heinous crimes on women’s bodies described in this chapter. To explain the narrative and their “place” in the public domain, one must realize that such a discourse, and the contradicting narratives that it generates, is in itself an indicator that opportunities are slowly transforming gender constructions in India. What Gramsci has called *senso commune* (common sense) in his *Note Books* (Crehan 2016), he refers to the way ordinary people view the reality of the world they inhabit. Suggested by emerging gender constructions, especially for women, perception of what is “proper” and how space should be navigated may no longer be such an obvious truth to a growing number of young people – men and women alike. As Crehan (2016: 47) puts it, “At any historical moment, even within the same place, there will be multiple narratives, some closely connected and overlapping, some conflicting and contradictory but all of which are, to some rational beings, self-evident truths” (Crehan 2016: 47). Although men occupy a different “habitus” (Bordieu 1977) than women, their explanations for sexual violence that women were in the wrong place at the wrong time are eroding, however slow it may be.

There are crosscutting and conflicting narratives about propriety, one set inherited from historical wisdom informed by caste and class and feudal hierarchies, the other received from a global world where gender roles are increasingly being redefined and public space reallocated. Historically, in a city like Delhi, women of all

classes and castes develop strategies of negotiating public space (Anjum 2010). For example, the definition of public domain is modified to suit the traditional division of labor for lower-caste women, such as the Dhobi (Channa 1992: 336).

Media often play a key role in reshaping these narratives. But the media in India also must negotiate what Dasgupta (2015: 252) refers to as “the contradiction inherent in the politics of globalization,” since the “commodification of women’s body is not at all approved by the models of a national value system, rather it puts modern Indian urban women into severe ambivalence.” With the movement of the political regime of India toward right-wing conservatism, these contradictions are getting even more severe.

Like all situations where the old and the new are in a state of clash, new norms may not emerge fast enough to thwart escalating sexual violence, for example, and become a part of the popular narratives. So-called self-evident truths are never evident when perceived from the vantage point of people located on varying positions in the social hierarchy. Urban India is today in a state of confusion, precisely because changes that should work as positive influences for women, such as education and the ability to earn a living, have been rapid and as yet unassimilated. It is the patriarchal narratives that are still hegemonic and hold the public attention. Violence is often a covertly legitimized means to keep rebellious voices and independent women under control.

The rules of the game clearly need to change. Even in the face of right-wing political turn, public outcry, combined with a reinvigorated women’s movement exerting its strength in the face of such politics, is slowly eroding norms restrictive to women in India. Women like myself know how to navigate both caste and gender norms in public. But we still need to be wary of our actions and keep to the rules, while at the same time challenging these very rules when opportunities present themselves, such as in teaching, writing, and collective action. Time will tell how long it will take to resolve these issues. Emerging rules

are difficult to maneuver, but necessary for better prospects and well-being for the next generation of Indian women.

NOTES

- 1 Dhobi “washermen” also includes Dhobi women.
- 2 Nirbhaya means “fearless” in Sanskrit and was used to hide the identity of the victim, and also as a recognition of the courage she showed in fighting her attackers.

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Chapter twenty-four

The Promises and Pitfalls of Microfinance in Pakistani Women's Lives

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INTRODUCTION

Microfinance first emerged in the 1970s as a strategy to alleviate poverty, empower the disenfranchised, and bolster the economies of developing nations. Microfinance provides small loans and other small-scale financial services—such as savings accounts and insurance—to individuals lacking collateral, credit history, and/or documentation establishing or verifying identity, such as a birth certificate or government identification card. In theory, microfinance alleviates poverty by creating self-employment opportunities and new business ventures. Its framework assumes that female participation in income-generating enterprises will address gender inequality by having a positive impact on women's household roles, leading to decreased birth rates and higher levels of personal and family well-being. Proponents of microfinance believe that women's access to credit and capital empowers them at the individual, household, and community level. Women's ability to fund their children's education, make household purchases, or supplement husbands' low earnings through the acquisition of a loan, enhances their material and social status. Women's entrepreneurial efforts provide jobs and income from buying consumer goods, thus enhancing nations' economic bottom lines.

Critics suggest microfinance is not a panacea or magic bullet for improving the lives of the

world's poor, but rather serves as a potential, though imperfect, entry point for their economic, social, political, and cultural participation via formal commercial markets. It is important to recognize that microfinance programs operate in contexts in which cultural and institutional norms devalue women and the poor, and particularly poor women, and their work. Women's economic and social disadvantage results from a rigidly gendered division of labor that isolates them in the private sphere and considers their entrepreneurial endeavors as secondary or supplemental to their roles as wives and mothers. In both the private and public realms, threats of violence and sexual exploitation constrain women's activities, as does their lack of formal education. Finally, women's entrepreneurial potential or their access to credit or capital via microfinance, mean, in effect, that they are valuable only for what they contribute to a developing nation's bottom line rather than for their intrinsic value as human beings. Thus, relying on microfinance to improve the quality of women's lives, reduce poverty, and achieve gender equality may divert attention away from other more effective strategies to empower women and raise their status, such as improving educational access, providing comprehensive reproductive health and family planning services, or expanding healthcare and stabilizing infrastructure.

In this chapter, we examine the impact of microfinance in the lives of Pakistani women, with particular attention to the historical, cultural, and social contexts that shape its utilization as a strategy for poverty alleviation, female empowerment, and Pakistan's national economic growth. As a development strategy designed to fulfill social needs through the provision of access to credit and capital to the disenfranchised, microfinance has not been immune to the trends of globalization. This has important consequences in Pakistan, where women's use of microfinance has led to asymmetrical social and economic outcomes. Microfinance is only effective in empowering women and positively transforming their lives and their societies if the external environment is conducive to female empowerment. The "sharp right turn" toward "neoliberal globalization" (NLG) undermines microcredit (Lindsey 2013) and contributes to uneven, and unevenly distributed, social and economic outcomes for Pakistani women utilizing microfinance (Mahmood 2011; Khan and Noreen 2012; Muhammad et al. 2012; Jafree and Ahmad 2013; Mahmood et al. 2014; Naeem et al. 2014; Adnan et al. 2015; Ahmad and Ahmad 2016; Monne et al. 2016; Naeem and Sana-ur-Rehman 2016; Ahmad and Satti 2017; Zulfiqar 2017). Social and cultural conditions must allow women to be independent, economically autonomous, physically and socially mobile, and to act as entrepreneurs in order for empowerment to flourish. Although pitfalls riddle the landscape of microfinance in Pakistan, we conclude with a discussion of strategies that may offer some measure of promise for achieving its intended goals.

ORIGIN AND EVOLUTION OF MICROFINANCE

First introduced as a poverty alleviation and women's empowerment strategy in the 1970s in Bangladesh and India, microfinance has undergone significant change. Dr. Mohammed Yunus, a

Vanderbilt-trained economist, founded the Grameen Bank in Bangladesh in an effort to counter the widely held but misguided belief that the indigent were to blame for their impoverishment. In Dr. Yunus's view, lack of access to capital—rather than laziness or stupidity—prevented such individuals from becoming successful business owners (Jackson Lee 2007). Microfinance—the provision of small loans, savings accounts, and financial planning services and investment opportunities to individuals without collateral, established credit history, or high incomes—responded to commercial banks' failure to meet the financial needs of the rural poor, and especially rural poor women (Coleman 2006).

Linking women's empowerment to microfinance became "institutionalized" as a development goal in 1975 at the first World Conference on Women in Mexico City; women's problems accessing credit, and the consequences of their exclusion from formal (commercial) financial markets, garnered significant attention (Adnan et al. 2015). On December 15, 1988, the United Nations declared 2005 the "Year of Microcredit" (Coleman 2006; Naeem et al. 2014), and in 2006 Dr. Yunus received the Nobel Prize for his pioneering efforts of the Grameen Bank which, by November 2007, boasted serving over seven million borrowers, 97 percent of whom were women (Jackson Lee 2007).

One cannot understate the significance of linking women's empowerment to microfinance as a development strategy; women experience its implications at the individual, household, and community level. Kabeer (1999) argues that empowerment is a process of change that involves resources, agency, and achievements. Khan and Noreen (2012: 4515) take this definition further by stating that empowerment is the ability of individuals "to have access to productive resources that enable them to obtain the goods and services they need" as well as "participate in the development process and the decisions that affect them." Empowerment is the

ability to exercise choice in one's life. Thus, empowerment is "a multidimensional and inter-linked process of change in power relations" (Mayoux 2000: 18). This process consists of *power within* (the ability for women to articulate their own goals by working with other social and political organizations), and *power over* (the ability to change underlying inequalities in power and resources that may impede goal achievement).

Mayoux (2005) and Ramirez (2006) identified three primary microfinance models or paradigms. Quite notably, these three models—poverty reduction, financial sustainability, and feminist empowerment—define empowerment differently. Yet each accounts for empowerment as a multidimensional process of change in power relations to expand individual choices and capacities for self-reliance (Mayoux 2003).

The poverty reduction model seeks to develop sustainable livelihoods, community development, social services, literacy, health care, and infrastructure. This approach targets women because of high rates of female poverty and women's disproportionate share of household responsibilities; the focus is on households rather than the status of women, *per se*. Scholars using this approach argue that by giving women access to credit and material resources, household welfare improves, which ultimately contributes to greater gender equality.

The second model—financial sustainability—helps the "bankable poor" by targeting women because of their higher loan repayment rates; this model views women's economic activity as a new source of national economic growth (much as small-scale enterprises are touted). Here, empowerment is individualistic and based on the notion of self-reliance; this model assumes women will be able to use their finances to improve their overall well-being, automatically leading to greater social and political empowerment.

Finally, the feminist empowerment model targets women for microfinance programs with the goals of bringing about gender equity and human rights. This approach generates and utilizes

policies to achieve gender awareness and feminist organization. Within the model, empowerment refers to the "transformation of power relations throughout society" (Ramirez 2006: 4), and is "rooted in the notion of powerlessness or the absence of power" (Kabeer 1994: 223). The feminist empowerment model assumes the need for macro-level changes within an environment, allowing for women's explicit challenges to gender subordination; it seeks to link women to existing services and infrastructure, develop new technologies, build information networks, and change social policy. Goals within this model include: changing household power relations, creating gender awareness, encouraging gender advocacy, and challenging and transforming gender discrimination. Feminist empowerment provides women with the ability to make decisions that affect their social status and position, and to have and exercise power.

By many measures, Pakistan's women are highly disempowered and disadvantaged. Over one-fifth (22.59 percent) of the Pakistani population was living below the poverty line in 2010, with women comprising the majority of this group (55.8 percent), making Pakistan ripe for microfinance expansion (Mahmood 2011). The World Economic Forum ranked Pakistan 144 out of 145 countries on its 2015 Global Gender Gap Index; over 60 percent of girls in Pakistan have never been to school and under half of the total female population is literate, with a rural women's literacy rate of just 35 percent. Compared to other South Asians, Pakistanis have extremely limited access to financial services: just 14 percent claim access, compared to 32 percent, 48 percent, and 59 percent, of Bangladeshis, Indians, and Sri Lankans, respectively. There is also a significant gender gap in financial access in Pakistan: just over 5 percent of women have access to banking compared to one-fifth of men (Zulfiqar 2017). Pakistani women face patriarchal norms that define social gatherings and business activities as "restricted" and "against the tradition and family norms" of a highly gendered division of labor

and sex-segregated spheres of interaction and influence (Ahmad and Satti 2017). Women and girls also face violence and sexual exploitation in both private and public institutions (Zulfiqar 2017). Pakistani women and their families face the additional burdens of such problems as a lack of basic infrastructure, especially in rural areas where the vast majority of women (78 percent) reside (Khan and Noreen 2012). As a primarily agrarian, rural-dwelling nation, employment rates are low for both men and women, but there is also a gender gap in Pakistan's labor force participation: over two-thirds men (68.9 percent) to 36.4 percent women, respectively (Zulfiqar 2017). Compounding infrastructure and unemployment issues are inflation and economic volatility, sectarianism, and political insecurity (Jafree and Ahmad 2013). These challenging conditions affected the emergence and growth of Pakistan's microfinance industry, itself weathering the effects of ideological and institutional shifts.

Pakistan's microfinance industry started in the early 1980s with the provision of small loans in the country's northern region by the Aga Khan Rural Support Programme; by the 1990s this model extended nationwide and led to the creation of the National Rural Support Program, the Kashf Microfinance Bank (MFB), and the Pakistan Microfinance Network (Muhammad et al. 2012). By the early 2000s, Pakistan further institutionalized and expanded their microfinance industry with the passage of the Microfinance Institutions Ordinance. This had the effect of allowing the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) to establish MFBs and placed development of microfinance under control of the country's central bank (Zulfiqar 2017). Significantly, the growth and expansion of microfinance in Pakistan between the 1990s and 2000s occurs at the same time that the emergence of NLG is radically altering "globalization" or "globalism" and development strategies (Lindsey 2013).

Characteristics of NLG include intensified deregulation and the privatization and corporatization of "public goods" (i.e. natural resources,

education, healthcare, etc.) under conditions in which the interests of political, financial, and corporate elites are aligned and cemented. NLG promotes and rewards individualism and private wealth and devalues social solidarity in favor of personal responsibility. The ideologies and practices of NLG are contradictory: they deepen women's disadvantages while promising diversity, fairness, transparency, and rights (Lindsey 2013). In the case of microcredit, in particular, for-profit financial institutions are replacing the non-profit, village bank model; this removes women's access to models of successful peer lending strategies and programs promoting literacy and entrepreneurialism (Lindsey 2013). This has ushered in an era of "modern," or commercialized, microfinance for which Pakistan serves as an interesting case study.

Advocates of commercialized microfinance insist it "democratizes" finance by allowing for-profit commercial banks to compete with non-commercial (non-profit) microfinance providers; they claim for-profit banks can "project capitalism's 'softer' side by reaching out to the bottom of the socioeconomic pyramid for both profits and poverty alleviation" (Zulfiqar 2017: 163). However, for-profit MFBs do not face the same pressures as older non-governmental (NGO) Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) for empowerment goals; prudential regulations issued by the SBP do not mention that MFBs need to target women. MFBs are also encouraged by the SBP to find clients who are above the poverty line. Combined, these SBP policies shift the emphasis away from women and the chronic poor. Additionally, "modern" microfinance emphasizes the utilization of microcredit and eschews other financial services such as saving accounts or insurance that would better absorb the shocks of economic uncertainty associated with poverty (Zulfiqar 2017).

MFBs are rapidly embracing individual lending while MFIs retain their group-lending tendencies. This disrupts important opportunities for Pakistani women to confront what Naila Kabeer calls "patriarchal risk," "a sense of insecurity in

the absence of male companions” (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016: 189). Women’s mobility is constrained by social and cultural norms that prevent them from full participation in public realms (Mahmood 2011); the “Self-Help Group” (SHG) feature of MFIs creates women-only spaces where microfinance recipients can exchange ideas and experiences with individuals who have similar problems (Adnan et al. 2015; Ahmad and Ahmad 2016).

Finally, the “collateralization” of “modern” microfinance carries significant implications for women and the poor and is a radical departure from the collateral-free loan model of Dr. Yunus’s Grameen Bank. Gold-backed loans—which allow borrowers to use gold jewelry to not only secure loans, but receive them in a significantly reduced time frame relative to traditional loans—are heralded by MFBs as an opportunity for clients to turn “dead capital” into a usable economic asset. They were one of the fastest-growing MFB products by 2012 and all Pakistani MFBs offered them. However, gold-backed loans are never the full value of the jewelry placed up as collateral: to insure themselves against fluctuations in the price of gold, MFBs loan just 70 percent of the gold’s value. Gold jewelry is also a heavily gendered, intergenerational asset. A low- or middle-income woman’s primary form of savings or investment, gold jewelry is often the only asset that belongs only to her. Patriarchal norms may prevent women from accessing or controlling loans obtained with their jewelry, and default on a gold-backed loan could lead to significant losses of (intergenerational) household wealth (Zulfiqar 2017). Recent analyses suggest that Pakistani women experience the promises and pitfalls of microfinance unevenly, especially in regard to its primary goals of poverty reduction, financial sustainability, and empowerment (Mayoux 2005; Ramirez 2006). As we discuss below, these outcomes reflect some broader trends related to microfinance in other parts of South Asia, and are affected themselves by trends in globalization.

THE PROMISES OF MICROFINANCE

Proponents of microfinance suggest that investing in women empowers them to participate in decision-making processes, gain access to resources, and contribute to greater economic growth and development. In Bangladesh and Nepal, these benefits contribute to greater family well-being, increased respect for women, and increases in women’s self-esteem, assertiveness, and self-confidence (Afrin et al. 2010; Kabeer 2005; Sharma 2007). Microfinance as a route to women’s empowerment addresses, then, women’s inability to make choices due to social restrictions and exclusions they encounter, such as restricted physical mobility (i.e. the ability to travel), lack of access to material and social resources, and dependence on male guardianship (Kabeer 1999; Mayoux 2000), including in Pakistan (Azam Roomi and Harrison 2010). Moreover, participation in microfinance programs raises the dignity, social empowerment, organizational and management skills, mobilization, and collective strengths of women (Afrin et al. 2010).

Bangladesh and Malaysia, respectively, offer evidence that women do experience increases in participation in decision-making, access to financial or economic resources, and involvement in larger social networks (Pitt et al. 2006; Al-Mamun et al. 2014)). Other benefits include women’s increased marital bargaining power, greater freedom of movement (i.e. physical mobility), and increased spousal communication about family planning and parenting issues (Pitt et al. 2006; Afrin et al. 2010; Al-Mamun et al. 2014). At the household-level, the social impact of microfinance for women has resulted in greater food security, lower rates of malnutrition among female children, and decreases in infant mortality (Kabeer 2005).

This is significant because Pitt et al. (2006) found that men’s participation in microcredit programs *negatively* affected women’s participation

in social networks, their marital bargaining power and decision-making roles, and physical mobility. Kabeer (2005) suggests that the positive household-level impacts were absent when men received loans. Bangladeshi women who had husbands with a liberal gender ideology were more likely to participate actively in deciding how loan money was used (Rabiul Karim and Law 2013). Study findings are unclear as to whether women's microfinance participation led to liberal gender ideology in husbands or if husbands with liberal gender ideology were more likely to encourage their wives to participate in such programs, but Bangladeshi women's household decision-making role increased nonetheless (Rabiul Karim and Law 2013).

Pakistani women, like their South Asian women counterparts discussed above, have also experienced some positive improvements in their families' standards of living and their household and community status via microfinance participation. In a study of 200 Pakistani microfinance clients in the Bahawalpur district, Khan and Noreen (2012) found that female empowerment was associated with greater spending on children's education and health care needs. Female empowerment was influenced by age (which influences autonomy), husband's level of education, the amount of paternal assets women inherit, marital status, the number of living sons women had, and the amount of microfinance women received. In particular, women with sons tended to have greater power; bearing male children is a positive social achievement in patriarchal Pakistan. Bringing assets to a marriage (including creditworthiness and gold jewelry) grants women the ability to participate in the financial decision-making process (Khan and Noreen 2012).

Similarly, Mahmood's (2011) analysis of 37 Pakistani female microfinance participants in the Punjab province found that most participants made loan applications and loan-use decisions in conjunction with their husbands. Women felt more empowered to make financial decisions in

regard to the health and educational needs of their children, though not for themselves. Their study also found that approximately 66 percent of participants took out loans on their own and made economic decisions by themselves, while 34 percent of participants had their loans used by their husbands/head of household (Mahmood 2011). Women microfinance recipients in the Quetta district of Pakistan reported feeling more financially secure, more capable of supporting family members financially, and experienced improvements in interpersonal skills relative to non-beneficiaries (Naeem et al. 2014).

Women clients from Bahawalpur, Lodhran, and Multan reported that access to and utilization of microfinance earned greater respect from their husbands and their husbands' families, and it has increased their centrality in the household, as well as economic independence (Adnan et al. 2015). The group-lending model offered by Akhuwat, an MFI in Rawalpindi district, fosters women's increased participation in other groups and networks facilitated by the organization (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016). Almost all participants (98.88 percent) reported increased social mobility through required visits to group meetings, commuting to and selling goods in the market, and visiting MFI offices. This had the added benefits of increasing participants' fluency in Urdu, and their exposure to new ways of speaking and the mannerisms of formal environments (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016). Additionally, two-thirds (67 percent) of Akhuwat clients ultimately moved into the role of "community leader" by spurring others to seek the MFI's services in order to emulate their success (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016).

Finally, evidence from Gilgit district reveals rural women's participation in microfinance created greater decision-making agency in the areas of mobility, household spending, and spending on community affairs and political parties (Ahmad and Satti 2017). Women exhibited greater political participation because they had to get a National Identity Card in order to run a business,

which is also required to vote in elections (Mahmood et al. 2014). Urban women receiving microfinance in Rawalpindi believed overwhelmingly that a good living, access to good food, shelter, clothing, and education for their children, was their legal and basic human right (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016). This evidence seems to suggest that Pakistan's microfinance industry is achieving the goals of assisting women to rise from poverty and build their entrepreneurial skills, for their good and the good of their families and the economy (Mahmood et al. 2014).

THE PITFALLS OF MICROFINANCE

Critics have noted that poverty alleviation and financial sustainability models of microfinance cite empowerment as goals, but fail to discuss explicitly how to implement policies to achieve them (Mayoux 2005; Ramirez 2006). While microfinance can be a route to women's empowerment, it also contributes to women's continued disempowerment. Women's dependence on loans and increased debt for the sake of household improvements and daily well-being may lead them to forgo their own necessities, including food and clothing. Ironically, access to loans may increase gender inequality in households as other women in the household take over the unpaid domestic work that entrepreneurial women are unable to complete due to the time and energy demands required of informal economic work, which is, by definition, unpredictable and viewed as supplemental to family incomes (Mayoux 2005; Mahmood et al. 2014). This has serious implications for girls' schooling and educational attainment. In their study of microfinance recipients in Pakistan's Rawalpindi district, Ahmad and Ahmad (2016) found that women kept their daughters home from school to help with income-generating work in need of completion. Women in Pakistan's Punjab province, did not feel empowered to spend money on their own education

after participating in a microfinance program (Mahmood 2011).

Microfinance has an uneven impact on rates of domestic violence. Financial disputes within the household *related to* microfinance loans may lead to women's greater risk of domestic violence, particularly if male relatives feel slighted by the inattention to their needs, and by the redefinition of their roles as primary breadwinners (Kabeer 2005; Pitt et al. 2006; Ramirez 2006; Armendáriz and Roome 2008). Three percent of respondents in a survey of microfinance clients in Bahawalpur, Lodhran, and Multan reported more quarreling with their husbands; quarrels often resulted from women's inability to repay loans and husbands' refusal to assist their wives with repayment (Adnan et al. 2015). Although a majority of Akhuwat MFI participants in the Rawalpindi district reported considerable declines in domestic violence incidents since beginning income-generating activities supported through loans, slightly more than 10 percent claimed their husbands continued to abuse them (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016).

Just because a woman may obtain a loan does not mean it is *her* loan. Microfinance has traditionally targeted women because it may be easier for women to fulfill loan program requirements, such as their availability—in the absence of formal employment or school attendance—to meet with loan officers and other MFI personnel. Men not targeted by these programs often use their female relatives as cover, sometimes without their knowledge or consent, or coerce women into taking loans out for them (Mayoux 2000; Pitt et al. 2006). Although Bangladeshi *women's* joint decision-making increases with microfinance participation, Kabeer (2001) found that Bangladeshi *men* who received microfinance reported more independent discretion, particularly in relation to loan use, business management, and income disposal. Historically, men use microfinance funding for their own businesses without investing earnings back into the household (or women's businesses) (Mayoux 2005). In Bangladesh

Rabiul Karim and Law (2013) observed that despite women being the majority of applicants (51 percent) for microfinance due to their low socioeconomic status, husbands fully controlled loans in over 80 percent of cases. Similar patterns of men benefiting from women's microfinance loans emerge in Pakistan. In the Bahawalpur district of Pakistan, husbands, fathers, or other male heads-of-household used 34.33 percent of microfinance program's loans provided to women applicants (Khan and Noreen 2012). Among urban and peri-urban borrowers from Karachi, Lahore, and Rawalpindi, 27 percent of women clients reported handing the loan over to their husbands (Zulfiqar 2017). A 2013 study places the rate at which women turn over their loan to male relatives higher at between 50–70 percent, a rate that includes forced borrowing (Zulfiqar 2017).

Uddin (2015) asks if participation in microfinance challenges patriarchal structures or simply encourages women to engage in domestic activities to generate income in Bangladesh. This is an important question for any developing country, including Pakistan, because it recognizes that borrowers availing themselves to microfinance are extremely likely to work in the informal sector of the economy in occupations or industries such as embroidery and stitching, operating small retail stores or resale operations, or raising livestock or agricultural goods (Jafree and Ahmad 2013). In Pakistan's Punjab region, women *already* possessing marketable skills utilized their loans to continue working as entrepreneurs, but women who lack training or experience, however rudimentary, in managing a business, networking, and controlling or maximizing their income, faced barriers to entrepreneurship and economic autonomy (Mahmood et al. 2014). Informal work frequently earns a piece-rate rather than set hourly wage and is contractual, thus short-term or temporary. Informal work is therefore less lucrative than wage labor or non-homebased businesses and considered merely supplemental (Zulfiqar 2017). Participants in a

microfinance program in Lahore, Pakistan, did not experience a transition into formal employment because of microfinance loan utilization, and a quarter remained unemployed (Jafree and Ahmad 2013). Microfinance, then, may not offer a clear pathway to full-time, regulated work.

When women do achieve entry to the market, figuratively and literally, patriarchal barriers remain. A study by Azam Roomi and Harrison (2010) examining gender-related challenges faced by female Pakistani entrepreneurs found that the cultural norms of “*ardah*” (veil) and “*izzat*” (honor) played an important, but negative, role in their economic success. These norms lead to gender segregation and exclusion from the public sphere and prohibit women's interactions with unfamiliar men, in order to maintain women's honor (Adnan et al. 2015). Female entrepreneurs in Bahawalpur, Lodhran, and Multan, Pakistan reported difficulty interacting with those male employees who had trouble accepting female authority. Whether as entrepreneurs or clients, women microfinance recipients experienced challenges to their credibility (Azam Roomi and Harrison 2010).

As markets deregulate and mass-produced goods begin to flood in, poor rural women championed by development strategies like microfinance find that their traditional crafts—and even they themselves—cannot compete with cheaper imports or international firms, leading to high(er) failure rates of women's microbusinesses (Lindsey 2013). To be fair, this is not a problem limited to just Bangladesh or Pakistan, in particular, or South Asia, more broadly. In developed nations like the United States, where microcredit and microenterprise are attempts to “change welfare as we know it,” many women are encouraged to “stay at home running businesses (what we call ‘pink collar’ businesses) that are little more than extensions of women's domestic routine” (Ehlers and Main 1998: 425–426). American women's microenterprise ventures tended to be “built around the type of work or hobbies women already do or are familiar with (e.g. cleaning, day

care, cooking or baking, sewing, handicrafts, selling women's products to neighbors and friends)" with the negative consequences of heightening women's disenchantment with entrepreneurship and delegitimizing them as "real" business owners (Ehlers and Main 1998: 430). American borrowers on Kiva, a U.S.-based non-profit online peer-to-peer lending platform, seek crowdfunded loans to assist with expanding home-based cleaning businesses, purchasing food or cooking supplies for self-run catering operations, or acquiring stock for small storefronts. Harnessing the power of the internet and combining it with the power of personal narrative allowed Kiva to "engag[e] average-income people" as donors "to unlock a new type of more connected capital" (Flannery 2007: 37). Online, peer-to-peer microfinance platforms transform *individuals* into "charitable microbanks," thereby increasing "the potential scope and effectiveness of microfinance" (Jackson Lee 2007: 176). However, this does little to challenge the perceptions and structures of "women's work" in microfinance utilization.

Besides their relegation to the informal sector of the economy, female microfinance clients confront sexist structures and practices embedded in the industry itself. Although they are targets of these programs, women often receive smaller loans with shorter repayment periods for businesses that have little room for expansion, and which tend to be less lucrative than male businesses, making female wealth accumulation difficult if not impossible (Faridi 2011). This is true in Pakistan for both MFIs and MFBs. When made by MFIs, average loans sizes for men and women are similar, but men receive almost \$50USD more from MFBs than do women. While MFIs provide male and female borrowers with similar loan amounts, women's loans may be limited in scope (i.e. for the purpose of livestock management only), which further blocks Pakistani women from real economic gains (Zulfikar 2017).

It is naïve to assume that microfinance can eliminate power issues between the rich and poor, but also within the poor, because people may still

pursue self-interest over collective good if given the choice. In his study of Thai village banks, Coleman (2006) found that relative to their less "wealthy" counterparts, "wealthy" female villagers self-selected into bank programs and often became committee leaders. These leaders then borrowed money in their own names, organized with other relatives to pool their loans, gave low interest rates to relatives, and then re-loaned money at higher rates to other borrowers. Consequently, leaders experienced greater overall wealth and income than less wealthy village bank members. As his study concludes, "the programs surveyed are not reaching the poor as much as the relatively wealthy" because participant households are significantly wealthier than non-participants, thus confirming suspicions among the poorest of the poor that programs are open only to the rich or that they "would 'not be qualified' to join" (Coleman 2006: 1619, 1624).

Pakistan's microfinance industry also does not reach the poor as much as the relatively wealthy, but for reasons other than self-selection into particular bank programs. Rural women, the group idealized in the original goals of microfinance, are primarily agricultural workers who earn low incomes; their lower incomes translate into smaller loan amounts than non-rural women (Jafree and Ahmad 2013). Compared to urban women who invested microfinance loans into their own entrepreneurial activities, rural women used their loans for consumption purposes (Mahmood 2011). This included purchasing household appliances (TVs, washing machines, water-coolers, etc.), furniture, or motorized transportation (i.e. motorcycle or rickshaw) (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016). Corporations benefit from women's consumption of mass-produced consumer goods. At the same time, women must also use their incomes (or loans) to secure re-privatized social goods such as healthcare, childcare, and education (Lindsey 2013; Zulfikar 2017).

Location is another significant factor in the unequal distribution of microfinance benefits in Pakistan. Microfinance providers are likely to

open and operate in relatively well-developed areas (Monne et al. 2016). It is costlier to screen applicants, and monitor and administer loans, in rural areas than urban areas because rural areas are less densely populated and clientele live farther away from branches. Rural customers' low creditworthiness and investors' uncertainty about repayment performance contribute to "rational herding" by microfinance providers. In urban areas, where clients tend to have better creditworthiness and additional resources to ensure repayment. "Regions that have already attracted some MFIs may be more likely to attract more MFIs subsequently," accounting for greater urban access (Monne et al. 2016: 267).

Finally, the emergence of "modern" finance in Pakistan does little to address patriarchal norms that constrain women's empowerment, and recent evidence suggests Pakistan's commercial MFBs may actually utilize and reinscribe them to shore up their attractiveness to Microfinance Investment Vehicles (MIVs). As noted previously, SBP's prudential regulations do not require MFBs to target women, whereas outreach to women is a central operational mechanism of non-commercial MFIs operated by NGOs (Zulfiqar 2017). Since the 2000s, even MFIs that "spun off" independent MFBs changed lending strategies to "focus on profits" because they were "no longer a *bibion ka* (ladies') bank" (Zulfiqar 2017: 171). Although some lenders recognize that women's acquisition of microfinance loans, ostensibly on behalf of improving their family's standard of living, is honorable, they acknowledge access does not inherently raise women's status in society. A lender from Lahore, who provided loans to primarily rural clients, claimed that women "are often seen as worse than cows and buffalos in many villages." Such entrenched views were unlikely to change rapidly, simply because women could apply for or obtain a loan (Zulfiqar 2017: 173). Requiring women applicants to list the name of the (male) family member who will take over the loan upon disbursement, further implies patriarchal control over microfinance

(Zulfiqar 2017). Consequently, only a quarter of Pakistani MFB borrowers are women, and they hold just under one-fifth of the MFB portfolio (Zulfiqar 2017).

Women's consensus orientation (i.e. obtaining a loan to privilege *family* welfare over their individual welfare) is incompatible with NLG's male-identified values of individualism and competition (Lindsey 2013). Rabiul Karim and Law (2013) noted a gendered difference in loan utilization in Bangladesh: women tended to use loan money to repay other outstanding debts or loans, a strategy known as "debt reduction," rather than for entrepreneurial endeavors. In Pakistan, Mahmood (2011) found that urban Punjab women were more likely to use loan money on a business, while rural Punjab women were more likely to spend it on basic survival needs such as food. In the context of NLG, "debt reduction" stands in opposition to "income generation" as the "efficient" and "appropriate" use of microfinance loans because it fails to satisfy the profit-making demands of capitalism (Mahmood 2011).

Microfinance contributes to unequal and uneven outcomes, both positive and negative, in Pakistani women's lives. This is partly a result of the unique challenges posed by Pakistan's demographic profile and culture; it is partly the result of transformations occurring in microfinance itself. In the next section, we discuss possible strategies for realigning current microfinance practice in Pakistan with the goals for women's empowerment envisioned by microfinance pioneers.

DISCUSSION

As conceptualized by Dr. Mohammad Yunus, and as implemented by Grameen Bank in the 1970s, microfinance approached poverty reduction and economic development from the "bottom up" by providing a point of entry to formal financial services for the rural poor and women. This contrasted to more common "top-down" approaches endorsed by development economists

(Naeem et al. 2014: 35). However, the empirical evidence outlined above reveals that the laudable goals of both microfinance (i.e. poverty reduction, financial sustainability via entrepreneurship, and women's empowerment) and NLG (i.e. deregulation, privatization, and democratization through commercialization) are incompatible in "modern" microfinance. Already unequal and uneven outcomes widen as MFBs crowd out MFIs in the provision of microfinance in Pakistan and beyond.

A weakness of microfinance is its hybrid nature as a social enterprise; its combination of development logic and finance logic are inherently incompatible. In other words, poverty reduction and banking do not mix; providing services to women is a sacrifice of financial performance. Patriarchal norms and structures limit the profitability of women's businesses; at the same time international investors are pressuring microfinance institutions to forgo their social mission to enhance their bottom line (Zulfiqar 2017). The emphasis on individualism and competition in "modern" microfinance, and its preference of individualized lending, contrasts sharply with women's tendency to emphasize consensus and collectivism, as well as with the original group-lending, joint-liability model of traditional microfinance (Lindsey 2013; Zulfiqar 2017). Presently, a potential shift away from NLG to state capitalism models offers opportunities to implement correctives to Pakistan's microfinance industry (Lindsey 2013).

Many early MFI programs emphasized entrepreneurship training and networking; both positively correlate with women's gains across a number of empowerment dimensions and contribute to improvements in women's well-being and status. Unfortunately, business training remains unavailable to a majority of MFI program participants, even long-term clients (Mahmood 2011). When available, it is promising. Female borrowers of two NGO-based MFIs in the Punjab region of Pakistan received courses in business orientation, cash flow development,

and other financial literacy and finance programs (Mahmood et al. 2014). Greater knowledge about assessing markets and dealing with customers reduced power imbalances for women entrepreneurs, and peer mentoring via required monthly meetings, or small SHGs, helped "to build bonds, create a sense of belonging, facilitate learning of business practices and instil (sic) discipline amongst women entrepreneurs" (Mahmood et al. 2014: 245). Participation in group-lending programs contributed to microfinance participants' *collective* reaction to violence against fellow women. In the Rawalpindi district of Pakistan, group solidarity provided women with courage to speak up publicly and privately about a range of concerns, including those regarding MFI officials.

With entrenched cultural barriers to formal education, women benefit from budgeting, savings, and investment training provided by microfinance programs (Ahmad and Ahmad 2016). Increasing operational costs, uncertain repayment rates, and general political instability, mean that many non-commercial MFIs are unable to fund non-financial services like training and networking meetings (Jafree and Ahmad 2013). MFBs can bridge this gap. Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) is NLG's marketing vehicle to attract new consumers, allowing a corporation to profit from claims about its contributions to the local community (Lindsey 2013). This virtually demands that commercialized MFBs reinvest their profits into expanded subsidized training programs and networking opportunities, especially women's-only SHGs, to fulfill promises of CSR. Innovative techniques will be required in expanding any training to Pakistani women due to their low literacy rates. Expanded education via CSR should also include courses or training that would allow microfinance clients to develop marketable skills for employment beyond the informal sector. The concurrent demands of domestic chores limit home-based work's advantages (Jafree and Ahmad 2013).

Broadly defined, microfinance is the provision of a broad array of financial services to groups excluded from formal banking and finance. However, Pakistan's microfinance providers emphasize credit or loan utilization to the exclusion of insurance, savings, or investment products, which are more useful to the impoverished for weathering financial crises (Zulfiqar 2017). As discussed above, women frequently utilize loans to meet basic household expenses, rather than to foster their own self-employment and entrepreneurship. Naeem et al. (2014) and Naeem and Sana-ur-Rehman (2016) recommend consumer credit or special loans for family or domestic needs, in addition to business loans and business training.

Finally, women must remain the primary targets of microfinance if it is to remain a strategy of developing nations to alleviate poverty, empower women, and grow their economies. The emergence and expansion of state-backed MFBs indicates that "modern" microfinance in Pakistan is no longer "gender sensitive" and contributes to widening gender inequalities by integrating patriarchal norms and practices into their services (Zulfiqar 2017). MFBs are, of course, not responsible for the patriarchal norms or practices that are prevalent in Pakistani society, but their *employees* must resist reproducing them. In cases of loans collateralized by women's gold jewelry, MFBs face an institutional moral hazard because women often do not control the loan's use, to say nothing of coercion to apply in the first place (Zulfiqar 2017).

MIVs need to encourage commercial microfinance providers to contest patriarchal norms whether through rewards (investment) or sanctions (disinvestment). MIVs seek to place international investors' debt and equity funds in the most profitable microfinance firms (Zulfiqar 2017). Commercial microfinance firms that train employees to recognize and disrupt sexist practices or discriminatory practices—via workshops, classes, orientations—may be able to harness the marketing power of CSR. Investors in MIVs must demand this. Women already contribute to corporations'

bottom lines through the gender wage gap, private purchase of formerly public goods, and unpaid reproductive labor in the domestic sphere (Lindsey 2013). Commercial MFBs, under the guise of CSR, may as well help profit by promoting and institutionalizing gender sensitive (women-focused) practices and policies too.

CONCLUSION

Kabeer (2005: 4718) writes, "However effective the role of microfinance organizations in providing financial services to the poor, they cannot substitute for broader policies to promote pro-poor economic growth, equitable social development and democratic participation in collective forums of decision-making." True empowerment of women occurs when national (and international) environments allow women to control physical, human, and financial resources and national and organizational cultures reflect this empowerment. However, it is important to acknowledge that empowerment is different at the individual, household, community, and social levels:

Microfinance institutions may lead to the empowerment of women by increasing their incomes and their control over that income, enhancing their knowledge and skills in production and trade, and increasing their participation in household decision-making. As a result, social attitudes and perceptions may change, and women's status in the household may be enhanced.

(Ramirez 2006: citing Gulli 1998, non-italics emphasis in the original)

For Pakistani women, the negative impacts of microfinance offset its positive impacts (Muhammad et al. 2012; Jafree and Ahmad 2013; Naeem et al. 2014; Ahmad and Ahmad 2016; Monne et al. 2016; Naeem and Sana-ur-Rehman 2016; Zulfiqar 2017). Additionally, the competing logics governing microfinance as a "hybrid" institution contribute to unequal and unevenly distributed outcomes

for borrowers in Pakistan (Zulfiqar 2017). Microfinance operates as a potential entry point for women's empowerment and poverty alleviation, but one should not view it as a singular or simple solution. Kabeer (2005: 4718) warns, "There are no magic bullets, no panaceas, no blueprints, no readymade formulas which bring about the radical structural transformation that the empowerment of the poor, and of poor women, implies."

Besides helping women meet their daily needs, microfinance programs must also help women address their "strategic gender interests" and confront patriarchal structures for true empowerment to occur (Kabeer 2005). Addressing women's "strategic gender interests" involves abolishing gendered divisions of labor, challenging unequal control over resources, ending male violence, eliminating sexual exploitation, giving women control over their bodies, and establishing political and social equality. Empowerment is not an automatic outcome of women's participation in microfinance but needs to be a crucial part of policy design. Microfinance will be most effective when additional services are available to the poorest of the poor, including health care, business and organizational skill training, and political advocacy and when women actively participate in microfinance policy planning and implementation. It will also require us to privilege women's intrinsic value as human beings over their economic value alone.

NOTE

Disclaimer: This chapter was prepared by Priya Dua, in her personal capacity, in cooperation with Veronica E. Medina. The opinions expressed in this article are Dr. Dua's own and do not reflect the view of the United States Department of Agriculture, or the United States government.

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Chapter twenty-five

Afghan Women The Politics of Empowerment in the Post-2001 Era

Orzala Nemat

INTRODUCTION

Afghan women are among those women whose “portraits” have been used most often in the contemporary era to symbolize victimhood, helplessness, migration, pain, sorrow, and even justification to wage wars. Yet, in reality, women in Afghanistan portray a different face to their identity, one of *heroism* such as Malala of Maiwand in the 1880s (Johnson and Leslie 2013: 171), one of *resilience* such as stories of war widows who are single heads of their families, one of *silent resistance* such as women who ran clandestine classes under the Taliban regime, and one of *courage* such as women who spoke out about injustices and raised their voices for peace (Brotsky et al. 2014; Rostami-Povey 2007). This chapter challenges the reductionist portrayals of the Afghan women as passive victims in the post-2001 context of Afghanistan by highlighting women’s political participation and their agency in their everyday practices of governance within their local communities and at the national level.

Specifically, I explore Afghan women’s situation within the context of globalization and the way development and social change have evolved as a result of post-2001 liberal intervention in Afghanistan, resulting from the “War on Terror” (that followed the al-Qaeda attacks on the US on September 11, 2001). Theoretically, the chapter

will follow a political economy framework where concepts such as patriarchy and patrimonialism and their linkages will be examined in order to provide an in-depth understanding of the context and the way liberal interventionism operates in such contexts. I base my analysis on my extensive field research on women’s empowerment projects over the past 16 years in Afghanistan, and on my collection of prior writings and conference presentations, as well as on secondary literature on Afghan women and their role in state-building and the evolution of Afghan women’s socio-political situation over the past decade and a half.

Establishing a broader historical context is crucial for an enhanced understanding of Afghan women’s political and social position in society. I follow this principle in this chapter where Afghan women have become the unit of analysis within the broader context of liberal interventionism and its state-building and governance projects, operating in a society dominated by (neo-)patrimonialism and patriarchy. Such concepts help us elaborate the situation of Afghan women. Therefore, I provide historical and contextual realities of Afghanistan and its place in a global context, and I also examine the socio-political situation of Afghan women. Throughout, two elements are central. One is the activities of external governments and international

organizations as they frequently have included women-oriented programs as part of the much broader post-2001 War on Terror. Second is the patriarchal and patrimonial power relations that have impacted Afghan society and that continue to pose major challenges to Afghan women in their everyday lives.

GENDER, STATE-BUILDING, AND GOVERNANCE

The post-2001 context of Afghanistan represents an informative model of liberal intervention in a country with protracted years of war and conflict. This intervention, according to some, was framed as a war to “liberate” Afghan women (Gallagher 2004). It is important to analyze how the post-Cold war era has entered yet another phase where the oppression of ruling regimes toward women has become a motivating factor, not only for those taking military action, but also for those who believe that toppling a brutal regime would shorten the path to a democratic society. Indeed, some well-known feminist organizations in the West, such as Feminist Majority and Equality Now have welcomed the War on Terror and US intervention in Afghanistan (Schulte 2001; Smeal 2001).

On the global level, “governance” has become a dominating concept. Hence, governance interventions in the post-Cold War era have shifted toward liberal interventionism that is manifested in numerous “peace operations” including the former Yugoslavia (1991), Bosnia (1992–1995), Kosovo (1998–1999), East Timor (1974–1999), Sierra Leone (1991–2002), Haiti (1994–1995), Côte d’Ivoire (2002–2004 and 2010–11), Democratic Republic of the Congo (1998–2003), Burundi (1993–2005), Iraq (2003–2011), Afghanistan (2001–present), and most recently, in Libya (2011). While these interventions have varied in character, not least in their legality, all involved wide-ranging efforts to transform the conflict-affected countries through reforms of the state,

institution-building, women’s rights, civil society, and the promotion of a free market economy. These interventions were often justified in terms such as “protecting” the population and promoting democracy and human rights. The growing focus on governance is reflected in increased funding, with OECD governments providing over US\$10 billion a year for governance interventions globally (IDS 2010).

As Richmond (2005) has pointed out, liberal peace-building has historical roots that precede the end of the Cold War. Contemporary debates on liberal peace-building resonate with Augustinian thinking on “tranquillity of order” (Richmond 2005; Saint Augustine 1991) and Hobbesian thinking about containing the state of nature. However, central to contemporary liberal peace-building is the idea that sustainable peace can be achieved through the simultaneous pursuit of conflict resolution, market sovereignty, and liberal democracy (Pugh et al. 2004). In order to achieve this, there is a need to promote “good governance.” And one of the core principles of the good governance model is gender equity or ensuring that men and women benefit equally from resources and authority.

There is a significant gap in the study of the gendered and gendering nature of state-building and governance in the context of conflict-affected settings (O’Reilly 2012; Scott 2007). Accordingly, there is a need to further explore the complex ways in which masculinities and femininities continue to be “(re)constructed, (re)produced and maintained in relation to other forms of identity” (Handrahan 2004; O’Reilly 2012: 530). O’Reilly points out that relations between gender and liberal interventionism are mutually constitutive and reinforcing and that gender identities are seen as an “enabling condition of liberal interventionism and vice versa” (O’Reilly 2012: 538–9). The idea that women in particular developing countries are oppressed and need protecting is part of the underlying logic and justification for liberal interventionism, and Kandiyoti (2005), drawing on feminist scholars, has demonstrated how women’s

rights and participation have become an iconic characteristic of liberal interventionism. As such, Kandiyoti (2005) and Abu-Lughod (2002) have argued that Western interventions are justified by supporting women in Muslim countries. According to Kandiyoti, this has been coined “feminism as imperialism.” Kandiyoti also refers to Arat-Koc’s (2002) findings that connect women’s oppression to cultural and religious practices, which on the one hand, are seen as justifying “humanitarian war” or as an obligation to “protect” women, and on the other hand, as highlighting the limits of the intervention in bringing about real change. Whether gender conditionalities in broader governance or local governance interventions have been effective or not, the rhetoric of women’s rights and the moral obligation to save and support women have been integrated into most of the policies, programs, and projects that are sponsored through liberal states. Although, in theory, such approaches appear smooth and regulated, the manner in which each recipient country responds entails a complex process involving various factors.

DEMOCRACY AND PATRONAGE-BASED POLITICS IN AFGHANISTAN

Elaborating concepts such as democracy and patronage-based politics is crucial in order to understand how global interventions operate within societies where historical and contextual characteristics are not entirely compatible with what constitutes a liberal democracy. In the post-2001 context, based on the Constitutional Loya Jirga in 2004, 68 seats in the Afghanistan Parliament were designated as “reserved seats” so as to ensure women’s representation in both houses of the Parliament. Indeed, in the 2005 parliamentary elections, women actually surpassed the quota by securing 75 seats (28 percent) across Afghanistan. After decades of violent conflict, war, and the massive level of discrimination against women by

different ruling regimes since the 1970s, the experience of democracy through voting and being elected was re-established and opened the sphere for women to run for office. The allocation of seats was seen as a complementary and critical part of ensuring full representation of women in a democratic system. Yet, in reality, most of the “reserved seats,” especially in the 2009 elections and increasingly afterwards, were filled by women who were sponsored formally or through informal channels by power-brokers, warlords, or those who found themselves unable to compete against their rivals in the election contests (Coburn and Larson 2014; Dimitroff 2005; Nemat 2015; Sissener and Kartawich 2005).

To develop a better understanding, it is necessary to situate Afghanistan’s post-2001 parliamentary elections—and how women’s inclusion was dealt with—in a particular context of liberal state-building intervention in conflict-affected settings governed by a patriarchal and patronage-based system of rule. This will allow us to provide an analysis of the factors that lead to whether or not women secure strong political representation in the country.

PATRIARCHY AND (NEO-) PATRIMONIALISM

As noted previously, I discussed the aspirational goals of “good governance” which include participation, transparency, accountability, and an equitable form of governance as its core principles. Yet, in developing countries, the ability to control violence and to accumulate and distribute resources is the key governance capacity that matters (Khan 2010); hence, any action that restricts the activities of political elites will be resisted or subverted by the elites. Therefore, examining and, indeed, changing gender relations in societies under a patrimonial system of rule first requires an understanding of gender relations or the differing roles of men and women in society. Charrad (2011: 52) describes the linkage

between patriarchy and patrimonial rule as follows: “The connections of patriarchalism as authority expressed in the household over the kinship group and the structure of rule over a larger population have far-reaching implications . . . [in that] the patrimonial ruler ‘owns’ his subjects as he does his wife and his children.”

Charrad’s explanation of the gendered dimensions of patrimonial rule draws upon Max Weber’s description of patrimonialism as a “special case of patriarchal domination-domestic authority decentralized through assignment of land and sometimes of equipment to sons of the house or other dependents” (Weber 1922/1978: 1011 quoted in Charrad 2011: 52). In countries like Afghanistan, patrimonialism is in part about controlling violence and the distribution of resources. Often women are used as a form of currency to strengthen political coalitions or to resolve disputes and conflicts between rival groups through bartering them in marriage. Such practices limit women’s individual agency; however, there are also examples where women have exercised agency within the limited spaces at their disposal (Nemat 2014; Nemat and Werner 2016; Rostami-Povey 2007; Tapper 1991: 21–23).

Kandiyoti (2005: 10) considers how the years of war, particularly under the Taliban regime in Afghanistan, have transformed “traditional” forms of social control where decisions about women’s dress and mobility and relations between men and women—which were previously under the social control of household, kinship group, and community elders—were subsequently mandated by decree and enforced by groups of armed young men representing the state, or the Taliban regime. Kandiyoti (2005: 10) further argues that this approach not only oppressed women, but potentially also disempowered the *non*-Taliban men by “robbing them of their prerogatives.” This example reflects the social aspect of changes that are linked to the political economy of war and how externally funded factions were able to rule and control the population and change the social norms.

Protracted conflict has affected gender relations in other ways as well. For example, war-induced migration has forced many families to flee from Afghanistan to urban centers in Iran and Pakistan. Such mobility and migration resulted in these Afghans gaining access to modern and secular education that, in turn, has changed men’s as well as women’s views about the position of women in society and their public role. Hence, patriarchy under (neo-)patrimonialism should not be seen as static, but rather as a dynamic phenomenon that is constantly changing, both reflecting and generating broader societal shifts.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW

Since the nineteenth century, various political regimes in Afghanistan have made women’s rights an integral part of discourse, seeking to create a stronger public role for women in socio-political and economic spheres. Support for reforms first emerged under the rule of Amir Abdur Rahman Khan in the 1800s. He ordered the abolition of some traditional customs (such as forcing widows to marry their deceased husband’s brother), raised the age of marriage, allowed women to inherit property, and secured women the right to divorce under defined conditions (Ahmed-Gosh 2003). Abdur Rahman Khan’s successors—Habibullah Khan in the early 1900s, followed by King Amanullah Khan in the 1920s—attempted to build on these reforms by sending Afghan girls abroad for education, building schools for girls beyond the capital, and denouncing polygamy. Despite resistance from some conservative segments of the population, women from Amanullah’s family—particularly his wife, Queen Soraya—were instrumental in promoting women’s public roles in Afghan society. Yet, Amanullah Khan’s government was toppled by Habibullah Kalakani in 1929, whose rule was somewhat similar to the Taliban’s, as he closed all schools for women and all Western education centers (Ahmed-Ghosh 2003: 7; Nemat

2011). Following this brief period of turmoil, the country embarked on expanding public spaces for women in the early 1930s. Many women were educated as teachers, nurses, lawyers, doctors, engineers, and in other professions, and they were able to assume formal, public roles in government offices in the cities. However, women in rural areas often remained isolated, with less access to education and other services. More recently, Article 25 of Afghanistan's 1964 Constitution emphasized the equal rights and obligations of all Afghans without discrimination or preference, and this, for the first time, opened the space for women to vote and to be elected to public office (Nemat 2011). Since then, a limited number of women have become members of parliament or have assumed leadership positions in a few government offices.

Rapid reforms continued in the 1970s under the regime of the Soviet-sponsored People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA). Women's literacy efforts and broader land reform campaigns were used to extend reforms to rural and remote areas. The PDPA made education compulsory for girls and boys, as well as for adults, and raised the marriage age to sixteen. The PDPA's radical socialist agenda—most notably its promotion of state-atheism, confiscation of land, and abolishment of bride prices—triggered strong reactions by the local population, especially among power-brokers (Ahmed-Ghosh 2003; Grau and Jalali 2002). In Kabul, women were relatively active as party central committee members and cabinet members, as well as participants in anti-government activities such as demonstrations and the distribution of anti-government propaganda (Benard 2002). However, at the sub-national level, outside of the major provincial capitals, there was significant opposition to supporting women's literacy and their involvement in politics.

The civil war period of the 1990s and the Taliban's rule of 1996 to 2001 brought a major backsliding in many of the reforms, once again restricting women to household roles. Systematic

discrimination against women began during the Mujahiddin era in the early 1990s where, due to ongoing factional fighting, most of the country's institutions were damaged and their staff, particularly female staff, lost their jobs. This situation was intensified under the Taliban and included various decrees related to Afghan women and to Afghan cultural issues (see Amnesty International 1999; Rashid 2000: 217–19). By the mid-1990s, the public infrastructure had been significantly damaged or destroyed, and funding for education and other public services decreased dramatically, leaving non-governmental organizations to fill the gaps through confined projects with very limited outreach. Additionally, the formal ruling regimes promoted a far more restrictive and fundamentalist approach with regards to women's mobility and access to services. They eventually eliminated Afghan women's right to education and to participation in the political sphere. However, it is important to recognize the silent forms of resistance and resilience that the Afghan people, particularly women, performed during this period: for example, by running home-based literacy and health education classes for women and girls, and continuing to work in the health sector (Nemat 2011: 22–25; also see Rostami-Povey 2007).

WOMEN IN PARLIAMENTARY POLITICS

One effective way to examine Afghan women's participation in the political realm is to consider women and their motivations for participating in political activities, such as parliamentary elections, and also to examine factors that facilitate and hinder this process. As such, parts of the following analysis are linked to my previous publications (Nemat 2015; Nemat and Werner 2016). According to Afghanistan's 2004 Constitution, women's participation in elections is obligatory. Furthermore, there is a 25 percent quota for women's inclusion in the Lower House of Parliament,

and women should constitute 50 percent of the Upper House appointees selected by the president, and 20 percent of the “reserved seats” in the provincial and district councils (Afghanistan Constitution 2004; Afghanistan Electoral Law 2014).

Afghan women’s political participation, in general, in the post-2001 political context has been linked to the relative openness of the socio-political atmosphere. With greater demand from the international community and the political elite allying with them, and with some local and grassroots women leaders seeking leadership positions at different levels, various power-holders or patrons have also used women’s “reserved seats” for their own interest by sponsoring women who could then become advocates for their own political and economic interests within the system. This has been particularly significant in areas where election campaigns or contestations among male candidates from rival groups were more intense. In such areas, during previous parliamentary elections, independent women or those without patronage-network support lost the elections to women who enjoyed such support. The decision-making process among the women candidates differed between those who ran relatively independent campaigns in comparison with those who ran campaigns sponsored by stronger patrons or power-brokers. In the former case, women had far more liberty and flexibility in how to run their campaigns and who to reach out to, as they were able to use their own constituencies and use their agency in building coalitions with other members to reach their goal. The constituencies could be defined in the line of geographical, tribal, family, and political affiliates, as well as gender-based affiliates, as candidates sought to mobilize more women to vote for them.

In contrast, women candidates who were directly sponsored by an influential power-broker, lacked independence and had to rely on the sponsor’s organizational network in terms of organizing and running campaigns and even visiting certain areas and meeting particular people and officials. As voters, women were encouraged

to take part by voting, in some instances, according to their own wishes, while in others, following family or larger community’s desire to vote for a particular candidate. Therefore, the motivations among women as candidates and as voters have differed depending on the context, the position and affiliations a candidate had with larger power-brokers, and their popularity (or lack of) in the given context. And although rare, in the later elections (e.g., in 2010 and the provincial council elections of 2014) some women also acted as patrons or network supporters to other women.

Various factors have fostered Afghan women’s political participation and running for parliamentary seats, such as international donors’ reiteration of political commitment to women’s political participation and also donors’ provision of resources specifically for women candidates, such as campaign training, printing of posters, and inclusion of voting information for women in civic education trainings so as to provide awareness of their obligation to vote. Such interest or indirect pressure also has encouraged the government of Afghanistan to take practical actions in supporting female candidates during elections. For instance, during the last parliamentary and provincial council elections, the government attempted to ensure the safety of female candidates by providing trained guards.

The government’s commitment to women’s political participation, however limited in some instances, has resulted in strengthening the roles of women in politics and in ensuring that their voting rights are guaranteed. For instance, while some members of the previous (and current) government view women’s political participation as a necessity and constitutional obligation, others use this as leverage to attract international donors’ attention and also use women’s inclusion in parliament as a means to secure their own personal or group goals. Overall, the more open social and political environment in the post-2001 context—in terms of acceptability of women’s public roles—has also been an important factor

in facilitating women's role in politics, and in electoral democracy in particular.

Furthermore, it is important to note that the emergence of a new class of women leaders from rural communities and urban settings, who have become active particularly in the provision of social services, has also facilitated the participation of a number of women in politics who have emerged as independent candidates and have run their own electoral campaigns. Nevertheless, some women candidates have become co-opted or have been defeated by rival women candidates who received support from patronage-based networks or powerful men. This is a significant issue as it demonstrates how Afghan women's public roles, as independent agents, have been threatened by those who seek to keep women under the influence or control of *patronage networks* and of a *patriarchal system*.

Overall, the major hindering factor related to women's political participation has been the lack of sufficient security and safety arrangements. As Lough et al. (2012) have highlighted, some security arrangements to protect female candidates were implemented in the 2009–2010 elections. However, such arrangements were not adequate in preventing attacks, and the perpetrators of these attacks on female political leaders have not been held accountable. Indeed, female political leaders, including elected members of parliament and councils, have become a regular target of assassinations, kidnappings, and terrorist attacks (Nemat and Samadi 2012). The Taliban and other armed groups have continued to issue public threats against women candidates as well as voters and female staff of the electoral offices (Lough et al. 2012: 13).

This lack of security has led to further instability across the country over recent years, and it also has further threatened the fragile situation of women in politics. As such, the Afghan government's inability to provide reasonable protection for women leaders and to investigate cases of murdered women politicians and other public figures has weakened, to a large extent,

motivation among other women to stand as candidates for elections or to take part in campaigns and in voting. Nonetheless, the fact that women are being targeted, can also be seen as an indicator of the fear that opponents of Afghan women's political participation feel from the increasing and more active role of women in decision-making (Nemat and Samadi 2012).

Clearly, there are both covert and overt opponents to women's political participation within the current system. The use (or more precisely, abuse) of quotas and women's space in the political system by different power-brokers and patronage networks, including drug-mafia, warlords or strongmen, and other corrupt officials, is another serious hindering factor. While, in appearance, there is female representation in parliament, in reality women who are elected to "reserved seats," through previously mentioned channels of power-brokers and patronage networks, continue to fail in advancing the women's agenda, either due to insufficient capacity to address these concerns or because of their subjugation to the aforementioned power-brokers. Significant examples of these include the blockage of the Elimination of Violence Against Women (EVAW) law in the Afghanistan Parliament by conservative MPs and the failure of a large number of female MPs to be present to vote in support of the first female candidate for the Afghan Supreme Court (Hasrat-Nazimi and Saifullah 2015; Roehrs 2013). In sum, although the Afghan legal framework and political commitments have been formally portrayed as equal in terms of women's and men's rights to vote and to be elected, opportunities for women, both as voters and as candidates, have been far too unequal and too limited (Lough et al. 2012).

"MODERNIZING" AFGHAN WOMEN?

The justification for post-2001 external intervention, particularly the War on Terror in

Afghanistan, has coincided with rhetoric on the “liberation” of Afghan women (Abu-Lughod 2002: 783–790; Kapur 2002: 211). From presidential speeches to discussions among traditional leaders in Afghanistan’s local settings, women’s rights and women’s political participation in decision-making have become part of the discursive debates within Afghan politics since 2001. Furthermore, the Taliban’s ill-treatment of women has contributed significantly to such a justification. The broadcasting and publishing of a public execution video was one powerful factor. Specifically, a woman named Zarmina was publicly executed by Taliban police in the Ghazi Sports Stadium on November 17, 1999. The incident was filmed by the Revolutionary Association of the Women of Afghanistan and received significant media coverage in Kabul on the day of its occurrence; later, the video was publicized globally, symbolizing an image of the Taliban’s treatment of women (see ABC News 2002). Indeed, still other photos of beatings and amputations of women also have become part of War on Terror propaganda posters and billboard ads.

Securing women’s rights and ensuring their full participation in all aspects of life were goals of the historical Bonn Agreement, which has become the foundation for the post-2001 political settlement (Nemat 2011). Cooperation with the United States and its allies in Afghanistan has meant that every Afghan leader, including warlord commanders and veterans of the anti-Soviet Mujahiddin era, are obliged to express their support for women’s rights (at least in speeches). Starting with former president Hamid Karzai (first as chairman of the transitional administration), all higher-ranking and lower-ranking officials have expressed their support through somewhat superficial statements to the media (e.g., celebrating International Women’s Day with speeches about women’s rights), with a purpose of showing allegiance to the US and ally efforts. In practice, however, very few among the

political elites have accepted or endorsed outstanding women leaders who spoke up in parliament or in other political settings.

Yet, in contrast, this opportunity to empower Afghan women has been recognized by others, including moderate Afghan leaders within government and civil society, who have used the international and national political commitment to encourage donors to fund more women-focused programs and projects. Also, by using Islamic references, women’s organizations and moderate Afghan politicians have succeeded in presenting a far more lasting and moderate model of democracy and of women’s rights that could also be accepted, even by conservative elements of Afghan society (Ahmed-Ghosh 2006).

Since 2001, international donors, government leadership, and allies have expressed greater political commitment to women’s economic empowerment; and women-focused programs and projects have significantly increased their outreach, thereby now covering relatively larger parts of both urban and rural areas. Other recent and significant contributions to women’s advancement include constitutional guarantees and electoral rights for women, including their representation in parliament, institutional and legal reforms that aim to ensure women’s access to the public sector and to the justice system, national and subnational policies that include gender as a crosscutting theme, and the ratification of various international treaties and conventions that mandate the Afghan government to report on women’s rights. Although questions may be raised as to the effectiveness and sustainability of these advancements, they have undoubtedly opened more space for Afghan women’s meaningful participation in the public sphere. Nonetheless, the unprecedented flow of resources and the expanded political support have still not resulted in the complete transformation of gender relations and women’s place in the society.

Mixed Motivations and Instrumentalization of Women's Empowerment

In spite of the advancements just noted, valid questions arise. If political will is present and international interventions have been endorsed by national leaders—who not only agreed, but supported women's full inclusion in all political, social, and economic spheres—then why do women continue to remain isolated from key hubs of power and decision-making and why do women's rights continue to be systematically violated? And why is their security, political participation, and legal status at even greater risk than in the past 16 years? Scholars and policy-makers have different responses to these questions which relate to their own world-view (see, for example, Arat-Koc 2002; Chaudhary et al. 2011; Kandiyoti 2005; Rostami-Povey 2007; Wimpelmann 2017). Arguably, there are several important factors to consider when trying to answer these questions.

Military intervention related to the War on Terror and its linkage to the goal of “liberating” Afghan women and “saving” them from the “barbarian” Taliban brought increased attention to women's rights efforts, which was followed by a substantial flow of resources into Afghanistan (see, for example, Hunt and Rygiel 2006; Kapur 2002; Runyan and Peterson 2013). However, for many intervening governments, institutions, and organizations, Afghanistan and its people were considered as passive recipients of aid and assistance. This meant that international operations were seen as being applied to a *tabula rasa* or a blank slate (Gilman 2003; Hunt and Rygiel 2006; Latham 2000; Nemat 2016; Roxborough 2012; Runyan and Peterson 2013). It was assumed that once the Taliban were eliminated as a ruling regime, there would be no resistance to women's active public roles (Kapur 2002). This assumption led the international community to largely overlook existing power structures and the dominance of

the patronage-based system, which obviously has patriarchy at its core (Charrad 2011). Most project documents, policy papers, and media outputs highlighted the Taliban's anti-women mentality, associating every aspect of women's subordination and discrimination with the Taliban and their followers (Nemat 2014). In reality, a far more complex set of power relations exists, with competing forces (in addition to the Taliban) operating for their own party, group, community, or larger constituency's interests, and thereby defending women's rights or respecting them only if those rights do not threaten their own power and authority (Nemat 2014). Ultimately, to understand the situation of Afghan women in the contemporary context, it is crucial to recognize that the Taliban are not the only forces discriminating against women and that there is a far more complex set of power relations that results in the subordination of women.

Furthermore, the reality is that there have been mixed motivations and intentions by various funding countries and international agencies. Safeguarding their own national security, eliminating safe havens for terrorist operations at a global level, maintaining a stronger presence of influence in the region, and introducing a liberal democratic system through constitutional democracy, development aid, and investment and privatization are among the factors that have led to international intervention and that have, directly or indirectly, impacted gender relations in Afghanistan. In sum, the “development environment” in Afghanistan is complex, with various modes of assistance being implemented by multiple countries and international organizations. These modes range from Wilsonian approaches based on external interventionism as a response to existing needs, to Dunantist approaches based on humanitarian principles, to religious and faith-based approaches that sometimes counter these other approaches. All these approaches operate in one context and for the same population, yet impact men and women in different ways. Indeed,

this is an issue that is not limited to Afghanistan (see Mitri 2014).

Short-Term Surge and the Question of Sustainability

One of the major issues related to intervention models is that of long-term international sustainability. The scale and flow of resources, political commitments, and intergovernmental relations all affect how women-focused programs and projects are implemented and sustained. For instance, the “Quick Impact Projects” (QIPs) became an important tool for US funded programs, and by 2007 over 440 such projects had been completed, the majority of which were small infrastructure projects in rural areas (USAID 2013). Yet, the drawback of these projects—particularly those focused on women and gender-related activities—has been the short implementation timeframe (generally less than six months) wherein only a few outcomes could be assessed, thereby raising the issue of long-term sustainability.

Furthermore, while donor funding increased dramatically with the military surge in 2009, it has been declining since the drawdown of military forces began in 2012 (SIGAR 2013). This has led to a backsliding of progress related to jobs and infrastructure (e.g., roads, clinics, and schools). The elimination of large-scale, off-budget funding has resulted in large-scale unemployment, limited access to jobs, and an increasing number of dysfunctional buildings, clinics, and schools that the government cannot afford to maintain and sustain without international funding. Various examples of these projects can be found in the quarterly reports from the US Special Inspector General for Afghanistan Reconstruction (SIGAR 2008 to present).

Indeed, innovative approaches are needed to address the issues of donor dependency, lack of sustainability, and more-balanced funding. In terms of the economy, Afghan women lack direct access to markets, sufficient skills to run their

own businesses beyond the project life-cycle, and lasting mechanisms to support micro-level, meso-level, and macro-level enterprises that benefit women.

Most significantly, women’s rights projects, in turn, have not adequately challenged the structural aspects of women’s subordination related to patriarchy that result in their lower status in the domestic and public spheres. Thus, programs and projects that seek to empower women or build their capacities must broaden their focus to the key cultural elements of patriarchy within Afghan society in order to enhance their effectiveness. As one example, in protesting the efficacy of women’s rights workshops and trainings, a woman trainee complained that although she has acquired many certificates, her place in society has not yet improved. Undoubtedly, behavioral and attitudinal changes take time, but there is little evidence that short-term, one-time workshops, which most often focus *only* on women, can lead to such changes. In addition, often women and men have material motivation (i.e., receiving per diem, travel sponsorship, and other incentives) to participate in these workshops which makes applying what they have learned less likely.

Finally, in examining rural and urban interventions, there is no doubt that during the post-2001 era—with the aim of expanding the Afghan government’s influence into the districts and communities—unprecedented nationwide coverage has been achieved. However, for numerous reasons, outreach to rural areas still remains limited, particularly in regard to women’s active and meaningful engagement in public life. For example, particular incorrect assumptions have led to inappropriate or less effective interventions in Afghanistan’s rural settings: the idea that illiteracy is equivalent to lack of knowledge, that rural women are passive objects with no power and authority, that rural women have little or no mobility or access to productive roles in the economy, and that rural women do not resist patriarchy. Although more in-depth research is

required to fully examine these misconceptions, contemporary and historical literature and ethnography on Afghan women already challenge them by highlighting women's agency, their active role in the economy, and their productive roles and power and influence within the existing patriarchal system of rule (see, for example, Chaudhary et al. 2011; Kandiyoti 2005).

AFGHAN WOMEN AND CHANGE

Clearly, Afghan women's position in society and overall gender norms have been affected by different aspects of interventions in the country, both historically and in recent years. As Kandiyoti (2005) has argued, gender norms were even affected under the Taliban regime in the late 1990s, where male members of the households—who traditionally considered themselves as protectors of their female relatives—found themselves helpless in public spaces as Taliban police controlled women's dress code, their appearance, and whether they were accompanied by a “correct” close male family member or *Mahram* (Kandiyoti 2005).

During the post-2001 context of Afghanistan, however, as a result of neoliberal interventions through political commitments, development projects and programs, and also the promotion of liberal values through the mass media, and with generous financial support, women in major cities and across the country have received various forms of support, ranging from access to basic social services to means of communications such as mobile phones, internet access, and attending national ceremonies. Furthermore, during the post-2001 era, there has been increased focus on women at the subnational level, and thus women in districts and villages have received more attention in the post-2001 context than at any other time in the history, albeit with still large discrepancies and limitations.

Ultimately, Afghan women are now entering more prominently into the public sphere, not only

because of the rhetoric of women's “liberation” but also because such rhetoric has been somewhat integrated into the internal political and economic dynamics of the country. As this rhetoric and resulting actions have dramatically challenged traditional and deeply embedded norms of patriarchy within Afghan society, Afghan women have gained greater access to facilities and opportunities and they also have felt more secure to have a public presence and to have a voice.

At the same time, while empowered, Afghan women have become subject to increased domestic violence. Therefore, one can argue that the increase in such violence is directly or indirectly correlated with the surge of international projects and funding that has empowered women, raised their awareness, and provided them with tools to become more independent (also see Billaud 2015). Yet, while such projects have sought to improve the situation of Afghan women, these projects have largely overlooked how men—with their masculine identity operating within the same household, community, and broader society—cope with, or adjust to, Afghan women's increased levels of empowerment. Therefore, such projects should broaden their scope to include men and therein address women's situation within the broader context of Afghan patriarchal culture.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I have sought to convey the socio-economic and political complexities of Afghanistan and to highlight critical issues related to gender. More specifically, international liberal intervention projects since 2001 have produced mixed results in Afghanistan. This has, for the most part, been due to the fact that liberal values—centered around the promotion of democracy, good governance, and gender equality—were introduced into Afghanistan, a society with a complex, pre-existing socio-political system based on patriarchy and on patronage systems of rule and power relations. The dominance of such

a system raises the question of whether Afghanistan can establish a just and democratic system or instead will continue with a (neo-)patrimonial system wherein the nature of relations remains the same as before, i.e. based on patronage-politics and superficial elections. Under such circumstances, which have included phony elections, relations between the elected parliamentarians and their constituencies have been based purely on patronage rather than on citizens' rights to representation in a truly democratic sense. Furthermore, patronage-based politics has been inspired and reinforced socially by patriarchy, and as such, politics and patriarchy have formally and informally imposed limitations on women's access to political participation.

Although the focus on Afghan women's issues is not unique to the post-2001 period, the scale and scope of interventions and the response of the Afghan population are particularly noteworthy. Further, the effectiveness of various approaches used by international donors and governments to empower Afghan women also has produced mixed outcomes. Thus, many different national and international social actors, with their own strategic, geopolitical, military, and factional or personal objectives, have instrumentalized women's rights. In this context, serious challenges remain related to mixed motivations, misconceptions, and long-term impact and sustainability. However, in the end, the day-to-day reality of Afghan women's experiences must be recognized, and at the same time, the resilience, resistance, proactivity, and agency of Afghan women must be acknowledged, harnessed, and integrated into any process of seeking to enhance their empowerment and to improve their well-being.

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Part V

Eurasia and Central Asia

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Chapter twenty-six

Women in Azerbaijan Decades of Change and Challenges

Mehrangiz Najafizadeh

Situated west of the Caspian Sea, with Turkmenistan, Kazakhstan, and the remainder of Central Asia to the east, Azerbaijan is at the crossroads of Europe and Asia. While Azerbaijan and countries of Central Asia have their own unique attributes, they share particular cultural and sociopolitical elements including Turkic linguistic ties, Islamic heritage, and 70 years under the Soviet Union, as well as periods of political and economic transition following the demise of the Soviet Union.

For Azerbaijan, the declaration of independence from the Soviet Union in 1991 brought the establishment of the contemporary Republic of Azerbaijan and ushered in a new era of sociopolitical and economic change for the Azeri people. In this chapter, I focus on the contemporary era and on the changing “place” (status, roles, and rights) of women in Azeri society. However, given that major social, political, and economic events in the late 1800s and 1900s were instrumental in reconstructing Azeri women’s place and identity in Azeri society and provided the foundation for women’s place in contemporary Azerbaijan, I begin with an overview of this historical context.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT AND AZERI WOMEN

Through the Russo-Persian wars of the early 1800s and the Gulistan Treaty of 1813 and the

Turkmanchay Treaty of 1828, Persia conceded the region now known as the Republic of Azerbaijan to Czarist Russia. This period, from the 1800s through the first two decades of the twentieth century, witnessed gradual but dramatic change in women’s “place” within Azeri society. Despite being governed by Czarist Russia, the daily lives of Azeris remained largely shaped by a lengthy and persistent patriarchal cultural foundation and by a dominant Islamic religious ideology. Indeed, throughout this era, firmly established *patriarchy* and *Islamic religious ideology* remained as key elements in the *social construction* of women’s “place” in Azeri society. As such, a majority of Azeri women occupied submissive roles, remained illiterate, were largely relegated to passive caregiving roles within the family, and were precluded from active participation in public life, as men dominated the public arena.

However, during the 1800s and early 1900s, two major events occurred that ultimately had a major impact on the *social reconstruction* of Azeri women’s roles. *First*, on the economic front, Azerbaijan emerged as a major producer and international exporter of oil, which brought about new commercial and cultural contacts with Russia and Europe. Such cultural contacts included increased exposure to ideologies of secularism and to Western cultural conceptions of women’s roles. The oil boom also brought about the accumulation of immense monetary wealth by Europeans

and Russians, as well as by some Azeris the latter of whom ultimately engaged in major philanthropic efforts to support social reforms, including reforms pertaining to Azeri women.

Second, the Azeri people also witnessed the emergence and expansion of the Azeri Enlightenment Movement during this era, led by Azeri intelligentsia including Mirza Fatali Akhundov, a philosopher and literary figure who, during the 1800s, advocated social reforms such as expanding literacy, eliminating religious fanaticism and intolerance, and enhancing the rights of women. Other key intelligentsia during this era of dramatic social reform and of the social reconstruction of the roles of Azeri women included Hasan bey Zardabi, founder of the first Azeri-language newspaper *əkinçi* (1875–1877); Haji Zeynalabdin Taghiyev, Azeri oil baron and philanthropist who, in the late 1800s and early 1900s, financially supported various Azeri-language newspapers, founded the first boarding school for Azeri Muslim girls, and engaged in (and financially supported) numerous other social reform activities; Jalil Mammadgluzade, editor of the social satirical and political activist magazine, *Molla Nəsrəddin* (1906–1931); and prominent Azeri women such as Hamida Javanshir, women's rights activist and philanthropist, and Khadija Alibeyova, first woman editor of an Azeri-language women's newspaper *Ishiq* (1911–1912).

Through their varied and extensive social reform activities and campaigns—including advocacy for women's education, women's public participation, and women's rights—the Azeri intelligentsia established the ideological foundation and fostered dynamic sociopolitical and cultural change during this era. Still others, including Ali bey Huseynzade, Ahmed Agaoglu, Ali Mardan-bey Topchubashov, and especially Mammad Amin Rasulzade—intellectual, activist, editor of newspapers *Təkamül* (1906–1907) and *Yoldas*, (1907), and first president of the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic—played critical roles in translating cultural notions of Azeri identity and nationalism into a political movement. With the founding of the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic in 1918, *Azeri women's roles*

were socially reconstructed and Azeri women's "place" was formally redefined, as legal measures were adopted granting women the right to vote and to participate in public and political realms (Akhundov 1998; Alstadt 1992: 89–107, 1996: 199–209; Bolukbasi 2011; Cornell 2011: 12–13; Hacilar 2012; Najafizadeh 2016, 2017; Najafov 2008; Rasulzade 1999; Republic of Azerbaijan Supreme Court n.d.; Seyid-zade 2011; Swietochowski 1985, 1995: 25–36, 68–103).

In stark contrast, April 1920 witnessed an abrupt end to the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic as the Bolsheviks invaded Azerbaijan and ushered in the Soviet era (1920–1991). Under Soviet rule, the influence of Islamic religious ideology gradually declined as the ideology of socialist egalitarianism became the rallying call. Such anti-Islamic efforts intensified in the late 1920s. The Soviet Cultural Revolution of this period portrayed Islam as the “enemy of women” and sought to foster the liberation of Azeri women as government officials prescribed the de-veiling of Azeri women and the integration of women into the Soviet educational system and labor force, as well as into other elements of the newly established Soviet public space. Clearly, Soviet literacy campaigns and efforts to encourage Azeri women to discard the traditional Islamic veil and to participate in the labor force were critical elements in the *social reconstruction* of Azeri women's roles and in the *social construction* of the new “Soviet Azeri woman,” who through “liberation” was expected to embrace Soviet ideology and the Soviet sociopolitical system (Alstadt 1992: 108–129; Cornell 2011: 31–37; Dilbazi 1999; Hadjibeyli 1957, 1958; Kuliev 1958; Najafizadeh 2003, 2012, 2017; Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003; Suny 1996).

The 1930s, in turn, witnessed Stalin's “great purge” of 1936–1938 which brought the imprisonment, exile, or execution of many Azeris—including both men and women, ranging from teachers and doctors in rural areas to literary figures and journalists in Baku, as well as intellectuals and even Communist Party members and government and military officials—who were perceived

as opponents of the Soviet system. Although numbers vary, well over 120,000 Azeris were executed or deported to Siberia or to Central Asia (Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003). Furthermore, as I have noted elsewhere (Najafizadeh 2017), political persecution continued until Stalin's death in 1953, with Azeri women accounting for 15 to 25 percent of those perceived as "enemies of the people." These women included both opponents and also relatives of men who opposed the Soviet state. In other cases, wives were forced to divorce their husbands or confront exile to a prison camp (Najafizadeh 2017; also see Alstadt 1992: 131–150; Bala 1957; Cornell 2011: 37–39; Rahimov 1999; Sadikhli 1999, 2006).

With the adoption of the new Constitution of Azerbaijan in 1937, Azeri women were granted "equal rights with men in every sphere of economic, public, cultural, social, and political activity" (Novosti Press 1967: 20). Nonetheless, such formal declarations of gender equality did not always translate into reality. Indeed, whereas the Sovietization activities of the 1920s, 1930s, and 1940s provided women opportunities in education and in workforce and political participation, the Soviet era also reinforced (legally and otherwise) various elements of Azeri patriarchal culture that emphasized traditional "female" roles within the home and family. As such, the state-proclaimed gender equality of the Soviet era was never fully achieved. Rather, most Azeri women merely experienced an expansion of roles such that these women continued to assume traditional caregiving roles within the private sphere of their homes and families while adding the burden of new roles in the public arena, including active participation in the labor force (Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003).

THE POST-SOVIET ERA: SOCIOPOLITICAL AND ECONOMIC TRANSITION

The declaration of independence from the Soviet Union on October 18, 1991, marked the beginning

of a period of sociopolitical and economic transition entailing initial jubilation. Most certainly, independence from Soviet socioeconomic and political ideology and control marked the start of a monumental period of self-determination for Azeris, including the emergence of women's advocacy groups and related non-governmental organizations (NGOs). Likewise, given the Islamic heritage of Azeris, independence from Soviet state atheist policies that had sought to eradicate Islamic ideology similarly marked the re-emergence of Islam, a quite significant change. Yet, independence also brought harsh realities of transition that posed numerous challenges for the Azeri people. In *the political realm*, the initial years of independence were quite tumultuous with the first president, Ayaz N. Mutalibov, being replaced by Abulfaz Elchibey in 1992, and with Elchibey being replaced by Heydar Aliyev in 1993. Heydar Aliyev was widely recognized by Azeris as a dynamic and charismatic leader, one who provided critical leadership from 1993 to 2003 in addressing sociopolitical and economic tensions and pressures that accompanied the young republic's transition from Soviet control to independence and participation in the global economy (see, e.g., Cornell 2011; Kamrava 2001; Najafizadeh 2015, 2017; SPPRED 2003, 2005; State Committee 2009, 2014; UNDP 1999).

Similarly, in *the economic realm*, like much of Central Asia the initial years of independence from Soviet-era economic policies and transition to privatization and free-market economy were fraught with disarray and uncertainties that impacted all Azeris. Indeed, the demise of the Soviet Union as a political entity also resulted in the demise of much of the former Soviet social and economic infrastructure within Azerbaijan, with a dramatic decline in public well-being. With over half the population on the poverty level and unemployment estimates approaching 40 percent, the scarcity of employment options left many Azeri men unable to find positions in their previous occupations. Consequently, many men remained unemployed while others migrated to Russia or to other countries in search of suitable

employment. For many Azeri women, in turn, the negative elements of economic transition further reinforced the “double burden” as women continued their traditional roles as primary caregivers within their families while simultaneously searching out income from formal employment or through the informal economy to support their families. In contrast to the former Soviet system where all Azeris, including women, had been largely protected by the “Soviet safety-net” and had been assured employment in either agricultural or industrial sectors, the economic disarray of independence brought dramatic increases in women’s unemployment not only in these sectors but also in education and medical systems, where large numbers of Soviet-era Azeri women had previously been employed (Ibrahimbekova 2000; Mikailova 1999; Najafizadeh 2001, 2015, 2017; Sabi 1999; Samedova 2000).

In quantitative terms, the negative impact of the initial years of economic transition is clear. For example, whereas in 1991–1992, Azerbaijan ranked 71 out of 173 nations on the United Nations Development Index, by the late 1990s it had dropped to 90 out of 173 countries, and it ranked 109 in overall health care (UNDP 1994: 130, 1999, 2000: 15; WHO 2000: 152). Furthermore, the quality of formal education declined, as did school enrollments and funding for education (Najafizadeh 2001; UNDP 2000: 19–20), and poverty dramatically increased, with 60 percent of the population on the poverty line and almost 20 percent categorized as “very poor” (IMF 2000: 33–34; UNDP 2000: 22; Mikailova 1999; Najafizadeh 2006).

Economic problems of the transition were further intensified by the *Nagorno-Karabakh War* with Armenia which had started in 1988 and continued during the early 1990s. The war resulted in the loss of thousands of Azeri lives and in nearly one million refugees and internally displaced persons (IDPs), a quite sizable number given Azerbaijan’s total population of 7.3 million in 1991. Constituting 71 percent of the IDPs, women were severely affected by the war as they shouldered

both the burden of the economic crisis as well as the burden of forced displacement and caring for their families as most lived in tents, railroad box-cars, abandoned buildings, and other “temporary” housing (Cornell 1999, 2011; Heydarov 2009; Najafizadeh 2003, 2006, 2013; UNDP 1999, 2000; UNHCR 2009).

As such, economic transition and the war impacted many Azeri families psychologically, resulting in stress and anxiety that contributed to increased substance abuse, domestic violence, and family conflict. Indeed, a survey in four regions found that 37 percent of women had experienced violence within their family and 75 percent viewed “lack of money” during the transition as a major factor related to such family violence (Abdulvahabova 2000; Ibrahimbekova 2000; Najafizadeh 2003, 2006; Seifullaghizi 2000; UNDP-GID 2000).

In the context of transitioning from a Soviet-based economy to free-market economy and in the context of the Nagorno-Karabakh War and its economic and social impact, the task of bringing stability to Azerbaijan’s fragile new economy was critical to addressing the pressing issues of poverty, unemployment, and forced displacement. And indeed, the redevelopment of Azerbaijan’s oil and natural gas resources ultimately did provide the much needed economic revival. In September 1994, Azerbaijan President Heydar Aliyev signed the “Contract of the Century,” an agreement between the Republic of Azerbaijan and a consortium of international oil companies, headed by British Petroleum (BP), which led to the re-vitalization of the Azerbaijan oil industry and included the construction of the Baku-Tbilisi-Ceyhan Pipeline in 2005 that was critical for the export of Azerbaijan oil to Western markets. The signing of the “Contract” was a major economic event as it laid the foundation for post-Soviet Azerbaijan to begin redeveloping its position as a major international supplier of oil and natural gas, thereby resolving the post-independence economic crisis of the 1990s and improving the well-being of the populace (Cornell 2011; Gokay

1998; Hoffman 1999; Najafizadeh 2015; Sagheb and Javadi 1994).

THE AZERI WOMEN'S MOVEMENT DURING TRANSITION

The Role of the State

During the Soviet era, Azeri women and men were formally decreed as equal. Although this ideal of equality did not always translate to reality, Azeri women did attain major benefits compared to the Czarist era. Equal pay for equal work, a quota system providing representation in the political system, and a government agency tasked with protecting women's welfare and women's rights are a few examples. Independence from the Soviet Union, in turn, provided Azeri women with new forms of freedom, including political and religious freedom, but it also affected women adversely through the dissolution of particular social programs and laws that had benefited women during the Soviet era (Najafizadeh 2015).

Concurrent with the dramatic political and economic change during the initial years of transition, the decade of the 1990s marked the beginning of the enactment of Azerbaijan government legislation, decrees, and acts pertaining to Azeri women, and it also marked the emergence of the post-Soviet Azeri women's movement (see, e.g., Cornell 2011; Kamrava 2001; SPPRED 2003; State Committee 2009, 2014; UNDP 1999). Of major significance was President Heydar Aliyev's 1994 Decree that led to the formation of the Azerbaijan National Preparatory Committee, which included women both from government agencies and from Azeri women's advocacy organizations (NGOs) and which was tasked with preparing for participation in the Fourth World Conference on Women, to be held in Beijing in 1995. Two points are particularly

noteworthy. *First*, President Aliyev's support for the establishment of the Preparatory Committee signaled a significant commitment by the newly independent Azerbaijani government to accord formal recognition and legitimacy to Azeri women's issues. *Second*, because formal education for both women and men had been a cornerstone of Soviet Azerbaijan social policy, a quite sizable number of highly educated Azeri women constituted a major force in the Azeri women's movement and in advocating on behalf of all Azeri women in newly independent Azerbaijan (Najafizadeh 2003, 2015; Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003).

Of central importance to the institutionalization of women's issues, Azerbaijan joined the international Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) in June 1995, and Azeri women, including both government and NGO representatives participated in the World Conference on Women in Beijing in September 1995. Certainly, the Beijing 1995 conference and subsequent cooperative efforts established the foundation for future NGO activities and for government decrees and legislation pertaining to women's issues, including: President Aliyev's 1998 Decree—"On Measures to Promote Women's Roles in Azerbaijan"—and the establishment of the Azerbaijan State Committee on Women's Issues to foster women's rights and also to develop relations with Azeri women's NGOs; the president's 2000 Decree, "On the Implementation of State Policy on Women's Issues in Azerbaijan"; and the president's signing in September 2000 of the "Millennium Declaration" which committed Azerbaijan to the eight United Nations Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), including the goal of promoting gender equality and the empowerment of women. Such presidential actions were of utmost importance as they provided formal governmental recognition of women's issues, to be followed in subsequent years by additional decrees and laws to protect and benefit women (IMF 2003; Najafizadeh 2015; OHCHR n.d.; UNWomen n.d.).

The Role of Azeri Women's NGOs

Together with government actions, Azerbaijan also witnessed a surge of Azeri women's NGOs (advocacy associations) that sought to address pressing needs of women during this period of social, political, and economic transition. Various factors were instrumental in fostering the emergence and growth of these women's advocacy groups, including: (1) an established base of highly educated women committed to gender equality; (2) increased awareness and sensitivity to issues of public well-being, in the context of the demise of the "Soviet safety-net," the economic-based suffering due to the transition, and the desperate need for humanitarian assistance to IDPs/refugees from the Nagorno-Karabakh War; (3) increased involvement of Azeri women in international conferences and forums that focused attention on women's issues, including the Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing, 1995; (4) increased interaction with international organizations—such as the United Nations Development Programme Gender in Development Project (UNDP-GID), the United Nations NGO Resource Center, the Open Society Institute (OSI-Azerbaijan), and the Initiative for Social Action and Renewal in Eurasia (ISAR)—which provided assistance both in the establishment and in the nurturing of Azeri women's NGOs (Lemberanskaya and Mamedova 2001; Najafizadeh 2001, 2003, 2006; Tohidi 2004; UNDP 1999: 8–12, 61–65).

As an example of one such Azeri NGO, the Azerbaijan Women and Development Center (*Azərbaycan Qadın və İnkişaf Mərkəzi*) was established in 1994 by Elmira Suleymanova: Doctor of Chemistry, academic scholar, and a leading advocate of women's rights. As the first gender-related research center in Azerbaijan, the Azerbaijan Women and Development Center was active in preparations for the Beijing World Conference on Women in 1995 as well as in addressing women's issues following the conference. More specifically, the Center has worked independently, as well as with national and international

agencies, to advocate for Azeri women's well-being by bringing women's issues to the forefront; examples include women's health, gender-based violence, women's social and political rights, and the rights of women IDPs/refugees. In addition, in 2002, Dr. Suleymanova was elected by the parliament to serve as the first Republic of Azerbaijan National Commissioner for Human Rights (Ombudsman), and she continues to serve in that capacity. Furthermore, the Azerbaijan Women and Development Center also continues to function on behalf of Azeri women (Najafizadeh 2003, 2006, 2017).

Taken together, the varied Azerbaijan government actions and the concerted efforts of Azeri women's NGOs have been instrumental in providing Azeri women a "voice" and in the *social reconstruction* of women's roles in the "new" post-Soviet Azeri society.

ECONOMIC RECOVERY AND THE WELL-BEING OF WOMEN

The 1994 "Contract of the Century" and various other economic development activities related to oil and natural gas production and export, discussed previously, ultimately provided substantial economic growth in post-Soviet Azerbaijan. Following President Heydar Aliyev's death in 2003, his son, Ilham Aliyev, was elected President of Azerbaijan, and he continued with development projects to improve the economy and to enhance public well-being. This economic recovery period also brought a construction boom including new housing as well as public infrastructure projects pertaining to water, electricity, and gas distribution, highways, ports, public parks, airports, and other such projects. Further, this period witnessed reductions in poverty and significant improvements in the standard of living, compared to the 1990s (Najafizadeh 2015, 2017). Such improvements in overall public well-being are reflected in the United Nations

Development Program *Human Development Report* (UNDP 2007, 2016) where Azerbaijan had a Human Development Index rank of 77 in 2014, compared to 101 in 2005. Likewise, poverty had declined since the 1990s, and life expectancy had increased quite significantly, from 65 years in the early 1990s to 71 years as of 2015. The economic recovery also had a specific impact on Azeri women's situation as Azeri women occupied 17 percent of the seats in the Azerbaijan Parliament, 94 percent of adult women completed at least some secondary level of schooling, 62 percent of women participated in the labor force, and Azerbaijan ranked 68 out of 188 nations on the UNDP Gender Inequality Index (UNDP 2016).

ISLAM AND WOMEN IN POST-SOVIET AZERBAIJAN

The Republic of Azerbaijan Constitution declares post-Soviet Azerbaijan to be a secular state with freedom for all religions. Although disrupted by 70 years of Soviet efforts to suppress Islam and to promote state-atheism, Islamic practices persisted informally and privately within many Azeri families during the Soviet era. Following independence, Islam initially gained public visibility in Azerbaijan in the early 1990s, and it has become much more public and prominent during recent decades, in part due to the government's acknowledgement and celebration of Azerbaijan's Islamic heritage. Examples include the government's recognition of Islamic holidays such as *Eid al-Adha* and *Eid al-fitr*, the restoration of religious shrines and mosques, and the construction of new mosques. Furthermore, the Holy Koran has been translated into Azerbaijani and is now readily available as are Islam-related books as well as internet-based religious information (Najafizadeh 2015). And various national and international conferences and events have been convened in Azerbaijan, including the conferences "Women in the Islamic World: Traditional

Values and Modernity" in 2009 and "Ministerial Conference on the Role of Women in the Development of the OIC [Organization of Islamic Cooperation] Member States" in 2014, as well as the "2017 Islamic Solidarity Games" with athletes from 54 Islamic nations including Central Asian countries.

Yet, while Islam is an integral part of Azeri cultural heritage and identity and an estimated 93 percent to 99 percent of Azeris view themselves as "Muslim," secular values are also very prominent in Azeri culture, and the most recent data from Win-Gallup International polls indicate that only 34 percent of Azeris consider themselves to be a "religious person." Thus, most Azeris view themselves as Muslim, yet a smaller percentage of Azeris are actually practicing Muslims. Furthermore, most Azeri women do not actively practice Islam, but of those women who do practice, most do so privately in their own homes. Relatedly, only a small percentage of Azeri women actually wear Islamic hijab (head-covering), the reasons ranging from individual choice to familial influence or pressure. Yet, for women, freedom of religion in post-Soviet Azerbaijan is quite significant in that they are now free to practice religion or not to practice and to do so either privately or publicly. For some Azeri women, Islam has become a factor in the *social reconstruction* of their identity and roles in Azeri society (Balci 2004; Cornell 2011; Goyushov 2008; Heyat 2002, 2006, 2008; Najafizadeh 2012, 2015, 2017; Smith 2017; Tohidi 1996, 1997, 1998; Valiyev 2005).

PERSISTING CHALLENGES FOR AZERI WOMEN

Azeri women have achieved major gains in many respects since independence, as reflected in Republic of Azerbaijan codes and laws, such as *The Republic of Azerbaijan Family Code* (1999), giving wife and husband equal property rights; the law *On Guarantees of Equal Rights*

for *Women and Men* (2006), prohibiting discrimination against women in employment and wages, in property rights, and social insurance; *The Republic of Azerbaijan Labor Code* (2010) providing for gender equity and maternity leave for women; and the law *On the Prevention of Domestic Violence* (2010), raising public awareness and developing legal mechanisms and measures to prevent violence, respond to victims, and prosecute perpetrators. Nonetheless, such legal protections, though quite significant, have not been uniformly interpreted or enforced (Gureyeva 2011, 2012; IMF 2003; Najafizadeh 2015; State Committee 2009, 2014; UNDP 1999, 2012a, 2012b). In the following, I provide an overview of some of the continuing challenges facing Azeri women.

Employment

During the 1990s, Azeri women tended to occupy more government jobs and positions in caregiving sectors—such as teaching, social work, and health services—where salaries had declined significantly (SSCAR 2000a: 103, 2000b: 70, 78; UNICEF 1999: 77). Further, although women constituted 77 percent of health and social work employees (including 61 percent of all physicians) and 68 percent of those in education, women earned only 60 percent of men's earnings in health care/social work and 70 percent of men's earnings in the education sector (Ibrahimbekova 2000: 8; Najafizadeh 2006; Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003; SSCAR 2000a: 85, 103, 2000b: 75–78, 101; UNDP 2000: 19–24).

Now, over 25 years later, Azeri women's employment has changed to some extent. Of Azeris employed in the formal economy, 48 percent are women, whereas 52 percent are men; in turn, 58 percent of unemployed Azeris are women, compared to 42 percent men. As of 2016, men continued to constitute the majority in all occupational sectors, except for education (73 percent women), health and social work (77 percent

women), and art, entertainment, and recreation (63 percent women). Yet, even in these sectors, men are disproportionately found in high level (and higher paid) administrative positions. For example, men constitute 79 percent of directors of general secondary schools, whereas women constitute 78 percent of the teachers in such schools. Similarly, in higher education, men constitute 86 percent of rectors and 80 percent of faculty deans, whereas women constitute 62 percent of “main teachers” and 71 percent of “teacher assistants.” Similarly, salaries still tend to be gendered. For example, in 2016, women employed in public education averaged 287 *manat* (Azerbaijan currency) per month, whereas men averaged 348 *manat*; women in human health and social welfare averaged 193 *manat* per month, compared to 268 *manat* for men (SSCAR 2017: 90–91, 93, 104–105, 110–111; also see UNFPA/UNDP 2015). This is consistent with the Republic of Azerbaijan State Committee for Family, Women, and Children Affairs findings that discriminatory employment practices continue to persist with women tending to occupy low-paying jobs and/or deriving lower income in the informal economy, and with men earning higher wages than women for the same type of work (UN-OHCHR 2015).

Two additional issues are relevant. *First* is the issue of unpaid domestic labor where data suggest that women devote an average of six hours per day to unpaid childcare and homecare, compared to two hours for men. *Second*, whereas the issue of women's “double burden” of paid and unpaid work is well noted, in some instances Azeri women carry a “triple burden” as they engage in formal paid work, informal agricultural labor or informal part-time labor, and domestic/family-related work (UNFPA/UNDP 2015: 160).

Informal Economy

Azeri women confront challenges not only in the formal economy, as noted above, but also in the

informal economy. Detailed data on women engaged in the informal economy are limited because of the nature of such income-generating activities which are not officially registered. Data that are available indicate that engagement in such activities is *almost twice as common for Azeri women* as it is for men. Informal economy activities for women vary greatly and range from bazaar vendors, small shop tenders, and shuttle traders to seasonally employed workers and those engaged in subsistence farming. Ultimately, Azeris engaged in the informal economy are particularly vulnerable because they may be forced to pay bribes or “informal fees” to be allowed to conduct their work and they do not officially register or pay government income taxes or social security taxes, thereby making them ineligible for either state unemployment benefits or pensions. Despite uncertainties and vulnerabilities associated with the informal economy, when employment in the formal economy is not available the informal economy offers Azeri women an alternative option for generating income (Guliyev 2015; Najafizadeh 2006; Najafizadeh and Mennerick 2003).

Education

Gendered patterns of formal employment and of earnings are likely to persist, given the continuing gendered patterns of enrollment among Azeri youth within the educational system. Focusing on higher education, female and male students differ quite dramatically in the areas of study that they pursue. For the 2016–2017 academic year, for example, the percentage of female and male students enrolled in public higher educational institutions was roughly equal (49 percent women and 51 percent men). Nonetheless, female students still tended to concentrate on the traditional “female majors,” such as education (78 percent) and culture and art (62 percent), whereas male students concentrated most heavily in areas of study most likely

to result in higher income employment, namely economics and management (66 percent), agriculture (62 percent), and technical and technological (73 percent). Indeed, one might argue that gendered education in Azerbaijan begins at very early ages (3 to 5 years) as reflected in preschool enrollments where, in early 2017, boys constituted 54 percent of preschool students compared to 46 percent girls. Among other factors, this may reflect the culturally based perception that places more value on the education of males than of females (SSCAR 2017: 47, 85–86; also see UNFPA/UNDP 2015).

Although the government of Azerbaijan is formally committed to efforts to encourage careers in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics for Azeri women (UNWomen 2017; Permanent Mission of the Republic of Azerbaijan to the United Nations 2017), *both education and employment* continue to be gendered and continue to be impacted by persistent and constraining *patriarchal traditions and perceptions of women’s “place.”* These include the social and cultural expectations that men are the primary breadwinners and that women’s roles, despite employment outside the home, should give primacy to the family and to family caregiving responsibilities. Although there are laws guaranteeing equality in employment and wages, in some contexts women still experience discrimination. Yet, it is also noteworthy that self-selection also occurs, as some women have been socialized to accept these same expectations for the “proper” role of Azeri women.

Thus, Azeri women still tend to confront major obstacles in pursuing education and careers outside the traditional domain of women. In my continuing field research in Azerbaijan, in June 2017 I engaged in extended discussions with a group of young professional women (25 to 35 years of age) in the capital city of Baku. These women represented a wide range of professionals, such as lawyers, managers, academics, and administrators. For some of these professional women, patriarchy remains a challenge as they feel that, despite

being equally qualified, they are held to different standards and that they must strive to gain respect and recognition within their respective professions. For these women, a central difficulty is that of being accepted as “legitimate”—that is, as being recognized as equally qualified as a man—by male colleagues and male clients.

Early Marriage

The Republic of Azerbaijan has adopted various conventions, laws, and decrees pertaining to gender and also to the welfare of children, including the Convention on the Rights of the Child (1992), CEDAW (1995), the Presidential Decree “On Measures to Promote Women’s Roles in Azerbaijan” (1998), the Law on the Rights of the Child (1998); the Optional Protocol of CEDAW (2000), the Republic of Azerbaijan Family Code (1998, amended/supplemented 2002), and the Presidential Decree on the “Approval of the Government Monitoring of the Implementation of the Rights of Children” (2012). Under the Family Code, marriage was previously permitted between men at the age of 18 and women at the age of 17 years. In 2011, the minimum age was raised to 18 years for women (AGIC n.d.; President of Azerbaijan n.d.; UNFPA 2014).

Forced marriages and early marriages are relatively uncommon in urban areas of Azerbaijan. However, despite legal prohibitions, such marriages still occur, especially in some rural areas. Unfortunately, it is difficult to obtain a complete accounting of the actual number of these marriages because (1) an unknown number of marriages are conducted by religious clergy without the couples having obtained a civil marriage certificate; (2) some parents misrepresent the age of their daughter on marriage documents; (3) forced marriages and early marriages are “hidden” due to the fact that they are illegal. However, the most recent available data indicate that 11 percent of Azeri girls are married by age 18 (UNICEF 2016: 150).

Several factors are relevant. In some instances, low-income parents view early marriage of their daughter both as a mechanism for helping their daughter obtain an improved lifestyle through her husband and his family, and as a mechanism for reducing their own family size, thereby allowing them to provide economically for their other children. In addition, in some rural regions, young women face limited educational and employment opportunities, and therefore early marriage becomes an acceptable option by the family and the community. In addition, a number of Azeris in some rural areas view marriage and bearing children as especially central to providing young women status and validation within the community.

In light of these various factors, familial pressure for the daughter to marry early and to bear children as soon as possible still exists in some rural regions, as reflected in a study in a rural region where 77 percent of the marriages came about through the parents’ decisions, without the consent of their daughters. While such practices may address cultural pressures and parents’ wishes, early marriage—and early childbearing—can negatively impact the young mother’s health and the health of her baby and can limit young women’s rights to pursue education and employment opportunities. Furthermore, not having their marriages legally registered places young women in the very vulnerable position of total dependence on their husband and the husband’s family, without legal protections. Indeed, although some Azeris view early-marriage as acceptable, and even desirable, some such young women can become more vulnerable to domestic violence (Ibrahimova and Abbasov 2011; Samadov 2017; Social Institutions and Gender Index 2014; State Committee 2016; UNDP 2017; UNFPA 2014; Verdiyev 2017).

Gender-Based Violence

One key to the understanding of gender-based violence in Azerbaijan is the patriarchal tradition

of Azeri men being viewed as head of the family and as maintaining power and control as the primary familial decision-maker, a tradition to which most men and women subscribe. Azeri women do have various legal protections, including the Law on the Prevention of Domestic Violence (2010), which provides for criminal prosecution of perpetrators and applies not only to physical violence but also to psychological and sexual violence. Yet, despite this legal foundation, at least two factors impede the effective enforcement of the law.

First, although official government statistics list women as constituting 78 percent of the victims of domestic violence, these data underrepresent the gravity of the problem because numerous domestic abuse cases are *not officially reported nor recorded* as many Azeris, both women and men, view such family-related situations as being a “private matter.” In these situations, female victims are reluctant to report the offenses to the police because of being constrained by cultural norms pertaining to the family and community. Indeed, Azeri women frequently do not report abuse because of fear of retaliation and more abuse, reluctance to bring shame to their family, and economic dependence on their husband, especially when the married couple has young children. Relatedly, in many cases, women are reluctant to discuss their situation even with family or friends, and women’s shelters are rare in urban areas and virtually nonexistent in rural areas, thereby adding to the women’s vulnerability and to their inability to improve their situation (Isgandarova 2017; Manjoo 2014; Najafizadeh 2003, 2006; Social Institutions and Gender Index 2014; SSCAR 2017: 170).

A *second* factor is the police. Although Azerbaijan law provides guidelines and procedures for police to follow, some police tend to view domestic violence as an issue that should be resolved as a private matter within the family. Wilson’s (2017) research indicates, for example, that police often decline to investigate domestic abuse and instead may pressure the abused wife to

seek reconciliation, while in other instances the police may attempt to dissuade persistent women from pursuing prosecution. This emphasis on attempting to prevent domestic violence cases from entering the formal judicial system tends to be based on cultural norms that emphasize maintaining the marriage and the family unit, despite issues of domestic violence. Indeed, this emphasis on Azeri cultural norms extends, according to Wilson, to the Azeri courts where judges frequently also emphasize reconciliation, despite evidence of even severe domestic abuse, and such norms are shared within some households where men *and* women have been socialized to believe that domestic abuse is justified under certain circumstances (Wilson 2017; also see Isgandarova 2017; Manjoo 2014; Najafizadeh 2003, 2006).

Continuing Challenges for IDP/Refugee Women

IDP/refugee women, discussed previously, also continue to confront challenges. The government has enacted various laws and policies to address IDP/refugee issues, including the 1999 Law on the Status of Refugees and Forcibly Displaced Persons, the 1999 Law on Social Protection of Forcibly Displaced Persons, and the 2004 State Programme for the Improvement of Living Standards and Generation of Employment for Refugees and IDPs (amended on various occasions to provide additional support for IDPs). Since their initial displacement in the early 1990s, IDPs have been receiving provisions such as a monthly allowance, as well as free utilities, access to free education including higher education, and free access to health services. Furthermore, in 2001 the government began closing IDP temporary housing and relocating IDPs to various new housing units and settlements, including the newly constructed (2013) settlement of *Mushvigabad* containing apartments, schools, and health clinics.

Nonetheless, IDPs continue to confront a myriad of issues. For one, IDP women and girls confront higher levels of gender-based violence, and also higher levels of early-marriage, than do other Azeris. Such issues can be attributed, in addition to factors discussed previously, to higher levels of economic vulnerability in IDP families as well as psychological vulnerabilities pertaining to uncertainties about their futures. Furthermore, despite major government efforts to provide new housing, many IDPs continue to live in “temporary” and often substandard conditions. Even those living in new settlements often find the relatively “remote” locations difficult, with limited employment opportunities, resulting in some men relocating to find jobs elsewhere. Also, for some, both living conditions and their status as IDPs serve as a stigma which further isolates them from mainstream Azeris. And although the Nagorno-Karabakh War is often referred to as “frozen,” intermittent clashes do continue along the 280 kilometer Line of Contact (from the 1994 cease-fire), and families who have no choice but to remain living near the line also continue to confront daily psychological trauma and threats to their physical safety. Finally, despite the passage of time, many IDP/refugee women continue to face emotional issues related to the death of their fathers, husbands, and sons during the war, the trauma of being abruptly forced from their homelands, and the decades-long uncertainty about their future (Azerbaijani Vision 2017; ICRC 2017; IDMC 2014; Kennan Institute 2013; Manjoo 2014; Najafizadeh 2013; Nazarli 2017).

CONCLUDING COMMENTS

In conclusion, many of the challenges that Azeri women continue to confront have been exacerbated by the Azerbaijan economic crisis of 2015. As oil prices on the world market declined precipitously, the value of the Azerbaijan *manat* declined by 50 percent. The consequences of the

2015 crisis were quite severe as the government was forced to reduce spending, some banks closed, and some businesses faced bankruptcy, while some workers’ faced an average decline of 48 percent in monthly wages and still others faced unemployment. Although more recent efforts have been made to introduce structural changes and to diversify the economy, women as well as men have been impacted by this drastic and unanticipated economic turn of events (Aliyev 2017; CESD 2016; Guliyev 2016, 2017; World Bank 2016).

Yet, throughout the post-Soviet era, Azeri women and Azeri women’s NGOs and advocacy groups, as well as government agencies including the State Committee for Family, Women, and Children Affairs, have continued as active and dynamic social actors in seeking to address, counter, and remedy issues and challenges associated with women’s “situation,” including persistent patriarchal norms. Azeri women have continued to fully utilize their agency to alter and to establish women’s “place” as equal members of Azeri society in the twenty-first century.

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Chapter twenty-seven

Female Religious Leaders in Uzbekistan

Recalibrating Desires and Effecting Social Change

Svetlana Peshkova

INTRODUCTION

In the Central Asian country of Uzbekistan, female religious leaders (*otinlar*) effect social change through intentional efforts to transform themselves and their communities into better Muslims, better humans. “Teachers,” an English translation of the word *otinlar*, plural form of the word *otin*, neither captures the kinds of knowledge these leaders possess and provide to others, nor does it fully describe these women’s role in social change.¹ Imbedded in indigenous local histories, *otinlar*’s politics in unusual places effect political and economic changes in indirect ways. They challenge structures of power and decision-making by providing alternative sensibilities and inculcating differently structured desires through education, ceremonial leadership, advice on day-to-day matters, and didactic storytelling (*masala*). In the context of the post-Soviet, post-Socialist quasi-market economy in Uzbekistan, *otinlar*’s leadership reflects social changes and contributes to social transformations in their communities in small yet significant ways. In this chapter, I demonstrate these women’s role in social change. As powerful decolonizing resources for their local communities, *otinlar*’s advice and storytelling challenge politically oppressive, economically

opportunistic and patrimonial local elites and a neoliberal market economy controlled by the state. They aim to attune individual desires by pointing out “moral limits of the market” and confronting a rapidly growing commodification of interpersonal relations linked to mass labor migration undermining local economies’ sustainability (Keshavjee 2014: 142). Like other post-Soviet subjects, *otinlar*’s personal desires are complex and conflicted. As a result, they do not dismiss the less ethical, in their view, desires of others, but work diligently on recalibrating them.

CENTRAL ASIA: TWENTY-FIVE YEARS OF CHANGE

The Soviet Union’s disintegration in the 1980s and early 1990s brought about hope for democratic reforms, freedom of movement beyond the Soviet borders, and a greater circulation of global goods and knowledge, including religious ideologies. Many were enchanted by the promise of capitalist reward of personal achievements with increased economic stability, while some warned that the fall of socialism would lead to growing economic disparities, challenges to local borders, infighting among local and national elites, and a

collapse of internationalism. Whether euphoric about the future or nostalgic about the past, all post-Soviet citizens had to adapt to the breakdown of a strong, centralized socialist Soviet state, which used to provide such essential services as free health care and education, job placement for college graduates, state-funded housing, paid maternity leave, and free childcare. In several newly founded independent countries, these social changes led to civil uprisings, abject poverty, and political repression that accompanied growing local nationalisms. Making a living and ensuring the well-being of one's family became a matter of daily struggle for millions of people in post-Soviet, post-Socialist countries. Remaining state services were neither guaranteed nor predictable. Currency, hymns, and alphabets changed rapidly, sometimes overnight. Private property nationalized at the beginning of the twentieth century was privatized at its end and often left in the hands of a select few. Natural resources became a matter of contention among government elites, oligarchs, and criminals, within and between independent states. Often compared to "shock therapy," a set of complex processes that accompanied the Soviet Union's disintegration affected the most vulnerable—the elderly, disabled, terminally ill, and children—in the harshest ways (Jones 2012: 338; Stuckler and Basu 2013: 29). Some more optimistic than others, all citizens of the former Soviet Union, including Central Asians, had to change their daily lives and their dreams for, and expectations of, their future.

Central Asian states of Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, Kazakhstan, and Turkmenistan, independent since the 1990s, are "not quite post-colonial and not entirely postsocialist [*sic.*]" (Tlostanova 2015a: 39). They preserved colonial dependencies on Russia and did not achieve success in creating market economies unfettered by local governments. Informed by various assemblages of socialist and neoliberal ideologies, these countries exemplify different forms of post-Socialist political and economic development.

In Kyrgyzstan, popular uprisings have resulted in political changes and several new presidents and cabinets. In Uzbekistan, a quarter of a century's authoritarian presidency of the first post-Soviet President, Islam Karimov, ended only in 2016.² In Turkmenistan, the post-Soviet president's personality cult, developed and maintained by its first and second presidents, has been ensured by the regime's systematic coercion, including political and religious repressions (Horák and Polese 2015). Uzbekistan's significant fossil fuel reserves and Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan's oil fields guaranteed the relative prosperity of local economic and political elites amassing large financial capital, which is somewhat redistributed through patrimonial ties and/or hidden in "off-shore" bank accounts (McGlinchey 2011). These states' economies are juxtaposed with those of Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan, not built on major gas and oil reserves, and therefore precarious politically and economically.

In Central Asia, like elsewhere, neoliberal capitalism was *not* meant to "protect the vulnerable, increase political participation, build social stability and cohesion, or promote social, economic, and political development," but rather to weaken a totalitarian state and benefit a select few (Keshavjee 2014: 140). Local oligarchs readily embraced the benefits of a neoliberal economy, such as transnational trade, lack of regulations, and conspicuous consumption, while many local people found themselves in desperate circumstances. The growing social austerity and commodification created a context where making a living became a matter of existential concern for local people. Their daily life continues to be shaped by a combination of Soviet socialism with its centralized economy and capitalism with its ideological commitment to the market's "invisible hand" reallocating resources and services through trickle-down economics. Such complex socioeconomic and political context creates a medley of social trajectories, be that a version of Western modernity and democracy or a comfortable predictability of patrimonial politics ensured by an

authoritarian state. A minority envision an Islamic state ruled by Islamic law and led by a religious leadership as the only state that guarantees its population's well-being. Among these individuals, some take economic hardships as divinely ordained spiritual tests. Others understand these hardships as manifestations of the triumph of the existing regime's immorality in need of reform through political, sometimes violent, actions. Yet others find an inspiration for achieving economic prosperity in Islamic teachings (e.g., Ilkhamov 2006). A common denominator of this diversity is that it falls upon ordinary citizens to safeguard their daily survival through different strategies.

As active participants adapting to changing circumstances, most Central Asians try to utilize new opportunities for wealth and consumption. Their strategies may include holding several jobs at the same time (multi-sited employment), taking advantage of capital flows in the form of humanitarian aid moved through local non-governmental organizations (NGOs), shuttle trade, and/or labor and seasonal migration (e.g., Botoeva 2015; Reeves 2011).³ These strategies inform and reflect social and economic changes. Commodification of interpersonal relations and labor migration are two particularly illustrative examples of neoliberal capitalism's effects on social dynamics in post-Soviet, post-Socialist space. *Otinlar*, through their gendered leadership, challenge these effects.

UZBEKISTAN AND OTINLAR

The ethnographic materials I use in this chapter come from a fertile Central Asian oasis enclave famous for cotton cultivation, the Ferghana Valley, currently divided between Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, and Kyrgyzstan.⁴ Historically, the populations of the valley housed and nurtured different faiths, including Zoroastrianism, Buddhism, Judaism, and Christianity. Nomadic and sedentary local peoples conquered by Muslim armies in the early eighth century gradually converted to Islam. By "localizing Islam and Islamizing local

traditions," Central Asian communities came to see "themselves as innately Muslim" (Khalid 2007: 22). By the fifteenth century, this part of Central Asia became one of the centers of Islamic learning, art, and sciences where Sufism integrated existing local practices and beliefs with those brought by the conquest.⁵

The Russian Empire conquered a large part of Central Asia in the nineteenth century. By the 1920s, this colonial territory was incorporated into the Soviet Union and later divided between the five Soviet Socialist Republics of Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, Kazakhstan, and Turkmenistan. Almost a century-long history of colonization, first as a part of the Russian Empire, and then as a part of the Soviet Union with its proclaimed state-atheism, resulted in rapid social transformations (Tlostanova 2015b). Emancipatory claims of Russian and later Soviet modernity introduced changes in gender roles, labor practices, education, marriage patterns, religious practices, and the legal sphere (Peshkova 2013). These changes had mixed results. Gender equality was announced but never achieved; a Russified universal education was not of very good quality, particularly in the periphery; the monoculture economy of cotton production and the double burden of reproduction and labor for women were coupled with some social guarantees; polygyny was legally outlawed but sometimes practiced as a "national tradition"; and although restricted in the public arena, religious practices flourished in other places, such as individual homes. In the early 1990s, Central Asian republics became sovereign countries and Islam became an important part of their nationalist ideologies.

Much of Uzbekistan's current population of almost 30 million self-identify as Muslim. A wealth of scholarly research reveals a great diversity and sociohistorical complexity of religious practice in the region (e.g., Abashin 2001; Basilov 1994; Gorshunova 2008; Kandiyoti and Azimova 2004; Karagiannis 2006; Khalid 2007; Louw 2007; Rasanayagam 2006; Sultanova 2011). Locals understand and enact being Muslim in a variety

of ways. Some believe in this worldly behavior's direct effect on their afterlife and try to lead a strictly ritualized daily life. Others are "secular" Muslims who either do not believe in God or understand their atheism and secularism in terms of being different from Muslims zealous in their faith (McBrien and Pelkmans 2008: 89). There are also Christians—most of them self-identify as Russian Orthodox—and some Protestant converts and devotees of Hare Krishna, a statistical minority in Uzbekistan. They too vary in their understanding and enactment of religious identity (e.g., Peyrouse 2007; Rasanayagam 2010).

Islam is not the sole "grand scheme" providing meaning to Muslims in Uzbekistan (Schielke 2010). Although daily life is punctuated by religious symbolism, making a living, food, shelter, marriage, family, and one's health are important matters of existential concern for all local individuals. These concerns engender contradictions and compromises and result in a wide range of religious practices and sensibilities. A performance of daily prayers and fasting during the holy month of Ramadan may reflect an individual's feelings of being a pious Muslim. These feelings are often not incommensurable with veneration of female saints and elements of natural landscape, such as rocks, mountains, trees, and springs said to possess special powers. Reflecting different needs, the same individual may pray at the sites said to be burial places of Muslim saints, organize ceremonial feasts or social events to express their gratitude to God or to a local saint (e.g., the female saint *Bibi Seshamba*), and embark on a pilgrimage to Mecca in Saudi Arabia. Seeking religious instruction can lead one to a Muslim homeschool or an Islamic university, while a malady motivates the same person to attend healing séances based on theosophical teachings, participate in Yoga practices, or receive an exorcism performed by reciting traditional formulas and verses from the Qur'an. Seeking a meaningful spiritual connection to the divine can lead a person to a Sufi gathering accompanied by a set of spiritual exercises, which include silent or

loud recitation of the sacred, often Qur'anic based, formulas and the performance of physical movements. A desire to control one's daily life and future can bring the same person to a future-telling practitioner or to meetings of transnational Islamic movements, such as *Hizb-ut-Tahrir* (the Party of Liberation), banned in Uzbekistan. Hence, local people adapt to changing circumstances and respond to existential concerns in different ways and as well as they can. Some of them become community leaders and stimulate social change through purposeful efforts to change themselves and others into better humans. *Otinlar* are among these leaders.

There are numerous historical and contemporary examples of women's religious and political leadership in the region and elsewhere (Peshkova 2009a). *Otinlar* are one part of two local historically embedded lines of gendered religious authority in Central Asia (Fathi 1997; Kamp 2006; Kandiyoti and Azimova 2004).⁶ Some of them come from long lines of local religious leaders. Others discover their calling later in life. Some possess rudimentary knowledge of the Qur'an, while others master Qur'anic recitation and understanding at the level recognized by Uzbekistan's Board of Muslims. Present in every neighborhood in Uzbekistan, *otinlar* officiate at ceremonial gatherings among local women. Some *otinlar* provide religious instruction despite existing legal prohibition of homeschooling Islam. Others perform healing rituals and mediate interpersonal conflicts. A very small number of *otinlar* hold administrative positions and advise the government on religious and communal matters (Peshkova 2014b). By offering all or some of these services, *otinlar* play an active role in their communities' daily life.

Daily life is not reduced to one space (e.g., a mosque), one motivation (e.g., personal salvation), or one gender (e.g., men), but happens everywhere and touches everyone, Muslim or not. Therefore, *otinlar*'s actions have social effects not only among Muslims; they create and transform social life in the country in several ways.

First, by officiating at ceremonial gatherings, *otinlar* provide women with a place for religious observance in domestic space or at sacred sites; the latter are often attended by Muslims and non-Muslims alike (Peshkova 2009b). Second, by providing religious instruction, mainly in domestic space, *otinlar* enhance their students' social standing and help these students to develop critical thinking about their lives and social environment (Peshkova 2014a). Third, while advice offered by some *otinlar* and their didactic storytelling (*masala*) are aimed at preserving some social relations and structure, the knowledge of Islamic ethical paradigm they disseminate in the process can create an impetus for social change by affecting individual moral transformation and daily actions. Although these women understand, interpret, and circulate such knowledge in a variety of ways and in different settings (e.g., social gatherings and home-schools), both advice and didactic storytelling are aimed at recalibrating individual desires to better align them with what *otinlar* consider to be Islamic ethical principles. *Otinlar* do not call for a revolution but for an individual moral evolution. Hence, while as a rule such efforts do not foster students' political engagement with the state they are still political; they require changes of oneself and social context.

By providing alternative sensibilities and inculcating differently structured desires through education, ceremonial leadership, advice and didactic storytelling, *otinlar* challenge structures of power and decision-making indirectly (Peshkova 2013). Through advice and storytelling, they often address direct and personal questions and problems, as a result providing a moral compass, spiritual guidance, and support to their local communities; they keep the promise of a different future alive and not limited to pragmatic needs of survival and consumerism. This transformative potential makes *otinlar* a powerful decolonizing resource, which helps local people to question politically oppressive and economically opportunistic local patrimonial elites

as well as a neoliberal quasi-market economy affected by the state's shifting alliances with the West, Russia, and Asia (Tlostanova 2015a: 38). Since large social and political forces are beyond their control, these women's politics may not affect political and economic decisions in direct ways (Mahmood 2005). But they help local communities to dream of a different ethical future and act on such dreams in the present. By focusing on "small stories, situated in specific local contexts," these women engage local communities and participate in social change (Lykke 2010: 133). Labor migration to Russia is a part of the specific local context that *otinlar* operate in; it stimulates existential problems and conflicts in local communities. As a result, labor migration is often addressed by these women.

PROMISES AND PERILS OF MIGRATION

Uzbekistan is one of the regional countries that provides a steady flow of labor migrants to Russia and to other countries such as Turkey. Remittances they send home often become the only steady and reliable source of income for local families (Ayupova 2015). After the Soviet Union's disintegration, first to emigrate were mainly Russian-speaking populations. By the beginning of the 2000s, a steady flow of local migrants both seasonal and permanent increased dramatically. By 2014, Russia became "the second largest recipient of international migrants in the world"; "the overwhelming majority of labor migrants" came from Central Asia, including more than two and a half million from Uzbekistan, or 7 to 10 percent of the country's current population (Agadjanian et al. 2014: 580). In 2015, there were close to three million Uzbek labor migrants in Russia. Because of the growing economic crisis in Russia, later that year the number of migrants from Uzbekistan decreased by 17 percent; the rest, however, continued to circulate between Russia and Uzbekistan (Abashin 2015: 130).

Finding employment in various sectors of the Russian economy but concentrating on trade and retail, construction work, and food and hospitality services, these labor migrants are mainly Muslim and male. Despite gendered social expectations that men, not women, should be the main providers for their families, and because of the unstable local economy in Uzbekistan, local women also seek employment abroad. About 12 percent of labor migrants in Russia are women, and about 47 percent of these are younger than 30 years old (Abashin 2015: 138). Often lacking work permits and existing in a suspended “semi-legal” state, male and female migrants face daily discrimination from local authorities, law enforcement agencies, employers, and the public (Abashin 2015: 130; Agadjanian et al. 2014: 581).

Individual experiences of labor migration are gendered and idiosyncratic; some migrate seasonally and a small number with children, while others create permanent families with Russian citizens and eventually receive Russian citizenship. Yet others use Russia as a transit zone to establish a life elsewhere in the world. Whether and how often labor migrants return to Uzbekistan depends on their personal circumstances and their incorporation into Russia’s economy, civil inclusion, and social ties (Agadjanian et al. 2014: 585). Most labor migrants lead truly transnational lives, dwelling between Uzbekistan and Russia (e.g., Abashin 2015: 131; Reeves 2013). Even if they receive Russian citizenship, their extended families and life experiences continue to connect them to Uzbekistan (Agadjanian et al. 2014: 581). Through financial remittances, they still participate in Uzbekistan’s local economy. For example, in 2013, the remittances from Russia totaled 6.7 billion US dollars, which is about 10 percent of Uzbekistan’s GDP (Abashin 2015: 132). In Uzbekistan, migrants’ families use this money to satisfy daily needs including what I call “feasting” economy, by sponsoring life-cycle events, such as weddings. In local communities, any significant changes in one’s social status, including birth, circumcision, weddings, and burial,

are marked by life-cycle ceremonies, which aim to inculcate norms of sociality and morality and involve family members and/or an individual’s social networks of neighbors, co-workers, and friends. In addition to fulfilling ritual obligations, these events nurture social relations and enhance sponsors’ symbolic capital. The remittances can also be invested in building or remodeling a house, educating children, paying medical bills, opening small businesses, and/or buying a car.

Feasting economy and gendered expectations, such as the husband’s ability to build or purchase a house for a family, have a long history in Central Asia and elsewhere and are not particular to the post-Soviet context and local neoliberal capitalism’s permutations. The precarious daily life without Soviet guarantees, however, contributes to a cognitive dissonance between expectations and reality—between promises and delivery—in terms of gender roles and interpersonal relations. This dissonance fuels social and personal conflicts and competing, often unsatisfied, desires of well-being in terms of social and economic security that propel labor migration in the first place (Reeves 2012). The failure of the local economy’s sustainability is one of the long-term effects of labor migration, diasporic existence, consumerism, and commodification of interpersonal relations. Labor migration also leads to increasing class divisions and fragmentation of existing family structures. *Otinlar* are among local figures who offer a way out of this vicious circle. Through advice and didactic storytelling, they work on recalibrating human desires from a fleeting short-term consumerist satisfaction to a long-term spiritual well-being, as they challenge a rapidly growing commodification of interpersonal relations and labor migration undermining the sustainability of local economy. In the paragraphs below, I focus on *otinlar*’s advice and didactic storytelling (*masala*) to demonstrate their role in social change as a powerful decolonizing resource for questioning patrimonial elites and the quasi-market economy controlled by a politically oppressive state.

OTINLAR'S ADVICE

Tursun-oi, a well-known local *otin*, provided informal religious instruction to local women and sometimes children, offered advice on daily problems and issues that members of the local community brought to her, and sometimes officiated at ceremonial gatherings.⁷ Throughout her almost two decade-long career as an *otin*, she repeatedly highlighted the importance of advice and didactic storytelling, which according to Tursun-oi, connected Islamic knowledge to daily life. In her view, *otinlar* were in a better position to connect religious knowledge to daily life than some local *imams* [male religious leaders]. *Otinlar* had space and time and could address any issue unlike *imams* at the mosques who, as public figures appointed by the state-run Board of Muslims, had limited time and had to be careful in their Friday sermons. Unless *imams* followed the directives of the board in their sermons and advice, they could be persecuted by the law enforcement agencies and potentially face jail sentences (McGlinchey 2007). *Otinlar*, with a rare exception, did not hold public office and could connect Islamic knowledge to daily life without fear of immediate persecution.

During my interview, Tursun-oi said that chaos within local families, the economy, the country, and the world made *otinlar*'s teaching about and explaining of Islam very urgent:

Now, especially, correct [Islamic] knowledge and behaviors are very important. If you ask me, there are signs of the end of the world. The Qur'an says that the stupid would rule, there would be zina [strife, fornication], peoples and countries would fight, relatives would fight, and those who love the Qur'an would be persecuted. It is taking place right now.

The most important challenge of the twenty-first century, in Tursun-oi's view, was the lack of an ethical paradigm; this was "a sign of the end of the world." Local people's daily existence

took place between two arduous realities, the not-quite-neoliberal economy and the not-quite-post-socialist but certainly authoritarian state. In a precarious sociopolitical and economic context, where it was often impossible to anticipate the chain of consequences of individual actions, it was hard to act ethically. Lacking well-entrenched connections in the corrupt economic-legal-criminal sector, one could become relatively wealthy and lose it all in a matter of days. For the right amount of money, one could buy any university degree but find no employment, and one could lead a pious life and be persecuted for it.

Responding to this challenge, Tursun-oi did not target politics or the economy directly but instead diligently worked on rekindling human memory of a universal ethical paradigm established by God for humanity, the knowledge that the infallible God, and not fallible humans, adjudicated the final judgment of one's efforts in doing the right thing. For Tursun-oi this knowledge was always already there, because, from the beginning of time, God created every human with the capacity to develop one's goodness, and every human had a soul knowing its own creation. Learning about Islam helped people to remember this ethical paradigm and to develop individual ability to recognize and realize in action their capacity to be good. By teaching others about Islamic ethical behavior through, among other things, advice and didactic storytelling, Tursun-oi and some of her current and former students, like Jahon, helped others to develop this ability.

Jahon, Tursun-oi's former student and another well-known local *otin*, was invited to lead various ceremonies and to consult on personal and family matters by her neighbors, students, and sometimes representatives of a local government in the valley. Women like Jahon and Tursun-oi felt that they had cultivated their morality and mastered knowledge about Islam to an extent where they were entitled to guide others toward moral transformation into being "truly" Muslim and therefore better humans. Responding to a popular interest in Islamic education and etiquette among

members of their local communities, *otinlar* like Tursun-oi and Jahon imparted Islam to their audiences during religious lessons, in personal communications, or while officiating at religious ceremonies. Since individual possession of correct knowledge did not assure one's moral transformation, *otinlar*'s advice on mundane matters meant to encourage individual mastery of this knowledge, which, in turn, would enhance one's ability to use Islamic knowledge situationally and creatively.

In one interview, Tursun-oi highlighted the importance of answering pragmatic questions raised by the audience and community members within and outside ceremonial contexts. Women, and sometimes men, approached her and Jahon for help evaluating their actions as Islamic or non-Islamic or to get advice on how to resolve an issue in an Islamic way. For instance, a couple of days before this interview, a female neighbor, whose husband had recently died, visited Tursun-oi seeking advice on what would be "an Islamic thing to do" with the gold she had amassed during her lifetime; should she spend it on "a feast" in her husband's honor? Tursun-oi advised this woman not to spend gold on a feast, but sell this gold and set money aside for her children's and grandchildren's future. "This would be a real *savob* [meritorious act]," said Tursun-oi. To her, a truly ethical act was not feasting but investing in the future generation's education.

Jahon too argued that feasting economy, including frequent lifecycle and propitiatory ceremonies, was one of the problems in Uzbekistan. Some individuals spend "too much money on such feasts" to "show off" their wealth. This "wrong" desire invalidated any ceremony by making it a sin and not a meritorious act. Jahon advised her neighbors, friends, and acquaintances to spend money not on ceremonial feasts but on books, on education, and "on happy life." For instance, earlier that year, a female neighbor complained to Jahon that her son had gone to Russia "to make money" but failed to send her enough cash to buy a lamb for an *ehson*, a ceremony aimed to appease and express gratitude to God for her son's success in

finding and maintaining this job. Jahon replied that God would not help her son in finding a good job if his mother was unhappy with him and insisted that there was no need for making a special *ehson* because as "a mother, a Muslim woman, and through her daily work around the house" she has already performed "seven or eight *ehsons* a day." These *ehsons* included "sending the daughter-in-law to work [taking care of the house, while her daughter-in-law was gone]," "raising her grandchildren," and making food and keeping the house tidy.⁸ These were not what Jahon called "open *ehsons*," but "covered [hidden] *ehsons*." These were "the best" *ehsons* because no one except God knew about them. Therefore, in Jahon's view, *ehson* did not have to be a ceremony or a feast; it could be individual ethical behavior in relation to others, which was often overlooked and taken for granted in daily life.

Through her advice, Jahon aimed to recalibrate her neighbor's desire from wanting to impress others through a lavish feast to a recognition of, and desire for, pragmatic daily care practices that were relational and in and of themselves signaled one's social value and importance. She reminded her that as a meritorious act, *ehson* was always already there in the form of care for others and in relation to them, including one's extended family. Daily gendered activities were not just duties and responsibilities that women were expected to perform in accordance with their ontological and biological differences from men, a notion affirmed by the nationalist ideology in Uzbekistan. These actions were also intentional meritorious acts rewarded by God in this and/or the next life. By providing a moral direction for daily mundane affairs and offering pragmatic solutions to daily problems, Tursun-oi and Jahon challenged, albeit indirectly, a compartmentalization of religious and daily life systematically promoted by Uzbekistan's government and its agencies (Papas 2005). Through their efforts to transform a desire for social recognition, based on the display of material goods in the form of a lavish feast, into a desire to impress others with care and knowledge,

Tursun-oi and Jahon undermined the foundation of neoliberal capitalism, a conspicuous consumption of material goods and services.

OTINLAR'S DIDACTIC STORYTELLING

"Masala [didactic storytelling] is very important. They [these stories] put Islam in simple words, connect it [Islam] to our life; make it easy [to understand religious knowledge]," said Tursun-oi in an interview. The main pedagogical purpose of didactic storytelling was to establish a correspondence between one's desires and beliefs and one's actions (Peshkova 2014b). A declaration of belief had to have concomitant actions and vice versa. Since the (Islamic) knowledge of how to do the right thing was essential to a life well led, didactic storytelling also meant to recalibrate individual desires and make one a better Muslim human.

According to Tursun-oi, Jahon, and *otinlar* like them, in a life well led, there should be no separation between an individual's thoughts and actions. Didactic storytelling helped to establish this correspondence. The pragmatic daily situations narrated in such stories became teachable moments by offering an opportunity to an individual for deeper critical insight into their own self. These stories introduced thinking situations, which included challenging a rapidly growing commodification of interpersonal relations and mass labor migration that undermined local economy's sustainability. A recalibration of desires that could take place in such thinking situations helped to establish correspondence between what one thought about, believed in, and desired and how one acted in the world.

Yet, individuals were not always receptive. For example, in one interview, Jahon reported that her audience may not have reacted immediately to her *masala*: *"I know that it is hard for people to accept it. They may not agree with me and may not like what I [have to] say, but I ask for their*

forgiveness and still tell them this masala [story]. Then I ask [the audience] to think about it." In reflecting on the importance of didactic storytelling, Jahon stressed that individual transformation was a process that could happen now or later, but this process, entailing struggle and doubt, was inevitable. Such didactic stories influenced people, directly or indirectly, and could foster individual ethical transformation—a moral evolution—that sooner or later had social effects.

The technology of didactic storytelling entailed making a moral choice among a range of possible choices. Any sociohistorical context offered multiple constraints and solutions. Each one of the didactic stories recognized this multiplicity by demonstrating that there were different ways of responding to a particular situation. Among all possible responses, a didactic story always pointed to the correct one. As a result, the story marked as incorrect other desires and actions and provided knowledge about virtues and vices one should aspire to achieve or to avoid repeating. By providing examples of what to want, what not to want, and how to and how not to act in each situation, *masala* became sites for self-reflection and critique that could, if not immediately then eventually, lead to one's moral transformation. Through *masala*, a storyteller did not force an individual to make a right choice or did not aim to disseminate theological knowledge per se. Rather, the didactic stories' social effects were indirect. They illustrated that (1) there were conflicting desires and ways of acting; (2) there was always an ethical desire and actions among others; (3) the choice to recalibrate one's desires and to change one's actions was individual.

The subjects of didactic stories varied. Storytellers created and refashioned them to reflect individual, societal, and familial issues in the context that included massive and gendered labor migration from Uzbekistan. While some local women engaged in economic trade in the form of short trips abroad, male migrants often left their homes for long periods of time. When their husbands left, the wives stayed behind taking care of

their extended families. Through her didactic storytelling Tursun-oi encouraged local women, and by extension their families, to have faith in God and look for happiness in Uzbekistan, despite its current socioeconomic environment. In one of the *masala*, she spoke of “always looking for a better place”:

Once, the Prophet was traveling from Mecca to Medina on a camel's back. He was invited to stay at many places, but he insisted that he would stay at the place where his camel would stop. He said, “Where the camel would lie down, this is where I would stay too. Allah [God] sent me here and I will be happy at any place where Allah wishes me to stay. I leave it to Allah to choose a place for me.” We too should accept [where we are] and find happiness here [in Uzbekistan]. It is Allah's will for us to be here and now.

This story about the Prophet's traveling, not unlike individual migration in search of a job and economic stability, created a teachable moment with two possible choices of action reflecting two competing desires. The Prophet could stay at any place of his choosing, but he left “it to God to choose a place.” Similarly, a desire for financial stability often led local men and sometimes women to “many places,” leaving their families behind. Some women, who stayed behind, assumed more independence and power in their families' decision-making. Others eventually discovered their husbands' second marriages and other children in Russia. Yet others lost touch with their husbands and struggled greatly due to limited income. The returning migrants had struggles of their own with reintegration into and readaptation to their familial and social environment (Ayupova 2015). Labor migration also bred inequality and undermined the development of the local long-term sustainable economy. By highlighting the Prophet's decision to rely completely upon God's will in choosing a place rather than accepting other humans' invitations or acting on his own volition, Tursun-oi's story

demonstrated that leaving for elsewhere was not the only possible or desirable choice of action. The correct choice of action, verified by the Prophet Muhammad's action, was to rely upon God, to stay and be happy at the place chosen for an individual by God. Making this right choice would require reshaping an individual's desire—and in this case, other family members' desires, since labor migration was often triggered by the needs and wants of the family—from a fleeting short-term consumerist satisfaction to a long-term spiritual well-being that will require “staying put” and finding happiness locally.

The content of this story could have political implications. It could be taken as a criticism of migration; by migrating, individuals failed to follow God's will to stay at the place chosen for them by God. This story could also be understood as a call for those who stayed behind to be patient and care for the rest of the family because it was God's will. As a pedagogical technique, this didactic story introduced labor migration as a site for the audience's thinking about and evaluating the correspondence between claiming to be Muslim and acting as one. By establishing the right desire corresponding to one's belief in the omniscient God (that “it is Allah's will”) and submitting to God's will (to stay and work “here”), this story invited individual self-reflection on the correlation between one's existing desires and beliefs and one's actions. A desire to be a good Muslim should have been given a priority over other desires, particularly consumerist ones and it was up to an individual to recalibrate existing desires and act accordingly.

Uzbekistan's rapidly entrenched class system was another topic explored in didactic storytelling. Jahon shared with me a story about economic redistribution:

In Islam, it is a good thing to help others, either with money, a good deed, or a kind word. Allah says that even one kind word is a great help. The more you give, the more you would get. Even if you share spiritual bogatstvo [wealth], such as a kind word or

a prayer, you may receive money as a reward from God. If you share money, you may receive spiritual [wealth], find peace and love . . . There are, of course, poor people who don't want to make money. These are lazy. There are people who have no money and are envious of those who do. This is not good either. The envy should not destroy people but make them want to do things. Share. God wants you to share. Try changing your [economic] situation . . . If you are envious of those who make money, try to use this envy to make more than they do and share it with others.

This didactic story did not directly criticize the post-Soviet, post-Socialist class system and those who had already amassed substantial financial capital, but reminded the audience that wealth had to be earned and redistributed in ethical ways. While redistribution itself was important, individual intentions that came with the action, including a desire to share, were similarly significant.

The pedagogical purpose of this story extended beyond its immediate content. In it, Jahon did not call for an ascetic life or criticize material desires. The denial of human desires, such as a desire to be wealthy, did not help one to become a better human. Jahon recognized the existence of such desires and introduced various individual choices of action in the context of the existing economic instability and growing conspicuous consumption. One could choose to make money and keep it for herself, to make money and redistribute it in the community (to share), or not to make money at all (be poor). The story's narrative reduced these choices to one correct choice, which was to share goods (money) and goodness ("to give" a kind word); talk, too, as a form of social action, was a meritorious act with spiritual and material consequences. This didactic story also examined a feeling of envy—a desire for that which others have—and corresponding actions. The story identified two kinds of envy; a negative envy resulted in individual inaction, while a positive envy stimulated individual action to

"make more than they [others] do" through hard work. However, this wanting and making more than others also had to correspond to an individual desire to share more than others. If these desires did not correspond, then they had to be recalibrated.

Like other didactic stories, this one meant to spawn questions about individual desires, faith in God, virtuous behavior, and the correlation between an individual's claim of being Muslim and her actions. The audience for this didactic story could have learned that God was the source of economic well-being, and God was the judge of all human actions. More importantly, this story was meant to generate self-critique where the self's desires would become an object to be examined carefully because in a life well led, individual desires and actions could not be disconnected.

In Uzbekistan, *otinlar*'s didactic storytelling often had an effective pedagogical value and could have indirect political applications or implications (cf. Forgas 2001). The primary pedagogical goal of didactic storytelling was not only to present what the author or narrator considered to be correct Islamic knowledge, but also to invite self-reflection of an individual's desires, beliefs, and actions. This could lead to readjusting existing desires, establishing correspondence between claiming to be a Muslim and acting as one, and as a result, fostering individual mastery of religious knowledge and creatively using this knowledge in different changing situations. Such stories, just like the advice *otinlar* provided on day-to-day matters, had less to do with scriptural sources but everything to do with pragmatic daily life and the conflicting desires it engendered. These stories' pedagogical value was in demonstrating that being "truly" Muslim was not about forming the self into a completely new person, or simply learning the fundamentals of Islam. Rather, to be a "true" Muslim meant to have a life well led together with others by recalibrating desires and realizing in action the initial and essential goodness with which God endowed everyone.

As a pragmatic pedagogical technique, didactic storytelling made Islamic knowledge easy to understand. By connecting an abstract theological knowledge of the universal ethical paradigm to daily issues and problems, *otinlar* helped to create a cognitive opening that could lead to individual moral change. Their active efforts to bring about small personal changes were not insignificant. They provided a venue for a moral evolution, which is a necessary step in any sustainable social change.

CONCLUDING COMMENTS: RECALIBRATING DESIRES AND SOCIAL CHANGE

Social activism and change can take different forms. One form of social change can occur through revolution or through reform whereas another form of social change can occur through individual activism and moral transformation. *Otinlar*'s attempts to modify individual desires through advice and didactic storytelling serve as an example of such activism. Even though these women effect moral change in different ways, the thirty *otinlar* I worked with and learned from seemed to agree that social change had to start with an individual who thoughtfully, experientially, and patiently cultivated her moral self. These women insisted that God's plan for humanity was for each person to learn how to lead this earthly life well together with others, as an aggregation of individuals, whereby every person purposefully extended themselves toward God and others through daily actions correlated to correct ethical desires.

An individual evolution into a moral subject capable of influencing and remaking oneself and one's immediate context required an ability to evaluate one's behavior, desires, and social context in order to enact change in oneself and others by following "correct" Islam. To facilitate such reflection, *otinlar* offered advice and didactic storytelling informed by what they considered to be an Islamic ethical paradigm encapsulated in the

sacred sources, and explicated by more knowledgeable individuals, like Tursun-oi and Jahon, to the less knowledgeable individuals. By following this paradigm, humans could change themselves and achieve a different Islamic society built on moral principles of care for oneself and others. Although an individual's moral evolution and the resulting social transformation were, according to these *otinlar*, long-term processes, changes were ongoing and already happening.

As post-Soviet subjects, *otinlar*'s personal desires were also conflicted. This might be one reason why they did not dismiss the less ethical, in their view, desires of others, but diligently worked on recalibrating them. These women too wanted to ensure their families' well-being, and they recognized that human beings desired material objects and social recognition. Their recognition of conflicting desires often came from personal experiences. For instance, Jahon, despite her insistence on an ethical existence and avoidance of the commodification of interpersonal relations and veneration of consumerism, was trying to ensure her family's well-being and had to be strategic. During one meeting, when I had not seen Jahon for several years, she enthusiastically reported that her husband too had left for Russia "to make money." She said that she was grateful that Karimov, the first post-Soviet President of Uzbekistan, "allowed Uzbeks" to travel overseas to earn money. In Russia, there were more job opportunities than in Uzbekistan, people's salaries were much higher, and "a Russian *rubl* [monetary unit] was worth more than an Uzbek *som* [monetary unit]." Hence, her husband's first long-term trip to, and work in, Russia allowed the family "to change our car from *Zhiguli* [Russian car maker] to *Nexia* [South Korean car maker]." After his current trip, she hoped they would be able "to fix this house." Jahon made plans. She wanted to go to *haji* with her husband and find husbands for her two youngest daughters. Her mission of changing others was important to Jahon but not essential. For her, too, family always came first and social change started with one's self at home.

NOTES

- 1 Terms used in this chapter reflect their Uzbek and/or Russian form and usage. The names of the individuals are pseudonyms.
- 2 The current Uzbek government and its President, Shavkat Mirziyoyev show very little difference from the previous one.
- 3 Shuttle trade refers to small business ventures characteristic of post-Soviet economy where local entrepreneurs import goods often from overseas for resale at local markets and shops.
- 4 My ethnographic methods included gathering life histories, interviewing, observing and participating in the ceremonial activities and daily lives of thirty local *otinlar*.
- 5 Sufism refers to sets of spiritual exercises traced to individual historical figures that became the loci of its knowledge and practice.
- 6 *Otinlar* are also active in other post-Soviet Central Asian countries and referred to by different terms such as *otinchalar* (pl.) or *bu-otin*, *bibi khalife/halifa/holpa*, *oy bibi mullo*, and *otin-bey* (sing.). English-language scholarly works mainly use *otins* (pl.).
- 7 My research does not speak on behalf of all women who self-identify as Muslim and *otinlar* in Uzbekistan and elsewhere in Central Asia.
- 8 It is customary to expect a daughter-in-law, not the mother-in-law, to take care of housecleaning, childcare, and food preparation.

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Chapter twenty-eight

Project *Kelin* Marriage, Women, and Re-Traditionalization in Post-Soviet Kazakhstan

Diana T. Kudaibergenova

INTRODUCTION

“What should I do if my husband beats me?” starts an anonymous message in a popular Kazakh female-only *Kelin* [daughter-in-law] cellular phone chat room. *“Hey, you [avatar name], new kelin [daughter-in-law]! What [do you mean] what to do? You have to love your husband, love his parents and all of his relatives (!), cook them food, do the laundry, clean up the house, smile and say ‘thank you’ to your mother-in-law’s criticisms, listen to everything she says and do everything she asks you to do and so on and so on . . .,”* goes an instant reply from another anonymous chat room user.

As reflected in this dialogue, young Kazakh females in the new “*Kelin*” chat room on the iTunes “Daughter-in-Law” cellular phone application (app) seem to build on an overwhelming consensus that domestic violence toward wives or daughters-in-law can be acceptable. Indeed, globalization and the dramatic increase in technology and access to computers and cellular telephones and related software programs and apps have greatly altered and enhanced modes of communication, including social media, as illustrated in the online chat room dialogue above. More specifically, in August 2015, a group of young Kazakh programmers from the Zero to One

Labs Studio launched the “*Kelin*” app for mobile telephones on iTunes. “*Kelin* app” instantly became the most popular downloaded app on iTunes in Kazakhstan as users were intrigued by the “Perfect *Kelin*” test and the chat room for users that provided a space for the most intimate discussions and questions. Although the app was intended for the actual daughters-in-law (*kelins*), it attracted a much wider audience including men and older women, as well as potential or real mothers-in-law. Indeed, the cultural concept of *kelin* garnered so much interest through social media in contemporary Kazakh society, and across Central Asia, that “Pandaland” alone had more than 40 popular articles dedicated to this concept (with an average of 10,000 reads), a local Kazakh comedy, *Kelinka Sabinka*, was the most successful and most watched local movie production since 1991, and the *Kelinka Sabinka* phenomenon in fact created a whole movement of satirical memes and jokes about the fate of Kazakh *kelins*.

The re-traditionalization or reinvention of certain traditions in favor of the new power order toward the neo-patrimonial and patriarchal post-Soviet system in Kazakhstan has shifted the positions of the previously emancipated women (Cleuziou and Drenberger 2016; Ismailbekova 2016; Kandiyoti 2007). The power of the

re-traditionalized discourse of the daughter-in-law in Kazakhstan can be demonstrated through the popularity and “stronghold” of these beliefs in the post-Soviet globalized urban and multicultural Kazakh society. In these conditions where the state cannot provide equal terms for both men and women and where women remain the child-bearers and primary childcare givers, the re-traditionalized discourses couple with globalized tools such as mobile apps and social media to cement the “traditional” role of women as marginalized and unpaid caregivers of their extended families. Furthermore, the post-Soviet shift in social and economic relations has marginalized the position of “emancipated women” in the society, economy, and politics. The position of the young wife, the *kelin*, has been shaped into the social and presumably traditional Kazakh role of the household keeper. This position secured young females’ honor and social status by providing them with a family but limited their social and economic freedom. The *kelin* has assumed the main housekeeping tasks (cleaning the house and raising kids), preparing food, taking care of her husband and his family, and most importantly, showing respect and pouring tea for family members and guests in the proper traditional manner, the latter being an important ritual of self-obedience traditionally ascribed only to the *kelin* (Ismailbekova 2016: 269).

In this chapter, I use my findings from a ten-month virtual ethnography and a number of interviews with actual *kelins* to examine how re-traditionalization discourses are formed and how young women themselves agree or disagree with their marginalized positions in the household. I downloaded the *Kelin* app in October 2015 and logged into the app every evening (or late night in Kazakhstan due to time differences between Cambridge, UK and Astana, Kazakhstan time) to note the most popular debates and discussions in the chat room. During my initial ethnography, the chat room was not divided into different themes, and messages diverged in different directions where some were discussed more

than others. Using this technique of following the most discussed issues, I was able to map the most popular themes: familial problems with in-laws, husband and domestic violence; the burden of *kelin*’s household activities; body politics (virginity, childbearing, and husband’s sexual satisfaction); and economic and money-related issues. I traced these themes and discussions in order to study how young married women agree or disagree with their status as the most marginalized members of their new families.

My focus in this chapter is both on the construction of re-traditionalized discourse of the *kelin*’s low status and also on the social and personal “acceptance” of such positions and behavioral attitudes. How and why do *kelins*—re-traditionalized daughters-in-law—continue to establish their marginality within the familial realm in the context of Kazakhstan’s rapid globalization and internationalization? I address these questions by examining the popular discourses of re-traditionalization of gendered roles and positions of young married women in their families and their own understanding of their status as *kelin*. *First*, I provide a context to the *kelin* evolution in Kazakh society and discuss the ways women’s economic situation may contradict the re-traditionalized values of her household roles. *Second*, I provide the findings from my virtual online fieldwork and analyze the internet-based mobile apps and chat rooms as well as popular blogs and social media in shaping the new “appropriate behavior” of daughters-in-law. In the *third* and final part of the chapter, I discuss how globalization and re-traditionalized discourses interact in making the *kelin* a marginalized and suppressed, yet accepted position, within Kazakh culture.

THE EVOLUTION OF THE KELIN ROLE AND STATUS IN KAZAKH SOCIETY

What is important in the analysis of the *kelin* role and status is careful consideration of the way this

status was shaped over time and the ways it was constructed. Contemporary Kazakh understanding of “*kelin*” equals an obedient and selfless slave that is also a family member. However, the historical development of women’s position in Kazakh society was slightly different from this very distinct image that is perhaps shaped by the economic and political conditions of the paternalistic society and values. In this section I briefly analyze and contextualize women’s role in the society.

Kazakh social media suggest “new” traditions wherein *kelin* has to be a very skilled caregiver who is able to wake up exactly at six o’clock in the morning to prepare breakfast for her family; she has to pour tea for the numerous relatives and never mix up their tea cups (*piala*); she has to bow to her husband’s relatives (*salelem beru* ritual), and according to some sources, even kiss their hands. However, *kelin*’s main responsibilities according to the widespread discourse is to take care of her family, raise children, clean the house, cook according to the “traditional Kazakh cuisine,” and, most importantly, acknowledge that her husband is the ultimate decision-maker in the family. But were these discourses and traditions always in place? Was it always the case that a young Kazakh woman occupied the most marginalized position in society?

Kazakhstani culture and society historically stem from the nomadic lifestyles of the numerous tribes that constituted the Kazakh khanate that formed around the fifteenth century. Women in this nomadic society were traditionally known as equal members of society. This factor was largely romanticized in some historical novels of the Kazakh Soviet period where wives of legendary freedom fighters were “imagined” as fighting on equal terms, wearing male garments, and riding the horse alongside their husbands (see Anuar Alimzhanov’s *Strela Makhambeta*, for example). However, nomadic lifestyles did dictate a reasonable equality and equal division of labor between men and women “specifically as a result of the nomads’ need to deal with both the political and

economic aspects of their mobile lives within their kinship-based social structure” (Ismailbekova 2014: 375). Nomadic women of Central Asia were involved in constant movements and herding as well as household chores. This entailed a very different lifestyle and different gender roles than in sedentary societies where the division of labor was highly gendered and where women occupied mainly labor and roles in private rather than public spheres.

The Soviet campaign for women’s liberation, in turn, became an ideological tool and an unfinished project of emancipation, as the state did not provide full involvement of women in ruling political positions but used them as a labor force in its developmentalist projects. Although Soviet women after liberation were given more rights and access to education and some job markets, they experienced the “double burden” of working in “traditionally female and low-paying sectors, such as clothing and textiles, or else into the bottom end of job hierarchies in new fields,” and taking care of their families (Buckley 1989: 2). The family institutionalized women’s positions as primary caregivers for their husbands and children. The Soviet discourse, however, did not position women’s roles within the tradition but rather within ideology; that is, women had to be active and working citizens as well as the “producers” of the nation. Soviet discourse did not facilitate the *kelin* or daughter-in-law discourse and many of the relations with in-laws were left for the contextual and private sphere of relations. In other words, the discourse did not provide a clear-cut blueprint for the young wife’s obligations to her family or in-laws apart from taking care of her own husband and children. Furthermore, child-free choices were highly stigmatized in Soviet society, which also supports the argument of its constructed, rather than real, idea of women’s emancipation.

The Soviet state and propaganda were mainly interested in women as a secondary labor force (compared to men), the main reproductive force, and one of the fields for its ideological

slogans and exemplification. Kandiyoti (2007: 602) termed this concept a “Soviet paradox” which is

“a paradox that resides in the combined and contradictory operations of a socialist paternalism that supported and legitimized women’s presence in the public sphere (through education, work and political representation), with a command economy and nationalities policies that effectively stalled processes of social transformation commonly associated with modernity.”

As a result, the legacies of this approach then provided “male privilege” in the most powerful political and economic decision-making (on the elite level) in post-Soviet Central Asian states where it “constitute[s] redeployment of notions of cultural authenticity in the service of new ideological goals” (Kandiyoti 2007: 603). I have argued elsewhere (e.g., see Kudaibergenova 2016, 2017) that this notion of “cultural” and national “authenticity” provided by the new political and ideological elites is openly contested by the diverse and unique female movement of cultural elites, such as female contemporary artists who may not directly identify with the feminist agenda but claim the state’s “inauthenticity.” This movement also does not hide the fact that young women in Kazakhstan, as well as elsewhere in Central Asia, remain the most vulnerable economic group.

The collapse of the Soviet Union deeply influenced the economic conditions of the new states of Central Asia where the old networks and states’ welfare systems were completely destroyed. The political elites of the new states of Central Asia were desperately looking for new ways to strengthen the weakened economy that severely impacted women (Buckley 1997; Ibanez-Tirado 2014; Ishkanian 2004; Ismailbekova 2014; Kamp 2005; Kandiyoti 1999; Lubin 1981; Nazpary 2002; Werner 2004). Indeed, Nazpary’s (2002) study of post-Soviet transition in Kazakhstan clearly demonstrated the devastating effect of structural unemployment on women. Whereas some women

were forced to engage in shuttle trade (Werner 2004), others had to engage in a sexual trade of favors and sex work to sustain their families (Nazpary 2002).

In contemporary Kazakhstan, young women seek to marry in order to secure their economic and social positions. A young wife’s roles and tasks of childbearing and caregiving for the whole family are considered more honorable, although less prestigious or not prestigious at all, compared to male’s breadwinner roles. But the *kelin*’s task is considered “natural and commonsensical although unpaid work.” As Werner (2004: 108) explains, “in modern societies, at least four factors influence women’s prospects for wage employment.” *First* are “social norms” closely connected to the husband’s reputation as the main provider for the family; *second* are constraints of “child care” that mainly fall on women’s shoulders, especially in traditional and re-traditionalized societies; and *third* are “economic and political factors.” While Soviet ideology portrayed women as becoming emancipated and as contributing to the labor force (Atwood 1999; Buckley 1989; Chatterjee 2002; Edgar 2006; Gapova 2002; Kamp 2006; Kandiyoti 2007; Kollontai 1920; Lubin 1981; Northrop 2004; Tohidi 1998), in reality women’s participation in the labor market and most importantly in top political decision-making was limited. Despite Soviet propaganda and programs on women’s emancipation, not even one woman was ever among the Politburo top political elite echelon and most post-Soviet political scenes, apart from the Baltic States, kept female politicians and female representatives of the state and nation as a minority (Kudaibergenova 2016; Megoran 1999). Finally, the *fourth* factor noted by Werner is globalization. “New social attitudes do not represent a complete break from the past,” writes Werner (2004: 108), and on the contrary, many societies continue pressurizing women to keep the “honor” of their cultures in the globalized workspaces where women have to become “invisible.” They are also invisible in their homes where “a good

kelin is expected to respect her in-laws by providing unpaid household services for them” (Werner 2004: 113).

Under these conditions and pressures, many women choose marriage as one way to secure their economic position but also to protect their bodies and their honor from accusations and violence. The widespread discourse of the new “traditions” and values of the familial ties, and the importance of saving her virginity before marriage have commodified the position of *kelin* within the family, society, and nation. But how do young women relate to these issues, and how do they navigate their roles and what is expected of them by this code of behavior? In the remainder of this chapter, I discuss the ways *kelin* discourses are formed, channeled, and settled through the popular media, and how young women themselves accept these positions.

GLOBALIZATION AND KELIN APP: EXPLORING THE APPSTORE TO DEFINE THE “APPROPRIATE BEHAVIOR” OF KELIN ONLINE

The popularization of the *kelin* discourse and attributes of the contemporary “traditional” *kelin* facilitate the acceptance of the *kelin*’s marginal status and obedient behavior that is expected of her. Many channels—including such globalized networks and social media as Instagram, Facebook, and Whatsapp as well as local television and print media—shape these views and attitudes by the production of popular satirical videos, anecdotes, and movies about *kelins*. *Kelin* discourse has become the most popular image for the discussion of rituals and “traditions” and through humor it also has facilitated a sense of acceptance. As noted previously, in August 2015, *Kelin* mobile app, for example, became the most popular app on Kazakhstani iTunes and was downloaded more than 15,000 times in the first

two weeks after the launch. The app was launched on the wave of popular videos and jokes about *kelin* status shared on Instagram and in the wake of *Kelinka Sabinka* popular films and series that started in 2011 as short videos about Sabina, a young Kazakh woman who was kidnapped and forcibly married in a remote village outside Almaty, the largest city in Kazakhstan.

Three different themes are at play in these humoristic videos, jokes, and mobile apps. *First*, these videos signal that *kelin* status becomes a maturing stage for stubborn young girls who finally have to submit to someone’s authority. *Second*, these videos demonstrate that even the most non-traditional young Kazakh women can be transformed into “traditional” *kelins* through their experience under watchful mothers-in-law. For example, these videos and discussions usually portray young Kazakh women as being too cosmopolitan: they live in big cities, mainly speak the Russian language, and prefer Western style clothes and culture which is usually symbolized by their dyed blonde hair. The conclusion of the first *Kelinka Sabinka* film, for example, demonstrates how her forced experience of serving as a *kelin* in a typical Kazakh village changed her into a “better” woman and a more moral person. Finally, the *third* theme found in all of these popular discourses is the woman’s complete self-sacrifice for the happiness of her family. According to this discourse, the *kelin* status invites the woman to consider giving up her job, interests, and aspirations outside her familial domain.

The actual experiences of *kelins* may be very far from humoristic accents of the popular discourses about them or from those popular shows such as *Kelin baige* [Daughters-in-law Competition] where they evaluate each other’s wedding days. However, this does not stop the popular discourse from forming. One of the main components of this discourse is the mobile *Kelin* app. The *Kelin* app started as a simple mobile app with four dimensions: the “Perfect *Kelin*” test that initially became the main selling point, recipes for the traditional Kazakh cuisine dishes,

dictionary explaining main Kazakh rituals and names of *kelin*'s new family members (the numerous in-laws), as well as the *Kelin* chat room.

The "Perfect *Kelin*" test evaluated the user's attitudes by questioning, for example, whether one would be willing to wake up in the middle of the night to feed her "husband's relatives who came to visit" and who then can come any time of the day. In order to receive one positive point, the user had to answer that question affirmatively. Half of the questions concerned the *kelin*'s appropriate behavior, which in the minds of the app developers, constitutes waking up at 6 am to prepare tea for your husband and his family, not saying a word when your mother-in-law is scolding you, and making dinner "even if you are tired" (the correct answer to that question is "I should because I am *kelin*"). Another half of the questions concerned the *kelin*'s knowledge of traditions and rituals of ethnic Kazakhs; it tested the knowledge of Kazakh words for the pre-wedding and wedding rituals and names for the new family members (the most popular is *ene*, meaning mother-in-law). Some of the questions asked the new *kelin* to evaluate her economic and social position in the family—for example, "You have a [prestigious] BA degree from the Kazakh-British Technical University and your husband has no degree; who is the most important person in your household?"—and the correct answer provided by the app was "your husband." In other instances the app tested the following: "How to ask your husband to buy you a new fur coat [for winter]?" evaluating most *kelins*' economic conditions depending on their husbands. However, it also specified that some *kelins* were working too: "Who should cook the dinner if you came home from work and you are tired?" with the correct answer: "I should because I am a *kelin*."

At the end of the evaluation, the app told users whether they qualified as "perfect" (100 percent *kelin*), or whether their results were "satisfactory," or even "bad." In these instances the app evaluation told the user that they were someone from a certain part of Kazakhstan—usually from northern

Kazakhstan—a region that is stereotypically considered as being the least informed about rituals and traditions. Many people reacted negatively to such conclusions, but some took it with pride. For example, Mada Mada, a famous Kazakh Instagram blogger known for her feminist views, shared a picture of her mere "1% Can be better" evaluation on the *Kelin* test, which greatly added to the growing popularity of the app. She later commented on her Facebook that she had no plans for marrying anytime soon and preferred to live her life as she pleased without following "traditional" moral behavior which gained her a scandalous yet popular position as an outspoken feminist blogger in Kazakhstan.

The "dictionary" section of the app provided "*kelin* keywords" to those who failed the part of the test dealing with Kazakh traditions. The keywords explained who were *ene* [mother-in-law] and *kuda* [in-laws on both sides]. It also explained the *kыз узату*, which is the ritual organized by the bride's family to send her off to the husband's family before the actual marriage, as well as other rituals and traditions. For example, if someone was not aware of the *shashu* [literally throwing candy instead of rice over newlyweds] or *betashar* [uncovering of bride's face and introducing her to the family of the groom] rituals, she could quickly access the basic explanation of these rituals.

The recipes section was the most straightforward one, and it repeated much of the food content provided by *Kelin* Instagram account, ranging from how to make perfect *beshparmaq* [traditional Kazakh cooked meat and dough dish] to how to make dietary cakes and ice cream. However, this section was crucial for the "perfect" *kelin* as part of her "product" description because, according to this re-traditionalized discourse, the *kelin* should cook "fresh and tasty" meals all day long, from the early morning full brunch to lunch and full supper for the whole family. The *Kelin* app tended to glamourize this very routine activity by providing non-Kazakh recipes and pictures of the "perfect *Kelin*" in fashionable

attire for cooking and spotless kitchenware on their Instagram photo-sharing account that also attracted many local followers. This image of Kazakh daughters-in-law is also supported by another initiative—the “Academy of the Perfect Wives”—which is a *kelin* school organized by a separate group of people based in the city of Almaty. This *kelin* school promises to teach young Kazakh wives everything from the perfect dress code and beauty secrets, to the “21st century culinary,” to the art of bringing up children, with the promise of the certificate for the “Ideal *Kelin*” by the end of the course.

The typical set of expectations for the “ideal *kelin*” is striking. Based on my online research and interviews, such expectations can be summed up as follows: (1) The perfect *kelin* has to be beautiful but respectful foremost to her husband and his relatives; (2) she has to cook well and keep the house with impeccable tidiness; (3) she has to be welcoming to her husband’s relatives and other guests; (4) she has to be quiet and never voice her concerns or bad mood in front of her husband or in-laws; (5) she has to take good care of her husband’s family and his younger siblings; (6) she has to know the ritual of tea preparation and tea serving, a tradition that is detailed in all the descriptions.

Kelin discourse is multifaceted in contemporary Kazakh society. Although the initial status of *kelin* was surrounded by honor and respect, recently it has gained more of a sarcastic and ridiculing position. There are numerous shows, series, and talk shows on mainly Kazakh language local television channels that discuss the marginalized roles of “traditional” *kelins*. Usually young *kelins* are portrayed in their obedient positions to the mothers-in-law. In one of the humoristic shows that started off as a small video shared on Instagram and through Whatsapp and Viber, a typical Kazakh mother-in-law is introduced to her son’s fiancée, a young Kazakh girl with dyed blonde hair from Almaty who barely speaks Kazakh. The dialogue starts with the mother-in-law interrogating the young woman in the Kazakh

language but not allowing her to answer by repeating on and on: “Shut up! Shut up!” in Kazakh. Finally, the fiancée becomes offended and looks to her husband-to-be for help. She can clearly demonstrate her understanding of Kazakh, but she continues to communicate in Russian, an attribute of a not-so-perfect Kazakh *kelin*. The son tries to defend his fiancée, but his mother replies to him in Kazakh with her usual “Shut up!” The video became so popular that both the mother-in-law and her son were selected to host their own show on one of the commercial TV channels where every episode starts with the interrogation of yet another potential *kelin*.

In the *Kelinka Sabinka* movie, the protagonist Sabina, a young urbanite Russian-speaking Kazakh woman played by the male actor and comedian Nurtas Adambay, is kidnapped to become the wife of Janibek who promised her to live in Dubai but instead brought her to a remote village outside Almaty from which she cannot escape. An urban socialite, she is forced to cover her unusual blonde hair with an *oramal* (headscarf), serve tea, prepare traditional Kazakh food, take care of the cow, and even clean the sheep intestines to prepare a local delicacy—the activities that typically constitute the household labor of a young daughter-in-law.

Being a *kelin* is not simply a lifestyle, it is a career, argues anthropologist Aksana Ismailbekova: “Women begin their careers as new brides (*kelins*) at the lowest position when they are first brought into their husband’s household. A young bride submits to the authority of her mother-in-law” (Ismailbekova 2016: 266). The mother-in-law is considered as the guardian of traditions and the main actor who is capable of bargaining with patriarchy in the family. In most of the chat discussions and videos, the powerful *ene* is considered the leader of the family and sometimes even the main financial dealer of the family budget. The *kelin*’s career and her gradual assertion of authority is based on her relations with her mother-in-law who is believed to establish the order and “traditions” in each

family. This image is intrinsic even to the most artistic expressions and evaluations of traditions, for example, in Yermek Tursunov's art house film—"Kelin"—where the mother-in-law is positioned as the highest authority and as the main keeper of traditions, up until the point when she passes her responsibilities to the *kelin*. In Tursunov's interpretation, the mother-in-law had to die in order to allow the *kelin* to become the new authority in the family.

In the next and final section, I shift focus directly to my study of the *Kelin* mobile app, chat rooms, and interviews conducted with young daughters-in-law to contextualize these findings with a more nuanced understanding of the roles and status of "*kelin*" among young women who were about to get married or who had been married already for at least one year and up to five years.

THE RISE OF RE-TRADITIONALIZATION

During my ten-month virtual ethnography, I was a frequent and active user of the *Kelin* app under the established framework of participant observation. I noted the most discussed themes and saved some of the comments for further analysis while keeping my field notes in a separate notebook. I noted that family problems, complaints about too much household work, and taking care of children, as well as husband's sexual satisfaction and premarital sex agreements, were the most discussed issues along with money-related debates and concerns. Most of these discussions, however, ended up with the growing consensus over prioritizing the family rather than the *kelin*'s personal choices. In the following, I focus on discussions of the problems addressed in the chat room. These include discussions on *domestic violence* including relations with the mother-in-law and *sexual life* discussions. The chat room users were anonymous and there were no mobile numbers or any personal data shared or used as part

of the research; all users had randomly assigned avatars (mainly animal symbols) and only a few signed their nicknames at the end of the every message (e.g., Panda, Mulya, and so forth). I kept track of the discussions by taking notes of the date and theme of the discussion instead of the names. For the purposes of clarification, in this chapter I assign every participant of each discussion with numbers: 1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, and so on, based on every new discussion or new social actor in the discussion. Here, I provide my own exact transcription and translation of feeds in the chat room. Most of the feeds were written in the Russian language with no more than 20 percent of the feeds in the Kazakh language.

In mid-October, a young and recently married *kelin* joined the chat room desperate for advice about her first big fight with her husband. Unable to hide the fact that a quarrel over a minor misunderstanding led to her being beaten by her husband, she wrote:

K.1.1: Girls, help me with a situation, please give me an advice, what to do? I had a fight with my husband, he "ate my brain" [bothered me a lot] and I told him that I would leave him. He beat me up. His mother saw how he was beating me up and she stopped him. Now he ate and left. He said that he didn't know when he would come back. I am feeling horrible inside. I am feeling so bad. What should I do? How should I behave with him from now on?

With this initial feed, the discussion started on domestic violence dividing the audience into those who suggested to "learn how to behave" and not to "irritate" the husband and those who suggested leaving the husband before getting pregnant.

K.1.2: Oh girls, why are you all getting beaten up, huh? Are you all spoiled and capricious, are you all [emotionally] unstable? If not – then don't wait for the changes and run away from such husbands.

In most of the discussions on domestic violence against *kelins* that I observed, victim blaming was a starting point:

K.1.3: I think women should also watch their tongues and watch what they say, I would've beaten up some women myself for their long tongue [inability to stop talking]. But you have to run away from the man who started beating you up.

Then, there were comments providing “practical advice”:

K.1.5: I think that the problem of domestic violence will never be solved so what is left to us is to become skillful in these conditions and not to irritate our husbands. Let him say whatever he wants until his bad mood goes away. In the beginning I also talked back to him but then I decided to keep it quiet. I kiss him instead and tell him that he's my baby, even though I am lying to him, and this way I am keeping our marriage.

Most domestic violence discussions also involved consideration for the well-being of the children and wives' inability to support them financially without a husband:

K.1.4: I am taking good care of my husband. I need him to support my son in the future. What is the point of irritating your husband every time? Either way it all depends on a smart woman.

At this point, the *kelin* who started the discussion gave more details about the fight that involved a minor disagreement but led to the initial intervention from the mother-in-law:

K.1.1: The worst thing was that his mom sat us both down and told us that is a normal phenomenon [for the husband to beat up his wife]. And she told me that if I want to keep the family I have to suck it up and live with [beating] husband. She said that's the destiny of the woman.

By then, however, most of the discussants had moved on to another case where a more experienced *kelin*, who was a mother of one child and who had a similar experience, was ready to file for divorce due to her husband's alcoholism and instances of domestic violence. In fact, very few participants of the chat room went back to the initial discussions and actors who voiced their concerns, to check up on them and find out whether their issues were resolved. Over time the chat room occupiers were more interested in “finished narratives,” that is, in longer stories of women who had left their husbands and were able to tell their stories “after divorce,” or who had managed to stay in the marriage. The interest for such stories was justified by the need to compare and analyze these situations further. But chat room gurus, who gained authority over time because of their experiences, were eager to comment on those “unresolved” familial issues too. Each story was quickly picked up and *kelins* instantly started commenting on the new case of domestic violence where the couple was on the verge of divorce:

K.2.10: Just tell me, are there any objective reasons [for divorce]? Because just filing for divorce is the easiest way [to end it]. But family relations are very hard work and mainly the woman has to take care of this [hard work].

Initially chat rooms were not separated and different chats and feeds were combined and shared between those who discussed someone's potential divorce, those who complained about their everyday chores, and their commentators:

K. 8.9: The keyword here [in marriage] is cooking ALL THE TIME. I am already tired of cooking several times a day.

K.9.16: I just sat down after a long day of serving for my in-laws. I feel like I am going to die.

Many *kelins* shared their advice concerning health and pregnancy and shared their experiences of being pregnant or giving birth and raising

children. Occasionally some “lost souls” joined the chat for a quick contraception consultation. Usually, those were unmarried women who had decided to “give” their “virginity” to their loved ones in hopes that “one day he promised to marry me.” Eventually, these women were criticized for dishonoring themselves and their bodies.

K.22.3: How to recover your virginity? There is no way for that! My advice to all the young girls: if you love each other so deeply it doesn't mean you should engage in “it” [sexual intercourse]. The best way is to abstain. Young men, they just can use you and dump you even if they love you. Every girl has to have her own head on her shoulders [meaning she has to think twice]! The best thing is to remain a virgin before marriage and only then to give it away to only one man—your one and only husband!!!

These posts were interspersed with some very alarming and even suicidal comments from those who were not able to “resist the temptation.” For example, one anonymous user who claimed to be 16 wrote the following note:

K.21.16: My love has gone but there is no way I can get back my virginity. I really regret losing it. I do not know what to do. My mom scolds me all the time and beats me, now grandma also knows. Basically, I cannot live now and I don't want to live now. I am looking for the killer [to kill me] because I do not have guts to do it myself [commit suicide]. I really love life but I do not know what to do anymore . . .

The discussions about body and sex in this chat room associated female virginity with the greatest honor and “gift” that a young wife could grant her husband, and sex was considered as both a bonding strategy and “reward” or a negotiating factor in quarrels and fights. Many chat room commentators, for example, suggested to not engage in sexual activity with the husband before resolving the argument. When some suggested

this “would only distract him,” others worried that after-sex discussions “interrupt your husband's pleasure.” The *kelin*'s body and her sexual activity were also considered as part of the “product” or commodity and some of the commentators were openly commenting on it.

K.7.3: Life after marriage: The situation changed a lot and I am stressed a bit. I am alone [in the new family] and my husband is not helping. He just yells all the time, but when he needs sex he is always nice and sweet. This is not my ideal life, this is not how I imagined it [married life].

Marriage is perceived by many young women in contemporary Kazakhstan as a fairy-tale like scenario where “in reality many things are a lot less glamorous and more pragmatic,” as one of my interviewees in Almaty recounted. However, many young women become convinced that the *kelin* status is the best scenario for them. There is, of course, a counter-discourse that is also provided on exactly the same platforms as popular blogs, Instagram, and Facebook and occasionally on news websites. Here, young and successful Kazakh women write their blog entries about being single at 28 and even 30 and “having it all.” And young feminist bloggers, such as Mada Mada and Diana Idris, who launched their semi-satiric campaigns against “Kazakh traditionalism” on their respective personal Instagram pages, are gaining more popularity. An alternative version to the *kelin*, namely the *toqal* [second wife] has been circulating in the public discourse ever since the late 1990s, and it also has grown in popularity. *Toqals* are viewed as completely the opposite of the *kelin*. They indulge in a free and usually luxurious or middle-class lifestyle but continue to depend financially on their “husband” or as it is alternatively termed, “sponsor.” The *toqal*'s main commodity is her ability to satisfy the “sponsor” sexually and emotionally. But in the end, the fate of both the *kelin* and the *toqal* is very similar and is connected to their economic

dependence on their husband or sponsor. Young women remain vulnerable as economic and social actors in Kazakhstan, and this is a growing problem as they engage in certain activities and lifestyles so as to provide stability and security for themselves and their families.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I have provided an ethnographic and contextualized overview of the position of young married women, *kelins*, in contemporary Kazakhstan and their status vis-à-vis economic and social challenges as well as the burden of the traditional way of thinking that falls on them. Re-traditionalization in gendered economies and lifestyles continues to privilege men over women, and “although modernization may have been the theory of Soviet intentions, neo-traditionalism became the theory of their unintended consequences” (Kandiyoti 2007: 606) that continue to influence contemporary gender relations in Kazakhstan. The rise of *kelin* discourse and its commodification is an alarming tendency that requires further study and attention from feminist scholars. After all, the *kelin*’s position is the most unstable and marginalized, given current economic and sociocultural conditions, and such chat rooms as the *Kelin* app not only reveal the gravity of the problems that many *kelins* confront but also how these problems are far from the satiric representation of the mainstream media.

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Chapter twenty-nine

“Women Move the Cradle with One Hand and with the Other, the World!”

Methodological Reflections on “The Woman Question” in Tajikistan

Sophie Roche

INTRODUCTION

A Tajik saying holds that “Women move the cradle with one hand and with the other, the world!” The meaning of this saying is that women may simply move a cradle with their baby and care for the family, while they can also have a significant impact on society. However, research on women in Central Asia has focused mainly on the vulnerability of women in their roles as wives and daughters within patriarchal systems and also as a consequence of the collapse of the Soviet Union. The emphasis on women as vulnerable subjects of society is not unusual, and it has been a part of long-term discourse in Central Asia. Specifically, led by the Bolsheviks, political activities were organized under the banner of freeing the woman from patriarchy (Kasymova 2008). Such activities included the campaign of unveiling (known as *hujum*) in the 1920s (Kamp 2006); health politics (*mission civilisatrice*) (Hohmann 2009; Hohmann and Garenne 2005); the battle against unhealthy practices (religious and medical practices) (Bushkov and Mikul’skii 1996; Northrop 2004: 60–61; Penkala-Gawęcka 2013; Poliakov 1992: 62); and economic reforms (*kolkhoz* system)

(Kuniansky 1981; Zikriyoeva 2001). However, much less effort was invested in changing gender divisions inside the family (Alimova and Azimova 1999; Keller 1998).

Imperial systems have employed gender as a category for politics far beyond the Russian context (Ashwin 2000; Kandiyoti 2007; Kaser and Katschnig-Fasch 2005; Northrop 2004; Tlostanova 2010; Woollacott 2006; Yuval-Davis 1997). New systems introduced new conceptions of the “ideal” woman, toward which other women were urged to orient themselves. Although in the 1920s, with the emergence of the Soviet era, stories of unveiling and educational achievements by women were considered exemplary (Edgar 2006), the tone became more modest after World War II (the Great Patriotic War) because Stalin needed women to take up their motherhood role again. The “mother-hero” was introduced as a new role model after the war in order to encourage childbirth under “socialist paternalism” (Jones and Grupp 1987; Verdery 1996: 62) and as surrogate proletariat (Massell 1974). These political models did not remain mere slogans but were integrated into public discourses and interpretations of one’s own life. During the Soviet era, Tajik women,

as mothers, proudly presented their children as proof of success in life, and they were honored by the Soviet state. Yet, with the collapse of the Soviet Union, Tajik women as mothers came to be neglected by the new independent, post-Soviet government. This new government, which gained power after the Tajik civil war of the early 1990s, once again used gender as a clear-cut concept to regulate society and promote nationalism (Kandiyoti 2007; Roche 2016). At the same time, many women became heads of their household after divorce or after the death of their husbands (Cleuziou 2016). Women took up various jobs and became the main breadwinner in many families. Kasymova (2008: 43) has even identified several domains, such as shuttle trade started by Tajik women. Thus, the Tajik woman is now supposed to represent the traditional values of Tajik culture as designated by the government, as well as to assume the care of the family when men are not able to do so.

Unlike other countries in Central Asia, Tajikistan experienced a civil war in the 1990s that destroyed many of the small industries and enterprises in rural areas, changed land ownership, and destroyed the infrastructure left over from the Soviet period. Since the early 2000s, Tajiks have rebuilt private homes, established small businesses, and invested in infrastructure. However, corruption and an increasingly restrictive political regime have hindered the progress. Furthermore, violence in families seems to be particularly prevalent in regions that have suffered from the civil war (Tokhtakhodjaeva 1995). Indeed, during my own fieldwork research in Tajikistan, I witnessed many violent scenarios that ended with kin advising the wife to endure domestic violence because it was linked to consequences of the civil war. The state never introduced measures to control domestic violence after the war, whereas international organizations have increasingly advocated that these practices be changed through legal measures, education, and by cultivating religious or cultural consciousness.

Indeed, with the arrival of international organizations during the post-Soviet era, violence against women was increasingly made public and became integrated into human rights discourse (Atlani-Duault and Poujol 2008; Haarr 2005, 2010; Hoare 2016; Sharipova and Fábíán 2010). Further, Direnberger (2014) found in her research that Tajik women, who were integrated into the development realm, accepted standards of gender suggested by international organizations while suffering from the tensions that these concepts caused in relation to actual practices in their families. It also is noteworthy that the mass out-migration of men during the post-Soviet sociopolitical and economic transition has eased the levels of violence and the pressure felt by many women in villages, but it has also created new problems for single mothers who have had to assume various gender roles (Cleuziou 2016). Indeed, one of the main sources of tension in Tajik society pertains to gender relations, a conceptual dispute between different parties with no consensus in sight.

I identify three main parties in this conceptual dispute pertaining to gender: *the government*, *international organizations*, and *neo-religious activists*. Whereas *international organizations* promote gender equality, the *Tajik government* considers women as the carriers of culture (Roche 2016). In this role, while the woman is expected to adhere to clothing rules and educational restrictions, she is also the core of many national celebrations and representative of Tajik national culture (cf. Suyarkulova 2016). This fetishizing of the woman at the state level not only ignores the reality of women's lives but also the role of family in shaping women's choices. Furthermore, *religious activists* consider both the international organizations' and the government's concepts of gender to be in opposition to Islam, which they wish to see as the main basis for Tajik social order. Although there is no common concept among all religious activists, they do share a set of ideas including the importance of family as a nuclear unit headed by the husband, who is also

the breadwinner. Thus, in recent decades we have seen Tajik society struggle to resolve a central point of dispute which pertains to the role, position, and representation of women. The dispute is, however, not mere rhetorical discourse but has fundamental consequences for women and the choices to shape their lives.

In this chapter, I utilize a methodological approach to outline how women present their lives through different sources, including *folk theater plays*, *interviews*, *ethnographic field experiences*, *letters*, and *diaries*. Thus I distinguish between reality, experience, and expression as Bruner (1986: 7) has suggested. Drawing from the anthropology of experience, various authors distinguish between the following: reality as life is lived, the experience of an event that is highly individual and complex and is presented visually or is performed, and expression, whereby "every telling is interpretative" and every story tells something different about experience, even for the same event. The examples presented in this chapter will outline different ways to think with (not about) women in society. Thus, one goal of the chapter is to demonstrate that violence against women is not a traditional pattern, but part of more fundamental changes that include socio-economic and political change, the loss of the unconditional support of matrilineage by women, and increased emphasis on reformed religious values with the father being the ultimate head of family. Few families have reached this imagined optimum of an Islamic family as promoted among Hizb ut-Tahrir members in which the mother lives in a modern flat with her children, while the loving father and husband works successfully outside of the home and the relatives are part of the social community, all equally living in religious harmony. The flat in Tajikistan is still seen as a step toward modern life (in Soviet modernity) as it eases the task of the daughter-in-law, who in rural areas manages the household and garden. In a flat, the daughter-in-law only cares for her own flat and that of her mother-in-law (they often live in the same building), but she

can physically retreat and manage her family as she wishes.

Such imagined concepts are relevant when women make use of them (whether as something to attain or reject) but may be irrelevant when women do not consider religion a solution to their lives. An example illustrates where Islamic concepts came to inspire young women to be active in society and develop individual careers. Specifically, the Islamic Revival Party of Tajikistan (the *Nahzat*) had more female than male members until it was banned in 2015. While the exact reasons for this have never been researched, it shows that women played active roles in societal discourses. This party also had leading women in place who promoted women to be active members of society far beyond the household. For instance, when I regularly visited the *Nahzat* in 2013, it was fashionable among girls of the *Nahzat* to get a driving license, enter the job market to gain financial independence from their parents, and make sure to receive an education in religious studies or any other subject deemed appropriate for women. These girls and women narrated their lives by using Islam as a frame of reference for their personal development.

In existential anthropology, analytical interpretations are taken from the narrators themselves and in relation to the observations and experiences of the ethnographers, rather than from theoretical models that are developed—without exception—in Western universities. In this sense, the different sources that I utilize in this chapter include *folk theater plays*, *interviews*, *ethnographic field experiences*, *letters*, and *diaries*. These sources are ways of engaging with existence itself and ways of sharing the experience of life. To address both the moving of the cradle and of the world by Tajik women is hence the goal of this chapter. The use of existential anthropology offers ways to reconsider women's experiences by paying attention to the way experiences are shared and how societal concepts are related, integrated, and negotiated.

FOLK THEATER AS GENDER PERFORMANCE

Theater culture was established in all Soviet cities in Tajikistan as part of urban life. Interestingly, today, theater in Tajikistan is considered primarily a leisure activity for women, even if men occasionally accompany their wives. Theater groups also have women play the roles, which is not evident in regions where, before the Soviet period, performances were carried out by men or ethnic groups (*Luli*), and young men would play the female roles. One of the genres, which Laura Adams traces back to the colonial period of Turkestan, is *maskhara*, a combination of satirical clowning, song, and storytelling (Adams 2005: 338). Today, *maskhara* is the most popular form of play in Tajikistan, often borrowing theater space in which to perform. The folk theater, *maskhara*, does not follow written scripts but takes real situations as its reference and works on situations that appear typical to the spectator. Humorous engagement with such situations is largely responsible for making *maskhara* so popular. Further, women play the main roles in most of the recent performances. In discussing the different genres the theater performs, the director, *Kamoli Khujandi*, explained:

As we are a theater of musical play, we try to organize only musical theater. As the name is such: Masaka musikavi . . . We also have a folklore ethnographic group, the ensemble of the grand-mothers (asambli bibiho), that is women who are old. They have their own leader but they are considered a small theater group. They work and use any building [for their theater]. You may have seen their performance on Navruz.

In Khujand, the second largest city in Tajikistan, the *maskhara* performance group includes several elderly women who practice independently from the theater team (theater *Kamoli Khujandi*). During festivals such as *Navruz* or New Year, the group performs outside the theater in public but

use the *Kamoli Khujandi*'s theater equipment. The subject of most *maskhara* performances is a mother-in-law (*khushtoman*) who manages her family. She is the central figure of the family and directs all other members, including the husband and children. The actors exaggerate the roles, which uncover the mother-in-law as the tyrant of the family. She will trick her husband to agree on the marriage of their son with the girl of her choice, surprise her husband when he tries to escape her grip as he turns to another woman, or plan the best party for her daughter. The *maskhara* is intended to encourage people to laugh about situations that many of the spectators have experienced and know from their own lives. The central subject in the *maskhara* is how and to whom to marry the children. When trying to have his choices agreed on, the father usually fails due to ruses by the wife. The woman, as mother-in-law, mother, and wife, is presented as the most powerful and merciless person inside a household, who makes all the decisions. Whereas *maskhara* can use any subject, the choice of the mother-in-law and wife as the main figure reflects the tension around "women" in society. The mother and mother-in-law are considered the strongest members of the family, representatives of Tajik culture, and politically loyal individuals.

If we look at performance as an expression of experience in the sense of Bruner (1986), the *maskhara* articulates, on the one hand, the tension in society over the gender conceptual references. Specifically, the Tajik mother-in-law is the one who most radically represents state values, which include: (1) maintaining clear gender roles; (2) preventing Islam from assuming a dominant role; (3) keeping children in check if their wishes are unlawful; (4) maintaining the clothing and skills that the state imagines Tajik traditions to look like. On the other hand, *maskhara* reveals the tensions inside the family among the different roles of its members. *Indeed, the performative presentation of the mother as the one who moves the cradle and the family, if not the whole village, is not a fiction but a daily experience that uncovers*

a social hierarchy in which women can hold powerful positions within the family and challenge male authority beyond the family context.

SUFFERING WOMEN AND PATRIARCHAL REPRESENTATIONS IN THE INTERVIEW NARRATIVE

Women present a very different view of society during interviews with external researchers and development workers. The interview, as a formal form of conversation in which the primary goal is the extraction of information by one party, creates a situation of power imbalance (Rosaldo 1986). This is by far not the most comfortable situation for all people, but it is still the most popular method in social sciences and for international organizations. In the Tajik context, experts consider the interview a professional way of inquiring about a subject, but interviews often create uneasiness among women who do not consider themselves experts. Many researchers have struggled with the difficulties of representing the reality of women's lives in Tajikistan through the analysis of interviews or visits to households, but in the end have imposed their own categories to make sense of the discrepancies and tensions. A first step is, therefore, to review the methods and to set aside categories of analysis in order to reflect on the concepts to which interview partners refer. "Women," as one of the core subjects of politics, is constructed by the state, which also provides the categories for personal interpretations. These categories include perceiving Tajik women as victims of political Islam, as being dependent on the government or international organizations for liberation and protection, as mothers of the nation, as long-suffering, as loving mothers, and as carriers of traditions. Yet, this political construction of women avoids acknowledging the agency of women and their choices other than what is expected and framed by the

state. For example, in the Tajik context, this ignores the fact that women depend more on their own brothers than on their husbands, and that these representations or concepts are constantly reshaped, rejected, accepted, and enforced through practice.

A common modern example is a mother who was left behind in Tajikistan by her husband who moved to Russia for work. From a patriarchal perspective, this created vulnerability because the mother and her children lost the breadwinner and then had to care for themselves. The mother described in the interview below became the target of her brothers-in-law, who wanted her house. The husband, being away from his wife and children lost his power as the head of the household and, under pressure from his family, divorced his wife who was consequently forced to give up her house. In order to understand this reaction, it is important to know that a woman is in fact less dependent on her husband than on her own brothers. Tajik wives never change kinship group (*avlod*); it is not even expected that a husband cares for his wife since it is her own father and brothers who will look after her when delivering her children or when ill, until her own sons are old enough to take over this care. In the case of the house, her own brothers would have been responsible to fight for her. The strong maternal line is reflected in the fact that the mother's brother (*taghoi*) is the father's replacement if the father dies. This contradicts Islamic patriarchal practices in which the father's brothers act as replacement, a practice that is increasingly established in urban centers and is spreading into rural areas as men consider Islam the sole basis of social order. The following is an example from my previous fieldwork:

Last year my husband left for Russia for good and did not call at all anymore—once he called but did not speak very nicely. Now and again he would send money, but for the four children it was just nothing. My neighbors watered the land, our toilet broke down, then my husband's brother came to

fight, so one day I took my things and went to my mother's house. My husband came back and divorced me, and my husband's brother threw us out of our own house. Now we don't have a roof and a house.

This passage emphasizes the interviewee's passivity in the process; she is the victim, and hence bears her fate patiently. This representation of passive self-presentation situates the woman as appropriate and good, and her suffering will be rewarded by God later. She follows a mode of narrative that is expected from her; she does not complain or revolt against injustice, nor has she tried to go to court but considers it a matter of fate. Suffering is part of being a woman and should be done with pride, according to Tajik women. Indeed, sharing stories of suffering increases the status of the woman who has endured this suffering, but it also works as a lesson to the audience. Often, I found myself crying upon hearing the difficulties a woman had gone through. The reaction to this was to mock me as being unable to recognize and honor a woman's suffering.

A second representation is found in episodes in life that highlight the difficulties and injustice experienced by women. Specifically, Tajik civil war narratives contain similar rhetoric:

One night they came to find me, to take me and my brother—we hid in a pile of hay. We had one neighbor who was a commander and my mother went to see him and he came and showed that he was the boss (zurush kard)—he was good with us. When he used to go to Kulob he would leave his Gharmi wife with us. He would say, come on Robia, we will give you to my brother [marry her to his brother] but then they gave [married] me to kin of my mother so that this would not happen.

The mother she mentioned in this interview saved the lives not only of her children but of many other people, but never did she portray herself as a hero. She also helped the neighbor's

wife who was a categorical enemy (*Gharmi*) of her husband (a *Kulobi*), who despite the war situation maintained a good relationship with the group he was fighting against.

Young women of marriageable age during the civil war were particularly at risk, and therefore hidden from soldiers. In the passage above, the mother who went to the neighbor for help appears to be vulnerable (going to ask for help is considered as acknowledging weakness by women), and it is the commander who demonstrates strength. However, I became well acquainted with the family over the course of a year and it was the mother who was the *heroine* in such situations. For example, she made contact across enemy lines, took care of the commander's wife, managed her children as *Gharmi* in the middle of the strongest enemies, the *Kulobi*, went back to their house to get their documents although this was deadly dangerous, brought her children to safe places in the mountains crossing countless checkpoints (many of them known as death points), and she saved other people's lives when she pretended they were relatives as they passed *Gharmi* military posts. None of the stories she or her daughter narrated portrayed her as heroine but rather as a victim of circumstance, of war, of difficulties. The interview reinforced the position of women as being vulnerable through the narrative of difficult situations. In such cases, the interview, which is considered the most popular method in social science and development work (as a tool of analysis, problem identification, and evaluation) has limited capacity to move beyond the representation of women as vulnerable and as victims of circumstance, of men, and of politics. Such representations are problematic as they conceal the agency of women and become established as the master narrative in the region: the woman needs to be saved, by external actors, from circumstances, from men, from religious influences, and from traditions.

When I traveled to the Gharm region in the early 2000s, it had changed considerably over the past decade. New Islamic concepts had marginalized the role of brothers and emphasized the

nuclear family under the protection of the husband. This form of religious family has been rapidly developing, particularly in urban centers. While many young married women enjoy this form of family in the beginning because of the mutual love involved and the possibility to distance one's self from the mother-in-law's grip, it leaves them with no protection or support from their own brothers when problems, such as divorce or illness, emerge.

THE INTIMACY OF WOMEN'S LIVES IN WRITTEN DOCUMENTS

So far, I have described theater plays and interview as two forms or sources of how women present their lives in society. In the following, I present another source of narration of Tajik women: *diaries and letters*. Although it is not an exception that women write poetry or diaries, relatively few written sources of rural women in Tajikistan have been presented. The purpose of writing diaries and letters is intellectual joy, gathering information, working through emotion, and most importantly, communicating among girls and young women. Such journals are full of pictures (cut out from journals or photographs), love declarations, drawings, and poetry. Such writings give women a voice, and as such, they are important because they open another dimension of self-presentation that engages with personal experiences and public discourses. It is true that today the mobile phone has replaced many former practices. However, these documents provide evidence of self-reflective behavior by women who do not see themselves simply as victims of a patriarchal system but as social actors who seek to establish themselves as respected members of society. Along with the loss of a dual lineage system and an increase in neo-Islamic societal ideas, these forms of female expression are now less common. On the one hand, women increasingly participate in public sectors including

journalism and academia; on the other hand, education as a form of personal development has lost its status in its former form, making space for new forms of knowledge such as about Islam. This section, however, focuses on writings of the 1990s and early 2000s. The young women who shared their writings with me acknowledged that the mobile phone has led them to write less, as much can now be shared in one phone call.

The passage below is taken from a young woman living in a village far up the mountains in the Rasht Valley, whose husband left for Russia. She had married despite wishing to study because her father did not have the financial means. She and her three sisters loved their parents and felt deep respect for the father, who was the one who took care of the family. When she married, she was hoping to establish a family following the rules of Islam, and (as much as possible) to be independent of her in-laws. I knew her before she married and when she was still giving lessons in Islam to girls in the neighborhood. She was a practicing Muslim and planned to have a family in which Islam would be the moral code and basis for mutual respect. Once she had married, she would forego her education and stay at home while she encouraged her husband to study, since a good family needed an educated person, either the husband or the wife. She and her husband had agreed that she would eventually continue her education, yet the promise was never fulfilled as he left for Russia to work. After falling sick and complaining about being separated for so long, she joined her husband, but after two years in Russia, she returned and moved to the capital city of Dushanbe where she lives with their three sons, while her husband continues to work in Russia. The passage demonstrates the way she perceives her relationship with her husband as a love relationship and the suffering that separation brings, although she was married to him without ever having met him prior to the marriage:

*The letter that you hold in your hands is the
one whose body hurts, whose full body laments,*

who . . . And this is my first and last letter. I would like to recall the first days of our joint life, the day when you thought you were the most happy person on earth just because you were with me. And I thought you were for me the closest person, closer than father or mother and my sisters. My luck did not last long, after three months you left and it seems you took everything with you. After you left, I became a different person, I did not eat and did not laugh anymore, and I have never found calm, either day or night. I waited patiently but no news came from you, although you had promised to be back after three months. I thought you would die without me, suffering just as much as I suffered from the separation and that you would yearn to come back. But you did not keep your promise, you did not come back . . .

Oh . . . how much I suffered without you, so much that my tongue no longer works. In this way I gave birth to an unwanted child. So many times when my soul was full of pain and I suffered, I took memories of you and tried to get help from you, but it was as if you had become a foreigner . . . I had hoped you would be with us that day and my eyes were turning towards the street. Again with a broken heart and hope for your coming, I waited, that you would come and celebrate with us, bring gifts for the child and for me.

(Note: The letter was never sent but remained in her diary.)

The diary entries reveal an emotional world of love and affection and the difficulties of suffering when exposed to one's in-laws without the husband. Many young women believe that a husband protects his wife from the aggression of her in-laws, although this is hardly ever the case. Women project love into their relationships with their husbands, a love that becomes idealized when he is in Russia. In discussions, the women would recall stories of suffering at the hands of their mothers-in-law, and thus would refer to the same mode of representations as discussed above. In the diary, however, the women unfold their personal relationships to their husbands, a subject

that is not part of the public discourse. A wife is not expected to show her love, although she can describe her suffering without restriction. Love and affection are part of the intimacy of family, as are humiliation and beatings by the husband.

Thus, to emphasize, the interviews, which I discussed previously, often revolve around the mother-in-law and the husband's brothers, with little information presented about the husband himself. Furthermore, the subject of the *maskhara*, also noted previously, focuses on what can be discussed in public and is often the subject of long, sad, and humorous storytelling. The mother-in-law relationship is a public relationship, while the husband-wife relationship is an intimate one.

In turn, the Tajik letters and diaries reflect the poetic way of expressing suffering which rests on Persian poetic tradition and motives in which loved ones are torn apart by force or circumstances. For example, one Tajik woman alludes to the idea that the pain of separation is reciprocal and leads to death, whereas joy is expressed with flowers of life, as she writes in a letter: "*You killed me. I had in my heart a hundred hopes and wishes, me who from the flowerbed of desire have not picked anything yet.*" Although "love" is never a subject in public gatherings because it is a personal experience, it is a dimension of Tajik society which I witnessed. For example, during my fieldwork, we would read love letters that the young women in the household received, usually containing a poem, in the evening (without the parents knowing about them) and would discuss the attributes of the author, the lover. I assisted young women meeting their lovers secretly and accompanied them to inquire about a young man with the local fortune teller (Roche 2012). Thus, the diary entry represents not an exception nor a rule or pattern, but rather the choice of interpreting one's life in notions of romantic love. It exists along with the public's (tyrannical) image of a mother-in-law and the emotional attachment to parents (*mehr*).

LETTERS AMONG SISTERS

Whereas the diary uncovered poetic forms of love and suffering taken from Persian culture, the next texts are letters that sisters wrote to each other. This form of communication among women creates solidarity and strength and care among siblings. The authors often complained that they did not have a brother who would defend them. Brothers are crucial to sisters in difficult situations, and when the father can no longer assume the task of caring for his daughters. The letter uncovers a quite formal relationship with the in-laws, in contrast to the emotional connection to the native family. The husband holds the key position in mediating between his wife and his relatives, and consequently, his absence is perceived as leaving his wife in the midst of a "foreign" system of exploitation. In this double lineage system, the nuclear family becomes the only connection between two families who compete for the offspring of this couple. The absence of one parent is hence felt as a tragedy even where the relationship among the in-laws is good.

Dear sister, because I cannot come myself I send you this letter, the mother-in-law is ill, you know what this means. Oh God, while I write my tears are flowing, I told myself that I will come to your house and insult them all. But what shall I do, don't be angry, control yourself. Continue to respect your mother-in-law, don't be sad about her threats to get you divorced [...] don't fall ill from thinking about who is an enemy and who is a friend. Do something so that all say: a thousand thanks. In the village there is a lot of talking and gossiping. Just because of this, show politeness and that you have been well educated, don't take out the sword.

(Note: Letter written to sister shortly after her marriage.)

This is part of a letter that the eldest sister wrote to her younger sister, the author of the diary above. It begins with sharing tears but then gets to the point of providing advice of how to deal

with the situation. She advises her sister to be patient and to control her behavior to impress her surrounding community. She suggests not to react and fight back, but rather to talk to the husband when he returns. The advice of conforming to expectations as long as the husband cannot interfere shows that women are well aware about possibilities and constraints, choices and their agency. What is at play here is the status of the sister, of her husband and her children, and the possibility of engaging with the husband's family in a formal way. The intention of the eldest sister to come for a visit reflects her position in the absence of a brother who would take care of the sister. What this letter uncovers is the painful process of learning how to deal with a situation by exploring the options and possibilities. Common events such as threats of divorce or actual divorce are not answered with specific cultural patterns or behavior, but different strategies are found for how best to cope with such situations. Each situation is taken as a new experience and new event that requires its own specific solution.

CONCLUDING COMMENTS

The end of the Soviet Union has led to considerable change for the societies that had lived under this system, and in Tajikistan, a civil war in the early 1990s accelerated this change. In those political changes that deeply affect such societies, women often have come to play a central conceptual role. Similarly, in Tajikistan, post-civil war society used gender as a way to establish order in society (Roche 2012: 302–305; Tadjbakhsh 1994), which was characterized by violence against women (Sharipova 2008). However, conservative gender roles clashed with the reality of life in which men were not able to perform as the only breadwinner in most families. Many women came to be seen as responsible for a stable society if they conformed to conservative gender roles, but in reality they had to close the countless gaps that had shaken society, including financial

care for children who had lost their fathers. Women now manage households in the absence of migrant husbands, supervise the education of girls and boys, as well as look after the fields and animals and participate in the collective duties of the village. Furthermore, I have seen many young men who outlined the rules of behavior for their future wives in a very narrow way, but once they had married, the most basic everyday task such as fetching water from the well forced them to review their radical concept of the “perfect” wife. While controlling and shaping their wives according to their imagination continues to take much of the husband’s efforts, the reality of life and its difficulties force them to compromise their narrow views.

Violence has marked the post-civil war Tajik generation, and Tajikistan has only begun to recover from the civil war’s effects, most of which remain unchanged, un-researched, and undiscussed. Nevertheless, the country is already slipping into a political system that celebrates mothers as “mothers of the nation” but does little to reduce poverty and the hardship of women more generally; rather it has imposed its version of culture and history onto the population. In this version, mothers act as a cultural fetish of the nation. There are still competing representations of women, as in the 1990s and early 2000s, and these will continue as long as radical versions appear as the only solution.

In this chapter, I have utilized my extensive prior fieldwork research experience in Tajikistan to examine various representations of women and how *methodological approaches* define expressions and interpretations of women’s lives. The interview, being the most popular, least time-consuming empirical method, has dominated research and has often promoted a picture of women as victims, endangered, and suppressed. Consequently, the public narratives appear justified in saving women from these difficulties. The use of diaries, letters, and participant observation shows that the interview is the most passive form of self-representation in which

women, consciously or unconsciously, construct themselves as enduring circumstances. Many ethnographers working in Central Asia with Muslim women living in rural areas have experienced the reluctance of women to say anything about society “*because I don’t know, you should ask an expert,*” who is by rule a man. Hence, we not only need to question the interview as the primary mode of data collection, which is also the fastest and hence most economical, but to take into consideration the consequences this method has and how women often come to be collectively classified as vulnerable in academic and developmental documents. The conclusion from such studies is that women need to be saved, whether through religious concepts, or human rights and development programs, or governmental nationalistic discourse. These discourses all consider patriarchy as factual and as a mode and pattern in society to be challenged, fought against, or defended. They ignore certain cultural practices, such as dual lineage, that allowed women to move between two family complexes and demand rights via their brothers and fathers, as well as from their maternal uncles. The failure to recognize such cultural practices can be attributed, in part, to the influence of Western concepts and of male ethnographers whose research has concentrated on male views of society. Indeed, even when international organizations tour through Tajikistan, most depend on male translators who adapt women’s responses. During my own extensive fieldwork in Tajikistan, women told me that they well understood that the translator was changing their words and meaning but could do nothing, as the foreigners seemed to fully trust their translators.

Other methods—such as the study of primary material from women including diaries, letters, or poetry, or long-term ethnographic fieldwork (meaning specifically living among people for several months and experiencing life alongside the women)—as well as a solid knowledge of the society’s political history, encourage us to explore

the lifeworld of women. Women experience and try to resolve the tension between ideal imagined gender rules and roles (advocated by religious activists, state actors, or international organizations) and the reality of life and the experiences they encounter on a daily basis. In order to understand how women move the world, we have to look at the way they move the cradle. Women remain central to conceptual discussions of political regimes even if their voices are represented by men. But it is in practical solutions that they matter, whether they save their family in times of war, care for the children and elderly in times of economic hardship, claim the care and attention of their kin, or claim religious positions.

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Chapter thirty

Tradition, Islam, and the State International Organizations and the Prevention of Violence against Women in Tajikistan

Lucia Direnberger

Violence against women in Tajikistan increased during the Tajik Civil War of 1992–1997 (Haarr 2007; Harris 2004; Kuvatova 2001; Sharipova and Katalin 2010; Tadjbakhsh 1994), which included former Soviet forces against the United Tajik Opposition composed of Islamic and democratic forces (Dudoignon and Jahangiri 1994). In this context, international organizations, whose activities focused on women's issues, became crucial actors in the reshaping of norms and practices related to violence against women, domestic violence, and the broader arena of women's rights. On October 26, 1993, the Tajik government signed and ratified the international Convention on the Eradication of all Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW). This commitment to CEDAW, as well as to other international conventions and declarations on women's issues, was interpreted as a way for the Tajik Republic to demonstrate its good intentions and openness toward international organizations (Sharipova and Katalin 2010: 151). However, implementing international norms and practices on the elimination or prevention of violence against women requires more than just recognizing international conventions. After the civil war, international organizations started funding programs aimed at

eliminating and preventing violence against women through various means, such as knowledge dissemination, support for legal reforms, and awareness campaigns. Since then, both international organizations' reports and public discourses have underlined the high rate of violence against Tajik women and the need to eliminate and prevent it.

In this chapter, I examine how international organizations produce knowledge about violence against women in Tajikistan through their definitions of the causes of such violence, including definitions of gender, tradition, culture, and Islam. I also analyze relationships between international organizations and government actors, religious leaders, the political opposition, and the women's movement in the policy-making arena as they seek to address the causes of violence against women and ways to eliminate such violence, whether referred to as "violence against women," "domestic violence," or "gender-based violence." In this chapter, I use the term "violence against women" to encompass all three.

Furthermore, the process through which gender, tradition, culture, and Islam are defined and intertwined reveals power relations within

international organizations, but also between international organizations and the state, the women's movement, and the political opposition. This chapter is based on an extensive review of reports and training materials produced by international organizations, as well as 40 semi-structured interviews conducted in Tajik, in French, and in English between 2012 and 2015 with Tajik and non-Tajik gender experts involved in international organizations and programs and with members of the civil society working on the prevention of violence against women. Most of these non-Tajik experts were from European and North American countries, and all the gender experts from these countries did have prior knowledge of Central Asia. Other non-Tajik gender experts were from Turkey, Iran, Caucasus, India, and Pakistan. To maintain confidentiality, in this chapter I am not providing the names of interviewees and organizations, nor the exact date and location of the interviews. All gender experts were very concerned about confidentiality because they were affiliated with international organizations at the time of the interviews, and they did not want to jeopardize their professional careers. Tajik gender experts, in turn, were doubly vulnerable because of the increasing authoritarian practices of the ruling regime during this period.

This chapter is organized in two sections. In the *first section*, I analyze how organizations use definitions of traditions and of Islam in their activities related to violence against women programs, and how these definitions shape their perspectives and production of knowledge. In the *second section*, I examine how some gender experts in international organizations in Tajikistan have restricted the use of references to Islam and to culture so as to avoid competing with government interpretations and to avoid challenging the ruling regime. As a consequence, partnerships between Tajik women's rights activists and international organizations have remained limited in the context of increased authoritarian practices of the government.

THE POLITICAL USES OF "TRADITION": PRODUCTION OF KNOWLEDGE ABOUT VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN IN TAJIKISTAN

Soviet Legacy and International Organizations

With the beginning of the Soviet era in Tajikistan, violent acts against women were officially reported by the Soviet regime only when perpetrators were identified as opponents of the regime. For example, during the *hujum* (de-veiling) campaign (1927–1929), murders of unveiled women perpetrated by men identified as *Basmachi*, opponents of the Soviet regime, were officially reported by state representatives, the press, and academia in Central Asia (Harris 2004; Kamp 2006; Northrop 2004). While these murders were used by Soviet propaganda to illustrate the backwardness of Central Asian societies, the Soviet justice system failed to condemn these murderers and perpetrators of other violent acts against women (Keller 1998). Under the Soviet regime, violence against women was overlooked when perpetrated by people not identified as enemies of the regime (Harris 2004: 46). In my own research, some women who experienced violence during the Soviet period explained that they did not know where to file a complaint. Others reported that, in the last 20 years of the Soviet regime, state structures would only intervene when made aware of a violent act perpetrated against a woman by an opponent of the regime.

As a part of the USSR, the Soviet Socialist Republic of Tajikistan considered women's liberation as a priority (Aminova 1985; Harris 2004; Nabieva 1986; Tadjbakhsh 1994). The state enjoyed a monopoly over the definition of "women's issues" and over the scope of its interventions, and state actors and researchers emphasized the issue of women's oppression. While the agency of Tajik women was highlighted

by academic research published by Tajik women in Tajikistan, it was mostly invisible in the Russian Soviet knowledge production structured along racial power lines: that is, a white (Russian) center and a non-white (Tajik and Central Asian) margin. Russian Soviet studies reported experiences of women's oppression mainly as characterized by limited participation in education, economic activities, and the public space, and by polygamy and the wearing of the veil. Those studies insisted on the backwardness of rural areas described as religious and traditional places where women were more oppressed than in the cities. Research on women's oppression evolved during the Soviet period, partly due to the increased participation of Tajik women in research institutions and to political changes in the Soviet regime during the 1940s. While inequality between women and men in the political and economic center of the USSR was considered as a solved issue, Soviet researchers were still identifying it as a challenge to be addressed in Tajikistan (Direnberger 2014b).

The collapse of the USSR brought change in the gender arena, including gender-related international organizations that established a presence in Tajikistan. As such, most of the women identified as local partners by these international organizations had worked or been involved in Soviet structures and/or in post-Soviet structures. Some were employed in structures in charge of women and family affairs at the national level while others were researchers working on women's issues in Tajikistan and Central Asia. They were the first Tajik partners involved in international agendas on the prevention of violence against women, and therefore they were invited to join the "Fourth World Conference on Women: Action for Equality, Development and Peace" in Beijing in 1995. In Tajikistan, they published the Russian and Tajik translations of the United Nations Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW), ratified in 1993 by the Tajik government, and they also convened seminars and a

post-Beijing conference entitled "Women in Our Contemporary Times" to speak about violence against women and CEDAW. During my research in Tajikistan, one of the women who participated in these activities indicated that these were the first public debates on violence against women in Tajikistan. As she recalled, during the Soviet era they worked on women's issues such as women's education and women's work, and they engaged in seminars, the production of reports and leaflets, and the publication of press materials. In contrast, their work with women changed drastically during the post-Soviet era with the introduction of "violence against women" into the scope of their activities. As such, a taboo had been broken as the facts concealed under the Soviet regime spread into the public sphere to be discussed by women. She also argued that the conference of international organizations and women's non-governmental organizations (NGOs) in Beijing provided women with a diversified understanding of the various forms of violence against women: physical, psychological, and sexual. For her, violence against women stemmed from the fact that women had limited knowledge of their rights, as Islam and traditions deprived them of education. In other interviews, women NGO leaders also argued that urban women, who are more educated, suffer less from male violence than rural women, who are less educated. As a consequence, these women leaders in the post-Soviet era created new spaces where they could speak about and condemn violence against women and provide a Tajik translation of the terminology used within international organizations.

Producing Data, Creating Traditions

International organizations in Tajikistan increased their activities pertaining to the elimination and/or prevention of violence against women after the

civil war (1992–1997). The United Nations and its agencies were already involved in such activities, and other international organizations officially endorsed the recommendations of the International Conference on Population and Development (Cairo, 1994) and the Fourth Conference on Women (Beijing, 1995) to address the issue of violence against women (Jutta 2007). In 1996, the Forty-Ninth World Health Assembly recognized that violence, especially against women and children, had become a worldwide public health problem and urged its member states to assess the issue of violence. This new international agenda had a specific impact on Tajikistan as the country was selected by the World Health Organization (WHO) to conduct a pilot survey on violence against women (WHO 2000).

As a result, the WHO conducted the first survey on violence against women in Tajikistan in the late 1990s (WHO 2000). This survey was launched with the support of two other international organizations and implemented by an NGO led by a Tajik woman. It focused on the different forms of male violence against women, the identification of perpetrators, and the spaces where violence against women takes place. Furthermore, violence and the causes of violence based on the perceptions of women were identified as follows: “a great degree of tradition,” “low status of women,” “lack of education,” “economic difficulties,” “disintegration of the family,” and “cultural changes” (WHO 2000: 25). *However, response options reveal a major definitional bias in that the report does not indicate how the word “tradition” is defined and understood by the interviewees.* Apparently, the survey assumed that the meaning of “tradition” does not need to be defined and that all people share the same understanding of the meaning of “tradition” regardless of their gender, social class, ethnicity, and age.

Specifically, the WHO survey asked female interviewees “their opinion regarding the causes of violence.” In total, 56 percent of the interviewees indicated that, “to a great degree,” tradition is the cause of such violence, while an additional

31 indicated that “it often contributes to violence” for a total of 87 percent. Furthermore, 86 percent of the respondents attributed such violence to “the low status of women in society,” 77 percent noted “lack of education,” and 93 percent noted “economic difficulties” as contributing factors. As such, the WHO study concluded that “tradition is singled out as the major cause of violence” while “disintegration of the family and cultural changes have been perceived as determining factors in the spread of violence” (WHO 2000: 25). However, in coming to this conclusion, it is quite striking that the WHO study *did not consider* the economic factor where 93 percent of the interviewees identified “economic difficulties” as causing violence, compared to 87 percent of the interviewees who identified “tradition” as an underlying factor and thereby the WHO experts sought solely to emphasize “tradition” as causing violence.

Indeed, during my own research, some Tajik women explained violence against women in a way that did not fit into this WHO pre-defined scheme. For example, since the end of the civil war, these women have been involved in women’s groups of the Khatlon region, one of the economically poorest areas in the country but also one of the most affected by armed conflicts. As one woman stated:

Just after the Civil War, families didn’t let their girls go to school. They didn’t let their girls go outside of home. They were so afraid of the sexual assaults that women suffered during the civil war. There were so many rapes, by militia, by the regular army, by all armed males. And nobody spoke about that, even during the peace-building and state-building process. So we decided to go door-to-door and speak with parents and to say that it was important that their girls go back to school.

These respondents identified the “regular army” (not only the militia, as mentioned in the report) as a perpetrator of violence. They also blamed

the stakeholders in the peace-building and state-building processes, the political opposition, and the international organizations for their silence and sustained unresponsiveness.

Furthermore, one of the Tajik key partners in the WHO survey, who had a scientific background from the Soviet period, suggested another way to analyze the causes of violence against women. During the civil war, she was involved in a group opposing the former Soviet forces and fighting to end the conflict and to set up democratic institutions in Tajikistan. She left Tajikistan during the war and became familiar with the NGO system abroad. When she returned to Tajikistan after the peace agreement, she officially registered an NGO with the intent of conducting a survey on the areas affected by the civil war and thus contribute to the peace-building process. She was hoping to have an impact at two different levels. At the international level, she wanted to draw the attention of the international community to the women in Tajikistan and in Central Asia. At the national and local level, she intended to support the elimination of violence against women by encouraging the organizing of “ordinary women” in order to break the existing silence on violence against women in the public sphere and to fight against the political system and the conservatives that perpetuate women’s subordination and contribute to the persistence of violence against women.

Embedding Traditions and Islam

The recruitment of gender experts working in Tajikistan shifted in nature at the beginning of the 2000s. While Tajik gender experts were involved in the first survey on violence against women, many subsequent programs were conceived by foreign experts. There are two major explanations for this shift. First, the end of the armed conflict made it easier for people unfamiliar with the Tajik “field” to blend in. Second, the

number of programs aimed at preventing violence against women increased considerably. For instance, in 2001, the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (OSCE) expressed its deep concerns about the spread of violence against women through the voice of Gerard Stoudmann, the ambassador and director of the OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights (ODIHR) when he commented that: “Violence against women as such already justifies the intervention of the OSCE as it is a serious human rights violation” in Central Asia. He concluded by saying that “addressing violence against women fits very well into the philosophy of this organization and serves our long-term objective of ensuring strong civil society and stability” (OSCE 2001).

For many gender experts employed by violence against women reduction programs, social trends such as “back to tradition” and “Islamization” justify the intervention of international organizations. As a European gender expert heading the gender office of an international organization commented during an interview:

Violence against women wouldn’t even be raised here without the international organizations activities. When you see the return to tradition and the Islamization of the society and the weakness of the civil society, how would you expect another situation?

The international sphere appears as the gatekeeper of this issue in the public space in Tajikistan, whereas local spaces are seen as “weak” or as obstacles to the prevention of violence against women. Thus, the international sphere refers to conventions, rights and the application of rights, data and research, “gender philosophy,” and mobilization, while local spaces are associated with notions of weakness, tradition, or religious practices harmful to women.

Another European gender expert who was hired on a short-term contract by a United Nations agency to work on a gender program in the late

2000s explained the low level of school attendance among girls:

It is more a return to tradition. For example, the importance of puberty as an obstacle to the schooling of girls. Once girls reach puberty, parents don't let them go out. They are afraid of gossip and fear for their family's honor . . . Economic factors also matter. Girls have to help their mothers at home. But when you see the increased number of veiled women in the streets in Dushanbe, you understand that traditions are more and more important in the Tajik society. And polygamy also increases the violence against women.

This interviewee identified the increased number of women wearing veils as a sign of the “Islamization” of Tajik society and drew attention to tradition and religion as the most important explanatory factors for violence against women.

Likewise, some *non*-Tajik gender experts consider the “Islamization process” (and more generally religion) as a major factor of discrimination, inequalities, and violence against women. As Amjad (2009: 160) comments: “Religion condones most of the discriminatory practices against women, promoting control over women’s social life, women’s confinement in homes and their obligation to do house work.” In her analysis, Amjad combines religion and tradition; however, she does not distinguish between the two in terms of their consequences for women. Furthermore, some experts also use Islam to homogenize and essentialize Muslim societies. For example, a European gender expert in Dushanbe, who worked for five years on the prevention of violence against women, noted:

We have to adapt [our activities] depending on the contexts. For instance, we also find a Muslim version of the Duluth wheel . . . A researcher made the adaptation of the Duluth Wheel to Islamism . . . based on a lot of interviews. The researcher succeeded in creating the wheel with typical characteristics of the Muslim society. In our

society, for example, there is not the same threat with the Bible but there is a threat here.

However, this interpretation of Islam hides all the historical, economic, political, and social diversity existing within Muslim states and Muslim societies. Instead, this type of analysis makes violence against women as something specific to Muslim societies.

Similarly, violence against women is mainly presented as a regional issue by international gender experts and comparisons are only made with other neighboring countries (Afghanistan and other Central Asian countries). During informal exchanges with some Tajik gender experts, I spoke about the state of violence against women in France (a country of which I am a citizen), about the obstacles to the elimination of violence against women, and about the fact that violence against women is perpetrated by men from all social classes and races. Most of them expressed their deep surprise with comments, such as “*it can still happen in Europe?*” and “*I really didn’t know that it was still such an issue in France.*” Indeed, one of them commented that “*it is because there are a lot of Muslims in France.*” These reactions show how the racialization of sexism (Durand and Kréfa 2008; Hamel 2005) impacts the perspectives of Tajik gender experts working with international organizations.

Although referring to Islam and tradition by gender experts working in international organizations aims to convey an in-depth understanding of the local contexts, it actually produces homogenization and essentialization of the Tajik society. This is similar to the Soviet legacy on the narratives on Islam and traditions related to the gender order. As such, Tajikistan is branded by tradition, Islam, and women’s oppression, whereas in direct contrast, international organizations are branded as representing human rights and as being the main (or only) actors in the progress of women’s rights in the region. This construction of “the suffering Muslim woman” (Eisenstein 2004) also legitimates humanitarian and military

interventions in the region (Abirafeh 2009; Abu-Lughod 2013; Daulatzai 2006; Eisenstein 2004; Mahmood 2008).

MAKING A DISTINCTION BETWEEN “TRADITION” AND “ISLAM” AND PROMOTING CULTURE AS A TOOL FOR THE PREVENTION OF VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN

Interpretations of Islam: Local and Diverse

Since the beginning of the 2000s, some Tajik gender experts have argued that there are three main reasons why Islam can be a useful tool in the prevention of violence against women. *First*, since the late 1990s, some international organizations described the importance of Islam and of garnering “the support of religious leaders in . . . explaining Islamic gender principles and the role of women in the family” and of “involving the top level religious leadership in collaboration with government bodies . . .” (see WHO 2000: 34). Likewise, Tajik gender experts increasingly engaged with religious leaders and gained a better knowledge of Islamic laws and interpretations.

Second, some Tajik women’s NGOs dedicated to the prevention of violence against women and funded by international organizations have developed strategies to use Islam as a tool and a source of legitimacy and support for the prevention of violence against women; and in so doing, they have mobilized religious leaders in the mediation processes in cases of domestic conflicts. In turn, some international organizations provided funding and technical support to these activities and thus became familiar with the use of Islam as a tool for the prevention of violence against women. As part of their activities, these women’s NGOs selected verses from the Quran

and *hadiths* to show that Islamic teachings forbid violence against women. Whereas some international experts saw this collaboration as a sign of Islamization in Tajikistan, others considered it as a strategy to combat impunity for perpetrators of violent acts and as an effort to find and share reformist religious interpretations (Direnberger 2014a).

Third, some studies conducted by Tajik gender researchers have recently focused on the role of women in Shia and Sunni Islam. For example, in an interview with a social science researcher in Dushanbe, the researcher commented:

In the Shia traditions, women have more protection. The image of the daughter of prophet Mohamed in Shia is important. She was some kind of model, she was very respected. From that perspective, women benefit from some kind of respect . . . you know . . . and as a mother . . . Fatima was not only the daughter of the Prophet, she was also the wife of Ali, who took over after the death of prophet Mohamed. The Shia tradition goes through Ali and its descendants. As a wife, as a mother of Imam Hussein and Hassan . . . So as a daughter, as a wife, as mother, through these three images, women, Shia women, have a lot of power.”

Because of the lack of funding in public research institutions, some of these researchers acquired positions as gender experts in international organizations in Tajikistan. While contributing to gender expertise, they developed arguments in favor of Islam as a mechanism to prevent violence against women. Indeed, such new practices and narratives on gender and Islam within international organizations have contributed to the emergence of an approach describing Islam as a tool for the prevention of violence against women. As one gender expert commented:

Islam . . . is a religion that gives most . . . a lot of power to women, a lot of power. But the majority of our men do misinterpretations . . . Quran is interpreted as if men could beat their wives if they

don't obey . . . Quran says that you [a husband] can punish your wife when she does something wrong and makes you unhappy but the word punishment is understood wrongly. Punishing is beating and killing or just telling her she didn't do the right thing? It is the second point.

This approach to the relationship between Islam and the prevention of violence against women allows new forms of partnerships. In 2000, an NGO, which was working on maintaining the dialogue between religious and democratic forces on the one hand and the government on the other, published a booklet entitled *Mas'uliyati mard dar buniyodi binoi oila az nigohi islom* [*Men's responsibilities in the foundation of the family from the perspective of Islam*]. This document forbids forced marriage. It explains that Islam does not allow violence against women within the family and that Islam promotes family well-being and harmonious relations between men and women in the household. Religious representatives contributed to the publication of this booklet which was funded by UN Women.

This approach takes into account different interpretations of Islam and religious practices. As such, gender experts have started collaboration with religious leaders belonging to reformist branches of Islam. As one Tajik gender expert stated:

I always say that there are two kinds of religious representatives. Those who are really conservative and those who are not and work with the women resource centre. We are learning from those. For example, when the women resource centre deals with projects on domestic violence prevention, these mullahs fully understand and they provide interpretations of Quran and hadiths to support the project. Domestic violence is forbidden by Islam. Mullahs say to the parents who don't forbid but are indifferent to girls' education: "Quran says that girls' education is a necessity and it is even more important than for boys." In many cases, parents change their mind. In this context, the women

resource centre allows girls to continue their study until the end of high school at least.

Such initiatives benefit from long-term support from international organizations. The booklet on men's responsibilities, referred to above, has been extensively circulated to all UN Women partners in Tajikistan for more than 15 years. This dissemination process has gone beyond the national intervention level as Tajik experts have also promoted the booklet at the international level. For example, one of the Tajik experts surveyed explained that this initiative was presented during an international workshop organized in India by UN Women, with representatives from different organizations and countries of the region. According to this Tajik expert, participants expressed a very deep interest in this activity, as it provides a more comprehensive tool that takes into account the local context as well as the reality and diversity of religious practices.

These types of initiatives and activities shed light on the diversity of religious interpretations in Tajikistan, and as such, they challenge the homogeneous and static approach to Islam. They make it possible for international organizations to better understand the local religious interpretations by Tajik religious leaders who condemn violence against women.

Framing Practices and Collaborations, Restricting Activities

In some Muslim countries, the use of Islam as a tool to prevent violence against women is restricted in terms of collaborations and activities, as male religious leaders are involved in this process, but female religious leaders are excluded. However, in Tajikistan as well as elsewhere in Central Asia, religious leadership is not restricted to men. Some women—called *bibikhalifas*, *bibiotuns*, or *otins*—take on active roles and perform religious ceremonies and teach Islam to young

girls. They played a crucial role in the transmission of Islam during the Soviet era (Fathi 2004), and they continue today. Whereas in the Khatlon region, for example, women NGOs do not consider *bibiotuns* as allies in the prevention of violence against women, in contrast, in the Khujand region, some *bibikhalifas* do seem to be involved in advocacy work on women's rights led by women's NGOs. Some Tajik gender experts have attempted to involve *bibikhalifas* in international programs, but most often they could not convince project managers to fund such partnerships because the project managers did not consider female religious leaders as important stakeholders in Tajikistan. Nonetheless, in a very few cases, some *bibikhalifas* have been involved in gender programs as a "target group." As a Tajik leader of a women's NGOs in Dushanbe commented:

The international organization proposed a programme to promote women's leadership. I thought we could educate these otins because they have an important role in the mahallas [community structures associated with local neighborhood councils]. They provide advice to the community. People trust them. I gathered some of them. The international organization didn't know they had religious power. But I had problems, the government put the pressure on the project, and the IO [international organization] involved finally understood what was going on. We had twelve months of funding but we had a lot of problems with the local authorities that didn't want to give more importance to bibiotuns. The programme was stopped by the authorities and the IO [international organization] decided not to renew this initiative.

While partnerships between religious *men* and international organizations are promoted by the government, collective meetings with religious *women* and trainings organized for them by international organizations are perceived as a threat by local government structures. Nonetheless, some international organizations have initiated a

partnership with women involved in the promotion of Islam as a pillar of human and women's rights. For example, women from the Islamic Renaissance Party of Tajikistan (IRPT) were very much involved in their party (Direnberger 2017) but also in the peace-building and state-building partnership programs led by these international organizations. These women were identified and promoted as key stakeholders in the 2000s, and some attended a workshop on female political leadership in Tajikistan, as well as international meetings abroad. They were also invited to official policy dialogue meetings on violence against women at the national and international levels.

During one of these meetings held in Dushanbe at the beginning of 2010, these women raised the issue of low representation and low participation of national women's organizations in the policy-making process pertaining to Tajik women's rights, and they asked for increased support in favor of the inclusion of Tajik women in policy-making. They also questioned the translation of the international agenda into the Tajik context and the lack of consideration for local demands. In addition, they denounced the fact that the language of communication during these meetings was Russian, which should not be considered as a local language and excludes Tajik women, especially young Tajik women educated after the collapse of the USSR. According to these women, violence against women is not related to Islam. Instead, they emphasized the importance of existing economic inequalities between women and men and the negative impacts of traditions. Furthermore, they emphasized that the ineffectiveness of policies against violence against women can be attributed to the low level of women's participation in political and government institutions.

When included in the initiatives of international organizations, the women from the IRPT experienced discrimination in the recruitment or collaboration processes. Wearing a *hijab* and being a member or sympathizer of the IRPT were clearly depicted as causes of marginalization by the women I interviewed. When these

women faced increased threats and harassment because of their political engagement as members of the IRPT, international organizations provided no substantial support except for a mere reference to such violence in their official reports. In October 2015, the IRPT was banned by the Tajik government and one of its female leaders was arrested. According to different media sources, she was raped and tortured during her detention. The silence of international organizations involved in gender and/or women's issues in Tajikistan revealed the limits of the use of Islam in the prevention of violence against women. Quite notably, violence against opposition women (i.e., IRPT women) was not considered to be violence against women.

“Respect for Women is our Culture!”

On December 2, 2015, UN Women convened about 60 Tajik youth, representing a diversity of ethnicity and religion, to participate in discussions about the key messages of the “16 Days of Activism against Gender Violence” campaign. (These activities were part of the much larger “16 Days” global campaign that originated in 1991 to counter gender-based violence.) Some of these young people were volunteers from UN Women or from other UN agencies. Others, including young women and men between 15 and 25 years old, were members of the association, “Builders of Motherland” [*Sozandagoni Vatan*], supported by the Republic of Tajikistan Committee for Youth Affairs, Sports, and Tourism. During this workshop, some of the participants said that family was the most important element in society and that everything had to be done to protect the family's welfare. According to them, violence against women affects the stability of the family and should not be tolerated. They also emphasized that Tajik culture and “ancient traditions” never tolerated violence against women and that women had always been respected in the Tajik

culture. This narrative is consistent with the efforts of the Tajik government, which has intensified its emphasis on the celebration of “the mother” based on ancient Tajik traditions (Direnberger 2014a).

During the 16 Days of Activism against Gender Violence campaign, notions of culture, tradition, and Islam were intertwined and were used to give visibility to localized beliefs and groups that opposed or resisted the campaign against gender-based violence. It also entailed a major shift for the international organizations, as these organizations no longer viewed culture, tradition, and Islam as specific obstacles (Direnberger 2017).

Nonetheless, some significant differences do exist between “Western” and Tajik perspectives and approaches to gender issues, and international organizations need to demonstrate cultural awareness and sensitivity in devising policies and projects to address issues such as gender equality and gender-based violence. As one Tajik gender expert involved in the 16 Days of Activism against Gender Violence campaign commented:

How to bring society to understand women's role and what do you mean by equality? And how do we empower women in a very culturally sensitive way? We should not say “women will decide over men what to do,” we have to be very careful when bringing up this issue. In the Western countries, it's different. Here, in our countries, it's different. We have to be very careful when we talk about, you know, empowering women and making them equal to men. Don't make it visible. Don't make it loud.

CONCLUSION

In seeking to combat long-standing gender-based violence in Tajikistan and to support women's rights, some international gender experts and some Tajik gender experts working in international organizations have viewed tradition and

Islam as obstacles. In contrast, other gender experts have been challenging this view and have used Islam, tradition, and culture as tools in their efforts to counter and prevent violence against women, based on the assumption that the prevention of violence against women and Islam and/or Tajik culture are not incompatible.

On this basis, some Tajik and international gender experts have diversified their partnerships with religious leaders and government institutions in order to utilize Islam and culture in the prevention of violence against women. At the same time, in the context of the “war against terrorism,” international organizations have faced a complex situation restricting the use of Islam and culture so as to avoid competing with government interpretations and to avoid challenging the ruling regime. As a result, relationships between international organizations and some Tajik women’s rights groups have remained limited due to the increased authoritarian practices by the government. Tajik women religious leaders and women political leaders from the opposition forces, for example, have been excluded from active involvement in women’s issues. The exclusion of these women, in turn, sustains the belief that Tajikistan needs gender experts trained and promoted by international organizations and legitimizes their intervention in the name of women’s right.

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Chapter thirty-one

Rural Women's Encounters with Economic Development in Kyrgyzstan

Deborah Dergousoff

Rural women in Kyrgyzstan confront a very difficult economic environment. This chapter focuses on relations and challenges pertaining to the “work” rural women do to foster “development” in their communities. In examining such issues, I rely primarily on research that I had conducted in Kyrgyzstan as well as my experiences and observations while living and teaching there. My fieldwork in rural Kyrgyzstan was initiated in collaboration with Gulnara Baimambetova, Chair of the Women Entrepreneurs Support Association (WESA), as part of a research project for which we hoped to secure funding to investigate opportunities for the efficient delivery of informal adult education in diverse rural regions. My research suggests that women entrepreneurs constitute an element that is central to the struggle to improve the well-being of families and communities in rural regions of Kyrgyzstan. It also suggests particular complexities in development-related social relations and in issues pertaining especially to agricultural work.

Development programing can be understood as a complex interplay of conflicted and interested goals, means, and agencies, but also as the process and outcome of a complex of consciously directed actions pursued by diversely located actors and agencies. Utilizing a feminist political economy perspective, I examined the potential to improve rural women's income-generating

activities in the context of the broader capitalist market. The overall objective of my research was to understand how initiatives developed by international non-governmental organizations (NGOs) organize processes of “development” in rural regions of Kyrgyzstan. To develop a fuller understanding, I applied institutional ethnography to examine the processes through which training programs aimed at improving the well-being of women were organized and established at local sites in Kyrgyzstan. Institutional ethnography is a method of inquiry for investigating social processes that coordinate the work done by actual people in local sites to meet the requirements and specifications of institutional practices and professional discourses developed elsewhere (Smith 2005). My main focus was on how rural women's lives become entangled in the broader process of development practices in Kyrgyzstan.

THE RESEARCH CONTEXT

Kyrgyzstan became a sovereign state in December 1990 and officially declared political independence from the Soviet Union in August 1991. After independence, Kyrgyzstan was the first Central Asian country to commit to market reforms and to the agenda of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and until 2013, was the

only such country to meet the requirements for membership in the World Trade Organization (WTO). Kyrgyzstan's "transition" to a market economy has been fraught with a number of challenges: limited access to economic resources and information; administrative barriers, including corruption, at various levels; ineffective use of export capacity; issues with investment climate; extensive presence of informal economy; delayed progress in reforming systems of technical regulation; and inadequate financial support for businesses (Dergousoff 2014; Umurzakov et al. 2014).

In turn, major international influences in Kyrgyzstan's transformation to a market economy include: Russia, with whom Kyrgyzstan has continued to maintain close ties and on whom it remains economically dependent; China, Turkey, and Kazakhstan as important trading partners; and Europe and the U.S. as important investors. Because powerful international influences tend to be primarily concerned with economic development, political and institutional reforms have not kept up with economic reforms in the country. Thus, there are few stable and reliable systems in place to sustain an emerging economy or to support social welfare programs (Cummings 2012; Pomfret 2004). It is estimated that 38 percent of Kyrgyzstan's population of 5.8 million live below the poverty line, and of those, 66 percent live in rural regions (IMF 2014). All regions of the country rely heavily on migrant labor remittances (Isabaeva 2011; Schmidt and Sagynbekova 2008) and on foreign donors and international NGOs whose programs and agendas are developed for the most part outside of local control (Hemment 2000; Kuehnast and Nechemias 2004a).

Given that large numbers of both women and men live in poverty in Kyrgyzstan, poverty rates in rural areas appear to be more closely related to area of residence than to gender. As noted by the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO 2016), rural women's status was improved by the law "On Agricultural Land Management," passed in 2006, which

enabled women to obtain, register, and inherit land shares. However, the problem is that while legal barriers to women's rights to property ownership may have been removed, cultural and traditional barriers continue to persist in practice. The implications, in combination with gender-blind agricultural reforms, are that rural women are prevented from receiving many of the benefits of either land redistribution or agricultural reform. This is significant given that over 35 percent of all working women and 30 percent of all working men are employed in agriculture. Further, of all agricultural workers, the percentage of women workers increased from 40 percent to 44.5 percent between 2012 and 2014. This may be due, in part, to high levels of male labor migration ("remittances account for 31 percent of the country's GDP" [FAO 2016: 7]) that leave females behind to take on roles and duties typically performed by men doing agricultural work, though some women also migrate either from rural areas to urban areas or to neighboring countries, particularly the Russian Federation and Kazakhstan (FAO 2016).

Recent research conducted by the FAO (2016) found that women constitute a minority among farm managers and farming entrepreneurs. The majority of farms in Kyrgyzstan are small family-owned enterprises, 75 percent of which are considered "peasant farms." Women working on peasant farms are more often categorized as self-employed rather than as entrepreneurs. Further, self-employment income tends to be less stable, and neither self-employed women nor women entrepreneurs have access to social benefits such as pensions, sick leave, or maternity leave. Women also tend to be primarily employed by family members (77 percent) from whom many receive no payment at all for agricultural work. Overall, Kyrgyz women are relatively well educated, but they are disadvantaged when it comes to access to information about "agricultural technologies" and "marketing of agricultural products." This disadvantage is at least partly due to the traditional and cultural segregation of occupations

whereby women are less likely to be encouraged to engage in agriculture-related vocational training. For example, during the 2014–2015 academic year, women accounted for fewer than 20 percent of the students, in secondary vocational institutions, specializing in agricultural studies (FAO 2016: 40). Indeed, vocational training overall appears to be less available to women living in rural areas, and therefore, many of their skills are learned informally from family members. Women are socialized to prioritize domestic responsibilities, and thus many “spend a greater proportion of their time on unpaid domestic work than in employment” (FAO 2016: 30). Nevertheless, some women do supplement family incomes with entrepreneurial activities such as handicrafts and community-based tourism.

FIELDWORK

WESA’s Gulnara Baimambetova and her staff have spent years working with partners from international aid and development organizations to design training courses that provide locally adapted instruction to assist Kyrgyz women with starting and operating small-scale social enterprises in baking, curtain design, needlework, and hair-styling, as well as fruit, vegetable, and milk processing and customer service for restaurants and cafes, to name a few. WESA’s courses, available to beginner and experienced entrepreneurs of all ages, have been especially valuable for middle-aged and older women living in remote agricultural areas where few economic opportunities exist.

In addition to numerous meetings at the WESA headquarters my fieldwork included a visit to Jerge-Tal, a remote village in the mountainous region of Naryn, where my research assistant and I accompanied the WESA team to observe a set of training programs. We later made two additional visits to Jerge-Tal, independent of WESA, and a visit to the Osh region and to Kara Balta where we met with a WESA expert and her

colleagues. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with current and former WESA women trainees, WESA trainers and consultants, educators and youth in the school system, as well as individuals who had not had access to training programs in their region, local authorities, and representatives of international NGOs. The women agricultural workers (WESA trainees), who were a central focus of my research, ranged in age from 20 to 50 years, with the majority in the range of 30 to 40 years of age. All interviews were tape recorded, translated, and transcribed. The rationale for using a range of interviews was to develop a deeper understanding of the work of WESA and of Kyrgyz women entrepreneurs.

In addition to interviews, I used historical accounts, participant observation, and ethnographic field notes to produce a narrative account primarily focused on the “everyday” in order to account as much as possible for the “lived world” that I was observing. I also kept a daily journal that included field observations beyond interview contexts (i.e., conversations with village hosts, taxi drivers, and so forth); conversations with colleagues about daily life occurrences; and observations based on interactions with my students while I was teaching at the American University of Central Asia in Bishkek. During my first visit to Kyrgyzstan in 2010–2011, ordinary events such as following a map, going to the bank, getting my visa extended, and shopping at the bazaar drew me into complex relations and processes that I did not fully understand. I also came to realize that the day-to-day lives of NGO workers and women entrepreneurs in rural Kyrgyzstan were somehow connected to these relations and processes in ways I needed to comprehend more fully. It was striking to observe how quickly “development” was progressing when I returned to teach in Kyrgyzstan in 2014–2015: most notably, how banking had been adapted to accommodate new technologies and that Bishkek Park, a multilevel shopping mall with a skating rink at its center, had been built to accommodate corporate name brands and other high-end stores. In short,

during the course of my extended activities in Kyrgyzstan, I developed an enhanced understanding of how people living in different circumstances, with different perspectives or interests, are drawn into a common set of institutional relations and processes that come to organize the “work” that they do and their understanding of how to conceptualize their “work.” Indeed, as I discuss in the following section, work has been an integral part of the culture of Kyrgyzstan and is integrally related to the issue of Kyrgyz women and to entrepreneurship.

THE SOCIAL ORGANIZATION OF “WORK” IN KYRGYZSTAN

Cultural Attitudes toward Work

My ethnographic research in Kyrgyzstan included the examination of *work* as something that people both *do* and *talk about*. In this sense, I found that linguistic clues could provide important insights into how Kyrgyz people make sense of the concept of “work.” For example, in this excerpt from an interview with a potato farmer in Naryn region, the farmer stated:

We know each other, and among us there are such people who are lazy, drink alcohol, or other problems. We are all “ishterman” (hard worker men) . . . my people should be “ishtemchil” (hard, good worker) and become wealthy . . . You should be “ishterman”!!! Otherwise you can’t achieve.

de la Croix (2014: 82), in her study of frames for valuing labor in rural Kyrgyzstan, suggests that there are “layers of meaning” behind Kyrgyz words associated with “work.” For instance, “A cluster of words define ‘work’ in Kyrgyz: the word *ish* (work) is both a noun and a verb . . . Someone who is *ishterman* is industrious or diligent, while an *ishmer* is an active person, a master of his craft.” de la Croix found that while her

respondents did not always agree about what constituted work as a category, or on the nature and value of work, they all felt that the purpose of the work they did was to serve a particular group of other people. While work was considered to be “an activity carried out for the benefit of people one *belongs* to” (de la Croix 2014: 79), this did not extend to working for money for someone else in the village. “Kyrgyz people prefer control over their work”; to perform manual labor for others is felt to be akin to *kulduk* (slavery) and will impact negatively upon one’s social standing in the community (de la Croix 2014: 94). Kinship patronage, migrant labor, and formal wage contracts are all perceived as performing services for wealthier people and, therefore, sometimes fall under the category of *kulduk* (de la Croix 2014).

Sovietization of Work

The legacy of change introduced during the Soviet era is also an important context for understanding how Kyrgyz people perceive and talk about “work” and “employment.” During the Soviet era, a program of full labor force participation was imposed to eliminate “all types of economic independence based on private ownership, including independent agriculture,” thereby resulting in people becoming “dependent on the state” (Tokhtakhodjaeva 1995: 103). As such, there were particular implications for Central Asian women, who were identified early on as the primary vehicle for accomplishing social transformation in the region (Massell 1974). Central Asian women’s entry into the labor force in the Soviet era was a state-mandated obligation—not a choice—and thus was variously perceived as coercion and as an opening of possibilities by the women involved. Soviet policies, such as childcare and maternity leave, were instituted ostensibly to facilitate gender equality in access to the workplace. However, some would argue that, in practice, those policies were really more

concerned with the need for women's labor than with an ideological commitment to equality itself. Work was understood to be wage labor for the state and was glorified by the state as the means toward creating a befitting *homo sovieticus*. Employment was a constitutionally protected "right" and relatively inexpensive food, housing, and services were considered an entitlement from the state in contrast to something that could be "claimed." Yet, accessing entitlements was often a matter of having "connections," bribes, or bartering, and was "frequently mediated through personal connections" (de la Croix 2014; Verdery 1996).

Despite Sovietization, many tasks remained as the domain of Kyrgyz women, and the household division of labor was never fundamentally transformed by state socialism (Gal and Kligman 2000). Especially for village women, work did not provide "economic independence" and therefore they were "materially dependent upon men" and could not "demand their rights" (Tokhtakhodjaeva 1995: 93). Women did, however, reach educational levels equal to or higher than men and also constituted "a substantial percentage of the professional class of physicians, lawyers, engineers, and scientific workers. Workforce participation rates for women were the highest in the world, with 90 percent of working-age women either on the job . . . or attending school" (Kuehnast and Nechemias 2004b: 4). Equality may not have been achieved in the Soviet system, but women had been provided with generous maternity leave, extended leave to care for sick children, shorter working hours, and the opportunity to work part-time at any point in their career without loss of pension or other entitlements.

Following independence, Kyrgyzstan confronted massive economic hardships that impacted Kyrgyz women—rural and urban, and low-skilled and highly-educated—as they experienced a drastic decline in the state social welfare support system. For example, state-funded day-care centers declined by 75 percent between 1990 and 1994. Yet, the role of women has remained

prominent in the "development" of contemporary Kyrgyzstan.

Women and NGO Work

Various training programs for Kyrgyz women entrepreneurs have been instituted in the post-Soviet era. Such training programs are part of a strategy developed by Western gender specialists concerned with how to address the problem of women's social and economic marginalization. As such, they are tied into an international development programming complex wherein concerns with women's well-being are articulated through *institutional processes* that produce definitions of gender (and of poverty), establish gender-sensitive training programs and policies, and assess effective implementation and compliance with institutional requirements. The processes through which Kyrgyz women become entitled to request support for their work and to receive aid draws them into institutional accountability circuits. To begin with, the "work" in question must be "eligible" for support (e.g., microfinance, training, resources), and to be eligible, it must be "officially classifiable" as "work" (Bhatt 2013). The process of becoming officially classifiable draws rural women into an institutional apparatus that operates according to a set of managerial practices that are external to their local setting, but practices that women must comply with in order to receive support. Indeed, development programs and agencies import managerial practices into local work processes so that officially classifiable terms like "gender mainstreaming," "humanitarian aid," and "adult education" can be made "measurable" and "accountable" to assure that the goals of the development agency are being met. Yet, the problem with such officially classifiable terms is that they do not adequately represent the social and economic realities that Kyrgyz women, at the local level, experience in their daily lives.

THE TRANSITION TO CAPITALIST MARKET ECONOMY: CHALLENGES AND OBSTACLES

In the Central Asian region, feudal modes of production were prevalent until their transformation was brought about by Sovietization, a process in which producers maintained some means of subsistence but were forced into a dependent relationship with the state. In the case of agriculture, farm production was divided into units called *brigades* that were further subdivided into specialized farms with their own farm leaders and technical experts. Chemical and seed inputs were centrally arranged and provided, and veterinarians, breeding experts, and accountants were employed so there was no need for laborers to concern themselves with learning all aspects of farming. As a consequence, when agricultural production shifted from the Soviet system to individual ownership in post-Soviet Kyrgyzstan in the 1990s, farmers were ill-prepared with the skills and knowledge to manage their own farms.

To develop this notion more fully, it is useful to focus on one of the key participants in my research, Erke Podkuiko, a farmer and WESA expert, who had been providing training programs for women entrepreneurs since 2003. Erke received university training in agriculture during the Soviet era and was able to reflect on the practical difficulties women confronted in the shift from collective to individual farming. First, women experienced gaps in practical knowledge about the very basics of how to plant, apply fertilizer and pesticides, as well as the timing and duration of watering. It was also difficult for farmers to access information about what varieties of seeds to grow or how to obtain them, as was also the case for women who had previously procured seeds grown on the collective farms for use in their home gardens. They were unfamiliar with how to calculate how many hectares of any given crop they would need to plant in order to pay

expenses and earn a profit, or where to sell their harvest, or how to negotiate for better prices. Indeed, even if all this information had been available, there might not have been enough money in the village to buy seeds. Microcredits were available, but women were required to organize into groups to take advantage of them, and they were unfamiliar with the procedures for such organizing. To organize into groups, they were required to have a market, and this, in turn, required access to other information and to business relationships that they did not have. Obtaining credit also required funds to pay bribes. Even when groups did organize and became profitable, issues of trust led to problems with dividing the profits. Furthermore, Kyrgyz rural women confronted the need to learn how to save funds for the future so that they would have money necessary to buy seeds for the following spring planting season.

Important knowledge gaps also existed regarding the kinds of documentation the post-Soviet agricultural system required, especially with respect to land redistribution and taxation. Even though Kyrgyz families were given land rights, they were required to register their property with local authorities. Further, although both women and men had been given ownership of land, women have been particularly disadvantaged. Specifically, when women marry and leave their families they lose ownership of their land, and they are not allowed ownership of land in their new husband's family. In turn, in divorce proceedings, husbands are often able to bribe the courts to deny women their rights to ownership even though they are technically entitled to a portion of their husband's property, especially if they have children. Inheritance issues also impact women, as when women are unfamiliar with the legal requirements for registering their husband's property in their own name upon the husband's death. Further, for those people who had never registered their property, problems arise when attempting to transfer parental property to their children.

In addition to establishing property rights, registration of property allows the municipality to collect land taxes. Kyrgyz farmers are entitled to a “release” from land taxes in the event of significant crop loss due to weather conditions, but to obtain a release, they need to initiate a claim. Many women farmers either do not know that they are entitled to a release, do not understand the documentary processes involved, or do not have the adequate math skills required to make the necessary calculations on the required forms. Erke described her frustrations with teaching simple math skills:

We teach them in class, they sit and listen, but when they come home they forget everything. They do not know how to count. For example, wheat costs 3 soms, from one hectare will be 3 tons, thus 9000 soms. But Kyrgyz people cannot count—no matter what you teach them they themselves do not count, thus bankruptcy again and again.

It is not that the women are illiterate. Rather, as noted earlier, during the Soviet era (as now), women reached educational levels equal to or higher than men. However, agricultural work in the Soviet era was highly differentiated so there was no need for farm laborers to know how to apply math calculations to understand how to make their productive work profitable.

Today, bureaucratic and documentary processes require payment, but farmers often do not have accurate information about how much it will cost or where to go to activate various documentary processes. As one of the WESA participants remarked:

We cannot get information from local authorities, and local authority, aksakals, cannot give us information and knowledge because there are new means, new chemical goods that aksakals do not know about.

When they attempt to do so they may be sent to several different bureaucracies, each one involving

a small fee, before they are able to complete the process. This is problematic for farmers, not only in terms of costs, but also in terms of wasted time, as one woman farmer commented:

Now about 12-15 farming families organized a group, so we are working with Erke eje . . . We refer to eje regarding issues that we do not understand . . . Mostly farmers work in the fields. They have no time to figure out how to work with documents. So leaders of the group come to Erke eje for a consultation. Then that leader comes back and explains it all to them. For a whole group to come, they have no time to do that, especially during summer time.

In post-Soviet Kyrgyzstan, agricultural production is subject to local and global price fluctuations. To succeed, farmers must have specialized knowledge and skills, including how to access and comply with documentary processes associated with new production standards. When products do not meet the standards, they are less profitable. To produce high quality products, farmers need access to information, skills, resources, and funding. Because these are seldom adequately available, much of what is produced ultimately is substandard, and substandard products are sold at low prices at the bazaar or by street vendors, rather than in the more lucrative export markets. Agricultural production is also a highly time-sensitive activity that is subject to environmental factors such as drought, hail, and pest infestations. As Erke explained, sound agricultural techniques involve understanding the entire cycle: what, when, and how to plant; when and how to water, fertilize, and apply pesticides; and when and how to harvest. To emphasize the urgency of timing, she cited the Kyrgyz proverb, “*jazdin bir kyny – bir jilga da*,” which translates to “one day in spring is equal to a whole year.”

Indeed, Erke is quite knowledgeable about regional variations and about important differences between remote rural regions and those closer to larger urban centers. She knows that the

varieties of tomato that grow successfully in Issyk-Kul or Chui region where she lives will not grow in the mountainous Naryn region, and she also knows how to find a variety that will produce in Naryn. She is knowledgeable about markets and regional variations related to them. She knows that export production works well in Issyk-Kul, and where farmers can get the best price for their tomatoes in Chui region. Erke knows that cows in Chui region produce five liters of milk, whereas in Naryn they produce only three liters. This knowledge is important because her work with WESA involves working with resources that are already available in the village. In Chui region, for example, factory production is a rational strategy given good yields and proximity to Bishkek, whereas it would be ill-advised to establish a milk-producing factory in Naryn where cows produce less, transportation costs are prohibitive, and climatic conditions would force operations to close for most of the winter. Thus, rural women find attending Erke's seminars beneficial, as this WESA participant remarked:

Our income has increased (smiles). If you fulfill everything according to Erke's directions, the harvest increases. Of course if your harvest increases, so does your income. That is why we try not to miss seminars. If someone is not able to attend, then other members try to come to visit. Then we teach each other what and how to do things.

As a female farmer and WESA expert, Erke has firsthand knowledge about the realities of farming and how these realities impact Kyrgyz women's lives. She understands that time, scheduling, and transportation can be impediments to women's participation in training courses. She is aware that disjointed training programs cannot provide the comprehensive set of skills and knowledge required for successful agricultural production. Indeed, she maintains that training related to farming can be more effective by training *families*,

rather than groups of women. Daily realities are such that women are not able to come to work if their families need them at home for various caregiving activities. Agricultural training programs teach women how to plant, but women still need men to plough. Families work cooperatively in agricultural production, and there is always someone in charge who will delegate tasks and complete the required work. Further, for families, there are also fewer problems when dividing profits. Thus, the potential benefits that one *family* can receive from training can far outweigh the benefits if divided among ten different households.

CONCLUDING COMMENTS

The central issue that emerged during my research in Kyrgyzstan was the question of why, despite over a decade of international aid and development work, so little seemed to be improving in the economic condition of rural women and the communities in which they live. What was happening in development work such that relatively little positive change was occurring?

Transforming how people value and understand the concept of "work" entails understanding how they activate and produce the material conditions of their lives. It is evident that some NGO trainers understand the concept of "work" very differently from others with whom they are tasked with training how to "work" effectively within processes of "development." Such trainers take for granted the knowledge and skills that are necessary to meet the NGO's required standards, such as filling out applications and performing mathematical calculations, because the trainers take these tasks for granted in their own work practices where written forms/documents of reporting are required. However, in contrast, rural women, for whom these development programs are designed, understand their own work in terms of very different processes and relations.

Local individuals and groups, such as WESA, are able to gain important insights from observing

day-to-day activities and by consulting with women farmers and with each other about their observations. Ultimately, the key issue or problem is that while local experts may have their own theories, expertise, and ideas about what needs to be done in the field, their work processes most often are organized by, and accountable to, outside interests that fund their work. This results in disjuncture between their understanding of what needs to be done, how ideally they would like to go about getting things done, and what in the end actually gets done.

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Chapter thirty-two

Women as Change Agents Gender in Post-Soviet Central Asia

Rano Turaeva

INTRODUCTION

The collapse of the Soviet Union in 1990 had a drastic effect on the former Soviet republics of Central Asia resulting in turmoil in the region and bringing about major political, economic, and social transformations. Further, the path taken by the post-Soviet Central Asian republics (except Kazakhstan) led to the deterioration of the existing infrastructure and industrial production, which resulted in the loss of jobs and economic deficiency and the failure to provide basic daily necessities for the citizenry. Some scholars of the post-Soviet transition have referred to this change as “de-development” or “de-modernization” which is characterized by the erosion of development. The same observations could also be heard from female residents of the region, many of whom marked the collapse of the Soviet Union as the beginning of going backwards; or as many women would say: “after Soviet Union broke we went back to the stone age” (Meurs and Ranasinghe 2003). Indeed, various scholars have studied the phenomenon of de-development in Central Asia and the Caucasus as well as in other post-Soviet settings (Bridger 1987; Bridger and Pine 1998; Burawoy and Verdery 1998; Creed and Wedel 1997; Ishkanian 2000, 2003).

In the years immediately following the collapse of the Soviet Union, economic crises impacted

most of the Central Asian economies, bringing uncertainty, insecurity, and disorder at all levels of society such as labor markets, local governance, and family and kinship networks. As one consequence, since the early 1990s until now millions of Uzbeks, Kyrgyz, and Tajiks have been migrating to Russia in search of employment. Indeed, even the economic crisis in Russia has not stopped migrants from Central Asia from seeking work in Russia. In contrast, Kazakhs and Turkmen have *not* migrated in masses. Rather, Kazakhstan became another destination for migrants from Central Asia, and Turkmenistan attempted to keep its citizens from migrating by providing the minimum basics and by paying comparatively higher salaries than in most other Central Asian countries. Nonetheless, hundreds of thousands of Turkmen have migrated to Turkey for work or education, and increasing numbers of women from Turkmenistan have gone into small-scale trade between the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Turkey, and Turkmenistan.

Globalization processes have been influencing and changing cultures, traditional structures, norms, and beliefs throughout the world and these processes have provided new opportunities for both men and women in Central Asia. Religious belonging, strict gender roles, and tradition have not prevented Central Asian women, particularly female entrepreneurs, from taking advantage of

the opportunities created by globalization, the opening of borders, and increased mobility. Rather, these elements and the economic hardships of the post-Soviet transition have provided incentives for creativity and innovation among economic entrepreneurs. Both men and women became mobile entrepreneurs with the goal to “*find money*.” As a Turkmen woman entrepreneur, who was a member of a four-women group trading between Tashauz (Turkmenistan) and Dubai (UAE), lamented during a research interview which I conducted in Uzbekistan: “*It became difficult to find money/to earn money, so we all became mobile and are on the move, on the road [in a negative tone], both men and women . . . men are in Russia and women are in Dubai.*” Indeed, Central Asian women have long been innovative and adaptive. Even starting from the 1970s and 1980s, as some Central Asian women recounted, small-scale traders and other entrepreneurs were mainly women. Yet, the economic hardships of the post-Soviet period impacted Central Asian women particularly harshly, and this has led to changing norms and roles of women within families, kinship structures, and local governance systems such as *mahalla* committees and neighborhood meetings.

Until recently, researchers have not systematically studied the *agency of women in Central Asia*, and the literature on women predominantly underestimates the agency and role of women in marriage, life cycle events, family economics, and other activities related to local communities such as neighborhoods and *mahallas*. *Mahalla* (mainly in Uzbekistan) is the name for a neighborhood unit which has its own office, neighborhood committee, *zhensovet*, police officer, and an identification card officer.

Clearly, the situation of women—within the social and political space—in Central Asia is quite complex. Indeed, these women continue to face basic structural constraints and challenges in their everyday lives. Therefore, when analyzing the position of women in Central Asia, it is important to contextualize those barriers, opportunity

systems, and women’s agency. Most certainly, the higher levels of state administration and political/business elite in Central Asia have remained predominantly male. Furthermore, individuals and families who possess power and economic capital have not necessarily had to send their family members to Russia in search of employment. As such, it is clear that the division between the wealthy and the poor did become more extreme during the economic crisis that followed the collapse of the Soviet Union. Nonetheless, a significant question remains as to what are the changing gender roles in the post-Soviet era where more and more Central Asian women have assumed leading roles in the economic lives of their families.

In this chapter, I focus mainly on middle-class and working-class women in Central Asia. In doing so, *first*, I provide an overview of the situation of women during the Soviet era, so as to provide historical background; I then focus on Central Asian women in the post-Soviet period. *Second*, I present case studies of women in Central Asia so as to cast light on some of the unique situations and social relations that women navigate. *Third*, I discuss two other elements related to the lives of Central Asian women as well as women’s agency and decision-making.

SECTION ONE: CENTRAL ASIAN WOMEN DURING THE SOVIET PERIOD AND DURING THE POST-SOVIET PERIOD

Gender and Change During the Soviet Period

The Soviet system had direct implications for social life as it focused on modernity (*sovremenost*). The type of modernity promoted by Soviets, in turn, emphasized education, loyalty to the Soviet state and its ideals, gender equality,

and an active fight against traditionalism (*pere-jitki*) in different aspects of life. Further, the most important element in the liberation of women from traditional power structures of patronage and kinship was the establishment of a strong welfare system on which citizens could rely in order to become independent from their kinship and to pursue independent lives, even though the welfare system did not fully replace the traditional loyalties and status system within kinship and patronage systems. The major achievements of welfare policies during the early Soviet rule were the empowerment of women both in the family and in the broader society through introducing family and child welfare policies, together with educational training and other related programs. Especially in Central Asia, the largest advancements were made by unveiling Muslim women, providing them with access to education (with literacy rates increasing to 99 percent), and training them to enter the labor force. These policies were intended to foster a decisive break from the old system of family relations and to create a “Soviet family.”

The two parallel developments of urbanization and industrialization, which were implemented throughout the Soviet Union, influenced family patterns and life styles of most Soviet citizens. These processes were coupled with the development of the infrastructure: building roads and gas pipelines and providing electricity that reached even remote rural areas. The establishment of the Soviet social security system was another major social welfare achievement, and trades unions, in turn, provided benefits for those who were in the labor force, including those temporarily disabled by illness or forced to pause because of pregnancy and maternity. Furthermore, trade unions provided funds for organized holidays, children's summer camps, and housing provision.

The large-scale reforms introduced by the Soviet government, and particularly programs that fostered the empowerment of women, marked the beginning of change in gender relations and of gender equality in Central Asia

(Lubin 1981; Massell 2015). Although Soviet efforts to achieve gender equality were not fully successful, the Soviets were effective in bringing women out of their homes, unveiling them from the *paranji* (traditional Central Asian clothing that covered the woman's head and body), and educating and providing women with jobs. The process was not easy, and these efforts developed extensively in the 1950s and 1960s. Indeed, women born during Soviet rule in the early 1950s were supported and encouraged to continue their education, and a considerable number of Central Asian women became highly educated. Women who lived in small villages could travel to the larger cities or capital cities throughout the Soviet Union to obtain free higher education with state financial support. After graduation, the state system of redistribution dispersed graduates according to the Soviet system of state quotas all over the Soviet Union which further interfered with traditional family structures and values in Central Asia. This marked a major change as women were transformed from *paranji* wearing housewives to students, working women, and members of the political party in Central Asia.

One of the remarkable achievements of Soviet Union policies to liberate Muslim women in Central Asia was the creation of *zhensovet* (women's council), an institution which was responsible for addressing women's issues. *Zhensovet* sought to engage women both politically and economically, through literacy campaigns and later through economic empowerment and social engagement at the community level, and to promote and support women as leaders. Indeed, *zhensovet*, which was initially created during Soviet rule to promote the equality of women, was ever-present in every state agency that was responsible for issues of women working, studying, or involved in a given organization. The process of “liberation of women” during the Soviet era has been critically discussed by many scholars (Akiner 1997; Ishkanian 2003). Although tradition and long-standing gender expectations were not totally eliminated during the Soviet period, the

Soviets did substantially improve the lives of Central Asian women through education, career promotion, and status advancement.

Gender and Change during the Post-Soviet Period

After 70 years of the continuous liberation of women under the Soviet Union, the post-Soviet period is seen by many women as a period of turning backwards. During my fieldwork in Central Asia, women made various comparisons such as the following:

The Soviets took us out from Stone age (kamenniy vek/ literally stone age) where we drove in donkey carriages and could not leave the four walls of dark houses built from mud. The Soviets unveiled us and took us out to schools, gave us cars, roads, houses with lights and heating, provided secure jobs and holidays. And now [in the post-Soviet era] we are back in the Stone Age to our donkey carriages, put the scarves on and sit in dark and cold homes hungry.

Indeed, during the post-Soviet period, increasing numbers of families have become more traditional as the traditional authorities have gained more power, salaries have been reduced, electricity and water shortages have become more common, holidays are no longer paid by the state or by employers as during Soviet times, and schooling has become quite expensive in terms of school clothing, materials, books, food, and transportation. Consequently, many people do not send their children to school but rather send them to work in the bazaar. This backward change, from women's perspectives has also had direct implications for the change in gender roles and gender perception within local communities.

One might expect that this turn "backwards" described by women would automatically lead to the return to patriarchal rule and male domination in the everyday lives of these women.

However, the situation in Central Asia is more complicated than that. When one asks about who is now a decision-maker and whether men are now the only decision-makers, the answers are *not* a simple "yes," given that post-Soviet economic hardships are felt not only by women but also by men. As to authority and decision-making power, women in my research indicated that "*now money decides who is the boss and what needs to be done.*" With both women and men earning money to support the family, this implies equal chances for both men and women to become a decision-maker or at least participate on equal terms not only within the private sphere of the family but also publicly. Therefore, these opportunities or hardships have forced and/or provided incentives for women to become more innovative economically and to take the initiative to earn money (Welter and Smallbone 2008).

In the context of Soviet modernity and post-Soviet traditionalism in Central Asia, some people criticize those who have become "too modern" or "too Russified" because they perceive modernity as being linked to the culture of Russians (*russ-lashgan*/Russianized) which is now seen as something foreign and alien. Nonetheless, this modernity is accepted both by critics and also by those who actively enjoy it (for instance, women described in the "snapshots" in Section Two of this chapter). Further, one would expect that the younger generation and those who enjoy the benefits of modernity (including modern clothing, non-traditional ways of life, education, gender equality) would raise their children based on those modern standards. However, in some instances, these parents, who have benefited from that modernity, try to make their children adhere to traditional rules, value systems, gender roles, and traditional views on life choices including choice of marital partner and profession. Ultimately, given this mixture of modernity and post-Soviet traditionalism, it appears that in many cases, education only serves as a status symbol for women since most of the educated women are forced to give up their professions and to stay

at home. Indeed, some women even question: “*why did they let me study and then don’t let me work?*”

Furthermore, whereas the institution of *zhensovet* was initially created during the Soviet period to promote equality of women, in the early 1990s (i.e., the early years of the post-Soviet period), *zhensovet*, particularly in universities, was transformed into a network to control women, mainly monitoring the behavior of female university students instead of addressing larger gender inequality issues. Furthermore, in other contexts, the *zhensovet* controls the funds to be allocated for programs targeting women, and thus non-governmental organization (NGO) leaders (the majority of whom are women) are usually at the whim of *zhensovet* leaders. This influence on the distribution of funds is a powerful tool for those with authority and monopoly over funding for the NGO sector.

At the level of local government administration, *zhensovet* plays a crucial role in the advancement of control over the female population particularly in authoritarian governments such as Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, and Tajikistan. *Zhensovet* can be found within the *mahalla* committees in Uzbekistan, and in other countries they are integrated into local government administration systems. *Zhensovet*s, as a Soviet creation, initially advanced the liberation of women and advocated gender equality by providing education and jobs, and by creating childcare systems, as well as encouraging the active participation of women in all spheres of Soviet society. In the post-Soviet period, *zhensovet*s have continued to exist and to serve the state in whatever ideology or agenda that the state has proposed related to women and families. This is not necessarily the liberation of women or empowerment of women, but rather the introduction of restrictions on women’s rights and freedoms in relation to family roles, childcare, and mobility.

Although the predominance of women entrepreneurs selling goods in the markets is not a novel development in post-Soviet Central Asia,

the number of women involved in trade and other economic activities has drastically increased where even teachers and educated women have had to leave their state employment in order to earn “*real money*.” As such, female entrepreneurship in Central Asia still has not been adequately researched even though this form of employment is dominated by women rather than men. Certainly, there is a substantial pool of works on the feminization of labor in Central Asia and around the world (Akiner 1997; Bruno 1997; Buckley 1981, 1989, 1997; Ilin and Ilin 1996; Kuehnast and Nechemias 2004; Malyuchenko 2015; Mupedziwa and Gumbo 2001; Özcan 2006, 2010; Tantiwiranond 2004; Welter et al. 2006), and Werner 2003, for example, studied small-scale trade in rural Kazakhstan and skillfully demonstrated the change in the role and status of women traders who became family breadwinners as a result of their economic activities. Kandiyoti (2000), in turn, traced the “feminization of unskilled agricultural labor” in Uzbekistan, and there also are several studies of the participation of rural women in agricultural labor and the changing gender roles in Uzbekistan (Alimdjanova 2009; Gunchinmaa et al. 2011; Kandiyoti 2003). However, female entrepreneurship remains an understudied topic that is important to the understanding of the everyday economic mosaic of contemporary Central Asia and of the lives of Central Asian women.

Finally, whereas Central Asia is a Muslim-dominated region where scholars have observed some people returning to Islam after 70 years of Soviet-promoted atheism, female entrepreneurship in these Muslim societies, in turn, is a challenging endeavor where women must navigate between tradition and modernity. During my research in Central Asia, the return to religion was perceived by most women as a turn backwards. Yet, for some, it can be a source of income. Peshkova (2015: 26), for example, cites an *otincha* (female religious educator) in Ferghana Valley who stated that many of the religious educators (*otinchalar*) “turned religious knowledge into business” by receiving compensation in the form

of money or other material objects for their religious performance in related events. Furthermore, the parallel existence and interaction between tradition and modernity in the context of Muslim societies has been examined in some insightful studies particularly focusing on women in Central Asia (Fathi 2006; Ishkanian 2003; Kamp 2005; Kandiyoti 2007; Kandiyoti and Azimova 2004; Tadjbakhsh 1998; Werner 2003), and Akiner 1997 has studied how women navigate between modernity and tradition in Uzbekistan, while Fathi (2006) has written about religious teachers and healers, including *otinoy*s and their role in the religious education of Uzbek women.

SECTION TWO: CASE STUDIES AND “SNAPSHOTS” OF WOMEN IN CENTRAL ASIA

In this section, I utilize my previous research in Central Asia to provide case studies or “stories” of women’s lives in different Central Asian countries. These stories provide a view of some portions of the life histories of a small number of individual social actors in various contexts. The case studies are not intended to be representative of all Central Asian women, but rather to provide “snapshots” of some of the issues and constraints that Central Asian women face and of some of the ways these women cope with and negotiate various aspects of their lives. In conveying these women’s stories, I use pseudonyms rather than their actual names.

Turkmen Trader

Meral is a young trader of silk fabrics (a local term *tulqi*) which are imported from South Korea and Dubai. From the very young age of 15, she joined her mother in the early 1990s, selling goods her mother imported in the *bay bazar* in Tashauz, Turkmenistan. She has a younger

brother who also became involved in the family business. The family lived in their grandparents’ house in a very traditional neighborhood where most of their relatives also lived. Meral’s house was located in an area where the streets were not asphalted and remained wet in winter because there was no drainage system and everybody threw their used water into the streets. She was closely involved in their family business where her mother became the main source of family income after the collapse of the Soviet Union when her husband lost his job and later became physically disabled. This was a turning point in her family where Meral and her mother had to take on the burden of financial responsibility. Meral’s brother was much younger than her, and therefore, she had the responsibility of selling the goods that her mother brought from abroad.

After Meral’s marriage at the age of 18, and her divorce only one-and-a-half years later, she managed her own fabric business. She had been forced into this marriage although she had already chosen a potential husband, a cabdriver. Meral’s family was highly respected, and with the success of their family business, they were able to buy a very nice flat, in a multistoried residential building with running water and electricity, in a very prestigious, modern quarter of Tashauz. However, the cabdriver (Meral’s love) was raised in a poor family with many siblings, and culturally, it is impossible for a divorced woman to remarry a man who has never been married before. If this happens, as in the case of Meral, people need to find some kind of justification for the remarriage, and love alone cannot serve as a justification for such “a serious step.”

During her unhappy marriage, I asked Meral why she had married if she actually loved another man. She explained that, culturally, she had to marry the first husband (who was chosen by her family) in order to be able to eventually marry her true love. After her divorce, her parents would agree to any marriage “even to the cabdriver from a poor family.” This happened exactly according to her scenario. She was unhappy with

her first marriage and complained to her parents, including threatening to kill herself. Finally, she was allowed to end her marriage and move back to her parents' house. This was accepted by her parents because she was good at doing business and making money, and Meral's mother was considered to be very modern and accepting of her daughter's decision.

Ultimately, Meral renewed her relationship with the cabdriver, and they were married and lived in the flat given to Meral by her parents. This was a perfect arrangement for Meral where she could continue her business in *bay bazar* and live with the man she loved. She now has two children and lives without her parents-in-law in a four-room flat. Her income from her business is considerable which gives her agency in making decisions in the family despite gender differences and kinship hierarchies.

Uzbekistani Tajik Businesswoman and a Second Wife

Almagyl is a young woman who escaped Tajikistan during the civil war and currently lives in Uzbekistan. At the beginning of her life in Uzbekistan (at the age of 19) she became a lover or unofficial second wife of a successful businessman. She was actively involved in business projects, such as providing industrial companies with raw materials. Her lover invested in her business which she successfully continued and advanced even after her lover left the country. Shortly thereafter, Almagyl found another man with whom she had worked as a business partner for a long time. However, he was already married and had three children. She did not mind that he had another family. She said that his family is his duty to his parents and that their love is their duty to one another as lovers. After about nine years, Almagyl finally became pregnant and gave birth to three children although, as an unofficial second wife, she was not accepted into the family of her lover.

As a lover or second wife, a woman has the privilege of being outside all the traditional constraints any woman would have as a first and official wife which would include serving parents-in-law, performing all official responsibilities, and keeping the pride of the family by sitting at home and taking care of the children. Since it is shameful for a woman to be a lover, the woman usually lives separately from her kinship networks in a flat bought by her lover. Furthermore, she does not get recognition from the relatives of the man. Rather, financial security of lovers or second wives is usually provided by the "husbands" and the relationship is usually kept as an open "secret," which means that partners do not share life events with relatives from either side and if the events concern the partners' children they are usually kept within a very small circle of friends.

Tajik Entrepreneur and a Second Wife

The story of Nozima is very complicated. Nozima is in her early forties and is a nurse by education. She divorced her husband after she learned that he had a lover. With the remittances from abroad (two daughters living in France and Russia) she established a small business of her own as a single woman in Dushanbe, Tajikistan. She met her lover, Rahim, as a patient in the medical clinic where she worked as a nurse. As she described him: *"He came to me very sick and very badly taken care of, and I made him healthy and took good care of him and made him good-looking by buying him stylish clothing. I made him chelovekom ("human being" in Russian) meaning a respectful person with a status."*

Rahim divorced his first wife, but his family remarried him to a young woman from a wealthy family without Nozima's knowledge. (Rahim's parents would never have approved of his relationship with Nozima because she was older than him, and therefore their relationship remained

secret.) The situation reached its peak when Nozima found out about Rahim's secret marriage. She then left him, and she agreed to marry a mullah as a second wife. Indeed, the mullah's first wife was Nozima's own friend who asked Nozima to marry her husband, justifying this by saying that *"it is better my husband has a good loyal woman who I know and does not marry someone who I don't know and take my husband away forever."* After marriage to the mullah, Nozima was not left alone by her previous lover, Rahim, who instead claimed her back, and given the situation, the mullah husband left Nozima.

Until now, Nozima has been living in the drama and conflict between her lover, Rahim, and his family. She is in her early forties which is not an ideal age for being an attractive lover, but she is a good partner in bed, which she says is her main asset. Nozima took her lover, Rahim, as a business partner which bound him to her. Rahim, in turn, is bound to his official wife since they married according to traditions and she is from a wealthy family. This makes each participant bound to the other. Unlike other cases of second wives, the case of Nozima is unusual wherein she has stronger financial independence and continues the relationship because of her feelings.

Kazakh Rural Entrepreneur

Halima, a Kazakh woman in her early thirties, tells her story as a "success story." She came to Kazakhstan from Turkmenistan in the late 1990s as a student to study accounting. She successfully finished her studies but did not pursue her career as an accountant. Rather, she married a son of the woman for whom she had worked; she has four children with her husband and runs a small store within the family business. Describing herself as an average Kazakh rural woman, she sells items in their small store and takes care of her children and is an obedient *kelin* (daughter-in-law) for her mother-in-law who is a widow.

Although her husband financially supports their family, she claims to make a considerable financial contribution by being closely involved in sales. Halima considers herself as an entrepreneurial woman who is financially independent and manages her family budget. She also believes that she can achieve more and that they will be able to build a house for their family. She is happy with her life and her dream is that she marries off her daughters and her son and that she becomes a respectable mother-in-law herself.

Kyrgyz Intellectual

Aynura is in her late thirties and is currently unmarried. She received her university education in the United States, and when her visa expired, she returned to Kyrgyzstan where she is teaching at a local university. She had a boyfriend in the U.S. from whom she had to part when she returned home. She owns a flat in a city which she bought with her own savings. She is financially independent since she does not have to pay rent and can use her salary for living expenses. She lives alone while her family lives in a rural area. Furthermore, because she did not fulfill the family expectations of marrying at an early age and having children, she is more or less isolated from her family and kinship. Aynura is single, and because of her age, she believes that she now falls under the Kyrgyz category of *qaryqiz* (old maid) and is *"too old to marry."*

Aynura dreams of leaving Kyrgyzstan as soon as she has an opportunity to obtain either a scholarship or a job in Europe or in the U.S. She hopes to find a good partner for herself and have a family. She portrays herself as a free woman and at the same time not completely free because she is caught up in the web of prejudice and tradition. She is independent financially, but she still feels that she is bound by the traditions and rules of Kyrgyz society where women are expected to conform to the gender-based established rules, traditions, and expectations.

Summary of Case Studies

Most of the women from the case studies had financial independence, and their “voices were heard” at least within their nuclear family. Most of them were active agents in shaping their future and making decisions whether financial, personal, or social. The social pressures of the tradition-bound communities where women entrepreneurs reside are both constant and substantial, as their movements, social contacts, clothing, and absence from home are continuously observed, criticized, and actively discussed in social gatherings and elsewhere. The women in these case studies were, to varying degrees, successful in coping with those constraints, continuing with their activities, and gaining and maintaining respect and status within their social networks, community, and kinship. These women not only actively navigated between modernity and tradition but also actively participated in creating a future for themselves and for their children.

SECTION THREE: SECOND WIVES, *CHYORNAYA KASSA*, AGENCY AND DECISION-MAKING

First/Official Wives, Lovers, and Second Wives

Although the role of “second wife” was noted in the case studies discussed earlier in this chapter, it is useful to focus on additional details. Specifically, during the course of my extensive research in Central Asia, I personally became friends with more than 50 women, all from urban locations, who are second wives or lovers (*oydash*), and I studied 12 such women from Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, and Tajikistan. In rural areas it is almost impossible to have a lover or second wife because the community arrangements and the

kinship groups are closely knit. However, it is often the case that a rural migrant in a city or town has a second wife while his first wife remains in the village taking care of his parents.

Most of the second wives I studied indicated that it is better for a woman to be a lover or a second wife, rather than a traditional and official wife, because life as a lover or second wife offered more advantages. Such advantages included freedom from all traditional burdens, better treatment by their men, more presents, more financial support, more romantic relationships, relative independence, and a modern life. In turn, the disadvantages included the secrecy of the relationship and the uncertain future because of men getting old and leaving the lover or second wife without financial security. This, of course, can be avoided in some cases by securing property in the name of the lover or second wife, obtaining a stable job and income, or opening a small business.

Two of the twelve women I studied were officially introduced to the family of the husband and were accepted by the family as second wives in order to be integrated into events and responsibilities, whereas one officially moved in with her lover after his wife died. Other women successfully managed to become official wives by demanding that their lovers divorce their official first wives. In these cases, the divorce took place when the men were in their late forties and fifties. Second wives are usually much younger than their partners with an average age difference of more than 10–15 years, which puts these women in a more privileged position. Whereas first wives are busy with childrearing, caring for parents-in-law, and other responsibilities and have little time to take good care of themselves, second wives tend to take care of their appearance as their appearance is their main asset. Further, young women prefer men with money who can finance their lives, and in the ideal scenarios, buy them a flat, a car, or a house. For some wealthy men, in turn, it is important to have a young attractive lover which adds to their reputation of

being able to manage more than one wife or one family. For second wives, the main benefit is financial security although they have to sacrifice their reputation.

***Chyornaya kassa* as a Safety Net for Women in Central Asia**

Besides financial income and security from being a second wife or from being a successful entrepreneur, some women find it useful to join or form a *chyornaya kassa* (literally from Russian “black cashier desk”) or *gaps/krugs* (Turaeva 2016). *Chyornaya kassa* is a cash pool where members of the relevant group gather once per month and pool a certain amount of cash which one woman receives in the number of months equal to the number of members of the group. For instance, if a woman joins a *chyornaya kassa* of 12 women with a US\$50 contribution, the woman receives US\$600 once a year. Cash rotation networks are not new and are known as a source of income in many other countries (Ardener and Burman 1995). These groups, which I met with during my field research in Uzbekistan, accumulated a total contribution of US\$150 to US\$200 each month. However, the monthly contribution sometimes became a burden for some women who could not afford it and thus had to leave the group. Nonetheless, the *chyornaya kassa* did provide various opportunities for members, including starting small businesses.

Agency and Decision-Making

The women I have described in the previous case studies have had to struggle with both old and new challenges depending on their individual circumstances. Women’s “double burden” or even “multiple burden” brought on by the economic and political turmoil and challenges after the collapse of the Soviet Union significantly worsened

the situation of Central Asian women. One would expect that the *re-traditionalization* of Central Asia and the return of Islam, which to some degree contributed to the process of *re-patriarchalization* of kinship structures and social organization in Central Asian societies would automatically imply women’s passivity as well as a lack of voice and the absence of women’s agency. However, this would be an oversimplification of the situation which is far more complex.

The case studies that I presented regarding the stories of these particular Central Asian women demonstrate considerable diversity among women in different settings and in different countries within Central Asia. Yet, there are underlying common themes of women’s agency, decision-making power, and their ability to cope with various types of social, cultural, and economic situations. While women, including those in these case studies, are sometimes viewed as weak or powerless, they do demonstrate considerable control over their lives.

Women innovatively negotiate and cope with the hurdles of often complicated traditional family arrangements and the challenges posed by their work life, and they find their own ways to actively create their own social networks. For instance, in the Turkman case, one could easily speculate about Meral’s first marriage as a purely forced marriage, and therefore conclude that the young girl had no say and therefore lacked agency. However, the fact is that, to some degree, Meral herself planned her marital situation by agreeing to the arrangements of her parents and by fulfilling her obligations as a daughter to her parents. She was convinced that she had to marry the first husband in order to gain the status of being divorced and thereby become free to marry a man of her choice.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

In this chapter, I have examined some of the salient issues related to gender roles as they are

undergoing major transformation in Central Asia. As such, I have argued that economic hardships, globalization, and increased migration have created not only challenges for female members of these Muslim-dominated societies but also have created opportunities to negotiate between modernity and tradition. Focusing on Central Asia, I have traced changes in gender roles from the Soviet to the post-Soviet periods using the examples of five women and gender-based institutions, such as *zhensovet* and *chyornaya kassa*, in order to illustrate the complexities of this process. I have argued that women's situations are not as clear cut as women often depict them as they recall the "good old times" of the Soviet era as a period of liberation and as a golden age of "real communism," and the post-Soviet period as a time of "darkness" and of "turning backwards" or "de-development." These women's stories from Central Asia reveal that social change in the post-Soviet period is marked by the creation of another image of women: specifically, women who have survived economic difficulties and been central figures in supporting their families and who continue to challenge tradition and to serve as agents of change.

Although comparison between the Soviet and post-Soviet eras is often simplified and referred to only in the context of economic change, there are also other changes that took place beyond the local concerns of economic survival: namely, accelerated migration, globalization, trans-nationalization of economic and social relations, and political change. Scholars have also observed religious changes in the region from Soviet atheism to the return of Islam in the post-Soviet period, including issues regarding radicalism (Tucker and Turaeva 2016; Turaeva forthcoming).

These changes have also been accompanied by an important continuity of empowerment of Muslim women in Central Asia from the Soviet period to the present. The process of empowerment of women during the Soviet rule in Central

Asia is qualitatively different from that of the current process of increasing the importance of women in both social and economic spheres. From a gender perspective, the change from feminization of labor to feminization of entrepreneurship is an important development that has revealed quite dramatic changes in gender roles and the crystallization of new images of women in Central Asia. There is a large body of literature on feminization of labor in general, but there is a need for more qualitative studies and ethnographic research on a variety of issues related to female entrepreneurship in Central Asia, including topics ranging from changing family structures to female economic activities and their contribution to local and national economies.

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